

Question ID 169e56a2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 169e56a2

Astronomers investigated the Arabia Terra region of Mars because it appears to contain irregularly shaped craters that may have been caused by massive volcanic explosions. In their investigations of Arabia Terra, the researchers found remnants of ash deposits in an amount and thickness that would result from a massive volcanic eruption. However, erosion and past resurfacing events could have modified the surface of the planet. Therefore, _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the current makeup of the Arabia Terra region might not accurately reflect the volcanic activity of Mars’s past.
- B. eruptions from Mars’s volcanoes were likely not as massive as astronomers previously believed.
- C. ash was most likely expelled from multiple different volcanoes on Mars’s surface.
- D. the craters found in the Arabia Terra region were necessarily created by events other than volcanic eruptions.

ID: 169e56a2 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of the Arabia Terra region of Mars. According to the text, there are craters in Arabia Terra that could be the result of volcanic activity, and researchers have found evidence of ash deposits consistent with a large eruption. The text goes on to note, however, that erosion and other events could have altered the surface of Mars. This observation suggests that current conditions on Mars’s surface are not necessarily a reliable guide to past events—some signs of past events could have been transformed or erased entirely—and thus the current makeup of Arabia Terra may not accurately reflect past volcanic activity.

Choice B is incorrect because the text suggests only that past events could have changed Mars’s surface such that its current appearance isn’t a reliable guide to past activity, not that it’s likely that past eruptions were not as massive as astronomers previously believed. Nothing in the text supports a conclusion about the likely size of past eruptions. Choice C is incorrect because the observation that resurfacing events could have changed the appearance of Mars doesn’t imply that the ash discussed in the text likely came from multiple volcanoes. Although it’s possible that the ash came from different volcanoes, there’s no information in the text supporting a conclusion about how likely that possibility is. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that the Arabia Terra craters had to have been created by something other than volcanic eruptions. Although the text does suggest that the evidence consistent with volcanic eruptions shouldn’t be taken as definitive proof of past eruptions, that doesn’t mean that the craters couldn’t have been created by eruptions, only that we can’t be certain they were.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ea200c39

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: ea200c39

Hypothesizing that reliance on smartphones for information retrieval will lead a person to incorrectly remember instances of phone-assisted retrieval as instances of retrieval from memory, researchers asked participants general-knowledge trivia questions, instructing them to answer certain questions using only their smartphone and other questions using only their memory. When surveyed a week later, participants exhibited higher levels of misattribution for answers retrieved in the smartphone condition than for those retrieved in the memory condition, a finding that the researchers claimed supported their hypothesis.

- Which question would be most useful to answer in determining the validity of the researchers’ claim as it is presented in the text?
- A. Were participants as likely to remember the source of their information when asked a week later as they would have been if asked immediately after answering the trivia questions?
 - B. Were participants less confident about the accuracy of information they were instructed to retrieve from a smartphone than they were of that retrieved from their own memory?
 - C. How likely were participants to answer all the trivia questions correctly in both the smartphone and the memory conditions?
 - D. How did participants attribute information they were instructed to retrieve from a smartphone in instances when they already knew that information independently of their phone?

ID: ea200c39 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it identifies a question that directly addresses a potential confounding factor in the research. The text discusses a study investigating source misattribution for information retrieved with the assistance of a smartphone—that is, how well people remember whether they used a smartphone to look up information or retrieved the information from their memory. The researchers hypothesized that smartphone reliance causes people to mistakenly think that they retrieved the information from their memory when they in fact used a smartphone. To test this hypothesis, the researchers instructed participants to look up answers to some trivia questions on smartphones and to answer some questions using only their memory. The text then indicates that a week later, participants were more likely to misremember smartphone-assisted answers as coming from memory than to misremember memory-based answers as coming from smartphones. The researchers claimed that the higher misattribution rates for the smartphone-retrieval condition supported their hypothesis. However, the text doesn’t specify whether the study design accounted for the possibility that some participants might have known many—perhaps even all—of the trivia answers beforehand. If participants already knew some answers they were instructed to look up on their phones, their later attribution of those answers to memory might be accurate rather than a misattribution. Knowing how participants attributed information in such cases would help determine whether the observed effect reflects smartphone-induced misattribution or simply participants’ recall of prior knowledge. Thus, in evaluating the validity of the researchers’ claim, it would be most useful to know how participants attributed information they were instructed to retrieve from a phone in instances where they already knew the information.

Choice A is incorrect. Although survey timing is a methodological consideration, it doesn't help distinguish between genuine misattribution caused by smartphone reliance and other explanations for the observed effect. Though it's plausible that participants' recollections of their information source may have been more accurate immediately after answering the trivia questions than they would have been a week later, the one-week delay would affect both conditions equally and doesn't specifically challenge the researchers' claim about smartphone-induced misattribution. Choice B is incorrect because confidence in the accuracy of retrieved information doesn't directly pertain to source misattribution. The researchers' claim concerns whether participants believed information came from their smartphone or their memory, not how confident they were in its correctness. Instead, a useful question would need to address the source-attribution process itself. Choice C is incorrect because the accuracy of the participants' answers doesn't bear on the researchers' claim about source misattribution. The claim concerns the remembered origin of answers, not their correctness. Instead, the relevant issue is whether participants who looked up answers they already knew might have attributed those answers to memory regardless of which of the two experimental conditions they answered those questions under.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 41914016

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 41914016

Researchers hypothesized that a decline in the population of dusky sharks near the mid-Atlantic coast of North America led to a decline in the population of eastern oysters in the region. Dusky sharks do not typically consume eastern oysters but do consume cownose rays, which are the main predators of the oysters.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ hypothesis?

- A. Declines in the regional abundance of dusky sharks’ prey other than cownose rays are associated with regional declines in dusky shark abundance.
- B. Eastern oyster abundance tends to be greater in areas with both dusky sharks and cownose rays than in areas with only dusky sharks.
- C. Consumption of eastern oysters by cownose rays in the region substantially increased before the regional decline in dusky shark abundance began.
- D. Cownose rays have increased in regional abundance as dusky sharks have decreased in regional abundance.

ID: 41914016 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ hypothesis about the connection between the dusky shark population decline and the eastern oyster population decline. The text indicates that although dusky sharks don’t usually eat eastern oysters, they do consume cownose rays, which are the main predators of eastern oysters. An increase in the abundance of cownose rays in the region in response to a decline in the abundance of dusky sharks would directly support the researchers’ hypothesis: a higher number of cownose rays would consume more eastern oysters, driving down the oyster population.

Choice A is incorrect because a finding that there’s an association between a decline in the regional abundance of some of dusky sharks’ prey and the regional abundance of dusky sharks wouldn’t directly support the researchers’ hypothesis that a decline in dusky sharks has led to a decline in eastern oysters in the region. Although such a finding might help explain why shark abundance has declined, it would reveal nothing about whether the shark decline is related to the oyster decline. Choice B is incorrect because a finding that eastern oyster abundance tends to be greater when dusky sharks and cownose rays are present than when only dusky sharks are present wouldn’t support the researchers’ hypothesis that a decline in dusky sharks has led to a decline in eastern oysters in the region. The text indicates that the sharks prey on the rays, which are the main predators of the oysters; if oyster abundance is found to be greater when rays are present than when rays are absent, that would suggest that rays aren’t keeping oyster abundance down, and thus that a decline in rays’ predators, which would be expected to lead to an increase in the abundance of rays, wouldn’t bring about a decline in oyster abundance as the researchers hypothesize. Choice C is incorrect because a finding that consumption of eastern oysters by cownose rays increased substantially before dusky sharks declined in regional abundance wouldn’t support the researchers’ hypothesis that the decline in dusky sharks has led to a decline

in eastern oysters in the region. Such a finding would suggest that some factor other than shark abundance led to an increase in rays' consumption of oysters and thus to a decrease in oyster abundance, thereby weakening the researchers' hypothesis.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 23d47b9b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 23d47b9b

Participants’ Evaluation of the Likelihood That Robots Can Work Effectively in Different Occupations

Occupation	Somewhat or very unlikely (%)	Neutral (%)	Somewhat or very likely (%)
television news anchor	24	9	67
teacher	37	16	47
firefighter	62	9	30
surgeon	74	9	16
tour guide	10	8	82
Rows in table may not add up to 100 due to rounding.			

Georgia Tech roboticists De’Aira Bryant and Ayanna Howard, along with ethicist Jason Borenstein, were interested in people’s perceptions of robots’ competence. They recruited participants and asked them how likely they think it is that a robot could do the work required in various occupations. Participants’ evaluations varied widely depending on which occupation was being considered; for example, _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the example?

- A. 47% of participants believe that it is somewhat or very likely that a robot could work effectively as a teacher, but 37% of respondents believe that it is somewhat or very unlikely that a robot could do so.
- B. 9% of participants were neutral about whether a robot could work effectively as a television news anchor, which is the same percent of participants who were neutral when asked about a robot working as a surgeon.
- C. 82% of participants believe that it is somewhat or very likely that a robot could work effectively as a tour guide, but only 16% believe that it is somewhat or very likely that a robot could work as a surgeon.
- D. 62% of participants believe that it is somewhat or very unlikely that a robot could work effectively as a firefighter.

ID: 23d47b9b Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it effectively uses data from the table to complete the example of variations in participants’ evaluations. The table shows participants’ evaluations of the likelihood that robots could work effectively in different occupations. The text asserts that participants’ evaluations varied widely depending on the occupation being considered and introduces an example supporting that assertion. The data from the table showing that 82% of participants believe that it is somewhat or very likely that a robot could work effectively as a tour guide but only 16% of participants believe that it is somewhat or very likely that

a robot could work effectively as a surgeon illustrate this assertion: those data show participants' views changing substantially with the occupation being considered.

Choice A is incorrect because it does not describe data that illustrate the assertion that participants' evaluations varied widely depending on which occupation was being considered. Although this choice accurately describes data in the table, data about participants' responses when considering a single occupation—teaching—could not be an example of people's views changing substantially depending on the occupation being considered. Choice B is incorrect because it identifies a similarity in participants' responses when considering two different occupations, but the assertion that the example is intended to illustrate is that participants' evaluations varied widely depending on the occupation being considered. Although this choice accurately describes data in the table, those data do not illustrate the assertion in the text. Choice D is incorrect because it does not describe data that illustrate the assertion that participants' evaluations varied widely depending on which occupation was being considered. Although this choice accurately describes data in the table, data showing participants' evaluation of just one occupation could not be an example of participants' evaluations changing depending on the occupation under evaluation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 06d60825

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 06d60825

One challenge when researching whether holding elected office changes a person’s behavior is the problem of ensuring that the experiment has an appropriate control group. To reveal the effect of holding office, researchers must compare people who hold elected office with people who do not hold office but who are otherwise similar to the office-holders. Since researchers are unable to control which politicians win elections, they therefore _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. struggle to find valid data about the behavior of politicians who do not currently hold office.
- B. can only conduct valid studies with people who have previously held office rather than people who presently hold office.
- C. should select a control group of people who differ from office-holders in several significant ways.
- D. will find it difficult to identify a group of people who can function as an appropriate control group for their studies.

ID: 06d60825 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of the challenge researchers face when studying the effects of holding elected office on a person’s behavior. The text explains that it’s hard for researchers to test for the effects that elected office has on people because finding people to serve as a control group is difficult. The text indicates that a control group needs to be made up of people who share characteristics of the group being tested but don’t have the variable being tested (in this case, holding elected office). Because researchers aren’t able to influence who wins elections, they’re also unable to determine who would serve as an appropriately similar member of a control group. Thus, it logically follows that researchers will find it difficult to identify a group of people who can function as an appropriate control group for their studies.

Choice A is incorrect because the text focuses on the struggle to put together a control group for experiments; it doesn’t suggest that finding information about politicians’ behavior is difficult. Choice B is incorrect because the experiments mentioned in the text are testing the effects of holding elected office on a person’s behavior. Studying people who have already held elected office wouldn’t provide an opportunity to note any behavioral changes that the position might cause. Choice C is incorrect because the text defines people in a control group as those "who are otherwise similar to the office-holders"; selecting people who differ from the office-holders wouldn’t fit the criteria for an appropriate control group.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4cb07b12

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 4cb07b12

The following text is adapted from William Shakespeare’s 1609 poem “Sonnet 27.” The poem is addressed to a close friend as if he were physically present.

Weary with toil, I [hurry] to my bed,
The dear repose for limbs with travel tired;
But then begins a journey in my head
To work my mind, when body’s work’s expired:
For then my thoughts—from far where I abide—
[Begin] a zealous pilgrimage to thee,
And keep my drooping eyelids open wide,

What is the main idea of the text?

- A. The speaker is asleep and dreaming about traveling to see the friend.
- B. The speaker is planning an upcoming trip to the friend’s house.
- C. The speaker is too fatigued to continue a discussion with the friend.
- D. The speaker is thinking about the friend instead of immediately falling asleep.

ID: 4cb07b12 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The speaker describes going to bed for “repose” (rest) but finding that his thoughts are focused on the friend the speaker is addressing, and the thoughts are keeping the speaker awake.

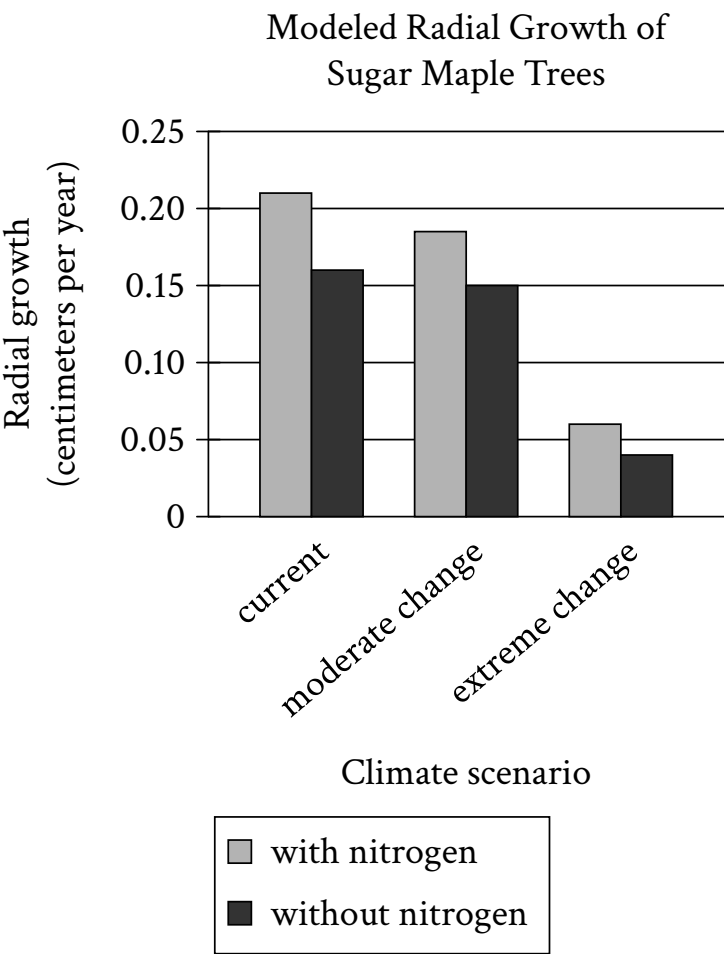
Choice A is incorrect because the speaker isn’t asleep; the thoughts about the friend are keeping the speaker awake. Choice B is incorrect because the speaker isn’t talking about taking a literal trip; rather, the speaker uses the metaphor of a journey to describe internal thoughts. Choice C is incorrect because the speaker isn’t having a discussion with the friend.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 44ebfc85

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 44ebfc85



Inés Ibáñez and colleagues studied a forest site in which some sugar maple trees receive periodic fertilization with nitrogen to mimic the broader trend of increasing anthropogenic nitrogen deposition in soil. Ibáñez and colleagues modeled the radial growth of the trees with and without nitrogen fertilization under three different climate scenarios (the current climate, moderate change, and extreme change). Although they found that climate change would negatively affect growth, they concluded that anthropogenic nitrogen deposition could more than offset that effect provided that change is moderate rather than extreme.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that support Ibáñez and colleagues’ conclusion?

- A. Growth with nitrogen under the current climate exceeded growth with nitrogen under moderate change, but the latter exceeded growth without nitrogen under extreme change.
- B. Growth without nitrogen under the current climate exceeded growth without nitrogen under moderate change, but the latter exceeded growth with nitrogen under extreme change.
- C. Growth with nitrogen under moderate change exceeded growth without nitrogen under moderate change, but the latter exceeded growth without nitrogen under extreme change.

D. Growth with nitrogen under moderate change exceeded growth without nitrogen under the current climate, but the latter exceeded growth with nitrogen under extreme change.

ID: 44ebfc85 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it describes data from the graph that support Ibáñez and colleagues' conclusion that increasing anthropogenic nitrogen deposition can compensate for the negative effect of climate change on tree growth if that change is moderate but not if it's extreme. The bar graph shows the growth of sugar maple trees with and without nitrogen fertilization under three different climate-change scenarios: current conditions, a moderate change, and an extreme change. According to the graph, radial growth without nitrogen fertilization is projected to be about 0.16 centimeters (cm) under current conditions, 0.15 cm under a moderate change, and 0.04 cm under an extreme change. The graph also shows that with nitrogen fertilization, growth is projected to be about 0.18 centimeters under a moderate change but only about 0.06 centimeters under an extreme change. Thus, the data in the graph support the researchers' conclusion by showing greater growth for a moderate change using nitrogen fertilization than they do either under current conditions without nitrogen fertilization or under an extreme change with nitrogen fertilization.

Choice A is incorrect. Although it accurately represents the data in the graph, this fact pattern doesn't support Ibáñez and colleagues' conclusion that the decline in radial growth due to climate change will be partly offset by higher levels of anthropogenic nitrogen, but only if change to the climate is moderate and not if it's extreme. To support this would require comparing radial growth without nitrogen fertilization under current climate conditions to the growth with nitrogen fertilization under both moderate and extreme changes. This choice mentions only growth with nitrogen fertilization under current climate conditions and moderate change and growth without nitrogen fertilization under an extreme change, which don't provide a basis to determine whether higher nitrogen in the future will be able to offset reduced growth due to climate change. Choice B is incorrect. Although it accurately represents the data in the graph, this fact pattern doesn't support Ibáñez and colleagues' conclusion that the decline in radial growth due to climate change will be partly offset by higher levels of atmospheric nitrogen, but only if change to the climate is moderate and not if it's extreme. The support needed would compare radial growth under current climate conditions without nitrogen fertilization to the growth with nitrogen fertilization under moderate and extreme changes. This choice mentions only growth without nitrogen fertilization under current conditions and moderate change and growth with nitrogen fertilization under extreme change, which don't provide a basis to determine whether higher nitrogen in the future will be able to offset reduced growth due to climate change. Choice C is incorrect. Although it accurately represents the data in the graph, this fact pattern doesn't support Ibáñez and colleagues' conclusion that the decline in radial growth due to climate change will be partly offset by higher levels of atmospheric nitrogen, but only if change to the climate is moderate and not if it's extreme. The support needed would compare radial growth without adding nitrogen under current climate conditions to the growth with nitrogen fertilization under moderate and extreme changes. This choice mentions only the growth with and without nitrogen fertilization under moderate climate change and growth without nitrogen fertilization under extreme change, which don't provide a basis to determine whether higher nitrogen in the future will be able to offset reduced growth due to climate change.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6b7e16bd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 6b7e16bd

Sense and Sensibility is an 1811 novel by Jane Austen. In the novel, Austen describes Marianne Dashwood’s ability to persuade others of the rightness of her artistic judgments, as is evident when Marianne visits with John Willoughby, a potential suitor:

Which quotation from *Sense and Sensibility* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “Above all, when she heard him declare, that of music and dancing he was passionately fond, she gave him such a look of approbation as secured the largest share of his discourse to herself for the rest of his stay.”
- B. “Their taste was strikingly alike. The same books, the same passages were idolized by each—or if any difference appeared, any objection arose, it lasted no longer than till the force of her arguments and the brightness of her eyes could be displayed.”
- C. “It was only necessary to mention any favourite amusement to engage her to talk. She could not be silent when such points were introduced, and she had neither shyness nor reserve in their discussion.”
- D. “They speedily discovered that their enjoyment of dancing and music was mutual, and that it arose from a general conformity of judgment in all that related to either. Encouraged by this to a further examination of his opinions, she proceeded to question him on the subject of books.”

ID: 6b7e16bd Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. By showing that "any difference" in taste was quickly overcome by "the force of [Marianne’s] arguments," this choice effectively demonstrates Marianne’s "ability to persuade others."

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t effectively illustrate the claim. This choice shows that Marianne and John share an interest in music and dancing, but it doesn’t provide evidence of Marianne’s "ability to persuade others." Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t effectively illustrate the claim. This choice shows that Marianne enjoys talking about her interests, but it doesn’t provide evidence of Marianne’s "ability to persuade others." Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t effectively illustrate the claim. This choice shows that Marianne and John share many interests and generally agree on music and dancing, but it doesn’t provide evidence of Marianne’s "ability to persuade others."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID db39fb59

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: db39fb59

Under normal atmospheric pressure at Earth’s surface, water molecules form a tetrahedral network stabilized by hydrogen bonds between adjacent molecules. Extreme high pressure, such as can be found in deep ocean waters, destabilizes these bonds and compresses water’s structure, allowing water molecules within organisms to permeate proteins and impede crucial biological functions; yet deep-sea organisms known as piezophiles have adapted to extreme pressure. Studies have found a positive correlation between the depths that various piezophiles inhabit and concentrations of a compound called trimethylamine N-oxide (TMAO) in their muscle tissues, which has led a team of researchers to hypothesize that TMAO reduces water’s compressibility.

- Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ hypothesis?
- A. Water molecules are found to be impervious to TMAO even when the water molecules’ tetrahedral configuration has been distorted by high pressure.
 - B. Examination of TMAO’s molecular structure shows that TMAO molecules retain their shape even as pressure increases.
 - C. A positive correlation is found between concentrations of TMAO and the rate at which water’s molecular structure compresses as pressure increases.
 - D. Analysis of water’s molecular structure under high pressure reveals that hydrogen bonds are more stable when TMAO is present than when it is not.

ID: db39fb59 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support the researchers’ hypothesis that TMAO reduces water’s compressibility. The text explains that at great depths in the ocean, extreme pressure compresses the molecular structure of water by destabilizing the hydrogen bonds between adjacent molecules, thereby allowing water to penetrate proteins and harm the associated organisms. However, deep-sea organisms called piezophiles have adapted to live at these depths and previous studies show a positive correlation between the depth at which a piezophile species lives and the species’ level of the compound TMAO. Because this hypothesis links TMAO levels with reduced compressibility of water’s tetrahedral molecular structure, a finding that TMAO helps maintain the hydrogen bonds between water molecules under high pressure would strongly support that hypothesis.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the researchers’ hypothesis suggests a relationship between TMAO and water molecules’ tetrahedral molecular structure, that relationship involves TMAO helping maintain water’s tetrahedral molecular structure under high pressure; as presented in the text, the hypothesis doesn’t contend that water molecules are impervious to, or incapable of being penetrated by, TMAO. Choice B is incorrect because the text discusses how the molecular structure of water, not TMAO, is compressed under extreme pressure and never addresses how TMAO might be affected by such pressure. Choice C is incorrect because the researchers’ hypothesis holds that water under extreme pressure is more resistant, not less, to being compressed when TMAO concentrations are higher. Moreover, the positive correlation mentioned in the text is between TMAO concentrations

and the depths at which piezophiles live, not between concentrations of TMAO and the rate at which water's molecular structure compresses as pressure increases.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7ce63013

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 7ce63013

Philosophers note that many people have an intuitive sense that while we ought not to lie, there may be circumstances in which lying is permissible. If this intuition is correct and we lack an inviolable duty to speak truthfully, what grounds opposition to lying in the first place? Japa Pallikkathayil has advanced one answer by appealing to a duty to respect others’ agential interests: the possession of false beliefs constrains agency, and thus we ought not to impede the formation of true beliefs unless doing so prevents a greater constraint on someone’s agency or an otherwise impermissible end.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. One potential means of justifying opposition to lying is Pallikkathayil’s argument that we have an obligation to respect other people’s agency that entails a commitment to truthfulness except in certain circumstances.
- B. Many people have an intuitive sense that lying is permissible in some circumstances but lack a principled way to identify those circumstances, and Pallikkathayil’s argument may provide a means of resolving that problem.
- C. Pallikkathayil’s argument suggests that if we have a duty to respect other people’s agential interests and if possession of false beliefs constrains agency, then we have an inviolable duty to speak truthfully.
- D. Pallikkathayil’s argument shows that if our intuition that circumstances may make lying permissible is correct, then it is unclear whether there are any grounds for an opposition to lying in the first place.

ID: 7ce63013 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text begins by noting a common intuition that lying might sometimes be permissible, which raises the question of what is the reason for being against lying. The text then presents Pallikkathayil’s answer to this question: we have a duty to respect others’ agential interests (that is, we have an obligation to allow people to exercise their free will in order to best serve their own ends), false beliefs constrain agency (the implication here being that people who are deceived about what is true are impeded in acting in their own best interests), and so we should not hinder the formation of true beliefs (we should not deliberately deceive a person) unless doing so prevents a greater limitation on someone’s agency or prevents some otherwise impermissible end (for example, it might be morally permissible to lie to someone in the rare circumstance where a false belief would lead a person to act in their own best interest, and where they would not do so if they knew the truth). Thus, the main idea of the text is that Pallikkathayil offers a potential justification for opposing lying based on respecting agency, while still allowing for exceptions in specific circumstances.

Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t focus on people’s lack of a principled way to identify circumstances where lying is permissible or indicate that Pallikkathayil’s argument resolves this specific problem. Rather, the text presents Pallikkathayil’s argument that lies limit agency but may be permitted in very specific situations (to prevent a greater limitation on someone’s agency or an otherwise unacceptable outcome) as one of a number of possible arguments about why lies are undesirable but sometimes permissible. Choice C is incorrect because it directly contradicts the text. Pallikkathayil’s argument, as described in

the text, wouldn't lead to an "inviolable duty to speak truthfully." On the contrary, the text explicitly states that Pallikkathayil's position is that interfering with people developing accurate beliefs is wrong, except when such interference prevents either a more significant limitation on someone's agency or an outcome that would be unacceptable for other reasons. This indicates that Pallikkathayil's argument allows for some exceptions to the duty to speak truthfully, making it not inviolable. Choice D is incorrect because Pallikkathayil's argument doesn't suggest that if it is permissible to lie in at least some circumstances, then it is unclear whether there are good reasons for opposing lying in any circumstances. Instead, the text presents Pallikkathayil as offering a specific ground for opposing lying (respecting others' ability to act in their own best interests) while qualifying that assertion by presenting a situation in which lying might sometimes be morally permissible.

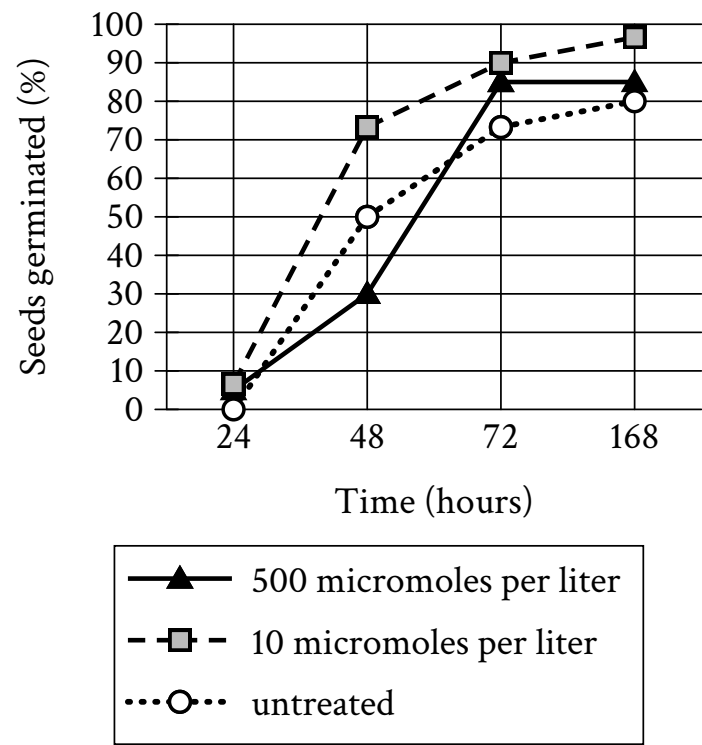
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 62bd05a8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 62bd05a8

Seed Germination with and without H₂S Treatment



In high concentrations, hydrogen sulfide (H₂S) is typically toxic to many plants. Frederick D. Dooley and colleagues wanted to understand what effects low doses of H₂S might have on plant growth. They treated bean, corn, wheat, and pea seeds with various concentrations (measured in micromoles per liter) of H₂S and tracked the germination of those seeds along with the germination of untreated seeds. Treatment with particular concentrations of H₂S was associated with accelerated germination: for example,

- Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the statement?
- A. at 24 hours, less than 10% of seeds treated with H₂S at a concentration of 10 micromoles per liter had germinated, whereas more than 90% of those seeds had germinated at 168 hours.
 - B. at 48 hours, more than 70% of seeds treated with H₂S at a concentration of 10 micromoles per liter had germinated, whereas only approximately 50% of untreated seeds had germinated.
 - C. at 168 hours, more than 90% of seeds treated with H₂S at concentrations of 10 or 500 micromoles per liter had germinated, whereas less than 70% of untreated seeds had germinated.
 - D. at 48 hours, approximately 50% of seeds treated with H₂S at a concentration of 10 micromoles per liter had germinated, whereas only approximately 30% of untreated seeds had germinated.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The claim is that some concentrations of H_2S led to increased germination rates, and this choice accurately shows that seeds treated with 10 micromoles per liter of H_2S tended to germinate faster than untreated seeds.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn't justify the claim. The claim compares the germination rates of seeds exposed to certain concentrations of H_2S to untreated seeds, but this choice only discusses one concentration of H_2S , so it can't support any comparison between treated and untreated groups. Choice C is incorrect. This choice misreads the graph. At 168 hours, only about 85% of seeds treated with H_2S at 500 micromoles per liter and well over 70% of untreated seeds had germinated (about 80%). Choice D is incorrect. This choice misreads the graph. At 48 hours, about 70% of seeds treated with H_2S at 10 micromoles per liter and about 50% of untreated seeds had germinated.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4da09374

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 4da09374

Paleontologists searching for signs of ancient life have found many fossilized specimens of prehistoric human ancestors, including several from the Pleistocene era discovered in a geological formation in the Minatogawa quarry in Japan. However, to study the emergence of the earliest multicellular organisms to appear on Earth, researchers must turn elsewhere, such as to the Ediacaran geological formation at Mistaken Point in Canada. A UNESCO World Heritage Site, the 146-hectare reserve contains more than 10,000 fossils that together document a critical moment in evolutionary history.

What does the text indicate about the geological formation at Mistaken Point?

- A.

It holds a greater number of fossils but from a smaller variety of species than the formation in the Minatogawa quarry does.
- B.

It has provided evidence that the earliest human species may have emerged before the Pleistocene era.
- C.

It is widely considered by paleontologists to be the most valuable source of information about prehistoric life forms.
- D.

It contains specimens from an older time period than those found in the formation in the Minatogawa quarry.

ID: 4da09374 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The text says that the formation at Mistaken Point contains fossils of “the earliest multicellular organisms,” which implies that these fossils are from an older time period than the fossils of “prehistoric human ancestors” found in the Minatogawa quarry.

Choice A is incorrect. The text says that the formation at Mistake Point contains “more than 10,000 fossils,” but it doesn’t compare this number to the number of fossils in the Minatogawa quarry. It also doesn’t say anything about the variety of species in either formation. Choice B is incorrect. The text says that the formation at Mistaken Point contains fossils of “the earliest multicellular organisms,” but it never says that the site contains early human fossils too. Rather, the early human fossils mentioned in the text were found in the formation at Minatogawa quarry. Choice C is incorrect. The text says that the fossils at Mistaken Point “document a critical moment in evolutionary history,” but it never says that Mistaken Point is the most valuable source of information about prehistoric life forms.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 24916063

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 24916063

For many years, the only existing fossil evidence of mixopterid eurypterids—an extinct family of large aquatic arthropods known as sea scorpions and related to modern arachnids and horseshoe crabs—came from four species living on the paleocontinent of Laurussia. In a discovery that expands our understanding of the geographical distribution of mixopterids, paleontologist Bo Wang and others have identified fossilized remains of a new mixopterid species, *Terropterus xiushanensis*, that lived over 400 million years ago on the paleocontinent of Gondwana.

- According to the text, why was Wang and his team’s discovery of the *Terropterus xiushanensis* fossil significant?
- A. The fossil constitutes the first evidence found by scientists that mixopterids lived more than 400 million years ago.
 - B. The fossil helps establish that mixopterids are more closely related to modern arachnids and horseshoe crabs than previously thought.
 - C. The fossil helps establish a more accurate timeline of the evolution of mixopterids on the paleocontinents of Laurussia and Gondwana.
 - D. The fossil constitutes the first evidence found by scientists that mixopterids existed outside the paleocontinent of Laurussia.

ID: 24916063 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it states why Wang and his team’s discovery of the *Terropterus xiushanensis* fossil was significant. The text explains that up until Wang and his team’s discovery, the only fossil evidence of mixopterids came from the paleocontinent of Laurussia. Wang and his team, however, identified fossil remains of a mixopterid species from the paleocontinent Gondwana. Therefore, the team’s discovery was significant because the fossil remains of a mixopterid species were outside of the paleocontinent Laurussia.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text states that Wang and his team identified fossilized remains of a mixopterid species that lived more than 400 million years ago, it doesn’t indicate that mixopterid fossils previously found by scientists dated to a more recent period than that. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text states that mixopterids are related to modern arachnids and horseshoe crabs, it doesn’t suggest that the fossil discovered by Wang and his team confirmed that this relationship is closer than scientists had previously thought. Choice C is incorrect because the team’s fossil established the presence of mixopterids on Gondwana, not on Laurussia. Moreover, the text only discusses the fossil in relation to the geographical distribution of mixopterids, not in relation to their evolution.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4eea5cf1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 4eea5cf1

Neurobiologists Laura Cuaya, Raúl Hernández-Pérez, and colleagues investigated the language detection abilities of eighteen dogs. The researchers monitored the brain activity of Joey (an Australian shepherd), Mini (a mixed breed), and other dogs while the animals listened to three recordings: one of *The Little Prince* being read in Spanish, the second in Hungarian, and a third made up of short, randomly selected fragments of the first two, scrambled so that they didn't resemble human speech. Each dog was familiar with either Spanish or Hungarian, but not both. The team concluded that differences in dogs' anatomical features may affect their ability to distinguish speech from nonspeech.

Which finding from the study, if true, would most directly support the team's conclusion?

- A. Long-headed dogs accustomed to hearing Spanish tended to show more brain activity when hearing Spanish than long-headed dogs accustomed to hearing Hungarian showed when hearing Hungarian.
- B. Compared with shorter-headed dogs, longer-headed dogs showed a greater difference in brain activity when hearing either Spanish or Hungarian than when hearing the scrambled recording.
- C. The pattern of brain activity that long-headed dogs showed when hearing the scrambled recording was different from the pattern of brain activity that short-headed dogs showed when hearing the language they were accustomed to.
- D. Compared with shorter-headed dogs, longer-headed dogs showed a greater difference in brain activity when hearing the language they were accustomed to than when hearing the other language.

ID: 4eea5cf1 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support the research team's conclusion about anatomical features and speech detection in dogs. The text explains that a team of researchers monitored the brain activity of dogs while the dogs listened to three recordings: one of spoken Spanish, one of spoken Hungarian, and one of scrambled fragments that weren't recognizable as human speech. The text then states that the team concluded that differences in dogs' anatomical features may affect their ability to distinguish speech from nonspeech. The finding that longer-headed dogs exhibited a greater difference in brain activity when listening to the speech recordings (in Spanish or Hungarian) versus the nonspeech (scrambled) recording compared with shorter-headed dogs would establish an association between an anatomical feature (head length) and responses (as measured by brain activity) to speech versus nonspeech. This observed relationship between head length and brain activity patterns during exposure to speech and nonspeech would support the team's conclusion.

Choice A is incorrect because it describes a finding about dogs' responses (as indicated by brain activity) to hearing their respective familiar languages rather than dogs' ability to distinguish speech from nonspeech, which is what the team's conclusion specifically addresses. Moreover, this finding pertains to only one anatomical type (long-headed dogs), so it wouldn't support the conclusion that anatomical differences may affect dogs' ability to distinguish speech from nonspeech. Choice C is incorrect because it describes a finding involving a comparison between long-headed dogs listening to nonspeech and short-headed dogs

listening to speech, which wouldn't provide enough information to support the researchers' conclusion that anatomical differences may affect dogs' ability to distinguish speech from nonspeech. To support that conclusion, the finding would need to show how dogs with different anatomical features (for example, long-headed and short-headed dogs) respond to recordings of speech as well as recordings of nonspeech. Choice D is incorrect because it describes a finding about dogs' ability to distinguish between a familiar language and an unfamiliar one, not between speech and nonspeech. While this finding does compare dogs with different anatomical features (longer-headed vs. shorter-headed ones), it focuses on language recognition (Spanish vs. Hungarian) rather than the ability to distinguish speech from nonspeech, which is what the team's conclusion specifically addresses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 13587011

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 13587011

Average Number and Duration of Torpor Bouts and Arousal Episodes for Alaska Marmots and Arctic Ground Squirrels, 2008–2011

Feature	Alaska marmots	Arctic ground squirrels
torpor bouts	12	10.5
duration per bout	13.81 days	16.77 days
arousal episodes	11	9.5
duration per episode	21.2 hours	14.2 hours

When hibernating, Alaska marmots and Arctic ground squirrels enter a state called torpor, which minimizes the energy their bodies need to function. Often a hibernating animal will temporarily come out of torpor (called an arousal episode) and its metabolic rate will rise, burning more of the precious energy the animal needs to survive the winter. Alaska marmots hibernate in groups and therefore burn less energy keeping warm during these episodes than they would if they were alone. A researcher hypothesized that because Arctic ground squirrels hibernate alone, they would likely exhibit longer bouts of torpor and shorter arousal episodes than Alaska marmots.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support the researcher’s hypothesis?

- A. The Alaska marmots’ arousal episodes lasted for days, while the Arctic ground squirrels’ arousal episodes lasted less than a day.
- B. The Alaska marmots and the Arctic ground squirrels both maintained torpor for several consecutive days per bout, on average.
- C. The Alaska marmots had shorter torpor bouts and longer arousal episodes than the Arctic ground squirrels did.
- D. The Alaska marmots had more torpor bouts than arousal episodes, but their arousal episodes were much shorter than their torpor bouts.

ID: 13587011 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it describes data from the table that support the researcher’s hypothesis. According to the text, the researcher hypothesized that Arctic ground squirrels would exhibit longer torpor bouts and shorter arousal episodes than Alaska marmots do—or, put the other way, that the marmots would show shorter torpor bouts and longer arousal episodes than the ground squirrels do. The table shows data about torpor bouts and arousal episodes for the two species from 2008 to 2011. According to the table, the average duration of torpor bouts was 13.81 days for Alaska marmots, shorter than the average of 16.77 days for Arctic ground squirrels, and the average duration of arousal episodes was 21.2 hours for Alaska marmots, longer

than the average of 14.2 hours for Arctic ground squirrels. Thus, the table supports the researcher’s hypothesis by showing that Alaska marmots had shorter bouts of torpor and longer arousal episodes than Arctic ground squirrels did.

Choice A is incorrect because it inaccurately describes data from the table and doesn’t support the researcher’s hypothesis. The table shows that the average duration of arousal episodes was less than a day for both Alaska marmots (21.2 hours) and Arctic ground squirrels (14.2 hours). Additionally, information about arousal episodes for Alaska marmots and Arctic ground squirrels isn’t sufficient to support a hypothesis involving comparisons of both arousal episodes and torpor bouts for those animals. Choice B is incorrect because it doesn’t support the researcher’s hypothesis, which involves comparisons of arousal episodes as well as torpor bouts for Alaska marmots and Arctic ground squirrels. Noting that both animals had torpor bouts lasting several days, on average, doesn’t address arousal episodes at all, nor does it reveal how the animals’ torpor bouts compared. Choice D is incorrect because it doesn’t support the researcher’s hypothesis. Although the table does show that Alaska marmots had more torpor bouts (12) than arousal episodes (11) and that their arousal episodes were much shorter than their torpor bouts (21.2 hours and 13.81 days, respectively), comparing data across only Alaska marmot behaviors isn’t sufficient to support a hypothesis about torpor and arousal behaviors of both Alaska marmots and Arctic ground squirrels.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0db6e7e6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 0db6e7e6

Many animals, including humans, must sleep, and sleep is known to have a role in everything from healing injuries to encoding information in long-term memory. But some scientists claim that, from an evolutionary standpoint, deep sleep for hours at a time leaves an animal so vulnerable that the known benefits of sleeping seem insufficient to explain why it became so widespread in the animal kingdom. These scientists therefore imply that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. prolonged deep sleep is likely advantageous in ways that have yet to be discovered.
- B. most traits perform functions that are hard to understand from an evolutionary standpoint.
- C. it is more important to understand how widespread prolonged deep sleep is than to understand its function.
- D. many traits that provide significant benefits for an animal also likely pose risks to that animal.

ID: 0db6e7e6 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. It most logically completes the text. The text says that some scientists can't explain why prolonged deep sleep is so widespread, given that the known benefits of sleep don't seem to make up for how vulnerable it leaves an animal. This suggests that prolonged deep sleep probably has unknown evolutionary benefits that make up for the vulnerability.

Choice B is incorrect. It doesn't logically complete the text. The text only discusses the benefits and risks of one trait: sleep. So there's no basis for an inference about "most traits." Choice C is incorrect. It doesn't logically complete the text. The text says that it is already known that prolonged deep sleep is widespread in the animal kingdom. Rather, what some scientists can't explain is WHY prolonged deep sleep is so widespread, given that the known benefits of sleep don't seem to make up for how vulnerable it leaves an animal. Choice D is incorrect. It doesn't logically complete the text. The text only discusses the benefits and risks of one trait: sleep. So there's no basis for an inference about "many traits."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2a411e91

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 2a411e91

While attending school in New York City in the 1980s, Okwui Enwezor encountered few works by African artists in exhibitions, despite New York’s reputation as one of the best places to view contemporary art from around the world. According to an arts journalist, later in his career as a renowned curator and art historian, Enwezor sought to remedy this deficiency, not by focusing solely on modern African artists, but by showing how their work fits into the larger context of global modern art and art history.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the journalist’s claim?

- A. As curator of the Haus der Kunst in Munich, Germany, Enwezor organized a retrospective of Ghanaian sculptor El Anatsui’s work entitled *El Anatsui: Triumphant Scale*, one of the largest art exhibitions devoted to a Black artist in Europe’s history.
- B. In the exhibition *Postwar: Art Between the Pacific and the Atlantic, 1945–1965*, Enwezor and cocurator Katy Siegel brought works by African artists such as Malangatana Ngwenya together with pieces by major figures from other countries, like US artist Andy Warhol and Mexico’s David Siqueiros.
- C. Enwezor’s work as curator of the 2001 exhibition *The Short Century: Independence and Liberation Movements in Africa, 1945–1994* showed how African movements for independence from European colonial powers following the Second World War profoundly influenced work by African artists of the period, such as Kamala Ibrahim Ishaq and Thomas Mukarobgwa.
- D. Enwezor organized the exhibition *In/sight: African Photographers, 1940 to the Present* not to emphasize a particular aesthetic trend but to demonstrate the broad range of ways in which African artists have approached the medium of photography.

ID: 2a411e91 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support the arts journalist’s claim about Enwezor’s work as a curator and art historian. In the text, the arts journalist asserts that Enwezor wished not just to focus on modern African artists but also to show “how their work fits into the larger context of global modern art and art history,” or how their work relates to artistic developments and work by other artists elsewhere in the world. The description of *Postwar: Art Between the Pacific and the Atlantic, 1945–1965* indicates that Enwezor and Siegel’s exhibition brought works by African artists together with works by artists from other countries, thus supporting the arts journalist’s claim that Enwezor sought to show works by African artists in a context of global modern art and art history.

Choice A is incorrect because it describes a retrospective that wouldn’t support the arts journalist’s claim that Enwezor wanted to show how works by modern African artists fit into the larger context of global modern art and art history. The description of *El Anatsui: Triumphant Scale* indicates that the retrospective focused only on the work of a single African artist, El Anatsui. The description doesn’t suggest that the exhibition showed how El Anatsui’s works fit into a global artistic context. Choice C is incorrect because it describes an exhibition that wouldn’t support the arts journalist’s claim that Enwezor wanted to show how works by modern African artists relate to the larger context of global modern art and art history. The description of *The Short Century: Independence and Liberation Movements in Africa, 1945–1994* indicates that the exhibition showed how African artists

were influenced by movements for independence from European colonial powers following the Second World War. Although this suggests that Enwezor intended the exhibition to place works by African artists in a political context, it doesn't indicate that the works were placed in a global artistic context. Choice D is incorrect because it describes an exhibition that wouldn't support the arts journalist's claim that Enwezor wanted to show how works by modern African artists relate to the larger context of global modern art and art history. The description of *In/sight: African Photographers, 1940 to the Present* indicates that the exhibition was intended to reveal the broad range of approaches taken by African photographers, not that the exhibition showed how photography by African artists fits into a global artistic context.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c90795fe

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: c90795fe

At over a thousand pages across two volumes, *The Fifty-Year Mission*, compiled by Edward Gross and Mark A. Altman, is presented as the “complete, uncensored, unauthorized oral history” as told by the people behind the media franchise *Star Trek*. The work aspires to be comprehensive by, for example, including accounts from cast and crew members of every *Star Trek* television series and film to date. But while *The Fifty-Year Mission* is clearly a unique and valuable resource, it has a shortcoming common among oral histories: it lacks a clear authorial point of view that could otherwise unite the various accounts into a cohesive whole.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. The compilers of *The Fifty-Year Mission* had lofty goals for their oral history of the *Star Trek* franchise, but the published work lacks information about many key events in the franchise’s history.
- B. *The Fifty-Year Mission* includes more accounts from people involved with *Star Trek* television shows than it does from people involved with *Star Trek* films.
- C. The large amount of material compiled into *The Fifty-Year Mission* is surprising given that many of the people involved in the *Star Trek* franchise did not participate in the oral history project.
- D. *The Fifty-Year Mission* represents a worthwhile attempt to thoroughly recount the history of the *Star Trek* franchise, but its approach has an important limitation.

ID: c90795fe Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. According to the text, Gross and Altman’s book is a “valuable resource” because it’s a “complete, uncensored, unauthorized oral history” that features accounts from people involved with “every *Star Trek* television series and film” made. However, the text also points out an inherent shortcoming of the oral history approach used by the book’s creators: the lack of an authorial voice that could unify the many accounts into a coherent narrative. Thus, the text’s main idea is that while the book’s attempt at presenting a comprehensive oral history of the *Star Trek* franchise is a worthwhile one, the approach the creators selected has an important limitation.

Choice A is incorrect. While the goal of the book’s creators (providing a comprehensive history of the *Star Trek* franchise) could be described as lofty, the text’s criticism of the book is focused on the shortcomings of the oral history form, not on events in the *Star Trek* franchise that were not reflected in the book. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the book includes more accounts from people involved with television shows than with films. In fact, the text explicitly states that the book includes accounts from people involved with “every *Star Trek* television series and film” ever made. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that many people involved with the *Star Trek* franchise failed to participate in the book’s oral history project. The only mention of the scope of participation states that the book includes accounts “from cast and crew members of

every *Star Trek* television series and film to date." This information implies a high level of participation from relevant individuals, not a lack of participation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bc1b021e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: bc1b021e

In 2019, 20 previously unknown moons were confirmed to be orbiting Saturn. Three of the moons have prograde orbits (orbiting in the direction the planet spins), and the other 17 have retrograde orbits (orbiting in the opposite direction of the planet’s spin). All but one of the 20 moons are thought to be remnants of bodies that orbited Saturn until they broke apart in collisions. Although the one exceptional moon orbits in the same direction as the planet’s spin, its orbit is highly eccentric compared to the rest, which may suggest that it has a different origin than the other 19 moons.

Based on the text, which choice best describes the moon with the eccentric orbit?

- A. It doesn’t have a retrograde orbit, but it likely has the same origin as the moons with retrograde orbits.
- B. Its orbit is so tilted with respect to the other moons’ orbits that it’s neither prograde nor retrograde.
- C. It has a prograde orbit that is likely the result of having collided with another body orbiting Saturn.
- D. It has a prograde orbit and may not be a remnant of an earlier body that orbited Saturn.

ID: bc1b021e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately describes the moon with the eccentric orbit. The text indicates that three of the 20 newly discovered moons have prograde orbits, meaning that they orbit Saturn in the same direction as the planet’s spin, while the other 17 moons have retrograde orbits, meaning that they orbit Saturn in the opposite direction of the planet’s spin. The text then states that 19 of the 20 moons appear to be the remains of earlier bodies that orbited Saturn but were broken apart in collisions. The one exception is a moon that orbits Saturn in the same direction as the planet’s spin, meaning that the exceptional moon’s orbit is prograde. The text goes on to state that the exceptional moon’s orbit is so eccentric that the moon may have formed through a different process than the other 19 moons. The moon with the eccentric orbit, therefore, has a prograde orbit and may not be a remnant of an earlier body that orbited Saturn.

Choice A is incorrect because nothing in the text supports the idea that the moon with the eccentric orbit likely has the same origin as the moons with retrograde orbits. Although it’s true that the moon has a prograde orbit (and thus doesn’t have a retrograde orbit), the only information the text provides about the moon’s origin is that it may be different than the origin of the other 19 moons. Choice B is incorrect because the text states that the moon in question orbits Saturn in the same direction as the planet’s spin, meaning that the moon’s orbit is prograde, not that its orbit is neither prograde nor retrograde. Choice C is incorrect because the text merely notes that the moon in question has a prograde orbit without giving any indication of what likely caused that orbit.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c94cfc1b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: c94cfc1b

Pigments give paints and dyes their color. Ocher is a mineral-based pigment used to make several colors, including red. Red ocher gets its color from iron oxide. Pigments can also be plant-based; plant-based pigments contain a high level of carbon. In a 2023 study, archaeologists tested the red pigment on decorated beads made by members of the Natufian culture approximately 15,000 years ago. The test showed that the pigment found on several beads contained no iron but had a high level of carbon. This finding led the researchers to conclude that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the Natufian beads examined in the study are the oldest surviving examples of the use of plant-based pigments for decorating beads.
- B. the Natufian beadmakers used plant-based pigments rather than ocher to decorate some of the beads examined in the study.
- C. the Natufian beadmakers preferred to use plant-based pigments because they are much brighter than mineral-based pigments are.
- D. the pigments used by the Natufian beadmakers likely came from plants because ocher was difficult to find.

ID: c94cfc1b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of the chemical content of pigments. The text begins by differentiating between two kinds of pigments: mineral-based pigments such as red ocher, which get their color from iron oxide, and plant-based pigments, which have a high level of carbon. The text then goes on to describe an analysis by archaeologists of the pigment of decorated beads made by members of the Natufian culture around 15,000 years ago. The archaeologists found that the red pigment on some of the beads contained no iron but had a high level of carbon. Since red ocher gets its color from iron oxide, while plant-based pigments have a high level of carbon, the researchers concluded that the Natufian beadmakers used plant-based pigments to decorate some of the beads examined in the study.

Choice A is incorrect because the text does not indicate that the Natufians were the first to use plant-based pigments, so it cannot be concluded that the beads in the study were the oldest surviving examples of the use of plant-based pigments for decorating beads. Choice C is incorrect because the text does not compare the brightness of plant-based and mineral-based pigments. Choice D is incorrect. While it can be concluded that the Natufian beadmakers used plant-based pigments because the pigment found on several beads had a high level of carbon, the text offers no evidence that ocher was difficult to find.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c6033bf0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: c6033bf0

The following text is adapted from William Shakespeare’s 1597 play *The Tragedy of King Richard III*. Richard is reflecting on the recent arrest of his brother, the Duke of Clarence, on suspicion of treason against King Edward IV. Derby, Hastings, Buckingham, Rivers, Dorset, and Grey are also members of the English nobility.

RICHARD: I do the wrong, and first begin to brawl.
The secret mischiefs that I set [flowing]
I lay unto the grievous charge of others.
Clarence, whom I indeed have cast in darkness,
I do bewEEP to many simple [gullible people],
Namely, to Derby, Hastings, Buckingham;
And tell them ’tis the Queen and her allies
That stir the King against the Duke my brother.
Now they believe it, and withal whet me
To be revenged on Rivers, Dorset, Grey.

Which choice best describes what happens in the text?

- A. Richard describes having wept as he informed Derby, Hastings, and Buckingham that the queen and her allies convinced the king to act against Clarence, and says that the earnestness of his grief caused them to accept his version of events.
- B. Richard attributes Clarence’s troubles to both his own secret plotting and the distrust of Clarence that the queen and her allies Derby, Hastings, and Buckingham have planted in the king’s mind.
- C. Richard indicates that he has pretended to be aggrieved about Clarence’s situation and has proclaimed it to be the fault of the queen and her allies, but in reality, he has caused the hostility the king feels toward Clarence.
- D. Richard acknowledges that his mischievous nature has spurred him to commit misdeeds in the past, including instigating enmity between the king and Clarence, but he reports that he has hitherto not lost the trust of the queen and her allies.

ID: c6033bf0 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it accurately describes what happens in the text. Richard admits he committed “the wrong” and blames others for his own “secret mischiefs.” He reveals that he has “cast [Clarence] in darkness” (that is, caused his imprisonment) but feigns grief—“I do bewEEP”—before “many simple [gullible people],” namely Derby, Hastings, and Buckingham. He tells them that the queen and her allies are the ones who turned the king against Clarence. Richard’s use of “bewEEP” and his labeling of his audience as gullible confirm that his grief is a performance. Thus, Richard pretends to be aggrieved and blames the queen while actually being responsible for Clarence’s predicament.

Choice A is incorrect because it characterizes Richard’s grief as earnest, claiming that his sincere grief moved others to accept his claims. However, Richard admits his wrongdoing and calls his audience “simple [gullible people],” making clear that they were deceived by a calculated performance rather than persuaded by genuine emotion. Rather than being sincere, Richard’s weeping is part of a deliberate scheme to blame the queen and her allies for what he did. Choice B is incorrect because Richard does not attribute any portion of Clarence’s troubles to the queen; he reveals that he “cast [Clarence] in darkness” and merely tells others the queen is responsible. Additionally, Derby, Hastings, and Buckingham are not identified as the queen’s allies; rather, Rivers, Dorset, and Grey are implied to be the queen’s allies. Choice D is incorrect because the text does not address whether Richard has maintained the trust of the queen and her allies. Instead, Richard tells Derby, Hastings, and Buckingham that the queen is to blame for Clarence’s troubles, and they in turn urge him to seek revenge on Rivers, Dorset, and Grey, who are implied to be the queen’s allies. The speech focuses on Richard’s manipulation of others, not on his standing with the queen.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ae9d0163

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: ae9d0163

Believing that living in an impractical space can heighten awareness and even improve health, conceptual artists Madeline Gins and Shusaku Arakawa designed an apartment building in Japan to be more fanciful than functional. A kitchen counter is chest-high on one side and knee-high on the other; a ceiling has a door to nowhere. The effect is disorienting but invigorating: after four years there, filmmaker Nobu Yamaoka reported significant health benefits.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Although inhabiting a home surrounded by fanciful features such as those designed by Gins and Arakawa can be rejuvenating, it is unsustainable.
- B. Designing disorienting spaces like those in the Gins and Arakawa building is the most effective way to create a physically stimulating environment.
- C. As a filmmaker, Yamaoka has long supported the designs of conceptual artists such as Gins and Arakawa.
- D. Although impractical, the design of the apartment building by Gins and Arakawa may improve the well-being of the building’s residents.

ID: ae9d0163 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. According to the text, conceptual artists Gins and Arakawa have designed an apartment building that is disorienting because of several unconventional elements, such as uneven kitchen counters and “a door to nowhere.” The text goes on to suggest that there may be benefits to this kind of design because filmmaker Yamaoka lived in the apartment building for four years and reported health benefits. Thus, although the design is impractical, it may improve the well-being of the apartment building’s residents.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text mentions that Yamaoka lived in the apartment for four years, it doesn’t address how long someone can beneficially live in a home surrounded by fanciful features or whether doing so can be sustained. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text mentions the potential benefits of living in a home with disorienting design features, it doesn’t suggest that this is the most effective method to create a physically stimulating environment. Choice C is incorrect because the text refers to Yamaoka to support the claim that Gins and Arakawa’s apartment building design may be beneficial, but the text doesn’t indicate that Yamaoka supports the designs of other conceptual artists.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c725ee5a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: c725ee5a

Given the immense scope of space, the search for extraterrestrial life is almost necessarily concentrated on the exoplanets deemed to have the most plausible chance of success—typically, atmosphere-bearing terrestrial planets orbiting within a certain range of their stars (termed the habitable zone). Claiming that Earth experienced a long transition from single-lid to plate tectonics that accelerated the emergence and evolution of complex organisms, researchers Robert J. Stern and Taras V. Gerya hold that consideration of tectonics, an often overlooked factor, could help further narrow the search for advanced extraterrestrial species.

Based on the text, what do Stern and Gerya most likely believe about the development of complex life on exoplanets?

- A. It is more likely to occur on habitable zone planets with atmospheres and plate tectonics than on otherwise similar planets that lack plate tectonics.
- B. It is more likely to occur if habitable zone planets with atmospheres transition from single-lid to plate tectonics late in their history than if they transition early in their history.
- C. It is unlikely unless the transition from single-lid to plate tectonics occurs before the acquisition of a lasting atmosphere.
- D. It is probably more dependent on the presence of plate tectonics than on orbital distance from a host star or the presence of an atmosphere.

ID: c725ee5a Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes what Stern and Gerya most likely believe about the development of complex life on exoplanets. The text indicates that the search for extraterrestrial life already focuses on atmosphere-bearing planets in the habitable zone because their conditions are best suited for complex organisms. Stern and Gerya claim that plate tectonics on Earth accelerated the emergence of complex organisms, and they therefore hold that tectonics could “help further narrow the search.” This phrase implies that plate tectonics should be added to the existing criteria. In other words, the text implies that among habitable zone planets with atmospheres, those that also have plate tectonics would be more likely to enable the development of complex life than otherwise similar planets lacking plate tectonics.

Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t address whether the timing of the transition to plate tectonics—early versus late in a planet’s history—affects the likelihood of complex life. Although the text mentions that plate tectonics emerged on Earth after a “long transition” and that this process accelerated the development of complex life, it presents these details as context for why plate tectonics matter, not as a claim about when the transition would have needed to occur within the planet’s history. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss the timing of the acquisition of an atmosphere in relation to that of the transition to plate tectonics or explain why this would be relevant to the development of complex life. Rather, the text presents these as independent factors relevant to the search for extraterrestrial life. Choice D is incorrect because the text presents plate tectonics as an additional factor to consider alongside orbital distance from a host star and atmosphere, not as a more important one.

Stern and Gerya propose that tectonics could “help further narrow the search,” which implies supplementing, rather than superseding, the existing criteria.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 916944f0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 916944f0

Across brown bears—omnivores with high dietary plasticity—there is wide variety in dietary mix, which may reflect genetics, local resource availability, or social learning (cubs stay with their mothers for two years or more). Evaluating these possibilities, Anne Hertel et al. analyzed 30 years of data on trophic position (indicative of dietary mix) for female brown bears. After separation, daughters, who tended to settle near their mothers, occupied the same trophic positions as their mothers for two years, but the correlation disappeared by year five. Trophic correlation with unrelated individuals in similar habitats was modest, while habitat-independent correlation with nonmaternal relatives (e.g., cousins) was no different than with unrelated individuals. These findings suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. growing dissimilarity between mothers and their daughters with regard to dietary mix may reflect changes in the resources available in maternal habitats, though social learning could also contribute to the trend.
- B. dietary mix among females may reflect a social learning effect that eventually diminishes, though environmental constraints cannot be ruled out as a contributing factor.
- C. female dietary mix is best understood as changeable and contingent on fluctuating environmental conditions rather than as the result of social learning or genetic factors.
- D. social learning and resource fluctuations may both play a role in dietary mix among females, at least temporarily, though genetic factors appear to make a significant contribution as well.

ID: 916944f0 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Hertel et al.’s study of dietary mix variation among female brown bears. According to the text, the researchers evaluated genetics, local resource availability, and social learning as factors in female brown bears’ trophic position, or position in the food web. According to the text, daughters tended to settle near their mothers after separating and held the same trophic positions as the mothers for two years, but no longer did by the fifth year—a temporary similarity that may reflect a socially learned behavior that faded over time after separation. Additionally, the text states that the degree of similarity in trophic position between nonmaternal relatives (e.g., cousins) was the same as that between unrelated individuals, suggesting that genetics don’t significantly influence dietary mix, and the text also states that there was modest similarity in the trophic positions of unrelated individuals in similar habitats, suggesting that environmental conditions (which would include resource availability) may have some influence on dietary mix. Taken together, the findings suggest that while environmental constraints can’t be ruled out as a contributing factor, dietary mix among female brown bears may reflect a social learning effect that eventually diminishes.

Choice A is incorrect because the text notes that daughters tended to settle near their mothers after separating—that is, that they often didn’t leave the maternal habitat. Therefore, changes in resource availability in the mothers’ habitats would likely have

affected the daughters similarly instead of causing their dietary mix to differ from that of their mothers. Further, the form of social learning addressed by the text is that between mothers and daughters; although the daughters no longer held the same trophic position as their mothers five years after separating from them, the text doesn't address the possibility that the daughters' divergence from the dietary behaviors of their mothers is the result of learning from other bears or suggest that the daughters even interacted with other adult bears in a substantive way. Choice C is incorrect. Instead of suggesting that environmental conditions are the most important factor in dietary mix variation and that social learning isn't a factor, the findings discussed in the text suggest that environmental conditions may have some effect (since there was modest similarity in dietary mix between unrelated bears in similar habitats, or similar environmental conditions) and that social learning may be a factor (since daughters held the same trophic positions as their mothers for two years after separating but not for five years, which may reflect daughters maintaining dietary behaviors they learned from their mothers but changing their behaviors over time). Choice D is incorrect because the findings presented in the text argue against, not for, genetics as a significant factor in variation in dietary mix. The text indicates that independent of their habitats, the degree of similarity in dietary mix between nonmaternal relatives, like cousins, was the same as that between unrelated individuals. This means that genetic relatedness didn't have a detectable effect on dietary mix independent of shared habitat.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 588a4c0d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 588a4c0d

Rivers rich in sediment appear yellow, while increases in red algae make rivers appear red. To track things like the sediment or algae content of large US rivers, John R. Gardner and colleagues used satellite data to determine the dominant visible wavelengths of light measured for various segments of these rivers. The researchers classified wavelengths of 495 nanometers (nm) and below as red, wavelengths between 495 and 560 nm as blue, and wavelengths of 560 nm and above as yellow. The researchers concluded that for the Missouri River, segments flowing into lakes tend to carry more sediment than those flowing out of lakes.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ conclusion?

- A. The segments of the Missouri River that had higher levels of chlorophyll-a, which contributes to the green color of photosynthetic organisms, have dominant wavelengths of light between 490 and 560 nm.
- B. In lakes through which segments of the Missouri River pass, the dominant wavelength of light tended to be above 560 nm near the lakes’ shores and below 560 nm in the lakes’ centers.
- C. The majority of the segments of the Missouri River were found to have dominant wavelengths of light significantly higher than 560 nm.
- D. Segments of the Missouri River flowing into lakes typically had dominant wavelengths of light above 560 nm, while segments flowing out of lakes typically had dominant wavelengths below 560 nm.

ID: 588a4c0d Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support Gardner and colleagues’ conclusion that segments of the Missouri River flowing into lakes tend to carry more sediment than do segments of the river flowing out of lakes. The text says that rivers appear yellow when they contain a lot of sediment and appear red when they contain a lot of algae. It goes on to explain that Gardner and colleagues measured the wavelengths of light for different segments of rivers in the United States and classified those wavelength measurements into colors: red for wavelengths of 495 nanometers and below, blue for wavelengths between 495 and 560 nanometers, and yellow for wavelengths of 560 nanometers and above. Combined with the earlier information about river colors, this suggests that rivers rich in sediment will have wavelengths of 560 nanometers and above (since such rivers appear yellow). If researchers found that Missouri River segments flowing into lakes tend to have wavelengths above 560 nanometers and segments flowing out of lakes tend to have wavelengths below 560 nanometers, this finding would support Gardner and colleagues’ conclusion, since it would suggest that the river tends to carry more sediment when it flows into lakes than when it flows out of lakes.

Choice A is incorrect because finding that sections of the Missouri River with high chlorophyll-a levels have wavelengths between 490 and 560 nanometers would be irrelevant to the researchers’ conclusion that segments of the river flowing into lakes are richer in sediment than are segments of the river flowing out of lakes. This finding would not indicate anything about segments flowing

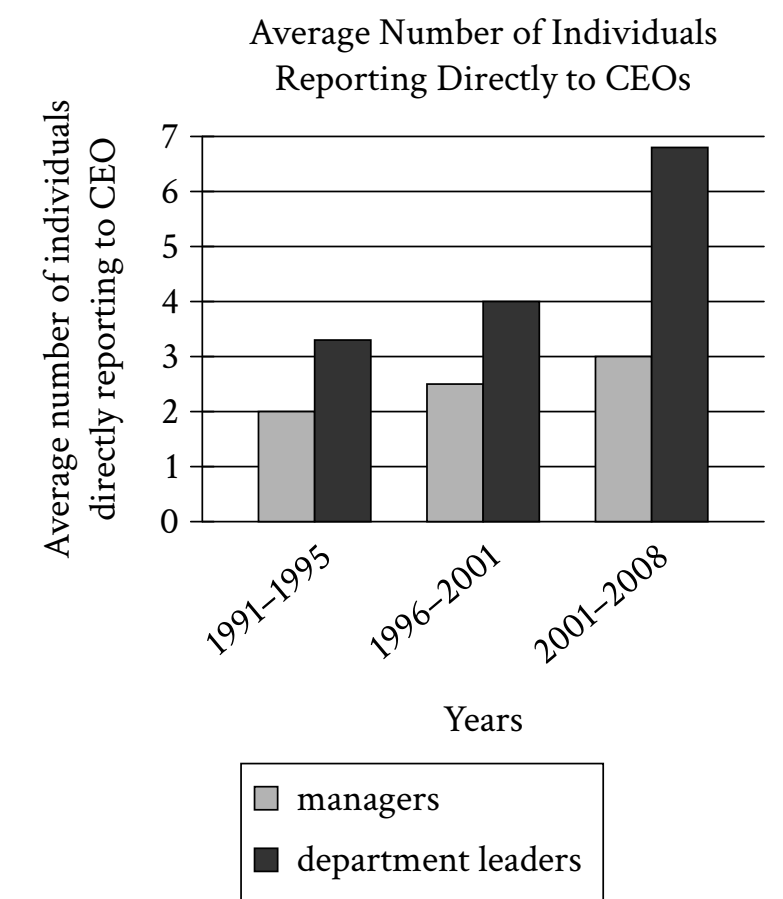
into or out of lakes. Choice B is incorrect because finding that lakes through which the Missouri River passes have higher wavelengths near their shores than in the center would not support the researchers' conclusion that segments of the river flowing into lakes have more sediment than segments flowing out of lakes. This finding would suggest only that there is more sediment around the edges of lakes than in their centers, which does not have any direct bearing on the researchers' conclusion about river segments flowing into and out of lakes. Choice C is incorrect because finding that most segments of the Missouri River have wavelengths significantly higher than 560 nanometers would suggest that most segments of the river are high in sediment, not that segments flowing into lakes are higher in sediment than segments flowing out of lakes. Only a comparison of river segments flowing into lakes with segments flowing out of lakes can support the researchers' conclusion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6ad914fb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 6ad914fb



Considering a large sample of companies, economics experts Maria Guadalupe, Julie Wulf, and Raghuram Rajan assessed the number of managers and leaders from different departments who reported directly to a chief executive officer (CEO). According to the researchers, the findings suggest that across the years analyzed, there was a growing interest among CEOs in connecting with more departments in their companies.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that support the researchers’ conclusion?

- A. The average numbers of managers and department leaders reporting directly to their CEO didn’t fluctuate from the 1991–1995 period to the 2001–2008 period.
- B. The average number of managers reporting directly to their CEO was highest in the 1996–2001 period.
- C. The average number of department leaders reporting directly to their CEO was greater than the average number of managers reporting directly to their CEO in each of the three periods studied.
- D. The average number of department leaders reporting directly to their CEO rose over the three periods studied.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it describes data from the graph that support the researchers' conclusion that there is a growing interest among CEOs in connecting with more departments in their companies. The graph shows the average number of individuals reporting directly to CEOs during three different time periods: the individuals are divided into managers and department leaders. The average number of department leaders directly reporting to their CEO during the 1991–1995 period was slightly more than three, during the 1996–2001 period it was four, and during the 2001–2008 period it was almost seven. Thus, the average number of department leaders reporting directly to their CEO rose over the three periods studied, which suggests that CEOs were connecting with more departments.

Choice A is incorrect because the average number of managers and department leaders reporting directly to their CEO rose for both categories between the 1991–1995 and 2001–2008 periods; thus, it isn't true that the average numbers didn't fluctuate. Choice B is incorrect because the average number of managers reporting directly to their CEO was highest in the 2001–2008 period, not in the 1996–2001 period. Choice C is incorrect. Although it correctly describes a feature of the graph, the observation that more department leaders than managers are reporting to CEOs does not by itself address the question of whether CEOs are connecting with more departments over time—to address that question, one needs to know whether the number of department leaders reporting to CEOs is increasing over time.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bc3b92b4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: bc3b92b4

Corn-Related Vocabulary in Various Southeastern Languages

Language family	Word (language)	English translation	Proposed origin in vocabulary of the Totozoquean language family
Muskogean	tanchi' (Chickasaw); tanchi (Choctaw); vce (Muscogee, pronounced "uh-chi")	corn	no
Iroquoian	se-lu (Cherokee)	corn	no
Caddoan	-k'as- (Caddo)	dried corn	yes
Chitimacha	k'asma (Chitimacha)	corn	yes

In Caddo, a language from what is now the US Southeast, vocabulary pertaining to corn cultivation resembles equivalent vocabulary in the Totozoquean language family in Mexico. This resemblance is perhaps attributable to cultural contact: such words could have entered Caddo through the intermediary of the neighboring but unrelated Chitimacha language, concurrent with the dissemination of corn itself from Mexico into the Southeast after 700 CE. That the vocabulary pertaining to domestic crops accompanies them as they diffuse into new regions is an established phenomenon globally. Crops may also be decoupled from vocabulary altogether: corn cultivation became ubiquitous among the Southeastern tribes, yet _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement?

- A. the origins of vocabulary pertaining to the crop vary across languages in the region, with the words for corn in Cherokee and the Muskogean languages showing no demonstrable relationship to Totozoquean vocabulary.
- B. the region is linguistically diverse, being home not only to Chitimacha and Caddo, but also to the Muskogean language family (including Chickasaw, Choctaw, and Muscogee) and to one Iroquoian language (Cherokee).
- C. corn-related vocabulary underwent changes when entering other, unrelated languages, as can be seen by the divergence of the Caddo word from the Chitimacha word it originated in.
- D. words for corn in the languages of the Muskogean family evolved from a common root, with the Muscogee word having lost certain consonant sounds still present in the Chickasaw and Choctaw words.

ID: bc3b92b4 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The table provides evidence that the words for corn in the Cherokee and Muskogean languages appear unrelated to those in Caddo language, which is described as closely related to the Totozoquean language family. This supports the claim that corn cultivation spread across the Southeast without necessarily spreading Totozoquean vocabulary along with it.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice emphasizes the diversity of Southeastern languages in general, but we're specifically looking for information about words associated with corn. Choice C is incorrect. This choice shows how words for corn can change and evolve, but we're looking for an example that shows how some words for corn can be completely unrelated. Choice D is incorrect. This choice shows words for corn that share a common root, but we're looking for an example that shows how some words for corn can be unrelated.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3d52112e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 3d52112e

The recovery of a 1,000-year-old Chinese shipwreck in the Java Sea near present-day Indonesia has yielded a treasure trove of artifacts, including thousands of small ceramic bowls. Using a portable X-ray fluorescence analyzer tool, Lisa Niziolek and her team were able to detect the chemical composition of these bowls without damaging them. By comparing the chemical signatures of the bowls with those of the materials still at old Chinese kiln sites, Niziolek and her team can pinpoint which Chinese kilns likely produced the ceramic bowls.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Because of a new technology, researchers can locate and recover more shipwrecks than they could in the past.
- B. Researchers have been able to identify the location of a number of Chinese kilns in operation 1,000 years ago.
- C. With the help of a special tool, researchers have determined the likely origin of bowls recovered from a shipwreck.
- D. Before the invention of portable X-ray fluorescence, researchers needed to take a small piece out of an artifact to analyze its components.

ID: 3d52112e Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. According to the text, thousands of ceramic bowls were found in a recovered Chinese shipwreck. The text goes on to say that Niziolek and her team used a special tool, a portable X-ray fluorescence analyzer, to determine the bowls’ chemical signatures. Comparing these chemical signatures with the chemical signatures of materials they had collected from old Chinese kiln sites, the text says, allowed the researchers to identify which kilns had produced the bowls. In other words, the researchers determined the bowls’ origin.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text indicates that the researchers used technology in the form of a portable X-ray fluorescence analyzer, it doesn’t specifically state that this technology is new. In addition, the text says that Niziolek and her team used the tool to determine the chemical composition of bowls that were found in a Chinese shipwreck, not to locate and recover the shipwreck itself. There’s no indication in the text that a new technology can help researchers locate and recover shipwrecks. Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that the researchers collected materials from old kiln sites for chemical comparison with the ceramic bowls, which means that the researchers must have already known the location of those kiln sites. Rather than identifying the location of the kilns, the researchers determined which kilns in operation 1,000 years ago had likely produced the bowls that were found in the shipwreck. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text says that using a portable X-ray fluorescence analyzer tool enabled Niziolek and her team to analyze artifacts in the form of ceramic bowls without damaging them, the text doesn’t discuss how researchers analyzed artifacts before this tool was invented. Moreover, the point that the bowls were left undamaged isn’t the text’s main idea. Rather, it’s a detail that’s provided to develop the main idea, which is that the researchers used a special tool to determine where the bowls had been produced.

Question ID f2ad6231

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: f2ad6231

Archaeologists have held that the Casarabe culture, which emerged in the southwestern Amazon basin in the first millennium CE, was characterized by a sparse, widely distributed population and little intervention in the surrounding wilderness. Recently, however, archaeologist Heiko Prümers and colleagues conducted a study of the region using remote-sensing technology that enabled them to create three-dimensional images of the jungle-covered landscape from above, and the researchers concluded that the Casarabe people developed a form of urbanism in the Amazon basin.

- Which finding about the remote-sensing images, if true, would most directly support Prümers and colleagues’ conclusion?
- A. They show shapes consistent with widely separated settlements of roughly equal small size surrounded by uncultivated jungle.
 - B. They show shapes consistent with long-distance footpaths running from Casarabe territories to large cities outside the region inhabited by the Casarabe people.
 - C. They show shapes consistent with scattered small farms created by clearing jungle areas near sources of fresh water.
 - D. They show shapes consistent with monumental platforms and dense central settlements linked to smaller settlements by a system of canals and roadways.

ID: f2ad6231 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. This finding, if true, would support the archaeologists’ conclusion. Dense central settlements linked to smaller ones would provide evidence of cities and suburbs—in other words, “a form of urbanism.”

Choice A is incorrect. This finding, if true, would weaken the archaeologists’ conclusion. Widely separated, small settlements with jungle in between would support the long-held belief that the Casarabe culture “was characterized by a sparse, widely distributed population and little intervention in the surrounding wilderness.” Choice B is incorrect. This choice wouldn’t support the researchers’ conclusion. These large cities are located outside Casarabe territory, which doesn’t show evidence of Casarabe urbanism. Choice C is incorrect. This finding wouldn’t support the archaeologists’ conclusion. Scattered small farms in jungle clearings are not good evidence to support the existence of cities (“a form of urbanism”).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cd290e3c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: cd290e3c

The Land of Enchantment is a 1906 travel book by Lilian Whiting. In the book, which describes the experience of traveling through the southwestern United States by train, Whiting reflects on the escape from everyday life that such a journey provides: _____

Which quotation from *The Land of Enchantment* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. "The opportunities and advantages already offered and constantly increasing are greater than would at first be considered possible."
- B. "The social and the picturesque charm of the long journey is singularly enhanced by the leisurely stops made for refreshment."
- C. "The real journey begins, of course, at Chicago, and as these trains leave in the evening the traveller fares forth in the seclusion of his berth."
- D. "One experiences a certain sense of detachment from ordinary day and daylight duties that is exhilarating."

ID: cd290e3c Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because. This quotation specifically describes a "sense of detachment from ordinary day," which matches the claim's focus on "escape from everyday life."

Choice A is incorrect. While this quotation describes new opportunities associated with Whiting's experience, it doesn't frame these opportunities as "an escape," and it doesn't directly compare Whiting's journey with "everyday life." Choice B is incorrect. While this quotation includes a positive characterization of Whiting's journey, it doesn't specifically address the idea of an "escape from everyday life," which is the focus of the claim. Choice C is incorrect. This quotation focuses on where the journey begins, not on how it feels like an "escape from everyday life."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f7ac3147

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: f7ac3147

The presence of other individuals of the same species has been observed to mitigate stress in highly social mammals. To investigate whether this phenomenon, known as social buffering, also occurs in reptiles, researchers led by Chelsea E. Martin monitored stress responses in wild southern Pacific rattlesnakes (*Crotalus helleri*) in three experimental treatments: when alone, with a rope, and with a companion *C. helleri*. The researchers compared the percent change between baseline and peak heart rate in response to a (harmless) disturbance, with higher values indicating higher stress levels.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the idea that social buffering occurs among *C. helleri*?

- A. The average percent change in heart rate was lower among *C. helleri* with a companion than among solitary *C. helleri* and *C. helleri* with a rope.
- B. Average peak heart rates were highest among solitary *C. helleri*, but no differences were observed in average peak heart rates between *C. helleri* with a companion and *C. helleri* with a rope.
- C. *C. helleri* with a companion displayed a lower average baseline heart rate and lower average peak heart rate than did solitary *C. helleri* or *C. helleri* with a rope.
- D. Solitary *C. helleri* had higher average baseline heart rates than did *C. helleri* in the other treatments, but the average percent change in heart rate was smaller among solitary *C. helleri* than among *C. helleri* with a companion.

ID: f7ac3147 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support the idea that social buffering—the mitigation of stress by the presence of other animals of the same species—occurs among *C. helleri*. According to the text, the researchers quantified the amount of stress in *C. helleri* as the percent change between baseline and peak heart rate, with higher values indicating greater stress. The text also describes the researchers’ three treatments: snakes alone, snakes with a rope, and snakes with a companion *C. helleri*. If the average percent change in heart rate was lower among snakes with a companion than among either solitary snakes or snakes with a rope, that would indicate two things: snakes accompanied by a companion experienced less stress than they did when alone, and the reduction wasn’t simply the result of any object being present, since the rope didn’t produce the same effect. Together, these results would directly support the conclusion that the companion’s presence mitigated stress, as the social buffering hypothesis predicts.

Choice B is incorrect because the finding compares peak heart rates among the three treatments rather than the percent change in heart rates among those treatments. The finding also indicates that snakes with a companion and snakes with a rope showed no differences in peak heart rates. If a rope produced the same effect as a companion did, that would suggest that the effect, whatever its extent, isn’t caused specifically by the presence of another individual of the same species and so wouldn’t support the social buffering hypothesis. Choice C is incorrect because the finding addresses absolute baseline and peak heart rates rather than the percent change between them, which is the measure of stress response the researchers used. Lower absolute heart

rates in companion-present snakes could reflect a generally calmer state but wouldn't show that the stress response to the disturbance was reduced and so wouldn't directly demonstrate social buffering as defined in the study. Choice D is incorrect because the finding states that the percent change in heart rate was smaller among solitary snakes than among snakes with a companion, which would indicate a smaller stress response when alone. This pattern would directly contradict the social buffering hypothesis rather than support it. Furthermore, a comparison of baseline heart rates would be immaterial for determining whether social buffering occurs among *C. helleri* because the text indicates that a change in heart rate, not average baseline heart rate, indicates a stress response.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 47564f39

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 47564f39

Employment by Sector in France and the United States, 1800–2012 (% of total employment)

Year	Agriculture in France	Manufacturing in France	Services in France	Agriculture in US	Manufacturing in US	Services in US
1800	64	22	14	68	18	13
1900	43	29	28	41	28	31
1950	32	33	35	14	33	53
2012	3	21	76	2	18	80

Rows in table may not add up to 100 due to rounding.

Over the past two hundred years, the percentage of the population employed in the agricultural sector has declined in both France and the United States, while employment in the service sector (which includes jobs in retail, consulting, real estate, etc.) has risen. However, this transition happened at very different rates in the two countries. This can be seen most clearly by comparing the employment by sector in both countries in _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement?

- A. 1900 with the employment by sector in 1950.
- B. 1800 with the employment by sector in 2012.
- C. 1900 with the employment by sector in 2012.
- D. 1800 with the employment by sector in 1900.

ID: 47564f39 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents data from the table that most effectively complete the statement about the rates at which employment shifted in France and the United States. The text states that over the last two hundred years employment in the agricultural sector has declined while employment in the service sector has risen in both France and the US, and the data from the table reflect these trends. The text asserts, however, that the transition from agriculture to services “happened at very different rates in the two countries.” This assertion is best supported by a comparison of data from 1900 and 1950: the table shows that in those years, employment in agriculture went from 43% to 32% in France (a decline of 11 percentage points) and from 41% to 14% in the US (a decline of 27 percentage points), and that employment in services went from 28% to 35% in France (an increase of 7 percentage points) and from 31% to 53% in the US (an increase of 22 percentage points). In other words, the rate of change was greater in the US than in France for both sectors.

Choice B is incorrect because comparing the data for 1800 and 2012 would suggest a similar rate of change in the two countries, not very different rates: employment in agriculture went from 64% in 1800 to 3% in 2012 in France, which is close to the change from 68% in 1800 to 2% in 2012 in the US, while employment in services went from 14% in 1800 to 76% in 2012 in France, which is close to the change from 13% in 1800 to 80% in 2012 in the US. Choice C is incorrect because comparing the data for 1900 and 2012 would suggest a similar rate of change in the two countries rather than very different rates: employment in agriculture went from 43% in 1900 to 3% in 2012 in France, which is close to the change from 41% in 1900 to 2% in 2012 in the US, while employment in services went from 28% in 1900 to 76% in 2012 in France, which is close to the change from 31% in 1900 to 80% in 2012 in the US. Choice D is incorrect because comparing the data for 1800 and 1900 would suggest a similar rate of change in the two countries, not very different rates: employment in agriculture went from 64% in 1800 to 43% in 1900 in France, which is fairly close to the change from 68% in 1800 to 41% in 1900 in the US, while employment in services went from 14% in 1800 to 28% in 1900 in France, which is close to the change from 13% in 1800 to 31% in 1900 in the US.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3c59a666

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 3c59a666

Swahili Speakers in Three African Countries

Country	Approximate number of speakers (in millions)	Estimated % of population
Democratic Republic of the Congo	22	25
Kenya	55	100
Tanzania	61	100

Swahili is estimated to be the first language of up to 15 million people worldwide. It’s also an officially recognized language in Tanzania, Kenya, and the Democratic Republic of the Congo, which means these countries use Swahili in government documents and proceedings. But even in countries where almost everyone speaks Swahili, for many it isn’t their first language but is instead their second, third, or even fourth language.

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to support the underlined claim?

- A. Tanzania has approximately 61 million Swahili speakers, which is much more than the estimated total number of people worldwide for whom Swahili is their first language.
- B. Tanzania is estimated to have at most 15 million Swahili speakers, while the country’s total population is approximately 61 million people.
- C. Approximately 100 percent of the people who speak Swahili as their first language live in Kenya, which has a total population of approximately 55 million people.
- D. Approximately 100 percent of Kenya’s population speaks Swahili, while only about 25 percent of the Democratic Republic of the Congo’s population speaks Swahili.

ID: 3c59a666 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the table to support the underlined claim. The text indicates that Swahili is the first language of up to 15 million people worldwide. The text goes on to claim, in the underlined portion, that even in countries where nearly everyone speaks Swahili, many of the language’s speakers don’t have Swahili as their first language. The table indicates that 61 million people in Tanzania, which amounts to 100 percent of the population, speak Swahili. If 61 million people in Tanzania speak Swahili, but only 15 million people worldwide have Swahili as their first language, that means there are many people in Tanzania who speak Swahili as a language other than their first language. This information about Swahili speakers in Tanzania therefore supports the claim that many Swahili speakers in countries where nearly everyone speaks Swahili speak it as a language other than their first language (such as their second, third, or fourth language).

Choice B is incorrect because it doesn't accurately describe information in the table. According to the table, Tanzania has 61 million Swahili speakers, not at most 15 million Swahili speakers. Additionally, the table indicates that 100 percent of Tanzania's population speak Swahili, which means that the number of Swahili speakers in the country and the country's total population should be the same, not that they should differ by such a large amount. Choice C is incorrect because there's no information in the table or the text that indicates where people who speak Swahili as their first language live. Although Kenya's total population can be inferred from the table—if Kenya has 55 million Swahili speakers and 100% of Kenya's population speak Swahili, then Kenya must have a population of 55 million people—nothing suggests that all the people who speak Swahili as their first language live in a single country, let alone that they all live in Kenya. Choice D is incorrect. Although the table does indicate that 100 percent of Kenya's population and 25 percent of the Democratic Republic of the Congo's population speak Swahili, this comparison is irrelevant to the claim that Swahili isn't the first language of many of its speakers even in countries where almost everyone speaks Swahili. On its own, a difference in the proportions of the population who speak Swahili cannot reveal whether those Swahili speakers have Swahili as their first language or a subsequent language.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a2b2701d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a2b2701d

An Ideal Husband is an 1895 play by Oscar Wilde. In the play, which is a satire, Wilde suggests that a character named Lady Gertrude Chiltern is perceived as both extremely virtuous and unforgiving, as is evident when another character says _____

Which quotation from *An Ideal Husband* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. "Lady Chiltern is a woman of the very highest principles, I am glad to say. I am a little too old now, myself, to trouble about setting a good example, but I always admire people who do."
- B. "Do you know, [Lady Chiltern], I don't mind your talking morality a bit. Morality is simply the attitude we adopt towards people whom we personally dislike."
- C. "[Lady Chiltern] does not know what weakness or temptation is. I am of clay like other men. She stands apart as good women do—pitiless in her perfection—cold and stern and without mercy."
- D. "Lady Chiltern, you are a sensible woman, the most sensible woman in London, the most sensible woman I know."

ID: a2b2701d Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most effectively uses a quotation to illustrate the claim that Lady Gertrude Chiltern is perceived as "both extremely virtuous and unforgiving." In the quotation, a man describes Lady Chiltern as someone who "does not know what weakness or temptation is." In other words, the man regards her as someone who is strong and adheres to a strict definition of moral perfection. However, he ironically suggests that this definition excludes mercy and forgiveness—qualities that are also thought of as virtues; according to him, Lady Chiltern is "pitiless in her perfection—cold and stern and without mercy." This description supports the idea that Lady Chiltern is perceived by others as virtuous as well as unforgiving.

Choice A is incorrect. The quotation supports the claim that Lady Chiltern is perceived as virtuous, in that it describes her as "a woman of the very highest principles." However, it doesn't characterize her as unforgiving or being perceived as such. Choice B is incorrect. The quotation suggests that Lady Chiltern is concerned with morality, but it suggests that her interest in discussing it is fundamentally hypocritical and functions as a means by which to judge others. However, the quotation doesn't address the question of whether Lady Chiltern is unmerciful to those who seek forgiveness for harm they have caused. Choice D is incorrect because it doesn't address either Lady Chiltern's perceived virtuousness or her perceived lack of forgiveness; instead, it expresses the belief that she is sensible.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 90865757

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 90865757

Some animal-behavior studies involve observing wild animals in their natural habitat, and some involve capturing wild animals and observing them in a laboratory. Each approach has advantages over the other. In wild studies, researchers can more easily presume that the animals are behaving normally, and in lab studies, researchers can more easily control factors that might affect the results. But if, for example, the results from a wild study and a lab study of Western scrub-jays (*Aphelocoma californica*) contradict each other, one or both of the studies must have failed to account for some factor that was relevant to the birds' behavior.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. When the results of a natural-habitat study and those from a lab study of a wild animal such as the Western scrub-jay conflict, the study in the natural habitat is more likely than the lab study to have accurate results.
- B. Studying wild animals such as the Western scrub-jay in both their natural habitat and lab settings is likely to yield conflicting results that researchers cannot fully resolve.
- C. Wild animals such as the Western scrub-jay can be effectively studied in their natural habitat and in the lab, but each approach has drawbacks that could affect the accuracy of the findings.
- D. Differing results between natural-habitat and lab studies of wild animals such as the Western scrub-jay are a strong indication that both of the studies had design flaws that affected the accuracy of their results.

ID: 90865757 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text begins by explaining that wild animals can be studied in their natural habitat or in a laboratory setting, with each setting offering unique advantages to researchers. The text then highlights an instance in which Western scrub-jays were studied in both settings but with conflicting results, indicating that one or both studies may have failed to account for the disadvantages of its research setting. Thus, the main idea of the text is that while wild animals can be effectively studied in natural or lab settings, there are drawbacks to each that need to be considered to ensure accurate results.

Choice A is incorrect because the text does not position one study setting (natural or lab) as superior to the other; rather, the text states that each one has advantages over the other. Choice B is incorrect. The text provides a hypothetical example of two studies in different environments with conflicting results, but this single example cannot be extrapolated to a general claim about the likelihood that results of studies in different environments will conflict. Additionally, the text does not assert anything about how researchers can or cannot resolve conflicting study results. Choice D is incorrect because the text does not state that discrepancies between natural-habitat and lab-based animal behavior studies are due to both of the designs being flawed. Rather, the text states that the conflict in results can be the consequence of one or both of the studies having failed to account for some factor.

Question ID a64e6a61

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: a64e6a61

Archaeologists and historians used to believe that the Maya civilization during its Classic period (roughly 250–900) lacked agricultural marketplaces. One reason for this belief was that these scholars misunderstood the ecology of the regions the Maya inhabited. Marketplaces typically emerge because different individuals or groups want to trade resources they control for resources they don’t control. Scholars seriously underestimated the ecological diversity of the Maya landscape and thus assumed that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. marketplaces likely would not have attracted many traders from outside the regions controlled by the Maya.
- B. farming practices would have been largely the same throughout Maya lands even if the crops people produced varied significantly.
- C. marketplaces would not have enabled Maya people to acquire many products different from those they already produced.
- D. farmers would trade agricultural products only if they had already produced enough to meet their own needs.

ID: a64e6a61 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of scholars’ understanding of Maya ecology and agricultural marketplaces. The text indicates that scholars used to believe that during the Classic period, the Maya civilization didn’t have agricultural marketplaces. According to the text, scholars held this view because they misunderstood the ecology of areas where the Maya lived. The text points out that people tend to create marketplaces in order to acquire resources they don’t otherwise control. Agricultural marketplaces would have allowed farmers who produced one type of crop to trade that crop for other types of crops that they didn’t produce. The text goes on to say, however, that scholars underestimated the ecological diversity of the Maya areas, meaning that scholars thought that the Maya landscape produced a smaller range of resources than it actually produced. Taken together, then, this information suggests that scholars assumed that marketplaces wouldn’t have allowed Maya people to acquire products different from the products they already produced: that is, if everyone produced the same array of crops, as scholars mistakenly believed, then there wouldn’t have been any need for marketplaces where people could trade those crops.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t say anything about trade between the Maya and people from outside the regions controlled by the Maya. Although scholars’ mistaken belief that the Maya lands weren’t very ecologically diverse would give those scholars a reason to think that the Maya didn’t have marketplaces, it wouldn’t lead scholars to assume that traders from outside Maya lands were uninterested in acquiring resources produced by the Maya. Even if the Maya actually did produce only a small array of resources throughout their lands, there is no reason to believe from the text that people outside Maya lands also produced these same resources and thus would have no need to trade with the Maya people. Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that scholars underestimated the ecological diversity of the Maya lands, which suggests that they mistakenly

believed that the Maya produced a relatively small array of resources throughout their territory, not that the crops the Maya produced varied significantly throughout the Maya lands. Although the scholars might have assumed that a lack of ecological diversity suggests that Maya farming practices were largely the same everywhere, the text does not support that they also assumed there was a lot of variation in the crops that Maya people produced. In fact, the text states that marketplaces emerge when people want to obtain resources they don't already control. If it were the case that scholars assumed that the crops Maya people produced varied significantly, this would have led them to conclude that Maya people likely established marketplaces so they could trade for resources they didn't already possess, not that the Maya civilization lacked marketplaces. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that scholars assumed that farmers wouldn't trade their agricultural products unless they had already met their own needs with those products. Instead, the text says that scholars thought that the Maya lands produced a smaller array of resources than they actually did, which the text suggests led scholars to assume that the Maya didn't have any need for marketplaces. The scholars' mistaken belief has no bearing on the issue of whether farmers met their own needs before trading their products.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fa8873e2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: fa8873e2

As the name suggests, dramaturges originated in theater, where they continue to serve a variety of functions: conducting historical research for directors, compiling character biographies for actors, and perhaps most importantly, helping writers of plays and musicals to hone the works’ stories and characters. Performance scholar Susan Manning observes that many choreographers, like playwrights and musical theater writers, are concerned with storytelling and characterization. In fact, some choreographers describe the dances they create as expressions of narrative through movement; it is therefore unsurprising that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. dramaturges can have a profound impact on the artistic direction of plays and musicals.
- B. choreographers developing dances with narrative elements frequently engage dramaturges to assist in refining those elements.
- C. dances by choreographers who incorporate narrative elements are more accessible to audiences than dances by choreographers who do not.
- D. some directors and actors rely too heavily on dramaturges to complete certain research tasks.

ID: fa8873e2 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Dramaturges help playwrights with storytelling and characterization. Choreographers often tell stories through dance, so they are also concerned with storytelling and characterization. This suggests that the fact that choreographers seek the help of dramaturges with the storytelling aspects of their dances should be “unsurprising.”

Choice A is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The beginning of the text does imply that this is true, but the end is leading to a conclusion about how choreographers use dramaturges. Choice C is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never mentions dances by choreographers who don’t incorporate narrative elements. Choice D is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text mentions in passing that directors use dramaturges to conduct research, but it never suggests that directors and actors are too reliant on them. Also, the text is leading to a conclusion about how choreographers use dramaturges.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c769d504

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: c769d504

In 1534 CE, King Henry VIII of England split with the Catholic Church and declared himself head of the Church of England, in part because Pope Clement VII refused to annul his marriage to Catherine of Aragon. Two years later, Henry VIII introduced a policy titled the Dissolution of the Monasteries that by 1540 had resulted in the closure of all Catholic monasteries in England and the confiscation of their estates. Some historians assert that the enactment of the policy was primarily motivated by perceived financial opportunities.

Which quotation from a scholarly article best supports the assertion of the historians mentioned in the text?

- A. "At the time of the Dissolution of the Monasteries, about 2 percent of the adult male population of England were monks; by 1690, the proportion of the adult male population who were monks was less than 1 percent."
- B. "A contemporary description of the Dissolution of the Monasteries, Michael Sherbrook's *Falle of the Religious Howses*, recounts witness testimony that monks were allowed to keep the contents of their cells and that the monastery timber was purchased by local yeomen."
- C. "In 1535, the year before enacting the Dissolution of the Monasteries, Henry commissioned a survey of the value of church holdings in England—the work, performed by sheriffs, bishops, and magistrates, began that January and was swiftly completed by the summer."
- D. "The October 1536 revolt known as the Pilgrimage of Grace had several economic motives: high food prices due to a poor harvest the prior year; the Dissolution of the Monasteries, which closed reliable sources of food and shelter for many; and rents and taxes throughout Northern England that were not merely high but predatory."

ID: c769d504 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The fact that Henry VIII commissioned a survey of church holdings just before enacting the Dissolution of the Monasteries suggests that he was interested in the potential profits from claiming their assets. This supports the historians’ assertion.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice describes a potential effect of the Dissolution of the Monasteries. The decrease in the proportion of monks in England isn’t relevant to the question of Henry VIII’s motivations. Choice B is incorrect. Details about how the monks were treated during the dissolution don’t address Henry VIII’s motivations for enacting the policy in the first place. That the monks could keep the content of their cells (their rooms) and sell off the timber they’d harvested has no impact on the value of the monasteries’ estates—their land holdings. Choice D is incorrect. This choice mentions one impact that the Dissolution of the Monasteries contributed to, two years after it happened. But it doesn’t help explain why Henry VIII might have wanted to enact the policy in the first place.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 27dad141

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 27dad141

Through adaptive radiation, multiple species of *Tetragnatha*—a genus of orb-weaving spiders—have significantly diversified their web architecture over a relatively short timescale. To investigate whether the material properties of *Tetragnatha* silk have been similarly affected by this evolutionary process, Angela M. Alicea-Serrano et al. examined the chemical composition of both the radial (non-sticky threads extending from the center) and capture (sticky threads that hold prey) silks that form the web as well as tested the tensile strength and viscosity of samples collected from three *Tetragnatha* species at two sites in the Hawaiian archipelago. The team found significant interspecies variation in these biomaterials.

- Which choice best states the main idea of the text?
- A. Research reveals that web architecture among species of *Tetragnatha* spiders has likely diversified more rapidly than the material properties of *Tetragnatha*’s silk have.
 - B. Research suggests that the material properties of silk from species of *Tetragnatha* spiders have diversified during adaptive radiation.
 - C. A study indicates that variations in web architecture among species of *Tetragnatha* spiders can likely be explained by corresponding variations in the material properties of their silks.
 - D. A study shows that adaptive radiation can explain interspecies variation in the web architecture of *Tetragnatha* spiders but not in the material properties of the spiders’ silk.

ID: 27dad141 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text notes that *Tetragnatha* spiders have diversified their web architecture, or web design, through adaptive radiation and that Alicea-Serrano et al. investigated whether silk material properties were also affected by this process. After examining chemical composition, tensile strength, and viscosity of silks from three *Tetragnatha* species, the team found significant interspecies variation in these material properties, meaning that there were observable differences in these traits across the studied species. In the context of the study’s research question, this finding suggests that the material properties of silk from species of *Tetragnatha* spiders have indeed diversified during adaptive radiation, which is the main idea of the text.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t compare the rate of diversification in web architecture to the rate of diversification in silk properties. Although the text notes that web architecture diversified “over a relatively short timescale,” it doesn’t make a corresponding temporal claim about silk properties or suggest that one changed more rapidly than the other. Choice C is incorrect because the study investigated silk properties as a separate question, not as an explanation for differences in web architecture. The researchers discussed in the text investigated whether silk properties were “similarly affected” by adaptive radiation, not whether they caused the variations in web design. Choice D is incorrect because it contradicts the findings described in the text.

The study found “significant interspecies variation” in silk biomaterials, suggesting that adaptive radiation did affect the properties of *Tetragnatha* spiders’ silk rather than showing that adaptive radiation cannot explain silk variation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2d476f20

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 2d476f20

In a study by Mika R. Moran, Daniel A. Rodriguez, and colleagues, residents of Quito, Ecuador, and Lima, Peru, were surveyed about parks in their cities. Of the 618 respondents from Quito, 82.9% indicated that they use the city’s parks, and of the 663 respondents from Lima, 72.7% indicated using city parks. Given that the percentage of Quito respondents who reported living within a 10-minute walk of a park was much lower than that reported by Lima respondents, greater proximity alone can’t explain the difference in park use.

- The text makes which point about the difference between the proportions of Quito residents and Lima residents using parks?
- A. It was much larger than the researchers conducting the study expected.
 - B. It is caused by something other than the parks’ proximity to city residents.
 - C. It could be due to inaccuracies in the survey results.
 - D. It was calculated using sources that predate the survey.

ID: 2d476f20 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a statement about the difference between the proportions of Quito residents and Lima residents using parks that is supported by the text. The text states that 82.9% of surveyed Quito residents and 72.7% of surveyed Lima residents reported using their city’s parks. The text then notes that compared to Lima respondents, a much smaller percentage of Quito respondents said they live within a 10-minute walk of a park. The text concludes that because a greater proportion of Quito respondents used parks despite generally living farther from them than Lima respondents did, "greater proximity"—being closer to a park—"can't explain the difference in park use." That is, the text makes the point that the difference between the proportions of Quito residents and Lima residents using parks is caused by something other than the distance of the parks from city residents.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t address whether the researchers had expected a particular result and doesn’t indicate that they were surprised by the difference in park usage between the two cities’ residents. The text simply presents the survey findings without stating the researchers’ expectations. Choice C is incorrect because the text gives no indication that there might be inaccuracies in the survey results; the text presents the findings as factual information and uses them as the basis for a conclusion that a certain factor doesn’t explain differences in park usage between Quito and Lima residents. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t mention any sources that predate the survey or suggest that the difference in proportions was calculated using such sources. According to the text, the information about park usage came directly from the survey of residents in Quito and Lima.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d6d3d811

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: d6d3d811

Black beans (*Phaseolus vulgaris*) are a nutritionally dense food, but they are difficult to digest in part because of their high levels of soluble fiber and compounds like raffinose. They also contain antinutrients like tannins and trypsin inhibitors, which interfere with the body’s ability to extract nutrients from foods. In a research article, Marisela Granito and Glenda Álvarez from Simón Bolívar University in Venezuela claim that inducing fermentation of black beans using lactic acid bacteria improves the digestibility of the beans and makes them more nutritious.

Which finding from Granito and Álvarez’s research, if true, would most directly support their claim?

- A. When cooked, fermented beans contained significantly more trypsin inhibitors and tannins but significantly less soluble fiber and raffinose than nonfermented beans.
- B. Fermented beans contained significantly less soluble fiber and raffinose than nonfermented beans, and when cooked, the fermented beans also displayed a significant reduction in trypsin inhibitors and tannins.
- C. When the fermented beans were analyzed, they were found to contain two microorganisms, *Lactobacillus casei* and *Lactobacillus plantarum*, that are theorized to increase the amount of nitrogen absorbed by the gut after eating beans.
- D. Both fermented and nonfermented black beans contained significantly fewer trypsin inhibitors and tannins after being cooked at high pressure.

ID: d6d3d811 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that would best support Granito and Álvarez’s claim that fermenting black beans makes them easier to digest and more nutritious. The text indicates that high levels of soluble fiber and raffinose in black beans make the beans hard to digest and that tannins and trypsin inhibitors make it harder for the body to extract nutrients from the beans. If it were found that fermenting the beans significantly reduces their levels of soluble fiber, raffinose, trypsin inhibitors, and tannins when cooked, this would directly support the claim that fermentation improves the digestibility of the beans and makes them more nutritious.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that trypsin inhibitors and tannins interfere with the body’s ability to extract nutrients from black beans; if fermentation and cooking were found to increase these antinutrients, fermented beans would likely be less nutritious than unfermented ones, not more nutritious (as Granito and Álvarez claim). Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t address the idea that greater nitrogen absorption in the gut has an effect on a food’s digestibility or level of nutrition, so the discovery of the presence of microorganisms that may increase nitrogen absorption wouldn’t provide relevant support for the claim that fermentation makes black beans easier to digest and more nutritious. Choice D is incorrect because Granito and Álvarez’s claim focuses on the effect of fermenting black beans, but the finding that nonfermented black beans also have fewer

trypsin inhibitors and tannins when cooked at high pressure would suggest that the role of the cooking method could be significant when it comes to nutrition; further, the finding wouldn't address the beans' digestibility.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0151f107

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 0151f107

Several studies of sediment (e.g., dirt, pieces of rock, etc.) in streams have shown an inverse correlation between sediment grain size and downstream distance from the primary sediment source, suggesting that stream length has a sorting effect on sediment. In a study of sediment sampled at more than a dozen sites in Alpine streams, however, geologists Camille Litty and Fritz Schlunegger found that cross-site variations in grain size were not associated with differences in downstream distance, though they did not conclude that downstream distance is irrelevant to grain size. Rather, they concluded that sediment influx in these streams may have been sufficiently spatially diffuse to prevent the typical sorting effect from being observed.

- Which finding about the streams in the study, if true, would most directly support Litty and Schlunegger’s conclusion?
- A. The streams regularly experience portions of their banks collapsing into the water at multiple points upstream of the sampling sites.
 - B. The streams contain several types of sediment that are not typically found in streams where the sorting effect has been demonstrated.
 - C. The streams mostly originate from the same source, but their lengths vary considerably due to the different courses they take.
 - D. The streams are fed by multiple tributaries that carry significant volumes of sediment and that enter the streams downstream of the sampling sites.

ID: 0151f107 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This finding would support the conclusion. If stream banks are collapsing into the water at multiple points, then sediment is getting into the water at those various points. This supports the conclusion that the inflow of sediment is very spread out.

Choice B is incorrect. This finding wouldn’t support the conclusion. The conclusion is about the influx of sediment being “spatially diffuse,” meaning spread out over a large area. The type of sediment wouldn’t have an impact on the conclusions. Choice C is incorrect. This finding wouldn’t support the conclusion. It doesn’t say anything about the influx of sediment being “spatially diffuse” (spread out). Choice D is incorrect. This finding wouldn’t support the conclusion. Any sediment that enters downstream of the sampling sites wouldn’t end up in the samples, so it wouldn’t affect the findings or the conclusion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 671216f3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 671216f3

Electronic music pioneer Wendy Carlos is credited with the music for three feature films: *A Clockwork Orange* (1971), *The Shining* (1980), and *Tron* (1982). However, her musical score for *A Clockwork Orange* is mostly made up of her arrangements of Ludwig van Beethoven’s work. Also, almost all the music that she and Rachel Elkind composed for *The Shining* was unused by director Stanley Kubrick. It did not appear in the film. Of the three films, *Tron* is the one in which audiences can hear the most of Carlos’s original compositions.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Of the three films for which Carlos is credited, *Tron* features the most original music from her.
- B. The director of *The Shining* used most of the music that Carlos composed for it.
- C. Beethoven is widely considered to be a more important composer than Carlos.
- D. Carlos is a notable innovator among film composers in the 1970s and 1980s.

ID: 671216f3 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it best states the main idea of the text. The text indicates that Wendy Carlos scored three feature films: *A Clockwork Orange*, *The Shining*, and *Tron*. It also indicates that Carlos’s work on *A Clockwork Orange* consisted primarily of electronic arrangements of Beethoven compositions and that very little of what she and Rachel Elkind composed for *The Shining* was used in the film. But the soundtrack for *Tron* consists largely of music composed by Carlos, so it contains more of her original music than do the soundtracks for the other two films. Thus, the main idea of the text is that of the three films for which Carlos is credited, *Tron* features the most original music from her.

Choice B is incorrect because it directly contradicts the text’s claim that "very little of what she and Rachel Elkind composed for *The Shining* was used in the film." Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t address the perceived quality of different composers, instead, it discusses how much of Carlos’s original work was used in each of the three films she scored. Choice D is incorrect because it doesn’t relate to any of the major themes of the text: the work Wendy Carlos did for three feature films, how much of that work was composed by Carlos, and how much of her original work was ultimately used in the film.

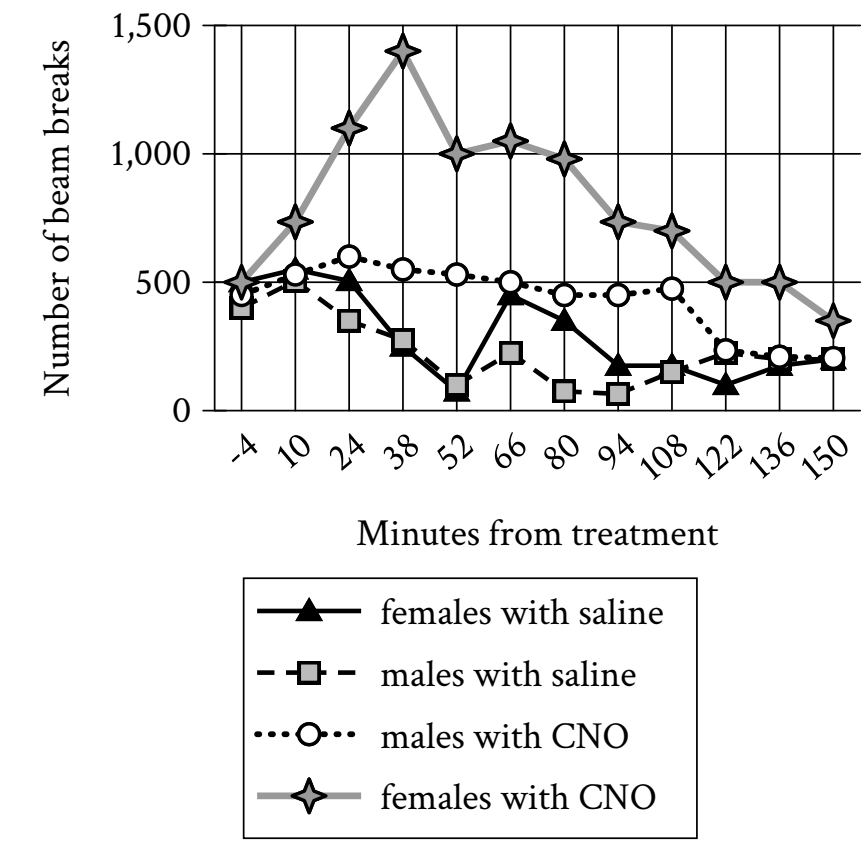
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a8a74b0b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a8a74b0b

Number of Infrared Beam Breaks by Mice
Treated with CNO or Saline, by Sex



To investigate the influence of certain estrogen-responsive neurons on energy expenditure, biologist Stephanie Correa et al. treated female and male mice with either saline solution or clozapine-N4-oxide (CNO), which activates the neurons. Monitoring the activity levels of the mice by measuring how frequently the animals broke infrared beams crossing their enclosures, Correa et al. found that the mice in their study showed sex-specific differences in response to neuron activation: _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the assertion?

- A. the four groups of mice differed greatly in their activity levels before treatment but showed identical activity levels at the end of the monitoring period.
- B. saline-treated females showed substantially more activity at certain points in the monitoring period than saline-treated males did.
- C. CNO-treated females showed more activity relative to saline-treated females than CNO-treated males showed relative to saline-treated males.

D. CNO-treated females showed a substantial increase and then decline in activity over the monitoring period, whereas CNO-treated males showed a substantial decline in activity followed by a steep increase.

ID: a8a74b0b Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The graph shows that the CNO-treated females were way more active than the CNO-treated males, while the saline-treated males and females (the control groups) had very similar activity levels. This supports the claim that there were sex-specific differences in the mice's response to neuron activation.

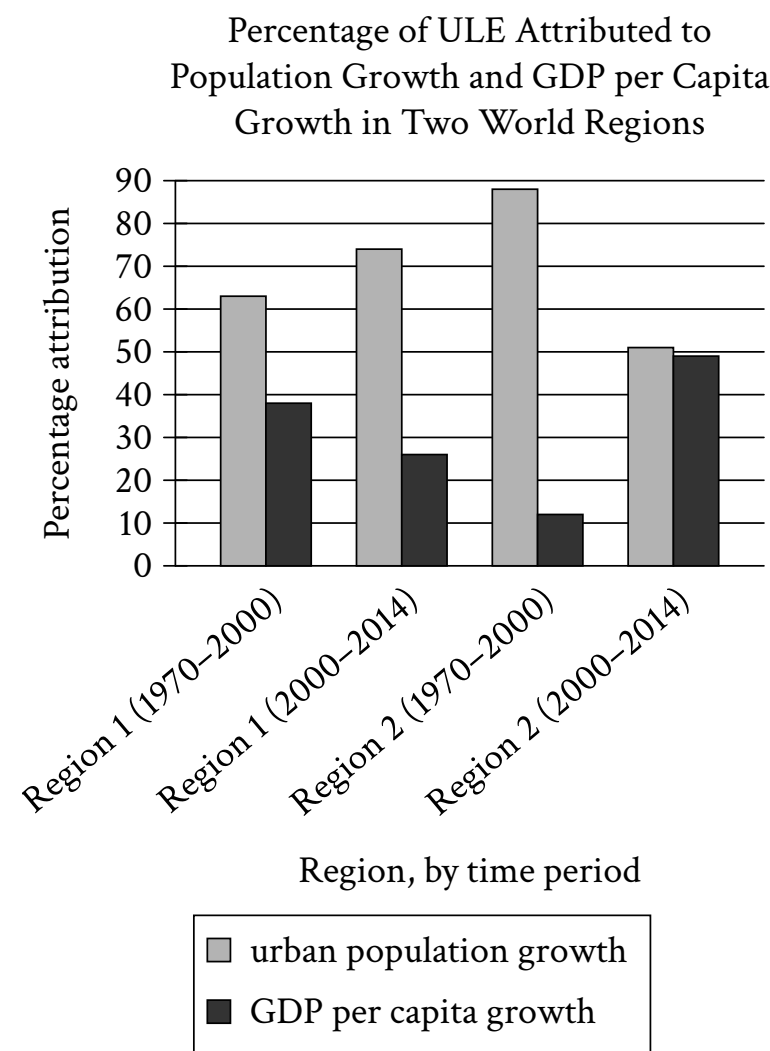
Choice A is incorrect. This choice misreads the graph. All four groups of mice started at nearly the same activity level before treatment (see how all four points are very close together at -4 minutes, meaning four minutes before treatment). Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn't complete the assertion. The assertion is about the mice's response to neuron activation, so we need to include the data about the CNO-treated females and males. Choice D is incorrect. This choice misreads the graph. The line for the CNO-treated males does not show a "substantial decline" until around 122 minutes, and there is no "steep increase" afterward.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ab346a98

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: ab346a98



In a study of urban physical expansion, Richa Mahtta et al. conducted a meta-analysis of more than 300 cities worldwide to determine whether urban land expansion (ULE) was more strongly influenced by urban population growth or by growth in gross domestic product (GDP) per capita, a measure of economic activity. Because efficient national government is necessary to provide urban services and infrastructure that attract economic investment, Mahtta et al. propose that absent other factors, the importance of GDP per capita growth to ULE would likely increase relative to the importance of population growth as governments become more efficient. If true, this suggests the possibility that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the statement?

- A. national governments of countries in Region 1 experienced declines in efficiency in the period from 2000 to 2014, relative to the period from 1970 to 2000.
- B. countries in Region 1 experienced a slower rate of economic growth in the period from 2000 to 2014 than countries in Region 2 did, despite increasing national government efficiency in Region 1.

C. national governments of most countries in Region 2 became more efficient in the period from 2000 to 2014 than they had been in the period from 1970 to 2000, but those of several countries in this region did not.

D. national governments of countries in Region 1 and in Region 2 generally became more efficient in the period from 2000 to 2014 than they had been in the period from 1970 to 2000, but at different rates.

ID: ab346a98 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the statement about Mahtta et al.'s proposal regarding factors that affect urban land expansion (ULE). According to the text, ULE is influenced by urban population growth and by gross domestic product (GDP) growth per capita. Reasoning that efficient national governments provide urban services and infrastructure needed to attract economic investment, Mahtta et al. suggest that, as governments become more efficient at providing urban services and infrastructure, GDP growth per capita will account for more ULE and urban population growth will account for less. But according to the graph, Region 1 saw an increase in the percentage attributed to urban population growth from 1970–2000 (between 60 and 65%) to 2000–2014 (between 70 and 75%) and a decrease in the percentage attributed to GDP growth per capita from 1970–2000 (between 35 and 40%) to 2000–2014 (about 25%). Because the percentage attributed to GDP growth per capita decreased (the opposite of what Mahtta et al. claimed would happen if the governments had become more efficient), the data suggest that the governments of Region 1 became less efficient at providing urban services and infrastructure over that period.

Choice B is incorrect. Neither the graph nor the text gives the regions' relative levels of economic growth or what effect Mahtta et al. would expect such growth to have. Furthermore, Mahtta et al.'s proposal suggests that Region 1's decline in the percentage of ULE attributed to GDP growth per capita from 1970–2000 (between 35 and 40%) to 2000–2014 (about 25%) would suggest decreasing, not increasing, government efficiency over this time. Choice C is incorrect. Neither the text nor the graph provides information about the relative efficiencies of different governments in Region 2. Choice D is incorrect. Mahtta et al.'s proposal suggests that more efficient governments will have a higher percentage of their ULE driven by GDP growth per capita and a lower percentage driven by urban population growth. For Region 2, the percentage of ULE attributed to GDP growth per capita increased from 1970–2000 (between 10 and 15%) to 2000–2014 (between 45 and 50%), but the opposite is true for Region 1, which saw the percentage of ULE attributed to GDP growth per capita decline over the same period. Thus, whereas the data suggest governments in Region 2 became more efficient, the data for Region 1 suggest that those governments became less efficient, not more.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d2899dce

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: d2899dce

In subtropical Asia, *Apis dorsata* (giant honeybee) plays an essential role in pollinating a wide variety of crops and wild plants. To study how different agricultural land covers affect the species, Rika Raffiudin and colleagues monitored the foraging activity of the bees as well as the pollen content of the honey from *A. dorsata* colonies at two sites in Indonesia: Kampar, characterized by its surrounding monoculture farms (growing a single crop), and Kerinci, a forest-agriculture site where multiple crops, including hot peppers and coffee, are grown nearby. The researchers concluded that a lack of crop variety may reduce total pollen collection by *A. dorsata*.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ conclusion?

- A. Pollen in honey samples from Kampar bee colonies was predominantly sourced from a single plant species, whereas pollen in honey samples from Kerinci bee colonies was sourced from multiple different plant species.
- B. In one Kerinci bee colony, a greater proportion of bees returned to their nests with pollen than returned without pollen, whereas the inverse was observed in a second Kerinci bee colony.
- C. Significantly fewer bees were observed engaging in foraging activities with the crops surrounding Kerinci than with the crops surrounding Kampar.
- D. Honey samples from Kerinci bee colonies contained significantly higher concentrations of pollen than honey samples from Kampar bee colonies did.

ID: d2899dce Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ conclusion that a lack of crop variety may reduce total pollen collection by *A. dorsata*. The text explains that the researchers compared two sites: Kampar, which is surrounded by farms all growing the same crop, and Kerinci, which is a forest-agriculture site with multiple crops. If honey samples from Kerinci bee colonies contained significantly higher pollen concentrations than honey samples from Kampar bee colonies did, this finding would suggest that bees in the multiple-crop environment collected more pollen overall, thereby supporting the conclusion that the low crop variety at the Kampar site corresponds with reduced total pollen collection.

Choice A is incorrect because this finding addresses the diversity of pollen sources—single species at the Kampar site versus multiple species at the Kerinci site—not the total quantity of pollen collected. Choice B is incorrect because this finding compares two colonies within Kerinci rather than comparing the two sites and it concerns whether bees returned with pollen, which doesn’t address the total quantity of pollen collected. Choice C is incorrect because the finding that fewer bees foraged at Kerinci—the higher-variety site—than at Kampar doesn’t address the conclusion about total pollen collected. If anything, a lower number of foraging bees would suggest reduced activity and hence a lower amount of pollen collected in the variety-rich environment, which would undermine rather than support the researchers’ conclusion.

Question ID d14277b4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: d14277b4

Studies of ocean wave breaking have predominantly focused on traveling waves (those propagating along the horizontal plane), so Mark McAllister et al. utilized a circular wave tank to produce and study spike waves, axisymmetric standing waves that can erupt vertically when traveling waves propagating in opposing directions intersect. Traveling waves break when wave steepness (height-to-length ratio) passes a critical threshold; breaking thus constrains wave height. McAllister et al. found that spike waves can exceed that constraint, as other factors than just steepness (e.g., jet stability and cavity shape) mediate spike-wave breaking.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Previous studies have suggested that steepness mediates breaking in traveling waves, but the study by McAllister et al. shows that jet stability and cavity shape may also influence breaking in such waves.
- B. The process of breaking limits the height of traveling waves, but the study by McAllister et al. suggests that spike waves can exceed those limits if their height-to-length ratio reaches a critical threshold.
- C. McAllister et al. suggest that spike waves can form when traveling waves propagating in opposing directions intersect and that spike waves tend to be higher than traveling waves.
- D. The study by McAllister et al. suggests that when traveling waves intersect in specific ways, the resulting wave may be higher than would be expected based on the properties of traveling waves.

ID: d14277b4 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text begins by explaining that most studies of ocean wave breaking have focused on traveling waves (those that move horizontally) but that McAllister et al. studied spike waves, which form when traveling waves moving in opposing directions intersect. The text establishes that while traveling waves break when their steepness exceeds a critical threshold (limiting their height), McAllister et al. found that spike waves can exceed these constraints because factors like jet stability and cavity shape can mitigate the effects of steepness. Thus, the main idea of the text is that spike waves resulting from traveling waves intersecting in specific ways can reach heights greater than what would be expected based on the general properties of traveling waves.

Choice A is incorrect because it misrepresents the information in the text; the text indicates that McAllister et al. showed that jet stability and cavity shape (along with steepness) influence breaking in spike waves, not in traveling waves. Further, the information about specific influences is not the main focus of the text. Choice B is incorrect because it misrepresents the information in the text; the text indicates that McAllister et al. found that spike waves can pass the steepness threshold at which traveling waves break because factors like jet stability and cavity shape affect the breaking of spike waves, not because they've simply reached a critical threshold of steepness. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text does explain that spike waves can form when traveling waves intersect, it presents this as a known fact that McAllister et al.'s study was based on, not as something the

researchers suggested. Further, the text indicates that spike waves can exceed a threshold that limits traveling wave height but doesn't focus on the idea that spike waves typically are higher than traveling waves.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f797e81c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: f797e81c

Fiber Characteristics of Mouflon, Navajo-Churro, and Spanish Merino Sheep

Type of sheep	Diameter of outer coat fibers (in microns)	Diameter of inner coat fibers (in microns)
Spanish Merino	19–24	17–21
Navajo-Churro	35 or higher	10–35
Mouflon	150	15

Domestic sheep’s wild ancestor, the mouflon, has a coarse outer coat and an inner coat of wool fiber that is finer in diameter and therefore much softer. In some domestic breeds, such as the Spanish Merino, the outer fiber is only marginally coarser than the inner, and the wool is soft overall. Thus, Merino wool is ideal for delicate garments worn against the skin. Meanwhile, the Navajo-Churro has been selected to retain the marked distinction between outer and inner fiber that the Merino has lost. Being coarser than Merino wool overall, Navajo-Churro wool yields a more durable yarn, which Diné (Navajo) weavers use in their celebrated rugs. Yet a comparison of the fiber characteristics of all three sheep reveals that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the text?

- A. the selection process that enabled the Navajo-Churro to retain its somewhat coarse outer fiber also resulted in inner fiber that, at its softest, is softer than either the mouflon’s or the Merino’s inner fiber.
- B. the Navajo-Churro more closely resembles its ancestor, the mouflon, in the uniform softness of its inner fiber, while the Merino more closely resembles the mouflon in the variable diameter of its outer fiber.
- C. domestication resulted in a counterintuitive increase in the inner fiber’s minimum diameter, making the inner fiber of the Merino and the Navajo-Churro less suitable for delicate garments than the mouflon’s inner fiber is.
- D. the domestication of the mouflon and the subsequent selection process that produced the Merino and the Navajo-Churro resulted in greater softness of outer and inner fiber alike.

ID: f797e81c Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it accurately uses data from the table to complete the statement about the fibers of three types of sheep. The text discusses some qualities of outer and inner fibers of mouflons, Spanish Merino sheep, and Navajo-Churro sheep and indicates that sheep fibers with finer, or smaller, diameters are softer than fibers with larger diameters. The text then sets up a conclusion that can be made by comparing the fibers of all three sheep types. The table shows that the minimum diameter of the Navajo-Churro’s inner fibers is 10 microns, which is smaller than the minimum diameters of the inner fibers of both the mouflon (15 microns) and the Spanish Merino (17 microns). Thus, comparing the fiber characteristics of all three sheep reveals that at its softest, the inner fiber of the Navajo-Churro is softer than either the mouflon’s or the Merino’s inner fiber.

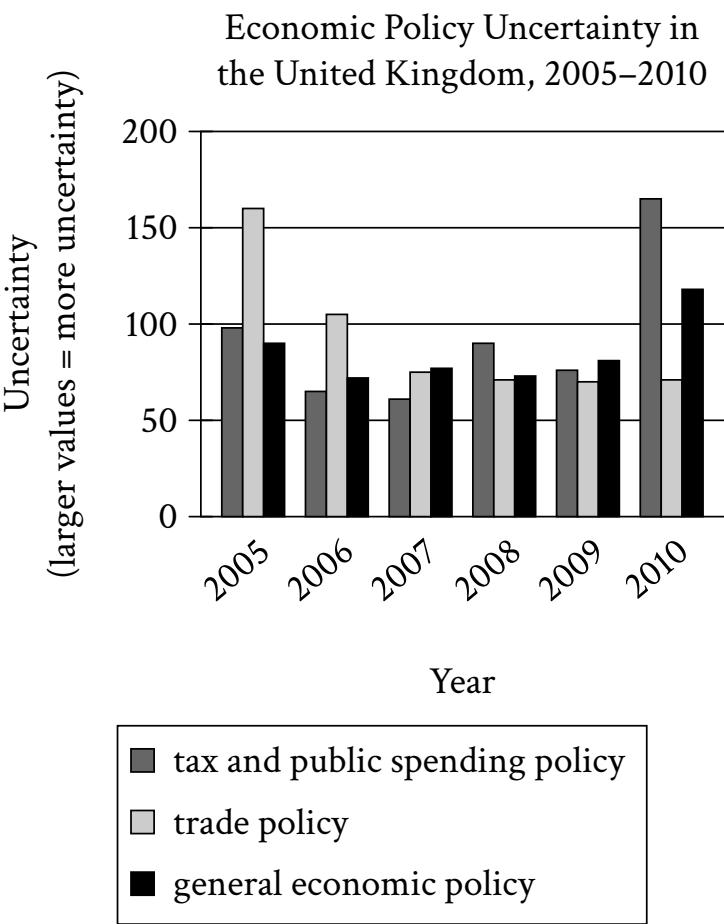
Choice B is incorrect because it doesn't accurately describe the data in the table. The table shows that the softness of Navajo-Churro inner fiber isn't uniform (since the diameter of Navajo-Churro inner fiber ranges from 10 microns to 35 microns) and that the diameter of the outer fiber of the mouflon isn't variable (rather, it is a uniform 150 microns). Choice C is incorrect because it doesn't accurately describe the data in the table. The text indicates that both Spanish Merino sheep and Navajo-Churro sheep were domesticated from mouflon sheep. The table doesn't show that domestication increased the minimum diameter of inner fibers for both Spanish Merino sheep and Navajo-Churro sheep from the 15-micron diameter of mouflon inner fibers: the minimum diameter of Spanish Merino increased to 17 microns, but the minimum diameter of Navajo-Churro inner fibers *decreased* to 10 microns. Choice D is incorrect because it doesn't accurately describe the data in the table. The text explains that sheep fibers with finer, or smaller, diameters are softer than fibers with larger diameters. The table does show that Spanish Merino outer fibers are finer, and thus softer, than mouflon outer fibers and that at their finest, Navajo-Churro outer fibers are softer than mouflon outer fibers, but it also shows that Spanish Merino inner fibers are less soft than mouflon inner fibers, since their minimum diameter is greater than 15 microns, and that Navajo-Churro inner fibers can be less soft than mouflon inner fibers, since the diameter ranges up to 35 microns.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c0e1f7de

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: c0e1f7de



High levels of public uncertainty about which economic policies a country will adopt can make planning difficult for businesses, but measures of such uncertainty have not tended to be very detailed. Recently, however, economist Sandile Hlatshwayo analyzed trends in news reports to derive measures not only for general economic policy uncertainty but also for uncertainty related to specific areas of economic policy, like tax or trade policy. One revelation of her work is that a general measure may not fully reflect uncertainty about specific areas of policy, as in the case of the United Kingdom, where general economic policy uncertainty _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to illustrate the claim?

- A. aligned closely with uncertainty about tax and public spending policy in 2005 but differed from uncertainty about tax and public spending policy by a large amount in 2009.
- B. was substantially lower than uncertainty about tax and public spending policy each year from 2005 to 2010.
- C. reached its highest level between 2005 and 2010 in the same year that uncertainty about trade policy and tax and public spending policy reached their lowest levels.
- D. was substantially lower than uncertainty about trade policy in 2005 and substantially higher than uncertainty about trade policy in 2010.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it uses data from the graph to effectively illustrate the text's claim about general economic policy uncertainty in the United Kingdom. The graph presents values for economic policy uncertainty in tax and public spending policy, trade policy, and general economic policy in the UK from 2005 to 2010. The graph shows that in 2005, the value for general economic policy uncertainty (approximately 90) was substantially lower than the value for uncertainty about trade policy specifically (approximately 160). It also shows that in 2010, the value for general economic policy uncertainty (approximately 120) was substantially higher than the value for uncertainty about trade policy (approximately 70). The substantial differences between these values in 2005 and 2010 support the claim that a general measure may not fully reflect uncertainty about specific areas of policy.

Choice A is incorrect because the graph shows that the level of general economic policy uncertainty was similar to the level of uncertainty about tax and public spending policy in both 2005 (with values of approximately 90 and 100, respectively) and 2009 (with values of approximately 80 and 75, respectively). Choice B is incorrect because the graph shows that general economic policy uncertainty was higher than uncertainty about tax and public spending policy in 2006, 2007, and 2009, not that it was lower each year from 2005 to 2010. Choice C is incorrect because the graph shows that general economic policy uncertainty reached its highest level in 2010, which was when uncertainty about tax and public spending policy also reached its highest level, not its lowest level.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c64d66f6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: c64d66f6

Within higher education, studying philosophy requires that students be conversant with the field’s foundational texts and historical figures. By contrast, *doing* philosophy within or beyond the academy demands the creative, self-directed application of acquired expertise to enduring questions about the nature of existence and knowledge. While both approaches engage with influential figures, those who do philosophy treat such figures as vital interlocutors who facilitate new insights rather than as ossified authorities who, though relevant to the present, primarily represent the discipline’s past.

Based on the text, which choice best describes the relationship between doing philosophy and studying philosophy?

- A. Doing philosophy helps students formulate concrete solutions to practical issues, whereas studying philosophy prioritizes engagement with historical arguments in the field.
- B. Doing philosophy involves developing novel ideas through imagined dialogue with past philosophers based on knowledge of those philosophers’ views acquired by studying philosophy.
- C. Doing philosophy requires students to challenge the ideas articulated by past philosophers, especially when these ideas are broadly accepted by other people studying philosophy.
- D. Doing philosophy represents a departure from the norms that govern scholarly inquiry, whereas studying philosophy requires conforming to these norms.

ID: c64d66f6 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes the relationship between doing philosophy and studying philosophy as presented in the text. According to the text, studying philosophy requires being familiar with foundational texts and historical figures, while doing philosophy demands “the creative, self-directed application of acquired expertise”—a phrase implying that doing philosophy builds on knowledge gained through study. The text adds that those who do philosophy treat influential figures as “vital interlocutors who facilitate new insights” (that is, as dialogue partners whose ideas help generate new thinking). In other words, doing philosophy involves developing novel ideas through engagement with the ideas of past philosophers, knowledge of which can be acquired only by studying philosophy.

Choice A is incorrect. While the text does state that studying philosophy requires engagement with historical texts and figures, the text describes doing philosophy as addressing “enduring questions about the nature of existence and knowledge,” which are abstract philosophical questions, not practical issues. Rather than formulating concrete solutions, doing philosophy involves the creative application of expertise to these broad, enduring questions. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t characterize doing philosophy as requiring students to challenge past philosophers’ ideas. Instead, the text suggests that those who do philosophy engage creatively with historical figures, which can, but doesn’t necessarily entail, opposition. Additionally, the text doesn’t claim that the ideas of past philosophers are broadly accepted by those studying philosophy. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss norms of scholarly inquiry or characterize either approach in terms of conforming to or

departing from such norms. Rather, the text notes that doing philosophy can occur “within or beyond the academy,” which suggests compatibility with scholarly settings rather than an inevitable departure from them.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 792a8a87

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 792a8a87

In Diné (Navajo) culture, *ikaah* (sandpaintings) are created and then erased as part of sacred healing ceremonies lasting no more than a few days, but Diné *hataalii* (chanter, healer, cultural guide) Fred Stevens developed fixatives to preserve desacralized sandpaintings. While on a US-sponsored cultural ambassadorial trip in Europe and the Americas in the 1960s, Stevens produced several such sandpaintings and gave them to cultural institutions. This may seem in tension with the role of cultural ambassador—how could static objects authentically represent an inherently ephemeral and dynamic practice?—but such a view is itself overly object-focused and neglects how Stevens strove to convey exactly those characteristics of *ikaah* as a cultural practice.

Which quotation from an art historian would most directly support the claim made in the text?

- A. “While Stevens’s ambassadorial sandpaintings are undoubtedly educative for audiences that have little exposure to Diné culture, they should not be confused with authentic *ikaah*, which cannot be extricated from a practice that is intentionally and necessarily transitory nor condensed into a single persistent object.”
- B. “The most compelling way to reconcile the apparent tension between the temporary and performative nature of *ikaah* and the persistent and static nature of Stevens’s ambassadorial sandpaintings is to recognize that Stevens was an ambassador not only of Diné culture but of a US art culture that tended to value permanent works over ephemeral ones.”
- C. “Stevens’s ambassadorial sandpaintings are best understood not as self-contained objects but as reminders of the public creations of the sandpaintings, during which Stevens conducted appropriate *ikaah* rituals and encouraged viewers to closely track his movements and subtle shifts in the sand throughout the process.”
- D. “It is important to recall Stevens’s own actions as a gift-giver—a temporary and performative role—of the sandpaintings, for by taking those actions, Stevens publicly enacted the transmission of knowledge of both traditional *ikaah* practices and cutting-edge chemistry (in the form of the preservative additives), a hybrid that reflects the dynamism of Diné culture.”

ID: 792a8a87 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most directly supports the text’s claim that Stevens strove to convey the ephemeral and dynamic characteristics of *ikaah* as a cultural practice. The text challenges the characterization of Stevens’s preserved sandpaintings as mere “static objects” that cannot “authentically represent” a practice defined in part by the absence of an end product; it claims instead that this “overly object-focused” interpretation overlooks how Stevens preserved the essential characteristics of traditional *ikaah* practice. This quotation supports the claim by explaining that Stevens’s sandpaintings should be understood “not as self-contained objects but as reminders of the public creations of the sandpaintings,” during which Stevens “conducted appropriate *ikaah* rituals and encouraged viewers to closely track his movements and subtle shifts in the sand throughout the process.” The fact that Stevens created the sandpaintings in a public setting and invited viewers to attentively engage with this process supports the claim that he sought to portray *ikaah* as a dynamic practice rather than as a static product. Further, the inherently impermanent nature of such a performance evokes the ephemerality that characterizes *ikaah*.

Choice A is incorrect because it contradicts rather than supports the text's claim that Stevens strove to convey the ephemeral and dynamic characteristics of *ikaah* as a cultural practice. This quotation argues that Stevens's preserved sandpaintings "should not be confused with authentic *ikaah*" and emphasizes that authentic *ikaah* "cannot be extricated from a practice that is intentionally and necessarily transitory." This view aligns with the "overly object-focused" perspective that the text argues against, rather than supporting the claim that Stevens successfully conveyed *ikaah*'s ephemeral and dynamic characteristics. Choice B is incorrect because it focuses on reconciling the tension between ephemeral and permanent forms rather than supporting the claim that Stevens actively conveyed *ikaah*'s ephemeral and dynamic characteristics. While this quotation acknowledges an apparent contradiction, it suggests that Stevens was accommodating US preferences for permanent artworks; it doesn't demonstrate how he communicated the ephemeral and dynamic nature of traditional *ikaah* practice. Choice D is incorrect. Although the quotation mentions Stevens's "temporary and performative role" as a gift-giver, it doesn't address how Stevens conveyed the ephemeral and dynamic characteristics of *ikaah* itself during his ambassadorial activities. The quotation focuses on Stevens's role in transmitting knowledge and representing cultural dynamism but doesn't specifically support the claim about his efforts to communicate the essential characteristics of *ikaah* practice. Further, the quotation incorrectly implies that Stevens shared his knowledge of preservative additives; the text doesn't establish that he revealed how the sandpaintings were preserved.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dd975895

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: dd975895

Many linguists have claimed that the lyricism of Alexander Pushkin’s Russian novel in verse *Eugene Onegin* makes the work incapable of being faithfully translated, especially into English. The original work is written much like a long poem, featuring linguistic patterns and flourishes specific to the Russian language. Rather than striving to portray each scene of the novel literally, John Cranko, in his ballet adaptation of *Eugene Onegin*, opted to let the essence of the work’s emotions inspire the passion of the dancers. Critic Emma Golden writes that Cranko’s “choreography uses the poetry of the human body to summon the parts of Pushkin’s novel that were deemed untranslatable—its commitments to rhythm, cadence, symmetry.” It seems, then, that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. Cranko’s loose adaptation of *Eugene Onegin* into a different medium may have preserved fundamental elements of the source material better than a strictly literal written translation of the text would have.
- B. though written works are frequently adapted into other formats, ballets are rarely considered to be faithful adaptations of texts.
- C. English is a particularly difficult language into which to translate poetic works, as its rhythms differ from those of many other languages.
- D. most critics believe that, like other English translations of *Eugene Onegin*, Cranko’s ballet adaptation fails to capture the essence of the original’s meaning.

ID: dd975895 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of John Cranko’s ballet adaptation of Pushkin’s Russian novel in verse, *Eugene Onegin*. According to the text, the novel’s lyricism—specifically its reliance on linguistic patterns and flourishes that are unique to the Russian language—renders a faithful translation, especially one into English, impossible. The text then discusses Cranko’s adaptation of *Eugene Onegin* into a ballet whose choreography, according to one critic, evokes aspects of the novel that were deemed untranslatable: “its commitments to rhythm, cadence, symmetry.” Given the claim that the ballet captures what would seem untranslatable, it can be inferred that Cranko’s loose adaptation of the novel into a different medium—namely, dance—may have preserved fundamental elements of the source material better than a strictly literal written translation into English or another language would have.

Choice B is incorrect because the text discusses one specific ballet adaptation of *Eugene Onegin* and one critic’s assessment of it. The text makes no general claims about the adaptation of written works into other formats or about whether ballets are typically considered faithful adaptations of such works. Choice C is incorrect because the text discusses the difficulty of translating only one poetic work—Pushkin’s Russian-language novel *Eugene Onegin*—into English and doesn’t consider whether English generally poses challenges for translators of poetic works of various languages. Moreover, the text focuses on the challenge presented by the Russian language’s unique patterns and flourishes, not a difficulty inherent to the English language.

Choice D is incorrect because the text gives no indication of what most critics believe about Cranko's adaptation of *Eugene Onegin* and instead presents the reaction of only one critic: Golden's praise of Cranko's ballet for capturing essential elements of the novel that have been "deemed untranslatable." Nothing in the text suggests that most other critics would disagree with Golden's positive view.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a108add5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: a108add5

To protect themselves when being attacked, hagfish—jawless marine animals that resemble eels—will release large quantities of slimy, mucus-like threads. Because these threads are unusually strong and elastic, scientist Atsuko Negishi and her colleagues have been trying to recreate them in a lab as an eco-friendly alternative to petroleum-based fibers that are often used in fabrics. The researchers want to reproduce the threads in the lab because farming hagfish for their slime would be expensive and potentially harmful to the hagfish.

Which choice best states the text’s main idea?

- A. The slimy threads that hagfish release might help researchers create a new kind of fabric.
- B. Hagfish have inspired researchers to develop a new petroleum-based fabric.
- C. Hagfish are not well suited to being raised in captivity.
- D. The ability of hagfish to slime their attackers compensates for their being jawless.

ID: a108add5 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The text first describes hagfish slime and its properties, then it transitions to talking about the possibilities of using lab-made equivalents to use in eco-friendly fabrics.

Choice B is incorrect. The text says the opposite of this choice. The researchers are developing an alternative to petroleum-based fabric. Choice C is incorrect. This choice is too narrow to be the main point of the text. Only one line describes how farming would be “potentially harmful” to the hagfish. Choice D is incorrect. This choice isn’t supported by the text. We don’t know from the text whether being jawless makes the hagfish more vulnerable.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c310fcd1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: c310fcd1

There Is Confusion is a 1924 novel by Jessie Redmon Fauset. In the novel, the narrator portrays the character Joanna as someone who admires ambition in other people to the exclusion of all other qualities: _____

Which quotation from *There Is Confusion* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. "Joanna was mightily interested in people who had a 'purpose' in life. Otherwise not at all."
- B. "Indeed from the very beginning Joanna showed her preference for her father."
- C. "Joanna was like her father not only so far as ambition was concerned but also in her willingness to work."
- D. "She had a good sense of logic, a strong power of concentration, and a remarkably retentive and visualizing memory."

ID: c310fcd1 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively presents a quotation from *There Is Confusion* that illustrates the claim that the narrator portrays Joanna as admiring the quality of ambition, or the determination to achieve something, and no other qualities in other people. By describing Joanna as not being interested in people unless they have "a 'purpose' in life"—that is, a goal they are determined to achieve—in which case she is very interested in them, the quotation reveals that Joanna cares only about others' ambition.

Choice B is incorrect because this quotation indicates only that Joanna has a preference for her father, without giving a reason for that preference; therefore, it doesn't illustrate the claim that Joanna cares only about others' ambition. Choice C is incorrect because this quotation doesn't illustrate that Joanna greatly admires the quality of ambition in others; it refers to Joanna's similarity to her father "so far as ambition was concerned" but doesn't reveal how she (or her father) views that quality. Choice D is incorrect because this quotation describes qualities Joanna possesses—praising her logic, concentration, and memory—instead of Joanna's interest in other people's qualities.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 16cf9126

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 16cf9126

Outi Tervo and team studied the effect of human-caused noise on narwhals (*Monodon monoceros*), arctic marine mammals that are sensitive to acoustic changes in their environment. Hypothesizing that elevated sound levels affect foraging among narwhals, Tervo’s team compared narwhal diving behaviors in natural sound conditions with those behaviors in two human-caused sound exposure conditions—ship sounds and ship sounds coupled with sonic pulses. Both exposure conditions resulted in significant decreases in the number and target depth of deep dives (associated with foraging) relative to natural conditions. However, differences between diving behaviors in the two exposure types were negligible, a finding that could be attributed to the fact that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. sonic pulses can be heard at significantly greater ocean depths than ship sounds can.
- B. ship sounds contribute so much to the overall sound level that the addition of sonic pulses has little effect on the narwhals’ auditory environment.
- C. narwhals forage at shallower depths in the presence of ship sounds alone than in the presence of ship sounds coupled with sonic pulses.
- D. the narwhals weren’t as sensitive to human-caused sounds as the researchers had predicted.

ID: 16cf9126 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of human-caused noise and narwhal behavior. The text establishes that Outi Tervo and team found that while both ship sounds alone and ship sounds coupled with sonic pulses significantly affected narwhal foraging behaviors compared to natural conditions, there were negligible differences between the narwhals’ responses to the two sound exposure types (a somewhat surprising finding because one might expect that adding sonic pulses would have an even greater impact). It logically follows that if ship sounds are already so loud that adding sonic pulses to them doesn’t substantially increase the level of human-caused sound exposure, the two conditions would produce essentially the same behavioral responses because the additional sonic pulses are essentially irrelevant.

Choice A is incorrect because the fact that sonic pulses are audible at greater depths than are ship sounds would be more likely to help explain a difference—not a similarity—in how the narwhals responded to the two types of sound exposure. If at some points during the study the narwhals were at depths where only sonic pulses (but not ship sounds) could be heard, then they might be expected to alter their diving behavior more dramatically in response to those pulses. But since the text reports negligible differences between diving behaviors in the two exposure types, the fact that sonic pulses reach greater depths than do ship sounds has little explanatory power in this context. Choice C is incorrect because the idea that the narwhals foraged at shallower depths in one of the two exposure conditions directly contradicts the information given in the text. The text states that there were negligible differences in the narwhals’ diving behaviors between the two conditions, meaning that the behaviors were

essentially the same. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text states that two conditions with human-caused sounds (ship sounds alone and ship sounds coupled with sonic pulses) had essentially the same effect on narwhals' deep dives, this indicates only that sonic pulses didn't meaningfully change the effect of ship sounds, not that the narwhals were less sensitive to human-caused sounds than predicted. Indeed, the text makes it clear that the sounds significantly altered the narwhals' behavior.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 71e63aa2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 71e63aa2

Microbial fuel cells (MFCs) capitalize on the ability of some species of bacteria to oxidize organic matter and transfer electrons extracellularly. The bacteria form a dense biofilm on the surface of an electron-collecting anode, but moving the electrons from the bacterial cytoplasm to an external electrode requires that the electrons pass through a series of inefficient oxidation-reduction (redox) reactions. Accordingly, MFC power output rarely exceeds a density of 0.30 milliwatts per square centimeter (mW/cm²). In an experiment, researchers added silver nanoparticles to carbon paper covering the anode in an MFC. The resulting power density was 0.66 mW/cm². Since metals such as silver exhibit high electrical conductivity, the researchers hypothesized that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. silver nanoparticles may allow electrons to bypass the series of redox reactions and transfer directly to the electrode.
- B. electrons may be conducted directly to the electrode before the silver nanoparticles catalyze the redox reactions.
- C. silver nanoparticles may increase the metabolic processes of the bacteria, thereby increasing the number of free electrons available to transfer to the electrode.
- D. as the density of the biofilm increases, the series of redox reactions may accelerate independent of the presence of the silver nanoparticles.

ID: 71e63aa2 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of microbial fuel cells (MFCs) and the effect of silver nanoparticles on power output. The text explains that in MFCs, electrons are transferred from the bacterial cytoplasm to an external electrode through a series of inefficient redox reactions, which typically prevent power output from exceeding 0.30 mW/cm². When researchers added silver nanoparticles to carbon paper covering the anode, power density more than doubled to 0.66 mW/cm². Critically, the text notes that metals such as silver exhibit high electrical conductivity. Given that the inefficiency of the redox reactions accounted for the limited power output of MFCs and that the addition of a highly conductive material dramatically increased that output, it is reasonable to hypothesize that the silver nanoparticles allowed electrons to bypass the redox reactions and transfer directly to the electrode.

Choice B is incorrect because the researchers’ hypothesis, as set up by the last sentence of the text, is specifically grounded in the high electrical conductivity of metals such as silver. Nothing in the text supports the idea that the silver nanoparticles function as catalysts for the redox reactions, nor does the text suggest that electrons are being conducted to the electrode independently of any role played by the silver nanoparticles. The text points to the conductivity of silver as the explanation for the increased power density, not to any catalytic effect of the nanoparticles on the existing redox reactions. Choice C is incorrect because the text never discusses the metabolic processes of the bacteria in the biofilm coating the electron-collecting anodes, nor is there any suggestion that the high conductivity of silver nanoparticles would interact with the bacteria’s metabolism in any way. Choice D is incorrect because the text never suggests that in the experiment, the biofilm on the electron-collecting anodes varied in density.

Moreover, the hypothetical statement begun in the last sentence of the text concerns the high electrical conductivity of metals such as silver. Thus, proposing that redox reactions—which, as the text establishes, conduct electricity—accelerated independently of a conductive metallic material (the silver nanoparticles) wouldn't logically complete that hypothesis.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1daf8efa

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 1daf8efa

Although Eastern North Pacific (ENP) gray whales generally migrate between their wintering waters along the coast of Mexico and their foraging waters in the Arctic, a subset of this population—known as the Pacific Coast Feeding Group (PCFG)—forages along the coastlines of Northern California (USA) and British Columbia (Canada) instead. Interestingly, individuals in this subset reach smaller maximum sizes than other ENP whales do, despite having similar pre-maximum growth rates. Researchers hypothesize that this difference may be an adaptation to distinct resource opportunities in the PCFG foraging range.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ claim regarding the size of PCFG whales?

- A. The average body size of PCFG whales observed along the coasts of Northern California and British Columbia has remained relatively steady in recent decades, while the average body size of ENP whales in the main group has slightly decreased.
- B. When present along the coasts of Northern California and British Columbia, PCFG whales tend to forage in rocky kelp beds at shallow depths inaccessible to whales as large as those in the ENP main group.
- C. When foraging along the coasts of Northern California and British Columbia, PCFG whales are in closer proximity to major ports and urban populations than ENP whales in the main group are when foraging in Arctic waters.
- D. Certain crustacean prey species available along the coasts of Northern California and British Columbia where PCFG whales tend to forage are not available in the Arctic waters where ENP whales in the main group forage.

ID: 1daf8efa Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ hypothesis that the smaller maximum size of PCFG whales is an adaptation to resource opportunities particular to their foraging range. The text explains that PCFG whales, a subgroup of ENP gray whales, forage along the coasts of Northern California and British Columbia rather than in the Arctic, where the main ENP group forages. The text goes on to state that PCFG whales reach smaller maximum sizes than other ENP gray whales despite having similar pre-maximum growth rates. If PCFG whales tend to forage in shallow, rocky kelp beds that whales as large as those in the main group cannot access, that would indicate that smaller body size confers a direct advantage in this foraging range—namely, access to a food source that larger whales cannot reach.

Choice A is incorrect because a finding describing recent trends in average body size for both groups of whales wouldn’t address whether the smaller maximum size of PCFG whales reflects an adaptation to their foraging environment. Recent stability or change in average size doesn’t speak to why the size difference between PCFG whales and the main ENP group exists. Choice C is incorrect because a finding about PCFG whales’ proximity to ports and urban populations wouldn’t address the resources available to PCFG whales or the relationship between body size and foraging. Proximity to human activity is irrelevant to a hypothesis about body size being an adaptation to resource opportunities. Choice D is incorrect. Although a finding about a certain prey species being available in the PCFG whales’ foraging waters but not in the main group of ENP whales’ foraging waters would establish that the PCFG foraging range offers distinct prey species, it wouldn’t connect the availability of those prey

species to body size in a way that would explain the PCFG whales' smaller size. Without indicating that the available prey in the PCFG range favors smaller whales, the finding falls short of supporting the hypothesis that smaller size is an adaptation to resource opportunities.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 80e3c332

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 80e3c332

Mosses can struggle in harsh desert conditions because these plants require enough sunlight for photosynthesis but not so much that they risk drying out. Researchers Jenna Ekwealor and Kirsten M. Fisher found several species of *Syntrichia caninervis*, a type of desert moss, growing under quartz crystals in California’s Mojave Desert. To evaluate whether these semitransparent rocks benefited the moss, the researchers compared the shoot tissue, a measure of plant growth, of *S. caninervis* when growing on the soil surface versus when the moss was growing under the quartz rocks. They found that the shoot tissue was 62% longer for moss growing under the quartz as compared to moss on the soil surface, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. *S. caninervis* is one of the few types of moss that can survive under semitransparent rocks.
- B. quartz crystals do not transmit the necessary sunlight for photosynthesis in *S. caninervis*.
- C. *S. caninervis* growing under quartz crystals experience lower light intensity and are thus able to retain more moisture.
- D. quartz crystals are capable of supporting *S. caninervis* growth if the crystals are not too thin.

ID: 80e3c332 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text. The text explains that while desert moss species need sufficient sunlight for photosynthesis, exposure to sunlight can also affect the plants negatively by drying them out. Ekwealor and Fisher’s team found specimens of *S. caninervis* moss growing under quartz crystals that were semitransparent, allowing some but not all sunlight to pass through them, and the shoot tissue of these specimens was longer than that of *S. caninervis* specimens found growing on the surface that were unprotected by such crystals. Since, as the text explains, the length of shoot tissue is an indicator of plant growth, and since greater exposure to sunlight results in greater loss of moisture, it can be inferred that *S. caninervis* growing under quartz crystals experience lower light intensity and are thus able to retain more moisture.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t mention another moss species besides *S. caninervis* or discuss whether other such species are able to grow under transparent crystals, as *S. caninervis* is. Choice B is incorrect because, as the text explains, specimens of *S. caninervis* were found growing under quartz crystals and exhibited more plant growth than specimens growing on the soil surface. This wouldn’t have been the case if the crystals transmitted insufficient light for the moss’s photosynthesis. Choice D is incorrect. The text contrasts the growth of *S. caninervis* specimens found beneath semitransparent quartz crystals with that of specimens found on the soil surface absent such crystals, but it doesn’t make a comparison among specimens growing beneath crystals of different degrees of thickness or consider how the relative thickness of the crystals affects the growth of the moss.

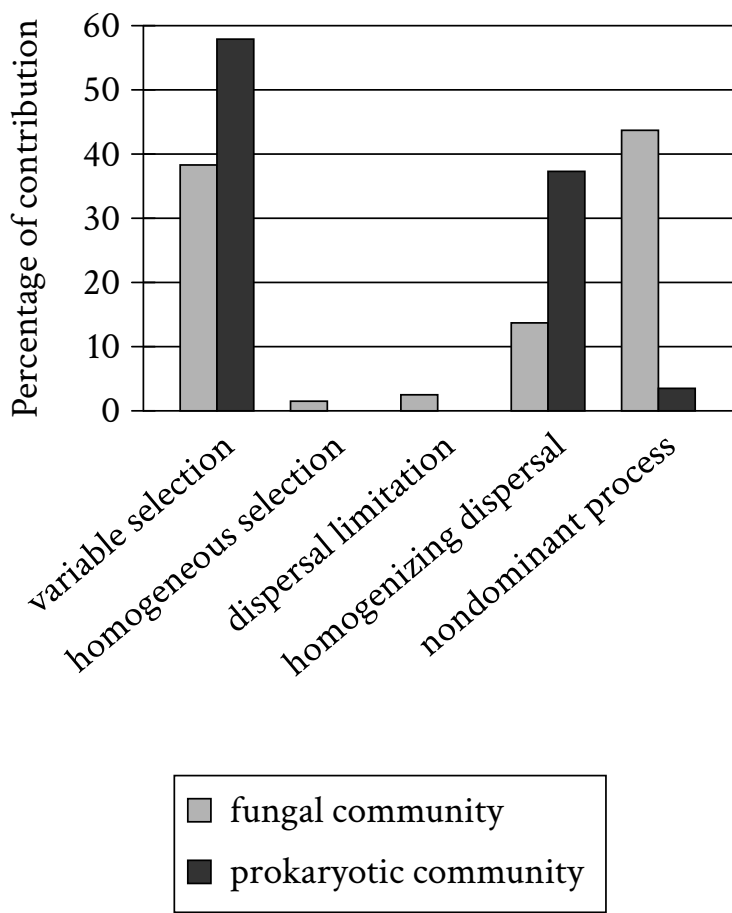
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 45d99965

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 45d99965

Relative Contributions of Processes to Prokaryotic and Fungal Community Assembly in Qinghai-Tibetan Lakes



In a 2020 study, Jian Yang et al. examined prokaryotic and fungal microbial communities in Qinghai-Tibetan Plateau lake sediment to understand the relative contributions of various factors to community assembly, or formation. They quantified the contributions of environmental pressures (variable and homogeneous selection), dispersal limitation, homogenizing dispersal, and nondominant processes. Tolerance of environmental pressures is known to be higher in fungi than in prokaryotes, which the researchers hypothesize accounts for the finding that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the statement?

- A. homogenizing dispersal contributed substantially less to fungal community assembly than variable selection did.
- B. the total number of factors that contributed to community assembly was greater for prokaryotes than for fungi.
- C. variable selection contributed substantially less to fungal community assembly than to prokaryote community assembly.

D. the contribution of homogeneous selection to community assembly was negligible for both fungi and prokaryotes.

ID: 45d99965 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the statement about the researchers' hypothesis regarding a finding. The text states that the researchers attribute a certain finding about community assembly in fungi and prokaryotes to the fact that fungi have a higher tolerance for environmental pressures than do prokaryotes. This finding, then, would be explained by the fact that fungi better tolerate environmental pressures, which the text defines as including variable and homogeneous selection. According to the graph, the contribution of variable selection to community assembly was nearly 40 percent for fungi but nearly 60 percent for prokaryotes, indicating that variable selection contributed significantly less to fungal community assembly than to prokaryotic community assembly. This finding aligns with the researchers' hypothesis: because fungi tolerate environmental pressures like variable selection better than prokaryotes do, those pressures play a smaller role in shaping fungal communities than in shaping prokaryotic communities.

Choice A is incorrect. Although this comparison is supported by the graph, which shows that homogenizing dispersal's contribution to fungal community assembly was just over 10 percent while variable selection's contribution was just under 40 percent, this comparison doesn't illustrate the hypothesis because it involves two factors affecting fungal community assembly. The researchers' hypothesis specifically concerns a difference between fungi and prokaryotes (namely, fungi's greater tolerance of environmental pressures), so a comparison that is limited to fungal community assembly doesn't represent a finding that aligns with this hypothesis. Choice B is incorrect because it mischaracterizes the information in the graph. The graph indicates that the total number of factors that contributed to community assembly was greater for fungi than for prokaryotes: all five factors made nonzero contributions to fungal community assembly, while two factors—homogeneous selection and dispersal limitation—appear not to have contributed to prokaryotic community assembly. In addition, the overall number of factors that influence community assembly isn't directly relevant to the researchers' hypothesis, which addresses the effects of higher tolerance of environmental pressures among fungi in comparison to prokaryotes. Choice D is incorrect. Although the graph indicates that homogeneous selection contributed only minimally to fungal community assembly and appears not to have contributed at all to prokaryotic community assembly, this isn't a finding that the researchers' hypothesis would account for. The hypothesis concerns a difference between fungi and prokaryotes that is plausibly attributable to fungi's greater tolerance of environmental pressures, which include homogeneous and variable selection. The finding that one type of environmental pressure contributed negligibly to both groups doesn't differentiate fungi from prokaryotes and therefore doesn't illustrate what the hypothesis is meant to explain.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 52bab679

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 52bab679

In classical Greek and Roman mythology, female characters are typically cast as either villains lacking in psychological depth or passive victims who are marginal to these stories, which usually focus on the exploits of male characters. Recently, a subgenre has emerged in which writers reimagine these stories from the perspectives of their female characters, giving them agency and complex motivations. Purists argue that such efforts represent a distinctively modern tendency to impose our own values on past civilizations, obscuring those civilizations’ beliefs. Defenders of the subgenre counter that reimaginings of the myths for new cultural contexts are almost as old as the myths themselves, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. bringing female perspectives to the forefront is not indicative of a novel attitude regarding fidelity to Greek and Roman myths’ ideologies.
- B. modern writers’ foregrounding of female characters is chiefly motivated by a desire to counterbalance the primacy of male perspectives among earlier adaptations of Greek and Roman myths.
- C. purists are overlooking a long tradition of adapting Greek and Roman myths to focus on female characters.
- D. the complex motivations given to female characters in modern retellings of Greek and Roman myths reflect a recent shift toward psychological depth in fictional representation.

ID: 52bab679 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of a literary subgenre that reimagines Greek and Roman myths in a more modern cultural context—namely, the greater visibility and psychological depth of female characters. According to the text, purists object that this subgenre imposes modern values on past civilizations, while the subgenre’s defenders argue that reimagining old myths for new cultural contexts is “almost as old as the myths themselves.” If this argument in defense of the subgenre is accurate, then bringing female perspectives to the forefront of myth is reflective of a long-established attitude regarding writers’ freedom to recontextualize the ideologies of Greek and Roman myths instead of remaining absolutely faithful to them.

Choice B is incorrect because the text suggests that modern writers who foreground female characters in their adaptations of Greek and Roman myths are motivated by a desire to counterbalance the primacy of male perspectives in the myths themselves, not in earlier adaptations of those myths. The text doesn’t indicate that the modern writers are responding to earlier adaptations and only discusses those adaptations in the context of the argument that recontextualizing Greek and Roman myths is a very old practice. Choice C is incorrect because the defenders’ claim concerns the general practice of reimagining myths for new cultural contexts, not specifically a tradition of focusing on female characters. The text doesn’t indicate that earlier reimaginings centered on female characters, so it wouldn’t be logical to conclude that purists are overlooking a long tradition of adapting myths to focus on female characters specifically. Choice D is incorrect. While the text supports the claim that the modern retellings of Greek and

Roman myths have given complex motivations to the female characters, it doesn't associate this development with a trend toward the portrayal of greater psychological depth in fiction more broadly or claim that such a trend exists. Moreover, the claim that there is an association wouldn't follow logically from the last sentence of the text, which asserts that reimagining myths in new cultural contexts is an established practice.

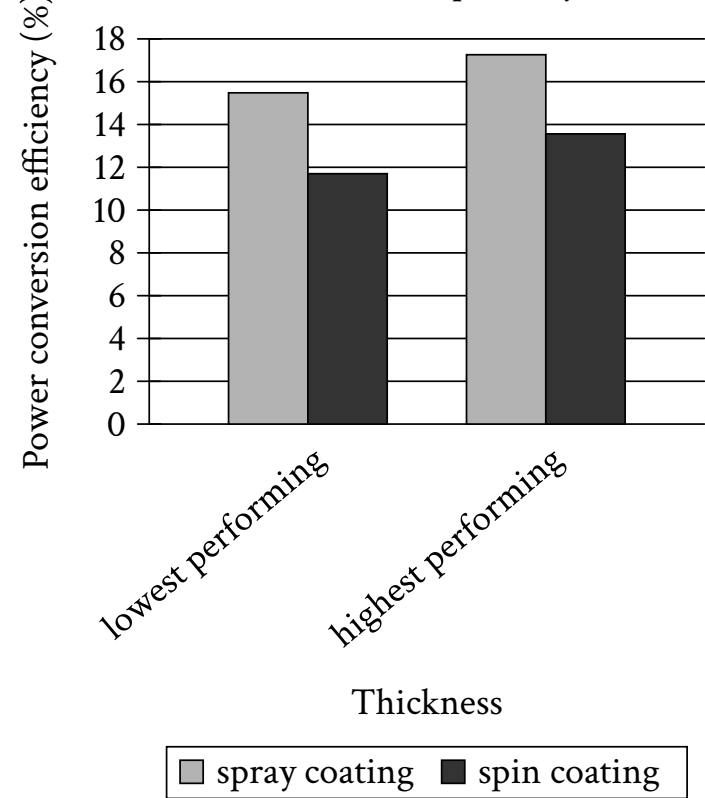
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID aa9e22a0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: aa9e22a0

Power Conversion Efficiency of
Lowest and Highest Performing
Spin-coated and Spray-coated
Electron Transport Layers



Perovskite solar cells convert light into electricity more efficiently than earlier kinds of solar cells, and manufacturing advances have recently made them commercially attractive. One limitation of the cells, however, has to do with their electron transport layer (ETL), through which absorbed electrons must pass. Often the ETL is applied through a process called spin coating, but such ETLs are fairly inefficient at converting input power to output power. André Taylor and colleagues tested a novel spray coating method for applying the ETL. The team produced ETLs of various thicknesses and concluded that spray coating holds promise for improving the power conversion efficiency of ETLs in perovskite solar cells.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that support Taylor and colleagues’ conclusion?

- A. Both the ETL applied through spin coating and the ETL applied through spray coating showed a power conversion efficiency greater than 10% at their lowest performing thickness.
- B. The lowest performing ETL applied through spray coating had a higher power conversion efficiency than the highest performing ETL applied through spin coating.

- C. The highest performing ETL applied through spray coating showed a power conversion efficiency of approximately 13%, while the highest performing ETL applied through spin coating showed a power conversion efficiency of approximately 11%.
- D. There was a substantial difference in power conversion efficiency between the lowest and highest performing ETLs applied through spray coating.

ID: aa9e22a0 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it describes data from the graph that support Taylor and colleagues' conclusion that spray coating holds promise for improving the power conversion efficiency of ETLs in perovskite solar cells. The text explains that perovskite solar cells' efficiency at converting light into electricity is diminished by their electron transport layer (ETL), which is applied through spin coating, but that Taylor's team devised a new spray coating method for applying the ETL that improves its power conversion efficiency. The graph displays data on the power conversion efficiency of solar cells in tests conducted by Taylor's team, with bars for both the highest- and lowest-performing ETLs in two data categories: spray coating and spin coating. According to the graph, the lowest-performing ETL applied through spray coating had a power conversion efficiency of between 14% and 16%, while the highest-performing ETL applied through spin coating had a power conversion efficiency of less than 14%. These data confirm that ETLs applied through novel spray coating are more efficient than those applied through traditional spin coating. Thus, the data support Taylor and colleagues' conclusion about spray coating's potential value.

Choice A is incorrect. Although this claim correctly describes the data in the graph by stating that both the lowest-performing ETL applied through spin coating and the lowest-performing ETL applied through spray coating had a power conversion efficiency greater than 10%, this relationship in the data doesn't support or relate to Taylor and colleagues' conclusion that spray coating promises greater efficiency for solar cells than traditional spin coating does. Choice C is incorrect. This claim does address the greater power conversion efficiency of the highest-performing ETL applied through spray coating, compared with the highest-performing ETL applied through spin coating. However, it also incorrectly cites the value for the efficiency of the highest-performing ETL applied through spray coating as approximately 13%, instead of a value between 14% and 16%, and the value for the efficiency of the highest-performing ETL applied through spin coating as approximately 11%, instead of a value between 12% and 14%, as shown in the graph. Choice D is incorrect because Taylor and colleagues' conclusion is based on the difference in the power conversion efficiency of ETLs applied through spray coating and that of ETLs applied through spin coating, not on the difference between the highest- and lowest-performing ETLs applied through just spray coating.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5267df34

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 5267df34

The ancient Greek concept of “mimesis,” a term used in the works of Plato, Aristotle, and other Greek philosophers in discussions of representational art—visual, performance, or literary art that aims to depict the real world—is a foundational concept of the Western philosophy of aesthetics. Mimesis is typically translated as “imitation” in modern editions of ancient Greek texts, but scholar Stephen Halliwell warns that this is overly reductive: “imitation” implies that art merely copies—and is thus by definition entirely derivative of—a reality that exists outside and prior to the work of art, and translating “mimesis” thusly obscures the multifaceted ways in which the ancient Greeks understood the relationship between art and reality.

Which statement, if true, would most directly support the claim by Halliwell presented in the text?

- A. One of the earliest appearances of mimesis’s root word, *mimos*, can be found in an ancient Greek tragedy in reference to dramatic impersonation, and the *mim-* root came to be generally associated with the musical and poetic arts by the fifth century BCE.
- B. Both Plato’s and Aristotle’s theorizations of mimesis examine the psychological effects that works of art induce in the viewer or listener.
- C. Although several of Plato’s earliest philosophical works discuss aesthetic ideas, the term “mimesis” doesn’t appear in Plato’s discussions of art until *Cratylus*, a relatively late work.
- D. Although Plato’s writings typically characterize representational art as an inferior reflection of the physical world, Aristotle suggests that mimesis can refer to art’s capacity to envision hypothetical conditions that could, but don’t yet, exist.

ID: 5267df34 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a statement that would support Halliwell’s claim that “imitation” is an overly simplified translation of the word “mimesis” in the context of ancient Greek philosophical discussions of representational art and that, because it suggests a view of art as merely copying things that exist in reality, the translation obscures the fact that Plato, Aristotle, and other ancient Greeks understood the relationship between art and reality in varied ways. If Plato’s works tend to treat representational art as an inferior or inadequate reflection of the physical world (consistent with the idea of mere imitation), while Aristotle’s works suggest that the term “mimesis” can refer to art’s ability to show conditions that don’t currently exist but could exist (going beyond imitation into novel creation), that evidence would support the claim that the term “mimesis” means more than just “imitation” and that ancient Greek philosophers held different views of the relationship between art and reality.

Choice A is incorrect because information about the root word *mimos* first being used in drama and the root *mim-* coming to be associated with music and poetry wouldn’t indicate anything about the meaning of the specific term “mimesis” as it was used by ancient Greek philosophers in discussions of representational art; thus, the information would have no bearing on Halliwell’s claim that a common translation of the specific term is an oversimplification. Choice B is incorrect because the issue of art’s psychological effects on audiences gets at how people respond to works of art instead of how art itself is related to reality, so the

idea that Plato and Aristotle both addressed such effects in their considerations of mimesis wouldn't have any bearing on Halliwell's claim that a common translation of that term oversimplifies the relationship between art and reality. Further, this idea would touch on one general similarity in approaches to mimesis instead of illustrating the multifaceted, or varied, ways Halliwell claims ancient Greek philosophers understood art's relation to reality. Choice C is incorrect because the idea that Plato discussed aesthetics in his early works but didn't use the term "mimesis" until later doesn't give any indication of how Plato or any other ancient Greek philosophers understood the relation between art and reality, so it would have no bearing on Halliwell's claim that a common translation of the term "mimesis" is oversimplified and fails to reflect the varied ways the philosophers understood that relationship.

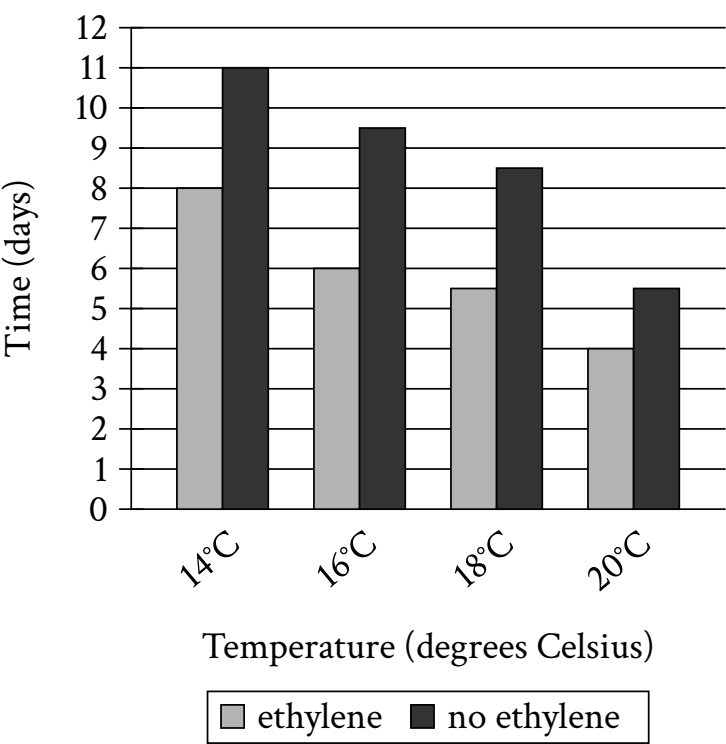
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 212d10e8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 212d10e8

Banana Ripening Time at Different Temperatures with and without Ethylene Treatment



A student is conducting an experiment to test the effect of temperature and ethylene treatment on the ripening speed of bananas. The student treated some bananas with ethylene while leaving others untreated, then allowed both types of bananas to ripen at one of four different temperatures. Comparing the data for bananas with and without ethylene, the student concluded that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the student’s conclusion?

- A. 20°C is the ideal temperature at which to store bananas to slow ripening time.
- B. for those bananas that were not treated with ethylene, differences in temperature were not associated with absolute differences in ripening time.
- C. bananas treated with ethylene ripen faster at 14°C and 16°C than at 18°C and 20°C.
- D. ethylene was associated with a greater absolute change in ripening time at 14°C, 16°C, and 18°C than at 20°C.

ID: 212d10e8 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the student's conclusion about banana ripening time with and without ethylene at different temperatures. The graph shows that at 20°C, the gap between the two bars showing ripening times for ethylene-treated bananas and untreated bananas crosses fewer than 2 gridlines (from about 4 days for ethylene-treated bananas to about 5.5 days for untreated bananas). Meanwhile, the graph shows that at 14°C, 16°C, and 18°C, the gap between the bars crosses more than 2 gridlines (from about 8 days for treated bananas to about 11 days for untreated bananas at 14°C; from about 6 days for treated bananas to about 9.5 days for untreated bananas at 16°C; and from about 5.5 days for treated bananas to about 8.5 days for untreated bananas at 18°C). Since the gap between the bars at each of these temperatures crosses more than 2 gridlines, and since each of these gaps is larger than the gap between the bars at 20°C, it can be concluded that ethylene was associated with a greater absolute change in ripening time at 14°C, 16°C, and 18°C than at 20°C.

Choice A is incorrect because the graph shows that ethylene-treated bananas stored at 20°C ripen more quickly than ethylene-treated bananas stored at the other temperatures do (about 4 days at 20°C vs. about 5.5, 6, and 8 days at 18°C, 16°C, and 14°C, respectively) and that untreated bananas stored at 20°C ripen more quickly than untreated bananas stored at the other temperatures do (about 5.5 days at 20°C vs. about 8.5, 9.5, and 11 days at 18°C, 16°C, and 14°C, respectively). The information in the graph therefore indicates that storing bananas at 20°C speeds up ripening time relative to storing bananas at the other temperatures shown, not that this storage temperature slows ripening time. Choice B is incorrect because the graph shows that as temperature increases, the ripening time of untreated bananas decreases, from about 11 days at 14°C to about 5.5 days at 20°C, with no exceptions to this trend. The graph therefore shows that differences in temperature were associated with absolute differences in ripening time, not that there was no association between differences in temperature and differences in ripening time. Choice C is incorrect because the graph shows that ripening times of ethylene-treated bananas at 14°C and 16°C were about 8 and 6 days, respectively, which is greater than, not less than, ripening times of ethylene-treated bananas at 18°C and 20°C, which were about 5.5 and 4 days, respectively. In other words, bananas treated with ethylene ripen more slowly, not faster, at 14°C and 16°C than at 18°C and 20°C.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a35a5695

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a35a5695

“Loon Point” is a 1912 poem by Amy Lowell. In the poem, which presents a nighttime scene on a body of water, Lowell describes an element of nature as an active participant in the experience, writing, _____

Which quotation from “Loon Point” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “Through the water the moon writes her legends / In light, on the smooth, wet sand.”
- B. “Softly the water ripples / Against the canoe’s curving side.”
- C. “Or like the snow-white petals / Which drop from an overblown rose.”
- D. “But the moon in her wayward beauty / Is ever and always the same.”

ID: a35a5695 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively illustrates the claim that Lowell describes an element of nature as an active participant in the experience of a nighttime scene on a body of water. The quotation presents the image of the moon shining on a body of water. However, instead of describing the moon in passive terms or simply stating that it reflects through the water and onto the sandy shore, the quotation portrays the moon as being engaged in the humanlike action of writing a legend. In other words, the moon is participating actively in the nighttime scene.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the quotation describes a nighttime scene on a body of water, the element of nature in these lines—the waves—isn’t portrayed as an active participant in an experience; instead, the waves merely ripple softly against a canoe, as waves would normally do. Choice C is incorrect because the quotation doesn’t present a nighttime scene on a body of water; instead, it describes petals falling from a rose. Choice D is incorrect. Although the quotation presents an image of an element of nature—the moon—it doesn’t mention a body of water; moreover, it portrays the moon not as an active participant in a scene but instead as static or unchanging (“ever and always the same”).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7440cac4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 7440cac4

The Souls of Black Folk is a 1903 book by W.E.B. Du Bois. In the book, Du Bois suggests that upon hearing Black folk songs, he felt an intuitive and sometimes unexpected sense of cultural recognition: _____

Which quotation from *The Souls of Black Folk* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “[Black folk music] still remains as the singular spiritual heritage of the nation and the greatest gift of the Negro people.”
- B. “Ever since I was a child these songs have stirred me strangely. They came out of the South unknown to me, one by one, and yet at once I knew them as of me and of mine.”
- C. “Caricature has sought again to spoil the quaint beauty of the music, and has filled the air with many debased melodies which vulgar ears scarce know from the real. But the true Negro folk-song still lives in the hearts of those who have heard them truly sung and in the hearts of the Negro people.”
- D. “The songs are indeed the siftings of centuries; the music is far more ancient than the words, and in it we can trace here and there signs of development.”

ID: 7440cac4 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because the quotation from *The Souls of Black Folk* illustrates the claim that Du Bois felt a sense of cultural recognition when he heard Black folk songs. In the quotation, Du Bois explains that for his entire life, Black folk songs “stirred [him] strangely.” Even though they originated in the South, a region he wasn’t familiar with, he knew the songs “as of me and of mine.” That is, he identified strongly with them and associated them with his community. Therefore, Du Bois felt an intuitive sense of cultural recognition when he heard Black folk songs.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the quotation considers the cultural and spiritual value of Black folk music, it doesn’t establish that this music inspired in Du Bois a sense of cultural recognition. Choice C is incorrect because this quotation addresses the cultural survival of Black folk songs despite attempts to caricature, or parody, them, not Du Bois’s sense of cultural connection to them. Choice D is incorrect because the quotation indicates that the Black folk songs and music are old, “the siftings of centuries,” instead of addressing how Du Bois felt when he heard the songs.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 80581d48

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 80581d48

Art collectives, like the United States- and Vietnam-based collective The Propeller Group or Cuba’s Los Carpinteros, are groups of artists who agree to work together: perhaps for stylistic reasons, or to advance certain shared political ideals, or to help mitigate the costs of supplies and studio space. Regardless of the reasons, art collectives usually involve some collaboration among the artists. Based on a recent series of interviews with various art collectives, an arts journalist claims that this can be difficult for artists who are often used to having sole control over their work.

Which quotation from the interviews best illustrates the journalist’s claim?

- A. “The first collective I joined included many amazingly talented artists, and we enjoyed each other’s company, but because we had a hard time sharing credit and responsibility for our work, the collective didn’t last.”
- B. “We work together, but that doesn’t mean that individual projects are equally the work of all of us. Many of our projects are primarily the responsibility of whoever originally proposed the work to the group.”
- C. “Having worked as a member of a collective for several years, it’s sometimes hard to recall what it was like to work alone without the collective’s support. But that support encourages my individual expression rather than limits it.”
- D. “Sometimes an artist from outside the collective will choose to collaborate with us on a project, but all of those projects fit within the larger themes of the work the collective does on its own.”

ID: 80581d48 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents the quotation that best illustrates the journalist’s claim. By indicating that a collective didn’t continue because it was hard to share credit and responsibilities within the group even though the company was enjoyable, the quotation shows that working collaboratively can be difficult for artists who are used to having complete control over their work.

Choice B is incorrect because the quotation indicates that members of a collective are able to collaborate together and have agreed on a fair way to manage their responsibilities; this doesn’t demonstrate the challenge of sharing control among members of a collective. Choice C is incorrect because the quotation highlights the support and encouragement of individual expression an artist experiences due to working in a collective; these positive aspects don’t demonstrate the challenge of sharing control among members of a collective. Choice D is incorrect because the quotation doesn’t address any challenges of sharing control among members of a collective; it simply indicates that artists sometimes choose to work with collectives without having to be a member. Therefore, the quotation doesn’t illustrate the journalist’s claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 058faa1b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 058faa1b

In 2018, scientists discovered an immense aggregation of *Muusoctopus robustus* (pearl octopuses) along a hydrothermal vent 3,200 meters beneath the ocean’s surface. Water temperatures at this site—named the Octopus Garden—climb as high as 11°C, much warmer than the ambient 1.6°C typical at this depth. Based on observations made over three years, scientists concluded that temperatures at the site likely confer reproductive benefits and that the site is used exclusively for reproduction—6,000 *M. robustus* adults, hatchlings, and eggs were observed at the garden, but no juveniles were present.

Which statement about *M. robustus* and the Octopus Garden is best supported by the text?

- A. *M. robustus* leave the Octopus Garden upon reaching an intermediary stage of development.
- B. The *M. robustus* population at the Octopus Garden remains stable despite variations in water temperature.
- C. *M. robustus* nests in the Octopus Garden contain on average fewer but larger eggs than nests at similar ocean depths.
- D. The Octopus Garden provides an ideal feeding ground for *M. robustus* hatchlings.

ID: 058faa1b Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the *M. robustus* population at the Octopus Garden. The text states that the scientists concluded that the site is likely used only for reproduction because over three years they saw many adults, freshly hatched octopuses, and eggs but didn’t see any juveniles. This suggests that the *M. robustus* octopuses that hatch at the Octopus Garden leave the site when they reach an intermediary state of development, returning only as adults for reproductive purposes.

Choice B is incorrect because the text never discusses the stability of the *M. robustus* population at the site, only that the scientists observed 6,000 adults, hatchlings, and eggs there. Further, the text presents the site’s temperatures as likely beneficial. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t provide any details about the eggs at the site and makes no mention of nests; it indicates only that eggs are present along with hatchlings and adults. Choice D is incorrect because the text makes no mention of the hatchlings feeding at the Octopus Garden, indicating only that the temperatures at the site are probably beneficial and that the site is likely used for reproduction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9552f7b9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 9552f7b9

Jean-Bernard Caron and colleagues recently discovered a cache of jellyfish fossils in the Burgess Shale, a site in the Canadian Rockies that is rich in fossils from the Cambrian period (over 500 million years ago). Caron and colleagues claim that these are the oldest jellyfish fossils ever discovered. In the past twenty years, two sites in China and the United States have yielded fossils of a similar age that some experts believe are most likely jellyfish due to their shapes and the appearance of projecting tentacles. But Caron and colleagues argue that the apparent tentacles are in fact the comb rows of ctenophores, gelatinous animals that are only distantly related to jellyfish.

Which statement, if true, would most directly weaken the claim by Caron and colleagues about the fossils found in China and the United States?

- A. Sites in the Canadian Rockies from later periods than the Cambrian period have yielded fossils that have been conclusively identified as ctenophore fossils.
- B. The fossils found in China and the United States are so poorly preserved that though they cannot be conclusively identified as jellyfish, they cannot be conclusively identified as ctenophores either.
- C. While ctenophore fossils have been discovered in China and the United States, they have never been discovered in the Burgess Shale.
- D. The fossils discovered by Caron and colleagues in the Burgess Shale were better preserved than the fossils discovered by other researchers in China and the United States.

ID: 9552f7b9 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a statement that, if true, would most directly weaken Caron and colleagues' claim that the apparent tentacles in the Chinese and American fossils are actually ctenophore comb rows. If the fossils are so poorly preserved that they cannot be conclusively identified as either organism, neither the claim that they are jellyfish nor, as Caron claims, that they are ctenophores would be supported.

Choice A is incorrect. Caron's claim is that fossils from the US and China are ctenophores, not jellyfish. These fossils are said to be "of a similar age" to the Cambrian fossils found in the Canadian Rockies. And nothing in the text or this choice suggests that the presence or absence of ctenophores after the Cambrian would have any bearing on whether the Cambrian fossils from the US and China are ctenophores. Choice C is incorrect. Caron's claim is that fossils from the US and China are ctenophores, not jellyfish. Nothing in the text suggests that the presence or absence of ctenophores in the Burgess Shale (in Canada) would affect whether the fossils found in the US and China are ctenophores. Choice D is incorrect. Caron's claim is that fossils from the US and China are ctenophores, not jellyfish. Although fossil quality is a plausible issue for the research described in the text, nothing in the text or this choice suggests that the fossils from US and China would have been too poorly preserved for proper identification.

Question ID 16f7b2f6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 16f7b2f6

In superfluorescence, electrical charges known as dipoles emit light in synchronized bursts so intense that they are visible to the eye. Until recently, this phenomenon has only been observed at extremely cold temperatures because dipoles cannot synchronize at higher temperatures. But in a study, Melike Biliroglu and colleagues observed superfluorescence at room temperature in thin films made of perovskite and other similarly crystalline materials; the researchers propose that the formation of shock-absorbing quasiparticles called polarons in the material protects dipoles from thermal interference.

Based on the text, how are polarons believed to be involved in the superfluorescence observed in Biliroglu and colleagues’ study?

- A. Polarons enable superfluorescent bursts to cross from one crystalline material to another.
- B. Polarons allow for the dipoles to synchronize despite higher temperatures.
- C. Polarons accelerate the dipoles’ release of superfluorescent bursts.
- D. Polarons decrease the intensity of the superfluorescent burst.

ID: 16f7b2f6 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes Biliroglu and colleagues’ claim about how the polarons function in relation to superfluorescence. The text indicates that “until recently,” superfluorescence (intense, synchronized bursts of light emitted by dipoles) has solely been observed at very cold temperatures. However, it also states that, recently, Biliroglu and colleagues report observing the phenomenon at room temperature. They achieved this using “thin films made of perovskite and other similarly crystalline materials,” which the researchers claim allows for the formation of polarons. They also suggest that these polarons might absorb the thermal shocks that typically disrupt dipole synchronization at warmer temperatures. Thus, based on the text, Biliroglu and colleagues believe that polarons help dipoles synchronize at temperatures well above those at which superfluorescence had previously been observed.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t address the prospect of a superfluorescent burst moving between crystalline materials or any other mediums. Choice C is incorrect because the text’s discussion of polarons is about how they might enable superfluorescence at higher temperatures than those at which it had previously been observed. Rather than suggesting that polarons speed up superfluorescent bursts, the text suggests that no superfluorescence can occur at room temperature in the absence of polarons. Thus, the text indicates that polarons make superfluorescent bursts more likely to occur at higher temperatures than those at which it had previously been observed, not that polarons accelerate the bursts. Choice D is incorrect because the text’s discussion of polarons is about how they might enable superfluorescence at higher temperatures than those at which it had previously been observed. In the absence of polarons, the text suggests there would be no superfluorescence at room temperature. Thus, rather than decrease the intensity of superfluorescent bursts, polarons make them more likely to occur under certain circumstances.

Question ID 6d028d72

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 6d028d72

Some ethicists hold that the moral goodness of an individual's actions depends solely on whether the actions themselves are good, irrespective of the context in which they are carried out. Philosopher L. Sebastian Purcell has shown that surviving works of Aztec (Nahua) philosophy express a very different view. Purcell reveals that these works posit an ethical system in which an individual's actions are judged in light of how well they accord with the individual's role in society and how well they contribute to the community. To the extent that these works are representative of Aztec thought, Purcell's analysis suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the Aztecs would have disputed the idea that the morality of an individual's actions can be assessed by appealing to standards of behavior that are independent of the individual's social circumstances.
- B. the Aztecs would not have accepted the notion that the morality of an individual's actions can be fairly evaluated by people who do not live in the same society as that individual.
- C. actions by members of Aztec society who contributed a great deal to their community could be judged as morally good even if those actions were inconsistent with behaviors the Aztecs regarded as good in all contexts.
- D. similar actions performed by people in different social roles in Aztec society would have been regarded as morally equivalent unless those actions led to different outcomes for the community.

ID: 6d028d72 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion about Aztec (Nahua) ethics. The text indicates that, according to Purcell's interpretation of available Aztec philosophical works, the Aztec ethical system views an individual's actions in relation to that individual's societal role and how the actions affect the community. The text contrasts this view with another held by some ethicists, namely that actions are morally good or bad regardless of the context in which they occur. Thus, Purcell's analysis suggests that the Aztecs would have asserted that the morality of an individual's actions are rooted in that person's position in the community and the actions' effects and therefore cannot be determined in the absence of that context.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the text indicates that morally judging an action according to Aztec ethics requires an understanding of the action's effects and the individual's social circumstances, it does not specify that only members of that society can acquire this information. Choice C is incorrect because it implies that the Aztecs considered some actions good or bad regardless of the surrounding context, which contradicts the text's claim that the Aztecs believed that the morality of an individual's action is dependent on the action's effects on the community and the person's specific circumstances. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text indicates that in Aztec ethics the morality of an action depends in part on how it affects the community, this is only one of the two factors—the other being the person's societal role—that need to be considered. Therefore, it

is possible that two actions with the same effect on the community could be considered morally distinct if they are performed by individuals in different social roles.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e16d4a26

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: e16d4a26

The following text is from Mick Herron’s 2023 novel *The Secret Hours*. The narrator is describing members of a government committee.

Finally, and adding much-needed gravitas, was Sir Winston Day, whose features seemed moulded to adorn a bust, or possibly a stamp, and whose forehead was so evidently bulging with grey matter that it would have been impertinent to inquire too closely into the actual achievements his half century of public service had produced. His recently published memoirs possibly cast light on this enigma, but given that such details were not provided until after the thirty-page mark, they might as well have remained state secrets.

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- Based on the text, which choice best describes Sir Winston Day?
- A. He has the appearance of a distinguished figure, but it is uncertain whether he has accomplished anything to earn distinction.
 - B. He looks like a person worthy of respect, but his memoirs reveal that some of his actions were dishonorable.
 - C. He would be a celebrated public figure if his achievements did not have to be kept secret.
 - D. He has maintained a modest profile even though he has served the public capably for many years.

ID: e16d4a26 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it accurately describes Sir Winston Day as he is portrayed in the text. The text indicates that Sir Winston’s “features seemed moulded to adorn a bust, or possibly a stamp,” suggesting that he appeared distinguished. But the text also indicates that his “actual achievements” during his long public service constitute an “enigma,” or mystery, highlighting the point with a joke about Sir Winston’s uninteresting memoirs (any information about his achievements past the first thirty pages “might as well have remained state secrets” since, it’s implied, no one bothered to read that far). Thus, the text suggests that Sir Winston appears distinguished even though his known accomplishments, if any, are relatively few.

Choice B is incorrect because nothing in the text indicates that Sir Winston behaved dishonorably. Rather, the text indicates that his “actual achievements” during his long public service constitute an enigma, or mystery, suggesting that he may have done very little, not that what he has done was disreputable. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text says that Sir Winston’s achievements that appear “after the thirty-page mark” in his memoirs “might as well have remained state secrets,” this is a joke about the public’s lack of interest in the memoirs, not a sincere claim that secrecy was intended. Choice D is incorrect because the text does not associate Sir Winston with modesty, nor does it suggest that he was a capable public servant. Rather, by indicating that Sir Winston’s “features seemed moulded to adorn a bust, or possibly a stamp,” the text suggests that Sir Winston’s appearance communicated importance, not modesty. The text further indicates that his “actual achievements” during his long public service constitute an enigma, or mystery, suggesting that he may have done very little, not that he was particularly capable.

Question ID 73bb38ef

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 73bb38ef

Some *Astyanax mexicanus*, a river-dwelling fish found in northeast Mexico, have colonized caves in the region. Although there is little genetic difference between river and cave *A. mexicanus* and all members of the species can emit the same sounds, biologist Carole Hyacinthe and colleagues found that the context and significance of those sounds vary by location—e.g., the click that river-dwelling *A. mexicanus* use to signal aggression is used by cave dwellers when foraging—and the acoustic properties of cave fish sounds show some cave-specific variations as well. Hyacinthe and colleagues note that differences in sonic communication could accumulate to the point of inhibiting interbreeding among fish from different locations, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. although *A. mexicanus* living in rivers are genetically similar to those living in caves, river fish rely on sonic communication less than cave fish do.
- B. although *A. mexicanus* is a single species at present, it could be in the process of splitting into distinct populations with different characteristics.
- C. although all *A. mexicanus* emit sounds, the fish living in rivers produce some sounds that the fish living in caves do not, and vice versa.
- D. although *A. mexicanus* from different locations can interbreed currently, river fish and cave fish are sufficiently genetically distinct that they can be considered separate species.

ID: 73bb38ef Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of *A. mexicanus*. According to the text, *A. mexicanus*, a river-dwelling fish species, has colonized caves. The fish that live in rivers and those that live in caves show no significant genetic differences and are all capable of making the same sounds. The text indicates, however, that Hyacinthe and colleagues found that sounds that the river fish use in a particular context and for a particular purpose are used in a different context and for a different purpose by the cave fish. Additionally, the sounds made by cave fish show some differences depending on the specific cave the fish inhabit. The text goes on to state that Hyacinthe and colleagues have noted that differences in how the fish use sound to communicate could eventually become so great that they prevent fish from different locations from interbreeding. In other words, the river fish might eventually only breed with other river fish (with whom they share characteristics regarding sonic communication that they do not share with cave fish), while the cave fish might only breed with other cave fish for a similar reason. In context, this observation suggests that even though the fish are a single species right now, they could be in the process of splitting into distinct populations with different characteristics.

Choice A is incorrect because there is no information in the text suggesting that the river fish are less reliant on sonic communication than the cave fish are. Although the text does indicate that the river fish and cave fish are genetically similar, the text describes both groups as using sonic communication and says nothing to indicate that one group depends on that

communication more than the other group does. Choice C is incorrect. The text states that all members of the species can emit the same sounds but that the function and context of sounds differ depending on whether the fish live in rivers or caves, but it does not indicate that river fish produce sounds that cave fish do not or vice versa. Choice D is incorrect because it contradicts the text. The text says that there is little genetic difference between the river fish and the cave fish, not that the river fish and cave fish are so genetically distinct that they can be considered separate species.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ee0acb4b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: ee0acb4b

Archaeologist Petra Vaiglova, anthropologist Xinyi Liu, and their colleagues investigated the domestication of farm animals in China during the Bronze Age (approximately 2000 to 1000 BCE). By analyzing the chemical composition of the bones of sheep, goats, and cattle from this era, the team determined that wild plants made up the bulk of sheep’s and goats’ diets, while the cattle’s diet consisted largely of millet, a crop cultivated by humans. The team concluded that cattle were likely raised closer to human settlements, whereas sheep and goats were allowed to roam farther away.

Which finding, if true, would most strongly support the team’s conclusion?

- A. Analysis of the animal bones showed that the cattle’s diet also consisted of wheat, which humans widely cultivated in China during the Bronze Age.
- B. Further investigation of sheep and goat bones revealed that their diets consisted of small portions of millet as well.
- C. Cattle’s diets generally require larger amounts of food and a greater variety of nutrients than do sheep’s and goats’ diets.
- D. The diets of sheep, goats, and cattle were found to vary based on what the farmers in each Bronze Age settlement could grow.

ID: ee0acb4b Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most strongly support the team’s conclusion that cattle were likely raised closer to human settlements than sheep and goats were. The text explains that Vaiglova, Liu, and their colleagues analyzed the chemical composition of sheep, goat, and cattle bones from the Bronze Age in China in order to investigate the animals’ domestication, or their adaptation from a wild state to a state in which they existed in close connection with humans. According to the text, the team’s analysis showed that sheep and goats of the era fed largely on wild plants, whereas cattle fed on millet—importantly, a crop cultivated by humans. If analysis of the animal bones shows that the cattle’s diet also consisted of wheat, another crop cultivated by humans in China during the Bronze Age, the finding would support the team’s conclusion by offering additional evidence that cattle during this era fed on human-grown crops—and, by extension, that humans raised cattle relatively close to the settlements where they grew these crops, leaving goats and sheep to roam farther away in areas with wild vegetation, uncultivated by humans.

Choice B is incorrect because if it were true that sheep’s and goats’ diets consisted of small portions of millet, which the text states was a crop cultivated by humans, the finding would suggest that sheep and goats were raised relatively close to human settlements, weakening the team’s conclusion that cattle were likely raised closer to those settlements than sheep and goats were. Choice C is incorrect because the finding that cattle generally require more food and nutrients than do sheep and goats wouldn’t support the team’s conclusion that cattle were likely raised closer to human settlements than sheep and goats were. Nothing in the text suggests that cattle were incapable of obtaining sufficient food and nutrients without access to human-grown crops. Hence, even if cattle’s diets are found to have different requirements than the diets of sheep and goats, the cattle could have met those requirements from food located far from human settlements. Choice D is incorrect because if it were true that the

diets of sheep, goats, and cattle varied based on what the farmers in each Bronze Age settlement could grow, the finding would weaken the team's conclusion that cattle were likely raised closer to human settlements than sheep and goats were, suggesting instead that all three types of animals were raised close enough to human settlements to feed on those settlements' crops.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2b64f805

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 2b64f805

Martin Dančák, Wewin Tjiasmanto, and colleagues have identified a new carnivorous plant species (*Nepenthes pudica*) in Indonesia. Like other carnivorous plants, *N. pudica* has pitfall traps, or pitchers, that capture prey, but unlike others, the pitchers of *N. pudica* are located underground. The researchers unearthed the new species on fairly dry ridges with surfaces that host few other plants and animals. Therefore, the researchers hypothesize that the *N. pudica* species likely _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. represents one of many undiscovered carnivorous plant species in the region.
- B. formed pitchers early in development to absorb more moisture.
- C. is buried by nearby animals as they forage along the ridges for food.
- D. evolved to have underground traps to access more prey than would surface traps.

ID: 2b64f805 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The text says that *N.pudica*’s prey-catching pitchers are underground. It also says that the ridges where *N. pudica* lives don’t have many plants and animals on the surface. This suggests that *N. pudica* evolved underground pitchers in order to catch more prey.

Choice A is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never mentions the possibility of other undiscovered carnivorous plant species in Indonesia, so there’s no basis to make this inference. Choice B is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text does say that the ridges where *N. pudica* lives are dry, but it also says that the purpose of carnivorous plant pitchers is to capture prey. It never suggests that these pitchers also absorb moisture, so there’s no basis to make this inference. Choice C is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never suggests that *N. pudica*’s underground pitcher can catch animals on the surface, so there’s no basis to make this inference.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 73091a9f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 73091a9f

The domestic sweet potato (*Ipomoea batatas*) descends from a wild plant native to South America. It also populates the Polynesian Islands, where evidence confirms that Native Hawaiians and other Indigenous peoples were cultivating the plant centuries before seafaring first occurred over the thousands of miles of ocean separating them from South America. To explain how the sweet potato was first introduced in Polynesia, botanist Pablo Muñoz-Rodríguez and colleagues analyzed the DNA of numerous varieties of the plant, concluding that Polynesian varieties diverged from South American ones over 100,000 years ago. Given that Polynesia was peopled only in the last three thousand years, the team concluded that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the cultivation of the sweet potato in Polynesia likely predates its cultivation in South America.
- B. Polynesian peoples likely acquired the sweet potato from South American peoples only within the last three thousand years.
- C. human activity likely played no role in the introduction of the sweet potato in Polynesia.
- D. Polynesian sweet potato varieties likely descend from a single South American variety that was domesticated, not wild.

ID: 73091a9f Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the sweet potato in Polynesia. The text indicates that the sweet potato is found in Polynesia but originated in South America, and that the sweet potato was being cultivated by Native Hawaiians and other Indigenous peoples in Polynesia long before sea voyages between South America and Polynesia began. The text goes on to note that research by Muñoz-Rodríguez and colleagues has established that the Polynesian varieties of sweet potato split from South American varieties more than 100,000 years ago, which is thousands of years before humans settled in Polynesia. If Polynesian peoples were cultivating the sweet potato before sea voyages between Polynesia and South America began, and if Polynesian varieties of sweet potato diverged from South American varieties well before people were in Polynesia, it can reasonably be concluded that humans didn’t play a role in bringing the sweet potato to Polynesia.

Choice A is incorrect. The text doesn’t provide any information about when the sweet potato began to be cultivated in South America, so there’s no support for the conclusion that cultivation began in Polynesia before it began in South America. Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that the sweet potato was being cultivated in Polynesia long before sea journeys between Polynesia and South America began. Therefore, it wouldn’t be reasonable to conclude that Polynesian peoples acquired the sweet potato from South American peoples. Additionally, the text indicates that the Polynesian varieties of sweet potato diverged from the South American varieties thousands of years before people settled in Polynesia, which suggests that the sweet potato was already present in Polynesia when people arrived. Choice D is incorrect because the text states that the domestic sweet potato, which is found in Polynesia, descends from a wild South American plant, not from a domesticated South American plant. The only people that the text describes as cultivating the sweet potato are Native Hawaiians and other Indigenous peoples of Polynesia.

Question ID 3f38da95

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 3f38da95

In the “language nest” model of education, Indigenous children learn the language of their people by using it as the medium of instruction and socialization at pre-K or elementary levels. In their 2016 study of a school in an Anishinaabe community in Ontario, Canada, scholars Lindsay Morcom and Stephanie Roy (who are Anishinaabe themselves) found that the model not only imparted fluency in the Anishinaabe language but also enhanced students’ pride in Anishinaabe culture overall. Given these positive effects, Morcom and Roy predict that the model increases the probability that as adults, former students of the school will transmit the language to younger generations in their community.

Which finding, if true, would most strongly support the researchers’ prediction?

- A. Anishinaabe adults who didn’t attend the school feel roughly the same degree of cultural pride as the former students of the school feel.
- B. After transferring to the school, new students experience an increase in both fluency and academic performance overall.
- C. As adults, former students of the school are just as likely to continue living in their community as individuals who didn’t attend the school.
- D. As they complete secondary and higher education, former students of the school experience no loss of fluency or cultural pride.

ID: 3f38da95 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support the researchers’ prediction about the language nest model of education. The text states that Morcom and Roy studied the effects of the language nest model of education on students at an Anishinaabe school, and they found that the model—which is used with students during pre-K or elementary school—increased students’ fluency in the Anishinaabe language and pride in Anishinaabe culture. The researchers predicted that the students’ positive early experiences with the Anishinaabe language would lead them to be more likely to later share the language with younger generations. If former students maintain full fluency and cultural pride after finishing secondary and higher education, it follows that they would be both able and motivated to share what they know with others; this would likely result in a higher probability of transmitting the language to younger generations, as the researchers predict.

Choice A is incorrect because finding that Anishinaabe adults who didn’t attend the school feel approximately the same degree of cultural pride as those adults who did attend wouldn’t support the researchers’ prediction that former students will be more likely to share their knowledge with younger generations. This finding would identify a similarity between the groups rather than a factor that might make former students more likely than other adults to transmit the language to younger people. Choice B is incorrect because finding that new students experience increased performance in language fluency and academics would suggest that the school has a positive effect on students when they attended but wouldn’t reveal anything about those students’ later actions as adults (such as their likelihood of sharing their knowledge with younger generations). Choice C is incorrect because finding that

Anishinaabe adults who attended the school are equally likely to stay in the community as adults who didn't attend the school wouldn't support the researchers' prediction that former students will be more likely to share their knowledge with younger generations. This finding would identify a similarity between the groups rather than a factor that might make former students more likely than other adults to transmit the language to younger people.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4e5e24ad

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 4e5e24ad

The interiors of many temples in the ancient Middle East needed to satisfy a precise set of acoustic demands: the sounds of chants and hymns should travel with clarity, while profound silences should be fully felt and appreciated. In a research paper, a student claims that the users of one such temple were aware of how the materials that were used within the structure could affect sound quality and that they deliberately applied this knowledge to influence how sound was experienced in the space.

Which quotation from a work by a historian would most directly support the student’s claim?

- A. “Many researchers believe that the central chamber of the temple had a high ceiling, a feature that has since become essential to the acoustic design of modern concert halls.”
- B. “The innermost room of the temple was likely among the quietest spaces in the interior of the temple.”
- C. “The acoustic environment of the temple was best suited for music that eschewed ornamentation in favor of simple melodies, harmonies, and rhythms.”
- D. “During special occasions, curtains were placed inside the temple to minimize reverberation and confine the sound to designated locations.”

ID: 4e5e24ad Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it provides a quotation that would most directly support the student’s claim that the temple’s users were aware of how materials used in the temple affected sound and deliberately applied that knowledge to shape the sonic experience of people in the space. The quotation indicates that curtains would, at times, be installed specifically “to minimize reverberation and confine the sound,” thereby illustrating that the users of the temple had knowledge of the acoustic properties of materials within the temple (how curtains dampen sound) and employed this knowledge to affect the experience of sound within the space.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the quotation describes a feature of the temple’s structure (the high ceiling), it makes no mention of the materials used, the materials’ acoustic properties, or temple users’ awareness of how materials impact sound quality. Choice B is incorrect because it doesn’t address any materials that were used in the temple, let alone their acoustic properties or temple users’ awareness of how materials impact sound quality. Choice C is incorrect because it doesn’t address any materials that were used in the temple, let alone their acoustic properties or temple users’ awareness of how materials impact sound quality.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f55b236f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: f55b236f

In a study of perceptions of listening ability, participants explained their position on a sociopolitical issue and then received a listener’s written summary that expressed agreement or disagreement. Within selected summaries, researchers embedded markers of attentive listening (e.g., references to specific details), hypothesizing that such indications would positively influence perceptions of listening skill even in the context of disagreement. Instead, participants consistently rated listeners who expressed disagreement as less skilled, regardless of the other traits of the listeners’ summaries.

What does the text most strongly imply about how participants responded to expressions of disagreement?

- A. When participants felt personally invested in the topics they discussed, they were less likely to perceive listeners who expressed disagreement as attentive, regardless of evidence to the contrary in these listeners’ summaries.
- B. When participants encountered summaries from listeners who expressed disagreement with their views, participants tended to disregard evidence that the listeners had in fact been attentive.
- C. Although participants maintained their positions regardless of a summary’s level of detail, they tended to regard listeners who expressed disagreement as more attentive when these listeners provided more detailed summaries.
- D. Although participants were critical of expressions of disagreement, they gave higher ratings to listeners whose summaries included markers of attentiveness than to listeners whose summaries did not include these markers.

ID: f55b236f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes what the text implies about participants’ responses to disagreement. The text describes a study in which participants were asked to explain their position on an issue to a listener, who then provided a written summary of that position that also expressed their level of agreement. The participants were then asked, based on these summaries, to rate listeners’ listening skill. The text indicates that researchers embedded markers of attentive listening, such as references to details, in some of the summaries, expecting that these markers would improve the participants’ perceptions of listening skill even when the listeners disagreed. Instead, participants rated disagreeing listeners as less skilled, or attentive, “regardless of the other traits of the listeners’ summaries.” This means that even when summaries contained evidence of attentive listening, participants still judged disagreeing listeners as less skilled—in effect, disregarding evidence that those listeners had been attentive.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text does suggest that participants tended to disregard evidence of attentiveness when listeners disagreed with their position on the topic they discussed, it doesn’t address participants’ level of personal investment in these topics; therefore, the text can’t support any conclusions about how personal investment in a topic affected participants’ perceptions of the listening skill of disagreeing listeners. Choice C is incorrect because it directly contradicts the text. The text states that participants rated disagreeing listeners as less skilled regardless of the other traits of the listeners’ summaries, which means markers of attentiveness (specific details) didn’t lead participants to regard disagreeing listeners as more attentive.

Instead, disagreement alone determined the participants' lower ratings. Moreover, the text doesn't address whether participants maintained their positions based on the listeners' summaries. The text focuses on factors affecting participants' perceptions of listeners' attentiveness, not on how features of listeners' summaries influenced the participants' views of the sociopolitical issue they discussed. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates the opposite: participants didn't give higher ratings to disagreeing listeners whose summaries included markers of attentiveness than to disagreeing listeners whose summaries didn't include these markers. Rather, the text states that participants rated disagreeing listeners as less skilled than agreeing listeners regardless of the other traits of the summaries, meaning attentiveness markers had no positive effect when listeners' summaries expressed disagreement.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0aec9475

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 0aec9475

With the ongoing expansion of e-commerce, consumers are expecting faster and faster delivery of goods, but delivery companies continue to struggle with last-mile logistics (the final step in delivery to consumers) due to challenges such as complex and inefficient delivery routes. Innovations to mitigate these challenges have been emerging—the use of aerial drones, for example—but these innovations tend to engender their own complications (e.g., regulations on the use of drones in residential airspace), leading researchers to conclude that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. consumers’ expectations for reduced delivery times may be outstripping what is viable for delivery companies to provide.
- B. a better understanding of consumers’ expectations for delivery is needed so that companies can better plan for fluctuations in delivery volume.
- C. rapid delivery is a leading factor in consumer satisfaction, and therefore delivery companies would benefit from investing resources in reducing delivery times.
- D. there may not be sufficient incentive for delivery companies to attempt to solve the problems associated with last-mile logistics.

ID: 0aec9475 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of consumer expectations and the struggles delivery companies face. The text states that while consumers expect ever-faster delivery of goods, delivery companies "continue to struggle with last-mile logistics." The text further explains that innovations aimed at addressing this challenge have a tendency to cause complications of their own. Because escalating consumer demands for speed are paired with persistent, complex delivery obstacles and new problems arising from attempted solutions, it logically follows that consumer expectations for delivery times may be exceeding what companies can feasibly provide.

Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t address the idea of delivery volumes at all and makes it clear that companies are already aware of and trying to address consumers’ expectations for delivery. Further, the challenge presented at the end of the text relates to new problems that tend to arise with solutions for logistical problems, not to a lack of understanding of what consumers want or how delivery volumes fluctuate. Choice C is incorrect. The text does suggest that rapid delivery is important for customer satisfaction and thus is a beneficial investment for companies, but that idea is already presented in the beginning of the text and doesn’t logically follow as a conclusion from the information about innovations companies are exploring to solve last-mile logistics problems; the idea that the potential solutions tend to introduce new issues points to the feasibility of meeting consumer expectations, not to the general fact that it would be beneficial to reduce delivery times. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that there may be insufficient incentive for delivery companies to try to solve last-mile logistics problems

—on the contrary, the text directly indicates that delivery companies are already actively pursuing innovations to try to address those problems, citing the example of the use of aerial drones, even though the innovations can introduce new complications.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 827d2928

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 827d2928

While mammals collectively exhibit the highest ratio of brain size to body size among vertebrates, a team led by paleontologist Ornella Bertrand demonstrates that for ten million years following the extinction of dinosaurs, that ratio in fact shrank for mammals as they evolved to fill newly vacated ecological niches and their bodies increased in size more rapidly than their brains. Competition for resources tends to favor intelligence and thus large, complex brains, but during this period, the abundance of resources relative to mammalian population numbers likely moderated competition and facilitated an increase in body size. Bertrand and her team reason that as population numbers swelled, competition intensified, creating conditions that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. heightened the advantage that large body size conferred on mammals in certain ecological niches.
- B. restricted resources so drastically that mammals struggled to secure enough food to maintain large brain sizes.
- C. favored an evolutionary increase in brain size relative to body size among mammals.
- D. encouraged mammals with large brain sizes to adapt to a range of ecological niches.

ID: 827d2928 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the evolution of mammalian brain-to-body size ratios. As the text explains, mammals evolved to fill ecological niches left vacant by the dinosaurs’ extinction, and for the next ten million years, brain-to-body size ratios among mammals shrank as their bodies grew more rapidly than their brains. This decline was a natural outcome of resource abundance since increased competition for resources tends to favor intelligence and large brains, while decreased competition conversely favors large body size. Later, mammalian population sizes “swelled,” resulting in intensified competition—that is, a decrease in the abundance of resources relative to population sizes. Given the relationship established between resource availability and the ratio of brain size to body size, it can be inferred that around ten million years after the dinosaurs’ extinction, ecological conditions favored an evolutionary increase in brain size relative to body size among mammals—a reversal of the previous trend.

Choice A is incorrect because, as the text explains, competition for resources tends to favor intelligence and large brains, not large body size. Thus, when mammalian population sizes swelled and competition among mammals intensified, the result would have been a decrease, not an increase, in the advantage that large body size conferred on mammals in certain ecological niches. Choice B is incorrect because the text frames competition for resources as a selective pressure favoring intelligence and brain size relative to body size. Thus, even if competition among mammals resulted in resource deprivation, these conditions would have favored adaptation toward larger brain-to-body size and consequently greater intelligence to compete more effectively for decreased resources. Choice D is incorrect. The period when mammals adapted to a range of ecological niches that is under discussion in the text is the ten million years immediately following the dinosaurs’ extinction, when competition for resources was low. Moreover, the text explains that increased competition tends to favor brain size, while decreased competition tends to favor

body size. Thus, when competition increased, the logical outcome would have been an increase in brain size relative to body size among mammals, not a dispersal of large-brained mammals into new ecological niches, which the text states had already occurred under the very different conditions of low competition.

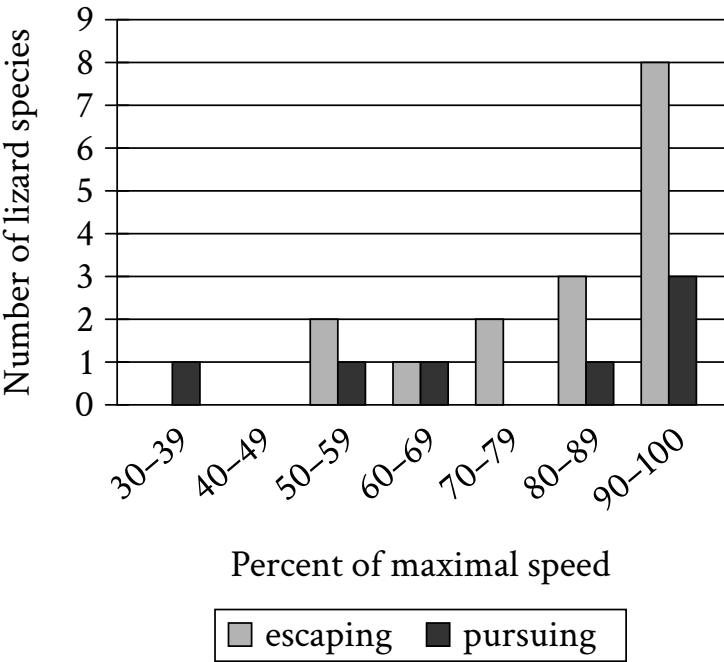
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a054c156

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a054c156

Number of Lizard Species by Average Percent of Maximal Speed Used When Pursuing Prey or Escaping Predators



It may seem that the optimal strategy for an animal pursuing prey or escaping predators is to move at maximal speed, but the energy expense of exploiting full speed capacity can disfavor such a strategy even in escape contexts, as evidenced by the fact that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the text?

- A. most lizard species use about the same percentage of their maximal speed when escaping predation as they do when pursuing prey.
- B. multiple lizard species move at an average of less than 90% of their maximal speed while escaping predation.
- C. more lizard species use, on average, 90%–100% of their maximal speed while escaping predation than use any other percentage of their maximal speed.
- D. at least 4 lizard species use, on average, less than 100% of their maximal speed while pursuing prey.

ID: a054c156 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it describes data from the graph that complete the text's discussion of lizard species' use of maximal speed when escaping predators. According to the text, moving at maximal speed (the highest speed possible) requires so much energy that it is not always an effective strategy for animals, even when they are escaping predators. The graph displays data on the average percent of maximal speed used by lizard species while either escaping predators or pursuing prey. The graph categorizes the data for both pursuing and escaping by the number of species using 30%–39% of maximal speed, 40%–49% of maximal speed, 50%–59% of maximal speed, 60%–69% of maximal speed, 70%–79% of maximal speed, 80%–89% of maximal speed, and 90%–100% of maximal speed, respectively. In the graph, there is at least one species in each of the following percent categories for maximal speed while escaping predators: 50%–59%, 60%–69%, 70%–79%, and 80%–89%. Thus, the data in the graph show that multiple lizard species move at an average of less than 90% of their maximal speed while escaping predation.

Choice A is incorrect because the data in the graph isn't organized in such a way that a comparison of the percentage of maximal speed used when escaping predation with the percentage used when pursuing prey is possible at the level of individual species. Choice C is incorrect. It is true that in the graph, the percent category with the largest number of species using maximal speed while escaping predators is 90%–100% (8 species total). However, these data don't complete the text, which is concerned instead with how animals are discouraged from using maximal speed even when escaping predators because of the amount of energy required to use it. Choice D is incorrect because these data from the graph pertain to maximal speed while pursuing prey and therefore don't complete the text's discussion of lizard species' use of maximal speed when escaping predators.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 04c2027b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 04c2027b

As a monthly newsletter formed in 1969 by a group of Asian American students at the University of California, Los Angeles, *Gidra* helped raise awareness about social and political issues concerning the Asian American community on campus and at large. The newsletter had an expansive reach for a publication of its kind: around 4,000 copies were published each month. A student writing a history paper, however, hypothesizes that *Gidra*’s influence cannot be measured by the number of newsletters published monthly alone.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the student’s hypothesis?

- A. The students who initially formed *Gidra* each contributed financially to its creation.
- B. In addition to covering current events, *Gidra* also featured works of art and literature.
- C. *Gidra* was initially based out of the Asian American Studies Center at UCLA.
- D. People would often give their copies of *Gidra* to others once they had finished reading an issue.

ID: 04c2027b Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. If there were more *Gidra* readers than there were copies of the newsletter, then the newsletter’s influence would be much greater than its 4,000 monthly copies.

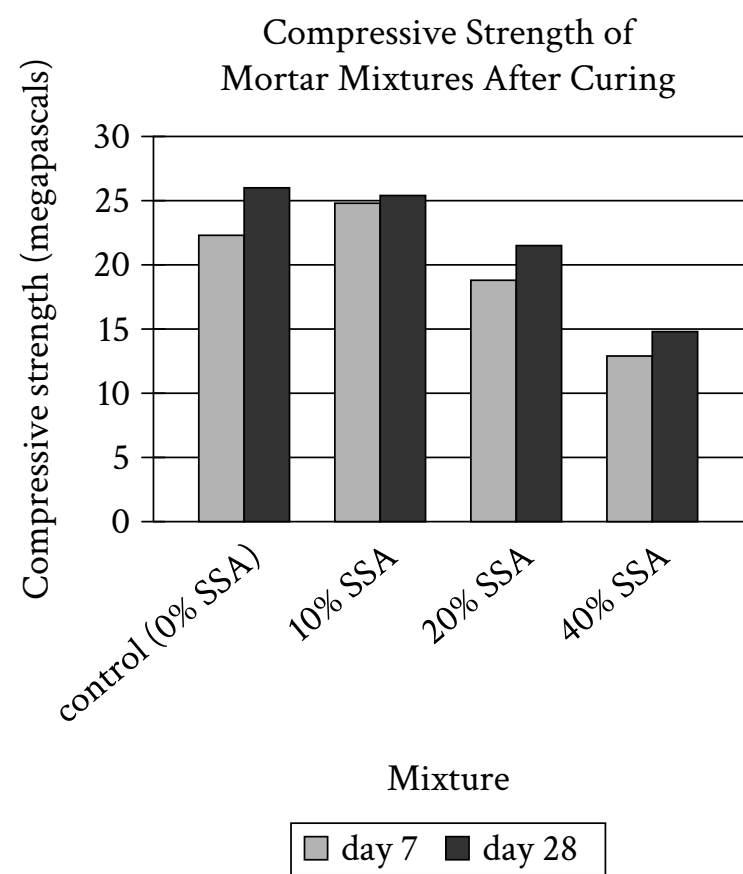
Choice A is incorrect. Information about the newsletter’s initial funding doesn’t tell us about the influence that the newsletter eventually had. Choice B is incorrect. While the content of *Gidra* was undoubtedly related to the newsletter’s influence, this information isn’t relevant to the specific hypothesis about monthly circulation numbers. Choice C is incorrect. Where the publishers of *Gidra* were initially based doesn’t tell us about the newsletter’s overall influence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e8dff6a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: e8dff6a



Mollusk shells are mainly composed of calcium carbonate, a chemical compound used in mortar and other construction materials. A research team led by Ariane da Silva Cardoso investigated pulverizing discarded Sururu mussel shells to create a substitute for fine aggregates (such as sand) in mortar mixtures. The team prepared mixtures with Sururu shell aggregate (SSA) replacing varying percentages of sand and then tested the mortars’ compressive strength on days 7 and 28 of curing. Based on their findings, the team recommended SSA substitution in relatively small proportions to avoid compromising strength.

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to support the researchers’ recommendation?

- A. The 10% SSA mixture’s compressive strength was greater than or approximately equal to that of the control mixture on day 7 and on day 28, but on both days the 20% and 40% SSA mixtures had less compressive strength than the control mixture did.
- B. The compressive strength of the 10% SSA mixture remained nearly the same from day 7 to day 28, while that of the 20% and 40% SSA mixtures changed substantially.
- C. The 10% SSA mixture’s compressive strength was greater than that of the control mixture on day 7, but by day 28 the 10% SSA mixture’s compressive strength had decreased while that of the control mixture had increased.
- D. The compressive strength of the 10% SSA mixture never surpassed the compressive strength measured for the control mixture on day 28.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the graph to support the researchers' recommendation that Sururu shell aggregate (SSA) substitution be done in relatively small proportions to avoid compromising the compressive strength of mortar mixtures. The text explains that a research team investigated whether SSA can serve as a substitute for sand in mortar mixtures. The graph presents the compressive strength (in megapascals) of mortar mixtures with SSA replacing 0% (control), 10%, 20%, and 40% of the sand on day 7 and day 28 of curing. The graph shows that the compressive strength of the 10% SSA mixture was approximately 25 megapascals on day 7, which is greater than the control mixture's approximately 22 megapascals on the same day. The graph also shows that the 10% SSA mixture's compressive strength was slightly more than 25 megapascals on day 28, which is only slightly less than the control's compressive strength on the same day (about 26 megapascals). Therefore, the graph shows that the compressive strength of the 10% SSA mixture was greater than that of the control on day 7 and roughly equal to that of the control on day 28, suggesting that substituting only 10% of the sand with SSA avoids compromising the mortar's compressive strength. The graph also shows that on day 7, the 20% and 40% SSA mixtures had compressive strengths of about 19 and 13 megapascals, respectively (both lower than the control's), and on day 28, they had compressive strengths of about 22 and 15 megapascals, respectively (once again lower than the control's). Thus, the data support the recommendation by indicating that substituting relatively small proportions of sand with SSA in mortar mixtures doesn't compromise strength compared with the control, whereas substituting larger proportions does.

Choice B is incorrect because the comparison it makes isn't relevant to the researchers' recommendation. Although the graph does show that the bars representing the compressive strength of the 10% SSA mixture on day 7 and day 28 are roughly the same height (suggesting that the mixture's compressive strength changed by only a small amount), and although there are relatively large gaps between the bars showing the compressive strength of the 20% and 40% SSA mixtures on day 7 and day 28 (suggesting that their compressive strength changed over time by a greater amount), this comparison concerns only how each SSA mixture's strength changed over time and doesn't compare the SSA mixtures with the control mixture. Supporting the recommendation that SSA substitution be done in small proportions requires evidence that small substitutions don't compromise strength relative to the control while larger substitutions do. Choice C is incorrect because it doesn't accurately represent the data in the graph, nor is the comparison it makes relevant to the researchers' recommendation. While the graph does show that the compressive strength of the 10% SSA mixture was greater than that of the control on day 7 (about 25 megapascals vs. about 22 megapascals) and, moreover, that the compressive strength of the control increased from day 7 to day 28 (from about 22 megapascals to about 26 megapascals), the graph shows that the compressive strength of the 10% SSA mixture increased by a small amount (from about 25 megapascals to slightly more than 25 megapascals), not that it decreased. Moreover, the researchers recommended substituting relatively small proportions (compared with larger proportions) of the mixtures with SSA; comparing the compressive strength of the 10% SSA mixture with that of the control without also considering how the compressive strength of the 10% SSA mixture compared with that of the 20% and 40% SSA mixtures wouldn't support the recommendation. Choice D is incorrect. Though the graph indicates that the 10% SSA mixture's compressive strength on day 7 and day 28 (about 25 megapascals and slightly more than 25 megapascals, respectively) didn't surpass the control mixture's compressive strength on day 28 (about 26 megapascals), this observation doesn't support the recommendation. The recommendation concerns the trade-off between SSA proportion and compressive strength; supporting it requires not just evidence about how the 10% SSA mixture compared with the control but also evidence about how the mixtures with larger proportions of SSA (20% and 40%) compared with the 10% SSA mixture and the control.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dfd39341

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: dfd39341

Among social animals that care for their young, such as chickens, macaque monkeys, and humans, newborns appear to show an innate attraction to faces and face-like stimuli. Elisabetta Versace and her colleagues used an image of three black dots arranged in the shape of eyes and a nose or mouth to test whether this trait also occurs in *Testudo* tortoises, which live alone and do not engage in parental care. They found that tortoise hatchlings showed a significant preference for the image, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. face-like stimuli are likely perceived as harmless by newborns of social species that practice parental care but as threatening by newborns of solitary species without parental care.
- B. researchers should not assume that an innate attraction to face-like stimuli is necessarily an adaptation related to social interaction or parental care.
- C. researchers can assume that the attraction to face-like stimuli that is seen in social species that practice parental care is learned rather than innate.
- D. newly hatched *Testudo* tortoises show a stronger preference for face-like stimuli than adult *Testudo* tortoises do.

ID: dfd39341 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of the study by Versace and colleagues. The text indicates that newborn animals of some species are attracted to faces and to stimuli that resemble faces. These species, the text says, share two characteristics: they’re social and they practice parental care, meaning that parents care for their young. The text goes on to describe Versace and colleagues’ experiment, which showed that *Testudo* tortoises, which aren’t social and don’t practice parental care, were attracted to a stimulus that resembles a face. Since Versace and colleagues have shown that a species that isn’t social and doesn’t practice parental care nevertheless has the innate characteristic of being attracted to face-like stimuli, it follows that this characteristic shouldn’t be assumed to be an adaptation related to social interaction or parental care.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that the tortoise hatchlings, which are solitary and don’t practice parental care, were attracted to the face-like stimuli, not that they perceived the stimuli as threatening. Choice C is incorrect because the phenomenon discussed in the text is an attraction to faces and face-like stimuli on the part of newborn animals, which can’t show any learned characteristics since they were just born. Additionally, the text tells us that the tortoises Versace and colleagues studied aren’t social and don’t practice parental care, so any findings about those tortoises wouldn’t be relevant to the question of whether an attraction to faces in social species that practice parental care is innate or learned. Choice D is incorrect because the text gives no indication that adult tortoises were tested on face-like stimuli and, if adults were in fact tested, no information about how they responded is provided. Since no information about adult tortoises’ responses is provided, no conclusion comparing those responses to the responses of newly hatched tortoises can be supported.

Question ID 1c6c2d41

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 1c6c2d41

In a series of experiments, Julio Sevilla and Claudia Townsend showed that manipulating the space between products in store displays can influence consumers’ views of those products. Participants in several of the experiments regarded the same products in the same (generic) retail settings as significantly more valuable when the product-to-space ratio was low than when it was high. But in one of the experiments, Sevilla and Townsend arranged the same jewelry with different levels of intervening space at an upscale retailer (Tiffany & Co.) and a relatively inexpensive retailer (Forever 21). The result of this experiment suggests that a store context associated with inexpensive products may moderate the effect Sevilla and Townsend observed in their other experiments.

- Which finding from the experiment with Tiffany & Co. and Forever 21, if true, would most directly support the conclusion presented in the text?
- A. At Tiffany & Co., participants judged jewelry spaced far apart to be substantially more valuable than jewelry spaced close together, but at Forever 21, participants judged jewelry spaced far apart to be only slightly more valuable than jewelry spaced close together.
 - B. At both Tiffany & Co. and Forever 21, participants judged jewelry spaced far apart to be less valuable than jewelry spaced close together, but the difference in perceived value was significantly greater at Tiffany & Co. than at Forever 21.
 - C. Participants judged jewelry spaced far apart at Tiffany & Co. to be similar in value to jewelry spaced far apart at Forever 21, but participants judged jewelry spaced close together at Tiffany & Co. to be more valuable than jewelry spaced close together at Forever 21.
 - D. When jewelry was spaced far apart, participants judged the jewelry at Tiffany & Co. to be more valuable than the jewelry at Forever 21, but when jewelry was spaced close together, participants judged the jewelry at Tiffany & Co. to be less valuable than the jewelry at Forever 21.

ID: 1c6c2d41 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support the text’s conclusion about the results of the experiment with Tiffany & Co. and Forever 21. According to the text, Sevilla and Townsend found in several experiments that when products in a generic retail setting are displayed with a low product-to-space ratio (that is, with lots of space between them), consumers view those products as significantly more valuable than when the same products are displayed with a higher product-to-space ratio (less space between them). The text then states that the results of an experiment specifically using the contexts of an inexpensive store (Forever 21) and an upscale one (Tiffany & Co.) suggest that an inexpensive store context may moderate, or lessen, that effect. If Sevilla and Townsend found that participants in the experiment with Tiffany & Co. and Forever 21 judged the same jewelry items as substantially more valuable when there was lots of space between them than when there was little space between them in the upscale store (Tiffany & Co.) but judged the same jewelry items as only slightly more valuable when there was lots of space between them than when there was little space between them in the inexpensive store (Forever 21), that finding

would demonstrate that increased space between products was associated with less of an increase in those products' perceived value at the inexpensive store than at the upscale store. Thus, the finding would support the text's conclusion that a store context associated with inexpensive goods moderates the effect Sevilla and Townsend observed in their earlier experiments.

Choice B is incorrect because if Sevilla and Townsend found that at both upscale and inexpensive stores, participants judged jewelry spaced far apart to be less valuable than jewelry spaced close together, that would show the opposite of the effect the researchers observed in their earlier experiments, not show that an inexpensive store context merely moderates, or lessens, that effect. Choice C is incorrect because this finding wouldn't show that the effect Sevilla and Townsend observed in their initial experiments (that products spaced far apart were perceived as more valuable than the same products spaced close together) is present but lessened in inexpensive retail contexts, as the text suggests. The conclusion in the text rests on determining the difference in jewelry items' perceived value between two spacing conditions within each store and then comparing the difference for the inexpensive store (Forever 21) to the difference for the upscale store (Tiffany & Co.); a finding that compares perceptions of the jewelry items' value between the two stores but for only one type of spacing condition at a time wouldn't provide information about the degree of difference between spacing conditions within each type of store context. Choice D is incorrect because this finding wouldn't show that the effect Sevilla and Townsend observed in their initial experiments (that products spaced far apart were perceived as more valuable than the same products spaced close together) is present but lessened in inexpensive retail contexts, as the text suggests. The conclusion in the text rests on determining the difference in jewelry items' perceived value between two spacing conditions within each store and then comparing the difference for the inexpensive store (Forever 21) to the difference for the upscale store (Tiffany & Co.); a finding that compares perceptions of the relative value of jewelry items between the two stores and for only one type of spacing condition at a time wouldn't provide information about the degree of difference between spacing conditions within each type of store context.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a70e7f08

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a70e7f08

Biologist Valentina Gómez-Bahamón and her team have investigated two subspecies of the fork-tailed flycatcher bird that live in the same region in Colombia, but one subspecies migrates south for part of the year, and the other doesn't. The researchers found that, due to slight differences in feather shape, the feathers of migratory forked-tailed flycatcher males make a sound during flight that is higher pitched than that made by the feathers of nonmigratory males. The researchers hypothesize that fork-tailed flycatcher females are attracted to the specific sound made by the males of their own subspecies, and that over time the females' preference will drive further genetic and anatomical divergence between the subspecies.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Gómez-Bahamón and her team's hypothesis?

- A. The feathers located on the wings of the migratory fork-tailed flycatchers have a narrower shape than those of the nonmigratory birds, which allows them to fly long distances.
- B. Over several generations, the sound made by the feathers of migratory male fork-tailed flycatchers grows progressively higher pitched relative to that made by the feathers of nonmigratory males.
- C. Fork-tailed flycatchers communicate different messages to each other depending on whether their feathers create high-pitched or low-pitched sounds.
- D. The breeding habits of the migratory and nonmigratory fork-tailed flycatchers remained generally the same over several generations.

ID: a70e7f08 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support Gómez-Bahamón and her team's hypothesis about fork-tailed flycatchers. The text indicates that although two subspecies of the birds live in the same region, the tail feathers of the migrating males make a higher-pitched sound than the tail feathers of the nonmigrating males do. Gómez-Bahamón and her team hypothesize that female fork-tailed flycatchers are attracted to the particular sound made by the tail feathers of males of their own subspecies, which will bring about additional "genetic and anatomical divergence" between the two subspecies. If it were found that the pitch generated by the tail feathers of migrating males is getting higher over successive generations, it would indicate that the shape of the migrating subspecies' tail feathers is diverging further from that of the nonmigrating subspecies. And if females continue to prefer the sounds of the males of their own subspecies, the females of the migrating subspecies will become acclimated to increasingly higher pitches over subsequent generations, causing further divergence between the subspecies. Thus, if it were found that migrating males' tail feathers were producing higher pitches over time, that would support the researchers' hypothesis.

Choice A is incorrect because the researchers' hypothesis is that female flycatchers prefer the sounds produced by the tail feathers of males of their own subspecies, which will lead to further divergence between the two subspecies. This finding is about the shape of wing feathers and how that affects long-distance flight, whereas the hypothesis is about the shape of tail feathers

and how that relates to female mate preference. Choice C is incorrect because the researchers' hypothesis is that female flycatchers prefer the sounds produced by the tail feathers of males of their own subspecies, which will lead to further divergence between the two subspecies. This finding focuses on how the tail feather sounds communicate different messages, which doesn't address differences between the subspecies or female preferences. Choice D is incorrect because the researchers' hypothesis is that female flycatchers prefer the sounds produced by the tail feathers of males of their own subspecies, which will lead to further divergence between the two subspecies. The finding that breeding habits haven't changed for either subspecies does not, by itself, suggest anything about female preferences or divergence between the two subspecies.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID de4dd845

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: de4dd845

In countries with right-hand traffic, drivers who want to make a left turn at a traffic intersection with stoplights have to wait for either a gap in oncoming traffic or a designated left-turn signal to turn green. At busy intersections, this often causes a backup of vehicles waiting to turn left or being prevented from proceeding by left-turning vehicles in front of them. Transportation researcher Vikash V. Gayah claims that in urban areas eliminating the option to turn left at busy intersections—both with and without dedicated left-turn signals—would improve traffic flow and, as a result, reduce overall travel times even if such a restriction would require drivers to sometimes travel a slightly longer distance.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researcher’s claim?

- A. In a town that installed left-turn signals at all busy intersections, seven out of ten survey respondents agreed with the statement “the streets in my community are easier to navigate by motor vehicle than before.”
- B. A traffic study of intersections in a large city shows that on average drivers wait longer to make a left turn at intersections without left-turn signals than at intersections with such signals.
- C. After a city eliminated left turns at busy intersections, a package-delivery company reports that its drivers have been able to reach more addresses in the city daily, on average, and therefore deliver more packages there annually.
- D. Statistics reveal that school buses in a city that eliminated left turns at most intersections took on average two minutes longer to complete their routes after the restriction took effect than they did before.

ID: de4dd845 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support Vikash V. Gayah’s claim that eliminating the option to turn left at busy intersections would improve traffic flow and reduce overall travel times. The text begins by describing a problem encountered by drivers in countries with right-hand traffic—namely that drivers wanting to make a left turn must wait for either gaps in oncoming traffic or for designated left-turn signals before proceeding. The resulting backup of vehicles causes increased traffic congestion at busy intersections that slows overall travel times. According to Gayah, eliminating left turns from busy intersections in urban areas would ease the congestion caused by vehicles waiting to turn left. If vehicles spend less time waiting at intersections for left turns, faster overall travel times would result even if some drivers would have to drive slightly longer distances to make the desired left turn. Drivers for package-delivery companies, who presumably spend most of the day driving to destinations across the city in which they are based, would likely provide a good indication of overall traffic patterns across the city. A finding that after a city had eliminated left turns at busy intersections, package-delivery companies were able to complete more daily deliveries on average—which implies faster travel times between package destinations—would therefore support the claim that overall travel times would decrease if left turns were eliminated at busy intersections.

Choice A is incorrect because a finding that a majority of survey respondents agreed with the statement that implementing left-turn signals at all busy intersections made navigating streets in their communities easier wouldn’t support the claim that

eliminating the option to turn left altogether at some busy intersections—both with and without dedicated left-turn signals—would improve the flow of traffic and overall traffic times. In fact, the text emphasizes that designated left-turn signals contribute to increased congestion because they require drivers to wait to turn left, which results in a backup of vehicles. Installing such signals at all busy intersections would thus potentially compound the problem of congestion, not improve it. Moreover, although making streets easier for drivers to navigate might indicate that left-turn signals are beneficial to drivers, it doesn't indicate that overall travel times would necessarily be reduced. Choice B is incorrect because a study concluding that drivers wait longer to make left turns at intersections without dedicated left-turn signals than at intersections with such signals wouldn't support the claim that eliminating the option to turn left altogether would reduce overall travel times. In fact, the finding would merely support the idea that installing left-turn signals would likely reduce the time drivers spend waiting at busy intersections that didn't previously have left-turn signals, not that overall travel times would be reduced. Choice D is incorrect because the finding that after a restriction eliminating left turns at most intersections took effect, school buses took longer to complete their routes than they did before the restriction was implemented would contradict rather than support the researcher's claim that eliminating left turns would reduce overall travel times.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4e03a86c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 4e03a86c

Duckweed is a small freshwater plant that is often exposed to zinc pollution. Sofia Vámos and colleagues collected samples of four duckweed ecotypes (genetically and geographically distinct populations within a species), along with water from each ecotype’s habitat. Hypothesizing that each ecotype is adapted to its local conditions in ways that bolster its growth and resistance to pollutants, the researchers grew each ecotype in all four water samples and with three levels of zinc (none, low, high). (The researchers did not replicate local differences in light or temperature.) They found that the ecotypes grew equally well in all four water samples and that adding zinc consistently enhanced growth, regardless of concentration, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. while the ecotypes are genetically and geographically distinct, those differences do not represent adaptations to local environmental conditions.
- B. there may not be significant differences in the water that each ecotype inhabits, but there are significant differences in each ecotype’s resistance to zinc pollution.
- C. if each ecotype is indeed locally adapted as the researchers hypothesized, those adaptations are to other environmental conditions than the water each ecotype inhabits.
- D. although the researchers’ hypothesis does not appear to be supported, this may be because the levels of zinc exposure the plants in the experiment received did not match their exposure in their natural environments.

ID: 4e03a86c Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Vámos and colleagues’ experiment with four duckweed ecotypes. According to the text, the researchers hypothesized that each ecotype is adapted to its local habitat in ways that help it grow more effectively and better tolerate pollutants. To test this, they grew each ecotype in water collected from all four habitats and exposed them to three different zinc levels. If the hypothesis were correct, each ecotype would be expected to thrive more in water from its own habitat than in the other waters and to respond to zinc levels differently depending on the level of zinc pollution in its home environment. However, the results showed that every ecotype grew just as well in every water sample, and that zinc boosted growth the same way across all ecotypes no matter the concentration. In other words, the experiment found no evidence that these ecotypes have specifically adapted to their local water or their local zinc exposure. It follows, then, that if each ecotype is actually locally adapted, it is adapted not to the water conditions in its habitat but to other environmental factors—such as local light or temperature levels, which the text notes the researchers didn’t account for in their experiment.

Choice A is incorrect because the findings presented in the text suggest only that the ecotypes’ genetic and geographic differences don’t represent adaptations to local water conditions and zinc levels, not that the differences don’t represent adaptations to *any* local environmental conditions. Indeed, the text notes that the researchers didn’t account for light or

temperature levels in each habitat, suggesting the possibility that the ecotypes are adapted to those or other local environmental factors. Choice B is incorrect because it contradicts the findings presented in the text. The text states that zinc consistently enhanced growth regardless of concentration, meaning the ecotypes all responded similarly to zinc. This uniform response indicates there *aren't* significant differences in their resistance to zinc pollution. Choice D is incorrect because the findings presented in the text don't demonstrate that the researchers' hypothesis of local adaptation isn't supported. That the ecotypes grew equally well in all of the water samples and equally benefited from added zinc at all levels, regardless of zinc levels in their natural environments, suggests only that the ecotypes aren't adapted to their local water conditions and zinc levels; these findings don't rule out the possibility that the ecotypes are adapted to other local factors in their habitats, such as light or temperature (which the text notes the researchers didn't examine).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e2c734d9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: e2c734d9

Percentages of New Year’s Resolution Makers Who Make Certain
Kinds of Resolutions

Type of resolution	Age 18-29	Age 30-49	Age 50-64	Age 65+
Health and exercise	79	80	79	76
Finances	68	63	56	47
Personal relationships	63	53	58	52
Hobbies	65	53	51	45

A Pew Research Center survey conducted in January 2024 found that three out of ten US adults make at least one New Year’s resolution (a promise for the year ahead), while half of those who make a resolution make more than one. The survey asked participants what kinds of resolutions they made and separated them into several categories. The table presents percentages of people who make particular kinds of New Year’s resolutions among those who choose to make them, indexed by age bracket.

Which choice best presents a conclusion about the habits of New Year’s resolution makers that is best supported by information in the text and the table?

- A. Resolution makers between the ages of 50 and 64 are more likely to make resolutions related to personal relationships and less likely to make resolutions related to finances than resolution makers between the ages of 30 and 49 are.
- B. Resolution makers between the ages of 18 and 29 are more likely to make resolutions about health and exercise than resolution makers between the ages of 30 and 49 are.
- C. The majority of US adults who make resolutions related to health and exercise also make resolutions in multiple additional categories.
- D. Among all US adults, people become less likely to make New Year’s resolutions as they age, regardless of the type of resolution.

ID: e2c734d9 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a conclusion about the habits of New Year’s resolution makers that is best supported by information in the text and the table. The table presents percentages of resolution makers who make particular kinds of resolutions, indexed by age bracket. According to the table, 58 percent of resolution makers ages 50 to 64 made resolutions related to personal relationships, compared to 53 percent of resolution makers ages 30 to 49—indicating that the older group is more likely to make such resolutions. The table also shows that 56 percent of resolution makers ages 50 to 64 made resolutions related to finances, compared to 63 percent of resolution makers ages 30 to 49—indicating that the older group

is less likely to make financial resolutions. Thus, the data support the conclusion that resolution makers between the ages of 50 and 64 are more likely to make resolutions related to personal relationships and less likely to make resolutions related to finances than resolution makers between the ages of 30 and 49 are.

Choice B is incorrect because according to the table, 79 percent of resolution makers ages 18 to 29 made resolutions about health and exercise, while 80 percent of resolution makers ages 30 to 49 made such resolutions. Therefore, resolution makers ages 18 to 29 are slightly less likely, not more likely, to make resolutions about health and exercise than resolution makers ages 30 to 49 are. Choice C is incorrect because neither the text nor the table provides information about whether resolution makers who make resolutions related to health and exercise also make resolutions in multiple additional categories. The text indicates that half of those who make a resolution make more than one, but it doesn't specify how many or in which categories, and the table presents only the percentages of resolution makers in each age bracket who made particular kinds of resolutions. Choice D is incorrect because the table presents data only about people who chose to make resolutions, not about all US adults; the table therefore can't support a conclusion about whether US adults overall become less likely to make resolutions as they age. Furthermore, although percentages of resolution makers generally decline as age bracket increases in some resolution categories, the table shows that the percentage of resolution makers who made health and exercise resolutions remains relatively stable across age brackets; thus, even among resolution makers, there isn't a consistent age-related decline across all types of resolutions.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 212910a1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 212910a1

Mosasaurus were large marine reptiles that lived in the Late Cretaceous period, approximately 100 million to 66 million years ago. Celina Suarez, Alberto Pérez-Huerta, and T. Lynn Harrell Jr. examined oxygen-18 isotopes in mosasaur tooth enamel in order to calculate likely mosasaur body temperatures and determined that mosasaurs were endothermic—that is, they used internal metabolic processes to maintain a stable body temperature in a variety of ambient temperatures. Suarez, Pérez-Huerta, and Harrell claim that endothermy would have enabled mosasaurs to include relatively cold polar waters in their range.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Suarez, Pérez-Huerta, and Harrell’s claim?

- A. Mosasaurs’ likely body temperatures are easier to determine from tooth enamel oxygen-18 isotope data than the body temperatures of nonendothermic Late Cretaceous marine reptiles are.
- B. Fossils of both mosasaurs and nonendothermic marine reptiles have been found in roughly equal numbers in regions known to be near the poles during the Late Cretaceous, though in lower concentrations than elsewhere.
- C. Several mosasaur fossils have been found in regions known to be near the poles during the Late Cretaceous, while relatively few fossils of nonendothermic marine reptiles have been found in those locations.
- D. During the Late Cretaceous, seawater temperatures were likely higher throughout mosasaurs’ range, including near the poles, than seawater temperatures at those same latitudes are today.

ID: 212910a1 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents the finding that, if true, would best support Suarez, Pérez-Huerta, and Harrell’s claim about mosasaurs. The text states that Suarez, Pérez-Huerta, and Harrell’s research on mosasaur tooth enamel led them to conclude that mosasaurs were endothermic, which means that they could live in waters at many different temperatures and still maintain a stable body temperature. The researchers claim that endothermy enabled mosasaurs to live in relatively cold waters near the poles. If several mosasaur fossils have been found in areas that were near the poles during the period when mosasaurs were alive and fossils of nonendothermic marine reptiles are rare in such locations, that would support the researchers’ claim: it would show that mosasaurs inhabited polar waters but nonendothermic marine mammals tended not to, suggesting that endothermy may have been the characteristic that enabled mosasaurs to include polar waters in their range.

Choice A is incorrect because finding that it’s easier to determine mosasaur body temperatures from tooth enamel data than it is to determine nonendothermic reptile body temperatures wouldn’t support the researchers’ claim. Whether one research process is more difficult than another indicates nothing about the results of those processes and therefore is irrelevant to the issue of where mosasaurs lived and what enabled them to live in those locations. Choice B is incorrect because finding roughly equal numbers of mosasaur and nonendothermic marine reptile fossils in areas that were near the poles in the Late Cretaceous would suggest that endothermy didn’t give mosasaurs any particular advantage when it came to expanding their range to include relatively cold polar waters, thereby weakening the researchers’ claim rather than supporting it. Choice D is incorrect because

finding that the temperature of seawater in the Late Cretaceous was warmer than seawater today wouldn't weaken the researchers' claim. Seawater in the Late Cretaceous could have been warmer than seawater today but still cold enough for endothermy to be advantageous to mosasaurs, so this finding wouldn't provide enough information to either support or weaken the researchers' claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 10184b7a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 10184b7a

As juveniles, all white-necked jacobin hummingbirds display vibrantly blue head plumage; when they enter adulthood, males retain these blue feathers and most females molt to a drab green hue. However, 28% of adult female jacobins remain identical in coloration to juveniles and adult males. Based on field observations in Panama, a team of researchers reports that while adult males show a clear preference in mate selection for adult females with drab green feathers, they also engage in more antagonistic behavior toward those adult females than toward blue-feathered adult females when competing for resources. Therefore, the team hypothesizes that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. adult male jacobins do not act antagonistically toward juvenile jacobins with blue head plumage when competing for resources.
- B. the percentage of blue-feathered females will increase until fewer than half of adult female jacobins are green-feathered.
- C. the occurrence of blue head plumage in adult female jacobins is driven by one or more factors not associated with mate attraction.
- D. coloration prevents green-feathered adult female jacobins from distinguishing between adult males and blue-feathered adult females.

ID: 10184b7a Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of researchers’ observations of white-necked jacobin hummingbird females that retain blue head plumage into adulthood. The text indicates that even though adult males show a clear preference in mate selection for adult females with drab green feathers, a significant percentage of adult females (28%) retain blue head plumage. Critically, the text also notes that the mating advantage conferred on adult females by green head plumage is offset by the fact that when competing for resources, adult males behave more antagonistically toward green-feathered adult females than toward blue-feathered ones. Given this discrepancy in the males’ behavior, it is reasonable to hypothesize that the occurrence of blue head plumage in adult females is driven by factors not associated with mate attraction—specifically, reduced antagonism during resource competition.

Choice A is incorrect because the antagonistic behavior discussed in the text is that displayed by adult male jacobins toward blue-feathered and green-feathered adult females, not toward juveniles. The text doesn’t discuss the behavior of adult males toward juveniles. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text cites the current percentage (28%) of female white-necked jacobin hummingbirds that retain blue plumage into adulthood, it doesn’t make predictions about future changes in the proportion of blue to green plumage in this species or provide information supporting such a prediction. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss the perceptual abilities of green-feathered adult females or whether they can distinguish between adult males and

blue-feathered adult females. Instead, the text focuses on adult male behavior—namely, mate selection and antagonism toward adult females.

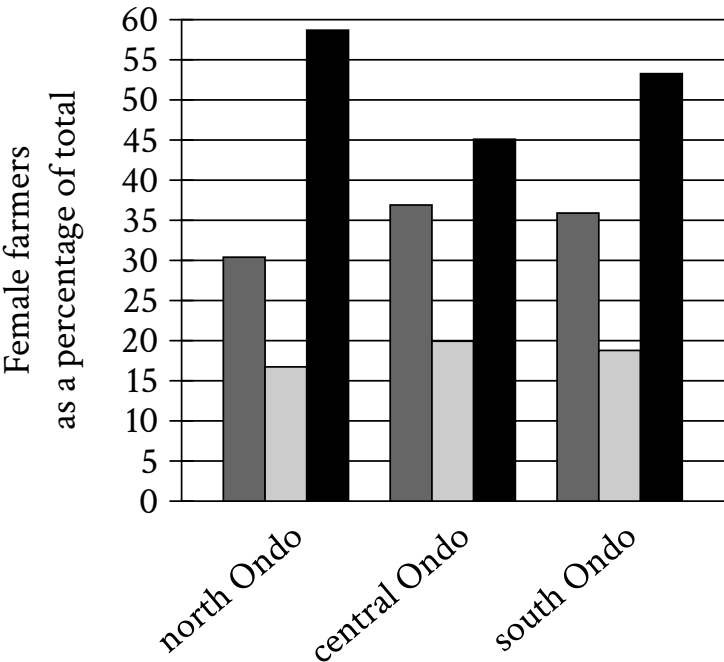
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8f8b176c

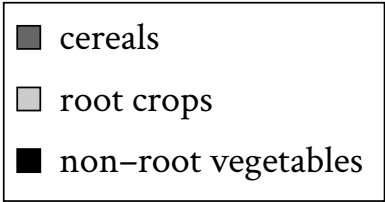
Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 8f8b176c

Percentage of Ondo State
Small-Scale Farmers Who Are
Female, by Main Crop Grown



Ondo State region



Geographer Adebayo Oluwole Eludoyin and his colleagues surveyed small-scale farmers in three locations in Ondo State, Nigeria—which has mountainous terrain in the north, an urbanized center, and coastal terrain in the south—to learn more about their practices, like the types of crops they mainly cultivated. In some regions, female farmers were found to be especially prominent in the cultivation of specific types of crops and even constituted the majority of farmers who cultivated those crops; for instance,

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the example?

- A. most of the farmers who mainly cultivated cereals and most of the farmers who mainly cultivated non-root vegetables in south Ondo were women.
- B. more women in central Ondo mainly cultivated root crops than mainly cultivated cereals.

- C. most of the farmers who mainly cultivated non–root vegetables in north and south Ondo were women.
- D. a relatively equal proportion of women across the three regions of Ondo mainly cultivated cereals.

ID: 8f8b176c Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it uses data from the graph to effectively complete the example of Eludoyin and his colleagues’ findings concerning female farmers in some regions of Ondo State, Nigeria. The graph presents values for the percentage of Ondo State small-scale farmers who are female, by type of crop and region. The graph shows that of the farmers mainly cultivating non-root vegetables, approximately 57% in north Ondo and approximately 54% in south Ondo are female; in other words, most of those farmers are female, which exemplifies the idea that female farmers make up the majority (more than half) of the farmers cultivating specific types of crops in some regions.

Choice A is incorrect because it inaccurately cites data from the graph: the graph shows that in south Ondo, most of the farmers mainly cultivating non-root vegetables are women (approximately 54%), but that only about 35% (less than half) of the farmers mainly cultivating cereals are women. Choice B is incorrect because it inaccurately cites data from the graph: the graph shows that more women in central Ondo mainly cultivate cereals than mainly cultivate root crops (approximately 36% and 20%, respectively). Additionally, it doesn’t effectively complete the example because the graph shows that female farmers don’t make up the majority (more than half) of the farmers for any type of crop in central Ondo. Choice D is incorrect because it doesn’t effectively complete the example; it simply states that a relatively equal proportion of women across the three regions mainly cultivate cereals, which doesn’t address the value for that proportion and thus doesn’t show that a majority (more than half) of the farmers cultivating certain crops are female.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9f8900d5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 9f8900d5

Given that stars and planets initially form from the same gas and dust in space, some astronomers have posited that host stars (such as the Sun) and their planets (such as those in our solar system) are composed of the same materials, with the planets containing equal or smaller quantities of the materials that make up the host star. This idea is also supported by evidence that rocky planets in our solar system are composed of some of the same materials as the Sun.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the astronomers’ claim?

- A. Most stars are made of hydrogen and helium, but when cooled they are revealed to contain small amounts of iron and silicate.
- B. A nearby host star is observed to contain the same proportion of hydrogen and helium as that of the Sun.
- C. Evidence emerges that the amount of iron in some rocky planets is considerably higher than the amount in their host star.
- D. The method for determining the composition of rocky planets is discovered to be less effective when used to analyze other kinds of planets.

ID: 9f8900d5 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would weaken the astronomers’ claim about the makeup of host stars and their planets. The text explains that because stars and planets begin forming from the same gas and dust, astronomers believe planets should be composed of the same materials as their host stars, but in equal or smaller quantities. The finding that the amount of iron in some rocky planets is much higher than the amount in their host star would weaken the astronomers’ claim because it would show that some planets contain the same material as their host star, but in higher quantities.

Choice A is incorrect because a finding only about the makeup of stars, whether they’ve cooled or not, would provide no information about the makeup of planets. Thus, it wouldn’t have any bearing on the claim that planets and their host stars are composed of the same materials in differing quantities. Choice B is incorrect because a finding about two host stars having similar proportions of certain materials wouldn’t provide any information about the makeup of planets. Thus, it wouldn’t be relevant to the claim that planets and their host stars are composed of the same materials in differing quantities. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that the astronomers’ claim is based on a fact—that stars and planets begin forming from the same gas and dust in space—which would remain true regardless of the effectiveness of a method for analysis of compositions. The text does cite analysis of rocky planets in our solar system and the Sun, but only as a single piece of evidence that is consistent with the claim and not as the source of the claim; the finding that the method used for that analysis is less effective in other scenarios wouldn’t weaken a claim that’s based on knowledge of how stars and planets initially form.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2f3c795c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 2f3c795c

Early Earth is thought to have been characterized by a stagnant lid tectonic regime, in which the upper lithosphere (the outer rocky layer) was essentially immobile and there was no interaction between the lithosphere and the underlying mantle. Researchers investigated the timing of the transition from a stagnant lid regime to a tectonic plate regime, in which the lithosphere is fractured into dynamic plates that in turn allow lithospheric and mantle material to mix. Examining chemical data from lithospheric and mantle-derived rocks ranging from 285 million to 3.8 billion years old, the researchers dated the transition to 3.2 billion years ago.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ conclusion?

- A. Among rocks known to be older than 3.2 billion years, significantly more are mantle derived than lithospheric, but the opposite is true for the rocks younger than 3.2 billion years.
- B. Mantle-derived rocks older than 3.2 billion years show significantly more compositional diversity than lithospheric rocks older than 3.2 billion years do.
- C. There is a positive correlation between the age of lithospheric rocks and their chemical similarity to mantle-derived rocks, and that correlation increases significantly in strength at around 3.2 billion years old.
- D. Mantle-derived rocks younger than 3.2 billion years contain some material that is not found in older mantle-derived rocks but is found in older and contemporaneous lithospheric rocks.

ID: 2f3c795c Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ conclusion that the transition from a stagnant lid regime to a tectonic plate regime occurred around 3.2 billion years ago. The text explains that early in Earth’s history, Earth exhibited a stagnant lid regime in which there’s no interaction between the lithosphere and the underlying mantle. The text further explains that, by contrast, once Earth began to exhibit a tectonic plate regime, its lithospheric and mantle material began to mix. If mantle-derived rocks younger than 3.2 billion years contain material not found in older mantle-derived rocks, that material must have originated somewhere other than the mantle. And if this material is found in both older and contemporaneous lithospheric rocks, that would imply that the lithosphere was able to mix with mantle material beginning around 3.2 billion years ago, as the researchers concluded.

Choice A is incorrect. The text gives no basis for comparing the quantities of lithospheric and mantle-derived rocks. Choice B is incorrect. The text gives no basis for comparing the material makeup of lithospheric rocks to that of mantle-derived rocks. Choice C is incorrect. A positive correlation between the age of lithospheric rocks and these rocks’ chemical similarity to mantle-derived rocks would mean that the oldest rocks would be the most similar, which contradicts the text’s claim that lithospheric and mantle-derived rocks were completely separate until 3.2 billion years ago. If the researchers’ conclusion about the onset of tectonics on Earth is correct, then younger lithospheric rocks would show greater chemical similarity to mantle-derived rocks than older lithospheric rocks do.

Question ID 86291ffc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 86291ffc

In documents called judicial opinions, judges explain the reasoning behind their legal rulings, and in those explanations they sometimes cite and discuss historical and contemporary philosophers. Legal scholar and philosopher Anita L. Allen argues that while judges are naturally inclined to mention philosophers whose views align with their own positions, the strongest judicial opinions consider and rebut potential objections; discussing philosophers whose views conflict with judges’ views could therefore

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. allow judges to craft judicial opinions without needing to consult philosophical works.
- B. help judges improve the arguments they put forward in their judicial opinions.
- C. make judicial opinions more comprehensible to readers without legal or philosophical training.
- D. bring judicial opinions in line with views that are broadly held among philosophers.

ID: 86291ffc Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Anita Allen’s argument about judges citing philosophers in their judicial opinions. The text indicates that judges sometimes cite philosophers when writing their judicial opinions and that, according to Allen, judges tend to cite philosophers whose views are in agreement with those of the judges themselves. Allen claims, however, that the best judicial opinions consider potential objections and rebut them, which suggests that judges may be able to strengthen their opinions by including discussions of philosophers with views contrary to their own.

Choice A is incorrect because Allen’s claim is that judges could improve their judicial opinions by citing philosophers who disagree with the views expressed in the opinions, which would necessarily require judges to consult philosophical works. Choice C is incorrect because there’s no discussion in the text about making judicial opinions more easily understood by any particular group of readers. The focus of the text is on Allen’s claim that judicial opinions could be strengthened by the inclusion of discussions of philosophers whose views disagree with those of the judges authoring the opinions. Choice D is incorrect because the text presents Allen’s argument that discussing philosophers whose views judges disagree with could strengthen judicial opinions, not that doing so could bring those opinions into line with views that are popular among philosophers.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1c8ea715

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 1c8ea715

A student in a political science course is writing a paper on Aristotle's *The Politics*, in which Aristotle offers his opinion on political instability and gives advice on how constitutions can be preserved. Aristotle observes that different forms of government can fall in different ways—for example, oligarchies might grant power to military leaders during wartime who refuse to relinquish that power during peacetime—but some methods of preserving order apply across all forms of government. The student claims that in particular Aristotle asserts that in a healthy state obedience to law must be as close to absolute as possible and that even minor infractions should not be ignored.

Which quotation from a philosopher’s analysis of *The Politics* would best support the student’s claim?

- A. “When constructing his argument regarding the characteristics of a well-functioning government, Aristotle asserts that ‘Transgression creeps in unperceived and at last ruins the state,’ illustrating this idea with a comparison to frequent small expenditures slowly and almost imperceptibly chipping away at a fortune until it is ultimately depleted.”
- B. “When Aristotle writes on the necessity of avoiding corruption in government, he proposes that ‘every state should be so administered and so regulated by law that its magistrates cannot possibly make money.’ In particular, he thinks oligarchies are particularly susceptible to corruption through bribery.”
- C. “When Aristotle considers the health of constitutions, he states that ‘Constitutions are preserved when their destroyers are at a distance, and sometimes also because they are near, for the fear of them makes the government keep in hand the constitution.’ He holds that rulers who wish to see constitutions preserved must continually remind the populace of the dangers that would result from a constitutional collapse.”
- D. “When contrasting different forms of government, Aristotle holds that ‘oligarchies may last, not from any inherent stability in such forms of government, but because the rulers are on good terms both with the unenfranchised and with the governing classes.’ That is, oligarchic leaders who wish to hold on to power will introduce members of disenfranchised classes into government in a participatory role.”

ID: 1c8ea715 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents the quotation that best supports the student’s claim that in *The Politics*, Aristotle gives advice on preserving constitutions—preventing governments from falling and maintaining order—and specifically asserts that in a healthy state, laws must be followed as strictly as possible and infractions should not be overlooked even if they are minor. The philosopher states that when Aristotle builds his argument about the characteristics of a well-functioning government, Aristotle asserts that transgression, or violation of law, will ruin the state if it "creeps in unperceived," or goes unnoticed. The philosopher then adds that Aristotle illustrates this point by comparing the situation to one in which small but frequent expenses diminish a fortune almost unnoticeably until, eventually, the fortune is entirely gone. In other words, the philosopher indicates that Aristotle makes the point that total obedience to law preserves a healthy state while even small violations, if ignored, will undermine the health of the state.

Choice B is incorrect because the philosopher addresses Aristotle's observation about corruption within the government (in particular, preventing the possibility that members of the government can take bribes), and although corruption can involve infractions, the observation is about a subset of people within the state and isn't directly connected to the importance of upholding total obedience to the law throughout the state. Choice C is incorrect because the philosopher discusses Aristotle's point about those who would intentionally destroy a constitution altogether and the need for rulers to remind the populace that it would be dangerous for a constitution to collapse, but neither idea is directly connected to the importance of upholding total obedience to the law. Choice D is incorrect because the philosopher explains that Aristotle makes the point that oligarchic leaders may retain power by having members of disenfranchised classes participate in government alongside governing classes, and this point doesn't address the importance of ensuring obedience to the law and addressing even minor violations.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9e4ab29e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 9e4ab29e

Plants like potatoes, tomatoes, and soybeans are susceptible to bacterial wilt disease caused by the bacteria *Ralstonia solanacearum*. A multinational team of scientists led by Zhong Wei studied whether other microbes in the soil might influence the degree to which plants are affected by the disease. The team sampled soil surrounding individual tomato plants over time and compared the results of plants that became diseased with those that remained healthy. They concluded that the presence of certain microbes in the soil might explain the difference between healthy and diseased plants.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the team’s conclusion?

- A. The soil surrounding healthy plants contained significantly higher concentrations of microbes known to inhibit *Ralstonia solanacearum* than the soil surrounding diseased plants did.
- B. The soil surrounding the plants contained high concentrations of *Ralstonia solanacearum* regardless of whether the plants were affected by wilt disease.
- C. The soil surrounding healthy plants tended to have significantly higher moisture levels than the soil surrounding diseased plants did.
- D. By the end of the experiment, over half the plants had been affected by wilt disease regardless of differences in the types and concentrations of microbes in the surrounding soil.

ID: 9e4ab29e Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice provides evidence that directly links the presence of *R. solanacearum*-inhibiting microbes in the soil to the health of tomato plants.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice would weaken the team’s conclusion. It suggests that the presence of the disease-causing bacteria had no effect on the health of the tomato plants. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the team’s conclusion. The conclusion is about microbes, not soil moisture. Choice D is incorrect. This choice would weaken the team’s conclusion. It suggests that the presence of the bacteria-inhibiting microbe in soil had no effect on the health of the tomato plants.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cb912b8b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: cb912b8b

North American Thrasher Mean Bill Size and Habitat Temperature Range

Species	Mean bill surface area (cm ²)	Mean maximum temperature of warmest month (°C)	Mean minimum temperature of coldest month (°C)
Brown thrasher	1.86	30.40	-4.29
Bendire's thrasher	1.98	36.57	0.24
Long-billed thrasher	2.24	35.27	8.82
Cozumel thrasher	2.28	33.27	18.21
Ocellated thrasher	3.26	27.56	5.45

It has been hypothesized that since birds can dissipate excess heat through their bills, bill size should increase with habitat temperature. To evaluate this hypothesis for a 2021 study, Charlotte Probst and colleagues gathered data on mean bill surface area of species of North American thrashers (genus: *Toxostoma*) as well as on climate conditions of the birds' native habitats. Based on their data, Probst and colleagues concluded that the hypothesis was not fully supported.

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to support Probst and colleagues' conclusion?

- A. Although the Bendire's thrasher has one of the smallest mean bill surface areas of the birds included in the table, its habitat has one of the lowest mean maximum temperatures in the warmest month and one of the lowest mean minimum temperatures in the coldest month.
- B. Although the Cozumel thrasher has the second greatest mean bill surface area of the birds included in the table, its habitat's mean temperature in the warmest month is significantly higher than that of the other birds' habitats.
- C. Of the birds included in the table, the brown thrasher has the smallest mean bill surface area and the habitat with the lowest mean minimum temperature in the coldest month, while the long-billed thrasher has the second-largest mean bill surface area and the habitat with the second-highest mean minimum temperature in the coldest month.
- D. Of the birds included in the table, the ocellated thrasher has the largest mean bill surface area and the habitat with the lowest mean maximum temperature in the warmest month, while the Bendire's thrasher has the second smallest mean bill surface area and the habitat with the highest mean maximum temperature in the warmest month.

ID: cb912b8b Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the table to support Probst and colleagues' conclusion about the hypothesis regarding the relationship between birds' bill size and habitat temperature. The text states that although it has been hypothesized that birds' bill size should increase with habitat temperature (an adaptation that reflects the fact that birds can release excess heat through their bills), Probst and colleagues concluded after studying mean bill surface area in North American thrashers that this hypothesis was not fully supported. In other words, Probst and colleagues did not observe the predicted positive relationship between mean bill surface area and habitat temperature in the thrashers they studied. The data in the table about the ocellated thrasher support Probst and colleagues' conclusion because this species has the greatest mean bill surface area (3.26 cm^2), but its habitat has the lowest mean maximum temperature in the warmest month (27.56°C). If the hypothesis were fully supported, species such as the ocellated thrasher that have colder habitats would likely also have smaller bills. Similarly, the data about the Bendire's thrasher support Probst and colleagues' conclusion because this species has the second-smallest mean bill surface area (1.98 cm^2), yet its habitat has the highest mean maximum temperature in the warmest month (36.57°C). If the hypothesis were fully supported, the Bendire's thrasher and other species with warmer habitats would also have larger bills. Because data in the table show that the ocellated thrasher and the Bendire's thrasher have the opposite or near opposite of the hypothesized relationship between bill size and habitat temperature, these examples support Probst and colleagues' conclusion that this hypothesis isn't fully supported.

Choice A is incorrect because it misrepresents the data in the table. Although the Bendire's thrasher has the second-smallest mean bill surface area of the species that are included in the table and although its habitat has the second-lowest mean minimum temperature in the coldest month, this habitat has the highest (rather than the lowest) mean maximum temperature in the warmest month. Moreover, the data about this species' bill surface area and mean minimum temperature suggest that smaller bills are associated with colder habitats, supporting rather than challenging the hypothesis that bill size increases with habitat temperature. Choice B is incorrect because it misrepresents the data in the table. Although the Cozumel thrasher has the second-greatest mean bill surface area of the species that are included in the table, its habitat's mean maximum temperature in the warmest month is not "significantly higher" than the mean maximum temperatures of the other habitats. On the contrary, the mean maximum temperature of the Cozumel thrasher's habitat is lower than that observed for the habitats of both the Bendire's thrasher and the long-billed thrasher. Choice C is incorrect because it misrepresents the data in the table. Although this choice accurately describes the brown thrasher's mean bill surface area and habitat temperature, it incorrectly states that the long-billed thrasher has the second-largest (rather than the third-largest) mean bill surface area of the species included. In addition, instead of revealing a lack of support for the hypothesis that bill size increases with habitat temperature, the data in this choice broadly reflect the hypothesized relationship.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3e1054a3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 3e1054a3

The single origin hypothesis of iron metallurgy posits that the craft originated in Anatolia (West Asia) circa 2200–2000 BCE before diffusing to other parts of the world, including Africa. Some proponents of the hypothesis argue that iron production technologies first arrived in North Africa through Carthage, where the earliest evidence of ironworking dates to approximately 800–600 BCE, before these technologies spread to sub-Saharan Africa over the following centuries. However, excavation of multiple sites on the Adamawa plateau in Central Africa conducted by Étienne Zangato and Augustin Holl uncovered evidence of iron workshops that may have been in operation as late as 900–750 BCE in Gbabari and as early as 2300–1900 BCE in Ôbouï and Gbatoro. These findings suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. iron production may have developed independently and relatively simultaneously in Anatolia and parts of Central Africa.
- B. iron production technologies found in Gbabari likely derived directly from technologies transmitted from Anatolia, but those found in Ôbouï and Gbatoro did not.
- C. iron production technologies were likely transmitted from Anatolia to Central Africa via an alternate route than the one suggested by some proponents of the single origin hypothesis.
- D. iron production may have originated in Anatolia much earlier than the available evidence currently indicates.

ID: 3e1054a3 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the origin of iron metallurgy in Africa. The text explains that the single origin hypothesis suggests that iron metallurgy originated in Anatolia in West Asia circa 2200–2000 BCE and then spread to other parts of the world, with some advocates of this hypothesis arguing that the technology reached sub-Saharan Africa through the North African site of Carthage, where evidence of ironworking dates as far back as approximately 800–600 BCE. However, according to the text, researchers uncovered evidence of iron workshops at one Central African site, Gbabari, dating to circa 900–750 BCE—slightly before ironworking in Carthage—and at two other sites in Central Africa, Ôbouï and Gbatoro, dating to as early as 2300–1900 BCE—significantly before ironworking spread to Carthage and roughly contemporaneous with its emergence in Anatolia. If iron metallurgy’s presence in Central Africa preceded its presence in North Africa, then this technology likely didn’t diffuse from Carthage to Central Africa. Moreover, this technology’s presence in Central Africa at roughly the same period when it originated in Anatolia would require its virtually immediate diffusion across the vast distances between the two regions—a development that would have been unlikely in the ancient world. Therefore, the researchers’ findings suggest that iron production may have developed independently and relatively simultaneously in Anatolia and parts of Central Africa.

Choice B is incorrect. The findings presented in the text indicate that iron metallurgy may have been occurring in Ôbouï and Gbatoro as early as 2300 BCE, which is earlier than it is thought to have emerged in Anatolia, and may have been occurring in

Gbabari as early as 900 BCE, which is earlier than it is thought to have arrived in Carthage as it began diffusing into Africa. These earlier instances suggest that instead of diffusing from Anatolia to Central Africa, this technology independently emerged in Central Africa instead, spreading from the earlier iron production sites in the region to the later site. Moreover, the text doesn't indicate any differences in the iron technologies used at the two earlier sites in Central Africa and the technology used at the later site that might suggest separate origins for iron metallurgy within the region. Choice C is incorrect because the text discusses findings that iron metallurgy may have been occurring in Central Africa at nearly the same time as or even slightly before it emerged in Anatolia, without time for it to have spread there from Anatolia—suggesting that the technology may have independently developed in parts of Central Africa. Thus, instead of suggesting an alternate route for the diffusion of iron production into Central Africa, the findings suggest that the technology didn't arrive there by diffusion through an intermediate geographical region at all. Choice D is incorrect because, as the text explains, researchers found that iron metallurgy may have been practiced at a Central African site as early as 2300–1900 BCE—a chronological range that not only predates the technology's spread from Anatolia to Carthage in North Africa circa 800–600 BCE but also overlaps with, and slightly precedes, the range assigned to its invention in Anatolia, 2200–2000 BCE. This finding suggests that instead of diffusing from Anatolia to Central Africa over a vast distance and a great expanse of time, this technology may have been independently invented by Central African civilizations at the same time as it was invented in Anatolia, if not slightly before then. Nothing in the text necessarily suggests that technology arose “much earlier” in Anatolia than the evidence there currently indicates.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a1b4796a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: a1b4796a

If some artifacts recovered from excavations of the settlement of Kuulo Kataa, in modern Ghana, date from the thirteenth century CE, that may lend credence to claims that the settlement was founded before or around that time. There is other evidence, however, strongly supporting a fourteenth century CE founding date for Kuulo Kataa. If both the artifact dates and the fourteenth century CE founding date are correct, that would imply that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. artifacts from the fourteenth century CE are more commonly recovered than are artifacts from the thirteenth century CE.
- B. the artifacts originated elsewhere and eventually reached Kuulo Kataa through trade or migration.
- C. Kuulo Kataa was founded by people from a different region than had previously been assumed.
- D. excavations at Kuulo Kataa may have inadvertently damaged some artifacts dating to the fourteenth century CE.

ID: a1b4796a Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of artifacts and Kuulo Kataa’s founding date. If it were true both that Kuulo Kataa was founded in the fourteenth century CE and that artifacts found in excavations of the settlement are from the thirteenth century CE, it would be reasonable to conclude that the artifacts weren’t created in the Kuulo Kataa settlement. That would suggest, then, that the artifacts originated somewhere else and eventually reached the settlement through trading or as people migrated.

Choice A is incorrect because the existence of thirteenth-century CE artifacts recovered during excavations of a settlement founded in the fourteenth century CE isn’t logically connected to artifacts from one century being more commonly recovered than artifacts from another century. Rather than suggesting anything about how frequently artifacts from different times are found, the existence of artifacts confirmed as predating the settlement’s founding suggests that those items arrived in Kuulo Kataa during or after its establishment. Choice C is incorrect because the text focuses on time periods and says nothing about which region the founders of Kuulo Kataa have been thought to come from; similarly, the text doesn’t suggest anything about where the thirteenth-century CE artifacts originated other than not from Kuulo Kataa. Therefore, it isn’t logical to conclude that the mere existence of artifacts confirmed as predating the Kuulo Kataa settlement suggests that the founders of the settlement came from a particular region other than one previously assumed. Choice D is incorrect because the existence of artifacts from the thirteenth century CE at a site dated to the fourteenth century CE doesn’t imply that fourteenth-century objects were damaged during excavations. There’s nothing in the text to suggest that any objects were damaged; rather, the existence of artifacts confirmed as predating the settlement’s founding suggests that those items were brought to Kuulo Kataa during or after its establishment.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2ac40e06

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 2ac40e06

Arthurian legends (tales related to the character of King Arthur) derive from many sources, such as *Vita Sancti Cadoci*, composed in the 11th century, and *Culhwch and Olwen* from the second half of the 12th century. One of the most significant sources, Geoffrey of Monmouth’s *History of the Kings of Britain*, was written in the 1130s; some material from it was later adapted by the Norman poet Wace into the *Roman de Brut* in 1155. But Wace didn’t merely adapt *History*, he added to it as well, introducing the famous Round Table at which Arthur’s knights assembled, which suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. *Roman de Brut* is more historically accurate than *History*, because *Culhwch and Olwen* had not been written when Geoffrey of Monmouth was writing his work.
- B. Geoffrey of Monmouth was unaware of stories of the Round Table when composing his *History*, though historians know that works containing such stories were available to him.
- C. Geoffrey of Monmouth’s accounts of Arthurian legends in his *History* are more similar overall in content to the accounts in *Culhwch and Olwen* than they are to the accounts in *Roman de Brut*.
- D. the Arthurian legends that the author of *Vita Sancti Cadoci* drew on would not have featured the Round Table.

ID: 2ac40e06 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the discussion about the genealogy of Arthurian legends. The text establishes a chronology of Arthurian sources, with *Vita Sancti Cadoci* composed in the 11th century (the 1000s), Geoffrey of Monmouth’s *History* written in the 1130s, Wace’s *Roman de Brut* in 1155, and *Culhwch and Olwen* in the second half of the 12th century (1150–1200). Importantly, the text indicates that along with adapting Geoffrey’s *History*, Wace added "the famous Round Table" to it. If Wace introduced the idea of the Round Table in 1155, it logically follows that this element was not present in earlier works. This suggests that the Arthurian legends that informed *Vita Sancti Cadoci*, which was written before both Geoffrey’s and Wace’s works, would not have featured the Round Table.

Choice A is incorrect because the text discusses several works that include legends about a character, King Arthur, but doesn’t address the historical accuracy of the stories in those works or suggest that the creation of *Culhwch and Olwen* was relevant to any other works’ accuracy. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that works containing stories of the Round Table were available to Geoffrey of Monmouth when he composed his *History* in the 1130s, whether he was aware of them or not; it instead suggests that the idea of the Round Table wasn’t introduced until more than a decade later, when Wace added it to Geoffrey’s *History*. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text indicates that the Arthurian legends in Geoffrey of Monmouth’s *History* differ from those in Wace’s *Roman de Brut* in that Wace added the idea of the Round Table, the text doesn’t compare the overall content of the Arthurian legends in the two works and doesn’t indicate anything about the overall content of the legends in *Culhwch and Olwen*.

Question ID 6875c7a6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 6875c7a6

“The Poet Walt Whitman” is an 1887 essay by José Martí, a Cuban author and political activist, originally written in Spanish. In the essay, Martí explores the value of literature, arguing that a society’s spiritual well-being depends on the character of its literary culture: _____

Which quotation from a translation of “The Poet Walt Whitman” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “Poetry, which brings together or separates, which fortifies or brings anguish, which shores up or demolishes souls, which gives or robs men of faith and vigor, is more necessary to a people than industry itself, for industry provides them with a means of subsistence, while literature gives them the desire and strength for life.”
- B. “Every society brings to literature its own form of expression, and the history of the nations can be told with greater truth by the stages of literature than by chronicles and decades.”
- C. “Where will a race of men go when they have lost the habit of thinking with faith about the scope and meaning of their actions? The best among them, those who consecrate Nature with their sacred desire for the future, will lose, in a sordid and painful annihilation, all stimulus to alleviate the ugliness of humanity.”
- D. “Listen to the song of this hardworking and satisfied nation; listen to Walt Whitman. The exercise of himself exalts him to majesty, tolerance exalts him to justice, and order to joy.”

ID: 6875c7a6 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively illustrates the claim that Martí argues that a society’s spiritual well-being depends on the character of its literary culture. In the quotation, Martí asserts that poetry is “more necessary to a people than industry itself” and that it has the power to provide people with “faith and vigor.” He also adds that literature gives people “the desire and strength for life.” Therefore, this quotation shows that Martí believes that literature is a societal necessity because it uplifts people and nourishes their spiritual well-being.

Choice B is incorrect. Although this quotation emphasizes the importance of literature, it focuses on how the nature of a society is reflected in that society’s literature rather than on literature’s value for people’s spiritual well-being. Choice C is incorrect. Although this quotation involves an element of spirituality, it doesn’t discuss literature. The quotation instead focuses on humanity’s actions. Choice D is incorrect because this quotation mainly focuses on the importance of Walt Whitman rather than on the value of literature in general.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 77953e2f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 77953e2f

“Mr. Cornelius Johnson, Office-Seeker” is a 1900 short story by Paul Laurence Dunbar. In the story, the narrator describes Mr. Cornelius Johnson’s appearance as conveying his exaggerated sense of his importance: _____

Which quotation from “Mr. Cornelius Johnson, Office-Seeker” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “He carried himself always as if he were passing under his own triumphal arch.”
- B. “The grey Prince Albert was scrupulously buttoned about his form, and a shiny top hat replaced the felt of the afternoon.”
- C. “It was a beautiful day in balmy May and the sun shone pleasantly on Mr. Cornelius Johnson’s very spruce Prince Albert suit of grey as he alighted from the train in Washington.”
- D. “Mr. Cornelius Johnson always spoke in a large and important tone.”

ID: 77953e2f Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This quote most effectively illustrates the claim. The claim is that the narrator describes Mr. Johnson as arrogant and self-important. This basically says that Mr. Johnson always looks like he’s congratulating himself for something, which definitely supports the idea that Mr. Johnson is arrogant! .

Choice B is incorrect. This quote doesn’t illustrate the claim. The claim is that the narrator describes Mr. Johnson’s appearance as conveying his arrogance. This describes his appearance, but the description doesn’t suggest a sense of arrogance. Choice C is incorrect. This quote doesn’t illustrate the claim. The claim is that the narrator describes Mr. Johnson’s appearance as conveying his arrogance. This doesn’t describe Mr. Johnson’s appearance very much, and it doesn’t suggest a sense of arrogance. Choice D is incorrect. This quote doesn’t effectively illustrate the claim. It describes Mr. Johnson’s tone of voice as “large and important,” but it doesn’t describe his appearance as conveying a sense of self-importance.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cbbbc796

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: cbbbc796

Zooarchaeologist Ophélie Lebrasseur and her team examined a fox skeleton discovered in 1991 at an archaeological site alongside artifacts of human habitation (like spear points) in central Argentina. Lebrasseur et al. determined that the fox was *Dusicyon avus*, an extinct species resembling a jackal, and radiocarbon dating placed the fox at the site at the same time as human inhabitants. (Indeed, the inhabitants may have deliberately buried the fox.) In addition, while wild foxes have a diet entirely made of meat, isotopic signatures of the skeleton’s teeth indicated that the fox’s diet, like that of the humans, was partly composed of plant material. Lebrasseur et al. therefore concluded that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the humans who were alive at the same time as the fox most likely ate more meat than the fox did.
- B. the fox may have been a companion animal of the humans who inhabited the site at the same time.
- C. the fox had a diet more similar to that of jackals than to that of wild foxes.
- D. the humans who were alive at the same time as the fox hunted using the spears whose points were also found at the site.

ID: cbbbc796 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Lebrasseur et al.’s examination of a fox skeleton found at an archaeological site in central Argentina. The text explains that the fox was found next to artifacts of human habitation, that radiocarbon dating indicated that it was at the site at the same time as human inhabitants, that humans at the site may have deliberately buried the fox, and that analysis indicated that the fox’s diet included meat and plant material, as the humans’ diet did, even though wild foxes eat only meat. The diet similarity, along with the fox’s location, the radiocarbon dating of its remains, and its possibly deliberate burial, suggests the fox was closely associated with the site’s human inhabitants—making it reasonable to conclude that the fox may have been a companion animal of those humans.

Choice A is incorrect. The text indicates that both the fox and the human inhabitants at the site had a diet that included both meat and plant material, but the text gives no information about the relative proportions of meat in the fox’s and the humans’ respective diets. Choice C is incorrect. The text states that *Dusicyon avus* is an extinct species that resembled a jackal, but this description refers to the fox’s physical appearance, not its diet, and no information is given about what jackals eat. Choice D is incorrect. The last two sentences of the text focus on the possibility that the human inhabitants of the site may have given the fox a burial and that they and the fox may have eaten a similarly omnivorous diet—details pointing to the conclusion that the fox may have been a companion animal of the inhabitants. Thus, a conclusion about the hunting technology used by the inhabitants wouldn’t follow from the text.

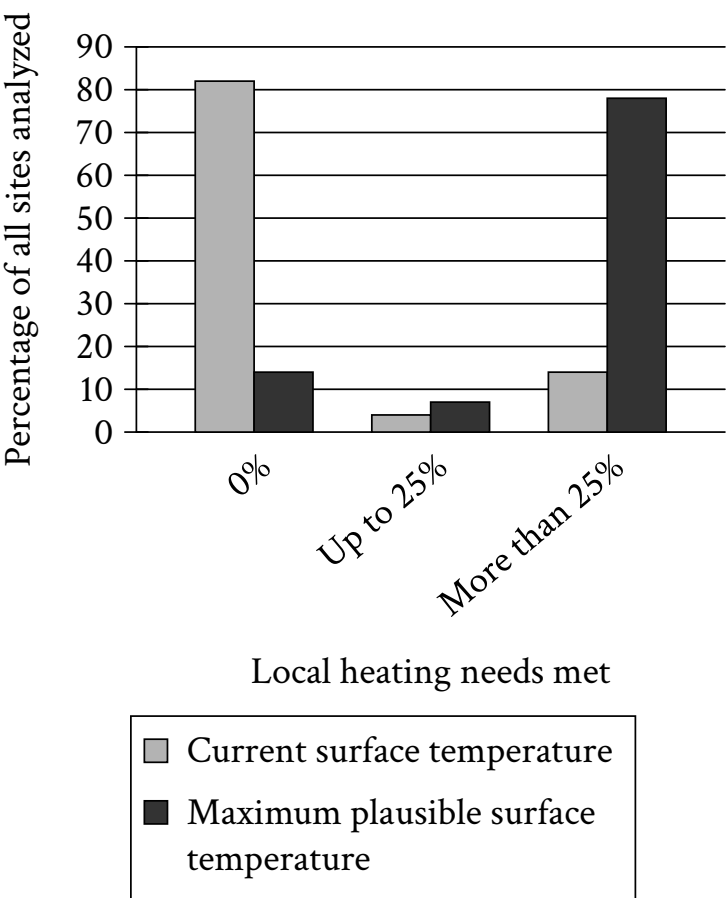
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6b1f0e55

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 6b1f0e55

Home Heating Needs Met with Subsurface Thermal Pollution for Two Temperature Conditions, by Percentage of Sites



Urbanization, industrialization, and the warming climate create thermal pollution (excess heat) in the shallow subsurface soil. Susanne A. Benz and colleagues analyzed thousands of sites on three continents under one scenario in which surface temperature remains at the current level and under another in which the surface reaches the maximum plausible temperature. They then categorized each site according to the percentage of local home heating needs that could be met using this excess subsurface heat. The team concluded that if surface temperature approaches the maximum plausible level, the percentage of sites where thermal pollution could feasibly contribute to meeting home heating needs will increase.

Which choice best describes data in the graph that support Benz and colleagues’ conclusion?

- A. Under both temperature conditions, less than 10% of sites were in the up-to-25% group, but at the maximum plausible surface temperature, almost 80% of sites could have all their local heating needs met by thermal pollution.

- B. At current surface temperatures, more than 80% of the sites have no need for supplemental local home heating from subsurface thermal pollution, but at the maximum plausible surface temperature, more than 70% of sites exhibit significantly greater home heating needs.
- C. At current surface temperatures, more than 80% of sites can meet, at most, 25% of local home heating needs with subsurface thermal pollution, but at the maximum plausible surface temperature, more than 80% of sites can meet greater than 25% of local home heating needs.
- D. At current surface temperatures, more than 80% of the sites cannot use subsurface thermal pollution to meet any portion of local home heating needs, but at the maximum plausible surface temperature, that percentage drops below 20%.

ID: 6b1f0e55 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The researchers concluded that as we approach maximum plausible surface temperatures, there will be a larger percentage of sites where thermal pollution could contribute to meeting home heating needs. By showing that only a small percentage of homes can currently use thermal pollution for home heating, and that this percentage would grow much larger at maximum plausible surface temperatures, this choice supports the researchers' conclusion.

Choice A is incorrect. We do not know how many sites could have all (i.e., 100%) of their local heating needs met by thermal pollution, as the graph only classifies sites by whether "0%," "Up to 25%," and "More than 25%" of heating needs could be met. Choice B is incorrect. The graph is not depicting need for supplemental heating from thermal pollution, but rather potential to use thermal pollution for supplemental heating. Choice C is incorrect. The graph indicates that, at current surface temperatures, less than 10% of sites can meet 25% of local home heating needs and that more than 80% of sites cannot meet any local home heating needs.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID eb7ba11e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: eb7ba11e

Effect of Paywall Introduction on Newspaper Companies’ Revenues

Newspaper	Total revenue change (\$ in thousands)	Percentage change (%)	Newspaper size
Los Angeles Times	93,966	12.5	large
The New York Times	235,788	20	large
The Denver Post	−3,765	−1	small
Sun Sentinel	−24,899	−11.9	small
Chicago Tribune	94,492	19	large

Digital paywalls restrict access to online content to those with a paid subscription. In an investigation of the effect of paywalls on newspaper company revenues for print and digital subscriptions and advertising, Doug J. Chung and colleagues compared actual outcomes (with a paywall) to control estimates (without a paywall). The researchers concluded that introducing a paywall is generally more beneficial for larger newspapers, which have high circulation and tend to offer a substantial amount of unique online content.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support Chung and colleagues’ conclusion?

- A. The *Chicago Tribune* and the *Los Angeles Times* had similar total revenue changes, but the *Los Angeles Times* had a smaller percentage change.
- B. The *Los Angeles Times* had a 12.5% revenue change, while the *Chicago Tribune* had a 19% revenue change.
- C. The *New York Times* had a 20% revenue change, while the *Denver Post* had a −1% revenue change.
- D. The *Denver Post* had only a −1% revenue change, which was the smallest percentage change of the selected companies.

ID: eb7ba11e Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The conclusion is that paywalls are more beneficial for large newspapers. This data supports that conclusion by comparing the revenue increase of a large newspaper to the revenue decrease of a small newspaper.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the conclusion. It doesn’t include any small newspapers for comparison.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the conclusion. It doesn’t include any small newspapers for comparison.

Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the conclusion. It doesn’t include any large newspapers for comparison.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f8e9d933

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: f8e9d933

For its 1974 work *Instant Mural*, the Chicano art collective Asco taped members Patssi Valdez and Humberto Sandoval to an outdoor wall in East Los Angeles. The work is manifestly a commentary on constraint, but many critics focus on Valdez and the social constraints women faced at the time, which is understandable but leaves the presence of Valdez’s male collaborator Sandoval unexplained. We should instead consider that in 1974, the art establishment’s recognition of Chicano artists was (and had long been) restricted to sociohistorical muralists, leaving nonmuralist Chicano artists—like Asco’s members—struggling to even exhibit their work; attending to this context opens an interpretation that accounts for all the evidence, allowing us to conclude that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. while Valdez’s presence in *Instant Mural* represents the social constraints placed on women at the time, Sandoval’s presence represents Chicano muralists’ frustration at their lack of recognition by the art establishment.
- B. the main subject of *Instant Mural* is female Chicano artists’ experience of being doubly constrained by gender-role expectations and the marginalization of certain types of art.
- C. *Instant Mural* is a reflection on the constraining aesthetic expectations placed on Chicano artists in general rather than on the social constraints placed on women specifically.
- D. *Instant Mural* is best understood not as a critique of the social constraints placed on women but rather as a critique of sociohistorical muralists’ depictions of Chicano culture.

ID: f8e9d933 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of *Instant Mural*. According to the text, the 1974 work *Instant Mural* involved taping two Asco members (Patssi Valdez and Humberto Sandoval) to an outdoor wall as a direct commentary on constraint (limitation or restriction). The text suggests that instead of focusing on Valdez’s role in the work and on social limitations women faced at the time—an approach that fails to explain the role of Sandoval, a man—people should consider that in 1974 (and long before) the art establishment limited recognition of Chicano artists to those who created murals with social and historical subjects, making it challenging for nonmuralist Chicano artists (such as Asco’s members) to show their work. The text suggests that considering the situation with the art establishment leads to a conclusion that accounts for the fact that *Instant Mural* is explicitly about constraint and features both a woman and a man taped to the wall: *Instant Mural* isn’t a reflection of the social constraints placed on women specifically but instead is a reflection on the constraining aesthetic expectations placed on Chicano artists in general (that is, the limits resulting from the lack of recognition of Chicano artists of any gender who did not create sociohistorical murals).

Choice A is incorrect. The text indicates that the art establishment in 1974 (and earlier) did recognize Chicano muralists to the exclusion of other Chicano artists, so there’s no reason to assume Asco’s work *Instant Mural* was intended to represent Chicano

muralists' frustration; it's far more likely that Asco's members—described as Chicano nonmuralists—were representing their own frustration at being unrecognized by the art establishment. Choice B is incorrect. The text emphasizes that while a common approach to *Instant Mural* focuses on Valdez and the social limitations women faced in 1974 but fails to account for the presence of a man in the work, there is a conclusion that explains Sandoval's role. But concluding that *Instant Mural* represents a double constraint experienced specifically by female Chicano artists would still fail to account for the inclusion of a man in the work. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text suggests that *Instant Mural* can be understood as something other than a commentary on social constraints women faced in 1974, it doesn't suggest that the work is best understood as a critique of the content of any other artworks. The text doesn't address how Chicano culture is depicted in sociohistorical murals; it discusses such murals only to make the point that in 1974 (and earlier) the art establishment recognized Chicano artists who produced them to the exclusion of Chicano nonmuralists, indicating a constraint all of Asco's members faced, regardless of gender.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2aba6f6d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 2aba6f6d

Although military veterans make up a small proportion of the total population of the United States, they occupy a significantly higher proportion of the jobs in the civilian government. One possible explanation for this disproportionate representation is that military service familiarizes people with certain organizational structures that are also reflected in the civilian government bureaucracy, and this familiarity thus _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. makes civilian government jobs especially appealing to military veterans.
- B. alters the typical relationship between military service and subsequent career preferences.
- C. encourages nonveterans applying for civilian government jobs to consider military service instead.
- D. increases the number of civilian government jobs that require some amount of military experience to perform.

ID: 2aba6f6d Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of military veterans working in civilian government jobs in the United States. The text indicates that the proportion of military veterans working in civilian government jobs is considerably higher than the proportion of military veterans in the population as a whole. The text also notes that the unusually high representation of military veterans in these jobs may be a result of the organizational structures shared by civilian government entities and the military. Hence, it’s reasonable to infer that it’s the familiarity of the structures of civilian government that makes jobs there particularly attractive to military veterans.

Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t address what a typical relationship between military service and later career preferences would be, and there’s no indication that it’s atypical for veterans to work in civilian government jobs after they’ve left the military. On the contrary, the text suggests that many military veterans are drawn to such jobs. Choice C is incorrect because the text is focused on the high representation of military veterans in civilian government jobs and doesn’t address nonveterans or their possible interest in military service. Choice D is incorrect because the text conveys that military veterans may be particularly interested in civilian government jobs due to the familiarity of organizational structures that are already in place, but there’s no reason to think that this interest would mean that more civilian government jobs will start to require military experience.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 289312dd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 289312dd

Political scientists who favor the traditional view of voter behavior claim that voting in an election does not change a voter’s attitude toward the candidates in that election. Focusing on each US presidential election from 1976 to 1996, Ebonya Washington and Sendhil Mullainathan tested this claim by distinguishing between subjects who had just become old enough to vote (around half of whom actually voted) and otherwise similar subjects who were slightly too young to vote (and thus none of whom voted). Washington and Mullainathan compared the attitudes of the groups of subjects toward the winning candidate two years after each election.

Which finding from Washington and Mullainathan’s study, if true, would most directly weaken the claim made by people who favor the traditional view of voter behavior?

- A. Subjects’ attitudes toward the winning candidate two years after a given election were strongly predicted by subjects’ general political orientation, regardless of whether subjects were old enough to vote at the time of the election.
- B. Subjects who were not old enough to vote in a given election held significantly more positive attitudes towards the winning candidate two years later than they held at the time of the election.
- C. Subjects who voted in a given election held significantly more polarized attitudes toward the winning candidate two years later than did subjects who were not old enough to vote in that election.
- D. Two years after a given election, subjects who voted and subjects who were not old enough to vote were significantly more likely to express negative attitudes than positive attitudes toward the winning candidate in that election.

ID: 289312dd Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would weaken the claim made by people who favor the traditional view of voter behavior. According to the text, people who favor that view believe that voting in an election doesn’t change a voter’s attitude toward the candidates in that election. If Washington and Mullainathan found that two years after an election, attitudes toward the winning candidate were significantly more polarized among subjects who had voted than among subjects who had been too young to vote, that would suggest that the act of voting did have an effect on the voters’ attitudes toward the candidates, which would undermine the claim that voting doesn’t change voters’ attitudes.

Choice A is incorrect because a finding about links between subjects’ attitudes and general political orientation, regardless of age and ability to vote, wouldn’t address the presence or absence of changes in attitudes among those subjects who did actually vote. Therefore, the finding wouldn’t have any bearing on the claim that voting in an election doesn’t change a voter’s attitude toward the candidates in that election. Choice B is incorrect because a finding that positive attitudes toward a winning candidate significantly increased in the two years after the election among subjects who had been too young to vote would involve only people who didn’t vote; therefore, the finding wouldn’t have any bearing on the claim that when people do vote, the act of voting doesn’t change their attitudes toward the candidates. Choice D is incorrect because the finding that subjects in both groups were

more likely to have negative attitudes than positive attitudes toward the winning candidate two years after an election would reflect all subjects' attitudes at one particular time whether they voted or not, rather than the presence or absence of a change in voters' attitudes after voting. Therefore, the finding would neither weaken nor strengthen the claim that voting in an election doesn't change a voter's attitude toward the candidates.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7c7dba12

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 7c7dba12

O Pioneers! is a 1913 novel by Willa Cather. In the novel, Cather depicts Alexandra Bergson as a person who takes comfort in understanding the world around her: _____

Which quotation from *O Pioneers!* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. "She looked fixedly up the bleak street as if she were gathering her strength to face something, as if she were trying with all her might to grasp a situation which, no matter how painful, must be met and dealt with somehow."
- B. "She had never known before how much the country meant to her. The chirping of the insects down in the long grass had been like the sweetest music. She had felt as if her heart were hiding down there, somewhere, with the quail and the plover and all the little wild things that crooned or buzzed in the sun. Under the long shaggy ridges, she felt the future stirring."
- C. "Alexandra drove off alone. The rattle of her wagon was lost in the howling of the wind, but her lantern, held firmly between her feet, made a moving point of light along the highway, going deeper and deeper into the dark country."
- D. "Alexandra drew her shawl closer about her and stood leaning against the frame of the mill, looking at the stars which glittered so keenly through the frosty autumn air. She always loved to watch them, to think of their vastness and distance, and of their ordered march. It fortified her to reflect upon the great operations of nature, and when she thought of the law that lay behind them, she felt a sense of personal security."

ID: 7c7dba12 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most effectively uses a quotation from *O Pioneers!* to illustrate the claim that Alexandra Bergson takes comfort in understanding the world around her. In the quotation, Alexandra is described as enjoying looking at the stars and feeling a "sense of personal security" when she contemplates nature's order and its governing laws. This suggests that Alexandra takes comfort in understanding the world around her.

Choice A is incorrect because the quotation expresses how Alexandra Bergson attempts to meet difficult situations with determination, not how she takes comfort in understanding the world around her. Choice B is incorrect because the quotation expresses "how much the country meant to" Alexandra Bergson, not how she takes comfort in understanding the world around her. In detailing some of the wildlife surrounding Alexandra, the quotation conveys that nature is important to her but not necessarily that it gives her comfort. Choice C is incorrect because the quotation describes Alexandra driving her wagon down a highway at night; it doesn't describe how she takes comfort in understanding the world around her or address how she's feeling as she drives off.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6e888a2f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 6e888a2f

In the twentieth century, ethnographers made a concerted effort to collect Mexican American folklore, but they did not always agree about that folklore’s origins. Scholars such as Aurelio Espinosa claimed that Mexican American folklore derived largely from the folklore of Spain, which ruled Mexico and what is now the southwestern United States from the sixteenth to early nineteenth centuries. Scholars such as Américo Paredes, by contrast, argued that while some Spanish influence is undeniable, Mexican American folklore is mainly the product of the ongoing interactions of various cultures in Mexico and the United States.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Paredes’s argument?

- A. The folklore that the ethnographers collected included several songs written in the form of a *décima*, a type of poem originating in late sixteenth-century Spain.
- B. Much of the folklore that the ethnographers collected had similar elements from region to region.
- C. Most of the folklore that the ethnographers collected was previously unknown to scholars.
- D. Most of the folklore that the ethnographers collected consisted of *corridos*—ballads about history and social life—of a clearly recent origin.

ID: 6e888a2f Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support Paredes’s argument that Mexican-American folklore is mostly the result of cultural interactions in Mexico and the United States rather than an adaptation of Spanish folklore. The text describes a disagreement among scholars about whether Mexican-American folklore mostly derived from the folklore of Spain or originated in Mexico and the United States as cultures there have interacted. The latter view is the argument that Paredes puts forward. If Mexican-American folklore collected in the twentieth century mostly consists of ballads about history and social life that originated recently, then that would support Paredes’s argument, since it would suggest that the folklore mostly arose after Spanish rule ended in the early nineteenth century and that the folklore reflects cultural interactions in Mexico and the United States rather than traditions from Spain.

Choice A is incorrect because the inclusion of songs influenced by sixteenth-century Spanish poetry among Mexican-American folklore collected in the twentieth century would not support Paredes’s view that the folklore was the result of cultural interactions in Mexico and the United States rather than an offshoot of Spanish folklore. If anything, the presence of such songs among the folklore collected in the twentieth century would weaken Paredes’s argument, since it would reflect the influence of Spanish culture on the folklore. Choice B is incorrect because the mere presence of similarities in Mexican-American folklore across regions would not be sufficient to draw a conclusion about where the folklore originated, let alone to support Paredes’s argument that the folklore reflects cultural interactions in Mexico and the United States. In fact, since Paredes argued that Mexican-American folklore is the product of various cultures interacting in Mexico and the United States, he would likely expect there to be regional variations in folklore as different cultures have interacted in different places. Choice C is incorrect because scholars’

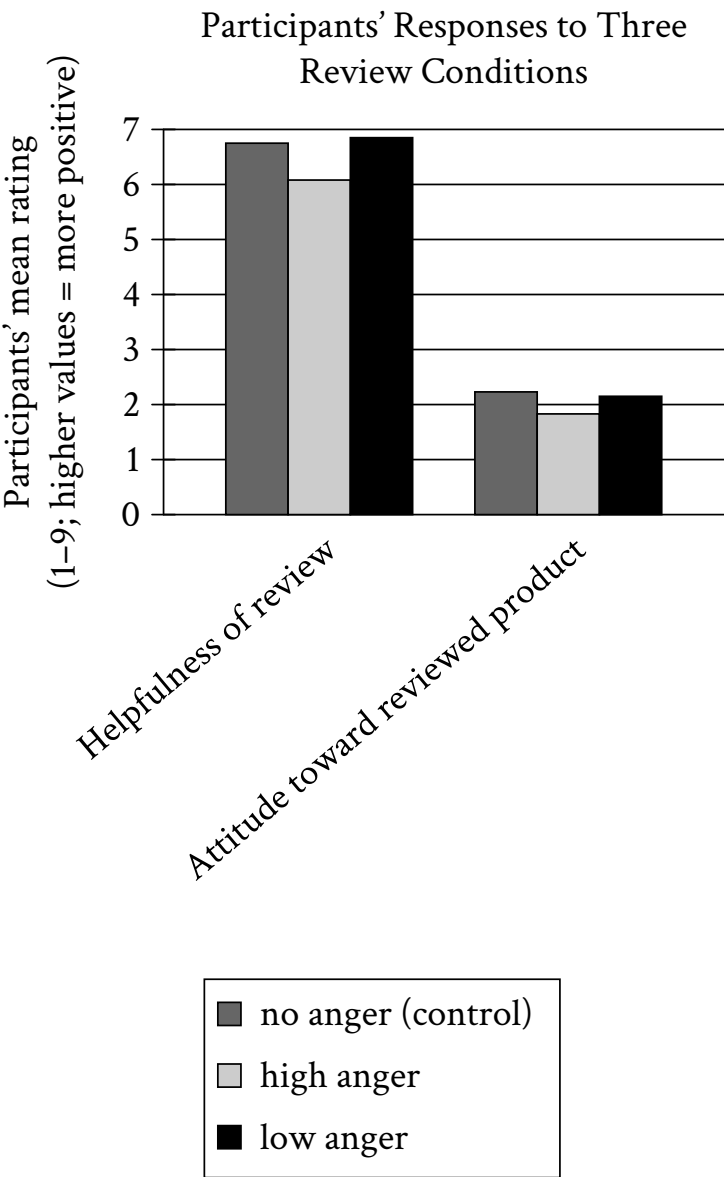
previous ignorance of the folklore would have no bearing on Paredes's argument that Mexican-American folklore mostly reflects cultural interactions in Mexico and the United States. The folklore's origins are independent of scholars' knowledge of the folklore.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bff2a5b2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: bff2a5b2



To understand how expressions of anger in reviews of products affect readers of those reviews, business scholar Dezhi Yin and colleagues measured study participants' responses to three versions of the same negative review—a control review expressing no anger, a review expressing a high degree of anger, and a review expressing a low degree of anger. Reviewing the data, a student concludes that the mere presence of anger in a review may not negatively affect readers' perceptions of the review, but a high degree of anger in a review does worsen readers' perceptions of the review.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that support the students' conclusion?

- A. On average, participants' ratings of the helpfulness of the review were substantially higher than were participants' ratings of the reviewed product regardless of which type of review participants had seen.

- B. Compared with participants who saw the control review, participants who saw the low-anger review rated the review as slightly more helpful, whereas participants who saw the high-anger review rated the review as less helpful.
- C. Participants who saw the low-anger review rated the review as slightly more helpful than participants who saw the control review did, but participants' attitude toward the reviewed product was slightly worse when participants saw the low-anger review than when they saw the no-anger review.
- D. Compared with participants who saw the low-anger review, participants who saw the high-anger review rated the review as less helpful and had a less positive attitude toward the reviewed product.

ID: bff2a5b2 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The claim is that low anger does not negatively affect readers' perceptions of the review, while high anger does negatively affect readers' perceptions of the review. This choice accurately expresses the supporting data from the "helpfulness of review" part of the graph: that low-anger reviews were rated as slightly more helpful than no-anger reviews, while high-anger reviews were rated as less helpful than no-anger reviews.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice does not support the conclusion. The conclusion is only about how participants feel about the review itself—the participants' ratings of the reviewed product are not relevant. Choice C is incorrect. This choice does not support the conclusion. The conclusion is only about how participants feel about the review itself—the participants' attitude towards the reviewed product is not relevant. Choice D is incorrect. This choice does not support the conclusion. The conclusion is only about how participants feel about the review itself—the participants' attitude towards the reviewed product is not relevant.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 454702c3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 454702c3

Conventional theories of rhetoric hold that presenting information as coming from credentialed experts increases that information’s credibility. When communications researcher Sungkyoung Lee and her colleagues tested messages seeking volunteers for clinical trials, however, they found that participants in their study judged recruitment messages from former trial volunteers as significantly more credible than messages from doctors (i.e., credentialed experts). One reason for this may be that the doctors’ status as credentialed experts wasn’t ignored but rather was outweighed by participants’ views of the experiential relevance of the two types of messengers; that is, participants may have reacted the way they did because _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. messages from former trial volunteers depicted clinical trials as being more positive experiences than did messages from doctors.
- B. participants did not have enough experience to evaluate the credibility of the doctors’ messages but did have enough experience to evaluate the credibility of former trial volunteers’ messages.
- C. the fact that former trial volunteers went through the same experience that participants were contemplating while doctors did not was more important to participants than the doctors’ status as credentialed experts was.
- D. participants regarded the experiences of both the doctors and former trial volunteers as relevant to the subject of clinical trials but were skeptical of the doctors’ status as credentialed experts.

ID: 454702c3 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of how participants considered messages from former trial volunteers and doctors. The text first establishes that information coming from credentialed experts typically increases the credibility of that information. However, the text goes on to describe a situation that goes against this expectation: the messages from previous trial volunteers were judged as more credible than the messages from licensed doctors when recruiting clinic trial participants. The text then goes on to speculate as to why this may have been the case, stating that participants likely considered the messages from the former trial volunteers to be more convincing than the messages from the doctors because the former trial volunteers were perceived as having undergone the same experience that the participants were considering. It is reasonable to infer, then, that participants regarded the former trial volunteers’ direct experience as more important to their decision-making than the doctors’ status as credentialed experts.

Choice A is incorrect because the text does not provide any indication as to the content or the tone of the messages provided by either the doctors or the former trial volunteers regarding the clinical trials. Choice B is incorrect. Since the study participants had not themselves participated in the clinical trial, they could not rely on their experience to evaluate the credibility of either the former trial volunteers or the doctors. Choice D is incorrect. While the text does establish that the participants likely considered the messages from both the doctors and the former trial volunteers, it does not suggest that the participants doubted the doctors’

credentials. Rather, the text speculates that participants may have given the experiences of the former trial volunteers more importance than the doctors' credentials when considering the recruitment messages.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 692ac9d3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 692ac9d3

Many of William Shakespeare’s tragedies address broad themes that still appeal to today’s audiences. For instance, *Romeo and Juliet*, which is set in the Italy of Shakespeare’s time, tackles the themes of parents versus children and love versus hate, and the play continues to be read and produced widely around the world. But understanding Shakespeare’s so-called history plays can require a knowledge of several centuries of English history. Consequently, _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. many theatergoers and readers today are likely to find Shakespeare’s history plays less engaging than the tragedies.
- B. some of Shakespeare’s tragedies are more relevant to today’s audiences than twentieth-century plays.
- C. *Romeo and Juliet* is the most thematically accessible of all Shakespeare’s tragedies.
- D. experts in English history tend to prefer Shakespeare’s history plays to his other works.

ID: 692ac9d3 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the relative appeal of different kinds of plays by Shakespeare to today’s audiences. According to the text, Shakespeare’s tragedies address broad themes that continue to appeal to today’s audiences. Indeed, the text suggests that these themes are timeless, as illustrated by the example of *Romeo and Juliet*, which the text states is still read and widely performed despite being set in the Italy of Shakespeare’s time. In contrast, the text indicates that audiences and readers may need to be familiar with several centuries of English history in order to understand Shakespeare’s history plays. Because many theatergoers and readers are unlikely to possess such extensive historical knowledge, it follows that they are likely to find Shakespeare’s history plays less engaging than his more accessible tragedies.

Choice B is incorrect because the text never introduces a comparison between Shakespeare’s tragedies and twentieth-century plays, only between Shakespeare’s tragedies and his history plays. Since twentieth-century plays aren’t mentioned, there’s no basis in the text for the idea that some of Shakespeare’s tragedies are more relevant than twentieth-century plays to today’s audiences. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text indicates that *Romeo and Juliet* is thematically accessible to today’s audiences, it doesn’t suggest that *Romeo and Juliet* is more accessible than Shakespeare’s other tragedies. Rather, the text presents *Romeo and Juliet* as an example to support the idea that Shakespeare’s tragedies hold continued appeal for today’s readers and theatergoers. Choice D is incorrect. Although experts in English history would likely possess the knowledge needed to understand Shakespeare’s history plays, the text never mentions such experts or suggests that they would enjoy the history plays more than Shakespeare’s other works.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cceb69a7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: cceb69a7

Initially observed in 2017, the interstellar object ‘Oumuamua is the first object of its kind to be seen in our solar system. Researchers have been puzzled because its acceleration cannot be entirely explained by the gravitational pull of nearby bodies: there must be a nongravitational influence on its velocity and trajectory. Some previously suggested explanations for this nongravitational acceleration involve mechanisms that are unlikely or unrealistic, such as geometric effects from ‘Oumuamua being potentially composed of several spatially separated bodies. Now, Jennifer Bergner and colleagues propose that the nongravitational acceleration is due to the gaseous expulsion of entrapped hydrogen from ‘Oumuamua’s water-rich icy body.

- Which statement, if true, would most strongly support the claim made by Bergner and colleagues about the cause of ‘Oumuamua’s acceleration?
- A. Existing proposed models of outgassing from ‘Oumuamua include the direct conversion of nitrogen or carbon monoxide from a solid to a gaseous state without becoming liquid, but these models have theoretical or observational inconsistencies.
 - B. ‘Oumuamua’s trajectory is inconsistent with a nongravitational acceleration that would be caused by the release of hydrogen gas resulting from the processing of water ice (H₂O), but the interstellar object’s observable properties can be explained if it has a significant component of molecular hydrogen ice (H₂).
 - C. Since nongravitational accelerations of interstellar objects are several orders of magnitude weaker than gravitational accelerations, deviation from behavior that could be fully attributed to gravitational pull has been detected on a limited number of objects similar to ‘Oumuamua.
 - D. Exposure to interstellar cosmic radiation can result in the formation of embedded pockets of hydrogen gas in water ice; moreover, when traveling through the solar system, ‘Oumuamua experienced warming sufficient to alter its icy structure and allow for outgassing.

ID: cceb69a7 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents findings that, if true, would support the claim made by Bergner and colleagues that the nongravitational acceleration of ‘Oumuamua is due to the expulsion of entrapped hydrogen. The text first introduces the observation of a unique interstellar object named ‘Oumuamua and goes on to explain that the object exhibited nongravitational acceleration that could not be fully attributed to the expected cause: gravitational pull of nearby celestial bodies. The text concludes by stating that Bergner and colleagues claim that the nongravitational acceleration is caused by expulsion of hydrogen gas from ‘Oumuamua’s water-rich icy body. To support this claim requires evidence that hydrogen gas could be present within ‘Oumuamua at all, which this answer choice presents: cosmic radiation can result in embedded pockets of hydrogen gas in water ice. Additionally, evidence that this gas can be released from such a body is required to fully support the claim, which this answer choice goes on to provide: ‘Oumuamua experienced sufficient warming as it traveled through the solar system to alter its icy structure and release the hydrogen gas. Thus, this answer choice provides the best evidence to support Bergner and colleagues’ claim.

Choice A is incorrect because this answer choice concerns faults with previous models of outgassing from 'Oumuamua of carbon monoxide and nitrogen, which would not support a claim regarding hydrogen outgassing. Furthermore, inconsistencies in other models would not provide evidence in support of a different model or explanation. Choice B is incorrect. The evidence presented in this answer choice would weaken the claim proposed by Bergner and colleagues that the nongravitational acceleration of 'Oumuamua is caused by the expulsion of hydrogen gas because this answer choice suggests that there is evidence that refutes this claim: 'Oumuamua's trajectory is inconsistent with a nongravitational acceleration caused by the release of hydrogen gas. Furthermore, the remaining portion of this answer choice is unrelated to the claim. Choice C is incorrect because the claim being made by Bergner and colleagues concerns the expulsion of entrapped hydrogen gas, but this answer choice is concerned solely with the differences in magnitude of gravitational and nongravitational acceleration, which would not support Bergner's claim. Furthermore, this answer choice discusses interstellar objects similar to 'Oumuamua, but the text states that 'Oumuamua is the first observed object of its kind in our solar system, so evidence from other, similar bodies would not be available.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2682b2de

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 2682b2de

In 1967 the US Congress created the Corporation for Public Broadcasting, which in turn created National Public Radio (NPR). NPR began producing and distributing high-quality news and cultural programming to affiliate stations across the United States in 1971. In a research paper, a student claims that the Corporation for Public Broadcasting and NPR were inspired by the British Broadcasting System (BBC), which had been established in the 1920s.

Which quotation from a work by a historian would be the most effective evidence for the student to include in support of this claim?

- A. "Although the BBC had begun as a private corporation, politicians successfully argued to make it a public company because they believed a public broadcaster could help build national unity in the aftermath of World War I."
- B. "For many decades, the BBC had no competition since it held Britain's only broadcasting license, whereas in the United States, the Corporation for Public Broadcasting launched NPR in a broadcasting market already filled with competitors."
- C. "Congress's embrace of publicly funded broadcasting reflected a common belief among US politicians that the role of government was not only to ensure people's safety and liberty but also to enrich people's lives in other ways."
- D. "The goal of the BBC was to support British democracy by promoting an informed citizenry, and US legislators believed that ensuring access to high-quality programming could do the same for democracy in the United States."

ID: 2682b2de Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because this quotation would be the most effective evidence to include in support of the claim that the Corporation for Public Broadcasting and NPR were inspired by the British Broadcasting System (BBC). The quotation states that the goal of the BBC was to support British democracy and that US legislators believed high-quality programming could accomplish the same goal for democracy in the United States. In other words, US legislators looked to the BBC as a model, taking direct inspiration from it when they created the Corporation for Public Broadcasting, which in turn created NPR.

Choice A is incorrect because this quotation provides historical information about the BBC, not information about the inspiration for the creation of the Corporation for Public Broadcasting and NPR. This quotation, therefore, is irrelevant to the student's claim that the BBC inspired the creation of the Corporation for Public Broadcasting, which in turn created NPR. Choice B is incorrect because this quotation contrasts the lack of competition faced by the BBC with the substantial competition faced by NPR, which has no bearing on the student's claim that the Corporation for Public Broadcasting and NPR were inspired by the BBC. Choice C is incorrect because this quotation focuses on a common belief among US politicians that inspired Congress's embrace of publicly funded broadcasting. The quotation doesn't say anything about the BBC and therefore doesn't support the claim that the BBC inspired Congress to create the Corporation for Public Broadcasting, which in turn created NPR.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 40092d6f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 40092d6f

Researchers Suchithra Rajendran and Maximilian Popfinger modeled varying levels of passenger redistribution from short-haul flights (flights of 50 to 210 minutes, from takeoff to landing) to high-speed rail trips. Planes travel faster than trains, but air travel typically requires 3 hours of lead time for security, baggage handling, and boarding that rail travel doesn’t, so short-haul routes take similar amounts of time by air and by rail. However, the model suggests that as rail passenger volumes approach current capacity limits, long lead times emerge. Therefore, for rail to remain a viable alternative to short-haul flights, _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. rail systems should offer fewer long-haul routes and airlines should offer more long-haul routes.
- B. rail systems may need to schedule additional trains for these routes.
- C. security, baggage handling, and boarding procedures used by airlines may need to be implemented for rail systems.
- D. passengers who travel by rail for these routes will need to accept that lead times will be similar to those for air travel.

ID: 40092d6f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Air travel usually requires much more “lead time” than train travel, so short flights end up taking the same amount of time as a train trip to the same destination. But train travel starts to need more “lead time” when the trains approach their capacity limits. This suggests that train companies should add more trains for these routes if they want to encourage travelers to take a train instead of a plane.

Choice A is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never discusses “long-haul routes” for either air travel or rail travel, so there is no basis to make this inference. Choice C is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text only mentions these procedures to explain why the “lead time” is so long for air travel. It never suggests that trains need to start implementing these procedures too. Choice D is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The goal is to make sure that trains “remain a viable alternative” to short flights, which suggests that anything that makes train travel take longer should be avoided.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 775716c9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 775716c9

The Household, Income and Labour Dynamics in Australia Survey (HILDA) examines trends in economic well-being among 25,000 people in Australia unfolding over many years. As is true of most longitudinal studies, this need for years of data collection results in high costs. By contrast, a relatively straightforward fitness study, such as one that is merely trying to identify the percentage of regular exercisers in a city who do weight training, may not need a large budget because _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. longitudinal methods are probably suitable for the fitness study.
- B. it would be easy for HILDA researchers to add questions to their economic well-being study.
- C. 25,000 people is more than enough for HILDA to find trends in economic well-being.
- D. the fitness study can be done well without years of data collection.

ID: 775716c9 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the costs of studies. The text indicates that HILDA is a longitudinal study—it involves repeated observations over a long time—and that the "need for years of data collection" is what causes it and most other longitudinal studies to have high costs. The text then contrasts such studies with more straightforward studies, using the example of a fitness study that wants only to find out how many regular exercisers in a particular location do weight training, that may not demand a large budget. The contrast emphasized in the text most directly suggests that the fitness study may cost less than a study like HILDA because the fitness study aims only to determine a current percentage and thus can be completed well without extending data collection over years.

Choice A is incorrect because the text explicitly introduces the idea of a less expensive, straightforward fitness study as a contrast to many longitudinal studies that, like HILDA, have high costs because they require data collection over many years. The fitness study is described as trying merely to gather information about a current behavior (how many regular exercisers do weight training) rather than track trends over time, which suggests that costs could remain low because expensive longitudinal methods would not be needed, not because they would be suitable. Choice B is incorrect because the idea that HILDA researchers could easily add questions to their study might be relevant to the costs of that survey but would be completely irrelevant as an explanation for why an unrelated fitness study may not need a large budget; the studies have no direct bearing on each other. Choice C is incorrect because the idea that HILDA involves more people than necessary would be relevant to the costs of that survey but would be completely irrelevant as an explanation for why an unrelated fitness study may not need a large budget; the studies have no direct bearing on each other.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ff58e164

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: ff58e164

Compiled in the late 1500s largely through the efforts of Indigenous scribes, *Cantares Mexicanos* is the most important collection of poetry in Classical Nahuatl, the principal language of the Aztec Empire. The poems portray Aztec society before the occupation of the empire by the army of Spain, and marginal notes in *Cantares Mexicanos* indicate that much of the collection’s content predates the initial invasion. Nonetheless, some of the poems contain inarguable references to beliefs and customs common in Spain during this era. Thus, some scholars have concluded that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. while its content largely predates the invasion, *Cantares Mexicanos* also contains additions made after the invasion.
- B. although those who compiled *Cantares Mexicanos* were fluent in Nahuatl, they had limited knowledge of the Spanish language.
- C. before the invasion by Spain, the poets of the Aztec Empire borrowed from the literary traditions of other societies.
- D. the references to beliefs and customs in Spain should be attributed to a coincidental resemblance between the societies of Spain and the Aztec Empire.

ID: ff58e164 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text. The text explains that the *Cantares Mexicanos* contains poems about the Aztec Empire from before the Spanish invasion. Furthermore, it indicates that notes in the collection attest that some of these poems predate the Spanish invasion, while some customs depicted are likely Spanish in origin. The implication is that some poems were composed before the invasion but the references to Spanish customs could have come about only after the invasion, and thus that the collection includes content that predates the invasion and also content from after the invasion.

Choice B is incorrect because the text clearly indicates that the collection is in Nahuatl, not Spanish, so the compilers’ unfamiliarity with Spanish is irrelevant to whether the collection contains material composed after the Spanish invasion. Choice C is incorrect because the text mentions only the Aztec Empire and Spain: there is no information about the relationship of Aztec literature to any traditions other than its own or Spain’s. Choice D is incorrect because the text states that some of the poems make “inarguable references” to common Spanish customs, which conflicts with the idea that these references can reasonably be attributed to mere coincidence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8ea2d570

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 8ea2d570

The fynbos shrubland is a diverse habitat found only in South Africa. It is adjacent to the Afro-temperate forest, with almost no transition space between the two distinct habitats. Plants in the fynbos have uniquely thin and long root systems that spread out over large distances to absorb nutrients from the soil. Ecologists transplanted tree seedlings from the forest into plots in the fynbos. Seedlings in plots isolated from the roots of fynbos plants exhibited a growth rate five times greater than that of the seedlings in plots in close proximity to the roots of fynbos plants.

Based on the text, what role do fynbos roots most likely have in maintaining the border between the fynbos shrubland and the Afro-temperate forest habitats?

- A. Fynbos roots damage the root systems of forest plants, leaving those plants unable to acquire sufficient nutrients.
- B. Fynbos roots extend close enough to the forest plants’ roots that they constitute a physical barrier that forest plants’ roots cannot pass.
- C. The root systems of fynbos plants allow the plants to take in so many soil nutrients that forest plants are prevented from flourishing in the fynbos.
- D. The root systems of fynbos plants enhance the soil immediately surrounding the plants, allowing them to thrive in an otherwise harsh habitat.

ID: 8ea2d570 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a conclusion about the role of fynbos roots in maintaining the border with the Afro-temperate forest that can be reasonably inferred from the text. The text states that plants in the fynbos have "uniquely thin and long root systems that spread out over large distances to absorb nutrients from the soil." The text then describes an experiment where forest tree seedlings grown in plots isolated from fynbos roots grew at a rate five times greater than seedlings in areas near fynbos roots. This strongly suggests that fynbos roots are depleting soil nutrients to such an extent that forest plants can't get enough nutrients from that soil to flourish, thereby hindering the formation of any significant "transition space" between the habitats and helping keep the border between them sharp.

Choice A is incorrect because there is no evidence in the text that fynbos roots physically damage the root systems of forest plants. Instead, the text explicitly describes fynbos plants as having "uniquely thin and long root systems that spread out over large distances to absorb nutrients from the soil." This description establishes that fynbos roots are specialized for efficient nutrient absorption. The experiment then confirms this function of the roots by showing that forest seedlings "isolated from the roots of fynbos plants exhibited a growth rate five times greater" than those near fynbos roots. This result demonstrates that when forest seedlings don't have to compete with the nutrient-absorbing fynbos roots, they grow much better. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text does indicate that the fynbos and the Afro-temperate forest are distinct from, and adjacent to, each other and that there is "almost no transition space" (area of mixed fynbos and forest plants), the experiment shows that forest

plants can grow in soil occupied by fynbos roots, just not very well. So, the idea that the fynbos roots physically obstruct forest plants is unsupported by the text. Choice D is incorrect because it directly contradicts the text's claim that fynbos roots absorb nutrients from, and therefore deplete, the soil they're in, and furthermore, nothing in the text suggests that the habitat of the fynbos is harsh in general.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fa7a2165

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: fa7a2165

Archaeologists have been debating the origin of a rare form of lead found in Shang dynasty (1766–1046 BCE) bronze artifacts since its presence was discovered in China in the 1990s. Different researchers have proposed theories on which regions of the world would have had the raw materials containing the specific lead in these artifacts, but no conclusive evidence has been presented. What is intriguing is that bronze artifacts from China dated after the Shang dynasty do not contain this form of lead, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. Shang dynasty bronze pieces are rare and therefore more valuable than those from other time periods.
- B. the source of some of the raw materials used to make bronze was exploited only until the end of the Shang dynasty.
- C. bronze was used for a short time during the Shang dynasty before different metals were used to make artifacts.
- D. methods used to analyze bronze artifacts are not useful on pieces that are dated after the Shang dynasty.

ID: fa7a2165 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The passage tells us that Shang dynasty bronze artifacts contained "a rare form of lead," but that bronze artifacts after this time did not contain that lead. Although we don't know where that specific type of bronze came from, we can conclude that that source was not used after the end of the Shang dynasty—otherwise, post-Shang dynasty pieces would also contain that rare form of lead.

Choice A is incorrect. Despite these pieces containing "a rare form of lead," there is no direct claim in the passage that Shang dynasty bronze is itself more rare or valuable than bronze pieces from other periods. Therefore, there's no basis for this inference. Choice C is incorrect. Although the passage mentions that the nature of the bronze in Chinese artifacts changed after the Shang dynasty, bronze was still used to create artifacts after this time. The passage in fact explicitly states "bronze artifacts from China dated after the Shang dynasty..." indicating that bronze was still used in China after the Shang dynasty. Choice D is incorrect. There's no mention in the passage of methods used to analyze bronze artifacts, so there's no basis for this inference.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6e366bf8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 6e366bf8

Researchers recently found that disruptions to an enjoyable experience, like a short series of advertisements during a television show, often increase viewers’ reported enjoyment. Suspecting that disruptions to an unpleasant experience would have the opposite effect, the researchers had participants listen to construction noise for 30 minutes and anticipated that those whose listening experience was frequently interrupted with short breaks of silence would thus _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. find the disruptions more irritating as time went on.
- B. rate the listening experience as more negative than those whose listening experience was uninterrupted.
- C. rate the experience of listening to construction noise as lasting for less time than it actually lasted.
- D. perceive the volume of the construction noise as growing softer over time.

ID: 6e366bf8 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. It most logically completes the text. The text tells us that disruptions to an enjoyable experience increase viewers’ enjoyment. It also says that researchers suspect the opposite is true for disruptions to an unpleasant experience. Thus, we can infer that the researchers expect to find that the interrupted unpleasant experience was worse for listeners than the uninterrupted unpleasant experience.

Choice A is incorrect. It doesn’t logically complete the text. The text never makes any claims about how irritating the disruptions themselves are perceived to be. Rather, the text says that pleasant experiences are perceived as more enjoyable with interruptions, and that the opposite is suspected to be true of unpleasant experiences. Choice C is incorrect. It doesn’t logically complete the text. The text never makes any claims about how long any experience is perceived to be. Rather, the text says that pleasant experiences are perceived as more enjoyable with interruptions, and that the opposite is suspected to be true of unpleasant experiences. Choice D is incorrect. It doesn’t logically complete the text. The text never makes any claims about how interruptions affect the perceived volume of the unpleasant or pleasant experience. Rather, the text says that pleasant experiences are perceived as more enjoyable with interruptions, and that the opposite is suspected to be true of unpleasant experiences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e988d80d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: e988d80d

Scholars have noted that F. Scott Fitzgerald’s writings were likely influenced in part by his marriage to Zelda Fitzgerald, but many don’t recognize Zelda as a writer in her own right. Indeed, Zelda authored several works herself, such as the novel *Save Me the Waltz* and numerous short stories. Thus, those who primarily view Zelda as an inspiration for F. Scott’s writings _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. overlook the many other factors that motivated F. Scott to write.
- B. risk misrepresenting the full range of Zelda’s contributions to literature.
- C. may draw inaccurate conclusions about how F. Scott and Zelda viewed each other’s works.
- D. tend to read the works of F. Scott and Zelda in an overly autobiographical light.

ID: e988d80d Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Zelda Fitzgerald’s contributions to literature. The text begins by saying that many scholars view Zelda mainly in terms of her marriage to F. Scott Fitzgerald and “don’t recognize Zelda as a writer in her own right.” The text then mentions a novel and “numerous short stories” that she wrote and that such scholars tend to ignore. Therefore, those scholars who focus on Zelda only as an inspiration for F. Scott’s writings risk misrepresenting the full range of Zelda’s contributions to literature.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text does mention that Zelda Fitzgerald “likely influenced” her husband’s literary work, its focus is on Zelda’s own writing, not on her husband’s writing or factors that might have influenced it. Choice C is incorrect because the text does not discuss F. Scott and Zelda Fitzgerald’s opinions of each other’s works. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text does suggest that F. Scott Fitzgerald’s works were “likely influenced in part” by his marriage to Zelda, it does not discuss autobiographical interpretations of the works of either F. Scott or Zelda.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0ed3fc40

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 0ed3fc40

To address the susceptibility of materials used in components of high-performance machinery, such as aircraft engines, to creep (deformation that is induced by persistent mechanical stress and that often occurs at elevated temperatures), materials researchers have developed silicon carbide (SiC) fibers for producing aerospace composites. Testing the thermomechanical properties of several commercially available SiC fibers, Ramakrishna T. Bhatt et al. found that in comparison with two polymer-derived SiC fibers, a nitrogen-treated SiC fiber exhibited a lower minimum creep rate, a measure of the rate at which a stress-exposed material deforms at a constant temperature and uniaxial load. The finding suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. unlike the two polymer-derived SiC fibers, the nitrogen-treated SiC fiber can substantially inhibit creep, provided that temperatures and loads are consistent.
- B. the two polymer-derived SiC fibers likely hold similar potential for reducing the creep resistance of materials exposed to stress and elevated temperatures, thus prolonging the life span of aerospace machinery.
- C. composites based on the two polymer-derived SiC fibers have chemical properties that may improve the mechanical and thermal stability of aerospace equipment to a greater extent than do composites based on the nitrogen-treated SiC fiber.
- D. aerospace composites containing the nitrogen-treated SiC fiber may have the ability to withstand mechanical stress for a longer period of time than can aerospace composites containing either of the two polymer-derived SiC fibers.

ID: 0ed3fc40 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of silicon carbide (SiC) fibers and creep, or deformation related to ongoing mechanical stress and elevated temperatures. The text states that Bhatt et al. found that a nitrogen-treated SiC fiber had a lower minimum creep rate than two polymer-derived SiC fibers did. Because having a lower creep rate means that the material is slower to deform with exposure to stress, as the text explains, this finding suggests that aerospace composites made with the nitrogen-treated SiC fiber may be able to withstand mechanical stress for a longer period than those made with the other two polymer-derived SiC fibers can.

Choice A is incorrect because it overstates the implications of the study’s findings, which have to do with the rate of a material’s deformation under stress, not the absolute degree of deformation. The text states that Bhatt et al. observed that a nitrogen-treated SiC fiber had a lower minimum creep rate than two polymer-derived SiC fibers did, meaning only that it deformed more slowly over time under constant stress, not that it underwent less deformation overall. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t establish any similarity between the two polymer-derived SiC fibers other than that both had a higher creep rate than the nitrogen-treated SiC fiber did in Bhatt et al.’s study. Moreover, reducing a material’s resistance to creep would mean that the material becomes *more* susceptible to deformation with exposure to stress and elevated temperatures, which would be expected to shorten rather than prolong the lifespan of machinery made with that material. Choice C is incorrect because the text suggests

that the stability of aerospace equipment may be better improved by composites containing nitrogen-treated SiC fiber than by composites containing the two polymer-derived SiC fibers, not the other way around. The text indicates that Bhatt et al. observed that the nitrogen-treated SiC fiber had a lower minimum creep rate than the other two fibers did, meaning that it was slower to degrade under exposure to mechanical stress and elevated temperatures—suggesting that it may remain stable for longer periods.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f8d0dc9c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: f8d0dc9c

In their meta-analysis of research on advergames (video games developed to promote products or services), Zeph M.C. van Berlo et al. confirm that such games, though they can elicit player interest, may not facilitate subsequent recall of product and brand information. This phenomenon can be explained by the finite nature of cognitive capacity as it is articulated in Annie Lang’s limited capacity model of motivated mediated message processing. In this case, players’ cognitive resources are directed foremost toward the advergame’s mechanics, leaving little or no capacity for encoding and storing the information the advertiser intends to be salient.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. The limited capacity model of motivated mediated message processing developed by Lang provides a means of explaining the finding by van Berlo et al. that players may not readily recollect the brand and product information embedded in advergames.
- B. Research by van Berlo et al. corroborates Lang’s conclusion that because people predominantly focus on game mechanics when playing video games, it is difficult for advergames to communicate brand and product information in ways that are highly memorable.
- C. The meta-analysis by van Berlo et al. reveals that higher engagement in advergame mechanics is linked to lower effectiveness in persuading players to purchase particular brands and products.
- D. Although the limited capacity model of motivated mediated message processing developed by Lang suggests otherwise, advergames can succeed as marketing tools, provided that they achieve a balance between game mechanics and the promotion of a brand or product.

ID: f8d0dc9c Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text begins by presenting van Berlo et al.’s finding that advergames—video games intended to promote a specific product or service—can be engaging to players but “may not facilitate subsequent recall of product and brand information,” ultimately limiting their effectiveness as advertisements. The text then suggests that Lang’s limited capacity model of motivated mediated message processing, which characterizes cognitive capacity as finite, can explain or account for van Berlo et al.’s finding: specifically, players’ attention is “directed foremost toward the advergame’s mechanics” instead of toward the advertising information. The main idea of the text is therefore that Lang’s model provides a means of explaining van Berlo et al.’s finding.

Choice B is incorrect because it mischaracterizes the relationship between Lang’s model and van Berlo et al.’s finding. The text presents Lang’s model as a broad theoretical framework about cognitive capacity that can explain van Berlo et al.’s finding. The text doesn’t indicate that Lang drew conclusions specific to video games that van Berlo et al. then corroborated. Choice C is incorrect because it mischaracterizes the findings of the meta-analysis by van Berlo et al. Although Lang’s model suggests that

engagement in advergame mechanics occurs at the expense of recalling advertising information, the text doesn't indicate that van Berlo et al. offered this explanation for their finding. The text merely states that van Berlo et al. found that advergames "can elicit player interest" but "may not facilitate subsequent recall of product and brand information." In addition, the text doesn't discuss whether players' ability to recall advertising content ultimately affects their purchasing behavior. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text presents Lang's model as an explanation of why advergames may not succeed in promoting recall of advertising information, the text doesn't suggest that advergames can succeed as marketing tools if they balance mechanics and promotion. The text doesn't propose a design solution to the limitations of advergames or suggest that these limitations can be overcome.

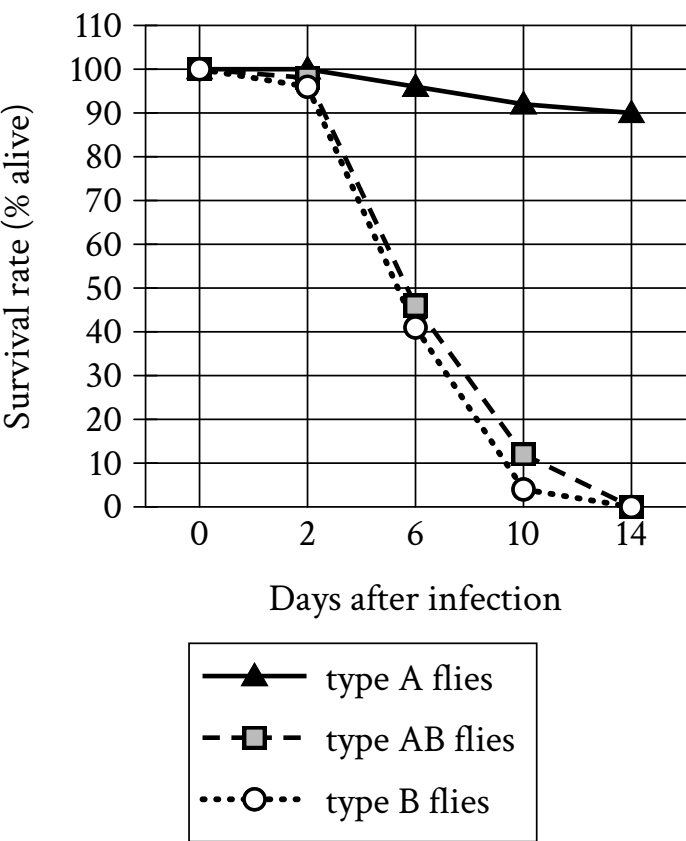
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e6974bce

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: e6974bce

Average Survival of Fruit Flies following Infection



In a study of the evolution of *DptA* and *DptB*—*Diptericin* genes encoding antimicrobial peptides that combat pathogens and foster beneficial microbes in fruit flies (*Drosophila*)—researchers assessed *Drosophila melanogaster* resistance to pathogenic infections by *Providencia rettgeri* and *Acetobacter sicerae*, bacteria common in the flies’ environments. Subjects included flies identified by mutations silencing *DptA*, *DptB*, or both *DptA* and *DptB* (termed types A, B, and AB, respectively). In conjunction with the observation that resistance to *P. rettgeri* correlates with *DptA* activity but is not significantly affected by *DptB* activity, data in the graph of survival rates post-*A. sicerae* infection suggest that _____

Which completion of the text is best supported by data in the graph?

- A. *DptA* confers defense against *A. sicerae* regardless of the presence of *DptB*.
- B. *DptB* protects against only one bacteria species, whereas *DptA* protects against multiple species.
- C. *DptB* may have developed as a specific defense against *A. sicerae*.
- D. defense against *A. sicerae* is strongest when both *DptA* and *DptB* are present.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text based on supporting data in the graph. The text indicates that in the fly *D. melanogaster*, *DptA* and *DptB* are genes that encode peptides that both fight pathogens and promote beneficial microbes. Researchers tested *D. melanogaster*'s resistance to *P. rettgeri* and *A. sicerae* bacteria based on which variation of the peptide-encoding gene the flies exhibit: *DptA* silenced (referred to as type A), *DptB* silenced (type B), or both silenced (type AB). The text also indicates that resistance to *P. rettgeri* correlates with *DptA* activity but not with *DptB* activity (which would manifest as type B flies surviving at a higher rate than other fly types when exposed to *P. rettgeri*). The graph shows the post-*A. sicerae* infection results, which indicate that *DptB* activity was most strongly associated with survival, whereas *DptA* activity was not (manifesting in the graph as the type A flies having greater survival rates than the other fly types). In other words, when *DptA* activity was silenced, the flies showed relatively high survival rates, but when *DptB* activity was silenced, whether on its own or in conjunction with *DptA* activity being silenced, survival rates were low, suggesting that *DptB* may have developed as a specific defense against *A. sicerae*.

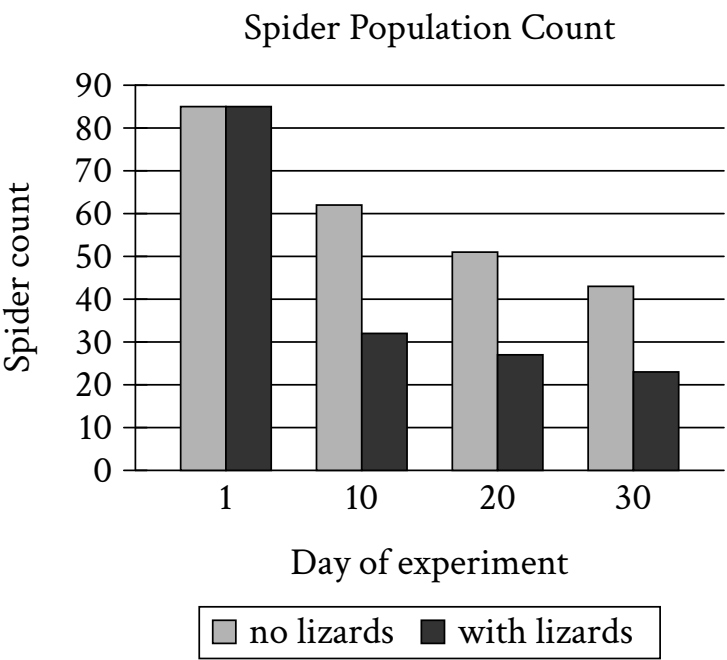
Choice A is incorrect. The graph suggests that *DptA* activity is associated with a low rate of survival, not a high one. Furthermore, the graph shows results for flies where *DptA* alone was silenced, *DptB* alone was silenced, and both were silenced and thus does not show any flies with activity in both *DptA* and *DptB*, which would be necessary to determine whether *DptA* conferred defense against *A. sicerae* in the presence of *DptB*. Choice B is incorrect. Only two bacteria species were considered in the text: *P. rettgeri* and *A. sicerae*. The text and graph taken together suggest that activity in *DptA* is associated with resistance to *P. rettgeri* while *DptB* activity is not, and that *DptB* activity is associated with resistance to *A. sicerae* while *DptA* is not. There is no further information to suggest one genetic type confers resistance to a greater number of pathogens than the other. Choice D is incorrect. The graph does not address flies with activity in both *DptA* and *DptB*. All flies represented in the graph had one or both of *DptA* and *DptB* silenced, or inactive.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 55949247

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 55949247



To investigate the effect of lizard predation on spider populations, a student in a biology class placed spiders in two enclosures, one with lizards and one without, and tracked the number of spiders in the enclosures for 30 days. The student concluded that the reduction in the spider population count in the enclosure with lizards by day 30 was entirely attributable to the presence of the lizards.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that weaken the student’s conclusion?

- A. The spider population count was the same in both enclosures on day 1.
- B. The spider population count also substantially declined by day 30 in the enclosure without lizards.
- C. The largest decline in spider population count in the enclosure with lizards occurred from day 1 to day 10.
- D. The spider population count on day 30 was lower in the enclosure with lizards than in the enclosure without lizards.

ID: 55949247 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it describes data from the graph that weaken the student’s conclusion about the reduction in the spider population in the enclosure with lizards. The graph shows that the enclosure with lizards and the enclosure without lizards each began with about 85 spiders, and that the number of spiders in each enclosure fell over the 30 days of the study. The student’s claim is that the reduction in spiders in the enclosure with lizards is “entirely attributable to the presence of the lizards,”

meaning that the spider population wouldn't have declined except for the presence of the lizards. This claim is weakened, however, by the fact that the enclosure without lizards also saw a substantial reduction in the number of spiders. Since the number of spiders fell in the enclosure without lizards as well as in the enclosure with lizards, there must be some other factor than just the presence of the lizards that contributed to the reduction in the spider population.

Choice A is incorrect because the fact that the two enclosures started with the same number of spiders is irrelevant to the claim that the reduction in spider population by day 30 in the enclosure with lizards can be entirely attributed to the lizards. Choice C is incorrect because the fact that the spider population in the enclosure with lizards fell more between days 1 and 10 than in other periods has nothing to do with the student's claim that the reduction in spiders in that enclosure by day 30 can be entirely attributed to the lizards. Choice D is incorrect. Although it's true that on day 30 the spider population was lower in the enclosure with lizards than in the enclosure without lizards, this fact doesn't weaken the student's claim that the reduction in the spider population in the enclosure with lizards can be entirely attributed to the lizards. Indeed, the lower spider population in the enclosure with lizards suggests that the lizards are contributing to the reduction in the spider population, though the fact that the spider population also fell substantially in the other enclosure means that the lizards aren't the only cause of the reduction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 38d30094

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 38d30094

One theory behind human bipedalism speculates that it originated in a mostly ground-based ancestor that practiced four-legged “knuckle-walking,” like chimpanzees and gorillas do today, and eventually evolved into moving upright on two legs. But recently, researchers observed orangutans, another relative of humans, standing on two legs on tree branches and using their arms for balance while they reached for fruits. These observations may suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. bipedalism evolved because it was advantageous to a tree-dwelling ancestor of humans.
- B. bipedalism must have evolved simultaneously with knuckle-walking and tree-climbing.
- C. moving between the ground and the trees would have been difficult without bipedalism.
- D. a knuckle-walking human ancestor could have easily moved bipedally in trees.

ID: 38d30094 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the evolution of bipedalism in humans. According to the text, one potential explanation for humans walking upright on two legs is that the behavior evolved from an ancestor that mostly stayed on the ground and walked on four limbs, as modern chimpanzees and gorillas do. However, the finding that orangutans, also a relative of humans, sometimes stand on two legs in trees while using their arms to balance and reach for fruits suggests another possible explanation: perhaps a tree-dwelling ancestor of humans began moving on two legs because it offered an advantage, such as access to certain foods.

Choice B is incorrect because the finding that modern orangutans (a relative of humans) sometimes stand on two legs in trees doesn’t offer any insight into when either bipedalism or tree-climbing behavior emerged in human ancestors. Additionally, the text indicates that one theory is that bipedalism evolved from a mostly ground-based ancestor that was already practicing knuckle-walking, not that bipedalism and knuckle-walking developed at the same time. Choice C is incorrect because the finding that orangutans (a relative of humans) sometimes stand on two legs in trees doesn’t offer any insight into how difficult it would’ve been to move between the ground and the trees without bipedalism; there’s no suggestion that climbing or moving in trees depends on the ability to walk on two legs rather than four, even if that ability might be helpful in certain circumstances. Choice D is incorrect because the finding that orangutans (a relative of humans) sometimes stand on two legs in trees doesn’t suggest that a knuckle-walking human ancestor could’ve easily moved on two legs in trees. Although the text indicates that bipedalism may have evolved from a human ancestor that mostly stayed on the ground and walked on four limbs, it gives no indication of how easy it would’ve been for such an ancestor to move bipedally in trees.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4252b950

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 4252b950

Psychologists Dacher Keltner and Jonathan Haidt have argued that experiencing awe—a sensation of reverence and wonder typically brought on by perceiving something grand or powerful—can enable us to feel more connected to others and thereby inspire us to act more altruistically. Keltner, along with Paul K. Piff, Pia Dietze, and colleagues, claims to have found evidence for this effect in a recent study where participants were asked to either gaze up at exceptionally tall trees in a nearby grove (reported to be a universally awe-inspiring experience) or stare at the exterior of a nearby, nondescript building. After one minute, an experimenter deliberately spilled a box of pens nearby.

Which finding from the researchers’ study, if true, would most strongly support their claim?

- A. Participants who had been looking at the trees helped the experimenter pick up significantly more pens than did participants who had been looking at the building.
- B. Participants who helped the experimenter pick up the pens used a greater number of positive words to describe the trees and the building in a postexperiment survey than did participants who did not help the experimenter.
- C. Participants who did not help the experimenter pick up the pens were significantly more likely to report having experienced a feeling of awe, regardless of whether they looked at the building or the trees.
- D. Participants who had been looking at the building were significantly more likely to notice that the experimenter had dropped the pens than were participants who had been looking at the trees.

ID: 4252b950 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most strongly support the researchers’ claim that they found evidence that experiencing awe can make people feel more connected to others and thus more likely to behave altruistically (with beneficial and unselfish concern for others). According to the text, the researchers tested for this effect by first having participants look at either something known to be awe-inspiring (very tall trees) or something ordinary (a plain building) and then purposely spilling pens near the participants. The finding that participants who had looked at the trees helped pick up significantly more pens than did participants who had looked at the building would support the researchers’ claim by demonstrating that the people who had experienced awe behaved more altruistically when the experimenter needed help than the other participants did.

Choice B is incorrect because a finding about helpful participants using positive words to describe the trees and the building after the experiment was over wouldn’t have any bearing on the researchers’ claim that experiencing awe increases altruistic behavior. The text doesn’t address the use of positive words to describe things or suggest any connection between using such words and having experienced awe, so that behavior wouldn’t serve as evidence that experiencing awe played a role in promoting helpful behavior. Choice C is incorrect because a finding that participants who didn’t help the experimenter were significantly more likely than others to report having experienced awe whether they had looked at the building or the trees would weaken the researchers’

claim that experiencing awe increases altruistic behavior by suggesting that the opposite might be true—that experiencing awe is in fact linked to choosing not to act in a way that benefits someone else. Choice D is incorrect because a finding about participants noticing that the experimenter had dropped the pens wouldn't have any bearing on the researchers' claim about people behaving altruistically. Being aware of a challenge or problem isn't necessarily beneficial on its own and isn't the same as offering help, so the finding wouldn't support the idea that experiencing awe increases altruistic behavior.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a2d63490

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: a2d63490

In her 1998 book *Blues Legacies and Black Feminism*, Angela Y. Davis bases her analysis in part on recordings of songs sung in the 1920s by Gertrude “Ma” Rainey and Bessie Smith. Davis focuses on how Rainey and Smith improvised the lyrics—replacing the original lines with mischievous jokes and wordplay. Davis’s work was particularly labor intensive because in order to transcribe, or write down, the lyrics as Rainey and Smith sang them, Davis had to listen repeatedly to the vinyl recordings, which weren’t very clear.

What does the text most strongly suggest about the songs sung by Rainey and Smith?

- A. The songs have grown in popularity since Rainey and Smith first sang them.
- B. There were more recordings made of Rainey’s songs than there were of Smith’s.
- C. There were few, if any, reliable transcriptions of Smith’s and Rainey’s improvised lyrics when Davis began her research.
- D. According to Davis, the songs sung by Rainey were more musically innovative than those sung by Smith typically were.

ID: a2d63490 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it describes the songs sung by Gertrude "Ma" Rainey and Bessie Smith in a way the text implies is accurate. The text describes Angela Y. Davis’s research on Rainey and Smith for her book *Blues Legacies and Black Feminism*, focusing on her efforts to transcribe the improvised lyrics in Rainey’s and Smith’s songs. The text calls Davis’s transcription process "labor intensive" since the lack of clarity in the recordings required her to listen to each repeatedly to verify the accuracy of her transcripts. The fact that Davis undertook a painstaking transcription process using only fairly low-fidelity recordings suggests that reliable transcriptions were otherwise unavailable to her.

Choice A is incorrect. The text doesn’t discuss the popularity of Rainey’s and Smith’s songs either in the 1920s or after. Although it is plausible that the music of Rainey and Smith is more widely enjoyed than it was in the 1920s, this isn’t supported by the text. Choice B is incorrect. The text doesn’t discuss which of Rainey and Smith was the more prolific recording artist and so provides no support for such a claim. Choice D is incorrect. The text discusses the creativity of both Rainey and Smith, but it does so only to note similarities between them in terms of improvisation and wit, not to emphasize differences between them or Davis’s relative views of the artists’ inventiveness.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cf92ac3a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: cf92ac3a

In a study of the cognitive abilities of white-faced capuchin monkeys (*Cebus imitator*), researchers neglected to control for the physical difficulty of the tasks they used to evaluate the monkeys. The cognitive abilities of monkeys given problems requiring little dexterity, such as sliding a panel to retrieve food, were judged by the same criteria as were those of monkeys given physically demanding problems, such as unscrewing a bottle and inserting a straw. The results of the study, therefore, _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. could suggest that there are differences in cognitive ability among the monkeys even though such differences may not actually exist.
- B. are useful for identifying tasks that the monkeys lack the cognitive capacity to perform but not for identifying tasks that the monkeys can perform.
- C. should not be taken as indicative of the cognitive abilities of any monkey species other than *C. imitator*.
- D. reveal more about the monkeys’ cognitive abilities when solving artificial problems than when solving problems encountered in the wild.

ID: cf92ac3a Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of the study of capuchin monkeys’ cognitive abilities. The text explains that the study failed to distinguish between outcomes for the tasks performed by the capuchin monkeys, such that simpler tasks requiring less dexterity, or skill, were judged by the same criteria as tasks that demanded more dexterity. Because the study didn’t account for this discrepancy, the researchers might have assumed that observed differences in performance were due to the abilities of the monkeys rather than the complexity of the tasks. In other words, the results may suggest cognitive differences among the monkeys even though such differences may not really exist.

Choice B is incorrect because the text focuses on the fact that the tasks assigned to the capuchin monkeys in the study varied in difficulty and that the variety wasn’t taken into consideration. The text doesn’t suggest that the capuchin monkeys couldn’t perform certain tasks, just that some tasks were more difficult to do. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the study’s results are indicative of the abilities of capuchin monkeys but not of other monkey species; in fact, the text suggests that the results may not even be an accurate reflection of capuchin monkeys’ abilities. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that the researchers compared results for artificial tasks with those for tasks encountered in the wild, although the tasks described in the text—sliding a panel and putting a straw in a bottle—are presumably artificial.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c465c636

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: c465c636

In 2022, Crystal Reeck and colleagues studied whether the decision-making modes that guide consumers influence their choice between nonenvironmentally friendly standard electricity plans and environmentally friendly green plans that cap electricity usage. Study participants who self-reported using either an Affect Mode or Role Mode—which prioritize choices that have a stronger positive emotional or social impact, respectively—were more likely to select a green plan. Conversely, participants using a Calculation Mode—which aims to minimize both financial cost and personal inconvenience—were more likely to select a standard plan, even when the green option was cheaper. This finding suggests that participants using a Calculation Mode _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. were equally unlikely to factor the financial savings of the green plan into their decision-making as were participants using either the Affect or Role Modes.
- B. may have been less strongly motivated to appear socially responsible with their choice of plan than they realized.
- C. may have determined that the green plan imposed additional burdens on them that were not sufficiently offset by the potential financial savings.
- D. were less likely to believe that the green plan was truly cost-effective than were participants using either the Affect or Role Modes.

ID: c465c636 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the influence of decision-making modes on consumers’ choices of different electricity plans. The Affect Mode describes choices based on the decision-maker’s preferred emotional outcome, the Role Mode describes choices based on the decision-maker’s social motivations, and the Calculation Mode describes choices based on minimizing financial costs and maximizing the decision-maker’s convenience. Thus, if those using a Calculation Mode disfavor the green plan, it would be due to some financial or convenience burden the green plan imposes that the other doesn’t. The text indicates that the green plan had a lower financial cost but was nonetheless rejected by participants using the Calculation Mode. It therefore follows that the green plan likely imposed a convenience burden that outweighed potential financial savings for these participants.

Choice A is incorrect. According to the text, the Affect Mode involves the decision-maker’s preferred emotional outcome, the Role Mode involves social motivations, and the Calculation Mode is oriented toward minimizing financial costs and maximizing the decision-maker’s convenience. Thus, unlike the Affect or Role Modes, the Calculation Mode would almost certainly involve taking price differences into account. Choice B is incorrect. According to the text, the Affect Mode involves the decision-maker’s preferred emotional outcome, the Role Mode involves social motivations, and the Calculation Mode is oriented toward minimizing financial costs and maximizing the decision-maker’s convenience. Thus, there is no reason to think that participants using the Calculation Mode at any point took social responsibility into account, let alone think that they discovered a disparity between their

expectations and reality. Choice D is incorrect. According to the text, the Affect Mode involves the decision-maker's preferred emotional outcome, the Role Mode involves social motivations, and the Calculation Mode is oriented toward minimizing financial costs and maximizing the decision-maker's convenience. Thus, the text doesn't indicate that cost-effectiveness is a factor for participants using the Affect or Role Modes, and there is no basis to compare their beliefs in the truthfulness of the green-plan description with those of the Calculation Mode users.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID de91be7b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: de91be7b

Land Area Covered by Native Flowering Plants at a Site in Antarctica

Species	Area covered in 2009 (in square meters)	Area covered in 2018 (in square meters)	Percent increase in area covered from 2009 to 2018
<i>Deschampsia antarctica</i>	1,230	1,576	28%
<i>Colobanthus quitensis</i>	6.9	10.7	55%

The only flowering plant species native to Antarctica, *Colobanthus quitensis* and *Deschampsia antarctica* grow in places where the earth remains free of ice for much of the year. Botanist Niccoletta Cannone wondered how the warming of Antarctica’s climate in recent years had affected these species, so she visited a site in Antarctica, first in 2009 and later in 2018, to count the number of plants growing there. Cannone found that the area of land covered by the two species had significantly expanded during the nine-year period. While both species likely benefited from warming temperatures, *Colobanthus quitensis* _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the comparison?

- A. suppressed the growth of *Deschampsia antarctica*, which covered a smaller area of land in 2018 than it had in 2009.
- B. saw a greater expansion than *Deschampsia antarctica* did, increasing the area of land it covered by more than half.
- C. showed a greater increase in the average size of individual plants than *Deschampsia antarctica* did.
- D. covered land newly freed from ice at a rate 55% faster than that of *Deschampsia antarctica*.

ID: de91be7b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the table to complete the comparison of how *Colobanthus quitensis* benefited from warming temperatures with how *Deschampsia antarctica* benefited from them. The table shows the land area covered by these two plant species at a site in Antarctica. According to the table, *Colobanthus quitensis* increased the area it covered by 55% from 2009 to 2018, whereas *Deschampsia antarctica* increased the area it covered by 28% during the same period. It therefore follows that *Colobanthus quitensis* saw a greater expansion than *Deschampsia antarctica* did and that *Colobanthus quitensis* increased the area of land it covered by more than half.

Choice A is incorrect because according to the table, *Deschampsia antarctica* covered 1,230 square meters of land in 2009 and 1,576 square meters of land in 2018. *Deschampsia antarctica* therefore covered a larger, not a smaller, area of land in 2018 than in 2009. Moreover, there’s no information in the text or the table that suggests that one species of the plant suppressed the other. Choice C is incorrect because it inaccurately describes the data in the table. The table shows the land area covered by

Colobanthus quitensis and *Deschampsia antarctica* and the percent increase in area covered by the two species from 2009 to 2018, not the average size of individual plants belonging to the two species. The data in the table therefore can't be used to make a comparison of the increase in individual plants' average size. Choice D is incorrect because the table shows the land area covered by *Colobanthus quitensis* and *Deschampsia antarctica* and the percent increase in area covered by the two species from 2009 to 2018, not the rate at which the species increased the area they covered. Moreover, there's nothing in the table or the text that suggests that the areas covered by the two species were newly freed from ice.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7a81af3c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 7a81af3c

Jan Gimsa, Robert Sleigh, and Ulrike Gimsa have hypothesized that the sail-like structure running down the back of the dinosaur *Spinosaurus aegyptiacus* improved the animal’s success in underwater pursuits of prey species capable of making quick, evasive movements. To evaluate their hypothesis, a second team of researchers constructed two battery-powered mechanical models of *S. aegyptiacus*, one with a sail and one without, and subjected the models to a series of identical tests in a water-filled tank.

- Which finding from the model tests, if true, would most strongly support Gimsa and colleagues’ hypothesis?
- A. The model with a sail took significantly less time to complete a sharp turn while submerged than the model without a sail did.
 - B. The model with a sail displaced significantly more water while submerged than the model without a sail did.
 - C. The model with a sail had significantly less battery power remaining after completing the tests than the model without a sail did.
 - D. The model with a sail took significantly longer to travel a specified distance while submerged than the model without a sail did.

ID: 7a81af3c Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This finding would most strongly support the hypothesis. The hypothesis is that the sail improved the dinosaur’s ability to chase quick, evasive prey. This finding suggests that the sail helped the dinosaur make sharp turns more quickly, which supports that hypothesis.

Choice B is incorrect. This finding wouldn’t necessarily support the hypothesis. The hypothesis is that the sail improved the dinosaur’s ability to chase quick, evasive prey. It’s unclear how the sail displacing more water would relate to that hypothesis—it doesn’t seem to be relevant. Choice C is incorrect. This finding wouldn’t necessarily support the hypothesis. The hypothesis is that the sail improved the dinosaur’s ability to chase quick, evasive prey. It’s unclear how the difference in battery power between the models would relate to that hypothesis—it doesn’t seem to be relevant. Choice D is incorrect. This finding would actually weaken the hypothesis. The hypothesis is that the sail improved the dinosaur’s ability to chase quick, evasive prey. This finding suggests that the sail slowed the dinosaur down—which would probably make it worse at catching quick, evasive prey.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c88583a4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: c88583a4

Percentage of Available Eggs Eaten by Cane Toad Tadpoles

Amphibian species (common name)	Percentage of eggs eaten	Native to Australia	Produces bufadienolide
Little red tree frog	1%	yes	no
Cane toad	90%	no	yes
Short-footed frog	7%	yes	no
Striped burrowing frog	10%	yes	no
Dainty green tree frog	1%	yes	no

Native to Latin America, the cane toad was introduced to Australia in the 1930s. In recent decades, tadpoles in the Australian population have been shown to consume eggs of their own species. A 2022 study showed that when presented with cane toad eggs as well as eggs of native Australian amphibians, cane toad tadpoles disproportionately consumed eggs of their own species. This behavior results from their attraction to bufadienolide, a chemical produced by the eggs of cane toads but not by the eggs of native amphibians. However, using data from this study, a student wishes to argue that the presence of bufadienolide doesn't entirely explain the cane toad tadpoles' preference for certain eggs over others.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support the student's argument?

- A. The tadpoles consumed a higher percentage of the striped burrowing frog eggs than they did of the eggs of the dainty green tree frog.
- B. The tadpoles left a certain percentage of the eggs of each of the five species unharmed, thus ultimately allowing them to hatch.
- C. The tadpoles consumed a lower percentage of the short-footed frog eggs than they did of the eggs of their own species.
- D. The tadpoles consumed the same percentage of the dainty green tree frog eggs as they did of the little red tree frog eggs.

ID: c88583a4 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the table to support the student's argument about the role of bufadienolide in the egg preferences of cane toad tadpoles. For each of five amphibian species included in the 2022 study, the table gives the percentage of available eggs that the cane toad tadpoles ate. According to the table, the tadpoles ate 10% of striped burrowing frog eggs and 1% of dainty green tree frog eggs, which suggests a preference for striped burrowing frog eggs over dainty green tree frog eggs. The table also indicates that neither of these species' eggs produces bufadienolide. Thus, these data suggest that something other than the presence or absence of bufadienolide is needed to adequately explain the tadpoles' egg preferences.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the table shows that for each of the five amphibian species, the cane toad tadpoles ate less than 100% of that species' eggs, which demonstrates that the tadpoles did indeed leave some eggs for each species unharmed, this fact alone is irrelevant to the tadpoles' preferences for some species' eggs over other species' eggs. Choice C is incorrect. Although the table indicates that the cane toad tadpoles ate 90% of the cane toad eggs and 7% of the short-footed frog eggs, which suggests that they prefer cane toad eggs over short-footed frog eggs, the table also indicates that cane toad eggs produce bufadienolide, whereas short-footed frog eggs do not. Therefore, these data are not sufficient to exclude that bufadienolide alone could explain the tadpoles' preference for some species' eggs over other species' eggs. Choice D is incorrect. Although the table shows that for both dainty green tree frog eggs and little red tree frog eggs, the cane toad tadpoles ate 1% of those species' eggs, it also indicates that neither produces bufadienolide. Thus, these data alone don't indicate bufadienolide's role in the tadpoles' egg preferences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2bedb5ca

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 2bedb5ca

A student performs an experiment testing her hypothesis that a slightly acidic soil environment is more beneficial for the growth of the plant *Brassica rapa parachinensis* (a vegetable commonly known as choy sum) than a neutral soil environment. She plants sixteen seeds of choy sum in a mixture of equal amounts of coffee grounds (which are highly acidic) and potting soil and another sixteen seeds in potting soil without coffee grounds as the control for the experiment. The two groups of seeds were exposed to the same growing conditions and monitored for three weeks.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the student’s hypothesis?

- A. The choy sum planted in the soil without coffee grounds were significantly taller at the end of the experiment than the choy sum planted in the mixture of soil and coffee grounds.
- B. The choy sum grown in the soil without coffee grounds weighed significantly less at the end of the experiment than the choy sum grown in the mixture of soil and coffee grounds.
- C. The choy sum seeds planted in the soil without coffee grounds sprouted significantly later in the experiment than did the seeds planted in the mixture of soil and coffee grounds.
- D. Significantly fewer of the choy sum seeds planted in the soil without coffee grounds sprouted plants than did the seeds planted in the mixture of soil and coffee grounds.

ID: 2bedb5ca Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it describes an experimental outcome that would most directly weaken the student’s hypothesis. According to the text, the student hypothesizes that *Brassica rapa parachinensis* (choy sum) will benefit more from acidic soil than it will from neutral soil. The text then explains that the student planted 16 choy sum seeds in potting soil with coffee grounds added to increase acidity and another 16 seeds in soil without coffee grounds as a control (a group identical to the experimental group except for the experimental modification being tested). If the hypothesis were correct, the plants in the more acidic soil-and-coffee-grounds mixture would grow faster than those in the control group. However, choice A proposes a scenario in which the plants in soil without coffee grounds were “significantly taller” than those in the more acidic mixture—an outcome that weakens the hypothesis that higher acidity is beneficial to the plants’ growth.

Choice B is incorrect. If the choy sum planted in the neutral soil produced less plant matter and therefore weighed less than the choy sum planted in the acidic soil-and-coffee-grounds mixture, this finding would strengthen the student’s hypothesis, not weaken it. Choice C is incorrect. If seeds planted in neutral soil (without coffee grounds) sprouted significantly later than seeds planted in the acidic soil-and-coffee-grounds mixture, this finding would strengthen, not weaken, the student’s hypothesis that acidic soil benefits choy sum. Choice D is incorrect. If seeds planted in the neutral soil (without coffee grounds) sprouted significantly fewer plants than seeds planted in the acidic soil-and-coffee-grounds mixture did, this finding would strengthen, not weaken, the student’s hypothesis that choy sum benefits from acidic soil.

Question ID e994ae01

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: e994ae01

The Post Office is a 1912 play by Rabindranath Tagore, originally written in Bengali. The character Amal is a young boy who imagines that the people he sees passing the window of his home are carefree even when engaged in work or chores, as is evident when he says to the daughter of a flower seller, _____

Which quotation from *The Post Office* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. "I see, you don't wish to stop; I don't care to stay on here either."
- B. "Oh, flower gathering? That is why your feet seem so glad and your anklets jingle so merrily as you walk."
- C. "I'll pay when I grow up—before I leave to look for work out on the other side of that stream there."
- D. "Wish I could be out too. Then I would pick some flowers for you from the very topmost branches right out of sight."

ID: e994ae01 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most effectively illustrates the claim that Amal imagines the people he sees are carefree even when engaged in work. In the quotation, Amal observes that the flower seller's daughter is "flower gathering," or working, as the text indicates. Moreover, Amal notes that the daughter's feet "seem so glad" and her "anklets jingle so merrily," suggesting that Amal believes that the flower seller's daughter is cheerful.

Choice A is incorrect because the quotation makes no observation about the cheerful mood of the flower seller's daughter. Choice C is incorrect because the quotation discusses how Amal envisions his future, not the feelings of the flower seller's daughter. Choice D is incorrect because the quotation discusses Amal's wishes, not the feelings of the flower seller's daughter.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4811f361

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 4811f361

Juvenile Plants Found Growing on Bare Ground and in Patches of Vegetation for Five Species

Species	Bare ground	Patches of vegetation	Total	Percent found in patches of vegetation
<i>T. moroderi</i>	9	13	22	59.1%
<i>T. libanitis</i>	83	120	203	59.1%
<i>H. syriacim</i>	95	106	201	52.7%
<i>H. squamatum</i>	218	321	539	59.6%
<i>H. stoechas</i>	11	12	23	52.2%

Alicia Montesinos-Navarro, Isabelle Storer, and Rocío Perez-Barrales recently examined several plots within a diverse plant community in southeast Spain. The researchers calculated that if individual plants were randomly distributed on this particular landscape, only about 15% would be with other plants in patches of vegetation. They counted the number of juvenile plants of five species growing in patches of vegetation and the number growing alone on bare ground and compared those numbers to what would be expected if the plants were randomly distributed. Based on these results, they claim that plants of these species that grow in close proximity to other plants gain an advantage at an early developmental stage.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support the researchers’ claim?

- A. For all five species, less than 75% of juvenile plants were growing in patches of vegetation.
- B. The species with the greatest number of juvenile plants growing in patches of vegetation was *H. stoechas*.
- C. For *T. libanitis* and *T. moroderi*, the percentage of juvenile plants growing in patches of vegetation was less than what would be expected if plants were randomly distributed.
- D. For each species, the percentage of juvenile plants growing in patches of vegetation was substantially higher than what would be expected if plants were randomly distributed.

ID: 4811f361 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it provides the most direct support from the table for the claim that the plants growing in close proximity to other plants gained an advantage at an early developmental stage. The table shows the total number of juvenile plants from five species that were found growing on bare ground and in patches of vegetation as well as the percentage of the total number of each species that were growing in patches of vegetation. For each of the five species, more than 50% of the juvenile plants were growing in patches of vegetation. The text notes, however, that a random distribution of plants across the landscape should result in only about 15% of the plants being found in patches of vegetation. In other words, for each of the five species, the percentage of juvenile plants found growing in patches of vegetation was substantially higher than could be

explained by chance alone. This finding supports the claim in the text: if plants growing in patches are overrepresented among plants that have survived to the juvenile stage, as the data show they are, then it suggests that it's advantageous for plants at an early stage of development to grow in patches of vegetation.

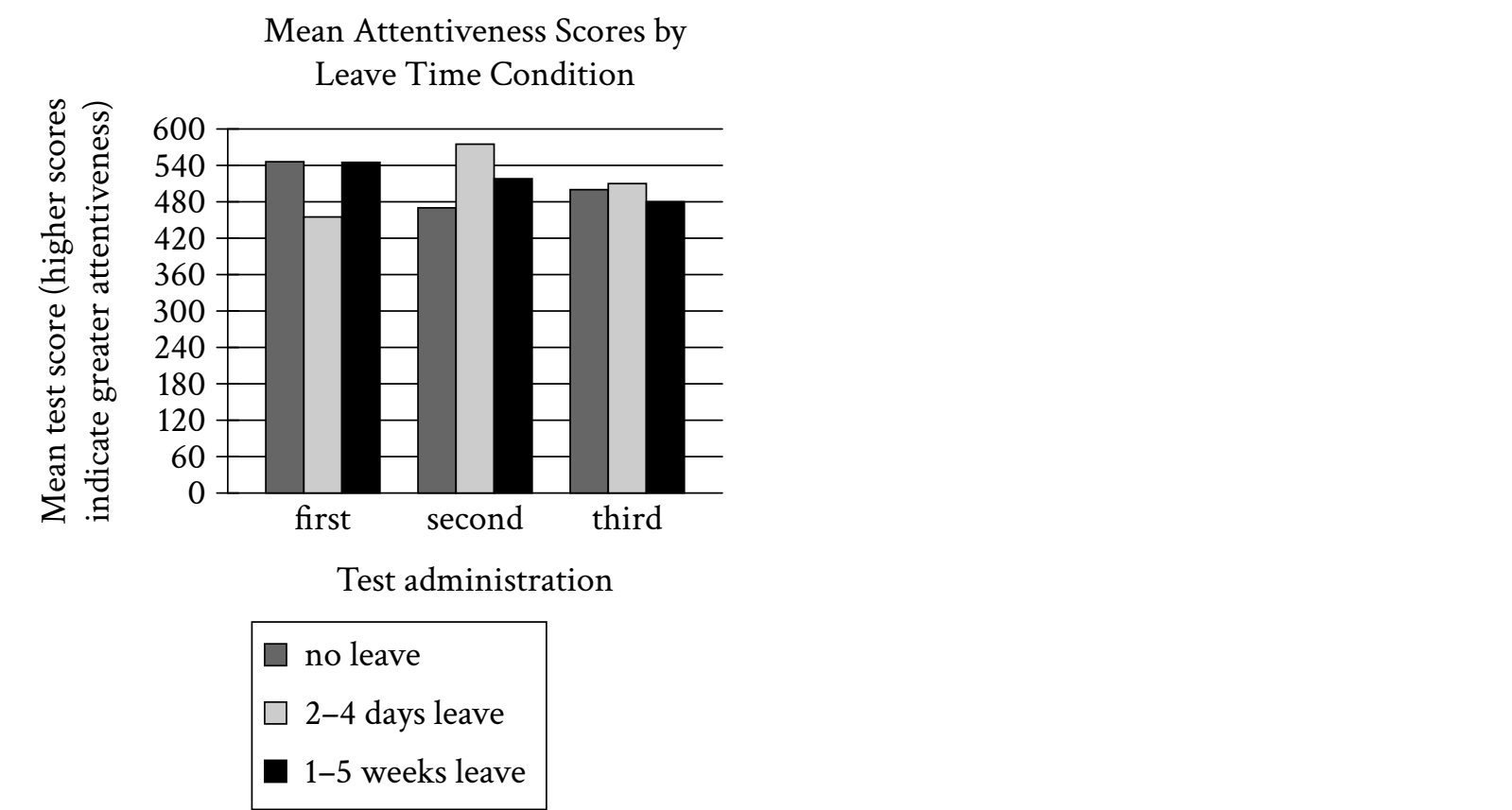
Choice A is incorrect because the statement that less than 75% of juvenile plants were found growing in patches of vegetation, while true, doesn't clearly support the claim that the plants growing in close proximity to other plants gained an advantage at an early developmental stage. Saying that less than 75% of plants were found in patches doesn't indicate how the percentage growing in patches compares with the percentage that would be expected to grow in patches on the basis of chance alone, which is the information necessary to evaluate whether the claim in the text has support in the table. Put another way, if the percentage of plants found growing in patches was 15% or less, it would be true that less than 75% were found in patches, but the data would in fact weaken the claim in the text, not strengthen it, since the data would show that growing in patches wasn't advantageous. Choice B is incorrect because only 12 plants of this species were found growing in patches, which was the lowest number of any species, not the greatest number. Additionally, even if it were true that this species had the greatest number of plants growing in patches, the finding would be irrelevant to the claim that plants of all five species gained an advantage by growing in close proximity to other plants. Choice C is incorrect because 59.1% of the plants of these species were found growing in patches, which is a far greater percentage, not a lower percentage, than what would be expected if plants were randomly distributed (around 15%). Additionally, if it were true that the percentage of plants growing in patches was lower for these species than what would be expected from chance alone, that finding would weaken, not strengthen, the claim that growing in patches is advantageous.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 20762e01

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 20762e01



To investigate potential cognitive benefits of taking leave from work, psychologist Jan Packer and colleagues conducted a six-month study of Australian university staff members who took no leave from work during the study, took 2–4 days of leave, or took 1–5 weeks of leave. Tests of attentiveness were administered to participants three times during the study: at random for the no-leave staff, and for the rest, one week before their leave, one week following their return to work, and one week after the second test administration. After analyzing the results, the researchers concluded that longer leave times might not confer a greater cognitive benefit than shorter leave times do.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that support the researchers’ conclusion?

- A. In the second test administration, participants who took 2–4 days of leave had higher average attentiveness scores than did those who took no leave, but in the third test administration, those who took no leave had higher average scores than those who took 1–5 weeks of leave.
- B. In the first test administration, participants who took 2–4 days of leave had lower average attentiveness scores than did those who took 1–5 weeks of leave and those who took no leave.
- C. In both the second and third test administrations, participants who took 2–4 days of leave had higher average attentiveness scores than did participants who took 1–5 weeks of leave.

D. In the second and third test administrations, participants who took 2–4 days of leave had higher average attentiveness scores than did those who took no leave.

ID: 20762e01 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it describes data from the graph that support Jan Packer and colleagues' conclusion about the effect of leave time on the attentiveness of university employees. According to the text, the researchers' study design included a group of employees who took no leave, a group who took 2–4 days of leave, and a group who took 1–5 weeks of leave. The participants who took leave were tested for attentiveness one week before their leave (the first test administration), one week after their return to work (the second test administration), and two weeks after their return (the third test administration). The participants who took no leave were tested three times at random. The graph shows that at one week after their return to work, participants who took only 2–4 days of leave had an average attentiveness score of between 540 and 600, while participants who took 1–5 weeks of leave had an average score of between 480 and 540. At two weeks after their return to work, those who took only 2–4 days of leave had an average score of between 480 and 540, while those who took 1–5 weeks of leave had an average score of approximately 480. In other words, the graph shows that on both post-leave testing dates, participants with longer leave times had lower average attentiveness scores than those with shorter leave times. Since attentiveness is an indicator of cognitive functioning, these data confirm Packer and colleagues' conclusion that longer leave times might not confer a greater cognitive benefit than shorter leave times do.

Choice A is incorrect. The graph does show that in the second test administration, participants who took 2–4 days of leave had higher average attentiveness scores than did those who took no leave and also shows that in the third test administration, those who took no leave had higher average scores than those who took 1–5 weeks of leave. But neither of these findings has a direct bearing on the researchers' conclusion, which concerns a comparison of participants who took 2–4 days of leave with those who took 1–5 weeks, rather than a comparison of either group with participants who took no leave. Choice B is incorrect. Although the graph does show that in the first test administration, participants who took 2–4 days of leave had lower average attentiveness scores than did those who took 1–5 weeks of leave and those who took no leave, this test administration occurred before any participants went on leave; therefore, these results have no bearing on the researchers' conclusion about how the amount of leave taken by participants affected their cognitive functioning. Choice D is incorrect. Although the graph does show that in the second and third test administrations, participants who took 2–4 days of leave had higher average attentiveness scores than did those who took no leave, the researchers' conclusion is about the effects of short leave compared with the effects of long leave, not the effects of short leave compared with the effects of no leave. These results are therefore irrelevant to the conclusion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cbe8a89c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: cbe8a89c

German theater practitioner Bertolt Brecht (1898–1956) believed that theater should elicit an intellectual rather than an emotional response from audiences, provoking them to consider social and political realities that extend beyond the characters and events depicted onstage. Brecht’s influence can be seen in English playwright Caryl Churchill’s 1979 play *Cloud 9*: although the play sometimes invites empathetic reactions, it primarily works to engage audiences in an interrogation of patriarchy and colonialism, which it does by placing audiences at a distance, thereby encouraging them to _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. focus on the characters’ beliefs about social and political issues as revealed by the characters’ actions.
- B. reflect on social and political phenomena not directly related to patriarchy and colonialism.
- C. recognize pertinent social and political parallels between Germany during Brecht’s time and England at the time when Churchill was writing *Cloud 9*.
- D. be dispassionate as they think critically about the social and political questions raised by the play.

ID: cbe8a89c Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Churchill’s play was influenced by Brecht’s belief that theater should elicit an intellectual rather than an emotional response from audiences, making them think about social and political issues that also exist outside of the play. Therefore, it makes sense that Churchill would strive to have audiences think dispassionately (i.e., without emotion) and critically about the social and political questions raised by the play.

Choice A is incorrect. The passage mentions that Churchill was influenced by Brecht’s belief that plays should provoke audience members “to consider social and political realities that extend beyond the characters and events depicted onstage,” so there’s no basis for an inference about audience members deeply engaging with characters’ beliefs and actions. Choice B is incorrect. Reflecting on things that aren’t related to patriarchy and colonialism wouldn’t “engage audiences in an interrogation of patriarchy and colonialism.” That creates a confusing contradiction. Choice C is incorrect. No mention is made of social and political issues in Germany during Brecht’s time, so there’s no basis for this inference.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a3f08545

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a3f08545

Correlations Between Congestion Ratings and Features of the Crowd in Raters’ Immediate Vicinity

Crowd feature	Before obstacle	After obstacle	Overall
Density	0.8592	0.7308	0.7447
Velocity	-0.9357	-0.9518	-0.8587

Researcher Xiaolu Jia and colleagues monitored individuals’ velocity and the surrounding crowd density as a group of study participants walked through a space and navigated around an obstacle. Participants rated how congested it seemed before the obstacle, after the obstacle, and overall, and the researchers correlated those ratings with velocity and density. (Correlations range from -1 to 1, with greater distance from 0 indicating greater strength). The researchers concluded that the correlations with velocity are stronger than those with density.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support the researchers’ conclusion?

- A. The correlation between congestion ratings before the obstacle and density is further from 0 than the correlation between overall congestion rating and velocity is.
- B. The correlation between congestion ratings before the obstacle and velocity is further from 0 than the correlation between congestion overall and velocity is.
- C. For each of the three ratings, the correlation with velocity is negative while the correlation with density is positive.
- D. For each of the three ratings, correlations with velocity are further from 0 than the corresponding correlations with density are.

ID: a3f08545 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

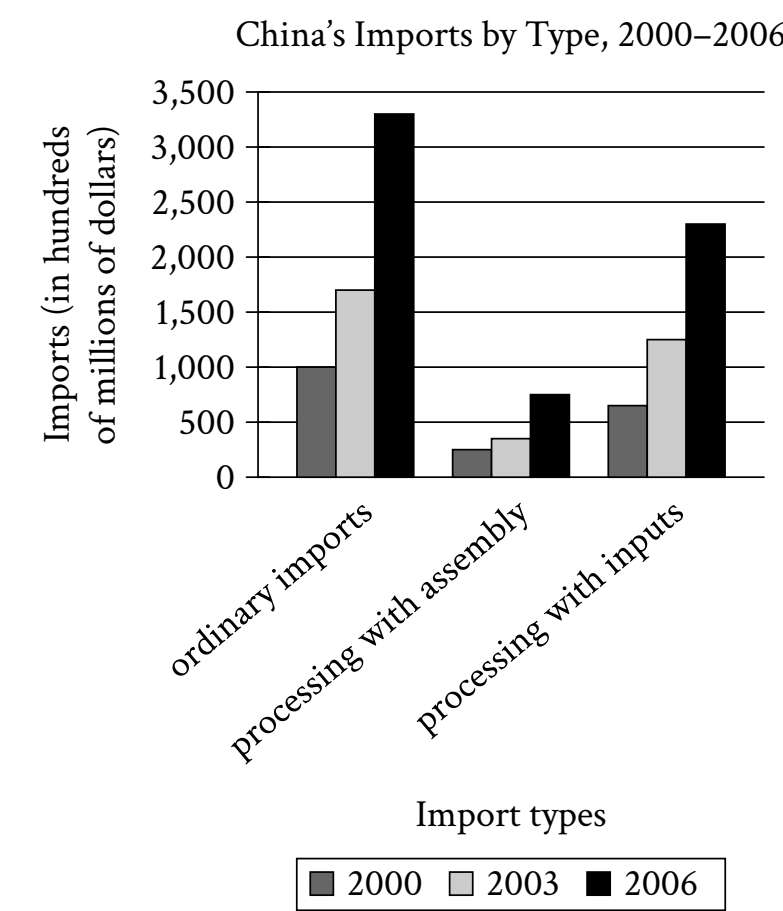
Choice D is the best answer. The text tells us that the farther the correlation is from 0, the “stronger” it is (doesn’t matter if it’s negative or positive). The table shows that the correlations with velocity are farther from zero than the correlations with density, which supports the conclusion that the correlations with velocity are stronger.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the conclusion. It makes an “apples to oranges” comparison by comparing density and velocity correlations across features instead of comparing them for each feature. Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the conclusion. It doesn’t include the density correlations for comparison. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the conclusion. The text tells us that the farther the correlation is from 0, the “stronger” it is: it doesn’t matter for “strength” whether it’s negative or positive.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: da397c6c



A student is researching the Chinese government’s 1992 shift to a market economy that emphasizes trade liberalization. One means of trade liberalization involves expanding from ordinary imports into an emphasis on processing imports, which have two types: processing with assembly (in which a firm obtains raw materials from a foreign trading partner without payment and sells the final goods to that partner, charging for assembly) and processing with inputs (in which a firm expends capital to buy raw materials from a trading partner, processes them into final goods, and sells those goods to whichever trading partner it chooses). The student asserts that while initial efforts at trade liberalization were shaped by Chinese firms’ limited capital, this situation resolved during the 2000s.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that support the student’s assertion?

- A. Processing imports with inputs were greater than both ordinary imports and processing imports with assembly in 2006.
- B. From 2000 to 2006, processing imports with inputs rose much more sharply than processing imports with assembly did.
- C. From 2000 to 2006, neither processing imports with inputs nor processing imports with assembly were greater than ordinary imports.
- D. Processing imports with assembly were greater in 2006 than processing imports with inputs in 2000.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it describes data from the graph that best support the student's assertion that initial efforts at trade liberalization in China were shaped by firms having limited capital (assets available for use) and that this situation resolved during the 2000s. The text explains that an approach to trade liberalization involves engaging in processing imports, one type of which doesn't require payment to a trade partner (processing with assembly) and one type of which requires upfront payment to a trade partner for raw materials (processing with inputs). The graph, which presents China's imports for ordinary imports and both types of processing imports in the years 2000, 2003, and 2006, shows that while processing imports with assembly rose from about 250 hundred million dollars in 2000 to about 750 hundred million dollars in 2006, processing imports with inputs rose much more sharply, increasing from approximately 650 hundred million dollars in 2000 to about 2,300 hundred million dollars in 2006. Because processing with inputs requires firms to pay for materials (expending capital) and processing with assembly doesn't, the sharper rise in processing imports with inputs suggests that Chinese firms' assets—and thus their ability to engage in that type of processing imports—were relatively limited in (and before) 2000 and then substantially increased from 2000 to 2006. In other words, the data suggest that the situation of having limited capital resolved during the 2000s.

Choice A is incorrect because the graph indicates that ordinary imports were greater than both types of processing imports in 2006, not that processing imports with inputs were greater than ordinary imports and processing imports with assembly that year. Choice C is incorrect because the observation that ordinary imports were greater than both types of processing imports in 2000, 2003, and 2006 doesn't address a change within any type of imports from 2000 to 2006, and an indication of a change in that period that might be related to the availability of assets is needed to support the assertion that the situation of having limited capital resolved during the 2000s. Choice D is incorrect because the fact that processing imports with assembly were greater at the end of the period from 2000 to 2006 than processing imports with inputs were at the start of the same period doesn't address a change within either type of imports during the period, and an indication of such a change that might be related to the availability of assets is needed to support the assertion that the situation of having limited capital resolved during the 2000s.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID aa8e7bcb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: aa8e7bcb

Many insects are iridescent, or have colors that appear to shimmer and change when seen from different angles. Scientists have assumed that this feature helps to attract mates but could also attract predators. But biologist Karin Kjernsmo and a team had the idea that the shifting appearance of colors might actually make it harder for other animals to see iridescent insects. To test this idea, the team put beetle forewings on leaves along a forest path and then asked human participants to look for them. Some of the wings were naturally iridescent. Others were painted with a nonchanging color from the iridescent spectrum, such as purple or blue.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the team’s idea?

- A. On average, participants found most of the purple wings and blue wings and far fewer of the iridescent wings.
- B. On average, participants found the iridescent wings faster than they found the purple wings or blue wings.
- C. Some participants reported that the purple wings were easier to see than the blue wings.
- D. Some participants successfully found all of the wings on the leaves.

ID: aa8e7bcb Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents the finding that, if true, would most strongly support the research team’s idea about the effect of iridescence, or colors that appear to shimmer and change. The text indicates that although some scientists have assumed that iridescence could attract predators, Kjernsmo’s team wondered if iridescent insects might be harder for other animals to see. The team tested this idea by asking human participants to look for both iridescent beetle wings and beetle wings that weren’t iridescent but that had been painted colors such as purple or blue. If participants located most of the purple or blue wings but far fewer of the iridescent wings, that finding would support the team’s idea since it would suggest that noniridescent wings are easier to see than iridescent wings.

Choice B is incorrect because if participants located the iridescent wings more quickly than the purple or blue wings, that finding would weaken the team’s idea, not support the team’s idea, since it would suggest that the iridescent wings were easier to see than the noniridescent wings. Choice C is incorrect because finding that some participants believed that the purple wings were easier to see than the blue wings would be irrelevant to the team’s idea. The purple and blue wings were both noniridescent, so any difference in how easy those two colors were to see would have nothing to do with the idea that iridescent insects are harder to see than noniridescent insects. Choice D is incorrect because if some participants found all the wings, that wouldn’t support the team’s idea that iridescent insects may be harder to see than noniridescent insects. If anything, this finding might weaken the team’s idea since it could suggest that iridescence had no effect on how difficult the wings were to see.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 70617b47

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 70617b47

The following text is from Ahmet Hamdi Tanpınar’s 1961 novel *The Time Regulation Institute* (translated from the Turkish in 2014 by Maureen Freely and Alexander Dawe). The narrator was once involved with the Time Regulation Institute, a fictional bureaucracy that regulates the time of Turkey’s clocks.

I may be the most humble and absurd man in the world and, as my wife says, the most slovenly creature you may ever meet—that is, before the founding of our institute—but I did come to know a truly great man who possessed a natural genius for invention. I spent years at his side. I watched the way he worked. I witnessed how an idea would suddenly catch fire in his mind and take shape, like a tree sprouting shoots and branches, before coming into being.

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Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. A person was fortunate enough to have found love despite his obvious shortcomings.
- B. An exceptionally talented person professes humility to avoid intimidating others.
- C. A person appreciates the extensive time he passed in the company of someone he deeply admired.
- D. A truly brilliant person lets ideas mature in his mind before expressing them aloud.

ID: 70617b47 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main idea of the text: a person appreciates the extensive time he passed in the company of a man he deeply admired. The speaker says that he spent "years" (a long period of time) in the company of a "truly great man" with "a natural genius for invention." These phrases indicate the speaker’s feelings of admiration.

Choice A is incorrect because though the text indicates that the speaker feels professional admiration for the "truly great man," the text does not indicate that the speaker feels love for him; nor does the text indicate that the speaker’s humility, absurdity, and slovenly nature proved to be an obstacle to this professional relationship. Choice B is incorrect because though the speaker describes himself as humble, the text does not indicate that he is exceptionally talented; nor does the text indicate that the "truly great man" professes humility or is concerned with whether he intimidates others. Choice D is incorrect because the text does not indicate how either the speaker or the "truly great man" express their ideas.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f250ff13

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: f250ff13

Readers sometimes divide the works of twentieth-century English author Evelyn Waugh into two periods: one consisting of his early satirical novels and the other consisting of his later, more serious—even ponderous—books. Critic Seamus Perry, however, challenges that strict division. Perry argues that Waugh’s writing didn’t change over time as much as some readers have suggested. For instance, Perry contends that some of Waugh’s earliest works, notably his biography of artist Dante Gabriel Rossetti, exhibit the earnest romanticism that would characterize Waugh’s later fiction.

Based on the text, which statement about Waugh’s works would Perry most likely agree with?

- A. Waugh’s works can appropriately be separated into two periods by their subject matter and tone.
- B. Regardless of when they were written, Waugh’s works have important similarities that transcend their differences.
- C. The earliest of Waugh’s works exhibit a satirical tone, even if that tone is more apparent in Waugh’s later works.
- D. Over time, Waugh’s works became less humorous and more focused on weightier topics.

ID: f250ff13 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a statement that is consistent with Perry’s position as described in the text. The text explains that although Waugh’s works are sometimes divided into an early period typified by satirical novels and a later period consisting of “more serious” works, Perry “challenges that strict division” and argues that Waugh’s writing “didn’t change over time as much as some readers have suggested.” As evidence, Perry notes that Waugh’s biography of Dante Gabriel Rossetti and other early works show the “earnest romanticism” associated with Waugh’s later fiction, suggesting continuity across the two periods and also across genres. It is therefore likely that Perry would agree that Waugh’s works have important similarities that transcend their differences, regardless of when they were written.

Choice A is incorrect because the text states that Perry challenges the “strict division” of Waugh’s works into two periods typified by their subject matter and tone. Perry therefore would likely disagree that such separation is appropriate; instead, he argues that Waugh’s writing shows more continuity across time than this division suggests. Choice C is incorrect because it mischaracterizes the similarity that Perry notes in Waugh’s earlier and later works. Perry contends that Waugh’s early works exhibit the “earnest romanticism” of his later fiction, not that the early works’ satirical tone appears more prominently later. Although the text mentions that Waugh’s earlier works are often satirical, Perry’s argument doesn’t emphasize this trait or trace its development over time. Choice D is incorrect because it reflects the periodization of Waugh’s works that Perry is challenging. The text indicates that Perry argues against the idea that Waugh’s writing changed dramatically over the course of his career, and Perry specifically emphasizes a point of similarity between Waugh’s earlier and later works. Given this stance, it’s unlikely that Perry would agree that Waugh’s works became less humorous and more serious over time.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c72e5f1e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: c72e5f1e

The following text is from Mark Haber’s 2022 novel *Saint Sebastian’s Abyss*. The narrator and Schmidt are both art critics.

When my first wife admitted to Schmidt over dinner that she didn’t find art, painting in particular, especially compelling, Schmidt winced, set down his fork, and sighed dramatically; he then excused himself, explaining an appointment he’d forgotten about had suddenly and inexplicably been remembered, while making it abundantly clear there was no appointment at all.

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Based on the text, what is notable about Schmidt’s behavior?

- A. Schmidt is only given to theatrical behavior when in the company of the narrator and his first wife.
- B. Schmidt’s absentmindedness regarding his schedule is uncharacteristic of him.
- C. Schmidt’s departure is occasioned by the resumption of a previous disagreement with the narrator’s first wife about a particular painting.
- D. Schmidt conveys his feelings about one of his dining companions without explicitly stating them.

ID: c72e5f1e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately describes what is notable about Schmidt’s behavior. According to the text, when the narrator’s first wife admits she doesn’t find art particularly compelling, Schmidt responds by wincing, sighing dramatically, and abruptly leaving dinner with an obviously false excuse about a remembered appointment. The narrator makes it clear that there is no actual appointment and that the excuse is merely a pretense. Through these actions—the physical reactions of wincing and sighing, followed by the transparent excuse to leave—Schmidt clearly communicates his disapproval of the wife without directly stating his feelings about her.

Choice A is incorrect because the text provides no evidence that Schmidt’s theatrical behavior—wincing, sighing dramatically, and abruptly leaving dinner—is unique to situations involving the narrator and his first wife. The text describes only one interaction involving Schmidt, so there’s no basis for determining whether his dramatic reactions are typical of him in all situations or limited to this particular social context. Choice B is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that Schmidt is typically mindful of his schedule or that forgetting appointments would be uncharacteristic of him. Rather, the text makes it clear that Schmidt hasn’t actually forgotten an appointment at all—the narrator indicates that Schmidt’s reason for leaving is an obvious fabrication, not a genuine instance of absentmindedness. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t mention any previous disagreement between Schmidt and the narrator’s first wife about a particular painting or any other topic. The text presents what appears to be a spontaneous reaction by Schmidt to the wife’s statement about not finding art compelling, not the continuation of an earlier conversation or dispute.

Question ID 1fe3f671

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 1fe3f671

In a three-year study of parasitic infections by *Anomotaenia brevis* tapeworms in *Temnothorax nylander* ants, entomologist Susanne Foitzik and colleagues found something unexpected: rather than reducing its host’s fitness, as is typical of parasites, *A. brevis* greatly extends the lifespan of a *T. nylander* worker ant and seems to halt the effects of aging. Furthermore, those infected receive special treatment, ceasing their share of labor to sustain the colony and remaining in the nest as uninfected workers feed, groom, and transport them. By contrast, the researchers observed that uninfected workers in parasitized colonies have shortened lifespans, most likely because the _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. uninfected workers are at high risk for direct exposure to *A. brevis* in the course of providing social care to the infected workers in the nest.
- B. need to compensate for reduced contributions within the colony while also caring for infected workers is burdensome to the uninfected workers.
- C. high level of activity maintained by the uninfected workers makes them better able than infected workers to quickly disperse when the nest is attacked by a predator.
- D. average lifespan of *T. nylander* worker ants in colonies without parasitic activity typically falls well below three years, the range covered by the study.

ID: 1fe3f671 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text describes a study examining the relationship between a species of parasitic tapeworm, *A. brevis*, and its host insect, the *T. nylander* ant. According to the text, researchers were surprised to find that the tapeworm extends the life of its ant host, rather than reducing it. The text goes on to state that the infected ants end up doing less work to sustain the colony and that as a result, the uninfected ants take on the infected ants’ share of labor in addition to caring for them in their infected state. The study’s researchers also observed that the uninfected ants have shorter lifespans than expected. If the infected ants, who are doing less work in the colony, have longer lifespans, it can be inferred that the less an ant works, the longer it will live. The opposite of this statement can also be inferred: the more an ant works, the shorter its life. So, since the workload within the colony is being redistributed so that the infected ants work less while the uninfected ants work more (as they take on the neglected duties of the infected ants and also care for those ants), then it can be inferred that the lifespans of the uninfected ants are shortened because the need to compensate for reduced contributions within the colony while also caring for infected workers is burdensome to the uninfected workers.

Choice A is incorrect because the text does not indicate how *A. brevis* is transmitted to the ants or assert that uninfected ants are more likely to be directly exposed to *A. brevis* while caring for infected ants. Choice C is incorrect because the text makes no mention of the relative abilities of infected and uninfected ants to escape predators: in fact, predators are not mentioned in the

text at all. Choice D is incorrect because the text does not supply any information about the average lifespans of the ants in colonies without parasitic activity; the text only indicates factors that lengthen and shorten the lifespans of ants in parasitized colonies.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c8897261

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: c8897261

ALSOL is a microcredit program in Mexico that makes small loans to female entrepreneurs who lack the collateral and credit history to secure financing from conventional banks. Borrowers use their business proceeds to repay loans in equal weekly installments and incur no penalty for missed payments other than lack of access to larger loans. Economists Gustavo Barboza and Sandra Trejos analyzed ALSOL data and found that rural borrowers, who mostly make and sell handicrafts, miss payments more often than urban borrowers do, partly because they sell their goods less frequently than they could. Barboza and Trejos claim that this behavior reflects strategic decisions that enable rural women to increase their profits per unit sold.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Barboza and Trejos’s claim?

- A. Many marketplaces require entrepreneurs to pay marketplace operators a fixed percentage of each day’s proceeds in exchange for permission to sell goods there.
- B. Rural entrepreneurs can typically sell their goods for higher prices in cities than in their home areas, but the number of people selling competing goods tends to be higher in cities.
- C. Due to the lower costs they incur, rural entrepreneurs tend to require smaller initial loans than urban entrepreneurs do.
- D. The cost to rural entrepreneurs to bring their goods to towns with marketplaces is high but largely independent of the number of goods they bring.

ID: c8897261 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support Barboza and Trejos’s claim that rural female entrepreneurs who have received small loans from ALSOL are strategic in selling their goods less frequently than they could, even if it means missing payments. The text explains that borrowers in the ALSOL program use proceeds from their businesses to repay loans in equal weekly payments, with almost no penalty for missed payments. According to the text, Barboza and Trejos found that rural borrowers miss weekly payments in part because they don’t sell their goods as often as they could, a move the researchers claim allows the entrepreneurs to help increase profits for the goods they sell. Finding that the cost of bringing goods to towns with marketplaces is high for rural entrepreneurs but is largely independent of how many goods are brought would support the researchers’ claim: traveling to marketplaces less frequently would mean that a rural entrepreneur spends less on travel overall, and taking a large load of goods to a marketplace for essentially the same cost as taking a small load would allow the entrepreneur to more substantially offset the cost of travel with greater overall sales at the marketplace, resulting in more profit per good sold—even if those profits are earned less frequently and don’t support weekly loan payments.

Choice A is incorrect because the finding that many marketplaces require entrepreneurs to pay the operators of the marketplace a fixed percentage of proceeds to be able to sell goods there wouldn’t explain why rural entrepreneurs strategically choose to sell their goods less frequently than they could in order to increase their profits per unit sold. With a fixed percentage of proceeds due to operators, the amount entrepreneurs have to pay operators would also be fixed regardless of frequency of selling. Choice B is

incorrect because the finding that rural entrepreneurs can usually sell their goods for higher prices in cities than in their local areas but also face higher competition to sell goods in cities wouldn't explain why rural entrepreneurs strategically choose to sell their goods less frequently than they could in order to increase their profits per unit sold. This is because both the higher prices and higher competition in cities would be stable factors—meaning there would be no clear reason for the rural entrepreneurs not to take every available chance to sell their goods in cities and to instead sell their goods in cities only sometimes. Choice C is incorrect because the finding that rural entrepreneurs have lower costs and thus tend to require smaller initial loans than urban entrepreneurs do has no bearing on rural borrowers strategically choosing to sell their goods less frequently than they could specifically to increase their profits per unit sold. The cost of producing goods doesn't depend on the frequency with which an entrepreneur sells those goods, so lower frequency alone wouldn't affect profits, and the initial loan amount is set and has nothing to do with how much profit is earned from each sale.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 58320829

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 58320829

Simulated Change in Annual Aquifer Input and Irrigation Output if Precipitation Concentration Increases as Climate Models Predict

Baseline concentration of annual precipitation	% change in water entering aquifers	% change in surface water used for irrigation	% change in groundwater used for irrigation
Precipitation is currently somewhat concentrated	4.9	0.4	0.9
Precipitation is currently evenly distributed	11.0	9.0	7.9

Some climate models for the western United States predict that while total annual precipitation may remain unchanged from the present level, precipitation will become concentrated into fewer but more intense rain and snow events. University of Texas climate scientist Geeta Persad and her colleagues simulated how the amount of water entering aquifers and the amount being used for irrigation purposes would change if this were to occur. Persad and her colleagues concluded that concentration of precipitation into fewer events would result in a higher number of dry days, triggering more irrigation, but that this change in irrigation output is highly sensitive to the baseline concentration of precipitation that currently exists in an area.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support Persad and her colleagues’ conclusion?

- A. If baseline precipitation is somewhat concentrated, the amount of water being used for irrigation will increase 0.4% for surface water and 0.9% for groundwater, whereas the amount of water entering aquifers will increase 11.0% if baseline precipitation is evenly distributed.
- B. If baseline precipitation is somewhat concentrated, water use for irrigation will increase only slightly, whereas it will increase 9.0% for surface water and 7.9% for groundwater if baseline precipitation is evenly distributed.
- C. If baseline precipitation is somewhat concentrated, the amount of water entering aquifers will increase 4.9%, while the amount being used for irrigation will increase 0.4% for surface water and 0.9% for groundwater.
- D. If baseline precipitation is somewhat concentrated, water use for irrigation will decline by a small amount, whereas it will increase 11.0% for surface water and 9.0% for groundwater if baseline precipitation is evenly distributed.

ID: 58320829 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it describes data from the table that support Persad and her colleagues’ conclusion. The text explains that, according to some climate models, precipitation in the western United States will become concentrated into fewer, more intense rain and snow events. According to the text, Persad and her colleagues concluded that more irrigation will consequently be needed but that the change in irrigation output will be highly sensitive to, or greatly affected by, the baseline

concentration of precipitation in an area. This conclusion is supported by data from the researchers' simulations of changes in annual irrigation output in two different scenarios—one in which an area's annual precipitation is already somewhat concentrated and one in which its annual precipitation is evenly distributed. The table shows that if baseline precipitation is somewhat concentrated, water use for irrigation will increase only slightly, whereas if baseline precipitation is evenly distributed, water use for irrigation will increase much more—9.0% for surface water and 7.9% for groundwater. This difference illustrates the researchers' conclusion that the amount of additional water needed for irrigation will vary greatly depending on how concentrated or spread out the annual precipitation in an area already is.

Choice A is incorrect because it compares changes in the amount of water being used for irrigation to changes in the amount of water entering aquifers. Persad and her colleagues' conclusion doesn't focus on changes to the amount of water entering aquifers; rather, the researchers' conclusion focuses on changes to irrigation output relative to how concentrated or spread out the annual precipitation in an area is. Choice C is incorrect because it supports only part of Persad and her colleagues' conclusion. According to the text, the researchers concluded that the concentration of precipitation into fewer events will trigger more irrigation but that this change in irrigation output will be highly sensitive to an area's baseline concentration of annual precipitation. The data in this choice support the idea that more irrigation will be needed, but to support the rest of the researchers' conclusion, additional data from the table are required to show that the increases in water use for irrigation will vary depending on how concentrated or spread out the annual precipitation in an area already is. Choice D is incorrect because data in the table indicate no declines in water use for irrigation, showing only increases in the form of positive values.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID edd8e6fc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: edd8e6fc

Herbivorous sauropod dinosaurs could grow more than 100 feet long and weigh up to 80 tons, and some researchers have attributed the evolution of sauropods to such massive sizes to increased plant production resulting from high levels of atmospheric carbon dioxide during the Mesozoic era. However, there is no evidence of significant spikes in carbon dioxide levels coinciding with relevant periods in sauropod evolution, such as when the first large sauropods appeared, when several sauropod lineages underwent further evolution toward gigantism, or when sauropods reached their maximum known sizes, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. fluctuations in atmospheric carbon dioxide affected different sauropod lineages differently.
- B. the evolution of larger body sizes in sauropods did not depend on increased atmospheric carbon dioxide.
- C. atmospheric carbon dioxide was higher when the largest known sauropods lived than it was when the first sauropods appeared.
- D. sauropods probably would not have evolved to such immense sizes if atmospheric carbon dioxide had been even slightly higher.

ID: edd8e6fc Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of the relationship between atmospheric carbon dioxide and sauropod body size. The text establishes that sauropods evolved to reach enormous sizes, and it notes that some scientists have asserted that the cause of this phenomenon was increased plant production that resulted from increased atmospheric carbon dioxide. The text goes on to state, however, that atmospheric carbon dioxide levels didn’t increase around the time of important periods in sauropods’ evolution of larger body sizes. If significant periods of sauropod evolution toward larger sizes occurred without increased atmospheric carbon dioxide levels, that suggests that the evolution of larger sizes didn’t depend on increased carbon dioxide in the atmosphere.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t describe any fluctuations in atmospheric carbon dioxide, so there’s no evidence in the text to support the conclusion that such fluctuations had different effects on different sauropod lineages. All that the text says about atmospheric carbon dioxide levels is that there weren’t increases at particular points that correspond with key moments in sauropod evolution. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates that there weren’t significant increases in atmospheric carbon dioxide around the time of important periods in sauropods’ evolution toward larger body sizes, not that atmospheric carbon dioxide was higher when the largest sauropods lived than when sauropods first appeared. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that atmospheric carbon dioxide levels didn’t increase at important periods in sauropod evolution, not that higher levels would have affected that evolution. The text provides no information about how higher levels of atmospheric carbon dioxide might have affected sauropods.

Question ID 069d7a45

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 069d7a45

Richard II is a play from the 1590s by William Shakespeare. Although King Richard has been vanquished by his cousin Henry Bolingbroke, he intimates that he is not entirely ready to show subservience to his cousin, saying, _____

Which quotation from *Richard II* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. "I have no name, no title,— / No, not that name was given me at the font,— / But 'tis usurp'd:— Alack the heavy day, / That I have worn so many winters out, / And know not now what name to call myself!"
- B. "Alack, why am I sent for to a king, / Before I have shook off the regal thoughts / Wherewith I reign'd? I hardly yet have learn'd / To insinuate, flatter, bow, and bend my knee."
- C. "Still my griefs are mine. / You may my glories and my state depose, / But not my griefs; still am I king of those."
- D. "Am I both priest and clerk? Well then, amen. / God save the King! although I be not he; / And yet, amen, if heaven do think him me."

ID: 069d7a45 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most effectively presents a quotation that illustrates the claim that Richard intimates he is not entirely ready to show subservience to Bolingbroke. The quotation conveys that Richard has not yet shaken off "the regal thoughts / Wherewith [he] reign'd"—that is, he still feels like a king—and that he has "hardly yet have learn'd / To insinuate, flatter, bow, and bend [his] knee," directly listing acts of subservience he is not prepared to perform. By stating his unreadiness to behave subserviently while still inhabiting a regal mindset, Richard intimates exactly what the claim describes.

Choice A is incorrect because this quotation centers on Richard's anguish over the loss of his name and title; it expresses confusion about his identity rather than illustrating that he is not yet prepared to show subservience to Bolingbroke. Choice C is incorrect because in this quotation Richard claims that his griefs remain his own even after his "glories" and "state" have been deposed; it concerns ownership of his suffering and identity rather than any unreadiness to behave subserviently toward Bolingbroke. Choice D is incorrect because the quotation depicts Richard as willing to go along with the assertion of others that Bolingbroke is the rightful king, although God, who in this case serves as an objective arbiter, may have a different opinion on who the rightful king is ("if heaven do think him me"). So the quotation suggests that Richard is willing to behave subserviently even if he thinks he has been wronged; it does not suggest that he is at present unwilling to show subservience.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b030788d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: b030788d

“When Dawn Comes to the City” is a 1922 poem by Claude McKay, who immigrated to the United States from the island nation of Jamaica as an adult. The poem conveys McKay’s contrasting feelings about New York City—his adopted home in the US—and his home country: _____

Which quotation from “When Dawn Comes to the City” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “A lonely newsboy hurries by, / Humming a recent ditty; / Red streaks strike through the gray of the sky, / The dawn comes to the city [New York City].”
- B. “Dark figures start for work; / I watch them sadly shuffle on, / ’Tis dawn, dawn in New York. / But I would be on the island of the sea, / In the heart of the island of the sea.”
- C. “And the shaggy Nannie goat is calling, calling, calling / From her little trampled corner of the long wide lea / That stretches to the waters of the hill-stream falling / Sheer upon the flat rocks joyously!”
- D. “The tired cars go grumbling by, / The moaning, groaning cars, / And the old milk carts go rumbling by / Under the same dull stars.”

ID: b030788d Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a quotation illustrating the claim that the poem conveys McKay’s contrasting feelings about New York City and Jamaica. McKay first presents a somewhat negative view of New York City, describing watching “dark figures” who “sadly shuffle” to work at dawn, and then indicates that he would instead like to be “in the heart of the island of the sea.”

Choice A is incorrect because the quotation focuses on a description of only one place (New York City, with its “lonely newsboy” and “red streaks” in the sky at dawn) rather than on different feelings about two places. Choice C is incorrect because the quotation focuses on a description of only one place (which isn’t named) rather than on McKay’s different feelings about two places. Choice D is incorrect because though McKay presents a negative image of an unnamed place with “tired cars” that grumble, moan, and groan, and “old milk carts” that rumble by under “dull stars,” the quotation focuses on McKay’s feelings about only one place rather than on different feelings about two places.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dbcb5652

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: dbcb5652

Ratified by more than 90 countries, the Nagoya Protocol is an international agreement ensuring that Indigenous communities are compensated when their agricultural resources and knowledge of wild plants and animals are utilized by agricultural corporations. However, the protocol has shortcomings. For example, it allows corporations to insist that their agreements with communities to conduct research on the commercial uses of the communities’ resources and knowledge remain confidential. Therefore, some Indigenous advocates express concern that the protocol may have the unintended effect of _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. diminishing the monetary reward that corporations might derive from their agreements with Indigenous communities.
- B. limiting the research that corporations conduct on the resources of the Indigenous communities with which they have signed agreements.
- C. preventing independent observers from determining whether the agreements guarantee equitable compensation for Indigenous communities.
- D. discouraging Indigenous communities from learning new methods for harvesting plants and animals from their corporate partners.

ID: dbcb5652 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the argument about an unintended effect of the Nagoya Protocol. The text explains that the Nagoya Protocol is an agreement ensuring that Indigenous communities are compensated when their agricultural resources and knowledge are used by corporations. The text then states that the protocol allows corporations to keep their agreements with Indigenous communities confidential, about which some Indigenous advocates express concern. Choice C, when inserted into the blank, gives a good justification for the advocates’ concern: such secrecy could mean that the public is unable to determine whether participating Indigenous communities were properly compensated under these agreements.

Choice A is incorrect. The text suggests that because corporations can keep their agreements with Indigenous communities confidential, Indigenous communities, not corporations, might not be compensated fairly. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the ability of corporations to keep their agreements with Indigenous communities confidential would place limits on how much research corporations can undertake. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that Indigenous communities aim to learn new harvesting methods from their corporate partners. Rather, the text suggests that corporations use the knowledge of Indigenous communities for their research.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e6c9e562

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: e6c9e562

Biologist Natacha Bodenhausen and colleagues analyzed the naturally occurring bacterial communities associated with leaves and roots of wild *Arabidopsis thaliana*, a small flowering plant. The researchers found many of the same bacterial genera in both the plants’ leaves and roots. To explain this, the researchers pointed to the general proximity of *A. thaliana* leaves to the ground and noted that rain splashing off soil could bring soil-based bacteria into contact with the leaves. Alternatively, the researchers noted that wind, which may be a source of bacteria in the aboveground portion of plants, could also bring bacteria to the soil and roots. Either explanation suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. bacteria carried by wind are typically less beneficial to *A. thaliana* than soil-based bacteria are.
- B. some bacteria in *A. thaliana* leaves and roots may share a common source.
- C. many bacteria in *A. thaliana* leaves may have been deposited by means other than rain.
- D. *A. thaliana* leaves and roots are especially vulnerable to harmful bacteria.

ID: e6c9e562 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Both explanations suggest that the bacteria come from the same place: either they come from the ground and make their way to the leaves, or they come from above the ground and make their way to the roots.

Choice A is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never discusses any benefits of any kind of bacteria. Choice C is incorrect. This conflicts with the text. One of the theories is that the bacteria in the leaves were deposited by rain splashing off soil. Choice D is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text only discusses “naturally occurring” bacteria. It never mentions either the harms or benefits of these bacteria.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9dfa59ac

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 9dfa59ac

The following text is from Milan Kundera’s 1984 novel *The Unbearable Lightness of Being* (translated by Michael Henry Heim in 1984). Karenin is a dog that belongs to Tomas and Tereza.

Karenin was not overjoyed by the move to Switzerland [from Prague]. Karenin hated change. Dog time cannot be plotted along a straight line; it does not move on and on, from one thing to the next. It moves in a circle like the hands of a clock, which—they, too, unwilling to dash madly ahead—turn round and round the face, day in and day out following the same path. In Prague, when Tomas and Tereza bought a new chair or moved a flower pot, Karenin would look on in displeasure. It disturbed his sense of time. It was as though they were trying to dupe the hands of the clock by changing the numbers on its face.

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- Which choice best states the main idea of the text?
- A. As a dog, Karenin possesses a sense of time that involves a strong preference for predictability and an aversion to disruption.
 - B. After he’s moved to a new home, Karenin’s negative response to changes has become more pronounced.
 - C. Similar to Tomas and Tereza, Karenin comprehends time as circular rather than as a straightforward progression.
 - D. As is the case for other dogs, Karenin’s sense of time seems to accelerate depending on the objects and places that surround him.

ID: 9dfa59ac Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text begins by stating that Tomas and Tereza’s dog Karenin felt disrupted by a recent move because of his dislike of change. The text then goes on to suggest that this is because the way a dog experiences time differs from the way humans experience time: time for a dog doesn’t move linearly, going "on and on, from one thing to the next," but instead moves circularly, "like the hands of a clock." That is, time for a dog is experienced as a cyclical pattern characterized by routine and predictability, with each day "following the same path." The text then concludes by providing examples of seemingly insignificant changes in routine that profoundly "disturbed [Karenin’s] sense of time," causing him to feel displeasure. Thus, the main idea of the text is that Karenin’s sense of time as a dog involves a strong preference for predictability and an aversion to disruption.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the text emphasizes Karenin’s displeasure with the recent move to a new home, it doesn’t suggest that the move has made his negative responses more pronounced than they once were. Rather, in accounting for Karenin’s displeasure with the move to Switzerland, the text explains that Karenin generally has a negative response to any kind of change.

Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that Karenin comprehends time similarly to how Tomas and Tereza comprehend it. On the contrary, the text strongly implies a contrast between dogs’ circular experience of time with the way humans experience time as a straightforward progression that can be "plotted on a straight line." Choice D is incorrect because

the text provides no indication that a change in the places and objects surrounding Karenin causes him to feel as though time is accelerating. Although the text does use the language of "dash[ing] madly ahead" in relation to time, the phrase appears in the context of a comparison illustrating how dogs experience time: time for a dog moves just as the hands of a clock do, in a circle and "unwilling to dash madly ahead"—that is, always in a regular and predictable way.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e62b540a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: e62b540a

A social species, chickens will cry out to one another in warning if they sense a hawk or other predator nearby. But if alone, a chicken will remain silent so as not to attract the predator’s attention. Sonja Hillemacher decided to use this behavior to determine whether individual chickens possess a capacity to recognize themselves visually when reflected in a mirror (a common standard for animal intelligence). In the first condition of her study, the subject could see its reflection, but no other chickens were present. In a second condition, another chicken was visible to the subject. Hillemacher presented an image of a hawk to the subject in both conditions, reasoning that if chickens lacked a capacity for visual self-recognition, then _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. neither study condition would elicit an audible response from the subject.
- B. the subject likely would cry out a warning in both study conditions.
- C. only the first study condition would elicit an audible response from the subject.
- D. the subject would fail to distinguish its reflection from the image of the hawk.

ID: e62b540a Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Hillemacher’s study of visual self-recognition in chickens. According to the text, when a predator is nearby, chickens cry out in warning if another chicken is present but remain silent if alone to avoid attracting the predator’s attention. The text explains that Hillemacher set up one condition in which a subject was alone and could see its reflection in a mirror and another condition in which the subject could see another chicken, and then presented an image of a hawk (a predator). It follows that if chickens aren’t capable of recognizing themselves visually in a mirror, the subject likely would cry out a warning in both conditions; in the first condition because it would perceive its reflection as another chicken—that is, it would think another chicken is present—and in the second condition because it would see that another chicken is actually present.

Choice A is incorrect because the text suggests that regardless of chickens’ ability to visually recognize themselves in mirrors, the subject in the second condition would cry out a warning because another chicken is actually present. Further, if chickens do lack visual self-recognition, the subject in the first condition likely would also cry out because it would think its reflection is another chicken. Choice C is incorrect. The text does suggest that if chickens lack the ability to visually recognize themselves in mirrors, the subject would cry out a warning in the first condition because it would think its reflection is another chicken. However, the text also indicates that regardless of their capacity of self-recognition, chickens cry out a warning when other chickens are present, and another chicken is present in the second condition. Therefore, both conditions—not just the first one—likely would elicit an audible response from the subject. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that the study was focused on determining whether chickens recognize themselves visually in a mirror or instead perceive their reflections as other chickens; there’s no suggestion that a lack of self-recognition would cause a chicken to confuse its reflection with the image of a hawk.

Question ID 78d0458a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 78d0458a

Gorgets, or necklaces with large pendants, have been part of the ceremonial attire of tribes from the US Southeast for centuries. One of the oldest examples, the Fairfield Gorget, was found in Fairfield, Missouri, in 1958. Its overall design resembles that of other art from the region during the Mississippian period (900–1600 CE). Yet the image on the gorget is of a jaguar—a species whose range doesn’t extend to Missouri. Jaguar images are common in ancient Mexican art, and Mexico lies squarely in the species’ range. Therefore, some scholars argue that long-distance trade in Mexican art objects brought the imagery to Missouri, where a local artist could have adopted it and incorporated it into the Fairfield Gorget.

Which finding, if true, would most strongly support the underlined explanation?

- A. The Fairfield Gorget is dated not to the Mississippian period but instead to the earlier Woodland period, which ended around 900 CE.
- B. The range of the jaguar is shown to have expanded dramatically after the Mississippian period came to a close around 1600 CE.
- C. An ancient Mexican art object is found at a site that dates to the Mississippian period and is close to where the Fairfield Gorget was found.
- D. Certain works by present-day artists from Southeastern tribes reflect outside cultural influences, including contemporary Mexican art.

ID: 78d0458a Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most strongly support the underlined explanation that the jaguar imagery on the Fairfield Gorget could have been inspired by art objects brought to Missouri from Mexico. The text describes the Fairfield Gorget as one of the oldest examples of these necklaces, noting that it’s similar to other art from the Mississippian period except for its image of a jaguar. The text goes on to explain that this is unusual because the jaguar’s range didn’t include Missouri. The Fairfield Gorget’s artist likely wouldn’t have encountered a live jaguar, but since such jaguar images were common in ancient Mexican art (and the jaguar’s range did include Mexico), perhaps some of that art inspired the gorget’s artist. Therefore, evidence that an ancient Mexican art object had been found at a site that was close to the Fairfield Gorget in both location and time period would strongly support the explanation that long-distance trade from Mexico took place during the Mississippian period and that jaguar imagery could have reached Missouri by those means.

Choice A is incorrect. The underlined explanation indicates that Mexican artistic influence preceded the creation of the Fairfield Gorget. An artifact from Mexico that appeared in Missouri only after the gorget was created cannot support such a claim. Choice B is incorrect. The underlined explanation pertains to whether the jaguar image on the Fairfield Gorget was suggested to the Mississippian artist who made it by encounters with depictions of jaguars in Mexican art. The appearance of jaguars in Missouri after the Mississippian period cannot provide evidence for such a claim. Choice D is incorrect. The underlined explanation

pertains to influence that Mexican art might have had on Mississippian art, restricted to the period from 900 CE to 1600 CE. The actions of contemporary artists cannot provide evidence for centuries-old networks of artistic influence and exchange.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 83f7c61c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 83f7c61c

Birds of many species ingest foods containing carotenoids, pigmented molecules that are converted into feather coloration. Coloration tends to be especially saturated in male birds’ feathers, and because carotenoids also confer health benefits, the deeply saturated colors generally serve to communicate what is known as an honest signal of a bird’s overall fitness to potential mates. However, ornithologist Allison J. Shultz and others have found that males in several species of the tanager genus *Ramphocelus* use microstructures in their feathers to manipulate light, creating the appearance of deeper saturation without the birds necessarily having to maintain a carotenoid-rich diet. These findings suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. individual male tanagers can engage in honest signaling without relying on carotenoid consumption.
- B. feather microstructures may be less effective than deeply saturated feathers for signaling overall fitness.
- C. scientists have yet to determine why tanagers have a preference for mates with colorful appearances.
- D. a male tanager’s appearance may function as a dishonest signal of the individual’s overall fitness.

ID: 83f7c61c Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Shultz’s finding about male tanagers. The text explains that because carotenoids both contribute to deeply saturated feathers and offer health benefits, having deeply saturated feathers is usually “an honest signal” (a true indication) that a bird is generally fit. However, Shultz and others have found that certain male tanagers can appear to have deeply saturated feathers even if they haven’t consumed a diet rich in carotenoids, thanks to microstructures in their feathers that manipulate light. If those birds aren’t necessarily eating carotenoid-rich diets, they may actually be less fit than other birds that appear to have similarly saturated feathers; this suggests that a male tanager’s appearance may function as a dishonest signal, or a false indication, of the bird’s overall fitness.

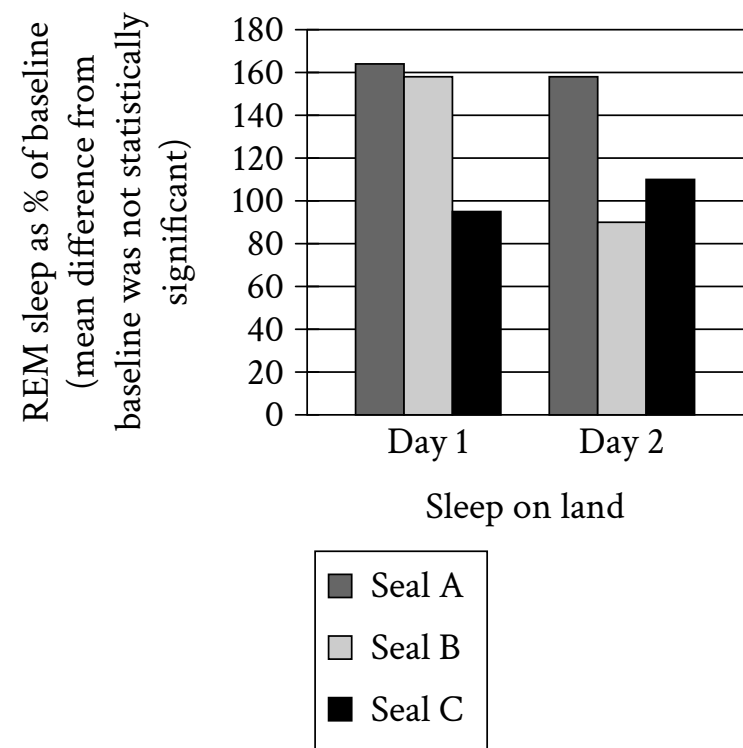
Choice A is incorrect because Shultz’s finding suggests that some tanagers can signal fitness without consuming the carotenoids that contribute to fitness, thereby making those signals dishonest, not that tanagers can give honest signals of their fitness without consuming carotenoids. Choice B is incorrect because Shultz’s finding suggests that the microstructures in certain tanagers’ feathers can give a dishonest signal of fitness, not that the microstructures are less effective than actual pigmentation for signaling fitness. Whether the signal of fitness is honest or dishonest has no bearing on how effective the signal is: a signal is effective if potential mates behave as though it’s true, regardless of whether it’s actually true. Since there’s no information in the text about how potential mates respond to the dishonest signals of some tanagers, there’s no support for the idea that the dishonest signals are less effective than the honest signals. Choice C is incorrect because Shultz’s finding suggests that certain male tanagers may appear to be fitter than they actually are, not that scientists haven’t determined why tanagers prefer mates with colorful appearances.

Question ID 83e0e256

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 83e0e256

Fur Seal REM Sleep on Land
after an Extended Period
in Water



Research suggests that REM sleep in animals is homeostatically regulated: animals compensate for periods of REM sleep deprivation by increasing subsequent REM sleep. When on land, fur seals get enough REM sleep, but during the weeks they're in the water, they get almost none. In a study of fur seals' sleep habits, researchers recorded the REM sleep (as a percentage of baseline) of fur seals once they had returned to land. They concluded that REM sleep may not be homeostatically regulated in fur seals, citing as evidence the fact that the seals in the study _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the text?

- A. didn't consistently demonstrate a significant increase in REM sleep after their period of deprivation in the water.
- B. showed no significant difference between REM sleep after returning to land and REM sleep while in the water.
- C. didn't show significantly less REM sleep during the second day after returning to land than they did during the first day.
- D. showed no significant differences from one another in baseline levels of REM sleep.

ID: 83e0e256 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. If REM sleep were homeostatically regulated in fur seals, then all the seals would compensate with REM levels significantly over baseline after going weeks without REM. We'd also expect the seals to maintain those elevated REM levels for some time. Since seals B and C return very quickly to baseline REM levels, this suggests that REM sleep in fur seals may not be regulated homeostatically.

Choice B is incorrect. The graph doesn't depict REM sleep while in the water for the seals in the study. Additionally, we're told fur seals get no REM sleep while in the water, which is significantly different to the values shown in the graph for after they return to land. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn't support the conclusion. If REM sleep were homeostatically regulated in fur seals, then we'd suspect the seals to sustain REM levels well above baseline for a prolonged period in order to compensate for weeks of REM deprivation while in the water. Whether or not there's a reduction in REM sleep from day 1 to day 2 doesn't tell us how REM sleep on those days relates to baseline, which is where our focus should be. Choice D is incorrect. The y-axis of this graph doesn't depict baseline levels of REM sleep, but rather shows REM sleep as a percent of baseline.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 717b0596

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 717b0596

A team of biologists led by Jae-Hoon Jung, Antonio D. Barbosa, and Stephanie Hutin investigated the mechanism that allows *Arabidopsis thaliana* (thale cress) plants to accelerate flowering at high temperatures. They replaced the protein ELF3 in the plants with a similar protein found in another species (stiff brome) that, unlike *A. thaliana*, displays no acceleration in flowering with increased temperature. A comparison of unmodified *A. thaliana* plants with the altered plants showed no difference in flowering at 22° Celsius, but at 27° Celsius, the unmodified plants exhibited accelerated flowering while the altered ones did not, which suggests that _____

- Which choice most logically completes the text?
- A. temperature-sensitive accelerated flowering is unique to *A. thaliana*.
 - B. *A. thaliana* increases ELF3 production as temperatures rise.
 - C. ELF3 enables *A. thaliana* to respond to increased temperatures.
 - D. temperatures of at least 22° Celsius are required for *A. thaliana* to flower.

ID: 717b0596 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of accelerated flowering in *A. thaliana* plants. The text indicates that *A. thaliana* plants show accelerated flowering at high temperatures. To investigate the mechanism for this accelerated flowering, biologists replaced the ELF3 protein in one group of *A. thaliana* plants with a similar protein found in another plant species that doesn’t show accelerated flowering. The team then compared these modified plants to *A. thaliana* plants that retained their original ELF3 protein. The text states that the two samples of plants showed no difference in flowering at 22° Celsius, but at 27° Celsius the unaltered plants with ELF3 showed accelerated flowering while the plants without ELF3 didn’t. If accelerated flowering at the higher temperature occurred in the *A. thaliana* plants with ELF3 but not in the plants without the protein, then ELF3 likely enables *A. thaliana* to respond to increased temperatures.

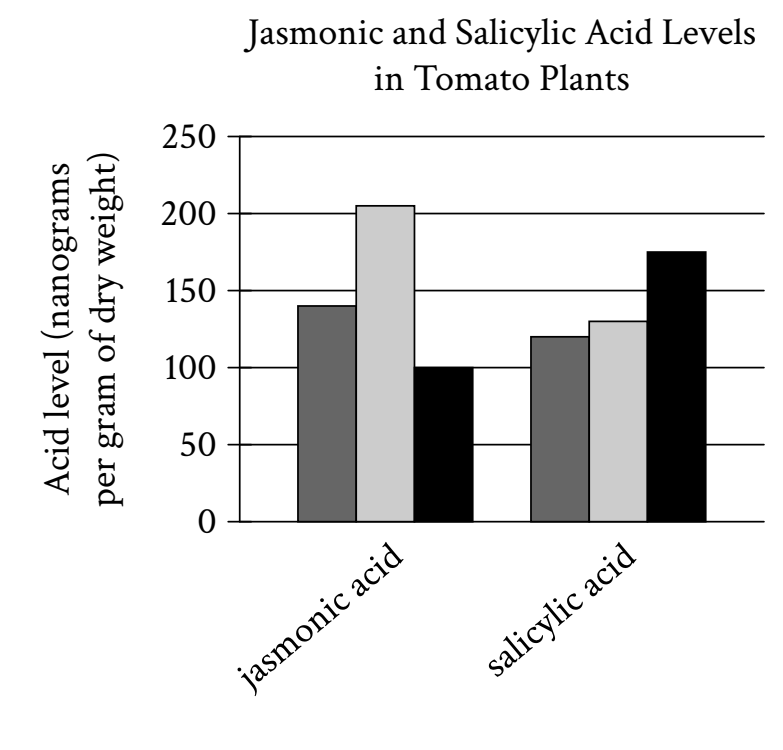
Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t mention whether any plants other than *A. thaliana* and stiff brome show temperature-sensitive flowering, so there is no support for the idea that this type of flowering is unique to *A. thaliana*. Choice B is incorrect because the text discusses the effects of ELF3 and not the production of it. There’s nothing in the text to suggest that the amount of ELF3 in *A. thaliana* varies with temperature. Choice D is incorrect. While the text states that there was no difference in the flowering of modified and unmodified *A. thaliana* plants at 22° Celsius, there’s no suggestion that *A. thaliana* only begins to flower at 22° Celsius; the text doesn’t mention a specific temperature threshold required for *A. thaliana* flowering.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9dc29fcb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 9dc29fcb



- control plants
- plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants and then infested
- plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants and then infested

In tomato plants, herbivory induces defensive production of jasmonic acid, while microbial infection induces defensive production of salicylic acid; plants also emit airborne chemicals to initiate the appropriate defense in nearby tomato plants. Researchers investigated the poor resistance tomato plants show to whitefly herbivory by exposing some plants to airborne chemicals from whitefly-free plants and others to airborne chemicals from whitefly-infested plants, then infesting both groups of plants with whiteflies. The researchers concluded that whiteflies induce tomato plants to emit chemicals that cause other tomato plants to preferentially defend against microbial infection even when under herbivorous attack.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that support the researchers' conclusion?

- A. When plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants were infested, they produced more jasmonic acid than did control plants, whereas when plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants were infested, they produced less jasmonic acid and more salicylic acid than did control plants.
- B. When plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants were infested, they produced less jasmonic acid than salicylic acid, whereas when plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants were infested, they produced about the same amount of jasmonic acid and salicylic acid.
- C. When plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants were infested, they produced both jasmonic acid and salicylic acid, whereas when plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants were infested, they exclusively produced salicylic acid.
- D. When plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants were infested, they produced less jasmonic acid than did control plants, whereas when plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants were infested, they produced more jasmonic acid and salicylic acid than did control plants.

ID: 9dc29fcb Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it best describes data from the graph that support the researchers' conclusion about whitefly-induced defenses in tomato plants. According to the text, tomato plants produce airborne chemicals that prompt nearby tomato plants to increase their production of appropriate defensive chemicals, such as jasmonic acid in response to herbivory and salicylic acid in response to microbial infection. The text goes on to indicate that researchers concluded that whiteflies induce tomato plants to emit chemicals that cause nearby plants to defend against microbial infection instead of herbivory from whiteflies. The graph shows that control tomato plants (plants that weren't exposed to any chemicals from nearby tomato plants and weren't subsequently infested with whiteflies) produced about 140 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight and about 120 nanograms of salicylic acid per gram of dry weight, which indicates the baseline levels of these defensive chemicals in tomato plants. The graph also shows that plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants produced about 205 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight when subsequently infested by whiteflies, which is more than the amount produced by the control plants. This suggests that when infested with whiteflies, tomato plants that weren't previously exposed to air from nearby whitefly-infested plants begin producing higher levels of jasmonic acid to defend against the infestation. Finally, the graph also shows that plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants and then subsequently infested by whiteflies produced approximately 100 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight (which is less than control plants did) and approximately 175 nanograms of salicylic acid per gram of dry weight (which is more than control plants did). This suggests that whiteflies cause tomato plants to emit chemical signals that decrease nearby plants' defenses against whitefly herbivory relative to baseline levels and redirect their defenses toward microbial infection, thereby supporting the researchers' conclusion that whiteflies cause tomato plants to emit airborne chemical signals that induce nearby plants to preferentially defend against microbes even when experiencing herbivory from whiteflies.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the graph shows that tomato plants exposed to whitefly-infested plants produced less jasmonic acid than salicylic acid (about 100 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight vs. about 175 nanograms of salicylic acid per gram of dry weight), and although this might suggest that those plants are therefore better defended against microbial attack than against herbivory, this wouldn't be sufficient to conclude that this is the case: without reference to the relative levels of defensive chemicals produced by the plants in the other experimental conditions, it would be impossible to conclude that exposure to air from whitefly-infested plants either induces or diminishes these plants' defenses to different kinds of threats. Furthermore, the graph shows that plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants produced about 205 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight and about 130 nanograms of salicylic acid per gram of dry weight, not that they produced the same amount of the two acids. Choice C is incorrect because it inaccurately describes the data in the graph. The graph shows that plants in all three conditions produced both jasmonic and salicylic acid, not that plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants produce no jasmonic acid at all. Choice D is incorrect. Although the graph shows that plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants produced about 100 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight when infested, which is less than the amount produced by control plants (about 140 nanograms per gram of dry weight), and although the graph shows that plants

exposed to air from whitefly-free plants produced about 205 nanograms of jasmonic acid per gram of dry weight when infested (which is more than the amount produced by control plants) and about 130 nanograms of salicylic acid per gram of dry weight (which is more than the approximately 120 nanograms per gram of dry weight produced by control plants), this wouldn't support the researchers' conclusion that plants exposed to air from whitefly-infested plants preferentially defend against microbial infection—that is, that they increase their levels of salicylic acid and decrease their levels of jasmonic acid relative to control plants. Rather, the data would suggest that exposure to air from whitefly-infested plants reduces plants' defenses against herbivory, but these data wouldn't indicate that whiteflies induce plants to redirect their defenses to guard against microbial infection. Furthermore, the data concerning plants exposed to air from whitefly-free plants merely indicate that these plants increase their defenses against both herbivory and microbial infection when infested by whiteflies.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f6ba1a62

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: f6ba1a62

E-book Sales as a Percentage of Total Unit Sales in All Book Formats for a Large US Trade Publisher, by Genre, 2006, 2011, 2016

Genre	2006	2011	2016
science fiction and fantasy	0.6	27.7	36.7
cookbooks	0	2.9	10.5
travel guides	0	5.5	24.6
romance	0.3	40.6	56.2

E-books became an increasingly popular means of reading in the United States in the 2000s and 2010s, though that popularity was concentrated in titles that, like those in most fiction genres, are meant to be read straight through from beginning to end. For books in nonfiction genres that do not tell stories and require the reader to flip back and forth through a volume, e-books were significantly less commercially successful. This can be seen by comparing _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to illustrate the claim?

- A. the percentage of 2016 cookbook sales that were e-books with the percentage of 2016 science fiction and fantasy sales that were e-books.
- B. the percentage of 2006 romance sales that were e-books with the percentage of 2016 romance sales that were e-books.
- C. the percentage of 2006 romance sales that were e-books with the 2006 science fiction and fantasy sales that were e-books.
- D. the percentage of 2011 travel guide sales that were e-books with the percentage of 2016 travel guide sales that were e-books.

ID: f6ba1a62 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it uses data from the table to effectively support the claim that book genres that typically require the reader to start at the beginning of the story and read straight through are more commercially successful as e-books than other genres. For each of three years, the table presents four book genres and the percentage of total sales for each genre in e-book format. Cookbooks, a nonfiction genre, do not require the reader to read straight through. According to the table, 10.5 percent of total cookbook sales in 2016 were in the e-book format. The 2016 percentage of e-book sales was 36.7 percent in the science fiction and fantasy genre, which are typically stories read straight through from start to finish. The higher percentage of total sales of the story-based e-books in 2016 supports the claim in the text.

Choice B is incorrect because it compares the e-book sales of romance books in 2006 to those in 2016. Romance books are meant to be read straight through from start to finish. The text claims that books that are not stories and do not require reading straight through are not as commercially successful in e-book format as those that do. As this choice is only comparing e-book sales for one genre, it does not support the claim. Choice C is incorrect because both science fiction and fantasy and romance novels are fiction books meant to be read straight through from beginning to end. The text claims that books that are not stories and do not require reading straight through are less commercially successful in e-book format than those that do. As this choice does not compare e-book sales of story genres to e-book sales in genres that are not stories, it does not support the claim. Choice D is incorrect. Although the data in the table show that the travel guide e-books made up a greater percentage of total sales in 2016 than in 2011, this doesn't illustrate the claim in the text that e-books in nonfiction genres not meant to be read straight through are less commercially successful. The claim cannot be supported without comparing the percentage of e-book sales between fiction and nonfiction book genres from the table.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8296d9ff

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 8296d9ff

Three Studies' Estimated Average Velocity of LMC

Researchers	Study year	Estimated average velocity
Murai and Fujimoto	1980	344 km/s
Kallivayalil and colleagues	2006	378 km/s
Gardiner and colleagues	1994	297 km/s

In 2006, Nitya Kallivayalil and colleagues calculated the most accurate estimate yet of the average velocity (in kilometers per second) of the Large Magellanic Cloud (LMC) galaxy. Before the 2006 study, estimates of the average velocity were low enough for the LMC to maintain an orbit around the Milky Way galaxy, but according to an analysis by Gurtina Besla and colleagues, the estimated velocity from the 2006 study is too high for the LMC to maintain such an orbit. Therefore, if Besla and colleagues are correct, the maximum average velocity for the LMC that would allow it to maintain orbit around the Milky Way is likely _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement?

- A. above 344 km/s but below 378 km/s.
- B. above 297 km/s but below 344 km/s.
- C. above 378 km/s.
- D. below 297 km/s.

ID: 8296d9ff Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it uses data from the table to give the range of velocities for the LMC from the 1980 value (344 km/s) to the 2006 value (378 km/s), thereby effectively completing the text. The text indicates that before 2006, all the estimated velocities of the LMC were within the range necessary to maintain orbit around the Milky Way galaxy. It then indicates that, according to Besla and colleagues, the 2006 estimate of 378 km/s is too high to maintain that orbit. This strongly implies that if the 1980 value (344 km/s) is below the orbital threshold, and if Besla and colleagues are correct that the 2006 value (378 km/s) is above that threshold, the maximum orbital velocity for the LMC must be somewhere in the range from above 344 km/s to below 378 km/s.

Choice B is incorrect. The text indicates that the 2006 velocity estimate for the LMC (378 km/s) was the first estimate that exceeded the velocity needed to maintain orbit around the Milky Way. Thus, the 1980 estimate of 344 km/s and the 1994 estimate of 297 km/s must both be below the maximum possible orbital velocity for the LMC. Choice C is incorrect. The text states that Besla and colleagues’ analysis found that the velocity from the 2006 study (378 km/s) was too high for the LMC to maintain orbit around the Milky Way. Therefore, if a velocity of 378 km/s is too high, an even higher velocity will also be too high. Choice D is

incorrect. The text indicates that the 2006 velocity estimate for the LMC (378 km/s) was the first to exceed the velocity range required to maintain orbit around the Milky Way. Thus, the 1994 estimate of 297 km/s must be below the maximum possible orbital velocity for the LMC.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 848c49b2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 848c49b2

Icebergs generally appear to be mostly white or blue, depending on how the ice reflects sunlight. Ice with air bubbles trapped in it looks white because much of the light reflects off the bubbles. Ice without air bubbles usually looks blue because the light travels deep into the ice and only a little of it is reflected. However, some icebergs in the sea around Antarctica appear to be green. One team of scientists hypothesized that this phenomenon is the result of yellow-tinted dissolved organic carbon in Antarctic waters mixing with blue ice to produce the color green.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the team’s hypothesis?

- A. White ice doesn’t change color when mixed with dissolved organic carbon due to the air bubbles in the ice.
- B. Dissolved organic carbon has a stronger yellow color in Antarctic waters than it does in other places.
- C. Blue icebergs and green icebergs are rarely found near each other.
- D. Blue icebergs and green icebergs contain similarly small traces of dissolved organic carbon.

ID: 848c49b2 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would weaken the scientists’ hypothesis about icebergs that appear to be green. The text indicates that most icebergs are either mostly white or blue in color but that some icebergs in Antarctica appear to be green. The text goes on to say that the scientists hypothesized that this green color occurs when yellow-tinted dissolved organic carbon in ocean waters mixes with blue ice. A finding that both blue icebergs and green icebergs contain similarly small traces of dissolved organic carbon would suggest that something other than yellow-tinted organic carbon causes some icebergs’ green color, since the blue icebergs that contain yellow-tinted organic carbon remained blue instead of turning green.

Choice A is incorrect because, according to the text, the scientists’ hypothesis was that blue icebergs, not white ones, change color when their ice mixes with yellow-tinted dissolved organic carbon. A finding that white ice, because of its air bubbles, doesn’t change color when it’s mixed with dissolved organic carbon would therefore have no bearing on the scientists’ hypothesis. Choice B is incorrect because the text focuses only on Antarctic icebergs that appear to be green. It doesn’t indicate that icebergs in locations other than Antarctica have been found to have a green hue. A finding that dissolved organic carbon has a stronger yellow color in Antarctic waters than in other places would therefore have no bearing on the scientists’ hypothesis that green color in icebergs in Antarctica is caused by yellow-tinted dissolved organic carbon mixing with blue ice. Choice C is incorrect because, according to the text, the scientists’ hypothesis was that blue icebergs turn green when their ice mixes with yellow-tinted dissolved organic carbon in the sea around them. If that’s correct, one would expect blue icebergs and green icebergs to be located at a distance from each other since all blue icebergs in an area where the waters contain yellow-tinted dissolved organic carbon would take on a green hue. A finding that blue icebergs and green icebergs are rarely found near each other would therefore strengthen, not weaken, the researchers’ hypothesis.

Question ID 99ea4a43

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 99ea4a43

Laura Mulvey has theorized that in narrative film, shots issuing from a protagonist’s point of view compel viewers to identify with the character. Such identification is heightened by “invisible editing,” or editing so inconspicuous that it renders cuts between shots almost unnoticeable. Conversely, Mulvey proposes that conspicuous editing or an absence of point-of-view shots would induce a more critical stance toward a protagonist. Consider, for example, the attic scene in Alfred Hitchcock’s *The Birds*, a conspicuously edited sequence of tens of shots, few of which correspond to the protagonist’s point of view. According to Mulvey’s logic, this scene should affect viewers by _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. obscuring their awareness of the high degree of artifice involved in constructing the montage.
- B. lessening their identification with the protagonist, if not alienating them from the character altogether.
- C. compelling them to identify with the film’s director, whose proxy is the camera, and not with the protagonist.
- D. diverting their attention away from the film’s content and toward its stylistic attributes.

ID: 99ea4a43 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. We’re told that point-of-view shots and “invisible editing” make audiences identify with a character. We’re also told that obvious editing and a lack of point-of-view shots have the opposite effect. Since the sequence in *The Birds* falls into this second category, it should have the effect of reducing the audience’s connection with the protagonist.

Choice A is incorrect. The passage doesn’t mention viewers’ awareness of artifice (i.e., camera trickery) in films, so there’s no basis for this inference. Choice C is incorrect. The passage doesn’t mention the director at all, so there’s no basis for this inference. Choice D is incorrect. The passage doesn’t discuss whether a film’s “stylistic attributes” may distract viewers from the film’s story, so there’s no basis for this inference.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4634396d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 4634396d

Overgrazing by purple sea urchins has caused many kelp forests along North America’s west coast to be replaced by urchin barrens—areas stripped of vegetation and covered in purple sea urchins. Urchins in barrens persist in a state of starvation that lessens their nutritional value—and thus their appeal—to many predators. Sarah Gravem and colleagues placed sunflower sea stars, a once-abundant predator species suffering massive population declines in recent years, in aquariums that each contained a nutritionally poor and a nutritionally rich purple sea urchin. The researchers found that the sea stars selected the nutritionally rich urchin in 42.7% of trials and the nutritionally poor urchin in 37.5% of trials, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. sunflower sea stars are willing to hunt sea urchins, but if given a choice, they will prey on other more nutritious marine animals instead.
- B. sunflower sea stars are reluctant to feed on both nutritionally poor and nutritionally rich sea urchins and are therefore unlikely to thrive in kelp forests.
- C. sunflower sea stars are less likely to consume sea urchins in barrens than other species of sea stars are, putting sunflower sea stars at a high risk of extinction.
- D. sunflower sea stars do not always avoid foraging on nutritionally poor sea urchins, making sunflower sea star population recovery a potentially important tool for controlling urchin barrens.

ID: 4634396d Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of the researchers’ findings about purple sea urchins and sunflower sea stars. The text explains that urchin barrens are areas that used to be kelp forests but are now covered by purple sea urchins. The text suggests that because there is no more vegetation to be consumed in those areas, the urchins exist in a state of starvation that makes them less nutritional for many predators. The text goes on to explain that in a study with a choice between two purple sea urchins, sunflower sea stars (a predator species that has been substantially declining) consumed a nutritionally rich urchin 42.7% of the time and a nutritionally poor urchin 37.5% of the time. Because the sunflower sea stars didn’t always avoid consuming nutritionally poor urchins, even when nutritionally rich ones were available, it follows that helping sunflower sea star populations to grow could help control urchin barrens by increasing the number of sea stars that may consume and thus remove nutritionally poor purple sea urchins from barrens.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates only that when presented with purple sea urchins, the sunflower sea stars in the study consumed both nutritionally rich and nutritionally poor ones. It doesn’t suggest that sunflower sea stars generally prefer other marine animals that are more nutritious; there’s no mention of other marine animals. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that sunflower sea stars are generally reluctant to feed on sea urchins. In fact, the text indicates that the sunflower sea stars in the study did consume sea urchins, feeding on both nutritionally poor and nutritionally rich ones. Choice C

is incorrect because the text addresses only the willingness of sunflower sea stars to consume the type of sea urchins found in barrens (nutritionally poor sea urchins), not how likely other species of sea stars are to consume them.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3349d220

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 3349d220

Data collected by the Mars rover *Curiosity* at the Gale Crater’s Murray Formation are suggestive of hydrological deposition of sediment in the distant past. To characterize the nature of the depositional environment, Frances Rivera-Hernández et al. analyzed the grain size of Murray Formation sediment, finding that although there are intervals of coarse grains, most of the sediment consists of fine grains that show signs of cracking due to episodic desiccation. Rivera-Hernández et al. concluded that the coarse grains are sandstone, which tends to be deposited by flowing water, whereas the fine grains are mudstone, which is slowly deposited by settling out of suspension in low-flow water, leading the researchers to posit that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. although the area of the Murray Formation experienced a prolonged period of dryness that prevented a lake from forming, water flowing from a distant source was present.
- B. a lake existed at the Murray Formation for a prolonged period, though the lake occasionally experienced drying and there were periods in which one or more streams were present.
- C. one or more streams existed at the Murray Formation for an extended period until being replaced by a lake that persisted for only a brief period before permanently drying.
- D. a stream-fed lake was present at the Murray Formation for an extended period, and although the streams experienced occasional drying, the lake did not.

ID: 3349d220 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the sediments found at the Gale Crater’s Murray Formation on Mars. The text states that data gathered by the *Curiosity* rover suggest that bodies of water deposited sediment on Mars’s surface long ago. The text goes on to say that studying the sediment, Rivera-Hernández et al. found some coarse grains they believe are sandstone, which tends to be left by flowing water, and many more fine grains they believe are mudstone, which tends to slowly sink in low-flow water. The text further indicates that the researchers noted cracks in the fine grains that suggest there were cycles of desiccation, or drying, at the site. Taken together, this information suggests that a lake (a body of low-flow water) existed at the site for a prolonged period but occasionally experienced drying and that there were periods in which one or more streams (flowing water) were present, since the extended existence of a lake would account for the abundance of fine grains, periods of drying would account for the cracks in the fine grains, and periods with streams would account for the sections of coarse grains.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that an abundance of fine grains of sediment was found at the Murray Formation site, which suggests that a low-flow water source (such as a lake) was present. Further, the text makes no mention of where the water at the site may have originated from. Choice C is incorrect because the evidence described in the text doesn’t support the idea that there were streams at the Murray Formation for an extended period and a lake for just a short time. The abundance of

fine grains suggests that a lake (a body of low-flow water) was present for an extended time, not just a short time, and the sections of coarse grains suggest that one or more streams (bodies of flowing water) were intermittently present while the lake existed, not at a separate time. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text suggests that both a low-flow body of water (such as a lake) and flowing water (such as streams) existed at the Murray Formation site, meaning that there could have been a stream-fed lake, the text explains that the fine grains that signify the presence of a lake exhibit cracking that indicates periods of desiccation, or drying, which suggests that a lake was present but *did* occasionally dry out.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d6f0ae33

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: d6f0ae33

A student is writing a paper about *One Night in Miami...*, a 2020 film directed by Regina King and written by Kemp Powers. Powers adapted the film’s screenplay from his 2013 play, which he wrote after learning about a 1964 meeting that took place in Miami, Florida, between four prominent figures of the Civil Rights movement: Malcolm X, Muhammad Ali, Jim Brown, and Sam Cooke. The student claims that although Powers was inspired by this meeting, the film is best understood not as a precise retelling of historical events but rather as a largely imagined but informed representation of them.

Which quotation from an article about *One Night in Miami...* would be the most effective evidence for the student to include in support of this claim?

- A. “When Powers learned of the meeting, he initially planned to write a much longer work about its four famous participants rather than focusing on the meeting itself.”
- B. “*One Night in Miami...* received numerous awards and nominations, including an Academy Award nomination for Powers for Best Adapted Screenplay.”
- C. “Powers has described *One Night in Miami...* as the story of four friends encouraging and supporting one another while engaged in a crucial political debate about how best to achieve equality for Black people in the United States.”
- D. “Powers could find only the most superficial historical details about the meeting, so he read extensively about the four individuals and their thinking at the time in an effort to portray what might have happened between them.”

ID: d6f0ae33 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it provides a quotation that effectively supports the student’s claim about the film *One Night in Miami...*. The quotation states that in researching the play on which the film was based, Kemp Powers only found superficial details about what actually happened during the 1964 meeting in Miami between four leading Civil Rights leaders, meaning that there is very little information about the meeting in the historical record. In the absence of greater details, it wouldn’t have been possible for the film to be a precise retelling of the historical events it depicts. The quotation explains that to compensate for this lack of information about the meeting, Powers did extensive research into the four figures and how they thought at the time in order to speculate in an informed way about what they might have said or what might have occurred between them. Therefore, the quotation effectively supports the claim that the film is best understood not as a precise retelling of a historical event but as a deeply informed imaginative rendering of that event.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the quotation discusses how on learning about the 1964 meeting in Miami, Powers was inspired to write a play and, later, to adapt it into a screenplay, it doesn’t discuss Powers’s approach to representing what had occurred in the meeting. Instead, it states that Powers didn’t initially plan to write a story only “focusing on the meeting itself” but rather had considered writing a “much longer” and more expansive work about the meeting’s four participants. Choice B is incorrect because the quotation doesn’t discuss Powers’s approach to representing historical events in his play and in the film; instead, the

quotation focuses on the film's positive critical reception by mentioning that it received numerous awards and nominations. Choice C is incorrect. Although the quotation references historical events that are discussed directly in the play and film by explaining how the four historical figures featured in the story engage in political debates about contemporary issues, it doesn't specify to what extent Powers's representation of what occurred during the 1964 meeting in Miami is a factual retelling of what happened and how much is an imaginative rendering of what might have happened. Rather, the quotation focuses on Powers's description of the film's basic premise and how the characters engage with the historical context of its setting.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5827cc83

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 5827cc83

NASA’s Aspera mission, led by Carlos Vargas, will investigate the circumgalactic medium (CGM), the huge swaths of low-density gas that fill and surround galaxies. Specifically, the team will focus on portions of the gas that exist in a “warm-hot” phase: these portions haven’t previously been observable but are thought to fuel new star formation and hold most of the mass that makes up a galaxy. Using a telescope capable of revealing these parts of the CGM, the Aspera mission should help answer long-standing questions about how galaxies emerge, change, and even interact.

- Which choice best states the main idea of the text?
- A. As the leader of NASA’s Aspera mission, Vargas will be the first person to investigate the makeup of the CGM.
 - B. Although galaxies that are surrounded by the CGM have been studied, researchers have been unable to directly observe low-density gas in the CGM in the “warm-hot” phase.
 - C. Researchers don’t yet have a complete understanding of the process of galaxy evolution but have raised the possibility that galaxies interact with each other at times.
 - D. The Aspera mission is expected to produce the first direct observations of CGM gas in the “warm-hot” phase, which likely has an important role in the evolution of galaxies.

ID: 5827cc83 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text begins by mentioning NASA’s Aspera mission, which will investigate the low-density gas that makes up the circumgalactic medium (CGM). According to the text, this mission will focus on a portion of the CGM’s gas that exists in a “warm-hot” phase; this “warm-hot” gas has not been previously observed, but it is thought to make up most of the mass of galaxies and play a part in star formation. Finally, the text mentions a telescope capable of examining this previously unobservable “warm-hot” gas: the Aspera mission will use this telescope in the hope of answering questions about galaxy formation and change. Therefore, the main idea of the text is that the Aspera mission is likely to produce the first direct observations of CGM gas in the “warm-hot” phase, which likely has an important role in the evolution of galaxies.

Choice A is incorrect. Although this choice mentions the Aspera mission, names its leader, and generally states the mission’s purpose, it does not reference the “warm-hot” gas or fully convey the reason why the Aspera mission is significant. Choice B is incorrect. Although this choice mentions the “warm-hot” gas that makes up a portion of the CGM, it does not reference the Aspera mission or describe its importance. The text also does not mention that galaxies surrounded by the CGM have been studied. Choice C is incorrect. Although this choice describes a problem related to the CGM that researchers have been attempting to solve and presents the speculation of those researchers, it does not mention the Aspera mission or describe its purpose.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 756aad6b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 756aad6b

To understand how Paleolithic artists navigated dark caves, archaeologist M^a Ángeles Medina-Alcaide and her team tested different lighting methods in a cave in Spain using replicas of artifacts found in European caves with art. They used three different Paleolithic light sources—torches, animal-fat lamps, and fireplaces—determining that each likely had a specific purpose. For instance, the team learned that the animal-fat lamps were less useful than torches while walking because the lamps didn’t illuminate the cave floor.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Medina-Alcaide and her team’s study demonstrated that fireplaces were essential to the creators of Paleolithic cave art.
- B. Medina-Alcaide and her team discovered that Paleolithic cave artists in Spain used animal-fat lamps more often than they used torches.
- C. Medina-Alcaide and her team were reluctant to draw many conclusions from their study because of the difficulty they had replicating light sources based on known artifacts.
- D. Medina-Alcaide and her team tested Paleolithic light sources and learned some details about how Paleolithic artists traveled within dark caves.

ID: 756aad6b Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text indicates that archaeologist M^a Ángeles Medina-Alcaide and her team used replicas of Paleolithic light sources to understand how Paleolithic artists moved through dark caves. The researchers learned, for example, that torches were more helpful for moving through caves than animal-fat lamps were. Thus, the main idea of the text is that Medina-Alcaide and her team tested Paleolithic light sources and learned some details about how Paleolithic artists traveled within dark caves.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t address the usefulness of fireplaces for Paleolithic cave artists; it only mentions fireplaces briefly as one of the three lighting methods the researchers tested. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss how often Paleolithic cave artists used each kind of light source tested. Although the text does compare animal-fat lamps with another lighting method, the point of that comparison is that animal-fat lamps were less useful than torches when walking, not that one method was used more often than another. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss either how difficult it was for Medina-Alcaide and her team to replicate light sources or how the team felt about drawing conclusions from their study. Instead, the text reveals that the team was able to conclude that each light source likely had a distinct purpose.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID adff3419

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: adff3419

Artificial leaves are a developing renewable energy technology that mimics the process of photosynthesis in plants. These devices are silicon-based solar cells coated in chemical catalysts that activate reactions that split water molecules into hydrogen and oxygen gas. The technology, while generating lots of interest, is not yet commercially viable as a large-scale energy source. To meet this challenge, scientists from many fields are researching ways to store, transport, and distribute the energy the devices produce while other scientists are working to improve the cost and efficiency of the devices.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Continued research and development in artificial-leaf technology is needed before the devices can be widely used as an energy source.
- B. The recent increase in the commercial use of artificial leaves as an energy source has encouraged many scientists to research ways to improve the technology.
- C. Artificial leaves split water molecules into oxygen and hydrogen gas using catalysts more efficiently than plants do using the process of photosynthesis.
- D. Artificial leaves were developed to mimic the natural process of photosynthesis in plants in order to store energy for long-term commercial use.

ID: adff3419 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. According to the text, artificial leaves are a renewable energy technology that’s in development and generating interest. The text goes on to state that artificial-leaf technology "is not yet commercially viable as a large-scale energy source" and that scientists from several fields are doing additional research to refine the technology. Thus, the main idea is that continued research and development in artificial-leaf technology is needed before the devices can be widely used as an energy source.

Choice B is incorrect. While the text does state that scientists from many fields are researching artificial leaves, they’re doing so to address the fact that the leaves are not yet commercially viable, rather than in response to an increase in commercial use. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text does explain that artificial leaves help split water molecules into oxygen and hydrogen gas using catalysts, it doesn’t argue that this process is more efficient than photosynthesis. This is merely a detail of the text and not the main idea, which is about the additional research needed to improve the cost and efficiency of these artificial leaves. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text indicates that artificial leaves mimic photosynthesis in plants, this is an incidental detail in support of the main idea that additional research is needed to make artificial leaves commercially viable.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 07302985

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 07302985

Jürgen Kocka and other historians of capitalism rarely discuss domestic capitalism in Africa before the period of European colonization, implicitly presenting capitalism as external to and imposed on Africa. Crislayne Alfagali and other Africanist scholars have shown, however, that in parts of Africa, returns-focused investment, the establishment of open markets for wage labor, and other features of capitalism predated colonization. One reason for this discrepancy is that historians of capitalism tend to focus on longitudinal economic data drawn from archival records, which do not exist for much of precolonial Africa.

Which statement about Alfagali and other Africanist scholars is best supported by information in the text?

- A. They likely make use of different types of evidence than historians of capitalism typically rely on.
- B. They likely differ from historians of capitalism in the methods they use to derive longitudinal economic data from archival records.
- C. They likely have a different view about which activities should be considered capitalist in nature than historians of capitalism do.
- D. They likely view capitalism as having been more beneficial for Africa than historians of capitalism do.

ID: 07302985 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a statement about Alfagali and other Africanist scholars that is supported by the text. The last sentence of the text explains that historians of capitalism generally rely on a type of data that requires "archival records, which do not exist for much of precolonial Africa." Nevertheless, Alfagali and other Africanist scholars have demonstrated that features of capitalism including "returns-focused investment,...open markets for wage labor, and other features of capitalism" existed in parts of Africa before colonization. Because archival records typically used by historians of capitalism aren't available for precolonial Africa, Alfagali and other Africanist scholars of precolonial capitalism in Africa likely used atypical sources for their studies.

Choice B is incorrect because the text states that archival records containing longitudinal economic data "do not exist for much of precolonial Africa." If these records don't exist for precolonial Africa, then Alfagali and other Africanist scholars couldn't derive data from them by any method. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn't suggest that Alfagali and other Africanist scholars define capitalism differently than other historians of capitalism do. On the contrary, the text simply asserts that specific features they found, such as "returns-focused investment [and] open markets for wage labor," are "features of capitalism," which implies scholarly agreement that these activities are capitalist in nature. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn't indicate any effects of capitalism in Africa, positive or negative. Rather, the text explains why precolonial Africa has been omitted from mainstream histories of capitalism and presents work by Alfagali and other Africanist scholars that challenges and corrects the historical record of precolonial capitalism.

Question ID 834ce843

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 834ce843

In the early 1970s, art historian Michael Baxandall created an approach to viewing art called the “period eye,” which explains how to look at art through the lens of its historical period. Baxandall argued that it is critical that art historians understand and communicate the original social and cultural contexts of older works of art so that it is clear what the artists intended and how the pieces would have been understood by their original viewers. Since it was first introduced, Baxandall’s period eye has significantly influenced the practice of art history.

Which statement, if true, would most strongly support the claim in the underlined sentence?

- A. Art historians working today have largely rejected the idea, common among Baxandall’s predecessors, that artists’ intentions should influence how artworks are interpreted.
- B. For some historical periods, it is difficult for art historians to reconstruct how the original viewers of artworks understood what artists’ intentions for their works were.
- C. Numerous art historians of the late twentieth century and twenty-first century have focused their scholarship on how various artworks were interpreted at the time of their creation.
- D. Many art historians working before the 1970s produced detailed analyses of the social and cultural contexts of older artworks, though few extended that approach to artworks produced in their own lifetimes.

ID: 834ce843 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a statement that, if true, would most strongly support the underlined claim that Baxandall’s period eye has significantly influenced the practice of art history since its introduction. The text explains that the period eye—an approach Baxandall introduced in the early 1970s—directs art historians to understand how artworks were originally understood by viewers from the same historical period in which the works were created. If numerous art historians working in the late twentieth and twenty-first centuries—that is, in the decades after Baxandall’s introduction of the approach—have focused on how artworks were interpreted at the time of their creation, their scholarship would correspond to the definition of period eye provided by the text, thereby supporting the claim that the period eye has been significantly influential.

Choice A is incorrect because, as the text explains, Baxandall explicitly recommended examining the social and cultural contexts in which older artworks were produced in order to appreciate the artists’ intentions. Thus, a widespread rejection of artistic intention as an interpretive guide would weaken, not support, the claim that Baxandall influenced the practice of art history. Choice B is incorrect because this statement considers a limitation in applying the period eye approach—namely, the difficulty of reconstructing original viewers’ understanding for some historical periods—instead of addressing whether the approach has influenced the practice of art history. Choice D is incorrect because the statement describes the practice of art historians working before the 1970s, prior to Baxandall’s introduction of the period eye. Pre-1970s scholarship cannot demonstrate Baxandall’s

influence on art history; if anything, it would suggest that some elements of his approach predated him, which has no bearing on whether his particular formulation has shaped the field since.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cc945c1e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: cc945c1e

“Gestures” in painting are typically thought of as bold, expressive brushstrokes. In the 1970s, American painter Jack Whitten built a 12-foot (3.7-meter) tool he named the “developer” to apply paint to an entire canvas in one motion, resulting in his series of “slab” paintings from that decade. Whitten described this process as making an entire painting in “one gesture,” signaling a clear departure from the prevalence of gestures in his work from the 1960s. Some art historians claim this shift represents “removing gesture” from the process. Therefore, regardless of whether using the developer constitutes a gesture, both Whitten and these art historians likely agree that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. any tool that a painter uses to create an artwork is capable of creating gestures.
- B. Whitten’s work from the 1960s exhibits many more gestures than his work from the 1970s does.
- C. Whitten became less interested in exploring the role of gesture in his work as his career progressed.
- D. Whitten’s work from the 1960s is much more realistic than his work from the 1970s is.

ID: cc945c1e Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Whitten thinks the tool made “one gesture” paintings, while historians think the tool “removed gesture” from the process completely. But putting that debate aside, both Whitten and the historians would agree that the paintings he made with the tool in the ’70s have way fewer gestures than his paintings from the ’60s, in which gestures are “prevalent,” meaning widely and extensively present.

Choice A is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text only discusses the “developer”—it never mentions other tools. Choice C is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. If anything, the text suggests the opposite: that Whitten became more interested in exploring the role of gesture in his work as his career progressed, as his earlier paintings had many gestures, and his ’70s paintings only had “one gesture.” Choice D is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never discusses the “realism” of Whitten’s art.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5712a45b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 5712a45b

Percentage Point Changes in US Federal Outlays Relative to GDP by Congressional Status

Period	Congressional status	Change in total outlays	Change in nondefense outlays	Change in defense outlays
1981–1988	divided	–0.4	–1.3	0.9
1975–1976	divided	2.7	3.0	–0.3
1977–1980	undivided	0.3	0.6	–0.3
1964–1968	undivided	1.9	1.4	0.5
1969–1974	divided	–1.8	2.1	–3.9

Economist Steve H. Hanke has shown that divided US Congresses—which occur when one party holds the majority in the House of Representatives and another holds the majority in the Senate—tend to accompany reductions in total federal outlays (spending) relative to gross domestic product (GDP), which Hanke interprets to reflect decreases in government size. Hanke calculated the percentage point change in total outlays (encompassing nondefense and defense outlays) for consecutive US Congresses. Hanke has pointed to his calculations as evidence that a divided Congress may be a “necessary but not sufficient condition” for a decrease in government size to occur.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support the underlined claim?

- A. The periods of undivided Congresses were associated with increases in nondefense outlays, whereas all the periods of divided Congresses except one were associated with reductions in defense outlays.
- B. All the periods of divided Congresses were associated with reductions in total outlays, although two periods were also associated with increases in nondefense outlays.
- C. The periods of undivided Congresses were associated with increases in total outlays, whereas all the periods of divided Congresses were associated with reductions in either nondefense outlays or defense outlays.
- D. All the periods of divided Congresses except one were associated with reductions in total outlays, whereas the periods of undivided Congresses were associated with increases in total outlays.

ID: 5712a45b Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The claim is that divided Congresses are necessary but insufficient—that is, we need divide Congresses, but they are not enough—to decrease government size, as measured by total federal outlays. This choice accurately expresses the supporting data from the “change in total outlays” part of the graph. Within the data set, divided Congresses sometimes decreased total outlays, but undivided ones never did.

Choice A is incorrect. The claim is only about government size, as measured by total federal outlays—defense and nondefense outlays aren't relevant. Choice B is incorrect. The claim is only about government size as measured by total federal outlays—nondefense outlays aren't relevant. Choice C is incorrect. The claim is only about government size as measured by total federal outlays—specific information about defense or nondefense outlays isn't relevant.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1931a93b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 1931a93b

Electra is a circa 420–410 BCE play by Sophocles, translated in 1870 by R.C. Jebb. Electra, who is in mourning for her dead father and her long-absent brother, is aware of the intensity of her grief but believes it to be justified: _____

Which quotation from *Electra* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “O thou pure sunlight, and thou air, earth’s canopy, how often have ye heard the strains of my lament, the wild blows dealt against this bleeding breast, when dark night fails!”
- B. “Send to me my brother; for I have no more the strength to bear up alone against the load of grief that weighs me down.”
- C. “I know my own passion, it escapes me not; but, seeing that the causes are so dire, will never curb these frenzied complaints, while life is in me.”
- D. “But never will I cease from dirge and sore lament, while I look on the trembling rays of the bright stars, or on this light of day.”

ID: 1931a93b Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. Electra states that she “knows her own passion,” which shows that she’s aware of the intensity of her grief. But she also claims that the “causes are so dire”—meaning the reasons for her grief are so awful—that she can’t let it go, which shows that she believes her grief is justified.

Choice A is incorrect. This quotation doesn’t show that Electra believes her grief is justified. It shows that Electra is aware of its intensity, but it doesn’t suggest that she believes she has a legitimate reason for feeling that way. Choice B is incorrect. This quotation doesn’t show that Electra believes her grief is justified. It shows that Electra is aware of its intensity, but it doesn’t suggest that she believes she has a legitimate reason for feeling that way. Choice D is incorrect. This quotation doesn’t show that Electra believes her grief is justified. It shows that Electra is aware of the intensity of her grief, but it doesn’t suggest that she has a legitimate reason for feeling that way.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a61456ac

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: a61456ac

Tatiana R. Feuerborn and colleagues analyzed the genomes of more than a hundred domesticated dogs from sites in Siberia dating from 11,000 years ago to the present. They found that the dogs constituted a genetically isolated population of Arctic breeds until approximately 2,000 years ago, at which point there was substantial interbreeding with Near Eastern dog breeds. Furthermore, beginning around 2,000 years ago, some sites contain artifacts consistent with a Near East origin, like glass beads, but the people show no evidence of having traveled extensively outside Siberia. From this, Feuerborn and colleagues concluded that around 2,000 years ago _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. dogs and artifacts like glass beads began to be transported from the Near East to Siberia.
- B. people from Siberia began to reach the Near East, where they acquired dogs and artifacts such as glass beads.
- C. glass beads and other artifacts from the Near East began to be exchanged for dogs from Siberia.
- D. dogs from the Near East began to be exchanged for glass beads and other artifacts from Siberia.

ID: a61456ac Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of Feuerborn and colleagues’ findings about sites in Siberia. The text states that genomic analysis of many domesticated dogs from Siberian sites dating from the last 11,000 years revealed that the dogs represented a genetically isolated population of breeds (that is, they didn’t reproduce with dogs of any outside breeds) until about 2,000 years ago, when there is evidence that the dogs began interbreeding with breeds from the Near East. The text also indicates that around the same time, the sites began to contain glass beads and other artifacts seeming to be from the Near East, even though there is no evidence that the people of those sites traveled widely outside Siberia. Because there is evidence of Near East dog breeds and Near East artifacts at Siberian sites beginning about 2,000 years ago but no evidence of the people’s travel to the Near East around that time, it’s reasonable to infer that Feuerborn and colleagues concluded that dogs and artifacts like glass beads were transported to Siberia from the Near East, starting around 2,000 years ago.

Choice B is incorrect because the text explicitly states that there is no evidence that the people of the Siberian sites 2,000 years ago traveled extensively beyond Siberia, which they would’ve had to do to reach the Near East; therefore, it wouldn’t make sense to conclude that the presence of Near East dog breeds and artifacts like glass beads suggests that people from Siberia began arriving in the Near East around 2,000 years ago. Choice C is incorrect because the text addresses the presence of Near East dog breeds (and evidence of interbreeding with Siberian dogs) and artifacts like glass beads at Siberian sites starting about 2,000 years ago, suggesting only that the dogs and artifacts started to arrive in Siberia around that time. The text doesn’t suggest the purpose of the arrival of the Near East dogs and artifacts or give any indication of Siberian dog breeds being transported elsewhere through trade. Choice D is incorrect because the text addresses the presence of Near East dog breeds and artifacts like

glass beads at Siberian sites starting about 2,000 years ago, suggesting only that the dogs and artifacts started to arrive in Siberia around that time; it doesn't suggest the purpose of this arrival and makes no mention of Siberian glass beads or other artifacts of Siberian origin.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 165b2f2e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 165b2f2e

Guilds in French Cities in the Late Eighteenth Century

City	Date	Inhabitants	Number of guilds	Inhabitants per guild
Paris	1766	600,000	133	4,511
Bordeaux	1762	80,000	49	1,633
Rouen	1775	74,000	112	661
Lyon	1789	143,000	72	1,986

Guilds—local associations of artisans and merchants in the same industry—were widespread in France from the medieval period until the late eighteenth century. But guilds were much more numerous relative to the population in some cities than in others: for example, _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement?

- A. there were 49 guilds in Bordeaux but 72 guilds in Lyon despite the two cities having nearly equal numbers of inhabitants.
- B. Lyon had far fewer inhabitants than Paris did but had many more guilds.
- C. there was one guild for every 661 inhabitants in Rouen but one guild for every 4,511 inhabitants in Paris.
- D. Paris had 133 guilds and 600,000 inhabitants, or one guild for every 4,511 inhabitants.

ID: 165b2f2e Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The claim we’re trying to prove is that guilds were much more numerous relative to population in some cities than others. This choice describes the guilds per number of inhabitants in two cities (Rouen and Paris), showing significant differences between guilds relative to population in these cities.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice misreads the table. Bordeaux had 80,000 inhabitants, according to the table, while Lyon had 143,000, so it isn’t correct to say that they had "nearly equal numbers of inhabitants." Lyon had almost twice as many inhabitants. Choice B is incorrect. This choice misreads the table. Although Lyon did have fewer inhabitants than Paris, it didn’t have more guilds—Paris had 133 guilds versus Lyon’s 72. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the claim. To show that guilds were more numerous relative to population in some cities than others, we would need to compare at least two cities, and this choice only mentions one.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 622c99ae

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 622c99ae

Poetry in Classical Nahuatl, the language of the Aztec Empire, relies on *difrasismo*, or a parallel noun construction that conventionally operates as a single metaphor. For example, the common difrasismo *in cuauhtli in ocelotl* (literally, “the eagle, the jaguar”) signifies “warrior.” The device’s function is both formal—providing structure to lines of verse—and ritual: semantic relations among the two nouns and the concept they signify can be tenuous, as in the previous example, such that difrasismos are often only intelligible according to the conceptual associations observed in Aztec ceremonial culture.

Which statement about the difrasismo *in cuauhtli in ocelotl* is most strongly supported by the text?

- A. Its metaphorical significance derives from the semantic equivalence of the two nouns constituting the difrasismo.
- B. Its unintelligibility may cause its formal function within a line of verse to go unnoticed by present-day readers.
- C. Its apparent obscurity can be resolved when considered in the proper cultural context.
- D. Its frequency in Classical Nahuatl poetry confirms its intelligibility to the Aztec audience.

ID: 622c99ae Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a statement about the difrasismo *in cuauhtli in ocelotl* that is directly supported by the text. The text begins by describing difrasismo, a device used in Classical Nahuatl poetry. The text then mentions the device’s two functions: a formal one (giving structure to lines of verse) and a ritualistic one. The text indicates that the relation between the words in a difrasismo may appear tenuous without the additional information supplied by Aztec ceremonial culture but that the meaning becomes intelligible in the context of that information. Therefore, the difrasismo’s apparent obscurity can be resolved when considered in the proper cultural context.

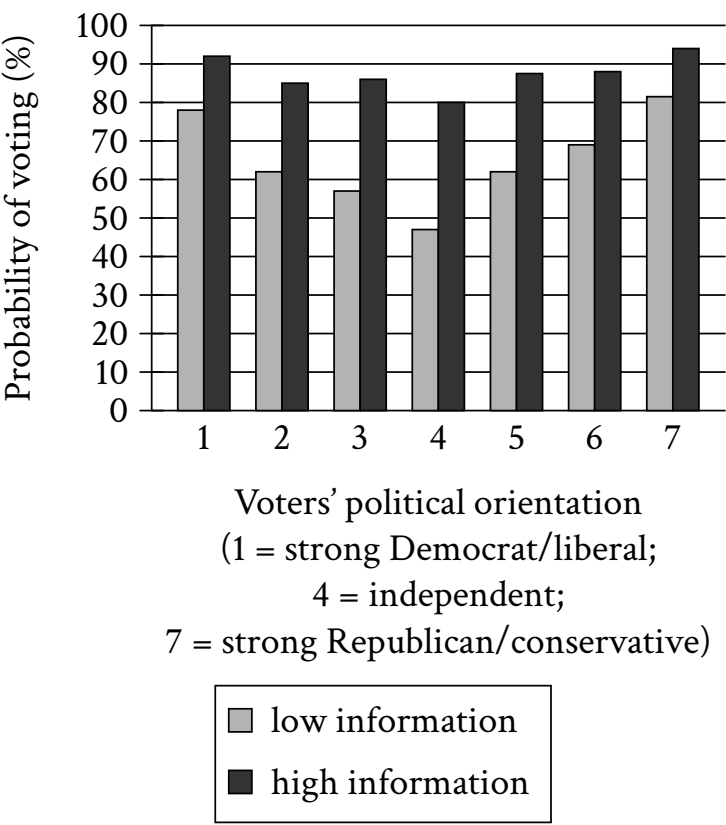
Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that the two nouns used in a difrasismo are semantically equivalent; instead, the text indicates that the two nouns used in a difrasismo make up a single metaphor whose meaning is often intelligible only in the context of information supplied by Aztec ceremonial culture. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that there’s a relationship between the formal function of the difrasismo and the difrasismo’s intelligibility. Additionally, the text suggests that present-day readers who are familiar with Aztec ceremonial culture wouldn’t find the difrasismo to be unintelligible. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that the frequency of difrasismo’s use in Classical Nahuatl is a necessary feature of intelligibility: the text indicates that an infrequently used difrasismo would presumably also be intelligible to members of an Aztec audience who are sufficiently familiar with Aztec ceremonial culture.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: ca48b8fd

Voters’ Political Orientation, Level of Political Information, and Probability of Voting



Economists Kerwin Kofi Charles and Melvin Stephens Jr. investigated a variety of factors that influence voter turnout in the United States. Using survey data that revealed whether respondents voted in national elections and how knowledgeable respondents are about politics, Charles and Stephens claim that the likelihood of voting is driven in part by potential voters’ confidence in their assessments of candidates—essentially, the more informed voters are about politics, the more confident they are at evaluating whether candidates share their views, and thus the more likely they are to vote.

Which choice best describes data in the graph that support Charles and Stephens’s claim?

- A. At each point on the political orientation scale, high-information voters were more likely than low-information voters to vote.
- B. Only low-information voters who identify as independents had a voting probability below 50%.
- C. The closer that low-information voters are to the ends of the political orientation scale, the more likely they were to vote.
- D. High-information voters were more likely to identify as strong Democrats or strong Republicans than low-information voters were.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it uses data from the graph to effectively support Charles and Stephens's claim about how level of information affects voters. The graph shows the probability of voting for both high- and low-information voters in seven categories of political orientation. Charles and Stephens claim that "the more informed voters are about politics...the more likely they are to vote." This statement correctly asserts that the graph shows a higher probability of voting for high-information voters than for low-information voters at each of the seven political orientations. Thus, this statement accurately cites data from the graph that support Charles and Stephens's claim about how level of information affects voters.

Choice B is incorrect. Although this statement is correct that the only probability in the graph below 50% is for low-information voters categorized as independent (orientation 4), the claim in question is about the relative likelihood that low- and high-information voters will vote, and without some reference to high-information voters, this statement cannot help support such a comparison. Choice C is incorrect. Although this statement is correct that the highest probabilities of voting for low-information voters are at the ends of the orientation scale (1 and 7), the claim in question is about the relative likelihood that low- and high-information voters will vote, and without some reference to high-information voters, this statement cannot help support such a comparison. Choice D is incorrect because the graph does not give any information about how many people are represented in any of the categories, so this statement is not based on data from the graph. Furthermore, even if we did have this information, the claim is about how level of information affects voters' probability of voting, not whether they're likely to strongly identify with a particular political party.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 969c6dd3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 969c6dd3

Studies conducted in individual Western societies have demonstrated associations between personality traits and five musical factors (mellowness, unpretentiousness, sophistication, intensity, and contemporariness) underlying individual preferences for styles of Western music. To investigate these associations across cultures, David M. Greenberg et al. collected music-preference assessments for Western genres and self-reported personality traits from participants in fifty-three countries across six continents. The study confirmed that the five-factor framework accurately captured participants’ tastes in Western music, and, moreover, the study found similar correlations between patterns of these factors and of personality traits, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. across cultural contexts, people who share similar profiles of personality traits tend to prefer listening to similar types of Western music.
- B. the five-factor framework can likely be used to predict preferences for non-Western music styles based on personality traits even if the characteristics of those styles substantially differ from characteristics of Western music styles.
- C. the strength of the relationship between personality traits and musical preferences varies less across cultures than researchers had previously assumed.
- D. people with a relatively high degree of familiarity with Western music styles are likely to express stronger preferences for those styles than people with a relatively low degree of familiarity with those styles are.

ID: 969c6dd3 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the cross-cultural study on personality traits and music preferences. The text first explains that previous studies in individual Western societies had found links between personality traits and five musical factors that shape individual preferences for Western music styles. This finding suggests that people in those societies who have similar personality traits likely prefer listening to similar types of Western music. The text goes on to state that Greenberg et al. conducted a study that expanded this research to a broader, cross-cultural context (fifty-three countries across six continents). This study validated that the five-factor framework accurately represented participants’ preferences for Western music and that the study found patterns linking those preferences to personality traits. It follows, then, that people with similar profiles of personality traits tend to prefer similar types of Western music across cultural contexts.

Choice B is incorrect because Greenberg et al.’s study examined only preferences for Western music styles, so the text provides no basis for inferring that the five-factor framework could predict preferences for non-Western music styles. The study was specifically limited to Western musical styles, and extending the study’s findings to non-Western music would go beyond what the study investigated or supports. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t mention what researchers had previously assumed about cultural variation in the strength of the relationship between personality traits and musical preferences. The text presents the cross-cultural consistency of the association between musical preferences and personality traits as a new finding but doesn’t

mention previous expectations or assumptions about this association. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn't address familiarity with Western music styles or suggest that familiarity influences preference strength for those styles. Greenberg et al.'s study focused on the relationship between personality traits and musical preferences across cultural contexts, not on how exposure or familiarity might affect those preferences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d8b42653

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: d8b42653

Indigenous cultures possess unique knowledge of the medicinal uses of plants. According to a 2021 study, 73 percent of the medicinal uses of plants native to North America are reflected in the vocabulary of a single Indigenous language. However, as more and more Indigenous people exclusively speak a globally dominant language, such as English, their ancestral languages fade from daily use. These facts lend added importance to tribal nations’ efforts to preserve their languages. By ensuring the continued use of Cherokee, Ojibwe, and the hundreds of other Indigenous languages in what is now the United States, tribal nations are also _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. increasing the number of medicinal plants represented in the vocabularies of Indigenous languages.
- B. transmitting terms for medicinal plants from Indigenous languages to globally dominant languages.
- C. preserving knowledge about the medicinal value of plants native to the tribal nations’ lands.
- D. ensuring that citizens of tribal nations have physical access to medicinal plants.

ID: d8b42653 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the relationship between Indigenous languages and knowledge of the medicinal uses of plants. The text states that Indigenous cultures possess special knowledge of the medicinal uses of plants, which is reflected in their vocabulary. The text then discusses how tribal nations are working to preserve their languages, whose daily use is declining as globally dominant languages become increasingly dominant in Indigenous communities. Given that the languages of tribal nations in what is now the United States function as repositories of knowledge about plants’ medicinal uses, it logically follows that continued use of those languages will assist with passing on knowledge about the medicinal value of plants native to the tribal nations’ lands.

Choice A is incorrect because the text states that preserving Indigenous languages will increase the knowledge, not the number, of medicinal plants. Choice B is incorrect because the text is concerned with how vocabulary about the medicinal value of plants can be preserved through the continued daily use of Indigenous languages, not with how such vocabulary can be incorporated into globally dominant, non-Indigenous languages. Moreover, the text explains that the exclusive use of globally dominant languages in Indigenous communities comes at an expense to the continued daily use of those communities’ languages. Given this relationship, it is unlikely globally dominant languages would borrow Indigenous vocabulary pertaining to plants’ medicinal uses. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss physical access to medicinal plants, instead focusing on Indigenous knowledge and language surrounding the medicinal uses of plants.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a873f6e6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a873f6e6

An archaeological team led by Piotr Bieliński and Sultan al-Bakri found remnants of a 4,000-year-old Bronze Age board game at a site in Oman. Little is left of the game except a stone board, which is carved with a grid and has places to hold game pieces. Some scholars claim that the game was largely played by traders.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the scholars’ claim?

- A. Other examples of the game dating to the same period have been found in the remains of several homes in the region, including in one home that may have belonged to a trader.
- B. Similar games have been found in other sites dating to the same period that were connected to the site in Oman via trade routes.
- C. The other known examples of the game dating to the same period have been found along routes that seem to have been used primarily by traders at the time.
- D. Remnants of other goods have been found at the site in Oman that probably also reached the location through trade.

ID: a873f6e6 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support the scholars’ claim about the board game. The text explains that the remains of a 4,000-year-old board game were found in Oman. The text then states that scholars claim this board game was played mostly by traders. If the other known examples of this board game from the same time period were discovered along routes that seem to have been used primarily by traders, this finding would directly support the scholars’ claim because it suggests that the game was largely played by traders who brought it with them for entertainment as they traveled.

Choice A is incorrect because this finding would suggest only that a single trader may have possessed examples of the board game, perhaps for the purpose of trading or selling the game to residents of Oman. For this reason, the finding wouldn’t directly support the scholars’ claim that the majority of the game’s players were traders. Choice B is incorrect because this finding doesn’t mention the board game at all, referring only to similar games found at other sites, and would therefore provide no direct support for the scholars’ claim about the board game. Choice D is incorrect because this finding doesn’t mention the board game at all, referring only to the remains of other goods found at the site in Oman, and would therefore provide no direct support for the scholars’ claim about the board game.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8b86f339

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 8b86f339

Characteristics of Five Recently Discovered Gas Exoplanets

Exoplanet designation	Mass (Jupiters)	Radius (Jupiters)	Orbital period (days)	Distance from the Sun (parsecs)
TOI-640 b	0.88	1.771	5.003	340
TOI-1601 b	0.99	1.239	5.331	336
TOI-628 b	6.33	1.060	3.409	178
TOI-1478 b	0.85	1.060	10.180	153
TOI-1333 b	2.37	1.396	4.720	200

“Hot Jupiters” are gas planets that have a mass of at least 0.25 Jupiters (meaning that their mass is at least 25% of that of Jupiter) and an orbital period of less than 10 days (meaning that they complete one orbit around their star in less than 10 days), while “warm Jupiters” are gas planets that meet the same mass criterion but have orbital periods of more than 10 days. In 2021, Michigan State University astronomer Joseph Rodriguez and colleagues announced the discovery of five new gas exoplanets and asserted that four are hot Jupiters and one is a warm Jupiter.

- Which choice best describes data from the table that support Rodriguez and colleagues’ assertion?
- A. None of the planets have an orbital period of more than 10 days, and TOI-628 b has a mass of 6.33 Jupiters.
 - B. TOI-1478 b has an orbital period of 153 days, and the masses of all the planets range from 0.85 to 6.33 Jupiters.
 - C. All the planets have a radius between 1.060 and 1.771 Jupiters, and only TOI-1333 b has an orbital period of more than 10 days.
 - D. Each of the planets has a mass greater than 0.25 Jupiters, and all except for TOI-1478 b have an orbital period of less than 10 days.

ID: 8b86f339 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it accurately describes data from the table that support Rodriguez and colleagues’ assertion about the classifications of the five new gas exoplanets. The text describes two categories of gas planets: hot Jupiters, which have a mass of at least 0.25 Jupiters and an orbital period of less than 10 days, and warm Jupiters, which have the same mass characteristic but have orbital periods of more than 10 days. According to the table, four of the gas exoplanets discovered by Rodriguez and colleagues have a mass of at least 0.25 Jupiters and an orbital period of less than 10 days, while one of the planets has a mass of at least 0.25 Jupiters and an orbital period of more than 10 days. These data therefore support Rodriguez and colleagues’ assertion that four of the new exoplanets are hot Jupiters and one is a warm Jupiter.

Choice A is incorrect because it doesn't accurately describe the data from the table. Although the table shows that TOI-628 b has a mass equivalent to 6.33 Jupiters, the table also shows that one of the planets—TOI-1478 b—does indeed have an orbital period of more than 10 days. Choice B is incorrect because it doesn't accurately describe the data from the table. Although the table does show that the masses of the five planets range from 0.85 to 6.33 Jupiters, the table also shows that TOI-1478 b has an orbital period of 10.180 days, not 153 days. Choice C is incorrect. According to the table, TOI-1333 b has an orbital period of only 4.720 days, not more than 10 days. Additionally, although the table does show that all the planets have a radius between 1.060 and 1.771 Jupiters, the text indicates that a planet may be classified as a hot Jupiter or a warm Jupiter based on its mass and orbital period, not on its radius, making the information about the range of the five planets' radius values irrelevant.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f27e490b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: f27e490b

Optical tweezers are specialized scientific tools—particularly useful in biology and medicine—that use high-powered beams of light to trap and manipulate minuscule particles for study. Use of the tool has led to several scientific and medical breakthroughs over the last few decades, but the particles are often under prolonged exposure to the intense heat of the light beams. To overcome the risk of overheating, and thereby damage, researchers sometimes attach nano-sized glass beads to particles, allowing the light to focus on the beads instead of the particles.

Based on the text, what is one advantage of attaching glass beads to particles when using optical tweezers?

- A. It decreases the time it takes for the optical tweezers to locate and capture the particles.
- B. It facilitates the maneuvering of particles without directly heating the particles themselves.
- C. It allows researchers to use weaker light beams to manipulate particles.
- D. It adds a material to which particles can transfer any heat absorbed from the optical tweezers’ light beam.

ID: f27e490b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text says that the glass beads get the "focus" of the light beams so that the particles don't overheat. From this, we can infer that the beads allow the particles to be manipulated without being directly heated by the light beams.

Choice A is incorrect. The text never says that attaching the glass beads saves time in any way. Choice C is incorrect. The text never says that attaching the glass beads allows researchers to use weaker light beams. Choice D is incorrect. The text doesn't say that the particles can transfer heat to the glass beads—rather, it says the heat from the light focuses on the glass beads instead of the particles.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d878f4e2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: d878f4e2

Disco remains one of the most ridiculed popular music genres of the late twentieth century. But as scholars have argued, the genre is far less superficial than many people believe. Take the case of disco icon Donna Summer: she may have been associated with popular songs about love and heartbreak (subjects hardly unique to disco, by the way), but like many Black women singers before her, much of her music also reflects concerns about community and identity. These concerns are present in many of the genre’s greatest songs, and they generally don’t require much digging to reveal.

What does the text most strongly suggest about the disco genre?

- A. It has been unjustly ignored by most scholars despite the importance of the themes addressed by many of the genre’s songs.
- B. It evolved over time from a superficial genre focused on romance to a genre focused on more serious concerns.
- C. It has been unfairly dismissed for the inclusion of subject matter that is also found in other musical genres.
- D. It gave rise to a Black women’s musical tradition that has endured even though the genre itself faded in the late twentieth century.

ID: d878f4e2 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The text argues that disco is "far less superficial" than its popular perception might indicate, and that love and heartbreak are "subjects hardly unique to disco."

Choice A is incorrect. This choice conflicts with the text, which says that scholars argue that disco "is far less superficial than many people believe." Choice B is incorrect. This choice says the opposite of what the text suggests. The writer argues that the genre is not as superficial as commonly believed, but that it always reflected "concerns about community and identity." Choice D is incorrect. The text doesn’t support this choice. There’s nothing in the text about disco giving rise to an enduring Black women’s musical tradition.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4c57061a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 4c57061a

Having demonstrated that the power conversion efficiency of new perovskite photovoltaic cells is nearly indistinguishable from that of cells recycled multiple times, Xun Xiao and colleagues evaluated the levelized cost of electricity (LCOE)—a measure of cost per produced electricity unit that incorporates materials acquisition costs as well as operating costs—for power plants utilizing each type of cell. With a modeled 15-year cell lifetime, the LCOE of plants using new cells was 4.99 cents per kilowatt-hour, whereas that of plants using cells recycled three times was 4.05 cents per kilowatt-hour. Moreover, the LCOE differential grew from 18.8% to 31.3% when the modeled cell lifetime was reduced by two-thirds.

- Based on the text, which choice, if true, most coherently and directly accounts for the observation presented in the underlined sentence?
- A. Cells can be recycled multiple times without a significant decrease in power conversion efficiency, and thus recycling cells more frequently does not change the LCOE for plants using recycled cells.
 - B. Although potentially less expensive than producing new cells, recycling cells does incur costs, and thus reducing cell lifetimes entails greater cumulative costs.
 - C. Securing new cell materials is more expensive than recycling cell materials, and thus more frequent cell replacement entails greater disparity in cumulative costs.
 - D. As the modeled cell lifetime decreases, plant operating costs increase, and thus the LCOE for plants using new cells diverges from that of plants using recycled cells.

ID: 4c57061a Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents information that, if true, would coherently and directly account for the researchers’ observation about the LCOE differential between plants using new cells and plants using recycled cells. The text explains that the researchers found that the LCOE—a cost-per-unit electricity measure that includes the cost of acquiring the materials—is higher for plants using new cells than for plants using cells recycled three times, with the gap between them growing from 18.8% to 31.3% when the researchers reduced the modeled cell lifetime by two-thirds (that is, from 15 years to 5 years). If obtaining new cell materials were more expensive than recycling preexisting cell materials, then plants using new cells would incur greater materials costs than plants using recycled cells when cells need to be replaced, and the greater frequency of cell replacement entailed by a shorter cell lifetime would force plants using new cells to incur that greater cost more often—widening the gap between those plants and plants using recycled cells.

Choice A is incorrect because the information that efficiencies are similar between new and recycled cells (which the text already establishes) and that frequency of recycling doesn’t affect the LCOE for plants using recycled cells wouldn’t address the effect of shorter cell lifetimes on the LCOE of plants using new cells. Information about that effect would be needed to account for the observation that the gap between the LCOEs for the two types of plants widens when cell lifetimes are shortened. Choice B is

incorrect. Although the choice does point to the possibility of a scenario that could explain the growth in the LCOE differential (“potentially less expensive than producing new cells”), it presents that information as a concession (“although”) to its central assertion, which is that the cumulative costs would increase if cells had to be replaced more frequently than on the original 15-year timeline. This choice doesn’t indicate whether the increased cumulative costs in question are those of recycled-cell plants or both types of plants; either way, an increase in cumulative costs isn’t a coherent or direct explanation for why the difference in costs between new-cell plants and recycled-cell plants increases when the cell lifetime is reduced by two-thirds. A coherent and direct explanation for growth in the cost difference between the two types of plants must focus on a disparate effect on the plants’ costs; choice B, however, presents information that could be but is not necessarily relevant to a disparate effect and then doesn’t draw the relevant conclusion from it, instead drawing a conclusion about cumulative costs that doesn’t entail a growing differential. Choice D is incorrect because even if plant operating costs increase as cell lifetime decreases, that would be true for plants using new cells and for plants using recycled cells and thus wouldn’t be responsible for a divergence; therefore, the finding wouldn’t coherently and directly explain the observation that the gap between the LCOEs of the two types of plants widens as cell lifetimes are reduced.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7bf476c9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 7bf476c9

A student is examining a long, challenging poem that was initially published in a quarterly journal without explanatory notes, then later republished in a stand-alone volume containing only that poem and accompanying explanatory notes written by the poet. The student asserts that the explanatory notes were included in the republication primarily as a marketing device to help sell the stand-alone volume.

Which statement, if true, would most directly support the student’s claim?

- A. The text of the poem as published in the quarterly journal is not identical to the text of the poem published in the stand-alone volume.
- B. Many critics believe that the poet’s explanatory notes remove certain ambiguities of the poem and make it less interesting as a result.
- C. The publishers of the stand-alone volume requested the explanatory notes from the poet in order to make the book attractive to readers who already had a copy of the poem in a journal issue.
- D. Correspondence between the poet and the publisher reveals that the poet’s explanatory notes went through several drafts.

ID: 7bf476c9 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it would most directly support the student’s claim about the motivation for including explanatory notes with the stand-alone volume of the poem. The text explains that the poem had previously been published without the notes in a quarterly journal. It stands to reason that readers who had purchased the journal issue containing the poem would be unlikely to purchase an unchanged version of the poem in a stand-alone volume. However, the inclusion of notes in that volume would encourage the purchase of a stand-alone volume, since the later text would differ from the original by including the author’s own explanation of the poem. Therefore, if it were true that the publishers of the stand-alone volume had requested the notes to make the book attractive to readers who already had a copy of the journal issue, this fact would support the student’s claim that the notes were included primarily as a marketing device.

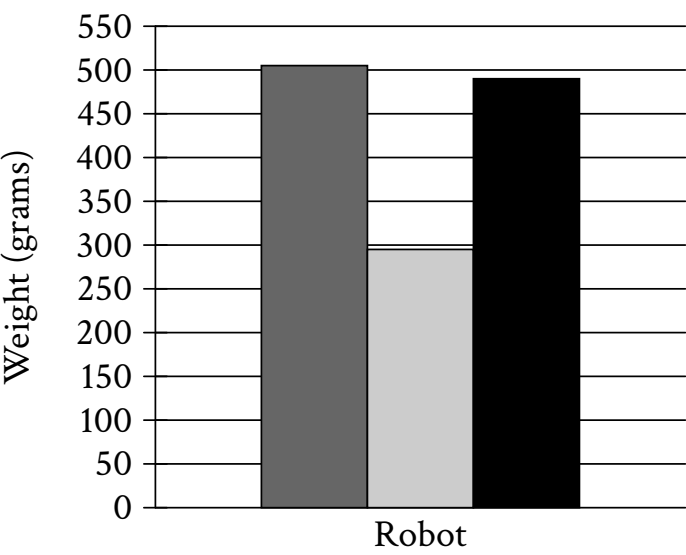
Choice A is incorrect because the student’s claim is about the motivation for including the explanatory notes in the stand-alone volume, not about changes that might have been made to the poem itself for publication in that volume; moreover, the text never suggests that such changes were made. Choice B is incorrect because the student’s claim is about why the explanatory notes were included in the stand-alone volume, not about how the notes affected readers’ and critics’ subsequent experience of the poem. Choice D is incorrect because the fact that the poet drafted multiple versions of the explanatory notes doesn’t directly address the issue of whether the notes were intended as a marketing device, as the student claims; the correspondence would support this claim only if it showed that the poet had revised the notes specifically to make them useful to the marketing of the stand-alone volume.

Question ID 804b474e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 804b474e

Weight of Three Aerial Robots



- Ultra-Fast Robot Hand
- Permanent Magnet Hand
- Yale Model T

Aerial robots vary considerably in their holding force; the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand, for example, has a holding force of 56 newtons, more than twice that of the Permanent Magnet Hand and more than four times that of the Yale Model T. Since an aerial robot must lift its own weight along with its cargo, engineer Jiawei Meng and colleagues used a ratio of each robot’s holding force to the robot’s weight to calculate payload capacity, with higher ratios corresponding to greater capacity, concluding that the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand has a higher payload capacity than the Yale Model T.

Which choice best describes data in the graph that support Meng and colleagues’ conclusion?

- A. The Ultra-Fast Robot Hand and the Yale Model T each weigh more than 450 grams.
- B. The Ultra-Fast Robot Hand and the Yale Model T each weigh more than the Permanent Magnet Hand does.
- C. The Yale Model T has a lower holding force than the Permanent Magnet Hand despite weighing more.
- D. The Ultra-Fast Robot Hand weighs only slightly more than the Yale Model T does.

ID: 804b474e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it describes data in the graph that support Meng and colleagues' conclusion that the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand has a higher payload capacity than the Yale Model T. According to the text, payload capacity is calculated by using a ratio of a robot's holding force to the robot's weight, and higher ratios indicate a greater payload capacity. The Ultra-Fast Robot Hand has a holding force of 56 newtons, four times greater than that of the Yale Model T. Additionally, the graph shows that the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand has a weight of approximately 500 grams, slightly more than the Yale Model T's weight of approximately 480 grams. Therefore, the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand has a higher ratio of holding force to weight than the Yale Model T. Since higher ratios correspond to greater payload capacity, the information from the graph indicating that the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand weighs only slightly more than the Yale Model T combined with the information in the text ultimately supports the conclusion that the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand has a higher payload capacity than the Yale Model T.

Choice A is incorrect. Although, according to the graph, it's true that both the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand and the Yale Model T weigh more than 450 grams, this statement doesn't support Meng and colleagues' conclusion that the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand has a higher payload capacity than the Yale Model T. This statement emphasizes a similarity, not a distinction, between the two robots. Choice B is incorrect. Although, according to the graph, it's true that the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand and the Yale Model T both weigh more than the Permanent Magnet Hand does, this statement doesn't support Meng and colleagues' conclusion that the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand has a higher payload capacity than the Yale Model T. This statement emphasizes a similarity, not a distinction, between the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand and the Yale Model T. Furthermore, the comparison to the Permanent Magnet Hand is irrelevant to the claim about the relative ratios and payload capacities of the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand and the Yale Model T. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text states that the Yale Model T has a lower holding force than the Permanent Magnet Hand, the graph provides no information about holding force. Moreover, information about the Permanent Magnet Hand is irrelevant to the conclusion by Meng and colleagues, which only concerns the Ultra-Fast Robot Hand and the Yale Model T.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 47c31054

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 47c31054

“The Young Girl” is a 1920 short story by Katherine Mansfield. In the story, the narrator takes an unnamed seventeen-year-old girl and her younger brother out for a meal. In describing the teenager, Mansfield frequently contrasts the character’s pleasant appearance with her unpleasant attitude, as when Mansfield writes of the teenager, _____

Which quotation from “The Young Girl” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “I heard her murmur, ‘I can’t bear flowers on a table.’ They had evidently been giving her intense pain, for she positively closed her eyes as I moved them away.”
- B. “While we waited she took out a little, gold powder-box with a mirror in the lid, shook the poor little puff as though she loathed it, and dabbed her lovely nose.”
- C. “I saw, after that, she couldn’t stand this place a moment longer, and, indeed, she jumped up and turned away while I went through the vulgar act of paying for the tea.”
- D. “She didn’t even take her gloves off. She lowered her eyes and drummed on the table. When a faint violin sounded she winced and bit her lip again. Silence.”

ID: 47c31054 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most effectively illustrates the claim in the text that in describing the teenaged girl, Mansfield contrasts the character’s pleasant appearance with her unpleasant attitude. In the quotation, Mansfield describes the teenager as having a “lovely nose” (a compliment about her appearance) but also as treating her makeup puff “as though she loathed it” (a judgment suggesting her unpleasant attitude).

Choice A is incorrect because the teenager's reaction to the flowers doesn’t make it clear that she has an unpleasant attitude, and nothing in the quotation indicates that any part of her appearance is pleasant. Choice C is incorrect because the quotation suggests that the teenager has an unpleasant attitude (being upset with the location and leaving the table before the narrator has paid for the meal) but doesn’t give any indication that she has a pleasant appearance. Choice D is incorrect because the quotation suggests that the teenager may have an unpleasant attitude (lowering her eyes, wincing, and sitting in silence) but doesn’t give any indication that any part of her appearance is pleasant.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1c0139f0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 1c0139f0

Geoglyphs are large-scale designs of lines or shapes created in a natural landscape. The Nazca Lines were created in the Nazca Desert in Peru by several Indigenous civilizations over a period of many centuries. Peruvian archaeologist Johnny Isla specializes in these geoglyphs. At a German exhibit about the Nazca Lines, he saw an old photograph of a large geoglyph of a whalelike figure and was surprised that he didn’t recognize it. Isla returned to Peru and used a drone to search a wide area, looking for the figure from the air. This approach suggests that Isla thought that if he hadn’t already seen it, the whalelike geoglyph _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. must represent a species of whale that went extinct before there were any people in Peru.
- B. is actually located in Germany, not Peru, and isn’t part of the Nazca Lines at all.
- C. is probably in a location Isla hadn’t ever come across while on the ground.
- D. was almost certainly created a long time after the other Nazca Lines geoglyphs were created.

ID: 1c0139f0 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Johnny Isla and the whalelike geoglyph. The text indicates that the German exhibit about the Nazca Lines included a photograph showing a whalelike geoglyph that Isla hadn’t known about before attending the exhibit, even though Isla “specializes in” Nazca Lines geoglyphs. Given his expertise, and his surprise at being unfamiliar with the whale glyph, the text strongly suggests that Isla believed he would have noticed the glyph if he had been to its location. Thus, the text implies that the whalelike geoglyph is likely in a location Isla had not previously been to.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t address either the species of whale that the geoglyph is meant to represent or its relationship to the earliest humans in the area that is now Peru. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text indicates that the photograph of the whalelike geoglyph was on display at a “German exhibit,” that exhibit was specifically “about the Nazca Lines,” which the text indicates are located in Peru. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text does indicate that the glyphs were created “over a period of many centuries,” the text doesn’t address when in that period of time any particular glyphs were created.

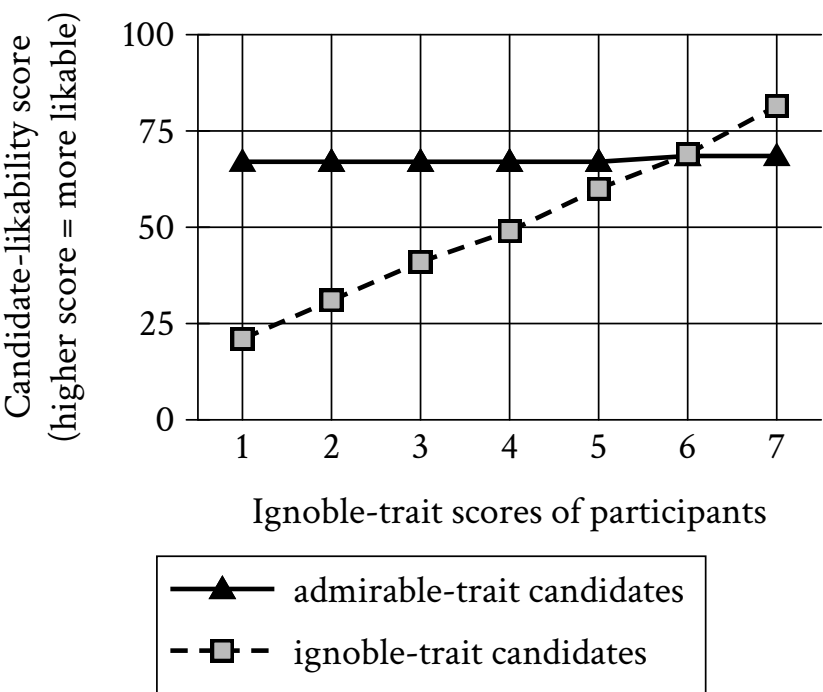
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dfc120dd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: dfc120dd

Participants' Likability Ratings for
Candidates by Candidates' Traits
and Participants' Ignoble-Trait Scores



Alessandro Nai et al. presented study participants with vignettes about fictive political candidates, portraying them as embodying a personality trait widely considered admirable (e.g., agreeableness) or one considered ignoble (e.g., cynicism). A survey recorded participants' ratings of the candidates' likability and showed that across participants, ignoble-trait candidates were less likable than admirable-trait candidates. However, when the researchers factored in the participants' own personality-trait scores, on a scale of 1 (least ignoble) to 7 (most ignoble), they concluded that this relative ranking of candidates persisted except among the participants with high ignobility scores.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that support the researchers' conclusion?

- A. There was a strong positive correlation between participants' ignobility scores and admirable-trait candidates' likability ratings, but there was no correlation between ignobility scores and ignoble-trait candidates' likability ratings.
- B. Participants with an ignobility score of 5 or less rated admirable-trait candidates as more likable than ignoble-trait candidates, whereas participants with an ignobility score of 6 or more rated ignoble-trait candidates as equally likable as or even more likable than admirable-trait candidates.
- C. Overall, participants rated admirable-trait candidates as quite likable, and that rating was not significantly affected by the participants' ignobility scores.

D. Unlike participants with an ignobility score of 6, participants with an ignobility score either greater or less than 6 gave admirable-trait candidates and ignoble-trait candidates different likability ratings.

ID: dfc120dd Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it describes data from the graph that support the researchers' conclusion that the trend of admirable-trait candidates being rated as more likable than ignoble-trait candidates held true when participants' own personality-trait scores were factored in, except among participants with high ignobility scores. The values on the x-axis represent survey participants grouped by their own ignobility scores, from low ignobility (1) to high ignobility (7), while the values on the y-axis represent the likability scores given to the political candidates. The graph shows that the full range of participants (from least to most ignoble) gave the admirable-trait candidates (represented by the line with triangles) a likability rating of approximately 70 out of 100; that is, regardless of their own level of ignobility, participants generally found admirable-trait candidates quite likable. However, the graph shows that participants varied in their views of ignoble-trait candidates (represented by the line with squares); likability ratings increased as the participants' own ignobility scores increased. Participants with low to medium-high ignobility scores (1 to 5) still rated the ignoble-trait candidates as less likable than the admirable-trait candidates, with all ratings falling below approximately 70, but participants with high ignobility scores (6 and 7) gave ratings equal to or higher than approximately 70. In other words, the previously observed trend of ranking admirable-trait candidates as more likable than ignoble-trait candidates persisted for participants with low to medium-high ignobility but not for participants with high ignobility.

Choice A is incorrect because it describes the opposite of what the graph shows. The graph shows a positive correlation between participants' ignobility scores and ignoble-trait candidates' likability ratings (as participants' ignobility scores increased, so did their ratings for ignoble-trait candidates' likability) and no correlation between ignobility scores and admirable-trait candidates' likability ratings (all participants gave admirable-trait candidates a rating of approximately 70 out of 100). Choice C is incorrect. The graph does show that regardless of their own ignobility scores, participants rated admirable-trait candidates as quite likable (a rating of approximately 70 out of 100). However, this doesn't support the researchers' conclusion because the conclusion has to do with how participants rated both types of candidates, not just the admirable-trait ones; moreover, the conclusion is that relative ratings were actually affected by the participants' ignobility scores. Choice D is incorrect. The graph does show that only participants with an ignobility score of 6 gave the same likability score to both admirable- and ignoble-trait candidates while participants with other ignobility scores gave a different rating for each candidate, but this doesn't support the researchers' conclusion. The conclusion isn't just that participants gave different ratings to the two types of candidates—it's that participants with low to medium-high ignobility scores specifically gave higher likability ratings to admirable-trait candidates than to ignoble-trait candidates and that participants with high ignobility scores didn't.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 663bef8a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 663bef8a

Many literary theorists distinguish between *fabula*, a narrative’s content, and *syuzhet*, a narrative’s arrangement and presentation of events. In the film *The Godfather Part II*, the *fabula* is the story of the Corleone family, and the *syuzhet* is the presentation of the story as it alternates between two timelines in 1901 and 1958. But literary theorist Mikhail Bakhtin maintained that *fabula* and *syuzhet* are insufficient to completely describe a narrative—he held that systematic categorizations of artistic phenomena discount the subtle way in which meaning is created by interactions between the artist, the work, and the audience.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A.

Literary theorist Mikhail Bakhtin argued that there are important characteristics of narratives that are not fully encompassed by two concepts that other theorists have used to analyze narratives.
- B.

Literary theorist Mikhail Bakhtin claimed that meaning is not inherent in a narrative but is created when an audience encounters a narrative so that narratives are interpreted differently by different people.
- C.

The storytelling methods used in *The Godfather Part II* may seem unusually complicated, but they can be easily understood when two concepts from literary theory are utilized.
- D.

Narratives that are told out of chronological order are more difficult for audiences to understand than are narratives presented chronologically.

ID: 663bef8a Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text begins by explaining that many literary theorists rely on the concepts of *fabula* (a narrative’s content) and *syuzhet* (a narrative’s arrangement and presentation of events) and illustrates these concepts by explaining how they can be applied to the film *The Godfather Part II*. The text then discusses how Mikhail Bakhtin, a literary theorist, argued that *fabula* and *syuzhet* can’t fully describe a narrative, since systematic categorizations such as these fail to account for all the ways in which interactions between the artist, the work, and the audience produce meaning. Thus, the main idea is that Bakhtin argued that there are important characteristics of narratives that are not fully encompassed by two concepts that other theorists have used to analyze narratives.

Choice B is incorrect because according to the text, Mikhail Bakhtin believed that meaning was created through the interactions of the artist, narrative, and audience, not simply through the interaction between the audience and narrative; moreover, the text doesn’t address whether Bakhtin focused on the ways in which different people interpret narratives differently. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text implies that the storytelling methods used in *The Godfather Part II* are complicated, it discusses the film only to illustrate how the concepts of *fabula* and *syuzhet* may be applied to a narrative. The film’s storytelling methods aren’t the primary focus of the text. Choice D is incorrect. The text discusses *The Godfather Part II*, whose narrative doesn’t adhere to a single chronological order, only to illustrate the concepts of *fabula* (a narrative’s content) and *syuzhet* (a narrative’s arrangement and presentation of events). The primary focus of this text isn’t the structure of this film or of other narratives that are told out of

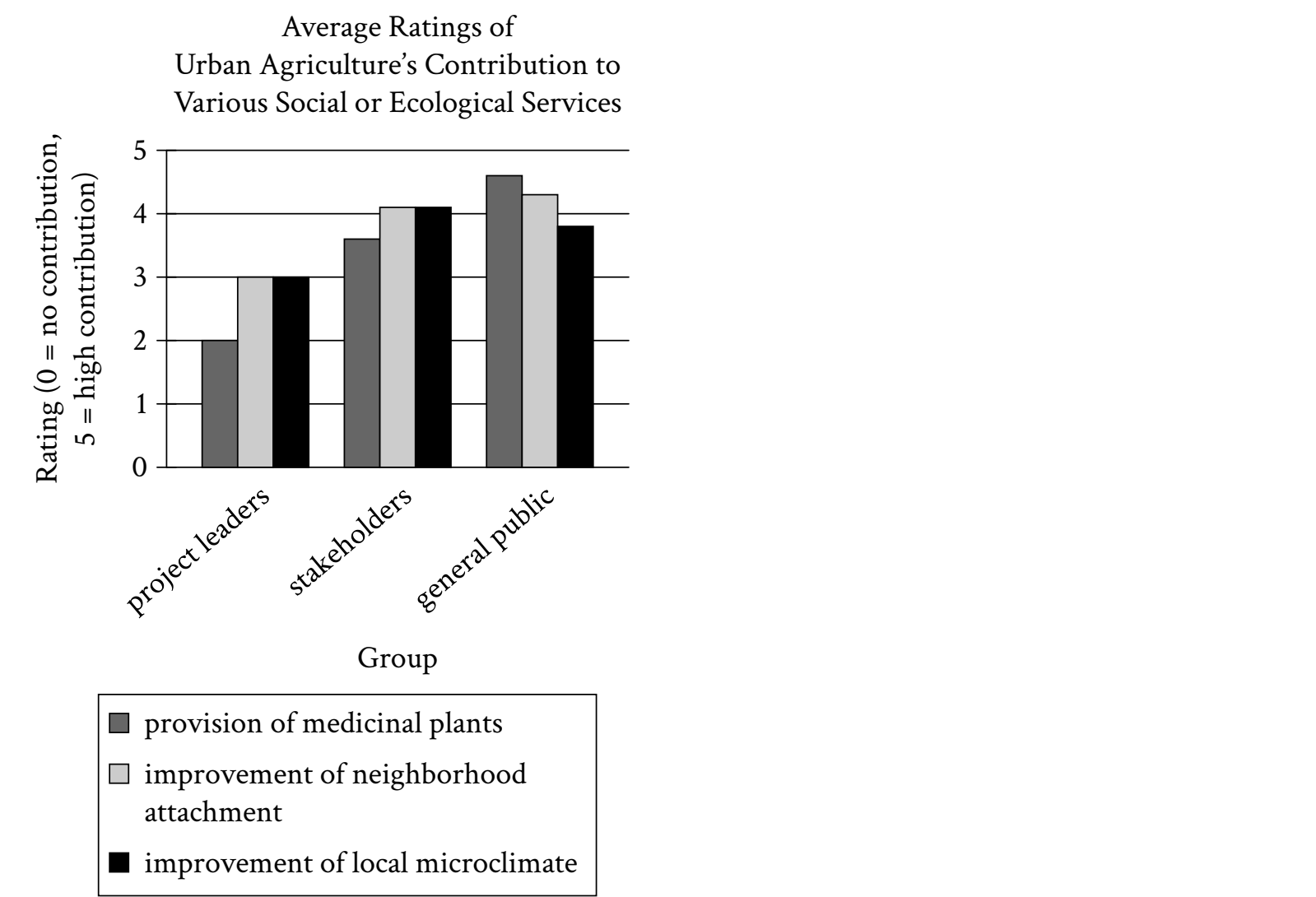
chronological order; moreover, the text doesn't consider whether such structures make it harder for audiences to understand narratives.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 34c4f656

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 34c4f656



Urban agriculture is the practice of growing plant- or animal-based products in urban settings such as community gardens and rooftop farms. Esther Sanyé-Mengual, Kathrin Specht, and their team surveyed three groups of people in Bologna, Italy—leaders of urban agriculture projects, stakeholders in urban agriculture (e.g., food researchers and urban farming associations), and the general public—to compare their views about the extent to which urban agriculture contributes to 25 social or ecological services that the team identified. The survey results show that, on average, project leaders rated urban agriculture as contributing less to

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the assertion?

- A. providing medicinal plants than to improving the local microclimate.
- B. improving community members’ sense of attachment to the neighborhood than to offering educational opportunities.

- C. improving the local microclimate than to providing medicinal plants.
- D. improving the local microclimate than to providing tourist attractions.

ID: 34c4f656 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the assertion about urban agriculture. The graph shows the average survey ratings, on a scale of 0 to 5, from three groups of people—project leaders, stakeholders, and the general public—concerning the contributions of urban agriculture. According to the graph, project leaders gave an average rating of approximately 2 to urban agriculture’s contributions to the provision of medicinal plants, which is lower than the average rating of approximately 3 that project leaders gave to urban agriculture’s contributions to both improving the local microclimate and improving a sense of attachment to the neighborhood. This shows that project leaders rated urban agriculture as contributing less to providing medicinal plants than to improving the local microclimate.

Choice B is incorrect because the graph doesn’t provide data about urban agriculture’s contribution to educational opportunities; therefore, this comparison can’t be made. Choice C is incorrect because it contradicts the data shown in the graph. On average, project leaders gave a rating of approximately 3 to urban agriculture’s contributions to improving the local microclimate, which is higher, not lower, than the average rating of approximately 2 that they gave to its contributions to providing medicinal plants. Choice D is incorrect because the graph doesn’t provide data about urban agriculture’s contribution to providing tourist attractions; therefore, this comparison can’t be made.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID af9c8dc1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: af9c8dc1

Some astronomers searching for extraterrestrial life have proposed that atmospheric NH₃ (ammonia) can serve as a biosignature gas—an indication that a planet harbors life. Jingcheng Huang, Sara Seager, and colleagues evaluated this possibility, finding that on rocky planets, atmospheric NH₃ likely couldn't reach detectably high levels in the absence of biological activity. But the team also found that on so-called mini-Neptunes—gas planets smaller than Neptune but with atmospheres similar to Neptune's—atmospheric pressure and temperature can be high enough to produce atmospheric NH₃.

Based on the text, Huang, Seager, and colleagues would most likely agree with which statement about atmospheric NH₃?

- A. Its presence is more likely to indicate that a planet is a mini-Neptune than that the planet is a rocky planet that could support life.
- B. Its absence from a planet that's not a mini-Neptune indicates that the planet probably doesn't have life.
- C. It should be treated as a biosignature gas if detected in the atmosphere of a rocky planet but not if detected in the atmosphere of a mini-Neptune.
- D. It doesn't reliably reach high enough concentrations in the atmospheres of rocky planets or mini-Neptunes to be treated as a biosignature gas.

ID: af9c8dc1 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it states a conclusion the researchers likely agree with, given the details in the text. The text explains that a biosignature gas is a gas that can be used as an indicator that a planet harbors some form of life and some astronomers have proposed that NH₃ could serve as a biosignature gas. The researchers evaluating this claim found that the atmosphere of rocky planets would be unlikely to reach "detectably high levels" of NH₃ without biological activity, which would support the proposal of NH₃ serving as a biosignature gas. However, the text also states that mini-Neptune planets can produce NH₃ in the absence of biological activity. Thus, the text is structured to lead to the conclusion that detectable levels of NH₃ in the atmospheres of rocky planets could constitute a biosignature, but that is not the case for detectable levels of the gas in the atmospheres of mini-Neptune planets.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that biological activity likely accounts for detectable levels of NH₃ in the atmospheres of rocky planets but mini-Neptune planets can have detectable levels of NH₃ in their atmospheres in the absence of biological activity. Therefore, both rocky planets and mini-Neptune planets can have detectable levels of atmospheric NH₃. Choice B is incorrect because the text states that for NH₃ to reach detectable levels in the atmospheres of rocky planets likely means they harbor biological activity, meaning that rocky planets with detectable NH₃ usually harbor biological activity. However, that does not entail that every rocky planet with biological activity will have detectable levels of NH₃ in their atmospheres. Choice D is incorrect because the text claims only that some astronomers have proposed using NH₃ as a biosignature gas without mentioning a minimum concentration of atmospheric NH₃ that must be met for it to function as a biosignature gas.

Question ID 792e99cf

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 792e99cf

Studies have demonstrated that positive feedback enhances real-world exercise performance and exercisers’ psychological experience of physical activity. Nicole Trewick and team tested their prediction that positive feedback would produce analogous results among participants cycling on a stationary bike in a virtual reality environment. After monitoring participants’ pedaling rate and heart rate to determine the effects on their physical endurance (e.g., their ability to sustain a certain target pedaling and heart rate) of feedback (positive, negative, or neutral) delivered at regular intervals, the researchers used participants’ questionnaire responses to assess their psychological experience of the task.

Assuming participants had similar baseline fitness levels, which finding from the study, if true, would most strongly suggest that positive feedback had the predicted psychological effect but not the predicted physical effect?

- A. Compared with participants who received positive feedback, participants who received neutral feedback reported lower enjoyment of the activity on average but maintained their heart and pedaling rates for longer durations than participants who received negative feedback.
- B. Compared with participants who received positive or neutral feedback, participants who received negative feedback reported lower enjoyment of the activity on average but maintained their heart and pedaling rates for longer durations.
- C. Compared with participants who received negative feedback, participants who received neutral feedback reported similar levels of enjoyment of the activity on average but maintained their heart and pedaling rates for shorter durations than participants who received positive feedback.
- D. Compared with participants who received negative or neutral feedback, participants who received positive feedback reported greater enjoyment of the activity on average but maintained their heart and pedaling rates for approximately similar durations.

ID: 792e99cf Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most strongly suggest that positive feedback had the psychological effect Trewick and her team predicted but not the predicted physical effect. The text explains that Trewick and team predicted positive feedback would, in a virtual reality environment, replicate two real-world results: an enhanced psychological experience (higher enjoyment) and improved physical endurance (longer maintenance of target heart and pedaling rates). If participants who received positive feedback reported greater enjoyment than those who received negative or neutral feedback, that would indicate that the predicted psychological effect occurred. At the same time, if those participants maintained their heart and pedaling rates for approximately the same durations as participants in the other groups, that would indicate that the predicted physical effect did not occur, since positive feedback didn’t produce longer maintenance of target heart and pedaling rates. Together, these results would indicate that positive feedback produced the predicted psychological effect but not the predicted physical effect.

Choice A is incorrect. Reported enjoyment being greater with positive feedback than with neutral feedback would be evidence of the predicted positive effect of positive feedback on participants' psychological experience, but the fact that participants had greater endurance with neutral feedback than with negative feedback wouldn't reveal anything about how endurance was affected by positive feedback, and thus wouldn't show that positive feedback didn't have the predicted physical effect. Choice B is incorrect. A finding that participants who received negative feedback reported lower enjoyment than participants who received positive or neutral feedback did would show that enjoyment was lowered by negative feedback but wouldn't confirm that enjoyment was greater with positive feedback than with neutral feedback, which a finding would need to do to demonstrate that positive feedback enhanced enjoyment as predicted. Further, the fact that participants who received negative feedback had greater endurance than those who received positive or neutral feedback wouldn't reveal whether positive feedback had an effect on endurance, either positive or negative. Choice C is incorrect because endurance being greater with positive feedback than with neutral feedback would show that positive feedback did have the predicted physical effect (enhancing endurance). Further, reported enjoyment being similar with neutral feedback and negative feedback wouldn't reveal anything about how enjoyment was affected by positive feedback, and thus wouldn't show that positive feedback had the predicted psychological effect.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7b3fa297

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 7b3fa297

Scholars are increasingly exploring the communication and preservation of ecological knowledge through Indigenous songs (e.g., Sakha songs about local ecosystems and those of the Kaluli people about rainforest sounds). In one study, ethnobiologist Dana Lepofsky et al. received insight from Kwaxsistalla Wathl'thla, a song keeper for the Kwakwaka'wakw people in Canada, into songs referencing the people's use of terraced gardens in intertidal zones along the Pacific Northwest coast for the cultivation of clams for consumption. Archaeological evidence of significant increases in clam size and abundance in that area concurrent with the documented past implementation of the method described in the songs supports the conclusion that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the practice used by ancestors of modern Kwakwaka'wakw people not only effectively maintained a food source but also promoted its robustness.
- B. non-Indigenous people around the Pacific Northwest coast adopted the practice developed by the Kwakwaka'wakw people after observing its efficacy.
- C. there is greater corroboration in the archaeological record of ecological practices described in Kwakwaka'wakw songs than of those described in Sakha and Kaluli songs.
- D. although contemporary Kwakwaka'wakw people have a deep understanding of and appreciation for the fishing and farming practices used by their ancestors, they no longer implement those methods.

ID: 7b3fa297 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of the use of songs by the Kwakwaka'wakw people to record and communicate ecological knowledge. The text indicates that some songs of the Kwakwaka'wakw people of Canada's Pacific Northwest region document how the people used terraced gardens in intertidal zones to cultivate clams for food. The text also explains that archaeological evidence shows increases in "clam size and abundance" that occurred along with the implementation of this cultivation method, suggesting the method's efficacy in not just supporting clam yields but also improving them. It follows, then, that the use of intertidal terraced gardens, as described in the songs, allowed the ancestors of modern Kwakwaka'wakw people to maintain clams as a food source and to cultivate larger and more numerous clams.

Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn't mention anything about cultivation practices among non-Indigenous people in the Pacific Northwest coastal region. Though the text conveys that archaeological evidence suggests that the clam cultivation practice mentioned in Kwakwaka'wakw people's songs was efficacious when implemented, it gives no indication that people other than the Kwakwaka'wakw adopted that practice. Choice C is incorrect because the text provides no information about the archaeological record as it pertains to Sakha and Kaluli songs and doesn't suggest that there is less corroboration of practices described in those songs than there is of the clam cultivation practice described in Kwakwaka'wakw songs. The Sakha and Kaluli songs are mentioned early in the text only as examples of Indigenous songs that contain ecological knowledge. Choice D is

incorrect because archaeological evidence that clam size and abundance both increased when Kwakwaka'wakw ancestors implemented intertidal terraced gardens provides information only about the past use of that method and doesn't suggest anything about present practices. The text indicates that knowledge of a past clam cultivation method is maintained in Kwakwaka'wakw songs but doesn't indicate whether modern Kwakwaka'wakw people use that or other fishing and farming practices used by their ancestors.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7a209bff

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 7a209bff

“Ghosts of the Old Year” is an early 1900s poem by James Weldon Johnson. In the poem, the speaker describes experiencing an ongoing cycle of anticipation followed by regretful reflection: _____

Which quotation from “Ghosts of the Old Year” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “What does this brazen tongue declare, / That falling on the midnight air / Brings to my heart a sense of care / Akin to fright?”
- B. “The snow has ceased its fluttering flight, / The wind sunk to a whisper light, / An ominous stillness fills the night, / A pause—a hush.”
- C. “It tells of many a squandered day, / Of slighted gems and treasured clay, / Of precious stores not laid away, / Of fields unreaped.”
- D. “And so the years go swiftly by, / Each, coming, brings ambitions high, / And each, departing, leaves a sigh / Linked to the past.”

ID: 7a209bff Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents the quotation that most effectively illustrates the claim that the speaker of the poem describes experiencing an ongoing cycle of anticipation followed by regretful reflection. In this quotation, the speaker notes that as years go by, “Each, coming”—that is, each new year as it comes—“brings ambitions high.” In other words, the speaker begins each new year with large goals. But the speaker goes on to say that as each year ends (“each, departing”), it “leaves a sigh / Linked to the past.” A sigh is an expression of longing or regret, so in the context of the whole quotation, this portion suggests that at the end of each year, the speaker regretfully reflects on not having achieved the ambitions formed at the beginning of the year. The phrases “the years go swiftly by,” “Each, coming,” and “each, departing” indicate that this experience happens over and over again: the speaker experiences a cycle of anticipation followed by regretful reflection.

Choice A is incorrect because this quotation does not describe an ongoing cycle of anticipation followed by regretful reflection. Instead, the speaker describes experiencing a sensation similar to fright as a result of something that has occurred at midnight. Specifically, the speaker has heard a “brazen tongue,” a figurative way of saying that the speaker has heard the clang of a bronze bell being rung. Choice B is incorrect because although this quotation does convey a sense of anticipation through its reference to “ominous stillness,” there is no suggestion of regretful reflection or any indication that the speaker is describing an ongoing cycle of anticipation followed by such reflection. Instead, the speaker is describing a particular moment when a winter storm appears to have momentarily calmed. Choice C is incorrect because although this quotation does convey a sense of regret (“many a squandered day”), nothing in the quotation suggests an ongoing cycle of anticipation followed by regret. Instead, the speaker is simply lamenting wasted time and opportunities.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8ef1dbda

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 8ef1dbda

In the mountains of Brazil, *Barbacenia tomentosa* and *Barbacenia macrantha*—two plants in the Velloziaceae family—establish themselves on soilless, nutrient-poor patches of quartzite rock. Plant ecologists Anna Abrahão and Patricia de Britto Costa used microscopic analysis to determine that the roots of *B. tomentosa* and *B. macrantha*, which grow directly into the quartzite, have clusters of fine hairs near the root tip; further analysis indicated that these hairs secrete both malic and citric acids. The researchers hypothesize that the plants depend on dissolving underlying rock with these acids, as the process not only creates channels for continued growth but also releases phosphates that provide the vital nutrient phosphorus.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ hypothesis?

- A. Other species in the Velloziaceae family are found in terrains with more soil but have root structures similar to those of *B. tomentosa* and *B. macrantha*.
- B. Though *B. tomentosa* and *B. macrantha* both secrete citric and malic acids, each species produces the acids in different proportions.
- C. The roots of *B. tomentosa* and *B. macrantha* carve new entry points into rocks even when cracks in the surface are readily available.
- D. *B. tomentosa* and *B. macrantha* thrive even when transferred to the surfaces of rocks that do not contain phosphates.

ID: 8ef1dbda Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support the researchers’ hypothesis about the plants’ dependence on dissolving rock. The text indicates that the roots of the two plant species grow directly into quartzite rock, where hairs on the roots secrete acids that dissolve the rock. The researchers hypothesize that the plants depend on this process because dissolving rock opens spaces for the roots to grow and releases phosphates that provide the plants with phosphorus, a vital nutrient. If the plants carry out this process of dissolving rock even when the rock already has spaces into which the roots could grow, that would support the researchers’ hypothesis because it suggests that the plants are getting some advantage—such as access to phosphorus—from the action of dissolving rock. If the plants don’t benefit from dissolving rock, they would be expected to grow in the cracks that already exist, as doing so would mean that the plants don’t have to spend energy creating and secreting acids; if, however, the plants create new entry points by dissolving rock even when cracks already exist, that would support the hypothesis that they depend on dissolving rock for some benefit.

Choice A is incorrect because the existence of soil-inhabiting members of the Velloziaceae family with similar root structures to those of the two species discussed in the text wouldn’t support the researchers’ hypothesis that the species discussed in the text depend on dissolving rock. If other such members exist, that might suggest that the root structures can serve more functions than secreting acids to dissolve rock (since dissolving rock may not be necessary for plants living in soil), but that wouldn’t suggest anything about whether the species discussed in the text benefit from dissolving rock. Choice B is incorrect because

differences in the proportions of citric and malic acid secreted by the two species would be irrelevant to the hypothesis that the plants depend on dissolving rock. There's no information in the text to suggest that the proportion of each acid has any bearing on the process of dissolving rock or on any benefits the plants might receive from that process. Choice D is incorrect because if the two species thrive on rocks without phosphates, that would weaken the researchers' hypothesis that the plants depend on dissolving rock partly because dissolving rock gives them access to phosphates. If the plants can survive on rocks without getting a vital nutrient by dissolving those rocks, then either the nutrient isn't actually vital for those plants or they can get the nutrient in some way other than by dissolving rocks.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 681862a4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 681862a4

East Australian humpback whales migrate up to 10,000 kilometers each year to reach their breeding grounds. Researchers long believed that migrating whales live only on the extra energy they stored up during the feeding season. But marine biologist Vanessa Pirotta and her team aren't so sure. They analyzed 20 years of observations of the migrating whales made by citizen scientists (members of the public who help collect data for scientific research). The team claims that the whales may not live only on their stored energy during migration.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the team's claim?

- A. Citizen scientists have observed many different types of marine animals feeding alongside the whales.
- B. Citizen scientists have made many observations of the whales feeding as they migrate to their breeding grounds.
- C. Citizen scientists have made more observations of the whales migrating to their breeding grounds than of the whales returning to their feeding grounds.
- D. Citizen scientists have recently begun to observe the whales migrating to their breeding grounds earlier in the year.

ID: 681862a4 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support Pirotta and her team's claim that East Australian humpback whales may not live only on stored energy during migration. The text explains that it has long been thought that East Australian humpback whales store extra energy during the feeding season and then use that energy to survive while traveling to their breeding grounds. If it were true that citizen scientists have often seen the whales feeding as they migrate to the breeding grounds, that would indicate that the whales sometimes feed and take in additional energy during the journey, meaning that they may not rely only on energy they stored before migrating.

Choice A is incorrect because finding that citizen scientists have observed many different types of marine animals feeding alongside the whales would have no bearing on the team's claim; the behavior of other animals is irrelevant, and without indicating the timing of the observed feeding, the finding wouldn't reveal whether the whales rely only on previously stored energy or ever take in additional energy during migration. Choice C is incorrect because finding that citizen scientists have more often observed whales on the way to their breeding grounds than returning to their feeding grounds would have no bearing on the team's claim. Since it would provide information about the timing of observations but not about the whales' observed activities, the finding wouldn't reveal whether the whales rely only on previously stored energy or ever take in additional energy during migration. Choice D is incorrect because finding that citizen scientists have recently started seeing the whales migrate to their breeding grounds earlier in the year would have no bearing on the team's claim. Since it would provide information about a change in the timing of migration but not about the whales' observed activities while migrating, the finding wouldn't reveal whether the whales rely only on previously stored energy or ever take in additional energy during migration.

Question ID 27ed6a27

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 27ed6a27

The novelist Toni Morrison was the first Black woman to work as an editor at the publishing company Random House, from 1967 to 1983. A scholar asserts that one of Morrison’s likely aims during her time as an editor was to strengthen the presence of Black writers on the list of Random House’s published authors.

Which finding, if true, would most strongly support the scholar’s claim?

- A. The percentage of authors published by Random House who were Black rose in the early 1970s and stabilized throughout the decade.
- B. Black authors who were interviewed in the 1980s and 1990s were highly likely to cite Toni Morrison’s novels as a principal influence on their work.
- C. The novels written by Toni Morrison that were published after 1983 sold significantly more copies and received wider critical acclaim than the novels she wrote that were published before 1983.
- D. Works that were edited by Toni Morrison during her time at Random House displayed stylistic characteristics that distinguished them from works that were not edited by Morrison.

ID: 27ed6a27 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support the scholar’s claim about Toni Morrison’s likely goal of strengthening the presence of Black writers on Random House’s list of published authors. The text explains that Morrison was the first Black woman to be an editor for Random House and that she was an editor there from 1967 to 1983. If it were true that Random House published a higher percentage of works by Black authors throughout the 1970s—during most of Morrison’s time working there—than it had previously published, that would suggest that Morrison may have made a deliberate effort to strengthen the presence of Black authors on the list of Random House’s published authors, thus supporting the scholar’s claim.

Choice B is incorrect because the scholar’s claim is about Morrison’s work as an editor at a publishing company and her likely effort to strengthen the presence of Black writers on that company’s list of published authors. It might be true that Black authors interviewed in the 1980s and 1990s often cited Morrison’s novels as an influence on their work, but that finding would simply suggest something about how those authors approached their work; it wouldn’t show that Morrison intended to increase the number of Black writers among the published authors specifically at Random House. Choice C is incorrect because the scholar’s claim is about Morrison’s work as an editor at a publishing company, not about her work as a novelist. Therefore, a finding that Morrison’s novels published after 1983 sold more copies and were more widely acclaimed than her earlier novels would have no bearing on the claim that as an editor Morrison made an effort to ensure that more Black writers were present on Random House’s list of published authors. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text discusses Morrison’s work as an editor at Random House, the scholar’s claim focuses on Morrison’s likely effort in that role to increase the number of Black writers present on

Random House's list of published authors, not on the influence she may have had on the content of the works she edited. Without knowing whether Morrison's stylistic influence led to more publications or if Morrison applied her influence specifically to works by Black writers, the finding that works edited by Morrison could be identified by stylistic characteristics would have no bearing on the claim that Morrison intended to strengthen the presence of Black writers among the published authors at Random House.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 720fc59a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 720fc59a

In a paper about p-i-n planar perovskite solar cells (one of several perovskite cell architectures designed to collect and store solar power), Lyndsey McMillon-Brown et al. describe a method for fabricating the cell’s electronic transport layer (ETL) using a spray coating. Conventional ETL fabrication is accomplished using a solution of nanoparticles. The process can result in a loss of up to 80% of the solution, increasing the cost of manufacturing at scale—an issue that may be obviated by spray coating fabrication, which the researchers describe as “highly reproducible, concise, and practical.”

What does the text most strongly suggest about conventional ETL fabrication?

- A. It is less suitable for manufacturing large volumes of planar p-i-n perovskite solar cells than an alternative fabrication method may be.
- B. It is more expensive when manufacturing at scale than are processes for fabricating ETLs used in other perovskite solar cell architectures.
- C. It typically entails a greater loss of nanoparticle solution than do other established approaches for ETL fabrication.
- D. It is somewhat imprecise and therefore limits the potential effectiveness of p-i-n planar perovskite solar cells at capturing and storing solar power.

ID: 720fc59a Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. Conventional solar cell fabrication increases “the cost of manufacturing at scale,” but spray coating might get rid of that problem.

Choice B is incorrect. This is not completely supported by the text. While it’s true that conventional ETL fabrication is expensive at scale, there’s nothing in the text that mentions other perovskite solar cell architectures. Choice C is incorrect. This choice does not match the text. Only one conventional method of ETL fabrication is described, so we can’t compare the solution loss in this method to that of other conventional methods. Choice D is incorrect. This choice isn’t supported by the text. The text never suggests that the effectiveness of solar cells changes based on their method of fabrication.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6a7a6377

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 6a7a6377

An analysis by Alain Elayi and colleagues of coins minted in Sidon in the fifth and fourth centuries BCE reveals a change in their composition over time: while a coin from circa 450 BCE contains about 98% silver and 1% copper, a coin from 367 BCE (the end of Ba'alšillem II's reign) contains 74.2% silver and 24.7% copper, giving it a relatively yellowish appearance that traders would have noticed. Because coins with a silver content below 80% were widely considered unsuitable for trade, Elayi et al. speculate that a crisis in confidence in the currency occurred in Sidon around 367 BCE, which was likely relieved—despite Sidon's persistent oppressive financial obligations—as a result of Ba'alšillem II's successor Abd'aštar I's decision to _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. proclaim that the percentage of silver in coins suitable for trade would be raised to a threshold higher than 80%.
- B. keep the amount of silver in Sidonian coins consistent with that in coins minted in 367 BCE but decrease their weight.
- C. begin minting heavier coins with a proportion of silver to copper similar to that in coins minted in 367 BCE.
- D. fund the mining of some copper deposits that were not available to Ba'alšillem II.

ID: 6a7a6377 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of Sidonian coins. As the text explains, researchers determined that Sidonian coins were made of silver and copper and that from 450 BCE to 367 BCE, the percentage of silver in each coin decreased from 98% to 74.2% while the percentage of copper increased from 1% to 24.7%. The text indicates that because the coins containing less than 80% silver weren't considered suitable for trade (suggesting that copper was less valuable than silver) and looked different from coins containing more silver, the researchers suspect there was a serious loss in confidence in the currency in Sidon in 367 BCE when the copper content was high. It's reasonable to assume that it wasn't possible to boost confidence simply by devoting a greater amount of valuable silver to the currency, since Sidon was under significant and ongoing financial pressure; however, keeping the total amount of silver the same and reducing the amount of copper in the coins would have resulted in smaller coins with a higher percentage of silver. Therefore, it makes sense to suggest that Abd'aštar I (the ruler after 367 BCE) likely restored confidence in the currency by deciding to keep the amount of silver in Sidonian coins consistent with that in coins minted in 367 BCE but to decrease the coins' weight.

Choice A is incorrect because the text conveys that a crisis in confidence in the currency of Sidon likely occurred around 367 BCE because the percentage of silver in coins had fallen below 80% (presumably because Sidon's financial pressures meant that less silver was available for currency), making the coins unsuitable for trade. Thus, announcing that the threshold for the percentage of silver in coins would be raised—that is, that coins would need to contain even more than 80% silver to be suitable for trade—likely would have worsened the crisis rather than relieved it. Choice C is incorrect because the text strongly suggests that a crisis in confidence in the currency of Sidon was caused by the proportion of silver to copper in the coins in 367 BCE, with 74.2% being too little silver for the coins to be considered suitable for trade; therefore, it's unlikely that minting coins with a similar proportion of

silver to copper (that is, still around 74.2% silver) would have restored confidence, even if the coins were heavier. Choice D is incorrect because the text gives no indication that funding the mining of more copper would have relieved a crisis in confidence in the currency of Sidon. The text establishes that Sidonian coins that visibly contained copper weren't considered suitable for trade, so Abd'aštar I wouldn't have wanted to add even more copper to them, and it's unclear how else copper mining would affect views of the currency.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b8f64864

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: b8f64864

Conservationists worldwide are working to protect ecosystems from habitat destruction and biodiversity loss, and in many cases, initiatives that rely on natural features or processes can help address such challenges. In response to a rapidly dwindling population of blueback salmon, the Quinault Indian Nation (a tribe in Washington State) partnered with the conservation organization Wild Salmon Center to restore naturally occurring logjams in the Quinault River. The logjams create shady pools where the blueback salmon can rest and spawn, thus promoting blueback population recovery.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. A partnership between the Quinault Indian Nation and Wild Salmon Center shows the importance of collaborative approaches to preserving biodiversity.
- B. Nature-based approaches can be effective ways to achieve conservation goals.
- C. As indicated by a recent project, logjams help the blueback salmon thrive and reproduce.
- D. Scientists now realize that nature-based conservation methods offer better long-term solutions to environmental issues than methods that are not nature-based do.

ID: b8f64864 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it best states the main idea of the text: that nature-based approaches can be effective for achieving conservation goals. The text indicates that in many cases where conservationists are trying to protect ecosystems, their methods depend on natural processes or features. The text then gives an example of this phenomenon, a project with the Quinault Indian Nation that allowed logjams to form naturally in a river, creating spawning habitats for blueback salmon.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text does suggest that the partnership with the Quinault Indian Nation was beneficial, this is not the central aim of the text; the text primarily argues that nature-based approaches to conservation can be effective. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text indicates that logjams are helpful to blueback salmon, the example of the blueback salmon project is included to illustrate the larger point made earlier in the text: that nature-based approaches to conservation are often effective. Choice D is incorrect. There is no evidence in the text to support a direct comparison of the efficacy of nature-based conservation approaches to other types of approaches. The text merely indicates that nature-based approaches can often be effective.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4f0ae95a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 4f0ae95a

Global Strontium
Seawater Curve

⁸⁷ Sr/ ⁸⁶ Sr	Age (Ma)
0.708980	6.20
0.709000	5.86
0.709020	5.40
0.709040	4.75
0.709060	3.00

The late Hemphillian (Hh) North American Land Mammal Age includes the subdivisions Hh3, 6.8 million years ago (Ma) to 6 Ma, and Hh4, 6 Ma to 4.75 Ma. While mammalian fossils have indicated that Florida’s Montbrook Fossil Site (MFS) and Palmetto Fauna of the Bone Valley Region (PFBV) date to Hh4, a more precise determination of the sites’ ages has proved challenging. Stephanie R. Killingsworth et al. compared average ratios of strontium-87 to strontium-86 (⁸⁷Sr/⁸⁶Sr) in fossil shark teeth from MFS and PFBV—0.709000 and 0.709028, respectively—to ⁸⁷Sr/⁸⁶Sr ratios in the global strontium seawater curve, a record that shows how ⁸⁷Sr/⁸⁶Sr ratios in seawater correspond to numerical ages and that is used to date fossils and, by extension, fossil sites. The researchers concluded that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement?

- A. mammalian fossil evidence offers less dating precision than do ⁸⁷Sr/⁸⁶Sr ratios in fossil shark teeth and that PFBV likely was deposited closer to the Hh3-Hh4 boundary than was MFS.
- B. the average ⁸⁷Sr/⁸⁶Sr ratios in the fossil shark teeth from MFS and PFBV only partially support the site age estimates previously established through mammalian fossil evidence.
- C. the average ⁸⁷Sr/⁸⁶Sr ratios in the fossil shark teeth from MFS and PFBV resolve previous uncertainty about the sites’ relative ages by indicating that both sites were deposited contemporaneously during the late Hh.
- D. the average ⁸⁷Sr/⁸⁶Sr ratios in the fossil shark teeth from MFS and PFBV corroborate that both MFS and PFBV fall within Hh4 but suggest that PFBV was likely deposited more recently than MFS.

ID: 4f0ae95a Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement about the researchers’ conclusion about fossil shark teeth. The text states that mammalian fossil evidence has placed both MFS and PFBV within Hh4 (6 Ma to 4.75 Ma) but “a more precise determination of the sites’ ages has proved challenging,” prompting

Killingsworth and colleagues to attempt to date the sites by comparing average $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratios for fossil shark teeth from MFS and PFBV to ratios in the global strontium seawater curve. Given that “ $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratios in seawater correspond to numerical ages,” a fossil whose $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratio corresponds to the ratio associated with a particular age in the global strontium seawater curve can be inferred to date to that age. According to the table, the $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratio of 0.709000 for fossil shark teeth from MFS corresponds to an age of 5.86 Ma, which falls within Hh4. By contrast, the table shows that the $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratio of 0.709028 for fossils from PFBV would fall between 0.709020 (5.40 Ma) and 0.709040 (4.75 Ma), indicating an age that falls within Hh4 but is more recent than MFS’s age of 5.86 Ma. The data therefore corroborate the conclusion that both sites fall within Hh4 while suggesting that PFBV was likely deposited more recently than MFS was.

Choice A is incorrect because the table indicates that MFS was deposited closer to the Hh3-Hh4 boundary than PFBV was, not the reverse. The table indicates that PFBV’s $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratio of 0.709028 corresponds to an age between 4.75 Ma and 5.40 Ma, while MFS’s $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratio of 0.709000 corresponds to an age of 5.86 Ma. Because the Hh3-Hh4 boundary occurs at 6 Ma, MFS was deposited closer to that boundary than PFBV was. In addition, the text doesn’t establish that mammalian fossil evidence offers less dating precision than $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratios do; it states only that mammalian fossils have placed both MFS and PFBV in Hh4 and that more precise dating has proved challenging. Choice B is incorrect because it mischaracterizes the level of support for the site age estimates established through mammalian fossil evidence. The table indicates that the average $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratios from MFS (0.709000) and PFBV (0.709028) both correspond to ages that fall within Hh4 (6 Ma to 4.75 Ma)—5.86 Ma for MFS and an age between 5.40 Ma and 4.75 Ma for PFBV. The $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratios therefore fully support, rather than only partially support, the previous mammalian fossil evidence placing both sites within Hh4. Choice C is incorrect because the table indicates that the average $^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$ ratios in fossil shark teeth from MFS (0.709000) and PFBV (0.709028) correspond to different ages—5.86 Ma for MFS and an age between 5.40 Ma and 4.75 Ma for PFBV. Because the ratios point to different ages, they don’t support the conclusion that the fossils at the two sites were deposited contemporaneously, or at the same time.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b736963c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: b736963c

The Hubble Space Telescope (HST) is projected to maintain operation until at least 2030, but it has already revolutionized high-resolution imaging of solar-system bodies in visible and ultraviolet (UV) light wavelengths, notwithstanding that only about 6% of the bodies imaged by the HST are within the solar system. NASA researcher Cindy L. Young and colleagues assert that a new space telescope dedicated exclusively to solar-system observations would permit an extensive survey of minor solar-system bodies and long-term UV observation to discern how solar-system bodies change over time. Young and colleagues’ recommendation therefore implies that the HST _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. will likely continue to be used primarily to observe objects outside the solar system.
- B. will no longer be used to observe solar system objects if the telescope recommended by Young and colleagues is deployed.
- C. can be modified to observe the features of solar system objects that are of interest to Young and colleagues.
- D. lacks the sensors to observe the wavelengths of light needed to discern how solar system bodies change over time.

ID: b736963c Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The HST will operate until at least 2030, but it’s only observing stuff inside our solar system 6% of the time. If we could get a different telescope to observe stuff inside our solar system 100% of the time and take more extensive images of certain things, then the HST could continue to be used mainly for observing stuff outside the solar system.

Choice B is incorrect. This inference is too strong to be supported by the text. Even if the new telescope is deployed, the HST might still be used as it’s being used now. Based on the text, the new telescope would just be used for more extensive and long-term imaging of solar system bodies, which doesn’t necessarily overlap with the HST. Choice C is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never mentions the possibility of modifying the HST, so there is no basis to make this inference. Rather, the researchers suggest using a different telescope to more closely observe certain objects. Choice D is incorrect. This inference is too strong to be supported. The text doesn’t give us enough info to assume that the HST lacks any particular sensors.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e8f7670b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: e8f7670b

Like many other genera of wild bees, bumblebees have in recent decades experienced population collapse caused by, among other factors, habitat destruction and climate variation. Bumblebees are also one of the most researched bee genera, second only to honeybees. As a result, ecologists have gained much of their insight about wild-bee declines from bumblebees. In a 2021 paper, zoologist Guillaume Ghisbain notes that bumblebees are among the relatively few wild-bee genera that display social behaviors and dietary generalism (ability to obtain nectar and pollen from a diversity of plant species), two traits that are associated with increased resilience to some specific environmental changes. Ghisbain therefore contends that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. although bumblebees and many other wild bees have experienced similar population declines in the past, compared with other wild bees, bumblebees are likely at greater risk of being harmed by climate variation than by habitat destruction.
- B. although bumblebees have been more extensively studied than most wild bees, researchers should not use bumblebees to draw conclusions about the decline of other wild bees, even ones with feeding patterns and levels of sociability that are similar to those of bumblebees.
- C. because bumblebees and other bees with generalist diets are less negatively affected by environmental stress than bees with specialized diets are, they are less likely to experience major population changes in the future than bees with specialized diets are.
- D. because the responses of bumblebees and other wild bees to environmental threats are not always comparable, researchers need to exercise caution when extrapolating information about wild-bee population declines from bumblebees.

ID: e8f7670b Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of wild-bee declines. The text establishes that bumblebees and other wild bees have been experiencing population collapse as a result of habitat destruction, climate variation, and other factors. The text then indicates that because bumblebees are very extensively researched, ecologists rely heavily on findings about them to understand wild-bee declines in general. However, the text then introduces Ghisbain’s observation that unlike most other wild-bee genera, bumblebees have certain traits (social behaviors and dietary generalism) linked to increased resilience to certain environmental changes. In other words, bumblebees aren’t necessarily representative of wild bees as a whole because they are likely more tolerant of some pressures. Therefore, it logically follows that Ghisbain would urge researchers to exercise caution when using bumblebee data to draw conclusions about other wild-bee population declines, since bumblebees and other wild bees don’t always respond comparably to environmental threats.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that climate variation is more of a threat to bumblebees than habitat destruction is or that it is a bigger threat to bumblebees than it is to other wild bees. The text simply indicates that climate variation and habitat destruction are among the factors that have caused population collapses for bumblebees and other wild-bee

genera. Choice B is incorrect. As it is presented in the text, Ghisbain notes that bumblebees may respond to environmental changes differently than many other wild-bee genera do; this suggests that bumblebees shouldn't be treated as representative of all wild bees, but there's no reason to think that Ghisbain would go so far as to assert that bumblebee data shouldn't be used to draw conclusions about other wild-bee genera that are similar to bumblebees in their dietary and social traits, even if there are relatively few. The text suggests caution in extrapolation, not a complete rejection of using bumblebee research. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text indicates that dietary generalism is linked to increased resilience to specific environmental changes (that is, to some but not all environmental stresses), it doesn't suggest that bumblebees and other bees with this trait are less likely than bees with specialized diets to experience major population changes. In fact, the text makes it clear that like many other wild-bee genera—most of which don't display dietary generalism—bumblebees are already experiencing population collapse.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID abcc9e23

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: abcc9e23

Properties of TRAPPIST-1 Exoplanets Compared to Earth's Properties

Planet	Orbital period (days)	Planet radius (Earth radii)
Earth	365.26	1
TRAPPIST-1b	1.51	1.09
TRAPPIST-1d	4.05	0.77
TRAPPIST-1e	6.1	0.92
TRAPPIST-1f	9.21	1.04

TRAPPIST-1 is a planetary system with a central red dwarf star and several Earth-sized exoplanets. Each planet in this system is so close in orbit to the star that the gravitational forces acting between the planet and the star cause the planet’s rotational period around its axis and orbital period around the star to be equal. For example, the orbital period of TRAPPIST-1e is _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the example?

- A. 1.51 days, which is the shortest rotational period of any of the TRAPPIST planets.
- B. 6.1 days, and its rotational period is also 6.1 days.
- C. 9.21 days, which is the same as the rotational period of TRAPPIST-1f.
- D. 6.1 days, and its rotational period is 0.92 days.

ID: abcc9e23 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it correctly uses data from the table to illustrate the relationship between orbital and rotational periods described in the text. For Earth and each of four TRAPPIST-1 exoplanets, the table provides the orbital period and radius (in relation to the radius of Earth). The text explains that for each TRAPPIST-1 exoplanet, gravitational forces cause the rotational period (how long the planet takes to spin once on its axis) to equal the orbital period (how long the planet takes to orbit the star). According to the table, TRAPPIST-1e has an orbital period of 6.1 days. Since the text states that the orbital and rotational periods are equal for these planets, TRAPPIST-1e’s rotational period must also be 6.1 days.

Choice A is incorrect because the table shows that TRAPPIST-1e has an orbital period (and thus a rotational period) of 6.1 days, not 1.51 days, which is the orbital period (and thus the rotational period) of TRAPPIST-1b. Furthermore, comparing the length of TRAPPIST-1e’s rotational period to those of the other exoplanets would not logically complete the example, which should illustrate how the orbital and rotational periods of a planet in TRAPPIST-1 are the same length. Choice C is incorrect because the table

shows that TRAPPIST-1e has an orbital period (and thus a rotational period) of 6.1 days, not 9.21 days, which the table shows is the orbital period (and thus rotational period) of TRAPPIST-1f. Additionally, comparing the rotational periods of two exoplanets would not logically complete the example, which should illustrate how the orbital and rotational periods of a planet in TRAPPIST-1 are the same length. Choice D is incorrect because although it correctly identifies TRAPPIST-1e's orbital period as 6.1 days, it incorrectly states that its rotational period is 0.92 days. This contradicts the text's statement that the orbital and rotational periods are equal for TRAPPIST-1 exoplanets. The value 0.92 actually represents TRAPPIST-1e's radius in relation to Earth's radius, not its rotational period.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cd86662a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: cd86662a

Euphorbia esula (leafy spurge) is a Eurasian plant that has become invasive in North America, where it displaces native vegetation and sickens cattle. *E. esula* can be controlled with chemical herbicides, but that approach can also kill harmless plants nearby. Recent research on introducing engineered DNA into plant species to inhibit their reproduction may offer a path toward exclusively targeting *E. esula*, consequently _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. making individual *E. esula* plants more susceptible to existing chemical herbicides.
- B. enhancing the ecological benefits of *E. esula* in North America.
- C. enabling cattle to consume *E. esula* without becoming sick.
- D. reducing invasive *E. esula* numbers without harming other organisms.

ID: cd86662a Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of leafy spurge and engineered DNA. The text establishes that using chemical herbicides to control leafy spurge in North America can also harm other plants nearby. The text then indicates that it might be possible to use engineered DNA to prevent plants from reproducing, which would be useful for “exclusively targeting” leafy spurge. If it’s possible to exclusively target leafy spurge with engineered DNA—meaning that only leafy spurge is affected by the engineered DNA—and prevent the plant from reproducing, then leafy spurge numbers could be reduced “without harming other organisms.”

Choice A is incorrect because the text raises the possibility of using engineered DNA to prevent leafy spurge from reproducing, not to make individual leafy spurge plants more vulnerable to chemical herbicides that already exist. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t describe any ecological benefits of leafy spurge in North America; instead, the text is focused on using engineered DNA to prevent leafy spurge from reproducing and thereby reduce its numbers. The only ecological effects of leafy spurge in North America that are described in the text are harmful. Choice C is incorrect because the text describes the possibility of using engineered DNA to prevent leafy spurge from reproducing; it doesn’t offer a way to enable cattle to eat leafy spurge without becoming sick.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e796bd3e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: e796bd3e

In a research paper, a student criticizes some historians of modern African politics, claiming that they have evaluated Patrice Lumumba, the first prime minister of what is now the Democratic Republic of the Congo, primarily as a symbol rather than in terms of his actions.

Which quotation from a work by a historian would best illustrate the student’s claim?

- A. “Lumumba is a difficult figure to evaluate due to the starkly conflicting opinions he inspired during his life and continues to inspire today.”
- B. “The available information makes it clear that Lumumba’s political beliefs and values were largely consistent throughout his career.”
- C. “Lumumba’s practical accomplishments can be passed over quickly; it is mainly as the personification of Congolese independence that he warrants scholarly attention.”
- D. “Many questions remain about Lumumba’s ultimate vision for an independent Congo; without new evidence coming to light, these questions are likely to remain unanswered.”

ID: e796bd3e Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it illustrates the student’s claim about some historians viewing Lumumba primarily as a symbol. This quotation argues that Lumumba “warrants” (or deserves) “scholarly attention” as a symbol and not for his “practical accomplishments”—that is, his actions as prime minister—which “can be passed over quickly,” or dismissed as being of comparatively little importance. Thus, the quotation expresses the view that the student criticizes some historians for holding.

Choice A is incorrect. Although this quotation touches on the difficulty of evaluating Lumumba’s legacy, it doesn’t address how historians of modern African politics view him as a symbol. Choice B is incorrect. While this quotation mentions Lumumba’s political beliefs, it doesn’t discuss historians viewing him as a symbol. Choice D is incorrect. This quotation touches on Lumumba’s vision for his country, but it doesn’t discuss historians viewing him as a symbol.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d97e5076

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: d97e5076

The following text is adapted from Fanny Burney’s 1778 novel *Evelina*. The text is an excerpt from a letter by Lady Howard to Evelina’s guardian, Reverend Villars, in which Lady Howard discusses an upcoming trip to London planned by her daughter Mrs. Mirvan’s family.

It is very earnestly [the Mirvans’] wish to enlarge and enliven their party by the addition of your amiable ward, who would share, equally with her own daughter, the care and attention of Mrs. Mirvan. Do not start at this proposal; it is time that [Evelina] should see something of the world. When young people are too rigidly sequestered from it, their lively and romantic imaginations paint it to them as a paradise of which they have been beguiled; but when they are shown it properly, and in due time, they see it such as it really is, equally shared by pain and pleasure, hope and disappointment.

Based on the text, Lady Howard would most likely agree with which statement about Reverend Villars?

- A. Although the manner in which he has raised Evelina is in many ways exemplary, he has been misguided in shielding her from the influence of other young people.
- B. He has imparted to Evelina his own idealistic view of the world, which results in her being unprepared to face inevitable disappointments.
- C. Although his desire to guard Evelina from unscrupulous people is commendable, his general mistrust has led him to be unduly wary of the Mirvans.
- D. He is overly protective of Evelina, who would likely benefit from a greater variety of experiences than she has had thus far.

ID: d97e5076 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a statement about Reverend Villars that Lady Howard would most likely agree with based on the text. In the text, Lady Howard urges Reverend Villars to allow his ward, Evelina, to join the Mirvans on a trip to London. Her first words after describing the Mirvans’ wish—“Do not start at this proposal”—suggest that she believes Villars will be alarmed by the idea, and she goes on to assure him that this alarm is unwarranted because Evelina will benefit from visiting London. Lady Howard supports her claim by arguing that excessive isolation from the world leads young people to entertain unrealistic, idealized views of it. On the other hand, she suggests, giving young people appropriate access to the world when they, like Evelina, are ready can help them develop a more balanced view of the world and its moral complexities. These words indicate that Lady Howard believes Evelina risks becoming too sheltered because of her guardian’s protectiveness and that she would benefit from exposure to a wider range of experiences than she has had thus far.

Choice A is incorrect because while the text does suggest that Lady Howard believes Reverend Villars has sheltered Evelina too much, it doesn’t specifically mention shielding her from the influence of other young people. Lady Howard refers more broadly to getting more exposure to the world and doesn’t focus on peer relationships. Additionally, the text doesn’t indicate whether Lady Howard finds other aspects of how Villars has raised Evelina to be exemplary. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t

suggest that Lady Howard believes Reverend Villars's view of the world is idealistic or that he has imparted an idealistic view of the world to Evelina. While Lady Howard does warn that young people who are too sheltered may develop romantic, idealized views of the world, she presents this as a general principle about sheltered youth, not as a specific criticism of Villars for having transmitted a naïve outlook to Evelina. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn't mention Reverend Villars being specifically concerned about protecting Evelina from unscrupulous people or suggest that he is exceptionally wary of the Mirvans. While Lady Howard's words certainly anticipate some resistance from Villars, the text doesn't specify the nature of his concerns beyond the general desire to protect Evelina from the world.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0f08c61d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 0f08c61d

Whistler waves are low-frequency plasma waves that on Earth are typically generated by lightning. Numerous recordings of whistler waves on Venus have led many scientists to suggest that the planet’s atmosphere is host to extensive amounts of lightning, and, in fact, Venusian whistler waves have similar energy signatures to those of whistler waves generated by lightning on Earth. The majority of Venusian whistler wave data come from two spacecraft missions—the Pioneer Venus Orbiter (PVO) and the Venus Express (VEX)—which have included few observations of other phenomena consistent with lightning occurrences (such as flashes of light), leading other scientists to suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. similarities in the energy signatures of Venusian and Earth whistler waves may reflect imprecisions in the PVO and VEX data.
- B. the purported Venusian whistler waves must actually be some other type of atmospheric activity than whistler waves.
- C. Venusian lightning has properties that make it unlikely to generate whistler waves.
- D. there are geophysical characteristics of Venus not shared with Earth that promote the generation of whistler waves.

ID: 0f08c61d Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of whistler waves on Venus and the question of their origin. The text explains that whistler waves are plasma waves and that on Earth they are generated by lightning. The text goes on to state that numerous recordings of whistler waves on Venus have led many scientists to suggest Venus hosts lightning. However, the text goes on to explain that data from the PVO and VEX missions have included little evidence of the other phenomena that would be expected if lightning were occurring in Venus’s atmosphere. Because there is a lack of additional evidence of lightning, it is reasonable to conclude that some scientists would be skeptical that lightning is the source of the whistler waves on Venus and would suggest unique geophysical characteristics of Venus as an alternative explanation for the waves’ generation.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that the other scientists are responding to the PVO and VEX data simply not showing additional evidence of lightning on Venus, not to flaws in the data. The text presents the similar energy signatures of Venusian and Earth whistler waves as an established observation and doesn’t suggest the PVO and VEX data are imprecise. Choice B is incorrect because the text presents the similar energy signatures of Venusian and Earth whistler waves as an established observation. The text indicates that the other scientists are concerned with the lack of corroborating evidence of lightning on Venus, suggesting not that they doubt that the waves are whistler waves but rather that they doubt that the waves are generated by lightning. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates that the other scientists are responding to the data providing little corroborating evidence of lightning on Venus. This suggests that instead of making a suggestion about properties of Venusian lightning, the other scientists likely would suggest that there may not even be lightning on Venus.

Question ID 3fd93f16

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 3fd93f16

Although it’s clear that Mars once had liquid water on its surface, astronomers have debated whether the evidence of ancient water reflects a prolonged phase of warm, wet conditions—the so-called wet and warm scenario—or a brief period of melting in an otherwise consistently frozen environment. Researchers Benjamin T. Cardenas and Michael P. Lamb recently added to this debate by using data from NASA and the Mars Orbiter Laser Altimeter to map the topography of what is now a large basin in Mars’s northern hemisphere. Cardenas and Lamb concluded that the wet and warm scenario is likely correct.

Which finding about the basin, if true, would most directly support Cardenas and Lamb’s conclusion?

- A. Its dimensions and shape indicate that it is unlikely to have formed as the result of an asteroid or comet impact.
- B. It has features suggesting that it once held an ocean that underwent gradual sea-level changes over an extended time.
- C. Its physical characteristics are most consistent with it having formed as a result of a massive but short-lived influx of liquid water.
- D. It is surrounded by channels that could have been formed either by running water or by flowing lava.

ID: 3fd93f16 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. This choice provides direct support for the researchers’ conclusion. If the basin once held an ocean of liquid water for "an extended time," that supports the "wet and warm scenario" on Mars, which involved a "prolonged" period of temperate conditions (and not just a "brief period of melting").

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t provide support for the researchers’ conclusions. The dimensions of the basin have little bearing on whether or not it was filled with liquid water, and for how long, and that’s the evidence that would support the "wet and warm" theory. Similarly, whether or not the basin was formed by an asteroid or a comet is irrelevant to the question of whether or not there was water in the basin for a long period. Choice C is incorrect. This choice does not provide support for the researchers’ conclusions, but rather the opposite. A "massive but short lived influx" of liquid water is not the same as a "prolonged phase of warm, wet conditions." It more reflects the opposing theory, a "brief period of melting." Choice D is incorrect. This choice does not support Cardenas and Lamb’s conclusion. Both theories about liquid water on Mars ("wet and warm" and "brief period of melting") involve flowing water, but lava isn’t mentioned at all in the text. Therefore, this choice doesn’t provide exclusive support for either theory.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 48ac2091

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 48ac2091

Dutch painters in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries often showed tables filled with large wheels of cheese or carved shards of butter. Some art historians, noting that dairy products were a major component of the Dutch diet, interpret these depictions as reflections of everyday Dutch eating habits. However, a group of researchers recently reviewed hundreds of food-related paintings and found that lemons—which could only be acquired in the Netherlands at great cost, since they had to be imported from warmer climates—feature in Dutch paintings of the period more than three times as frequently as dairy products do, thereby casting doubt on the idea that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. dairy products were a more significant component of the Dutch diet of the period than lemons were.
- B. food was a more popular subject among Dutch painters than it was among painters from other countries at the time.
- C. depictions of food in Dutch paintings of the period should be taken as realistic representations of Dutch eating habits.
- D. Dutch painters of the period may have depicted foods for symbolic reasons rather than to show what Dutch people typically ate.

ID: 48ac2091 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The text tells us that lemons—an expensive imported product—feature in Dutch paintings of the period more frequently than dairy products do. Since it’s unlikely lemons were eaten more often than dairy, this fact casts doubt on the theory that these paintings realistically depicted Dutch diets.

Choice A is incorrect. In fact, the text suggests the opposite: it says that dairy products were a "major component of the Dutch diet," while lemons were an expensive import item, so we can infer that lemons were eaten much more rarely than dairy products.

Choice B is incorrect. The passage doesn’t mention painters from other countries, so there’s no basis to make this inference.

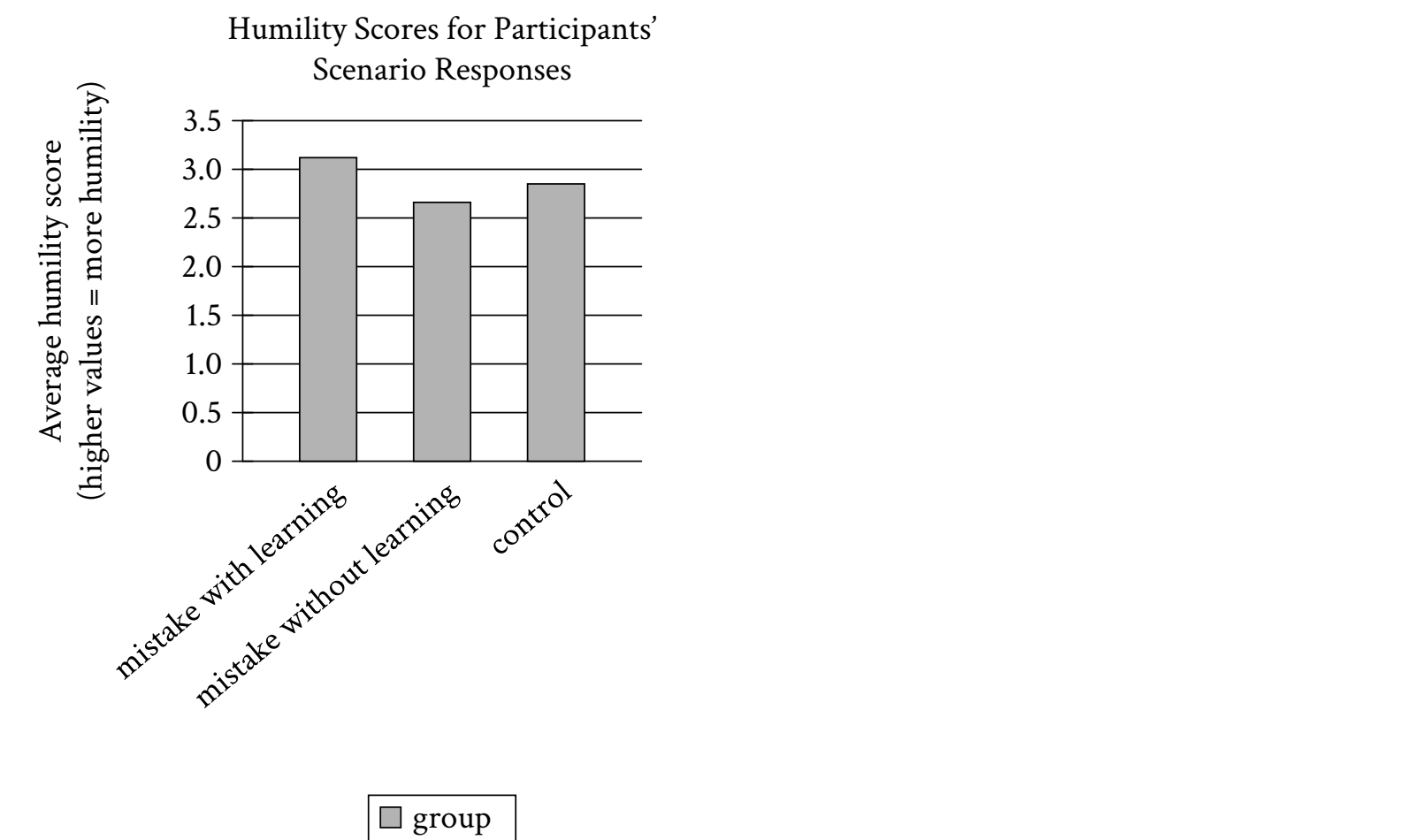
Choice D is incorrect. In fact, the text suggests that Dutch painters do have reasons for depicting foods other than to show what Dutch people typically ate. For example, lemons in a painting could indicate wealth or prosperity.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4e861b80

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 4e861b80



Jia Hu and colleagues hypothesized that workplace leaders who reflect on lessons learned from past mistakes are likely to exhibit more humility than leaders who don't engage in such reflection. To test this, the team placed 301 managers in one of three groups. Participants in two experimental groups were asked to reflect on a mistake, one group focusing on a mistake that resulted in learning and the other group focusing on a mistake that didn't result in learning. Participants in a control group were asked to reflect on their daily routine. All the participants then described how they would respond to a workplace scenario. After evaluating the responses for evidence of humility, the researchers concluded that their hypothesis was correct.

Which choice best describes data in the graph that support the researchers' conclusion?

- A. None of the three groups' average humility scores exceeded 3.5.
- B. The managers in the control group exhibited only slightly less humility on average than the managers in the two experimental groups did.
- C. The managers who reflected on a past mistake that resulted in learning exhibited more humility on average than the managers in the other two groups did.

D. All three groups exhibited less humility on average than the researchers expected.

ID: 4e861b80 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it describes data in the graph that support the researchers' conclusion that their hypothesis about workplace leaders and humility was correct. According to the text, Jia Hu and colleagues "hypothesized that workplace leaders who reflect on lessons learned from past mistakes are likely to exhibit more humility than leaders who don't engage in such reflection." The bar graph shows the humility scores for managers who participated in Jia Hu and colleagues' study. It shows average humility scores for managers who reflected on a past mistake that they learned from, managers who reflected on a past mistake that they didn't learn from, and managers who were in the control group that, according to the text, simply reflected on their daily routines. The graph shows that managers who reflected on a past mistake they learned from received an average humility score between 3.0 and 3.5. Both the control group and managers who reflected on a mistake they didn't learn from received a lower average humility score of between 2.5 and 3.0. Thus, the managers who reflected on a past mistake that resulted in learning exhibited more humility on average than the managers in the other two groups did. This supports the researchers' conclusion that their initial hypothesis that workplace leaders who reflect on past mistakes they learned from exercise greater humility was correct.

Choice A is incorrect. Although according to the graph it's true that none of the group's humility scores exceeded 3.5, this idea does not support the researchers' conclusion that their initial hypothesis was correct. The statement that none of the three groups' average humility scores exceeded 3.5 does not distinguish between those leaders who reflected on lessons learned from past mistakes and those who didn't, so it would not support Hu and colleagues' hypothesis that workplace leaders who reflect on past mistakes they learned from exercise greater humility. Choice B is incorrect. While the graph shows that managers in the control group did exhibit less humility than the experimental group of managers who reflected on a mistake they learned from, the graph also shows that the control group exhibited more (not less) humility than the experimental group that reflected on a mistake they didn't learn from. Furthermore, the idea that the managers in the control group exhibited only slightly less humility on average than the managers in the two experimental groups did would not support the researchers' conclusion that their initial hypothesis that workplace leaders who reflect on past mistakes they learned from exercise greater humility was correct. Choice D is incorrect because there is no indication in the graph that all three groups of participants exhibited less humility on average than the researchers expected. The graph and text don't cite any specific expectations that the researchers had with regard to the humility scores for each group.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fc2ce181

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: fc2ce181

Scientists studying Mars long thought the history of its crust was relatively simple. One reason for this is that geologic and climate data collected by a spacecraft showed that the crust was largely composed of basalt, likely as a result of intense volcanic activity that brought about a magma ocean, which then cooled to form the planet’s surface. A study led by Valerie Payré focused on additional information—further analysis of data collected by the spacecraft and infrared wavelengths detected from Mars’s surface—that revealed the presence of surprisingly high concentrations of silica in certain regions on Mars. Since a planetary surface that formed in a mostly basaltic environment would be unlikely to contain large amounts of silica, Payré concluded that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the information about silica concentrations collected by the spacecraft is likely more reliable than the silica information gleaned from infrared wavelengths detected from Mars’s surface.
- B. high silica concentrations on Mars likely formed from a different process than that which formed the crusts of other planets.
- C. having a clearer understanding of the composition of Mars’s crust and the processes by which it formed will provide more insight into how Earth’s crust formed.
- D. Mars’s crust likely formed as a result of other major geological events in addition to the cooling of a magma ocean.

ID: fc2ce181 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Cooling magma would create basalt, but “a planetary surface that formed in a mostly basaltic environment would be unlikely to contain large amounts of silica.” Since Mars’s crust does contain large amounts of silica, it is unlikely that Mars’s crust was formed exclusively by cooling magma. Therefore, there were likely other major geological events that created the high silica concentrations.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the passage discusses these two methods of collecting data about Mars’s crust, it never compares their reliability, so there’s no basis for this inference. Choice B is incorrect. The passage never mentions anything about the crusts of other planets, so there’s no basis for this inference. Choice C is incorrect. The passage never mentions Earth’s crust, so there’s no basis for this inference.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID da61337c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: da61337c

In present-day Chiapas, Mexico, archaeologist Robert Rosenswig, remote-sensing specialist Ricardo López-Torrijos, and colleagues have located 41 smaller settlements surrounding the ancient Mesoamerican city of Izapa. The researchers have concluded that these settlements were culturally linked to Izapa because each of the settlements is the same age and configured in the same manner as Izapa, with a pyramid to the north and a plaza to the south. Their shared structural orientation suggests that residents of the settlements likely performed some of the same cultural ceremonies as residents in Izapa did.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Researchers have determined that the arrangement of Izapa’s structures was based on those of other nearby settlements.
- B. Cultural ceremonies in Izapa seem to have played a more important role for its residents than those in smaller, surrounding settlements did.
- C. Although archaeologists have learned much about Izapa over years of research, they have only recently found the smaller settlements that surrounded it.
- D. Researchers have inferred that Izapa was related to the smaller settlements that surrounded it based in part on the similarity of their construction.

ID: da61337c Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text indicates that Rosenswig, López-Torrijos, and colleagues concluded that there is a cultural link between the city of Izapa and the 41 smaller settlements they located around the city. According to the text, the researchers reached this conclusion because Izapa and the settlements are of the same age and configuration in that all have a pyramid to the north and a plaza to the south. Thus, the main idea of the text is that researchers have inferred that Izapa was related to the smaller settlements that surrounded it based in part on the similarity of their construction.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text discusses a similarity between how structures in Izapa and nearby settlements are arranged, the text doesn’t indicate that the arrangement in Izapa is based on those of the nearby settlements. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text mentions that residents of Izapa and its surrounding settlements may have performed the same cultural ceremonies, the text doesn’t discuss the ceremonies’ importance for the residents. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text describes findings about Izapa, it doesn’t specify how much archaeologists have learned about Izapa over the years. Additionally, while the text indicates that the discovery of the 41 smaller settlements surrounding Izapa was made in present-day Chiapas and thus may be of recent date, this is a detail in the text, not its main idea.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e87e8cd0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: e87e8cd0

The most recent iteration of the immersive theater experience *Sleep No More*, which premiered in New York City in 2011, transforms its performance space—a five-story warehouse—into a 1930s-era hotel. Audience members, who wander through the labyrinthine venue at their own pace and follow the actors as they play out simultaneous, interweaving narrative loops, confront the impossibility of experiencing the production in its entirety. The play’s refusal of narrative coherence thus hinges on the sense of spatial fragmentation that the venue’s immense and intricate layout generates.

What does the text most strongly suggest about *Sleep No More*’s use of its performance space?

- A. The choice of a New York City venue likely enabled the play’s creators to experiment with the use of theatrical space in a way that venues from earlier productions could not.
- B. Audience members likely find the experience of the play disappointing because they generally cannot make their way through the entire venue.
- C. The production’s dependence on a particular performance environment would likely make it difficult to reproduce exactly in a different theatrical space.
- D. Audience members who navigate the space according to a recommended itinerary will likely have a better grasp of the play’s narrative than audience members who depart from that itinerary.

ID: e87e8cd0 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The text says that the production’s use of its large, winding space has a very specific effect on the audience. Given that the space itself is so important to creating this effect, it would be difficult to reproduce the production in a different space.

Choice A is incorrect. The fact that the venue is in New York City isn’t connected to the experimental nature of the performance. It’s the size of the venue, not its location in New York, that affects the theatrical experience. Choice B is incorrect. The text never suggests that audience members are disappointed because they can’t see the entire production. In fact, it suggests that that’s an important part of the experience. Choice D is incorrect. The text doesn’t mention a recommended itinerary for audience members.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0062824d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 0062824d

“Ad recall” measures how memorable an advertising campaign is. To provide advertisers with information about their ads’ memorability, a social media site regularly surveys users about whether they remember ads they had recently interacted with on the site. In a study that drew on this survey data, advertising researcher Kristen Sussman and colleagues noted that different kinds of social media interactions involve different levels of cognitive engagement: commenting on or sharing a post is more cognitively demanding than is clicking on embedded links or on a “like” button. The researchers hypothesized that interactions indicating high levels of cognitive engagement with ad content would result in relatively high levels of ad recall.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ hypothesis?

- A. Users who interacted with an ad were much more likely to do so by clicking on the ad’s “like” button than they were to interact with the ad in any other way.
- B. Users who interacted with an ad were significantly more likely to purchase the advertised product at the time they saw the ad than were users who saw the ad but did not interact with it.
- C. Compared with users who clicked on links in an ad, users who commented on that same ad were significantly more likely to remember seeing the ad when surveyed two days later.
- D. Although users who shared an ad were highly likely to remember details from the ad when surveyed two days later, those same users tended to forget those details when surveyed again a week later.

ID: 0062824d Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it details a finding that, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ hypothesis about ad recall. According to the text, the researchers found that commenting on an ad that appears as a social media post is more cognitively demanding for users than simply clicking on embedded links in such an ad. The researchers then hypothesized that a high level of cognitive engagement with ad content would result in a high level of ad recall, or memory of ad content. This hypothesis would be supported by the finding that users who had commented on an ad were more likely to recall its content when surveyed two days later than users who had simply clicked on links in the same ad.

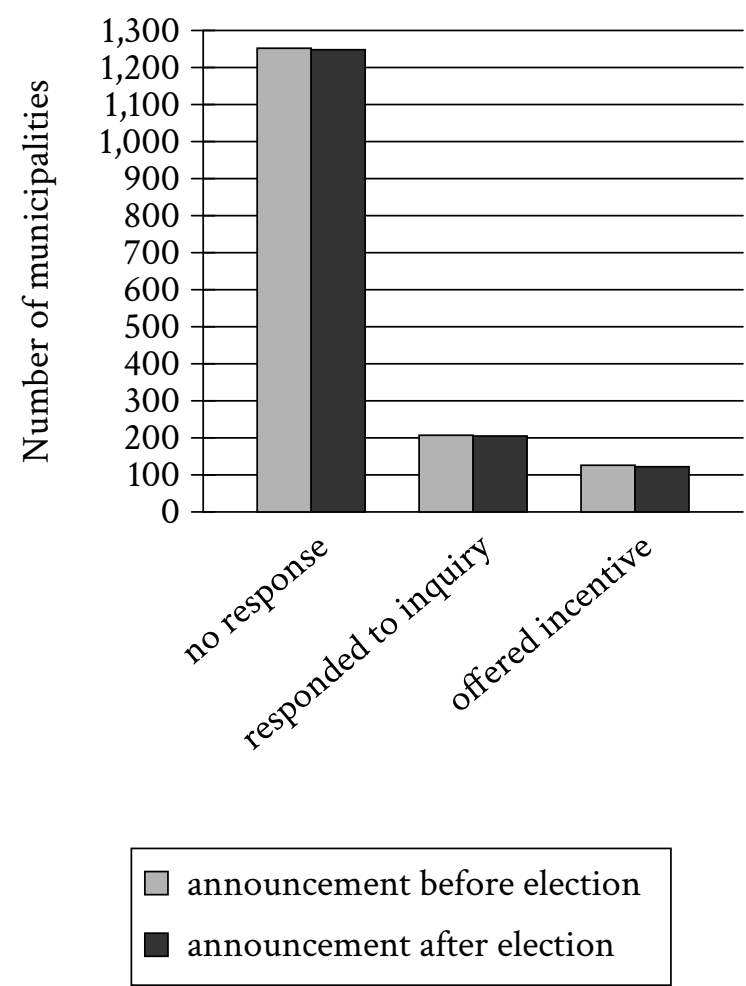
Choice A is incorrect. Although the text compares one form of social media user interaction with ads—clicking on the ad’s “like” button—with other forms of interaction—commenting on the ad and sharing it through social media—it does so in order to determine which form of interaction is associated with a higher level of ad recall. The text doesn’t note whether users were more likely to click on the “like” button than they were to interact with the ad in other ways. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that the study attempted to track whether social media users purchased the advertised product or to determine which form of interaction with ad content was more strongly associated with making a purchase. Choice D is incorrect. Finding that social media users who shared an ad forgot the content one week later would weaken, not support, the researchers’ hypothesis that cognitive engagement is associated with a high level of recall.

Question ID 7930ae78

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 7930ae78

Municipalities’ Responses to Inquiries about Potential Incentives for Firm



In the United States, firms often seek incentives from municipal governments to expand to those municipalities. A team of political scientists hypothesized that municipalities are much more likely to respond to firms and offer incentives if expansions can be announced in time to benefit local elected officials than if they can't. The team contacted officials in thousands of municipalities, inquiring about incentives for a firm looking to expand and indicating that the firm would announce its expansion on a date either just before or just after the next election.

Which choice best describes data from the graph that weaken the team’s hypothesis?

- A. A large majority of the municipalities that received an inquiry mentioning plans for an announcement before the next election didn't respond to the inquiry.
- B. The proportion of municipalities that responded to the inquiry or offered incentives didn't substantially differ across the announcement timing conditions.

C. Only around half the municipalities that responded to inquiries mentioning plans for an announcement before the next election offered incentives.

D. Of the municipalities that received an inquiry mentioning plans for an announcement date after the next election, more than 1,200 didn't respond and only around 100 offered incentives.

ID: 7930ae78 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text explains that firms in the United States often look to municipal governments (local governing bodies) for incentives to expand the firms into those areas. The text then indicates that a team of political scientists hypothesized that those governing bodies are much more likely to respond and offer incentives when the expansion (if there's going to be one) can be announced before an election, since announcing a firm coming to their area can benefit local elected officials. However, the graph—which presents the results of the political scientists' inquiries to municipalities about incentives for a firm in two timing scenarios—shows that the proportion of municipalities that responded to the inquiry or offered incentives didn't substantially differ based on timing. According to the graph, about 200 municipalities responded to the inquiry and about 100 offered an incentive when the announcement could be made before an election (represented by the gray bars) and about 200 municipalities responded to the inquiry and about 100 offered an incentive when the announcement would be made after an election (represented by the black bars). These data weaken the team's hypothesis by demonstrating that municipalities are *not* much more likely to respond and offer incentives when the timing means they could announce an expansion before an election.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the graph does show that a large number of municipalities didn't respond to inquiries in the scenario in which an expansion announcement could be made before an election (represented by the gray bars), the text indicates that the team hypothesized that there would be a substantial difference in municipalities' actions based on timing, and information about only one timing scenario doesn't reveal anything about whether such a difference occurred. Choice C is incorrect. The graph does show that in the scenario in which an expansion announcement could be made before an election (represented by the gray bars), about 200 municipalities responded to inquiries and about 100 offered an incentive, but the text indicates that the team hypothesized that there would be a substantial difference in municipalities' actions based on timing, and information about only one timing scenario doesn't reveal anything about whether such a difference occurred. Choice D is incorrect. Although this choice accurately describes data from the graph for the scenario in which an expansion announcement would be made after an election (represented by the black bars), the text indicates that the team hypothesized that there would be a substantial difference in municipalities' actions based on timing, and information about only one timing scenario doesn't reveal anything about whether such a difference occurred.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d492247c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: d492247c

The following text is adapted from Lewis Carroll’s 1889 satirical novel *Sylvie and Bruno*. A crowd has gathered outside a room belonging to the Warden, an official who reports to the Lord Chancellor.

One man, who was more excited than the rest, flung his hat high into the air, and shouted (as well as I could make out) “Who roar for the Sub-Warden?” Everybody roared, but whether it was for the Sub-Warden, or not, did not clearly appear: some were shouting “Bread!” and some “Taxes!”, but no one seemed to know what it was they really wanted.

All this I saw from the open window of the Warden’s breakfast-saloon, looking across the shoulder of the Lord Chancellor. “What can it all mean?” he kept repeating to himself. “I never heard such shouting before—and at this time of the morning, too! And with such unanimity!”

Based on the text, how does the Lord Chancellor respond to the crowd?

- A. He asks about the meaning of the crowd’s shouting, even though he claims to know what the crowd wants.
- B. He indicates a desire to speak to the crowd, even though the crowd has asked to speak to the Sub-Warden.
- C. He expresses sympathy for the crowd’s demands, even though the crowd’s shouting annoys him.
- D. He describes the crowd as being united, even though the crowd clearly appears otherwise.

ID: d492247c Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a statement about how the Lord Chancellor responds to the crowd that is supported by the text. The text indicates that the people in the crowd are roaring and shouting “Bread!” or “Taxes!” and presents them as not knowing what they really want. The Lord Chancellor’s response is to ask what their shouting means but also to observe that they’re shouting with “unanimity,” or total agreement. Clearly, this isn’t the case, which supports the statement that the Lord Chancellor describes the crowd as being united even though it’s not.

Choice A is incorrect because it isn’t supported by the text. Although the text indicates that the Lord Chancellor asks about the meaning of the crowd’s shouting, it doesn’t suggest that he knows what the crowd really wants. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the Lord Chancellor wants to speak to the crowd. Furthermore, the text doesn’t indicate that the crowd wants to hear from the Sub-Warden. Although the crowd roars when asked “Who roar for the Sub-Warden?” it’s unclear what the roaring means. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the Lord Chancellor knows of or sympathizes with the crowd’s demands. In addition, the text doesn’t indicate that the crowd’s shouting annoys the Lord Chancellor, just that it causes him to keep repeating “What can it all mean?”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6ac2b2f0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 6ac2b2f0

Boldly mixing elements of poetry, fiction, drama, philosophy, and manifesto, Puerto Rican writer Giannina Braschi creates cross-genre literature that explores themes such as immigration and independence. Her works have inspired responses from individuals across different fields and in a wide range of formats, from musical compositions and a comic book to architecture and furniture design. In an essay, a student asserts that the production of these diverse creations by others is reflective of Braschi’s own approach to crafting literature.

Which quotation from a scholarly review of Braschi’s work best supports the student’s claim?

- A. “Braschi is the focus of a 2020 collection of essays in which fifteen scholars from seven different countries delved into the linguistic and structural patterns of her writings.”
- B. “Braschi’s eagerness to push boundaries and blend genres within literature invites us to consider how other art forms might also engage with literature.”
- C. “Before settling in New York City, where she would go on to become a college professor, Braschi studied both literature and philosophy in several cities around the world.”
- D. “In addition to her creative literary works, Braschi has produced academic pieces analyzing writings by Miguel de Cervantes, Federico García Lorca, and other authors.”

ID: 6ac2b2f0 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents the quotation that best supports the student’s claim about Braschi. By describing how Braschi’s blending of genres invites her audience to think about how other art forms could also engage with literature, the quotation supports the idea that the diversity of responses to Braschi’s work reflects Braschi’s own approach to creating literature.

Choice A is incorrect because the quotation describes scholars from different countries writing essays about Braschi’s use of language in her writings; it doesn’t address how Braschi’s creation of cross-genre literature inspires diverse types of responses, which is the claim the student makes. Choice C is incorrect because the quotation focuses on the fact that Braschi studied in several different cities, which doesn’t address the student’s claim that Braschi’s creation of cross-genre literature inspires diverse types of responses. Choice D is incorrect because the quotation lists some of the authors who Braschi has written academic works about, which is irrelevant to the student’s claim that Braschi’s creation of cross-genre literature inspires diverse types of responses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 86aa56a6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 86aa56a6

Henry Ossawa Tanner’s 1893 painting *The Banjo Lesson*, which depicts an elderly man teaching a boy to play the banjo, is regarded as a landmark in the history of works by Black artists in the United States. Scholars should be cautious when ascribing political or ideological values to the painting, however: beliefs and assumptions that are commonly held now may have been unfamiliar to Tanner and his contemporaries, and vice versa. Scholars who forget this fact when discussing *The Banjo Lesson* therefore _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. risk judging Tanner’s painting by standards that may not be historically appropriate.
- B. tend to conflate Tanner’s political views with those of his contemporaries.
- C. forgo analyzing Tanner’s painting in favor of analyzing his political activity.
- D. wrongly assume that Tanner’s painting was intended as a critique of his fellow artists.

ID: 86aa56a6 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. It most logically completes the text. The text argues that Tanner and his contemporaries may have been unfamiliar with modern beliefs and values. This suggests that scholars who attribute those modern values to Tanner’s painting are risking judging the painting by standards that are not historically accurate.

Choice B is incorrect. It doesn’t logically complete the text. The text argues that Tanner AND his contemporaries may have been unfamiliar with modern views. It never suggests that Tanner’s views were different from his contemporaries’ views. Choice C is incorrect. It doesn’t logically complete the text. The text never suggests that scholars should analyze Tanner’s political activity instead of his painting. Rather, the text argues that Tanner and his contemporaries may have been unfamiliar with modern beliefs and values. Choice D is incorrect. It doesn’t logically complete the text. The text never suggests that Tanner wanted to critique his contemporaries with his painting. Rather, the text argues that Tanner AND his contemporaries may have been unfamiliar with modern beliefs and values.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6d072f3c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 6d072f3c

The Milky Way galaxy is composed of millions of stars in a relatively flat structure containing a thin disk and a thick disk. Based on computer simulations and analysis of data on the brightness, position, and chemical composition of about 250,000 stars in the thick disk (collected from two telescopes, one in China and one orbiting in space), astrophysicists Maosheng Xiang and Hans-Walter Rix claim that the thick disk of the Milky Way formed in two distinct phases rather than a single one.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ claim?

- A. The telescopes used by the researchers have detected stars of similar ages in galaxies other than the Milky Way.
- B. There’s an age difference of about 2 billion years between certain stars in the thick disk.
- C. The thin disk contains about twice as many stars that can be seen from Earth as the thick disk does.
- D. The stars in the Milky Way tend to have very similar chemical compositions.

ID: 6d072f3c Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. A consistent age difference of 2 billion years between certain stars within the thick disk would support the claim that the thick disk formed in two phases instead of one, with the second phase beginning 2 billion years after the first phase.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the claim. The researchers base their claim on their study of stars inside the thick disk of the Milky Way. This choice makes a comparison to stars in other galaxies, which isn’t relevant. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the claim. The researchers base their claim on their study of stars inside the thick disk. This choice makes a comparison to the thin disk, which isn’t relevant. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the claim. It’s too general. The claim is specifically about the thick disk.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a488586a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a488586a

Economists have demonstrated that herding—in which individuals converge on the same action by imitating the economic decisions of one or more peers—occurs among investors. Investigating whether herding also occurs among nations in matters of economic policy, Maru Etta-Nkwelle examined changes in the foreign currency reserves of emerging economies in various world regions in the years following the widespread financial crisis of 1997. Etta-Nkwelle posited that herding would manifest in regional peer countries converging on the same foreign currency accumulation rate regardless of each country’s observable circumstances. She found that Asian countries showed evidence of herding but African countries did not.

Based on the text, which finding, if true, would best account for the discrepancy Etta-Nkwelle observed?

- A. The majority of the currency held in reserves by the African countries was foreign currency, whereas the majority of the currency held in reserves by the Asian countries was domestic currency.
- B. Most of the African countries belonged to international economic unions that set individual foreign-currency accumulation policies for each member, whereas the Asian countries were largely free to set their own policies.
- C. The 1997 financial crisis resulted in immediate declines in many of the African countries’ foreign currency reserves, whereas the crisis had few short-term effects on the foreign currency reserves of most of the Asian countries.
- D. The African countries tended to accumulate a variety of foreign currencies for their reserves, whereas the Asian countries tended to favor a single foreign currency for their reserves.

ID: a488586a Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would best account for the discrepancy Etta-Nkwelle observed: Asian countries showed evidence of herding (converging on the same foreign currency accumulation rate as their regional peers), while African countries did not. The text defines herding as individuals converging on the same action by imitating their peers, which implies that the individuals choose to do so rather than being compelled to follow a particular course of action. This choice indicates that most of the African countries belonged to economic unions that dictated such monetary policies, whereas Asian countries were free to choose, and the similarity among the Asian countries suggests that herding can account for that similarity. The finding thus identifies a relevant difference between the two regions that accounts for the discrepancy.

Choice A is incorrect. Although this choice is related to reserves of foreign currency, the fact that African and Asian countries had different mixes of foreign and domestic currency reserves does not address the rate of foreign currency accumulation or whether herding is a contributing factor determining the rate of accumulation. Choice C is incorrect. This choice does not address currency accumulation. And although it describes differences in the currency reserves of African and Asian countries shortly after the 1997 financial crisis, it does not address the rate of foreign currency accumulation nor how similar the nations were in this regard to their neighboring countries. Choice D is incorrect. Although this choice discusses the variety of foreign currencies

accumulated by African countries as compared with Asian countries, it does not discuss the rate of foreign currency accumulation nor whether herding is a factor determining the rate of accumulation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 78dc1dbe

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 78dc1dbe

To understand how temperature change affects microorganism-mediated cycling of soil nutrients in alpine ecosystems, Eva Kaštovská et al. collected plant-soil cores in the Tatra Mountains at elevations around 2,100 meters and transplanted them to elevations of 1,700–1,800 meters, where the mean air temperature was warmer by 2°C. Microorganism-mediated nutrient cycling was accelerated in the transplanted cores; crucially, microorganism community composition was unchanged, allowing Kaštovská et al. to attribute the acceleration to temperature-induced increases in microorganism activity.

It can most reasonably be inferred from the text that the finding about the microorganism community composition was important for which reason?

- A. It provided preliminary evidence that microorganism-mediated nutrient cycling was accelerated in the transplanted cores.
- B. It suggested that temperature-induced changes in microorganism activity may be occurring at increasingly high elevations.
- C. It ruled out a potential alternative explanation for the acceleration in microorganism-mediated nutrient cycling.
- D. It clarified that microorganism activity levels in the plant-soil cores varied depending on which microorganisms comprised the community.

ID: 78dc1dbe Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it accurately describes why the finding about the microorganism community composition was important. The text describes an experiment by Eva Kaštovská and her team in which they collected plant-soil cores at one elevation and transplanted them to sites at a lower elevation, where the mean air temperature was warmer. Kaštovská and her team observed that microorganism-mediated nutrient cycling was accelerated in the transplanted cores and that "crucially, microorganism community composition was unchanged," which allowed the team to attribute the acceleration to changes in microorganism activity brought about by the difference in temperature. This strongly implies that the team wouldn't have been able to make that attribution otherwise, meaning that a change in microorganism composition represented another possible explanation for the acceleration that had to be ruled out.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text says microorganism-mediated cycling of soil nutrients increased in the transplanted cores, this is unrelated to what's important about the finding that the microorganism composition didn't change—that it allowed the team to attribute the change in activity solely to the change in temperature. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text compares activity in one core at two different elevations, the text doesn't address changes in activity at various elevations over time. Choice D is incorrect. Although different microorganisms likely exhibit different levels of activity, the text indicates that there was no change in microorganism composition, and there is nothing in the text about different microorganisms having different activity levels.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID eab5ee3a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: eab5ee3a

Almost all works of fiction contain references to the progression of time, including the time of day when events in a story take place. In a 2020 study, Allen Kim, Charuta Pethe, and Steven Skiena claim that an observable pattern in such references reflects a shift in human behavior prompted by the spread of electric lighting in the late nineteenth century. The researchers drew this conclusion from an analysis of more than 50,000 novels spanning many centuries and cultures, using software to recognize and tally both specific time references—that is, clock phrases, such as 7 a.m. or 2:30 p.m.—and implied ones, such as mentions of meals typically associated with a particular time of day.

Which finding from the study, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ conclusion?

- A. Novels published after the year 1800 include the clock phrase 10 a.m. less often than novels published before the year 1800 do.
- B. Novels published after 1880 contain significantly more references to activities occurring after 10 p.m. than do novels from earlier periods.
- C. Among novels published in the nineteenth century, implied time references become steadily more common than clock phrases as publication dates approach 1900.
- D. The time references of noon (12 p.m.) and midnight (12 a.m.) are used with roughly the same frequency in the novels.

ID: eab5ee3a Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ conclusion that an observable pattern in time references in novels reflects a shift in human behavior prompted by the spread of electric lighting in the late nineteenth century. If novels published after 1880 contain significantly more references to activities occurring after 10 p.m. than novels from earlier periods do, this would suggest a change in human behavior and daily routines enabled by the availability of electric lighting. Before electric lighting—which provided illumination more easily than other available forms of light—many activities ceased after nightfall, so references to late-night activities would be less common in earlier novels. An increase in such references after 1880 would align with the researchers’ conclusion, reflecting an increase in late-night activities made possible by electric lighting.

Choice A is incorrect because a decrease in references to 10 a.m. after the year 1800 would not support the researchers’ conclusion involving a shift in human behavior prompted by the spread of electric lighting toward the end of the 1800s. The time of 10 a.m. is in the morning and, in most places, characterized by daylight, so a change in references to that time would not be clearly linked to the impact of electric lighting. Choice C is incorrect because while an increase in implied time references relative to clock phrases in nineteenth-century novels could suggest a change in writing style or conventions, it does not directly support the conclusion involving a shift in human behavior prompted by the spread of electric lighting. The text indicates that the researchers’ conclusion is based on the content of the time references themselves, not the phrasing used. Choice D is incorrect. If

references to noon and midnight are used with roughly the same frequency in all the novels analyzed by the researchers, this would reflect a lack of change in human behavior with regard to time and therefore would not support the researchers' conclusion involving a shift in human behavior that occurred in response to the spread of electric lighting.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID df3c7fc6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: df3c7fc6

In her 2021 article “Throwaway History: Towards a Historiography of Ephemera,” scholar Anne Garner discusses John Johnson (1882–1956), a devoted collector of items intended to be discarded, including bus tickets and campaign pamphlets. Johnson recognized that scholarly institutions considered his expansive collection of ephemera to be worthless—indeed, it wasn’t until 1968, after Johnson’s death, that Oxford University’s Bodleian Library acquired the collection, having grasped the items’ potential value to historians and other researchers. Hence, the example of Johnson serves to _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. demonstrate the difficulties faced by contemporary historians in conducting research at the Bodleian Library without access to ephemera.
- B. represent the challenge of incorporating examples of ephemera into the collections of libraries and other scholarly institutions.
- C. lend support to arguments by historians and other researchers who continue to assert that ephemera holds no value for scholars.
- D. illustrate both the relatively low scholarly regard in which ephemera was once held and the later recognition of ephemera’s possible utility.

ID: df3c7fc6 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Johnson collected “ephemera,” or things that are meant to be thrown away. Scholars thought his collection was worthless to them, then later realized that it was potentially valuable. This suggests that scholars went from disregarding ephemera to recognizing their usefulness.

Choice A is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text tells us that the Bodleian Library acquired Johnson’s large collection of ephemera back in 1968, so we can assume that contemporary historians conducting research there do have access to that collection. Choice B is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text tells us that “Oxford University’s Bodleian Library acquired the collection,” but it never suggests that it was a challenge to do so. Choice C is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text actually suggests the opposite: the example of Johnson’s collection lends support to arguments that ephemera does hold value for scholars.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ded4d803

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: ded4d803

In their 2022 paper, Christos Dimopoulos et al., having granted that the existence of antigravity—in which antimatter and matter repel rather than attract each other—lacked affirmative experimental support, rightly argued that such antigravity was worth considering on theoretical grounds given that evidence against it was similarly lacking. But a 2023 report by an international team of researchers details the first direct ballistic observations of antihydrogen atoms under gravity inside a CERN particle accelerator. Corresponding most closely to predictions under gravitational attraction, these observations were thoroughly inconsistent with antigravity.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Antihydrogen ballistics observations were conducted at CERN to test specific conclusions about antigravity presented in the 2022 paper by Dimopoulos et al.
- B. Although theoreticians were justified in studying antigravity before the release of the 2023 report, the report’s findings suggest that the rationale for theoretical consideration offered in the 2022 paper by Dimopoulos et al. is no longer applicable.
- C. The theoretical approach represented in the 2022 paper by Dimopoulos et al. assumed that unambiguous proof of antigravity would not be achievable, but the results in the 2023 report undermine that assumption.
- D. Before 2023, researchers’ inordinate focus on theoretical considerations hindered the development of the experimental regimen for direct antihydrogen ballistics observations.

ID: ded4d803 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text begins by acknowledging that in 2022, Dimopoulos et al. were justified in arguing for antigravity on theoretical grounds because although there was no experimental evidence supporting its existence at that time, there was no evidence contradicting its existence either. The text then introduces the 2023 report describing an experiment that produced observations "thoroughly inconsistent with antigravity." Thus, the main idea is that while the study of antigravity was theoretically justified before the 2023 report (due to lack of evidence against it), the report’s findings undermine the rationale for such theoretical consideration since there is now evidence against this hypothetical phenomenon.

Choice A is incorrect. Although antihydrogen ballistics observations were conducted at CERN, the text provides no evidence that they were conducted to test conclusions in Dimopoulos et al.’s 2022 paper. Rather, the text presents the 2023 report as new evidence that contradicts the existence of the hypothetical phenomenon that Dimopoulos et al. had considered. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that Dimopoulos et al. assumed that unambiguous proof of antigravity would be unattainable. Rather, the text states that they argued antigravity was worth considering theoretically because evidence against it was lacking at that time. At the same time, the results in the 2023 report do not undermine but strengthen the idea that the proof of antigravity might not be achievable. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that there was an "inordinate focus

on theoretical considerations" before 2023 or that such a focus hindered the development of experimental methods. In fact, the text describes Dimopoulos et al.'s position regarding the theoretical consideration of antigravity as "rightly argued," indicating approval of their approach given the absence of experimental evidence at that time.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8dd98cfa

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 8dd98cfa

A member of the Otomi, an Indigenous people in Central Mexico, Octavio Medellín immigrated to the United States as a child, and his sculpture bears the impress of traditions on both sides of the border: US-based modernist sculpture, Mexican modernist painting, Otomi art, and the ancient sculpture of other Mexican Indigenous peoples, including the Maya. In his 1950 masterpiece *History of Mexico*, Medellín fuses these influences into a style so idiosyncratic that it resists efforts to view his work through the lens of nationality or cultural identity. Artists, he insisted, should strive for individual expression, even as they draw inspiration from their heritage and the communities where they live and work.

Which quotation from an art critic most directly challenges the underlined claim in the text?

- A. “Although a number of ancient Indigenous artistic traditions pictured human forms in profile, the forms populating the surface of *A History of Mexico* suggest a specifically Maya influence.”
- B. “In *A History of Mexico*, the synthesis of ancient and modernist traditions functions as a stylistic parallel to the work’s subject matter: a survey of centuries of Mexican history.”
- C. “Many critics focus on Indigenous influences in *A History of Mexico* and other key works by Medellín to the exclusion of influences from non-Indigenous art.”
- D. “While *A History of Mexico* features modernist motifs, it relies primarily on angular human forms in profile—a staple of Maya sculpture—and thus invites classification as Indigenous art.”

ID: 8dd98cfa Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. This critic challenges the claim by arguing that *A History of Mexico* is not so idiosyncratic (unique) as to resist classification because its use of Maya-style human profiles actually “invites classification as Indigenous art.” Therefore, according to this critic, the work can be viewed, at least partially, through a lens of national or cultural identity.

Choice A is incorrect. While it describes the Maya influence on a particular aspect of *A History of Mexico*, this quotation doesn’t push back on Medellín’s “idiosyncratic” (unique) style, nor does it try to categorize the entire work into a single cultural tradition. Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t directly challenge the underlined claim, but rather supports it. It suggests that the work effectively blends a variety of artistic products to create a single work that can’t be defined by any one tradition. Instead, the work recalls many centuries of history and culture all at once. Choice C is incorrect. This choice supports rather than challenges the underlined claim. The quotation argues that other critics focus too much on Indigenous influences on the artwork instead of viewing all of the influences equally—that they should instead be viewing the work as an idiosyncratic whole instead of through one or two narrow cultural lenses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5f78f5b8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 5f78f5b8

To investigate the history of plate subduction—when one of Earth’s tectonic plates slides beneath another—Sarah M. Aarons and colleagues compared ancient rocks from the Acasta Gneiss Complex in Canada to modern rocks. Using isotope analysis, the researchers found that Acasta rocks dating to about 4.02 billion years ago (bya) most strongly resemble modern rocks formed in a plume setting (an area in which hot rocks from Earth’s mantle flow upward into the crust). By contrast, they found that Acasta rocks dating to about 3.75 bya and 3.6 bya have an isotope composition that is similar to that of modern rocks formed in a subduction setting. Aarons’s team therefore concluded that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. subduction-like processes began occurring in some locations no later than 3.75 bya.
- B. subduction replaced mantle plume formation as the most common geological process by about 4.02 bya.
- C. the majority of the rocks in the Acasta Gneiss Complex formed through subduction.
- D. the rocks in the Acasta Gneiss Complex are of a more recent origin than scientists previously thought.

ID: 5f78f5b8 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

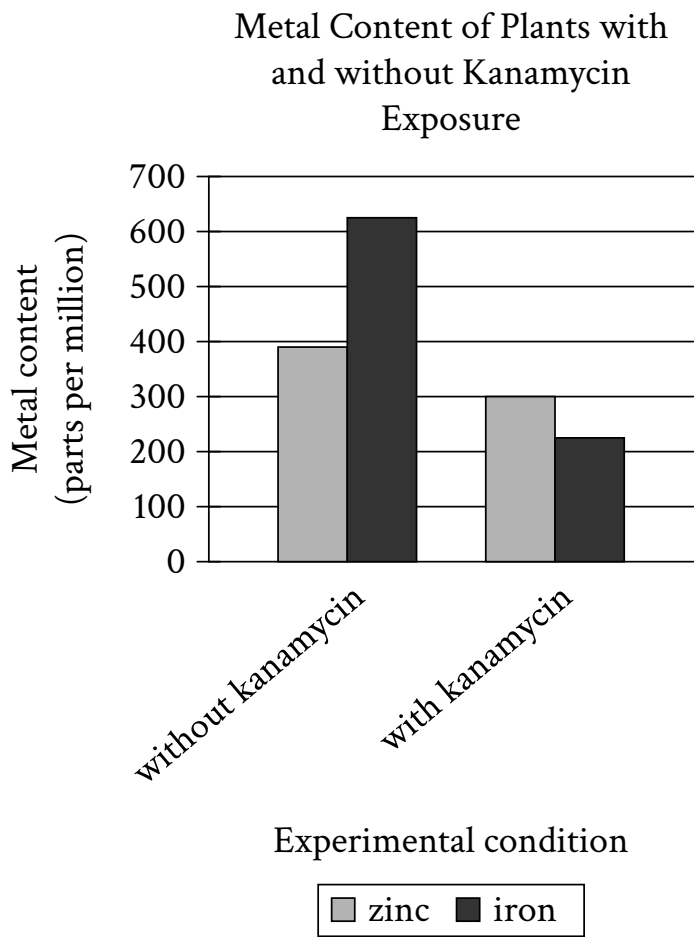
Choice A is the best answer. Because researchers found “Acasta rocks dating to about 3.75 bya” were similar to “modern rocks formed in a subduction setting,” we can infer that subduction-like processes must have begun occurring in the Acasta Gneiss Complex by this time.

Choice B is incorrect. We only know about geological processes at the Acasta Gneiss Complex, so we do not have information to make inferences about geological processes in general. Also, notice that the rocks dated to 4.02 bya were found to still be formed in a plume setting, so the transition must have happened after this time. Choice C is incorrect. There’s no mention in the passage of what proportion of the rocks within Acasta Gneiss Complex were formed through subduction, so there’s no basis for this inference. Choice D is incorrect. The passage discusses various rocks in the Acasta Gneiss Complex that are dated to different periods of time, but nothing in the passage suggests that these dates are or were wrong.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: ed594f26



Many plants lose their leaf color when exposed to kanamycin, an antibiotic produced by some soil microorganisms. Spelman College biologist Mentewab Ayalew and her colleagues hypothesized that plants’ response to kanamycin exposure involves altering their uptake of metals, such as iron and zinc. The researchers grew two groups of seedlings of the plant *Arabidopsis thaliana*, half of which were exposed to kanamycin and half of which were a control group without exposure to kanamycin, and measured the plants’ metal content five days after germination.

Which choice best describes data in the graph that support Ayalew and her colleagues’ hypothesis?

- A. The control plants contained higher levels of zinc than iron, but plants exposed to kanamycin contained higher levels of iron than zinc.
- B. Both groups of plants contained more than 200 parts per million of both iron and zinc.
- C. Zinc levels were around 300 parts per million in the control plants but nearly 400 parts per million in the plants exposed to kanamycin.
- D. The plants exposed to kanamycin showed lower levels of iron and zinc than the control plants did.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it best describes data in the graph supporting Ayalew and her colleagues' hypothesis that plants' response to kanamycin exposure involves altering their uptake of metals. The graph compares the metal content of two groups of plants, one with kanamycin exposure and a control group without such exposure. The amount of zinc in plants without kanamycin exposure is around 400 parts per million, while the amount of zinc in plants with kanamycin exposure is lower, at around 300 parts per million. Similarly, the amount of iron in plants without kanamycin exposure is a little over 600 parts per million, while the amount of iron in plants with kanamycin exposure is lower, at a little over 200 parts per million. Thus, the graph shows that plants with kanamycin exposure have significantly lower levels of both iron and zinc than the plants without kanamycin exposure. This is evidence supporting the hypothesis that kanamycin exposure results in plants altering their uptake of metals.

Choice A is incorrect because the graph shows that control plants contained higher levels of iron than zinc, not higher levels of zinc than iron; similarly, the plants exposed to kanamycin contained higher levels of zinc than iron, not higher levels of iron than zinc. Choice B is incorrect. Though the claim that both groups of plants contained more than 200 parts per million of both iron and zinc is supported by the graph, this alone does not state whether plants with kanamycin exposure have a different metal content than plants without kanamycin exposure. Choice C is incorrect. The graph shows that the zinc levels for the control plants (those without kanamycin exposure) were around 400 parts per million, not 300 parts per million, and that the zinc levels for plants with kanamycin exposure were around 300 parts per million, not 400 parts per million.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2d4e411c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 2d4e411c

Many intellectual histories of the Black Power movement of the 1960s and 1970s rely heavily on essays and other explicitly ideological works as primary sources, a tendency that can overrepresent the perspectives of a small number of thinkers, most of whom were male. Historian Ashley D. Farmer has shown that expanding the array of primary sources to encompass more types of print material—including political cartoons, advertisements, and artwork—leads to a much better understanding of the movement and the crucial and diverse roles that Black women played in shaping it.

Which choice best describes the main idea of the text?

- A. Farmer’s methods and research have enriched the historical understanding of the Black Power movement and Black women’s contributions to it.
- B. Before Farmer’s research, historians had largely ignored the intellectual dimensions of the Black Power movement.
- C. Other historians of the Black Power movement have criticized Farmer’s use of unconventional primary sources.
- D. The figures in the Black Power movement whom historians tend to cite would have agreed with Farmer’s conclusions about women’s roles in the movement.

ID: 2d4e411c Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. It best describes the main idea of the text. The text starts by saying that historians of the Black Power movement are too reliant on openly ideological works, which were written mostly by men, as sources. The text then describes Farmer’s research: she has shown that including other kinds of sources leads to a better understanding of the Black Power movement and the role Black women played in it.

Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t describe the main idea of the text. In fact, it conflicts with the text. The text says that historians have relied on "essays and other explicitly ideological works," which suggests that they *have* studied at least some of the intellectual dimensions of the Black Power movement. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t describe the main idea of the text. The text never mentions how other historians of the Black Power movement view Farmer’s use of unconventional sources. In fact, the text itself argues in favor of Farmer’s research, claiming that it has led to a "much better understanding of the movement." Choice D is incorrect. This doesn’t describe the main idea of the text. The text never mentions what any figures in the Black Power movement thought about women’s roles in the movement.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5d2397c6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 5d2397c6

The following text is from Maggie Pogue Johnson’s 1910 poem “Poet of Our Race.” In this poem, the speaker is addressing Paul Laurence Dunbar, a Black author.

Thou, with stroke of mighty pen,
Hast told of joy and mirth,
And read the hearts and souls of men
As cradled from their birth.
The language of the flowers,
Thou hast read them all,
And e’en the little brook
Responded to thy call.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To praise a certain writer for being especially perceptive regarding people and nature
- B. To establish that a certain writer has read extensively about a variety of topics
- C. To call attention to a certain writer’s careful and elaborately detailed writing process
- D. To recount fond memories of an afternoon spent in nature with a certain writer

ID: 5d2397c6 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately states the main purpose of the text. In the first part of the text, the speaker addresses Paul Laurence Dunbar’s ability to understand people (he has “read the hearts and souls of men” and written of their “joy and mirth”). In the second part of the text, the speaker describes Dunbar’s thorough understanding of the natural world (he has read “the language of the flowers” and engaged with “the little brook”). Thus, the text mainly praises Dunbar for being especially perceptive about people and nature.

Choice B is incorrect because the speaker describes Dunbar as having read the “hearts and souls of men” and the “language of flowers” to convey Dunbar’s ability to comprehend people and nature, not to suggest that Dunbar has literally read any of these things or has read a great deal about them. Choice C is incorrect because the text notes how well Dunbar has made sense of the topics he’s written about but doesn’t address any specific parts of Dunbar’s writing process beyond the suggestion that he used a pen. Choice D is incorrect because the text focuses on Dunbar’s understanding of people and nature as expressed in his writing. Nothing in the text suggests that the speaker is recalling a particular afternoon actually spent in nature with Dunbar; even if there had been a shared experience, the text isn’t focused on reminiscing.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 85539948

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 85539948

Many archaeologists will tell you that categorizing excavated fragments of pottery by style, period, and what objects they belong to relies not only on standard criteria, but also on instinct developed over years of practice. In a recent study, however, researchers trained a deep-learning computer model on thousands of images of pottery fragments and found that it could categorize them as accurately as a team of expert archaeologists. Some archaeologists have expressed concern that they might be replaced by such computer models, but the researchers claim that outcome is highly unlikely.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ claim?

- A. In the researchers’ study, the model was able to categorize the pottery fragments much more quickly than the archaeologists could.
- B. In the researchers’ study, neither the model nor the archeologists were able to accurately categorize all the pottery fragments that were presented.
- C. A survey of archaeologists showed that categorizing pottery fragments limits the amount of time they can dedicate to other important tasks that only human experts can do.
- D. A survey of archaeologists showed that few of them received dedicated training in how to properly categorize pottery fragments.

ID: 85539948 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support the researchers’ claim that archaeologists are unlikely to be replaced by certain computer models. The text explains that although archaeologists hold that categorizing pottery fragments relies on both objective criteria and instinct developed through direct experience, researchers have found that a computer model can categorize the fragments with the same degree of accuracy as the humans can—a finding that has caused some archaeologists to worry that their own work won’t be needed any longer. If survey results indicate that categorizing pottery fragments limits the amount of time archaeologists can dedicate to other important tasks that only human experts can do, that would mean that computer models aren’t able to do all of the important things archaeologists do, thus supporting the researchers’ claim that computer models are unlikely to replace human archaeologists.

Choice A is incorrect because if it were true that the computer model could categorize the pottery fragments much more quickly than the archaeologists could, that would weaken the researchers’ claim that archaeologists are unlikely to be replaced by certain computer models, since it would demonstrate that the models could conduct the archaeologists’ work not only with equal accuracy but also at a faster pace. Choice B is incorrect because the inability of both the computer model and the archaeologists to accurately categorize all of the pottery fragments presented wouldn’t support the researchers’ claim that archaeologists are unlikely to be replaced by certain computer models. The text indicates that some archaeologists are worried because the computer model’s accuracy is equal to their own, and that could be the case whether both were perfectly accurate or were unable

to achieve complete accuracy. Choice D is incorrect because survey results showing that few archaeologists received special training in properly categorizing pottery fragments wouldn't support the researchers' claim that archaeologists are unlikely to be replaced by certain computer models. The amount of special training in categorizing pottery fragments that archaeologists have received has no direct bearing on whether computer models' success at categorizing fragments will lead to the models replacing the archaeologists.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 264e2390

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 264e2390

The *Mammillaria* cactus *M. boolii* occurs naturally only in the state of Sonora in Mexico, and the smallness of its range makes it especially vulnerable to extinction. The traditional single-species approach to conservation emphasizes the need to focus on individual species most at risk, like *M. boolii*, but recently, conservationists have argued that an ecosystem-based approach that incorporates the many interactions between the climate, terrain, and various species of a given geographical area may lead to better outcomes for all the species in a given location. If this view is correct, the single-species approach to the conservation of *M. boolii* could thus _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. lead to a better understanding of how the distribution of *Mammillaria* species throughout Mexico has affected their survival.
- B. allow conservationists to better consider how climatic changes affecting Sonora may reduce the number of species competing with *M. boolii*.
- C. erroneously shift the focus of conservation efforts away from *M. boolii* itself.
- D. fail to consider the ways in which the survival of *M. boolii* may be influenced by changes in the populations of other species that inhabit Sonora.

ID: 264e2390 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of conservation approaches for the *Mammillaria* cactus *M. boolii*. The text establishes that *M. boolii* only grows naturally in the state of Sonora in Mexico, which makes it particularly vulnerable to extinction. The text then contrasts two approaches to conservation: the traditional single-species approach that individually focuses on at-risk species and a newer ecosystem-based approach that considers the interactions between climate, terrain, and various species in a geographical area. According to the text, conservationists have recently argued that this ecosystem-based approach may lead to better outcomes for all species in a location. If this ecosystem view is correct, then the single-species approach to conserving *M. boolii* would likely fail to consider how the cactus’s survival depends on its interactions with other species in Sonora’s ecosystem.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t address the distribution of *Mammillaria* species besides *M. boolii* throughout Mexico or discuss how that distribution affects survival. The text focuses specifically on *M. boolii* in Sonora and different approaches to its conservation. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that climatic changes in Sonora would reduce competition for *M. boolii* or that conservation efforts are focused on understanding this specific dynamic. In fact, the text implies that an ecosystem-based approach would consider climate among many other factors but doesn’t specify how climatic changes might affect competition between species. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the single-species approach would shift the focus of conservation efforts away from *M. boolii* itself—rather, it suggests that this approach

might be too narrowly focused on *M. boolii* alone without considering the broader ecosystem-related factors that affect its survival.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8027d835

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 8027d835

Mean Time (in Seconds) Spent per Flower for Four Pollinator Genera

Pollinator genus	Seconds per intact pin flower	Seconds per damaged pin flower	Seconds per intact thrum flower	Seconds per damaged thrum flower
<i>Habropoda</i>	2.7	5.4	4.1	9.5
<i>Osmia</i>	5.2	8.2	7.1	8.3
<i>Pierid</i>	2.6	4.0	2.4	1.9
<i>Xylocopa</i>	2.3	2.8	2.5	2.2

To study how floral damage affects the behavior of pollinators, such as bees, a team of researchers punched holes in the floral tissue of flowers from the vine yellow jessamine (*Gelsemium sempervirens*), a plant that produces flowers that have either a long pistil and a short stamen (pin morphs) or a short pistil and a long stamen (thrum morphs). The researchers then compared the time different insect pollinators spent visiting intact pin and thrum flowers to the time such pollinators spent visiting the artificially damaged pin and thrum flowers. The researchers concluded that the effect of floral damage on time spent per flower varied by both floral morph and the genus of the pollinator.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support the researchers’ conclusion?

- A. For pin flowers, damage led to longer times per flower in all pollinator genera, whereas for thrum flowers, damage led to longer times per flower only in *Habropoda* and *Osmia*.
- B. Compared with pollinators belonging to the genus *Osmia*, pollinators belonging to the genus *Xylocopa* spent less time on damaged pin flowers but more time on damaged thrum flowers.
- C. Damage led to shorter times per thrum flower in three pollinator genera (*Osmia*, *Pierid*, and *Xylocopa*), whereas it led to longer times per thrum flower in one pollinator genus (*Habropoda*).
- D. Pollinators belonging to the genus *Habropoda* spent 2.7 seconds on intact pin flowers and 4.1 seconds on intact thrum flowers.

ID: 8027d835 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it describes data from the table that support the researchers’ conclusion that the effect of floral damage on time spent per flower varied by both floral morph and the genus of the pollinator. The table presents the average time pollinators spent per floral morph. The data in the table shows that for pin flowers, the average time spent per flower by all pollinator genera was higher for flowers that had been artificially damaged than for intact flowers. By contrast, for thrum flowers, the difference in time spent on intact and damaged flowers is seen for only some pollinator genera. This supports the

researchers' conclusion that both floral morph and the genus of the pollinator are factors involved in the effect that floral damage has on time pollinators spend per flower.

Choice B is incorrect. The table shows that pollinators belonging to the genus *Xylocopa* spent less time on both damaged pin flowers and damaged thrum flowers than pollinators belonging to the genus *Osmia* did. Choice C is incorrect. The table shows that the artificial damage to the thrum flowers led to shorter average times spent by pollinators on those flowers for only two of the four pollinator genera represented in the table, not three. Furthermore, this choice doesn't address the effect the artificial damage had on pin flowers; thus, even if accurate, this evidence doesn't support the researchers' conclusion that both floral morph and pollinator genus affect time spent per flower when a flower has been damaged. Choice D is incorrect. While this statement is true based on the information in the table, it doesn't provide evidence that supports the researchers' conclusion that the effect of floral damage on time spent per flower varied by both floral morph and the genus of the pollinator because this choice provides information only about how much time one pollinator genus spent on intact flowers.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e2b32eaf

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: e2b32eaf

In the 1970s, a roughly 60,000-year-old piece of hyena bone marked with nine notches was discovered at a site in western France once inhabited by Neanderthals. Although many believe that only modern humans developed systems for notating numbers, one archaeologist asserts that this artifact may be a sign that Neanderthals also recorded numerical information. The notches on the bone are unevenly spaced but approximately parallel, and microscopic analysis reveals that they were made with a single stone tool; according to the archaeologist, this suggests that the notches were all made at one time by one individual as a means of counting something.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the underlined claim?

- A. Parallel lines are a common feature in modern humans’ early systems for recording numerical information.
- B. More than nine approximately parallel notches made with a different stone tool are present on another artifact found at a site in western France.
- C. It would have taken careful effort to make evenly spaced lines on bone with the stone tools typically used by Neanderthals.
- D. Decorative art discovered at another Neanderthal site in western France primarily features patterns of unevenly spaced parallel lines.

ID: e2b32eaf Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The archeologist bases their claim on the fact that the hyena bone features unevenly spaced parallel notches. But if unevenly spaced parallel lines were found on "decorative art" at another Neanderthal site, it would suggest that the hyena bone is probably decorative art as well—not a counting tool.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t weaken the underlined claim. If anything, it might actually strengthen the claim: assuming we can make an inference about Neanderthals using a fact about early humans, it provides more support for the idea that the person who made the notches was counting something. Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t weaken the underlined claim. The fact that another artifact had parallel notches made with a different stone tool doesn’t tell us anything about the use of either artifact. For all we know, they could both have been used for counting. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t weaken the underlined claim. The fact that it took effort to make the lines doesn’t tell us anything about what the lines were for.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 463f8a9a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 463f8a9a

Aerogels are highly porous foams consisting mainly of tiny air pockets within a solidified gel. These lightweight materials are often applied to spacecraft and other equipment required to withstand extreme conditions, as they provide excellent insulation despite typically being brittle and eventually fracturing due to degradation from repeated exposure to high heat. Now, Xiangfeng Duan of the University of California, Los Angeles, and colleagues have developed an aerogel with uniquely flexible properties. Unlike earlier aerogels, Duan’s team’s material contracts rather than expands when heated and fully recovers after compressing to just 5% of its original volume, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the aerogel’s remarkable flexibility results from its higher proportion of air pockets to solidified gel as compared to other aerogels.
- B. the aerogel’s overall strength is greater than that of other insulators but its ability to withstand exposure to intense heat is lower.
- C. the aerogel will be more effective as an insulator for uses that involve gradual temperature shifts than for those that involve rapid heat increases.
- D. the aerogel will be less prone to the structural weakness that ultimately causes most other aerogels to break down with use.

ID: 463f8a9a Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of aerogels. The text states that aerogels—highly porous foams—offer "excellent insulation" but typically break down after prolonged exposure to high heat. However, according to the text, Duan and colleagues developed an aerogel that "contracts rather than expands when heated" and recovers its original volume after this contraction. Thus, it is logical to conclude that Duan’s team’s aerogel material will be less prone to the structural weakness that caused earlier aerogels to break down.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text indicates that aerogels consist "mainly of tiny air pockets within a solidified gel," it doesn’t mention the number or proportion of air pockets to solidified gel in typical aerogels or in the aerogel developed by Duan’s team. Choice B is incorrect because the text suggests that the aerogel developed by Duan’s team has a higher, not a lower, ability to withstand exposure to intense heat due to its contraction and subsequent recovery. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text discusses temperature tolerances of aerogels and says that they offer "excellent insulation despite typically being brittle and eventually fracturing," it doesn’t discuss how different rates of temperature change can affect aerogels.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9ef8baf9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 9ef8baf9

The linguistic niche hypothesis (LNH) posits that the exotericity of languages (how prevalent non-native speakers are) and grammatical complexity are inversely related, which the LNH ascribes to attrition of complex grammatical rules as more non-native speakers adopt the language but fail to acquire those rules. Focusing on two characteristics that are positive indices of grammatical complexity, fusion (when new phonemes arise from the merger of previously distinct ones) and informativity (languages’ capacity for meaningful variation), Olena Shcherbakova and colleagues conducted a quantitative analysis for more than 1,300 languages and claim the outcome is inconsistent with the LNH.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Shcherbakova and colleagues’ claim?

- A. Shcherbakova and colleagues’ analysis showed a slightly negative correlation between grammatical complexity and fusion and between grammatical complexity and informativity.
- B. Shcherbakova and colleagues’ analysis showed a slightly negative correlation between grammatical complexity and exotericity.
- C. Shcherbakova and colleagues’ analysis showed a slightly positive correlation between grammatical complexity and fusion.
- D. Shcherbakova and colleagues’ analysis showed a slightly positive correlation between fusion and exotericity and between informativity and exotericity.

ID: 9ef8baf9 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support Shcherbakova and colleagues’ claim that the outcome of their study is inconsistent with the linguistic niche hypothesis (LNH). The text explains that the LNH holds that there is an inverse relationship between the prevalence of non-native speakers of a language (exotericity) and the grammatical complexity of that language—that is, that as the number of non-native speakers increases, grammatical complexity decreases, and vice versa. According to the text, Shcherbakova and colleagues focused on two positive indications of grammatical complexity—fusion and informativity—and analyzed their occurrence in over 1,300 languages. If the researchers found a slightly positive correlation between fusion and exotericity and between informativity and exotericity—meaning that to some extent, grammatical complexity increases as the number of non-native speakers of a language increases—their outcome would not be consistent with the assumption that exotericity and grammatical complexity are inversely related (the LNH).

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t be possible to say that a finding of a slightly negative correlation between grammatical complexity and both fusion and informativity is inconsistent or consistent with the LNH, since the finding would address only grammatical complexity (given that fusion and informativity are aspects of grammatical complexity) and wouldn’t move beyond that factor to address its relationship to the prevalence of non-native speakers of a language (exotericity), which is the relationship the LNH focuses on. Choice B is incorrect because a finding of a slightly negative correlation between grammatical complexity and the prevalence of non-native speakers of a language (exotericity)—meaning that as the number of non-native

speakers increases, grammatical complexity somewhat decreases, and vice versa—would be consistent, not inconsistent, with the LNH, since the text indicates that according to the LNH, there is an inverse relationship between grammatical complexity and exotericity; a negative correlation reflects an inverse relationship. Choice C is incorrect because it wouldn't be possible to say that a finding of a slightly positive correlation between grammatical complexity and fusion is inconsistent or consistent with the LNH, since the finding would address only grammatical complexity (given that fusion is a positive indication of grammatical complexity) and wouldn't move beyond that factor to address its relationship to the prevalence of non-native speakers of a language (exotericity), which is the relationship the LNH focuses on.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8ed8ef65

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 8ed8ef65

During their larval phase, numerous species of coral reef fish are drawn toward areas where light is present. To better understand how artificial light at night (ALAN) might affect some coral reef fish, researchers explored the effect of exposure to low levels of ALAN on the reproductive success of the common clownfish (*Amphiprion ocellaris*). While exposure to low levels of ALAN had no significant effect on spawning frequency and egg fertilization in *A. ocellaris*, incubation in the presence of ALAN completely inhibited hatching. These findings suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. *A. ocellaris* that settle in areas with low levels of ALAN have significantly higher rates of successful egg fertilization than *A. ocellaris* that settle in areas without ALAN do.
- B. the reproductive success of *A. ocellaris* would be at risk if they were to selectively settle in regions that are regularly exposed to low levels of ALAN.
- C. the reproductive success of *A. ocellaris* is more greatly affected by the presence of low levels of ALAN during incubation than the reproductive success of other species of coral reef fish is.
- D. the spawning frequency of *A. ocellaris* was more strongly affected by the presence of low levels of ALAN than egg fertilization was, though both were less affected than incubation.

ID: 8ed8ef65 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of artificial light at night (ALAN) and the common clownfish (*A. ocellaris*). The text indicates that researchers found that when *A. ocellaris* is exposed to low levels of ALAN, spawning frequency and egg fertilization aren’t significantly affected but hatching is completely inhibited—that is, the eggs never hatch. Therefore, if *A. ocellaris* were to settle only in regions where the fish would be regularly exposed to low levels of ALAN, their eggs would stop hatching and their reproductive success would be at risk.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that exposure to low levels of ALAN had no significant effect on egg fertilization for *A. ocellaris*, so there’s no reason to expect there would be any significant difference in rates of successful egg fertilization between areas with low levels of ALAN and areas without ALAN. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss the particular effects of low levels of ALAN on any species of coral reef fish besides *A. ocellaris*. For this reason, there’s no support in the text for the idea that the reproductive success of *A. ocellaris* is more greatly affected by the presence of low levels of ALAN than the reproductive success of other species of coral reef fish is. Choice D is incorrect. The text does indicate that *A. ocellaris* incubation was most strongly affected by low levels of ALAN, but it doesn’t indicate that there was a greater effect on spawning frequency than on egg fertilization; in fact, the text states that there was no significant effect on either.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8cdf1f62

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 8cdf1f62

Body Length, Filter Time, and Lunges per Dive for Four Whale Species

Whale species	Typical adult body length (meters)	Average time to filter all engulfed water (seconds)	Average number of lunges per dive deeper than 50 meters
fin	18–22	31.30	3.95
humpback	11–17	17.12	6.28
minke	7–10	8.88	7.48
blue	24–34	60.27	4.02

Some whale species practice lunge feeding, in which they lunge toward prey with their mouths open at wide angles, collect the prey and the surrounding water, and then filter out the water through baleen plates in their mouths. Although the volume of water engulfed increases with whales’ body length, the surface area of whales’ baleen plates, which influences the rate at which water can be filtered, does not increase with body length to the same degree, which helps explain why _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement?

- A. minke whales and humpback whales show similar average filter times.
- B. humpback whales show an average of 6.28 lunges per dive.
- C. fin whales show a longer average filter time than minke whales do.
- D. blue whales show the longest average filter time and the highest average number of lunges per dive.

ID: 8cdf1f62 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. To support the claim, we need to show that longer whales take more time to filter all the water they engulf than shorter whales do. This choice accurately reflects that a longer whale (the fin whale) takes more time to filter engulfed water (31.30 seconds on average) compared to a shorter whale (the minke whale, which only took 8.88 seconds on average).

Choice A is incorrect. The table shows that minke whales take an average of 8.88 seconds to filter engulfed water, while humpback whales take an average of 17.12 seconds to complete the same task. Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t reflect the claim about baleen plates. The claim explains why whales of differing lengths take different amounts of time to filter engulfed water. This choice doesn’t compare whales of different lengths, and it focuses on the number of lunges, which isn’t shown to be relevant to filter time. Choice D is incorrect. The table shows that blue whales average 4.02 lunges per dive, which is not the highest average among the whales in the table.

Question ID 033486ee

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 033486ee

Barchester Towers is an 1857 novel by Anthony Trollope. In the novel, Trollope’s portrayal of Dr. Proudie underscores the character’s exaggerated sense of his own abilities: _____

Which quotation from *Barchester Towers* most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “It must not...be taken as proved that Dr. Proudie was a man of great mental powers, or even of much capacity for business, for such qualities had not been required in him.”
- B. “[Dr. Proudie] was comparatively young, and had, as he fondly flattered himself, been selected as possessing such gifts, natural and acquired, as must be sure to recommend him to a yet higher notice.”
- C. “[Dr. Proudie’s] residence in the metropolis, rendered necessary by duties thus entrusted to him, his high connexions, and the peculiar talents and nature of the man, recommended him to persons in power.”
- D. “[Dr. Proudie] was certainly possessed of sufficient tact to answer the purpose for which he was required without making himself troublesome.”

ID: 033486ee Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. In this quotation, Dr. Proudie is described as "fondly flatter[ing] himself" that he has gifts that "must be sure to recommend him to a yet higher notice." In other words, he expects his skills to push him to greater fame and success. This implies an exaggerated sense of his own abilities, which matches the claim we’re trying to support.

Choice A is incorrect. This quotation doesn’t describe Proudie’s view of himself, nor does it paint him in an especially flattering light. Instead, by saying his mental powers and business skill are not "proved," it implies that he is actually dim-witted and bad at business. Choice C is incorrect. This choice describes Proudie’s closeness to power and importance, but it doesn’t show what Proudie thinks of himself. Proudie is not describing himself or his abilities here. The narrator is. Choice D is incorrect. While this quotation offers Proudie very mild praise, it doesn’t show what Proudie thinks of himself or his own abilities, which is what the claim focuses on.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9a84cafd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 9a84cafd

The widespread use of social media enables linguists to study changes in language usage in real time. A notable recent example is the proliferation of the affix *meng-* among speakers of Bahasa Indonesia, the official language of Indonesia. Linguists observed *meng-* originate as an onomatopoetic tag that social-media users applied to images of cats they posted; over time, users increasingly applied it as a prefix to existing words (e.g., *mengsedih* affixes *meng-* to the word for *sad*) in text that they posted. From there, it has begun to move into spoken Bahasa Indonesia. Linguists have noted many similar examples of this phenomenon occurring in other languages, suggesting that social media _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. is more useful for studying informal language than for studying formal or official language.
- B. appears to be exerting an exceptionally strong influence on the evolution of Bahasa Indonesia.
- C. may give linguists a somewhat misleading sense of how languages are changing.
- D. does not merely register changes in language usage but can facilitate such changes.

ID: 9a84cafd Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of linguists using social media to study changes in language usage in real time, providing the specific example of the affix *meng-* in Bahasa Indonesia. The text states that linguists first observed *meng-* being used as an onomatopoetic tag on social media, which then spread to being affixed to existing words in text posted on social media; from there, it has begun to move into spoken Bahasa Indonesia. As presented in the text, this progression from online usage to spoken language suggests that social media does more than just register or reflect changes in language—it can actively drive such changes. In the case of *meng-*, the text suggests, social media facilitated the movement of the affix from an online tag to part of spoken Bahasa Indonesia.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t differentiate between social media’s usefulness for studying informal versus formal or official language; it merely notes that Bahasa Indonesia is an official language. Choice B is incorrect because while the example given in the text focuses on changes in Bahasa Indonesia, the text doesn’t provide any evidence that social media is exerting an exceptionally strong influence on the evolution of this particular language compared to others. In fact, the text states that “linguists have noted many similar examples of this phenomenon occurring in other languages,” suggesting that social media’s influence is evident across multiple languages and not unique to Bahasa Indonesia. Choice C is incorrect because the text never suggests that social media provides a somewhat misleading sense of how languages are changing. Rather, the text suggests that by allowing linguists to directly observe linguistic changes, social media offers a clear window into language evolution.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3bfd6a3a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 3bfd6a3a

Credited Film Output of James Young Deer, Dark Cloud, Edwin Carewe, and Lillian St. Cyr

Individual	Years active	Number of films known and commonly credited
James Young Deer	1909–1924	33 (actor), 35 (director), 10 (writer)
Dark Cloud	1910–1920	35 (actor), 1 (writer)
Edwin Carewe	1912–1934	47 (actor), 58 (director), 20 (producer), 4 (writer)
Lillian St. Cyr (Red Wing)	1908–1921	66 (actor)

Some researchers studying Indigenous actors and filmmakers in the United States have turned their attention to the early days of cinema, particularly the 1910s and 1920s, when people like James Young Deer, Dark Cloud, Edwin Carewe, and Lillian St. Cyr (known professionally as Red Wing) were involved in one way or another with numerous films. In fact, so many films and associated records for this era have been lost that counts of those four figures’ output should be taken as bare minimums rather than totals; it’s entirely possible, for example, that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the example?

- A. Dark Cloud acted in significantly fewer films than did Lillian St. Cyr, who is credited with 66 performances.
- B. Edwin Carewe’s 47 credited acting roles includes only films made after 1934.
- C. Lillian St. Cyr acted in far more than 66 films and Edwin Carewe directed more than 58.
- D. James Young Deer actually directed 33 films and acted in only 10.

ID: 3bfd6a3a Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it uses data from the table to effectively exemplify the idea that the film outputs of the four individuals included in the table should be considered bare minimums—that is, that we should assume that the individuals actually had higher outputs than those recorded. The table presents the years during which the individuals were active and the number of known films the individuals are credited in. The table indicates that Lillian St. Cyr has 66 film credits as an actor and that Edwin Carewe has 58 film credits as a director; it follows that if some films and records for the era were lost, it’s possible that Lillian St. Cyr acted in far more than 66 films and that Edwin Carewe directed more than 58 films.

Choice A is incorrect because it doesn’t effectively exemplify the idea that the film outputs of the four individuals included in the table should be considered bare minimums. Rather than addressing the idea that the individuals likely had higher outputs than those presented in the table, this choice simply compares data from the table to make the point that Dark Cloud has fewer credited acting roles than Lillian St. Cyr (35 and 66, respectively). Choice B is incorrect because it misrepresents data from the

table, even though it may exemplify the idea that the film outputs of the four individuals included in the table should be considered bare minimums by implying that Edwin Carewe acted in more than 47 films. The table indicates that Edwin Carewe was active from 1912 to 1934, meaning that his 47 credited acting roles were in films made before or during 1934, not after that time. Choice D is incorrect because it doesn't effectively exemplify the idea that the film outputs of the four individuals included in the table should be considered bare minimums. Instead of addressing the idea that the individuals likely had higher outputs than those recorded, this choice suggests that James Young Deer actually acted in and directed fewer films than presented in the table (only 33 known films as a director instead of 35, and only 10 known films as an actor instead of 33).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a26ea54c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a26ea54c

Estimates of Tyrannosaurid Bite Force

Study	Year	Estimation method	Approximate bite force (newtons)
Cost et al.	2019	muscular and skeletal modeling	35,000–63,000
Gignac and Erickson	2017	tooth-bone interaction analysis	8,000–34,000
Meers	2002	body-mass scaling	183,000–235,000
Bates and Falkingham	2012	muscular and skeletal modeling	35,000–57,000

The largest tyrannosaurids—the family of carnivorous dinosaurs that includes *Tarbosaurus*, *Albertosaurus*, and, most famously, *Tyrannosaurus rex*—are thought to have had the strongest bites of any land animals in Earth’s history. Determining the bite force of extinct animals can be difficult, however, and paleontologists Paul Barrett and Emily Rayfield have suggested that an estimate of dinosaur bite force may be significantly influenced by the methodology used in generating that estimate.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support Barrett and Rayfield’s suggestion?

- A. The study by Meers used body-mass scaling and produced the lowest estimated maximum bite force, while the study by Cost et al. used muscular and skeletal modeling and produced the highest estimated maximum.
- B. In their study, Gignac and Erickson used tooth-bone interaction analysis to produce an estimated bite force range with a minimum of 8,000 newtons and a maximum of 34,000 newtons.
- C. The bite force estimates produced by Bates and Falkingham and by Cost et al. were similar to each other, while the estimates produced by Meers and by Gignac and Erickson each differed substantially from any other estimate.
- D. The estimated maximum bite force produced by Cost et al. exceeded the estimated maximum produced by Bates and Falkingham, even though both groups of researchers used the same method to generate their estimates.

ID: a26ea54c Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it accurately describes data from the table that support Barrett and Rayfield’s suggestion about bite force estimates. According to the text, Barrett and Rayfield believe that estimates of dinosaur bite force may be strongly influenced by the methods used to produce them—that is, that different methods may produce significantly different results. The table shows that the studies by Bates and Falkingham and by Cost et al. used the same estimation method (muscular and skeletal modeling) and produced similar bite force estimates (approximately 35,000–57,000 newtons and 35,000–63,000 newtons, respectively). The study by Meers, however, used body-mass scaling and produced a much higher bite force estimate (183,000–235,000 newtons), while the study by Gignac and Erickson used tooth-bone interaction analysis and produced a much lower bite force estimate (8,000–34,000 newtons). The fact that one method produced similar estimates in two different studies

and that two different methods used in other studies produced substantially different estimates supports the idea that dinosaur bite force estimates are significantly influenced by the methodology used to produce them.

Choice A is incorrect because it inaccurately describes data from the table. The table does show that the studies by Meers and by Cost et al. used different estimation methods and produced very different ranges of estimated dinosaur bite force, which would support Barrett and Rayfield's suggestion that different methodologies may produce significantly different estimates. However, the table doesn't show that the study by Meers produced the lowest estimated maximum bite force while the study by Cost et al. produced the highest. In fact, the study by Meers estimated a maximum bite force of approximately 235,000 newtons, which is the highest of all the estimated maximums. Choice B is incorrect. Although the data from Gignac and Ericson's study are accurately described, a single set of findings from one study using only one methodology can't show that different methodologies may produce significantly different dinosaur bite force estimates, as Barrett and Rayfield suggest. Choice D is incorrect. Although the table shows that the maximum bite force estimated by Cost et al. was higher than that estimated by Bates and Falkingham, the difference is relatively small; in fact, both teams estimated a minimum bite force of approximately 35,000 newtons and a maximum bite force close to approximately 60,000 newtons. Because these findings demonstrate that a single methodology (muscular and skeletal modeling) produced similar overall results in two studies, the findings don't support Barrett and Rayfield's suggestion that different methodologies may produce significantly different dinosaur bite force estimates.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8f133ad7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 8f133ad7

Several scholars have argued that conditions in England in the late ninth through early eleventh centuries—namely, burgeoning literacy amid running conflicts between England’s Anglo-Saxon kingdoms and Danish invaders—were especially conducive to the production of the Old English epic poem *Beowulf*, and they have dated the poem’s composition accordingly. It is not inconceivable that *Beowulf* emerged from such a context, but privileging contextual fit over the linguistic evidence of an eighth- or even seventh-century composition requires a level of justification that thus far has not been presented.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Although there are some grounds for believing that *Beowulf* was composed between the late ninth and early eleventh centuries, advocates for that view tend to rely on evidence that has been called into question by advocates for an earlier date.
- B. Although several scholars have dated *Beowulf* to the late ninth through early eleventh centuries, others have argued that doing so privileges a controversial interpretation of the social conditions of the period.
- C. Although *Beowulf* fits well with the historical context of England in the late ninth through early eleventh centuries, it fits equally well with the historical context of England in the seventh and eighth centuries.
- D. Although the claim of a late ninth- through early eleventh-century composition date for *Beowulf* has some plausibility, advocates for the claim have not compellingly addressed evidence suggesting an earlier date.

ID: 8f133ad7 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text states that some scholars have dated the composition of *Beowulf* to the late ninth through early eleventh centuries due to the poem’s fit with that period’s historical context. The text goes on to say that while it is “not inconceivable that *Beowulf* emerged from such a context”—that is, it is possible that *Beowulf* was composed during the late ninth through eleventh centuries—there is linguistic evidence that the poem was composed earlier, in the seventh or eighth century. According to the text, favoring the historical context over the linguistic evidence requires justification that scholars have not yet supplied. In other words, the text suggests that scholars who favor the later composition date need to explain why the poem’s fit with historical context should take precedence over the linguistic evidence, but they have not yet done so. Thus, the main idea of the text is that while there is some plausibility to the later composition date, advocates for the later date have not compellingly addressed evidence suggestive of an earlier date.

Choice A is incorrect because the text says that scholars who date the poem to the late ninth through early eleventh centuries have failed to account for the linguistic evidence that the poem may have been composed earlier, not that the evidence those scholars cite in favor of their view is unreliable or that anyone has cast doubt on that evidence. In other words, the text does not suggest that there are problems with the evidence cited by advocates of the later composition date, only that there is other evidence of an earlier composition date that those advocates need to consider. Choice B is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that those scholars who date the poem to the late ninth through early eleventh centuries are giving priority to a

controversial view of the social conditions at that time. The text makes no reference to any controversy about how scholars interpret that historical period. Instead, the text suggests that scholars who date the poem on the basis of its fit with the historical context of England in the late ninth through early eleventh centuries have failed to account for linguistic evidence that the poem may have been composed earlier. Choice C is incorrect because the text says nothing about how well the poem fits the historical context of England in the seventh and eighth centuries, let alone that it fits that historical context as well as it fits the historical context of the late ninth through early eleventh centuries. Rather, the text says that there is linguistic evidence that the poem may have been composed in the seventh or eighth century.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 09364cf8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 09364cf8

In vertical inheritance, parents pass genes to their offspring, but in horizontal transfer (HT), one species, often bacteria, passes genetic material to an unrelated species. In a 2022 study, herpetologist Atsushi Kurabayashi and his team investigated HT in multicellular organisms—namely, snakes and frogs in Madagascar. The team detected *BovB*—a gene transmitted vertically in snakes—in many frog species. The apparent direction of gene transfer seems counterintuitive because frogs usually don’t survive encounters with snakes and so wouldn’t be able to transmit the newly acquired gene to offspring, but the team concluded that *BovB* is indeed transmitted from snakes to frogs, either directly or indirectly, via HT.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the team’s conclusion?

- A. *BovB* can be transmitted across frog species through HT.
- B. Parasites known to feed on species of snakes and frogs in which the *BovB* gene occurs also carry *BovB*.
- C. *BovB* cannot be reliably transmitted from a snake species to bacteria that are usually encountered by frog species.
- D. Frog species with *BovB* show few discernible advantages as compared with frog species that do not carry *BovB*.

ID: 09364cf8 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. If there are parasites that feed on both snakes and frogs, they could carry *BovB* from snakes to frogs. HT could occur “indirectly” through those encounters, which frogs are more likely to survive than snake encounters.

Choice A is incorrect. The team’s conclusion specifically argues that *BovB* is transmitted from snakes to frogs via HT, and this choice doesn’t mention snakes. Choice C is incorrect. The team argues that *BovB* is transmitted from snakes to frogs via HT, and this answer choice discusses a scenario in which the gene is not transmitted. Choice D is incorrect. Whether or not frog species with *BovB* are advantaged isn’t relevant to the team’s conclusion about how the gene is transmitted.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b7557615

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: b7557615

Sir Gawain and the Green Knight is a circa 1400 poem written in Middle English—an archaic form of the English spoken today. Over the last several centuries, the English language has undergone such transformations in vocabulary, spelling, and grammar that most readers now rely on translations to read *Sir Gawain*. In the introduction to his 2007 translation, Simon Armitage remarks that the sonic patterns of the poem, which was written in alliterative verse (a verse form featuring extensive repetition of initial consonant sounds), are essential to its structure. Because many Modern English words begin with different sounds than their Middle English equivalents do, a strictly literal translation of *Sir Gawain* would therefore likely _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. preserve much of the original text’s meaning at the expense of other qualities that are also integral to the experience of reading the poem.
- B. appeal more to modern readers than would translations like Armitage’s that instead prioritize the original text’s sonic and structural qualities.
- C. be more faithful to the original intentions of the poem than most strictly literal translations of alliterative Middle English poems are to their originals.
- D. be preferable to modern readers who are primarily interested in learning what the poem reveals about historical conditions during the time it was originally written.

ID: b7557615 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of translating *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight*. The text states that the poem was written in alliterative verse, a form that features extensive repetition of initial consonant sounds, and that, according to Armitage, the patterns of sound in the poem are essential to the poem’s structure. The text also notes that many Modern English words begin with different sounds than their Middle English equivalents (that is, the words with the same meanings) do. This means that if a translator were to render the poem’s Middle English words into their direct Modern English equivalents, the initial consonant sounds of many words would change and the original alliterative patterns wouldn’t hold. It follows, then, that a strictly literal (word for word) translation would preserve much of the original text’s meaning at the expense of sonic and structural qualities that are also integral to the experience of reading the poem.

Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t address modern readers’ preferences among translation approaches. Although the text implies that Armitage may have prioritized the sonic patterns and structure of the original poem in his translation, it doesn’t give any indication that this approach would be less appealing to modern readers than an approach that directly translates the words but loses the original patterns of sounds in the poem. Choice C is incorrect. The text actually suggests that a strictly literal Modern English translation of *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* wouldn’t be especially faithful to the original intentions of the poem because the Modern English words would change the sonic patterns Armitage notes are essential to the alliterative poem’s

structure—that is, such a translation would change patterns of sound that are a fundamental part of the original poem’s composition. Moreover, there’s no reason to think that a strictly literal translation of that poem would be more faithful to the original intentions than literal translations of other alliterative Middle English poems would be, since they would presumably all face the issue of a change in the patterns of sounds. Choice D is incorrect because the end of the text makes a point about sounds, not meaning. Modern readers interested in gathering historical information from the poem might prefer a strictly literal translation (one that directly translates the words without making additional changes), but that idea doesn’t logically follow from the fact that many Modern English words start with different sounds than their Middle English counterparts; a change in the sounds wouldn’t have any effect on the information the poem conveys.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2182a10a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 2182a10a

Several artworks found among the ruins of the ancient Roman city of Pompeii depict a female figure fishing with a cupid nearby. Some scholars have asserted that the figure is the goddess Venus, since she is known to have been linked with cupids in Roman culture, but University of Leicester archaeologist Carla Brain suggests that cupids may have also been associated with fishing generally. The fact that a cupid is shown near the female figure, therefore, _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. is not conclusive evidence that the figure is Venus.
- B. suggests that Venus was often depicted fishing.
- C. eliminates the possibility that the figure is Venus.
- D. would be difficult to account for if the figure is not Venus.

ID: 2182a10a Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically completes the text’s discussion about the significance of the cupid found at Pompeii. The text indicates that the cupid is near a statue of a female figure who is fishing, and it goes on to indicate that because Venus is associated with cupids, some scholars believe the female figure to be the goddess Venus. But the text then says that, according to archaeologist Carla Brain, cupids may have also been associated with the activity of fishing, which, if true, would suggest that the mere appearance of a cupid near a female figure engaged in fishing does not indicate with certainty that the figure is Venus (that is, the cupid might be associated with fishing, and the figure might be anyone at all).

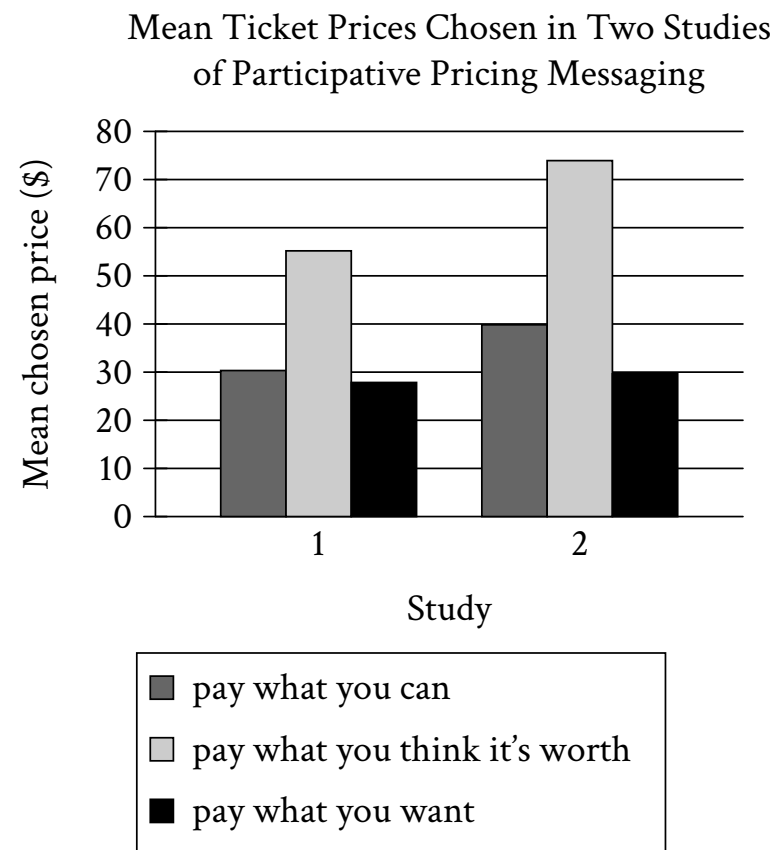
Choice B is incorrect because the text says nothing about how often Venus was depicted fishing in Roman art: it only implies that in certain instances a female figure may or may not be Venus. Choice C is incorrect because Carla Brain’s proposed explanation for the presence of the cupids makes no reference to the female figure, and so the possibility that the figure in the artworks is in fact Venus cannot be definitively eliminated. Choice D is incorrect because there is nothing in the text to suggest that the only reasonable way to interpret the figure is as Venus.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 11412319

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 11412319



Participative pricing, in which purchasers choose the prices they pay for products, can enable sellers to capitalize on the heterogeneous values consumers assign to the same goods and services, but doing so requires careful messaging. Annie Peng Cui and Jennifer Wiggins recruited 171 participants (ages 18–60) online for an initial study and 83 students (ages 18–31) at a state university for a second study to test the effect of three different messages—“pay what you can,” “pay what you think it’s worth,” and “pay what you want”—on how much participants would pay for concert tickets. Their results illustrate both the heterogeneity of consumer valuations and how sellers can benefit by prompting consumers to consider their own valuations:

- Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the text?
- A. the students tended to value the concert tickets more highly than did the more age-diverse group recruited online, but when considering what they could afford to pay, the students tended to choose a lower price than did the other group.
 - B. in all three messaging conditions, the group of participants recruited online tended to choose lower prices than did the students, but both groups tended to choose prices closest to the actual cost of the tickets when prompted to consider the tickets’ value.

- C. the students tended to value the concert tickets more highly than did the more age-diverse group recruited online, but both groups tended to choose a higher price when considering the value of the tickets than when considering what they could afford or wanted to pay.
- D. within each group of participants, there was wide variation in the value that individuals assigned to the concert tickets, but the students tended to assign a higher value to the tickets than did the more age-diverse group recruited online.

ID: 11412319 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the text about the effect of messaging on participative pricing. The graph shows mean ticket prices chosen by participants in response to three messages across two studies: Study 1, which the text indicates was conducted with an age-diverse group recruited online, and Study 2, which was conducted with student participants. The graph indicates that in the "pay what you think it's worth" condition, the mean price of the concert tickets in Study 2 was about \$74, which is greater than the mean price of about \$55 in Study 1. In other words, when participants were asked to consider their valuation of the tickets, the response was heterogeneous, or mixed. Moreover, according to the graph, both Study 1 and Study 2 show higher prices for the tickets under the "pay what you think it's worth" condition than they do under both the "pay what you can" and the "pay what you want" conditions. That is, the data suggest that both groups of participants named higher prices when considering the value of the tickets than when considering either what they could afford or wanted to pay, a finding that supports the idea that sellers can benefit when prompting consumers to consider their own valuations when they choose prices.

Choice A is incorrect because it contradicts information in the graph. Although the graph shows that students in Study 2 assigned a higher value to the tickets than did the age-diverse group in Study 1, which would support the idea that consumer valuations were heterogeneous, the graph shows that in the "pay what you can" (i.e., what you can afford) condition, the students in Study 2 assigned a higher price (about \$40), not a lower price, than the age-diverse group in Study 1 did (about \$30). Moreover, even if it were true that the students had assigned a lower price in this condition, it wouldn't support the result described in the text, only that the participants across the two studies had different ideas of what they can afford to pay. Choice B is incorrect. Although a finding that participants tended to choose prices that were closest to the actual ticket costs in the "pay what you think it's worth" condition would support the idea that sellers benefit by prompting consumers to think about their own valuations (since it's implied that sellers would lose money in the other conditions, where chosen prices were lower than the participants' valuations), neither the text nor the graph addresses how any of the prices chosen by the study participants relate to the tickets' actual market price. Choice D is incorrect. Although the wide variation in participant valuations would support the idea that consumer valuations tend to be heterogeneous, neither the text nor the graph provides any information from which to discern the relative levels of variance among the responses from participants in either study.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 05222aa1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 05222aa1

The ratio of methane to other atmospheric constituents—represented by a measure called the methane mole fraction—influences a variety of meteorological phenomena, notably precipitation and humidity. For Titan, Saturn’s largest moon, the observational data that exist are too sparse and discrepant to fully constrain the range of the methane mole fraction at various atmospheric levels. Juan Lora and colleagues point out that outputs of the IPSL atmospheric model of Titan, which track closely to observations in some respects, reflect how the model’s developers responded to this challenge: by prescribing a uniform methane mole fraction for the lowest level of the atmosphere. It is therefore important to note that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. some disagreements between the model’s simulations of Titan’s precipitation and humidity and the moon’s actual precipitation and humidity are to be expected.
- B. further observations of Titan may clarify the moon’s methane mole fraction sufficiently for the model to employ a single value rather than a range.
- C. even though the model’s outputs sometimes agree with observational data, Titan’s real methane mole fraction is likely higher than the methane mole fraction used in the model.
- D. inconsistencies across the model’s simulations of Titan’s precipitation and humidity could be attributable to variations in the moon’s methane mole fraction.

ID: 05222aa1 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of modeling the atmosphere of Titan. The text establishes that the methane mole fraction (the ratio of methane to other atmospheric components) influences precipitation, humidity, and other meteorological phenomena and that observational data for Titan are too lacking (“too sparse and discrepant”) to fully determine the range of this measure across the moon’s various atmospheric levels. The text indicates that because of this limitation, researchers developed an atmospheric model (IPSL) that uses a simplified approach: it applies a uniform methane mole fraction for the lowest atmospheric level. Since it is very unlikely that the actual methane distribution across atmospheric levels on Titan is uniform, and since the methane mole fraction directly affects precipitation and humidity, it logically follows that the model’s simplified treatment of the methane mole fraction would lead to some disagreements between the model’s simulations and Titan’s actual precipitation and humidity.

Choice B is incorrect because the text makes it clear that the model *already* uses a single value for Titan’s methane mole fraction instead of a range. Further, the text suggests that the single value is a simplification of what is likely a more complex reality, so there’s no reason to assume that a single value would be more desirable than a range. Choice C is incorrect. The text strongly suggests that Titan’s actual methane mole fraction differs from the uniform value used in the model, even though some of the model’s outputs align closely with observations, but nothing in the text indicates how the actual value would differ. There’s no

reason to assume that the actual methane mole fraction is higher than what the model uses. The “lowest level” mentioned in the text refers to the atmosphere and not Titan’s methane mole fraction. Choice D is incorrect because the text makes it clear that the model *doesn’t* reflect the actual variations in the methane mole fraction across Titan’s atmospheric levels, since observational data are too limited. Because the model uniformly applies a set methane mole fraction, no inconsistencies in the simulations would be attributable to actual variations in the moon’s methane mole fraction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fd410850

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: fd410850

The morphological novelty of echinoderms—marine invertebrates with radial symmetry, usually starlike, around a central point—impedes comparisons with most other animals, in which bilateral symmetry on an anterior-posterior (head to tail) axis through a trunk is typical. Particularly puzzling are sea stars, thought to have evolved a headless layout from a known bilateral origin. Applying genomic knowledge of *Saccoglossus kowalevskii* acorn worms (close relatives of sea stars, and thus expected to have similar markers for corresponding anatomical regions) to the body patterning genes of *Patiria miniata* sea stars, Laurent Formery et al. observed activity only in anterior genes across *P. miniata*’s entire body and some posterior genes limited to the edges, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. despite the greater prevalence of anterior genes in sea stars’ genetic makeup, posterior genes active at the body’s perimeter are primarily responsible for the starlike layout that distinguishes sea stars’ radial symmetry from that of other echinoderms.
- B. contrary to the belief that they evolved from early ancestors with the bilateral form typical of many other animals, sea stars instead originated with an atypical body layout that was neither bilaterally nor radially symmetrical.
- C. although the two species are closely related, there is only minimal correspondence in the genetic markers for head, tail, and trunk region development in *P. miniata* sea stars and *S. kowalevskii* acorn worms.
- D. rather than undergoing changes resulting in the eventual elimination of a head region in their radial body plan, as previously assumed, sea stars’ morphology evolved to completely lack a trunk and consist primarily of a head region.

ID: fd410850 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the morphology (form and structure) of sea stars, a type of echinoderm. The text indicates that echinoderms have radially symmetrical body plans (symmetrical around a central point, usually in the form of a star), whereas most animals have bilaterally symmetrical body plans (symmetrical along an axis running from head to tail through a trunk). According to the text, sea stars are unusual echinoderms because, despite their radial body plan, they descended from known bilateral ancestors. This shift in body plan was thought to be a process of losing the genetic markers associated with the head region. The text explains that by comparing the genes of one sea star species (*P. miniata*) to those of a close relative, the acorn worm, researchers determined that instead, anterior (head) genes are active across the sea star’s entire body, posterior (tail) genes are active in limited, peripheral locations of the body, and no trunk-related genes are active. This finding strongly suggests that, rather than becoming "headless" as they evolved from a bilateral ancestor, sea stars developed a body plan consisting almost entirely of a head region with a minimal tail region and no trunk region present.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t identify how any particular region of sea stars’ bodies influences the layout of sea stars’ radial symmetry. Moreover, the text indicates that the radial symmetry of echinoderms is "usually starlike," not that a starlike layout distinguishes sea stars from other echinoderms. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the idea that

sea stars evolved from an ancestor with bilateral symmetry is incorrect (describing the bilateral origin as "known") and doesn't address any body plans other than those with radial or bilateral symmetry. The text strongly suggests that rather than revealing something about sea stars' origin, Formery et al.'s findings contradict the assumption that the current body plan of sea stars is "headless." Choice C is incorrect because the text suggests that Formery et al. were able to make determinations about *P. miniata* sea stars' body plan based on the comparability of genetic markers between *P. miniata* and *S. kowalevskii* acorn worms. The text indicates only that little or no activity was observed in certain types of genes associated with body development in *P. miniata*, not that those genes turned out to largely differ from body-development genes in *S. kowalevskii*.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1fd27e72

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 1fd27e72

Delta 15-N Values in Seagrass Samples from Four Sites on the Yucatan, 2016–2017

Site	February 2016	October 2016	February 2017	October 2017
Akumal Bay	no data available	3.3	2.0	6.3
Mahahual	0.7	no data available	2.5	3.4
Tulum	6.1	5.9	2.3	5.5
Xahuayxol	0.9	0.3	−0.9	1.4

Because water from natural, uncontaminated sources is less enriched with the stable nitrogen isotope ¹⁵N than wastewater from human activities is, the presence of such wastewater in nature can be detected by examining delta 15-N values (a measure of the ratio of ¹⁵N to ¹⁴N) in plants. Karla A. Camacho-Cruz and colleagues assessed delta 15-N values in the seagrass *Thalassia testudinum* from sites on Mexico’s Yucatan peninsula with intermediate tourism development, including Akumal Bay and Tulum, and low tourism development, including Mahahual and Xahuayxol, throughout 2016 and 2017. The data suggest that the intermediate-tourism sites experienced influxes of human wastewater. However, the researchers concluded that this happened intermittently.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support the underlined conclusion?

- A. Although delta 15-N values were generally higher in Akumal Bay and Tulum than in Mahahual and Xahuayxol, the values were lower in Akumal Bay than in Mahahual and Xahuayxol in February 2017.
- B. Delta 15-N values reached their lowest level in February 2017 in both Akumal Bay and Tulum, but no data were available for Akumal Bay in February 2016, when the values reached their highest level in Tulum.
- C. Although all sites showed considerable variation in delta 15-N values, the values remained relatively constant in Akumal Bay from October 2016 to February 2017 and in Tulum from February 2016 to October 2016.
- D. In Akumal Bay and Tulum, delta 15-N values fluctuated considerably across the three measurements made from October 2016 to October 2017.

ID: 1fd27e72 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it describes data from the table that support the underlined conclusion. The text accompanying the table states that delta 15-N values (a measure of the ratio of two nitrogen isotopes) can be used as an indirect means of measuring the ratio of human wastewater to water from uncontaminated sources—the higher the delta 15-N values, the greater the presence of human wastewater. The text goes on to mention an experiment conducted by Camacho-Cruz and

colleagues measuring delta 15-N values in seagrass on the Yucatan peninsula at several sites, four of which are presented in the table accompanying the text. Two of the sites noted in the table, Akumal Bay and Tulum, had intermediate tourism development, and two others, Mahahual and Xahuayxol, had low tourism development. It is reasonable to infer that sites with intermediate tourism have a greater human presence than those with low tourism and therefore are subject to greater amounts of wastewater and exhibit higher delta 15-N values in seagrass. However, Camacho-Cruz and colleagues found that the increase in delta 15-N values was not constant. The table supports this conclusion because the two intermediate-tourism sites (Akumal Bay and Tulum) had delta 15-N values that fluctuated considerably—both had higher delta 15-N values than the two low-tourism sites (Mahahual and Xahuayxol) in October 2016 and October 2017, but in February 2017 the delta 15-N values for the intermediate-tourism sites dropped significantly (in fact, Mahahual, a low-tourism site, had a higher delta 15-N value for that period). The fluctuations in values in Akumal Bay and Tulum support the conclusion that these sites experienced influxes of human wastewater intermittently.

Choice A is incorrect because it inaccurately describes data from the table: in February 2017 the delta 15-N value in Akumal Bay was higher than the delta 15-N value in Xahuayxol, not lower. Choice B is incorrect because the absence of data for delta 15-N levels in Akumal Bay in February 2016 would neither prove nor disprove that the presence of human wastewater at Akumal Bay and Tulum was not constant. Despite the unavailable data, there is still enough information to conclude that delta 15-N levels at both sites fluctuated significantly and that influxes of human wastewater therefore happened intermittently. Choice C is incorrect because a constancy in delta 15-N values would not indicate that the influx of human wastewater was intermittent, but rather the opposite. Moreover, the two periods selected are not indicative of general trends in the whole table (for example, the values fluctuated significantly in Akumal Bay between February 2017 and October 2017, and in Tulum between October 2016 and February 2017).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d3a9c244

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: d3a9c244

Properties of Select Rotating Radio Transients

Name	Right ascension (hours)	Period (seconds)	Frequency (hertz)
J0545-03	5:45	1.074	0.931
J1654-2335	16:54:03	0.545	1.834
J0103+54	1:03:37	0.354	2.822
J0121+53	1:21	2.725	0.367
J0614-03	6:15	0.136	7.353

A student is researching rotating radio transients (RRATs), a subclass of pulsar stars characterized by short pulses of radio waves. The time between consecutive pulses of an RRAT is referred to as a period. Looking at the table, the student determines that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement?

- A. J0614-03 has the shortest amount of time between consecutive pulses of all the RRATs in the table.
- B. J0545-03 and J0121+53 have the same amount of time between consecutive pulses.
- C. J1654-2335 has the longest amount of time between consecutive pulses of all the RRATs in the table.
- D. J0103+54 and J0121+53 both have more than one second of time between consecutive pulses.

ID: d3a9c244 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately uses data from the table to complete the statement about certain rotating radio transients (RRATs). The table contains information about the right ascensions, periods, and frequencies of various pulsar stars called RRATs. According to the text, the period of an RRAT is defined as the time between consecutive pulses. The table shows that the period of RRAT J0614-03 is 0.136 seconds, which is the lowest number of all the periods of the RRATs listed in the table. If the period is the time between consecutive pulses, and J0614-03 has the shortest period, then J0614-03 has the shortest amount of time between consecutive pulses of all the RRATs in the table.

Choice B is incorrect because according to the table, J0545-03 has a period of 1.074 seconds and J0121+53 has a period of 2.725 seconds. According to the text, the period of an RRAT is the time between consecutive pulses. Therefore, since J0545-03 and J0121+53 have different periods, they do not have the same amount of time between consecutive pulses. Choice C is incorrect because according to the table, J1654-2335 has a period of 0.545 seconds, which is not the longest period of all the RRATs listed in the table. According to the text, the period of an RRAT is the time between consecutive pulses, and both J0545-03

and J0121+53 have longer periods than J1654-2335, so J1654-2335 does not have the longest time between consecutive pulses of all the RRATs in the table. Choice D is incorrect because according to the table, J0103+54 has a period of 0.354 seconds, and J0121+53 has a period of 2.725 seconds. According to the text, the period of an RRAT is the time between consecutive pulses, and only J0121+53 has more than one second of time between consecutive pulses, not J0103+54.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 959d74f9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 959d74f9

The following text is adapted from Jack London’s 1903 novel *The Call of the Wild*. Buck is a sled dog living with John Thornton in Yukon, Canada.

Thornton alone held [Buck]. The rest of mankind was as nothing. Chance travellers might praise or pet him; but he was cold under it all, and from a too demonstrative man he would get up and walk away. When Thornton’s partners, Hans and Pete, arrived on the long-expected raft, Buck refused to notice them till he learned they were close to Thornton; after that he tolerated them in a passive sort of way, accepting favors from them as though he favored them by accepting.

- Which choice best states the main idea of the text?
- A. Buck has become less social since he began living with Thornton.
 - B. Buck mistrusts humans and does his best to avoid them.
 - C. Buck has been especially well liked by most of Thornton’s friends.
 - D. Buck holds Thornton in higher regard than any other person.

ID: 959d74f9 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. After establishing that Buck views most people “as nothing,” the text explains that Buck won’t acknowledge people other than Thornton unless they appear friendly toward Thornton, and even then he’s only reluctantly accepting. Thus, the text focuses on the idea that Thornton has a special status in Buck’s mind, with Buck holding him in higher regard than other people.

Choice A is incorrect because the text conveys that Buck isn’t social with people other than Thornton but doesn’t address Buck’s life or temperament before he lived with Thornton. Choice B is incorrect because the text conveys that Buck doesn’t really care about people other than Thornton and is aloof toward them. However, there’s no indication that Buck mistrusts and avoids people generally; indeed, he accepts Thornton, who is a human. Choice C is incorrect because the text refers to random travelers praising and petting Buck and Thornton’s partners giving Buck favors, but there’s no indication that any of these people are Thornton’s friends or that they have a particular fondness for Buck.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a95d43fc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a95d43fc

Five of the Responses to Survey about Actions to Conserve Energy		
Action	Action category	Percentage of respondents selecting action (%)
Use efficient cars/hybrids	efficiency	2.8
Change thermostat setting	curtailment	6.3
Use bike or public transportation instead of car	curtailment	12.9
Use efficient light bulbs	efficiency	3.6
Turn off lights	curtailment	19.6

In a survey of public perceptions of energy use, researcher Shahzeen Attari and her team asked respondents to name the most effective action ordinary people can take to conserve energy. The team categorized each action as either an efficiency or a curtailment and found that respondents tended to name curtailments more often than they did efficiencies. For example, 19.6% of respondents stated that the most effective way to conserve energy is to turn off the lights, while only _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the text?

- A. 6.3% of respondents said it was most effective to use efficient cars or hybrids.
- B. 2.8% of respondents said it was most effective to change the thermostat setting.
- C. 12.9% of respondents said it was most effective to use a bike or public transportation.
- D. 3.6% of respondents said it was most effective to use efficient light bulbs.

ID: a95d43fc Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the table to complete the text’s discussion of Attari and her team’s survey results. The text states that the team asked respondents to identify the most effective action people can take to save energy, with the team classifying each action as either an efficiency or a curtailment. According to the text, respondents named curtailments more often than they did efficiencies. The text then offers an example that begins by citing a curtailment, turning off the lights, that was selected by a relatively high percentage of respondents (19.6%). Given that the example is presented in support of the idea that more respondents selected curtailments than efficiencies, the most effective way to complete the example is by citing an efficiency, using efficient light bulbs, that was selected by a relatively low percentage of respondents (only 3.6%).

Choice A is incorrect because it inaccurately describes data in the table. The data indicate that 6.3% of respondents said the most effective action was to change the thermostat setting, not to use efficient cars or hybrids. Choice B is incorrect because it

inaccurately describes data in the table. The data indicate that 2.8% of respondents said the most effective action was to use efficient cars/hybrids, not to change the thermostat setting. Choice C is incorrect because it mentions a curtailment (using a bike or public transportation) and not an efficiency. The text states that a research team asked respondents to identify the most effective action people can take to save energy, with the team classifying each action as either an efficiency or a curtailment. According to the text, respondents named curtailments more often than they did efficiencies. The text then offers an example that begins by citing a curtailment, turning off the lights, that was selected by a relatively high percentage of respondents (19.6%). Given that the example is presented in support of the idea that more people selected curtailments than efficiencies, the most effective way to complete the example is not by referring to another curtailment but rather by referring to an efficiency that was selected by a relatively low percentage of respondents.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 592258c2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 592258c2

One recognized social norm of gift giving is that the time spent obtaining a gift will be viewed as a reflection of the gift’s thoughtfulness. Marketing experts Farnoush Reshadi, Julian Givi, and Gopal Das addressed this view in their studies of norms specifically surrounding the giving of gift cards, noting that while recipients tend to view digital gift cards (which can be purchased online from anywhere and often can be redeemed online as well) as superior to physical gift cards (which sometimes must be purchased in person and may only be redeemable in person) in terms of usage, 94.8 percent of participants surveyed indicated that it is more socially acceptable to give a physical gift card to a recipient. This finding suggests that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. gift givers likely overestimate the amount of effort required to use digital gift cards and thus mistakenly assume gift recipients will view them as less desirable than physical gift cards.
- B. physical gift cards are likely preferred by gift recipients because the tangible nature of those cards offers a greater psychological sense of ownership than digital gift cards do.
- C. physical gift cards are likely less desirable to gift recipients than digital gift cards are because of the perception that physical gift cards require unnecessary effort to obtain.
- D. gift givers likely perceive digital gift cards as requiring relatively low effort to obtain and thus wrongly assume gift recipients will appreciate them less than they do physical gift cards.

ID: 592258c2 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of perceptions of digital versus physical gift cards. The text begins by explaining that the perception of "the time spent obtaining a gift...as a reflection of the gift’s thoughtfulness" is a social norm of gift giving. The text then explains that although those who receive digital gift cards view them as easier to use than physical gift cards, a marketing study nonetheless showed that 94.8% of participants found physical gift cards more "socially acceptable" to give. The text specifically contrasts the ease with which digital gift cards "can be purchased online from anywhere" with the fact that physical gift cards "sometimes must be purchased in person"—suggesting the greater difficulty of obtaining physical cards. Given the text’s initial premise that gift-giving norms equate the thoughtfulness of a gift with the effort involved in acquiring that gift, it is reasonable to infer that people perceive digital gift cards as requiring less effort to obtain and thus assume recipients will appreciate them less, even though recipients actually prefer gift cards in the more usable digital format.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text does discuss recipients’ preference of digital versus physical gift cards and the relative ease with which the two formats can be used, it doesn’t consider the misconceptions that gift givers may have of these factors. Moreover, the text establishes that recipients regard digital gift cards as easier to use and therefore preferable to physical gift cards. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t consider whether recipients of gift cards feel a sense of ownership toward

them, nor does the text touch on the greater tangibility of physical versus digital gift cards. Instead, the text contrasts the two formats of gift cards in terms of their respective usability and the difficulty involved in acquiring them and discusses how those factors influence people's perceptions of the two formats. Choice C is incorrect because it contradicts the text, which explains that recipients regard digital gift cards as superior to physical ones because they are easier to use than physical cards, not because physical gift cards require greater effort to obtain than digital gift cards do. Moreover, the text doesn't characterize the effort required to obtain physical gift cards as "unnecessary."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4c96b993

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 4c96b993

In 2016 biological anthropologist Heather F. Smith and her team investigated the evolution of the appendix, an intestinal organ that is present in some mammals, including humans, but is generally thought to have no function. Studying 533 mammal species, the team found that the appendix has emerged independently across multiple lineages in separate instances and, significantly, hasn't disappeared after emerging in specific lineages. Moreover, the team determined that species with the organ tend to have higher concentrations of lymphoid tissue, which supports immune responses, in the cecum, the organ the appendix is attached to. Therefore, the team hypothesized that the appendix likely _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. was once present in many nonmammal species but has since disappeared from those lineages.
- B. has been preserved in certain mammal species because it benefits their immune systems.
- C. will emerge in a greater number of mammal species because it may serve a necessary function in the immune system.
- D. produced higher concentrations of lymphoid tissue in mammals in the past than it does currently.

ID: 4c96b993 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of Smith and colleagues' investigation of the evolution and biological role of the appendix. The text indicates that the team found several instances of the appendix emerging and not disappearing in the lineages of various mammal species the team examined. Furthermore, the text states that species that possess an appendix also tend to have relatively high amounts of lymphoid tissue—a type of tissue that supports immune system function. Taken together, these details strongly support the hypothesis that the appendix has persisted in some species because it has a function that contributes to effective immune responses in those species.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn't address any nonmammalian species. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn't make predictions about the evolutionary future of the species Smith and colleagues examined, and although the implication of the text is that the appendix likely does serve a function for the immune system, nothing in the text indicates that the appendix will become more widespread in the future. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text does suggest an association between having an appendix and relatively high concentrations of lymphoid tissue, it doesn't claim that the appendix causes the tissue to grow, nor does it address the relative production of the tissue at different periods of time.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7469d34d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 7469d34d

As media consumption has become increasingly multiplatform and socially mediated, active news acquisition has diminished in favor of an attitude known as “news finds me” (NFM), in which people passively rely on their social networks and ambient media environments for information about current events. Homero Gil de Zúñiga and Trevor Diehl examined data on a representative group of adults in the United States to determine participants’ strength of NFM attitude, political knowledge, and political interest. Although no major election took place sufficiently near the study for Gil de Zúñiga and Diehl to identify causality between NFM and voting behavior, they did posit that NFM may reduce voting probability through an indirect effect.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the idea advanced by Gil de Zúñiga and Diehl?

- A. NFM attitude tends to increase in strength as major elections approach, and people are significantly more likely to vote in major elections than in minor elections.
- B. NFM attitude has a strong negative effect on political knowledge and interest, and there is known to be a strong positive correlation between political knowledge and interest and the likelihood of voting.
- C. Political interest is known to have a strong positive effect on likelihood of voting but shows only a weak positive effect on political knowledge, and NFM attitude shows little correlation with either political knowledge or political interest.
- D. The likelihood of voting increases as political knowledge increases, and the relationship between NFM attitude and political knowledge tends to strengthen as the size of people’s social networks increases.

ID: 7469d34d Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support the idea advanced by Homero Gil de Zúñiga and Trevor Diehl that NFM ("news finds me") attitude may reduce voting probability through an indirect effect. The text describes NFM as an attitude that has lowered people’s interest in actively acquiring news and introduces Gil de Zúñiga and Diehl’s study on the effects of NFM on people in the United States’ political knowledge and interest. The text goes on to say that despite the fact that the study didn’t occur near a major election, Gil de Zúñiga and Diehl still conclude that NFM may reduce voting probability. If the likelihood, or probability, that a person will vote is linked to that person’s level of political knowledge and interest, that would suggest that negatively affecting a person’s level of political knowledge and interest would also negatively affect how likely that person is to vote. Thus, if NFM attitude has a negative effect on political knowledge and interest, then it would also likely reduce voting probability.

Choice A is incorrect because the finding that NFM attitude increases as major elections approach wouldn’t address the effect of NFM on the likelihood of voting, which is the idea advanced by Gil de Zúñiga and Diehl. Moreover, although the text mentions that there were no major elections that occurred near the time of the study, it doesn’t discern between major and minor elections when discussing voting probability. Choice C is incorrect because finding that NFM attitude shows little correlation with either political knowledge or political interest would undermine, not support, Gil de Zúñiga and Diehl’s idea that NFM may reduce voting

probability because it suggests that NFM has no effect on political knowledge or political interest. Choice D is incorrect. Although Gil de Zúñiga and Diehl's idea would be supported by the finding that the likelihood of voting increases as political knowledge increases, nothing in the text suggests that the researchers' idea hinges on the size of people's social networks.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3b979539

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 3b979539

Archaeologists have observed similarities in the tools, such as bidirectional blades, uncovered at the Neolithic-period Mesopotamian settlement of Çayönü Tepesi and those uncovered at roughly contemporaneous settlements elsewhere in Southwest Asia, including those in the South Levant, Central Anatolia, and Central Zagros. Although similarities in tools could be attributed to imitative behavior or trade, Nefize Ezgi Altınışik et al. found evidence of genetic affinity among the populations of Çayönü Tepesi, Central Anatolia, the South Levant, and—to a lesser extent—Central Zagros.

Information in the text best supports which statement about the finding made by Altınışik et al.?

- A. It implies that people and tools likely arrived in Çayönü Tepesi from settlements in Central Anatolia and the South Levant at an earlier time than they did from settlements in Central Zagros.
- B. It raises the possibility that similarities in the design of tools found at Neolithic settlements in Southwest Asia emerged due to population blending between those settlements.
- C. It suggests that in the Neolithic period, people in the South Levant and Central Anatolia imitated tool designs originating in Çayönü Tepesi more frequently than people in Central Zagros did.
- D. It helps explain why contemporaneous Neolithic peoples in Southwest Asia had similar tools but lacked other obvious cultural similarities.

ID: 3b979539 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a statement about Altınışik et al.’s finding that is supported by the text. The text notes that tool similarities across Neolithic settlements could be attributed to imitative behavior or trade. However, Altınışik et al. found evidence of genetic affinity (that is, genetic relatedness) among the populations of these settlements. Genetic relatedness among populations with similar tools raises an alternative possibility: the tool similarities may have emerged through population blending rather than through imitation or trade alone. Thus, the finding raises the possibility that tool design similarities resulted from population blending.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t address the timing or direction of migration between settlements. Although lesser genetic affinity with Central Zagros could reflect various historical patterns, the text presents genetic relatedness as evidence of population intermixing, not as evidence about when people or tools arrived at particular locations. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that tools originated specifically at Çayönü Tepesi or that other settlements imitated its designs. Although the text notes that genetic affinity with Central Zagros was found “to a lesser extent,” this describes degrees of genetic relatedness, not the frequency of tool imitation. Instead, the text presents tool similarities as a shared phenomenon across settlements. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss a lack of cultural similarities among Neolithic peoples in Southwest Asia. Rather, the text focuses solely on tool similarities and genetic affinity without addressing other cultural parallels or differences.

Question ID 8b924b97

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 8b924b97

Founded in 1965 and originally established as a cultural extension of the United Farm Workers—a union representing many Mexican American agricultural workers at the time—the theater troupe El Teatro Campesino has achieved recognition as a source of inspiration for subsequent Chicano theater companies and as a contributor to the dramatic arts. In an article about the company, a theater historian posits that a significant stylistic influence on El Teatro’s early performances was the audience-mediated slapstick comedy of *carpa* theater, vaudeville-style shows popular in Mexico and the US Southwest in the 1920s and ’30s.

Which quotation from the article would best illustrate the theater historian’s claim?

- A. “The company presented *actos*, short comedy sketches, that often relied on exaggerated physical humor to groups of agricultural workers, whose reactions—enthusiastic cheers of appreciation and, occasionally, loud boos of disapproval—promoted improvisation.”
- B. “The company was focused on the reality of the present situation and discovered that humor was often found in that reality; consequently, comedy became a tool to convey social critique while entertaining and inspiring audiences.”
- C. “The company relied heavily on satire, humor, and references to contemporary popular culture as well as a make-do aesthetic—often referred to as *rasquache*—that reflected not only the troupe’s limited financial resources but also its sociopolitical message.”
- D. “The members of the company, which in addition to founder Luis Valdez consisted entirely of nonprofessional actors, traveled into farm fields, where they, with minimal props and costumes, performed comedy in the form of brief humorous vignettes.”

ID: 8b924b97 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively illustrates the theater historian’s claim that El Teatro Campesino’s early performances were influenced stylistically by *carpa* theater, vaudeville-style shows with “audience-mediated slapstick comedy.” The quotation indicates that El Teatro presented comedic sketches that often featured exaggerated physical humor and that the performers improvised based on the cheers and boos from the audience; thus, it illustrates that El Teatro’s performances were similar to *carpa* theater in the physical, slapstick nature of their comedy and in the way the performances were mediated, or shaped, by the audience’s reactions.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the quotation refers to El Teatro’s use of comedy and mentions audiences, it focuses on the company’s use of comedic aspects of reality as a tool to critique society while providing audiences with entertainment and inspiration; it doesn’t give any indication that El Teatro’s performances featured slapstick, or very physical, comedy or that they were directly shaped by the audience. Choice C is incorrect. Although the quotation refers to El Teatro’s aesthetic, or style, and mentions comedy, it indicates only that the company relied on satire and humor and had a style that reflected their limited financial means and sociopolitical message; it doesn’t give any indication that El Teatro’s performances featured slapstick, or very

physical, comedy or that they were directly shaped by the audience. Choice D is incorrect. Although the quotation refers to El Teatro's performance of comedy, it mentions only that the company performed brief humorous vignettes, or short humorous scenes, in farm fields; it doesn't give any indication that El Teatro's performances featured slapstick, or very physical, comedy or that they were directly shaped by the audience.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 63b43d2f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 63b43d2f

Approximate Rates of Speech and Information Conveyed for Five Languages

Language	Rate of speech (syllables per second)	Rate of information conveyed (bits per second)
Serbian	7.2	39.1
Spanish	7.7	42.0
Vietnamese	5.3	42.5
Thai	4.7	33.8
Hungarian	5.9	34.6

A group of researchers working in Europe, Asia, and Oceania conducted a study to determine how quickly different Eurasian languages are typically spoken (in syllables per second) and how much information they can effectively convey (in bits per second). They found that, although languages vary widely in the speed at which they are spoken, the amount of information languages can effectively convey tends to vary much less. Thus, they claim that two languages with very different spoken rates can nonetheless convey the same amount of information in a given amount of time.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support the researchers’ claim?

- A. Among the five languages in the table, Thai and Hungarian have the lowest rates of speech and the lowest rates of information conveyed.
- B. Vietnamese conveys information at approximately the same rate as Spanish despite being spoken at a slower rate.
- C. Among the five languages in the table, the language that is spoken the fastest is also the language that conveys information the fastest.
- D. Serbian and Spanish are spoken at approximately the same rate, but Serbian conveys information faster than Spanish does.

ID: 63b43d2f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it provides the most direct support from the table for the claim that two languages can convey similar amounts of information even if they’re spoken at different rates. The table shows the approximate rates at which five languages are spoken and the rates at which those five languages convey information. Vietnamese is spoken at around 5.3 syllables per second, whereas Spanish is spoken at around 7.7 syllables per second, but the two languages convey information at very similar rates: Vietnamese at a rate of around 42.5 bits per second and Spanish at a rate of around 42.0 bits per second. Thus, the description of Vietnamese conveying information at around the same rate that Spanish does despite being spoken more slowly supports the claim in the text that languages can convey the same amount of information even if spoken at different rates.

Choice A is incorrect because it isn't true that Thai and Hungarian have the lowest rates of speech of the five languages shown. According to the table, Hungarian is spoken at around 5.9 syllables per second, which is faster than Vietnamese (5.3 syllables per second). Additionally, even if this statement were true, the assertion that two languages are spoken the slowest and convey information the slowest wouldn't support the claim that languages can convey the same amount of information even if they're spoken at different rates. Choice C is incorrect because it isn't true that the fastest-spoken language (Spanish, at 7.7 syllables per second) also conveys information the fastest: Spanish conveys information at 42.0 bits per second, which is slower than the 42.5 bits-per-second rate at which Vietnamese conveys information. Additionally, even if this statement were true, the assertion that the language spoken the fastest also conveys information the fastest has no bearing on the claim that languages can convey the same amount of information even if they're spoken at different rates. Choice D is incorrect because it isn't true that Serbian conveys information faster than Spanish does. According to the table, Serbian conveys information at a rate of around 39.1 bits per second, which is slower than the 42.0 bits-per-second rate at which Spanish conveys information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5de85c2b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 5de85c2b

The following text is from William Shakespeare’s play *The Tempest*, first performed in 1611. Miranda has lived on an island with her father, Prospero, since she was three years old. Prospero has stated that Miranda likely does not remember anything other than her life on the island.

MIRANDA: 'Tis far off,
And rather like a dream than an assurance
That my remembrance warrants. Had I not
Four or five women once that tended me?

PROSPERO: Thou hadst, and more, Miranda. But how is it
That this lives in thy mind? What seest thou else
In the dark backward and abysm of time?
If thou remember'st ought ere thou camest here,
How thou camest here thou mayst.

- In the text, which point does Prospero most directly make about Miranda and her memories?
- A. Miranda’s reminiscences about her early childhood have a melancholy quality that betrays her discontented view of her current circumstances.
 - B. Miranda’s doubts about the accuracy of one recollection of a place other than the island are clouding her judgment and seem to be making her reluctant to explore her recollection of traveling to the island.
 - C. Miranda’s ability to summon details of an experience she had before arriving on the island suggests that she may also be able to summon details of her arrival on the island.
 - D. Miranda’s impression of a scene is vague because she is remembering a scenario she had daydreamed about as a child rather than a scenario that had occurred in reality.

ID: 5de85c2b Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a point that Prospero makes about Miranda. The text begins with Miranda responding to Prospero’s claim that she probably doesn’t remember her life before the island. She describes a distant memory, asking if she had "four or five women" caring for her. Prospero confirms this ("thou hadst") and then asks what else she can recall, stating that because she remembers one thing from the time before she lived on the island ("ought ere thou camest here"), she might also remember arriving on the island ("how thou camest here"). That is, Prospero indicates that Miranda’s ability to summon details of an experience from before her arrival on the island suggests that she may also be able to summon details of her arrival.

Choice A is incorrect because Prospero doesn't say anything about how Miranda presents her early childhood memory of having several people care for her—he indicates only his surprise that she remembers something from so long ago ("the dark backward and abysm of time") and his thought that she may also be able to recall another childhood event: her arrival on the island. Further, Prospero doesn't suggest that he believes Miranda is discontent in her current circumstances. Choice B is incorrect. Although Miranda suggests some doubt about her recollection of a place other than the island, in that she describes it as "like a dream" she can't be certain of, Prospero doesn't mention her uncertainty—though he himself wonders how it is possible that she correctly recalls something from so long ago ("abysm of time"). Rather than indicating that doubt is making Miranda reluctant, Prospero simply states that Miranda may have the ability to remember traveling to the island. Choice D is incorrect. Although Miranda describes a vague impression of several people who cared for her as a young child and states that it is "rather like a dream" instead of something she is certain is real, Prospero doesn't indicate that Miranda is remembering a childhood daydream. Instead, he confirms that what Miranda remembers actually happened, answering her question about having had caregivers with "thou hadst," and asks her what else she can remember from long ago.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 44132412

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 44132412

Although most songbirds build open, cupped nests, some species build domed nests with roofs that provide much more protection. Many ecologists have assumed that domed nests would provide protection from weather conditions and thus would allow species that build them to have larger geographic ranges than species that build open nests do. To evaluate this assumption, a research team led by evolutionary biologist Iliana Medina analyzed data for over 3,000 species of songbirds.

Which finding from Medina and her colleagues’ study, if true, would most directly challenge the assumption in the underlined sentence?

- A. Species that build open nests tend to have higher extinction rates than species that build domed nests.
- B. Species that build open nests tend to be smaller in size than species that build domed nests.
- C. Species that build open nests tend to use fewer materials to build their nests than species that build domed nests do.
- D. Species that build open nests tend to have larger ranges than species that build domed nests.

ID: 44132412 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would challenge the assumption that many ecologists have made about the connection between the building of domed nests and geographic range in songbirds. The text says that many ecologists have assumed that since domed nests provide protection from weather conditions, songbird species that build such nests should be able to have larger geographic ranges than songbird species that build open nests do. If Medina and her colleagues found that species that build open nests tend to have larger geographic ranges than species that build domed nests do, their finding would show the opposite of what the ecologists have assumed. It would therefore challenge the ecologists’ assumption.

Choice A is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that there’s a relationship between songbird species’ extinction rates and their geographic ranges. The finding that species that build open nests tend to have higher extinction rates than species that build domed nests do would therefore have no clear bearing on the ecologists’ assumption that domed nests allow species that build them to have larger geographic ranges than those of species that build open nests. Choice B is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that there’s a relationship between songbird species’ sizes and their geographic ranges. The finding that species that build open nests tend to be smaller in size than species that build domed nests are would therefore have no clear bearing on the ecologists’ assumption that domed nests allow species that build them to have larger geographic ranges than those of species that build open nests. Choice C is incorrect because although the text indicates that many ecologists have assumed that there’s a connection between how songbird species build their nests and the species’ geographic ranges, the text says that this assumption is based on the shape of the nests—that is, whether the nests are domed or open—not the number of materials used. The finding that species that build open nests tend to use fewer materials to build their nests than species that build domed nests

do would therefore have no clear bearing on the ecologists' assumption that domed nests allow species that build them to have larger geographic ranges than those of species that build open nests.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8f3e127d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 8f3e127d

In 1934 physicist Eugene Wigner posited the existence of a crystal consisting entirely of electrons in a honeycomb-like structure. The so-called Wigner crystal remained largely conjecture, however, until Feng Wang and colleagues announced in 2021 that they had captured an image of one. The researchers trapped electrons between two semiconductors and then cooled the apparatus, causing the electrons to settle into a crystalline structure. By inserting an ultrathin sheet of graphene above the crystal, the researchers obtained an impression—the first visual confirmation of the Wigner crystal.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Researchers have obtained the most definitive evidence to date of the existence of the Wigner crystal.
- B. Researchers have identified an innovative new method for working with unusual crystalline structures.
- C. Graphene is the most important of the components required to capture an image of a Wigner crystal.
- D. It’s difficult to acquire an image of a Wigner crystal because of the crystal’s honeycomb structure.

ID: 8f3e127d Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. According to the text, Eugene Wigner hypothesized that a crystal could exist that would be composed of electrons and have a honeycomb-like shape. The text goes on to say that the existence of the Wigner crystal remained unconfirmed until Feng Wang and colleagues were able to make an impression of one using two semiconductors and an ultrathin sheet of graphene. Thus, the main idea is that researchers have obtained the most definitive evidence to date of the existence of the Wigner crystal.

Choice B is incorrect because the text focuses on one kind of crystal—the Wigner crystal— and doesn’t discuss crystalline structures in general. And although the text conveys that Wang and colleagues figured out a way to capture an image of a Wigner crystal, it doesn’t address the idea of applying this approach to other types of crystals. Choice C is incorrect because the text describes in general the process Wang and colleagues followed to obtain an impression of the Wigner crystal; it doesn’t address the relative importance of each component in that process. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t state that researchers had a hard time getting an impression of the Wigner crystal because of its honeycomb structure. Nothing in the text indicates why it took so long to prove the existence of this crystal or take an impression of it.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b9ff6341

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: b9ff6341

Born in Chile in 1917, artist and ethnomusicologist Violeta Parra was a pioneer in the *nueva canción chilena* (Chilean New Song) movement that emerged in the late 1950s and then spread throughout Latin America, Portugal, and Spain as *nueva canción*. Parra traveled all over Chile compiling extensive records of authentic folk music as well as recipes, proverbs, and other facets of cultural history. These records formed the foundation for the early movement’s revival of traditional Chilean folk forms in new songs that represented modern realities of the working class and strongly advocated for social change. As the movement spread beyond Chile, the breadth of musical traditions incorporated into its foundation also expanded.

- Which detail about songs associated with *nueva canción*, if true, would best illustrate the underlined claim?
- A. Many feature political commentary addressing contemporary issues that stemmed from shared experiences of European colonization in Latin American countries.
 - B. Many demonstrate the stylistic influence of *corrido*, a genre of narrative songs from Mexico that had come to be characterized by political themes in the early 1800s.
 - C. Many were written with parts meant to be played on the *quena*, a traditional flute used across Andean countries, including Chile.
 - D. Many were produced by Argentinian artists in the late 1950s, with others by artists in additional Latin American countries first emerging soon after.

ID: b9ff6341 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a detail that, if true, would most effectively illustrate the underlined claim that as *nueva canción* spread beyond Chile, the breadth of musical traditions incorporated into its foundation also expanded. The text explains that the movement was initially founded on traditional Chilean folk forms compiled by Parra, so if many *nueva canción* songs demonstrate the stylistic influence of *corrido*—a Mexican narrative song genre—that would show that a musical tradition originating outside Chile became part of the movement’s foundation, directly illustrating the text’s claim about how the breadth of *nueva canción* expanded.

Choice A is incorrect because the finding addresses lyrical content—political commentary on issues stemming from European colonization—rather than musical traditions. Even if *nueva canción* songs across different countries share political themes, that doesn’t indicate that new musical forms or styles were incorporated into the movement’s foundation. Thematic content is distinct from the musical traditions that songs draw on stylistically. Choice C is incorrect because the *quena* is described as a “traditional flute used across Andean countries, including Chile,” meaning it’s part of the Chilean folk tradition that underpinned *nueva canción* at its origin. Use of the *quena* therefore wouldn’t illustrate the incorporation of musical traditions beyond those that founded the early movement in Chile. Choice D is incorrect because the finding establishes only that artists in additional Latin American countries produced *nueva canción* songs, not that those artists incorporated musical traditions from their own countries into the

movement. Artists in other countries could still have been drawing on the same Chilean folk forms that originally founded the movement, so geographic spread alone doesn't illustrate an expansion of musical traditions.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9c4c0554

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 9c4c0554

Distribution of Ecosystem Services Affected by Invasive Species by Service Type

Region (Overall)	Provisioning (75%)	Regulating (21%)	Cultural (4%)
West	73%	27%	0%
North	88%	12%	0%
South	79%	14%	7%
East	83%	6%	11%
Central	33%	67%	0%

To assess the impact of invasive species on ecosystems in Africa, Benis N. Egoh and colleagues reviewed government reports from those nations about how invasive species are undermining ecosystem services (aspects of the ecosystem on which residents depend). The services were sorted into three categories: provisioning (material resources from the ecosystem), regulating (natural processes such as cleaning the air or water), and cultural (nonmaterial benefits of ecosystems). Egoh and her team assert that countries in each region reported effects on provisioning services and that provisioning services represent the majority of the reported services.

Which choice best describes data from the table that support Egoh and colleagues’ assertion?

- A. Provisioning services represent 73% of the services reported for the West region and 33% of those for the Central region, but they represent 75% of the services reported overall.
- B. None of the percentages shown for provisioning services are lower than 33%, and the overall percentage shown for provisioning services is 75%.
- C. Provisioning services are shown for each region, while no cultural services are shown for some regions.
- D. The greatest percentage shown for provisioning services is 88% for the North region, and the least shown for provisioning services is 33% for the Central region.

ID: 9c4c0554 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The finding that all the regions reported at least some effects on provisioning services supports the first part of the assertion. And the fact that provisioning services comprise 75% of the reported services overall supports the second part of the assertion.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn't fully support the assertion. It doesn't include the finding that all the regions (not just Central and West) reported at least some effects on provisioning services. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn't fully support the assertion. It doesn't demonstrate that provisioning services represent the majority of the reported services overall. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn't fully support the assertion. It doesn't demonstrate that provisioning services represent the majority of the reported services overall.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 59c2832b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 59c2832b

The following text is adapted from María Cristina Mena’s 1914 short story “The Vine-Leaf.”

It is a saying in the capital of Mexico that Dr. Malsufrido carries more family secrets under his hat than any archbishop. The doctor’s hat is, appropriately enough, uncommonly capacious, rising very high, and sinking so low that it seems to be supported by his ears and eyebrows, and it has a furry look, as if it had been brushed the wrong way, which is perhaps what happens to it if it is ever brushed at all. When the doctor takes it off, the family secrets do not fly out like a flock of parrots, but remain nicely bottled up beneath a dome of old and highly polished ivory.

Based on the text, how do people in the capital of Mexico most likely regard Dr. Malsufrido?

- A. Many have come to tolerate him despite his disheveled appearance.
- B. Few feel concerned that he will divulge their confidences.
- C. Some dislike how freely he discusses his own family.
- D. Most would be unimpressed by him were it not for his professional expertise.

ID: 59c2832b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text describes a saying in the capital that Malsufrido keeps more secrets than an archbishop. It also says that when he takes off his hat, “the family secrets do not fly out... but remain nicely bottled up,” suggesting that he will not betray his confidences.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t reflect the text. While his hat is large and appears to have been brushed in the wrong direction, Dr. Malsufrido does not seem to be regarded as ill-dressed or disheveled. Choice C is incorrect. This choice is the opposite of what the text says. The secrets of families (his and others’) remain “bottled up” in his head. Choice D is incorrect. This choice isn’t supported by the text. His professional expertise is not discussed in the passage.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID efd9269d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: efd9269d

“Poetry” is a 1919 poem by Marianne Moore. The poem highlights an ambivalence toward poetry as the speaker acknowledges its merits while also expressing a sense of displeasure, writing _____

Which quotation from “Poetry” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “nor is it valid / to discriminate against ‘business documents and / school-books’; all these phenomena are important.”
- B. “One must make a distinction / however: when dragged into prominence by half poets, the result is not / poetry”
- C. “when [poems] become so derivative as to become unintelligible, the / same thing may be said for all of us—that we / do not admire what / we cannot understand.”
- D. “Reading [poetry], however, with a perfect contempt for it, one discovers that there is in / it after all, a place for the genuine.”

ID: efd9269d Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most effectively uses a quotation from "Poetry" to illustrate the claim that the poem highlights an ambivalence, or a conflicted attitude, toward poetry. In the quotation, the speaker suggests that one might read poetry with "contempt," or disdain, for it, but even with this negative attitude one will find "a place for the genuine." Because the quotation expresses conflicting attitudes toward poetry, it effectively illustrates the speaker’s ambivalence in discussing the merits and displeasure of reading poetry.

Choice A is incorrect because it doesn’t mention poetry or show ambivalence. Choice B is incorrect. Although the idea of "half poets" may seem to relate to ambivalence, the speaker mentions only negative attitudes toward certain works and the quotation therefore lacks a contrasting positive or neutral attitude that would be needed to indicate ambivalence. Choice C is incorrect because the speaker mentions only negative attitudes toward certain works and the quotation therefore lacks a contrasting positive or neutral attitude that would be needed to indicate ambivalence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 250d5b23

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 250d5b23

By running computer simulations of the development of our solar system, André Izidoro, Rajdeep Dasgupta, and colleagues concluded that the Sun may have been surrounded by three giant dust rings before the planets started to form. The researchers suggest that the materials in the innermost ring became the four planets closest to the Sun, the materials in the middle ring produced the rest of the planets, and the materials in the outermost ring created the asteroids and other small bodies in the region beyond Neptune. In one simulation, the researchers delayed the initial formation of the middle ring, causing oversized super-Earths to begin developing from the innermost ring. The researchers therefore hypothesize that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the middle ring formed earlier in the solar system’s development than the initial simulations suggested.
- B. the timing of the initial formation of the middle ring played an important role in determining the eventual size of Earth.
- C. if the formation of the outermost ring had occurred earlier in a simulation, all the planets would have become super-Earths.
- D. the innermost ring actually formed into all the planets in our solar system, not just the four closest to the Sun.

ID: 250d5b23 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically follows from the text’s discussion of André Izidoro, Rajdeep Dasgupta, and colleagues’ computer simulations of our solar system’s development. The text begins by stating that the simulations led the researchers to conclude that the solar system likely formed from three giant dust rings that encircled the Sun. The text explains that the four inner planets, including Earth, formed from the innermost ring and that the remaining planets formed from the middle ring. It then explains that in one simulation, the researchers delayed the formation of the middle ring—that is, they tested to see what would happen if the middle ring had formed later than it actually did. They found that doing so affected the size of the innermost planets, resulting in oversized super-Earths, planets that are much larger than Earth. Since the delayed timing had the effect of changing the size of Earth in the simulation relative to Earth’s real size, it’s reasonable to conclude that the timing of the middle ring’s formation was important in determining Earth’s eventual size.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text explains that when the researchers delayed the formation of the middle ring in one simulation, the size of the innermost planets was affected (which suggests that the middle ring likely formed earlier than it did in this simulation), the text doesn’t indicate that this was an initial simulation—that is, a simulation that was conducted before other simulations. Moreover, the text makes no reference to the specific results of any other simulations; therefore, there is no basis for comparing any conclusions based on the simulation in which the middle ring’s formation was delayed with conclusions based on other simulations. Choice C is incorrect because the text discusses how altering the timing of the formation of the middle ring, not the outermost ring, affected the four innermost planets’ eventual size in the researchers’ simulation; therefore, the simulation offers no basis for a conclusion about how the outermost ring’s formation affected the size of the planets. Choice D is incorrect because there is nothing in the text to suggest that the innermost ring produced all the solar system’s planets. Rather, the text

states that the simulations showed that the innermost planets formed from the innermost ring and that the remaining planets formed from the middle ring.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b9e60c7a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: b9e60c7a

Number and Origin of Clamshell Tools Found at Different Levels Below the Surface in Neanderthal Cave

Depth of tools found below surface in cave (meters)	Clamshells that Neanderthals collected from the beach	Clamshells that Neanderthals harvested from the seafloor
3–4	99	33
6–7	1	0
4–5	2	0
2–3	7	0
5–6	18	7

Studying tools unearthed at a cave site on the western coast of Italy, archaeologist Paola Villa and colleagues have determined that prehistoric Neanderthal groups fashioned them from shells of clams that they harvested from the seafloor while wading or diving or that washed up on the beach. Clamshells become thin and eroded as they wash up on the beach, while those on the seafloor are smooth and sturdy, so the research team suspects that Neanderthals prized the tools made with seafloor shells. However, the team also concluded that those tools were likely more challenging to obtain, noting that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to support the research team’s conclusion?

- A. at each depth below the surface in the cave, the difference in the numbers of tools of each type suggests that shells were easier to collect from the beach than to harvest from the seafloor.
- B. the highest number of tools were at a depth of 3–4 meters below the surface, which suggests that the Neanderthal population at the site was highest during the related period of time.
- C. at each depth below the surface in the cave, the difference in the numbers of tools of each type suggests that Neanderthals preferred to use clamshells from the beach because of their durability.
- D. the higher number of tools at depths of 5–6 meters below the surface in the cave than at depths of 4–5 meters below the surface suggests that the size of clam populations changed over time.

ID: b9e60c7a Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the table to support the researchers’ conclusion about the harvesting of clamshells by Neanderthals for use as tools. The text explains that Neanderthals used clamshells to make tools and that the sturdiest, and therefore the most desirable, shells for this purpose are found on the seafloor, not on the beach. However, the researchers also concluded that the clamshell tools made from shells from the seafloor are rarer than those made from shells

from the beach. Meanwhile the table shows that at each depth, the number of tools made from shells from the beach exceeds the number made from the more desirable shells from the seafloor. The fact that the more desirable shells are less common suggests that it was significantly more difficult to harvest shells from the seafloor than from the beach.

Choice B is incorrect because knowing which depth represents the period of time with the highest Neanderthal population does not help answer the question of why the Neanderthals consistently made more tools from the less desirable shells from the beach than they made from the more desirable shells from the seafloor. Choice C is incorrect because it claims that the beach shells are more durable than the seafloor shells, which contradicts the text’s description of shells from the seafloor as smoother and sturdier than shells from the beach. Choice D is incorrect because knowing which depth has the most artifacts or whether the clam population fluctuated does not help explain why tools made from the less desirable shells from the beach outnumber tools made from the more desirable shells from the seafloor.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d4affb34

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: d4affb34

Average Nitrate and Phosphate Concentrations in Seawater after Volcanic Eruption

Nutrient	Seawater in lava-affected area, 5–45 meters below surface	Seawater in lava-affected area, 75–125 meters below surface	Seawater outside of lava-affected area, 5–45 meters below surface	Seawater outside of lava-affected area, 75–125 meters below surface
Nitrate (micromoles per liter)	3.1	0.4	≤0.03	≤0.01
Phosphate (micromoles per liter)	0.17	0.09	0.14	0.06

After a volcanic eruption spilled lava into North Pacific Ocean waters, a dramatic increase of diatoms (a kind of phytoplankton) near the surface occurred. Scientists assumed the diatoms were thriving on nutrients such as phosphate from the lava, but analysis showed these nutrients weren’t present near the surface in forms diatoms can consume. However, there was an abundance of usable nitrate, a nutrient usually found in much deeper water and almost never found in lava. Microbial oceanographer Sonya Dyhrman and colleagues believe that as the lava plunged nearly 300 meters below the surface it dislodged pockets of this nutrient, releasing it to float upward, given that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement?

- A. at 5–45 meters below the surface, the average concentration of phosphate was about the same in the seawater in the lava-affected area as in the seawater outside of the lava-affected area.
- B. for both depth ranges measured, the average concentrations of nitrate were substantially higher in the seawater in the lava-affected area than in the seawater outside of the lava-affected area.
- C. for both depth ranges measured in the seawater in the lava-affected area, the average concentrations of nitrate were substantially higher than the average concentrations of phosphate.
- D. in the seawater outside of the lava-affected area, there was little change in the average concentration of nitrate from 75–125 meters below the surface to 5–45 meters below the surface.

ID: d4affb34 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The claim is that the lava freed the deep nitrate, allowing it to float upward. The table supports this by showing that there was more nitrate in the lava-affected seawater at various depths above 300 meters (the depth to which the

lava plunged) than in unaffected seawater.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn't complete the statement in a way that supports the claim. The claim is about nitrate, not phosphate. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn't complete the statement in a way that supports the claim. The claim is only about nitrate—the concentrations of phosphate aren't relevant. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn't complete the statement in a way that supports the claim. It doesn't say anything about the seawater inside the lava-affected area.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 39769e3d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 39769e3d

“To You” is an 1856 poem by Walt Whitman. In the poem, Whitman suggests that he deeply understands the reader, whom he addresses directly, writing, _____

Which quotation from “To You” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “Your true soul and body appear before me.”
- B. “Whoever you are, now I place my hand upon you, that you be my poem.”
- C. “I should have made my way straight to you long ago.”
- D. “Whoever you are, I fear you are walking the walks of dreams.”

ID: 39769e3d Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most directly illustrates the text’s claim about Whitman’s poem, “To You.” The text says that in this poem, Whitman suggests that he deeply understands the poem’s reader. This quotation says that the reader’s “true soul and body appear before” Whitman, thereby asserting that he can see the reader as the reader truly is, suggesting that he deeply understands the reader.

Choice B is incorrect because this quotation describes Whitman making the reader the subject of the poem (“you be my poem”), not Whitman deeply understanding the reader. Choice C is incorrect because instead of suggesting that Whitman deeply understands the reader, it emphasizes Whitman’s regret at not having addressed the reader sooner. Choice D is incorrect. Although this quotation shows Whitman directly addressing the reader and expressing concern about the reader, it doesn’t illustrate the idea that Whitman suggests that he deeply understands the reader. The quotation is simply expressing concern about the reader, which doesn’t necessarily imply deep understanding of the reader.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3e2ad5fc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 3e2ad5fc

For centuries, the widespread acknowledgment of the involvement of the cerebellum—a dense brain structure in vertebrates—in coordinating motor control in humans has hindered recognition of other possible functions of the structure. Neuroscience research from the last two decades now suggests that the cerebellum regulates emotion and social behavior, and recent research by Ilaria Carta and colleagues has identified a pathway connecting the cerebellum to a center for motivation and reward processing known as the ventral tegmental area (VTA).

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. The recent verification of a pathway between the VTA and the cerebellum confirms the cerebellum’s long-suspected role in motor coordination.
- B. Recent advances in the field of neuroscience have challenged widely accepted claims about the function of a pathway connecting the VTA and the cerebellum.
- C. The cerebellum has primarily been thought to regulate motor functioning, but in recent years neuroscience researchers have been uncovering additional functions.
- D. Technological limitations have historically hindered the study of the cerebellum, but the recent development of new technologies has led to greater insights into its functions.

ID: 3e2ad5fc Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The text says that the cerebellum has long been thought to regulate motor functioning, but new research shows that it may also have other functions—including regulating emotion and social behavior and some connection to motivation and rewards processing.

Choice A is incorrect. The VTA is described as “a center for motivation and reward processing,” and the discovery of the pathway between the VTA and the cerebellum supports the theory that the cerebellum is involved in functions other than motor coordination. Choice B is incorrect. The text says that recent research has identified this pathway, but it doesn’t discuss any previous “widely accepted claims” about the pathway’s function. The “widespread acknowledgement” mentioned early in the passage is about the cerebellum alone, not its connection to the VTA. Choice D is incorrect. The text never discusses any technological limitations or any new technologies.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e95c72c6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: e95c72c6

Ancestral Puebloans, the civilization from which present-day Pueblo tribes descended, emerged as early as 1500 B.C.E. in an area of what is now the southwestern United States and dispersed suddenly in the late 1200s C.E., abandoning established villages with systems for farming crops and turkeys. Recent analysis comparing turkey remains at Mesa Verde, one such village in southern Colorado, to samples from modern turkey populations in the Rio Grande Valley of north central New Mexico determined that the latter birds descended in part from turkeys cultivated at Mesa Verde, with shared genetic markers appearing only after 1280. Thus, researchers concluded that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. conditions of the terrains in the Rio Grande Valley and Mesa Verde had greater similarities in the past than they do today.
- B. some Ancestral Puebloans migrated to the Rio Grande Valley in the late 1200s and carried farming practices with them.
- C. Indigenous peoples living in the Rio Grande Valley primarily planted crops and did not cultivate turkeys before 1280.
- D. the Ancestral Puebloans of Mesa Verde likely adopted the farming practices of Indigenous peoples living in other regions.

ID: e95c72c6 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of Ancestral Puebloans’ migration to the Rio Grande Valley. The text states that in the late 1200s C.E., the Ancestral Puebloan civilization abandoned villages in its original homeland, which included the Mesa Verde site. The text goes on to say that recent genetic analysis has demonstrated that the modern turkey population in the Rio Grande Valley descends partly from the ancient turkeys raised at Mesa Verde, and that the genetic markers shared by the two turkey populations first appeared at Mesa Verde only after 1280 C.E. Therefore, it can reasonably be concluded that some Ancestral Puebloans migrated to the Rio Grande Valley in the late 1200s and carried their agricultural practices—including the farming of turkeys—to their new home.

Choice A is incorrect because the text never compares the condition of the Rio Grande Valley’s terrain to that of Mesa Verde’s terrain, either in the present or in the past. Choice C is incorrect. Although genetic analysis has demonstrated that the modern turkey population in the Rio Grande valley descended in part from the turkey population raised by the Ancestral Puebloans of Mesa Verde before their migration to the valley in 1280, this finding doesn’t eliminate the possibility that Indigenous peoples living in the valley before 1280 might also have farmed turkeys. Choice D is incorrect. The text doesn’t consider the possibility that before their migration to the Rio Grande Valley after 1280, the Ancestral Puebloans of Mesa Verde might have adopted turkey farming from an outside Indigenous civilization in another region; instead, the text provides evidence suggesting that the Ancestral Puebloans brought turkey farming to another region—the Rio Grande Valley—after 1280.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 504476cf

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 504476cf

Although many transposons, DNA sequences that move within an organism’s genome through shuffling or duplication, have become corrupted and inactive over time, those from the long interspersed nuclear elements (LINE) family appear to remain active in the genomes of some species. In humans, they are functionally important within the hippocampus, a brain structure that supports complex cognitive processes. When the results of molecular analysis of two species of octopus—an animal known for its intelligence—were announced in 2022, the confirmation of a LINE transposon in *Octopus vulgaris* and *Octopus bimaculoides* genomes prompted researchers to hypothesize that that transposon family is tied to a species’ capacity for advanced cognition.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the researchers’ hypothesis?

- A. The LINE transposon in *O. vulgaris* and *O. bimaculoides* genomes is active in an octopus brain structure that functions similarly to the human hippocampus.
- B. The human genome contains multiple transposons from the LINE family that are all primarily active in the hippocampus.
- C. A consistent number of copies of LINE transposons is present across the genomes of most octopus species, with few known corruptions.
- D. *O. vulgaris* and *O. bimaculoides* have smaller brains than humans do relative to body size, but their genomes contain sequences from a wider variety of transposon families.

ID: 504476cf Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The text says that LINE transposons are important in the human hippocampus, which supports complex cognition. If the LINE transposon found in octopuses is active in a similar part of their brain, that would suggest that LINE transposons support complex cognition in octopuses too, which in turn supports the hypothesis that LINE transposons are linked to advanced cognition in general.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the hypothesis. It doesn’t include anything about how LINE transposons function in species other than humans. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the hypothesis. It doesn’t include anything about how the LINE transposon in octopuses might support advanced cognition. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the hypothesis. It doesn’t include anything about how the LINE transposon in octopuses might support advanced cognition.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f96e3085

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: f96e3085

Pulitzer Prize–winning writer Héctor Tobar has built a multifaceted career as both a journalist and an author of short stories and novels. In an essay about Tobar’s work, a student claims that Tobar blends his areas of expertise by applying journalism techniques to his creation of works of fiction.

Which quotation from a literary critic best supports the student’s claim?

- A. “For one novel, an imagined account of a real person’s global travels, Tobar approached his subject like a reporter, interviewing people the man had met along the way and researching the man’s own writings.”
- B. “Tobar got his start as a volunteer for *El Tecolote*, a community newspaper in San Francisco, and wrote for newspapers for years before earning a degree in creative writing and starting to publish works of fiction.”
- C. “Many of Tobar’s notable nonfiction articles are marked by the writer’s use of techniques usually associated with fiction, such as complex narrative structures and the incorporation of symbolism.”
- D. “The protagonist of Tobar’s third novel is a man who wants to be a novelist and keeps notes about interesting people he encounters so he can use them when developing characters for his stories.”

ID: f96e3085 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The example of Tobar approaching his subject “like a reporter,” including conducting “interviews” and “research,” shows Tobar applying journalism techniques to his fiction-writing.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the claim. It tells us about Tobar’s initial career as a journalist, but it doesn’t say anything about him “applying journalism techniques” to his fiction-writing. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the claim. It tells us that Tobar applied fiction techniques to his nonfiction writing, but we’re looking for evidence of the other way around: that Tobar applied journalism techniques to his fiction-writing. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t support the claim. It tells us that a character in one of Tobar’s novels applied a journalism technique to his fiction-writing, but it doesn’t tell us that Tobar did that himself.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7c966237

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 7c966237

The Intertropical Convergence Zone (ITCZ), a band of clouds that encircles Earth in the tropics and is a major rainfall source, shifts position in response to temperature variations across Earth’s hemispheres. Data from Huagapo Cave in Peru suggest the ITCZ shifted south during the Little Ice Age (circa 1300–1850), but a shift as far into South America as Huagapo should have led to dry conditions in Central America, which is inconsistent with climate models. To resolve the issue, geologist Yemane Asmerom and colleagues collected data from Yok Balum Cave in Central America and compared them with the Huagapo data. They concluded that during the Little Ice Age, the ITCZ may have expanded northward and southward rather than simply shifted.

- Which finding from Asmerom and colleagues’ study, if true, would most directly support their conclusion?
- A. Neither the Yok Balum data nor the Huagapo data show significant local variations in temperature during the Little Ice Age.
 - B. Both the Yok Balum data and the Huagapo data show increased temperatures and prolonged dry conditions during the Little Ice Age.
 - C. The Yok Balum data show prolonged dry conditions during the same portions of the Little Ice Age in which the Huagapo data show heightened levels of rainfall.
 - D. The Yok Balum data and the Huagapo data show strongly correlated patterns of high rainfall during the Little Ice Age.

ID: 7c966237 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support Asmerom and colleagues’ conclusion that the ITCZ may have expanded northward and southward rather than shifting south during the Little Ice Age. The text indicates that the ITCZ, a band of clouds in the tropics that is a significant rainfall source, can change position. Data from Peru’s Huagapo Cave suggest that the ITCZ shifted south during the Little Ice Age. But according to the text, if the ITCZ moved into South America in that way, then Central America should have been drier than climate models suggest it was. In other words, rainfall should have been reduced in Central America because the ITCZ, a significant rainfall source, had shifted into South America, but climate models do not show such a reduction in Central America. The text goes on to say that Asmerom and colleagues tried to resolve this apparent conflict by collecting data from Yok Balum cave in Central America and comparing them with data from Huagapo, which led the researchers to conclude that the ITCZ may have expanded both northward and southward rather than simply shifting south. If it is true that Yok Balum in Central America and Huagapo in South America show strongly correlated patterns of high rainfall during the Little Ice Age, such a finding would support Asmerom and colleagues’ conclusion by suggesting that the two areas were affected by the same rainfall source, and thus that the ITCZ may have expanded rather than shifted.

Choice A is incorrect because there is no information in the text about how, if at all, the ITCZ affects temperature in areas where it is located. Rather, the text states that temperature variations across Earth’s hemispheres can shift the position of the ITCZ. Finding that neither Yok Balum nor Huagapo data show evidence of significant local variations in temperature during the Little Ice Age would have no clear bearing on Asmerom and colleagues’ claim. Choice B is incorrect because finding that both Yok Balum

and Huagapo experienced prolonged dry conditions during the Little Ice Age would not support Asmerom and colleagues' conclusion that the ITCZ, a major source of rainfall, may have expanded northward and southward rather than simply shifting south. Dry conditions in both locations would suggest that the ITCZ did not cover either location. Additionally, finding that temperatures were elevated in both locations would have no clear bearing on Asmerom and colleagues' conclusion, since there is no information in the text that indicates how, if at all, the ITCZ affects temperature. Choice C is incorrect because finding that Yok Balum experienced prolonged dry conditions at the same time that Huagapo experienced high rainfall would weaken Asmerom and colleagues' conclusion, not strengthen it. Such a finding would suggest that the ITCZ shifted south and left Central America dry rather than expanding both northward and southward.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 73a6cb79

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 73a6cb79

Baltimore, Maryland, has installed engineered structures along 71% of its shoreline to protect infrastructure from wave erosion and other hazards, a practice known as shoreline hardening. To evaluate the responses of waterbirds to two types of hardening structures—riprap and bulkheads—Diann Prosser et al. surveyed waterbird communities consisting of the tundra swan, the great blue heron, and 62 other species at different sites in the Chesapeake Bay on the US East Coast. Utilizing the Index of Waterbird Community Integrity (IWCI), on which a high score corresponds to high community integrity, the researchers found that bulkheads are more strongly negatively correlated with waterbird community integrity than is riprap.

Which finding, if true, would most directly illustrate the researchers’ finding?

- A. The difference in average IWCI scores for waterbird communities at Stony and Old Road, two sites with a higher percentage of shoreline consisting of bulkheads than of riprap, was statistically insignificant.
- B. Waterbird communities at Old Road, a site with a relatively high percentage of shoreline consisting of bulkheads, had lower average IWCI scores than did waterbird communities at Miles, a site with a relatively high percentage of shoreline consisting of riprap.
- C. Waterbird communities at Curtis, a site with a high percentage of shoreline consisting of bulkheads and riprap, had lower average IWCI scores than did waterbird communities at Onancock, a site with a low percentage of shoreline consisting of bulkheads and riprap.
- D. Waterbird communities at Curtis, a site with equal percentages of shoreline consisting of bulkheads and riprap, had higher average IWCI scores than did waterbird communities at Miles, a site with different percentages of shoreline consisting of bulkheads and riprap.

ID: 73a6cb79 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly illustrate the researchers’ finding about waterbird responses to shoreline hardening structures. The text explains that using the IWCI, an index on which higher scores indicate higher community integrity, researchers found that bulkheads are more strongly negatively correlated with waterbird community integrity than riprap is—that is, that bulkheads reduce the integrity of waterbird communities more than riprap does. The finding that waterbird communities at a site with a relatively high percentage of bulkheads along the shoreline (Old Road) had lower average IWCI scores than waterbird communities at a site with a relatively high percentage of riprap along the shoreline (Miles) did would illustrate the researchers’ finding, since it would be an example of lower waterbird community integrity in a location with substantial bulkhead presence than in a location with substantial riprap presence.

Choice A is incorrect because a finding of similar waterbird community integrity in two sites predominated by bulkheads wouldn’t reveal anything about waterbird community integrity at sites predominated by riprap or how waterbird community integrity compares between the two types of sites. Thus, the finding wouldn’t illustrate the discovery of a difference in how bulkheads and

riprap correlate with waterbird community integrity. Choice C is incorrect because it presents a finding that compares waterbird community integrity at sites with different overall amounts of shoreline hardening but without distinguishing between bulkheads and riprap. Such a distinction would be necessary to illustrate the researchers' finding of a difference in how bulkheads and riprap each correlate with waterbird community integrity. Choice D is incorrect because it presents a finding that addresses a difference in waterbird community integrity between one site with equal percentages of bulkheads and riprap along its shoreline (Curtis) and one site with unequal percentages of bulkheads and riprap (Miles) but without indicating whether bulkheads or riprap were more prevalent at Miles. This finding wouldn't provide any clear information about how bulkheads and riprap each correlate with waterbird community integrity, so it wouldn't illustrate the researchers' finding of a difference between those correlations.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 43499ccb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 43499ccb

In a 2017 article, historian Jasmine Kilburn-Toppin explains that in early modern London, members of the city’s guilds (trade and artisanal associations) were participants in a civic culture in which gift giving both signaled and conferred social status. Research on this phenomenon has tended to focus on philanthropic gifting by London’s largest guilds; for her part, Kilburn-Toppin focuses on the gifting of handmade objects and fixtures (such as decorative paneling or plasterwork) within the craft guilds, which were “composed of highly discerning producers and consumers of material cultures.” Given this characterization, it can reasonably be inferred that the gifting of such objects may have _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. ensured that knowledge of the materials and techniques used by members of the craft guilds stayed within the craft guilds.
- B. emphasized ostentatious offerings in the case of the largest guilds and prosaic objects in the case of the craft guilds.
- C. functioned as a way for craft guild members to maintain and enhance their professional reputations among their peers.
- D. conferred greater social status when the recipient belonged to one of London’s largest guilds than when the recipient belonged to a craft guild.

ID: 43499ccb Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it logically completes the text’s discussion of the role of gift giving among members of guilds in early modern London. According to the text, members of these guilds participated in a culture where giving gifts “both signaled and conferred social status”—that is, it indicated people’s social standing and also gave them social standing—and occurred in the forms of both philanthropic gifting (donations for humanitarian purposes) by large guilds, which much research has focused on, and the gifting of handmade items between craft guild members, which Kilburn-Toppin focuses on. The text indicates that Kilburn-Toppin characterizes craft guild members as people who made and consumed items and were “highly discerning,” or were careful judges of quality. Because gift giving benefited one’s status and if craft guild members were particularly attentive to quality, it follows that gifting handmade items within the guilds—between people who had high standards for items they made and for items they received—may have been a way for members to maintain and enhance their professional reputations, or their professional statuses, among their peers.

Choice A is incorrect because the text emphasizes the idea that members of guilds participated in gift giving both to display and receive social status, suggesting that the gifting of handmade items between the “highly discerning” members of craft guilds had to do with the members’ interest in quality and status; nothing in the text suggests that the practice of gifting those items within the craft guilds was intended to limit knowledge of materials and techniques to the members of those guilds. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t distinguish between “ostentatious,” or very showy, and “prosaic,” or ordinary, gifts and because the characterization at the end of the text pertains specifically to the gifting of handmade items indicative of great taste, not prosaic items, between members of craft guilds. And while the text indicates that London’s largest guilds gave philanthropic gifts

(donations for humanitarian purposes), it doesn't indicate whether these gifts would have been considered ostentatious. Choice D is incorrect because the characterization presented at the end of the text pertains specifically to the "highly discerning" members of craft guilds giving their handmade items as gifts to one another within the craft guilds; the text doesn't suggest anything about gifting those items to members of London's largest guilds or how that might affect status differently from giving them to other craft guild members.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID beb7b572

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: beb7b572

Archaeologist Weiwei Wang and her colleagues analyzed footed grinding slabs and other food-preparation tools excavated from Óc Eo, a Southeast Asian port city that flourished between the first and sixth centuries CE. Wang and colleagues recovered microscopic remnants of turmeric and other spices from the surfaces of the tools. Turmeric is native to South Asia, more than a thousand miles west of Óc Eo, and the researchers showed that the footed grinding slabs at Óc Eo are very similar to footed grinding slabs common throughout South Asia from around 500 BCE to 300 CE. Wang and colleagues’ findings therefore indicate that there must have been a trade link, whether direct or indirect, between the two regions.

- Which finding, if true, would directly weaken the conclusion about Wang and her colleagues’ findings that is presented in the text?
- A. Some of the spices recovered from Óc Eo are native to the Maluku Islands, which are located approximately 2,000 miles southeast of Óc Eo.
 - B. In the first through third centuries CE, there was a significant migration of people from South Asia to Southeast Asia.
 - C. Other types of artifacts originating in South Asia and dating to the first through sixth centuries CE have been found throughout Southeast Asia.
 - D. The people of Óc Eo and several communities in South Asia regularly traded with people in the region that is now the Southeast Asian country of Malaysia no later than the first century CE.

ID: beb7b572 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly weaken the conclusion that Wang and colleagues’ findings indicate a trade link between Óc Eo and South Asia. The text explains that turmeric (native to South Asia) and footed grinding slabs of a style common in South Asia between roughly 500 BCE and 300 CE were found at Óc Eo, a Southeast Asian port that flourished between the first and sixth centuries CE. From this evidence, the text concludes that these items must have reached Óc Eo through trade. If, however, there was a significant migration of people from South Asia to Southeast Asia during the first through third centuries CE, that would offer an alternative explanation: South Asian people could have brought turmeric and grinding slabs with them when they migrated. Thus, the finding would weaken the conclusion that trade must account for the items’ presence at Óc Eo.

Choice A is incorrect. A finding involving spices from a different region—the Maluku Islands, southeast of Óc Eo—wouldn’t undermine the conclusion because it wouldn’t reveal how the items from South Asia, a region to the west, reached Óc Eo. If anything, such a finding might be further evidence of broad trade networks involving Óc Eo. Choice C is incorrect. If it were true that other South Asian artifacts from the period when Óc Eo flourished have been found throughout Southeast Asia, that would suggest only that South Asian items other than turmeric and footed grinding slabs were present in the region at the time; it wouldn’t reveal anything about how any of those items reached Southeast Asia from South Asia. If anything, the widespread presence of South Asian artifacts in Southeast Asia during this period could be seen as further support for a trade network

connecting the regions. Choice D is incorrect because the finding that Óc Eo and some South Asian communities traded with people in another Southeast Asian location (what is now Malaysia) would suggest that this location could have been an intermediary for the movement of items from South Asia to Óc Eo. Such a finding would support, not weaken, the plausibility of an indirect trade link that's presented in the conclusion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c33f97c8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: c33f97c8

To better understand the burrowing habits of *Alpheus bellulus* (the tiger pistol shrimp), some studies have used resin casting to obtain precise measurements of the shrimps’ burrows. Resin casting involves completely filling an empty burrow with a liquid plastic that hardens to create a three-dimensional model; however, recovering the model inevitably requires destroying the burrow. In their 2022 study, Miyu Umehara and colleagues discovered that an x-ray computed tomography (CT) scanner can accurately record a burrow’s measurements both at a moment in time and throughout the entire burrow-building process, something that’s impossible with resin casting because _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. it can only be used on burrows below a certain size.
- B. it does not allow for multiple castings of the same burrow over time.
- C. the casting process takes more time than *A. bellulus* takes to construct a burrow.
- D. the process of recovering the model distorts the resin’s shape.

ID: c33f97c8 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Since resin casting “inevitably requires destroying the burrow,” it would be impossible to make multiple castings of the same burrow over time.

Choice A is incorrect. The passage doesn’t discuss size requirements for completing resin casting, so there’s no basis for this inference. Choice C is incorrect. The passage never mentions how long the casting process takes nor how long *A. bellulus* takes to construct a borrow, so there’s no basis for this inference. Choice D is incorrect. The passage never states that recovering the model distorts the resin’s shape, only that it destroys the burrow. Therefore, there’s no basis for this inference.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 03daf71e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 03daf71e

The following text is adapted from Guy de Maupassant’s nineteenth-century short story “The Trip of Le Horla” (translated by Albert M. C. McMaster, A. E. Henderson, Mme. Quesada, et al.). The narrator is part of a group traveling in a hot-air balloon at night.

The earth no longer seems to exist, it is buried in milky vapors that resemble a sea. We are now alone in space with the moon, which looks like another balloon travelling opposite us; and our balloon, which shines in the air, appears like another, larger moon, a world wandering in the sky amid the stars, through infinity. We no longer speak, think nor live; we float along through space in delicious inertia. The air which is bearing us up has made of us all beings which resemble itself, silent, joyous, irresponsible beings, peculiarly alert, although motionless.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. The narrator feels a growing sense of isolation even though his companions are nearby during the balloon ride.
- B. The narrator and his companions are completely absorbed in the change in perspective they gain while riding in the balloon.
- C. The narrator and his companions are troubled by the disorienting effects of the altitude while riding in the balloon.
- D. The narrator is pleasantly surprised by his companions’ unrestrained enthusiasm about the sensation of riding in the balloon.

ID: 03daf71e Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The narrator describes the view he and his companions have from the balloon: the earth lies beneath "milky vapors," and the balloon itself looks like another moon. The narrator goes on to explain how the people riding in the balloon are affected by the ride, explaining that they are immersed in the experience: floating along in "delicious inertia," or inactivity, like "silent, joyous, irresponsible beings." Thus, the main idea is that the narrator and his companions are completely absorbed in the change in perspective they gain while riding in the balloon.

Choice A is incorrect because the narrator never describes himself as feeling isolated from his companions; instead, he characterizes riding in the balloon as an experience he is sharing with them. And although he does imply a sense of isolation, it is isolation from those on the ground, as when he says of himself and his companions, "We are now alone." Choice C is incorrect because the narrator doesn't suggest that he or his companions are troubled by the effects of the balloon ride. Instead, he describes himself and his companions as "joyous" and the experience of floating in the balloon as "delicious." Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that the narrator is surprised by his companions’ response to the balloon ride. In fact, the text indicates that the narrator and his companions are having the same experience: they’re described as "silent" and "motionless," rather than as having unrestrained enthusiasm.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1354e284

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 1354e284

“Odalie” is an 1899 short story by Alice Dunbar-Nelson. In the story, a young woman named Odalie attends the annual Mardi Gras carnival in New Orleans, where she lives with her guardian Tante Louise. Dunbar-Nelson portrays Odalie as eager to escape the monotony of her everyday life: _____

Which quotation from “Odalie” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “Mardi Gras was a tiresome day, after all, she sighed, and Tante Louise agreed with her for once.”
- B. “In the old French house on Royal Street, with its quaint windows and Spanish courtyard green and cool, and made musical by the plashing of the fountain and the trill of caged birds, lived Odalie in convent-like seclusion.”
- C. “When one is shut up in a great French house with a grim sleepy tante and no companions of one’s own age, life becomes a dull thing, and one is ready for any new sensation.”
- D. “It was Mardi Gras day at last, and early through her window Odalie could hear the jingle of folly bells on the [participants’] costumes, the tinkle of music, and the echoing strains of songs.”

ID: 1354e284 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most effectively uses a quotation from “Odalie” to illustrate the claim that Odalie is eager to escape the monotony, or tedious lack of variety, of her everyday life. In the quotation, Odalie describes feeling “shut up” and complains that she has “no companions” except for her “sleepy tante.” Odalie goes on to say that, as a result, her life is “dull” and she is “ready for any new sensation,” meaning she wants a change. This suggests that Odalie wishes to get away from her monotonous everyday life.

Choice A is incorrect. Although this quotation includes the word “tiresome,” which means dull, it does so to suggest Odalie’s negative feelings about Mardi Gras, which is a once-a-year celebration, not her feelings about her everyday life. This quotation therefore doesn’t express that Odalie’s everyday life is monotonous or that she wishes to escape. Choice B is incorrect. Although this quotation ends by saying that Odalie lives in seclusion, or isolation, it doesn’t express that Odalie’s everyday life is monotonous or that she wishes to escape. Instead, it describes the pleasant qualities of the house Odalie lives in, saying that it has “quaint windows” and a “green and cool” courtyard that is “made musical” by the sounds of a fountain and pet birds. Choice D is incorrect because this quotation describes the lively sounds of a Mardi Gras celebration that Odalie hears through her window, not the monotony of Odalie’s everyday life or her wish to escape.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2a815356

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 2a815356

Modern dog breeds are largely the result of 160 years of owners crossbreeding certain dogs in order to select for particular physical appearances. Owners often say that some breeds are also more likely than others to have particular personality traits—basset hounds are affectionate; boxers are easy to train—but Kathleen Morrill and colleagues found through a combination of owner surveys and DNA sequencing of 2,000 dogs that while physical traits are predictably heritable among purebred dogs, behavior varies widely among dogs of the same breed.

- Which choice best states the main idea of the text?
- A. Dog breeds would not exist without many years of human intervention in dogs’ reproduction.
 - B. Research fails to confirm a commonly held belief about dog breeds and behavior.
 - C. The dog breeds most popular among owners have often changed over the past 160 years.
 - D. A study of dog breeds is notable for its usage of both opinion surveys and DNA sequencing.

ID: 2a815356 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text indicates that dog owners typically claim that some dog breeds are “more likely than others to have particular personality traits.” In other words, the text points out that a commonly held belief about dog breeds is that their personality traits are heritable. The text then states that Kathleen Morrill and colleagues undertook research about dog trait heritability and found that “behavior varies widely among dogs of the same breed.” Because Morrill and colleagues found evidence for variability rather than consistency in the behavior of dogs of the same breed, the statement that research fails to uphold a commonly held belief about dog breeds and behavior accurately reflects the main idea of the text.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text mentions that humans have long intervened in dogs’ reproduction by intentionally crossbreeding certain dogs, it doesn’t argue that such intervention is essential to the existence of dog breeds. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss the popularity of any dog breeds; breeds are mentioned as having certain traits, but the text says nothing about the popularity of these breeds or traits. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text briefly mentions that Morrill and colleagues conducted a study about dog traits using both surveys and DNA sequencing, this is not the main focus of the text. The text concerns the study’s results about the heritability of dog traits, not the particular methodology used by Morrill and colleagues.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID db71aeaa

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: db71aeaa

Ablation Rates for Three Elements in Cosmic Dust, by Dust Source

Element	SPC	AST	HTC	OCC
iron	20%	28%	90%	98%
potassium	44%	74%	97%	100%
sodium	45%	75%	99%	100%

Earth’s atmosphere is bombarded by cosmic dust originating from several sources: short-period comets (SPCs), particles from the asteroid belt (ASTs), Halley-type comets (HTCs), and Oort cloud comets (OCCs). Some of the dust’s material vaporizes in the atmosphere in a process called ablation, and the faster the particles move, the higher the rate of ablation. Astrophysicist Juan Diego Carrillo-Sánchez led a team that calculated average ablation rates for elements in the dust (such as iron and potassium) and showed that material in slower-moving SPC or AST dust has a lower rate than the same material in faster-moving HTC or OCC dust. For example, whereas the average ablation rate for iron from AST dust is 28%, the average rate for _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the example?

- A. iron from SPC dust is 20%.
- B. sodium from OCC dust is 100%.
- C. iron from HTC dust is 90%.
- D. sodium from AST dust is 75%.

ID: db71aeaa Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most effectively completes the example regarding the ablation rate of iron. The table shows the ablation rates for three elements—iron, potassium, and sodium—found in cosmic dust that comes from one of four sources. The text says that the ablation rate for a given element in slower-moving SPC and AST dust was lower than the ablation rate for that same element in faster-moving HTC or OCC dust. The text then presents the first part of an example of this pattern, describing an ablation rate of 28% for iron in AST dust. The information that iron from HTC dust had an ablation rate of 90% is therefore the most effective way to complete this example—the comparison of a relatively low ablation rate for iron in slower-moving AST dust with a relatively high ablation rate for iron in faster-moving HTC dust illustrates the tendency of ablation rates for a given element to be lower in slower-moving dust than in faster-moving dust.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that SPC dust, like AST dust, moves relatively slowly; a comparison of the ablation rates of iron from two slower-moving dust sources could not be an example of the difference between ablation rates in slower-

moving dust and faster-moving dust, which is the pattern that the example is supposed to illustrate. Choice B is incorrect because the example in the text is supposed to illustrate the difference in the ablation rates of the same element from slower-moving dust and faster-moving dust, and the first part of the example provides data about the ablation rate of iron, which means the second part of the example must also be about the ablation rate of iron, not the ablation rate of sodium. Choice D is incorrect because the example in the text is supposed to illustrate the difference in the ablation rates of the same element from slower-moving dust and faster-moving dust, and the first part of the example provides data about the ablation rate of iron, which means the second part of the example must also be about the ablation rate of iron, not the ablation rate of sodium. Additionally, any ablation rate from AST dust would be ineffective in this example since AST dust is referenced in the first part of the example and thus additional data focused on AST dust would not illustrate a variation across dust types.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ecae61a0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: ecae61a0

The Uto-Aztecan language family is divided into a northern branch, which includes the Shoshone language of present-day Idaho and Utah, and a southern one, whose best-known representative is Nahuatl, the language of the Aztec Empire in Mexico. Lexical similarities across the family, including of botanical terms, confirm descent from a single language spoken millennia ago, and the family’s geographical distribution suggests an origin in what is now the US Southwest. However, vocabulary pertaining to maize isn’t shared between northern and southern branches, despite the crop’s universal cultivation among Uto-Aztecan tribes. Given archaeological evidence that maize originated in Mexico and diffused northward into what became the US Southwest, some linguists reason that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. northern Uto-Aztecan tribes likely obtained the crop directly from a southern Uto-Aztecan tribe rather than from a non-Uto-Aztecan tribe.
- B. variation in maize-related vocabulary within each branch of the Uto-Aztecan family likely reflects regionally specific methods for cultivating the crop.
- C. southern Uto-Aztecan tribes likely acquired maize at roughly the same time as northern Uto-Aztecan tribes did, though from different sources.
- D. the family’s division into northern and southern branches likely preceded the acquisition of the crop by the Uto-Aztecan tribes.

ID: ecae61a0 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the discussion of Uto-Aztecan languages. The text explains that the northern and southern branches of the Uto-Aztecan language family descended from a single language (believed to have originated in what is now the US Southwest), resulting in similarities across the family’s languages; however, the branches don’t have similar vocabulary for maize, even though maize has been cultivated by all Uto-Aztecan tribes. The text also indicates that maize originated in Mexico and spread northward into what is now the US Southwest—the area where the Uto-Aztecan language family originated. It follows, then, that the language family had already divided into northern and southern branches before maize reached that area; if maize had been present before the division occurred, the family’s origin language would have had terminology for it that likely would have been reflected in the branches, meaning they would have had similar vocabulary for maize. If maize arrived after the division occurred, however, the tribes in the two regions likely would have developed vocabulary pertaining to maize separately, at the times when they acquired the crop.

Choice A is incorrect because the text focuses on vocabulary pertaining to maize in the branches of the Uto-Aztecan language family, and referring only to how some Uto-Aztecan tribes obtained maize wouldn’t directly address the role of language. Moreover, if northern Uto-Aztecan tribes had acquired maize from a southern Uto-Aztecan tribe, it’s reasonable to assume that the northern tribes might have also picked up southern Uto-Aztecan terminology for maize in that exchange. Choice B is incorrect

because the text discusses the fact that the northern and southern branches of the Uto-Aztecan language family don't have shared vocabulary pertaining to maize, not the idea that there are variations in such vocabulary within each branch—that is, the text focuses on differences between the two branches, not on differences between languages within a branch. Choice C is incorrect because the text focuses on vocabulary pertaining to maize in the branches of the Uto-Aztecan language family, and referring only to the timing and source of maize acquisition wouldn't directly address the role of language. Furthermore, the text implies that southern Uto-Aztecan tribes probably acquired maize before the northern tribes did, given the evidence that maize originated in Mexico—the location of the best-known representative of the southern branch of the Uto-Aztecan language family—before spreading to the north.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bf7613c5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: bf7613c5

King Lear is a circa 1606 play by William Shakespeare. In the play, the character of King Lear attempts to test his three daughters' devotion to him. He later expresses regret for his actions, as is evident when he _____

Which choice most effectively uses a quotation from *King Lear* to illustrate the claim?

- A. says of himself, "I am a man / more sinned against than sinning."
- B. says during a growing storm, "This tempest will not give me leave to ponder / On things would hurt me more."
- C. says to himself while striking his head, "Beat at this gate that let thy folly in / And thy dear judgement out!"
- D. says of himself, "I will do such things— / What they are yet, I know not; but they shall be / The terrors of the earth!"

ID: bf7613c5 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most effectively uses a quotation from *King Lear* to illustrate the claim that King Lear expresses regret for his actions. In the quotation, Lear describes striking himself on the head—the same act he’s engaged in as he speaks, and one that suggests he’s deeply upset with himself. Referring to himself in the second person (with “thy”), the character exclaims “Beat at this gate that let thy folly in / And thy dear judgement out!” Lear refers metaphorically to his own mind as a gate that has allowed folly, or poor judgement, to enter and good judgement to escape. This suggests that Lear regrets his attempts to test his three daughters’ devotion to him, regarding those attempts as examples of the folly that has entered the gate of his mind.

Choice A is incorrect because this quotation doesn’t express King Lear’s sense of regret over his own actions; instead, it expresses his belief that the harm that others have done to him (or the extent to which they have “sinned against” him) outweighs whatever harm he himself has caused by “sinning.” Choice B is incorrect because this quotation doesn’t express King Lear’s sense of regret over his own actions; instead, it expresses his thoughts about an approaching storm (“this tempest”), which he believes “will not give [him] leave to ponder,” or time to consider, the harm that he will continue to experience (“things” that “would hurt [him] more”). Choice D is incorrect because this quotation expresses King Lear’s vow to commit terrible actions (or “things” that “shall be / The terrors of the earth”) in the future, not his regret over actions that he’s already taken.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID abb7137f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: abb7137f

Volunteering, or giving time for a community service for free, is a valuable form of civic engagement because helping in a community is also good for society as a whole. In a survey of youths in the United States, most young people said that they believe volunteering is a way to help people on an individual level. Meanwhile, only 6% of the youths said that they think volunteering is a way to help fix problems in society overall. These replies suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. many young people think they can volunteer only within their own communities.
- B. volunteering may be even more helpful than many young people think it is.
- C. volunteering can help society overall more than it can help individual people.
- D. many young people may not know how to find ways to volunteer their time.

ID: abb7137f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of volunteering. The text asserts that volunteering benefits both the community in which one volunteers and society as a whole. It then states that in a survey of young people, a majority of respondents said that volunteering helps individuals, but only 6% of respondents said that volunteering helps society as a whole. If volunteering does in fact help society as a whole, as the text says, but only 6% of young people believe it does, then it’s reasonable to conclude that volunteering is more helpful than many young people think it is.

Choice A is incorrect because the text discusses young people’s beliefs about the benefits of volunteering, not where young people believe they are able to volunteer. Nothing in the text suggests that many young people believe they are only able to volunteer in their own communities. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text indicates that volunteering is beneficial for society as a whole, nothing in the text suggests that volunteering can benefit society more than it can benefit individual people. The text doesn’t compare the benefits to society with the benefits to individuals. Choice D is incorrect because the text discusses young people’s beliefs about the benefits of volunteering, not how to find volunteering opportunities. There’s nothing in the text to suggest that many young people don’t know how to volunteer.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 38000731

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 38000731

Many mosquito repellents contain natural components that work by activating multiple odor receptors on mosquitoes’ antennae. As the insects develop resistance, new repellents are needed. Ke Dong and her team found that EBF, a molecular component of a chrysanthemum-flower extract, can repel mosquitoes by activating just one odor receptor—and this receptor, Or31, is present in all mosquito species known to carry diseases. Therefore, the researchers suggest that in developing new repellents, it would be most useful to _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. identify molecular components similar to EBF that target the activation of Or31 receptors.
- B. investigate alternative methods for extracting EBF molecules from chrysanthemums.
- C. verify the precise locations of Or31 and other odor receptors on mosquitoes’ antennae.
- D. determine the maximum number of different odor receptors that can be activated by a single molecule.

ID: 38000731 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of mosquito repellents. The text begins by explaining that many repellents work by using natural components to activate multiple odor receptors on mosquitoes’ antennae, and that new repellents must be created whenever mosquitoes become resistant to older ones. The text then highlights a research team’s discovery that EBF, a molecular component of a chrysanthemum-flower extract, can repel mosquitoes by activating a single odor receptor, Or31, that is shared by all species of mosquitoes known to carry diseases. The text suggests that compared to the repellents mentioned earlier, a repellent that acts on the Or31 receptor would be more effective: by noting that all mosquito species known to carry diseases share the Or31 receptor, the text suggests that the Or31 receptor may be unique in this respect, meaning that a repellent such as EBF that acts on it would be more effective since it works on a single receptor shared by all mosquito species that carry diseases, rather than a combination of receptors that is not shared by all species. Once mosquitoes become resistant to EBF, it would therefore make sense for researchers to look for other molecular components similar to EBF that target the activation of Or31 receptors, since a single such component could also repel all disease-carrying mosquitoes.

Choice B is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that EBF molecules are difficult to extract from chrysanthemums and that investigating alternative extraction methods would therefore be useful for developing efficient and effective mosquito repellents. Rather, the text suggests that researchers developing new mosquito repellents should aim to identify molecular components similar to EBF, since that component targets the Or31 odor receptor shared by all species of mosquitoes known to carry diseases. Choice C is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that researchers are unaware of the precise location of Or31 and other odor receptors in mosquitoes’ antennae or that knowing this information would be useful for developing efficient and effective mosquito repellents. Rather, the text suggests that researchers developing new mosquito repellents should aim to

identify molecular components similar to EBF, which targets the Or31 odor receptor. Choice D is incorrect because it doesn't logically follow that the discovery of one odor receptor shared by all disease-bearing mosquitoes should lead to further research into which repellents might activate the greatest number of odor receptors. Rather, the text suggests that researchers developing new mosquito repellents should instead search for additional molecular components that, like EBF, activate the one odor receptor that is known to be shared by all disease-bearing mosquitoes.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 835c61ef

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 835c61ef

Data Sources for Neptune Temperature Analysis

Instrument	Observatory	Data type	Observation years
TEXES (Texas Echelon Cross Echelle Spectrograph)	Gemini Observatory	spectroscopy	2007, 2019
T-ReCS (Thermal-Region Camera Spectrograph)	Gemini Observatory	infrared imaging	2007, 2010
LWS (Long Wavelength Spectrometer)	Keck Observatory	infrared imaging	2003
VISIR (VLT Imager and Spectrometer for mid-InfraRed)	European Southern Observatory	spectroscopy	2006

Julianne I. Moses and colleagues have reported that Neptune may have cooled significantly between 2003 and 2020. The team reached this conclusion by analyzing existing infrared imaging and spectroscopy data about the planet obtained from various instruments in different years. Of the team’s sources listed in the table, the earliest example of spectroscopy data included in the analysis was obtained in _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the text?

- A. 2007 using TEXES at the Gemini Observatory.
- B. 2007 using T-ReCS at the Gemini Observatory.
- C. 2006 using VISIR at the European Southern Observatory.
- D. 2003 using LWS at the W.M. Keck Observatory.

ID: 835c61ef Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it effectively completes the text’s discussion of Moses and colleagues’ analysis of changes in Neptune’s temperature by using data from the table to identify the source of the earliest example of spectroscopy data included in this analysis. The text indicates that Moses and colleagues analyzed infrared imaging and spectroscopy data about Neptune obtained in different years by various instruments. The table lists the observatories where these instruments are housed, the type of data each instrument collected (infrared imaging or spectroscopy), and the years in which the instruments’ observations were made. According to the table, only two of these instruments obtained spectroscopy data: VISIR at the European Southern Observatory, which made its observations in 2006, and TEXES at the Gemini Observatory, which made its observations in later years (2007 and 2019). Although two other instruments are also included in the table, they obtained infrared imaging data, not spectroscopy data. Therefore, the earliest example of spectroscopy data included in the researchers’ analysis is the data obtained by VISIR at the European Southern Observatory in 2006.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the table indicates that TEXES at the Gemini Observatory collected spectroscopy data in 2007 and 2019, the table also indicates that this type of data was collected in 2006 by VISIR at the European Southern Observatory. Because the VISIR data were collected in the previous year, the data obtained in 2007 by TEXES are not the earliest example of spectroscopy data included in Moses and team’s analysis of Neptune’s temperature. Choice B is incorrect because the table indicates that T-ReCS at the Gemini Observatory collected infrared imaging data, not spectroscopy data. T-ReCS therefore cannot be the source of the earliest example of spectroscopy data that is included in Moses and colleagues’ analysis of Neptune’s temperature. Additionally, the T-ReCS data were collected in 2007, meaning that these data were obtained later than any type of data collected in 2006. Choice D is incorrect. Although the table indicates that data from LWS at the W.M. Keck Observatory were obtained in 2003, making these data the earliest example of any type of data included in the analysis, the table also indicates that LWS collected infrared imaging data, not spectroscopy data. LWS therefore cannot be the source of the earliest example of spectroscopy data included in Moses and team’s analysis of Neptune’s temperature.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ed3c9318

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: ed3c9318

Ana Castillo’s 1986 novel *The Mixquiahuala Letters* is a story told entirely through expressive letters from the narrator to her friend—letters that Castillo suggests could be read in several different orders. As they began reading it in class, some students remarked that they found the novel’s letter format daunting and its treatment of gender relations old-fashioned. The professor, however, pointed out that the novel is written in modern-sounding language and addresses issues that still matter today, suggesting that *The Mixquiahuala Letters* _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. has more to say about gender relations than other novels from the same period.
- B. is more relevant to contemporary audiences than it may seem at first.
- C. is easier to read than many contemporary novels that focus on friendship.
- D. is best understood after multiple readings in different orders.

ID: ed3c9318 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Ana Castillo’s 1986 novel *The Mixquiahuala Letters*. The text states that the novel consists entirely of letters from the narrator to her friend—a format that some students reading the novel in a class found intimidating. According to the text, those students also found the novel’s treatment of gender to be old-fashioned. In response to the students’ concerns, their professor emphasized the novel’s relevance: it’s written in modern-sounding language and addresses issues that still matter. This, in turn, suggests that *The Mixquiahuala Letters* is more relevant to contemporary audiences than it may initially seem.

Choice A is incorrect because the professor’s response to the students only mentions *The Mixquiahuala Letters*: it doesn’t compare the novel to others from the same period. Choice C is incorrect because nothing in the professor’s response to the students compares *The Mixquiahuala Letters* to contemporary novels about friendship. Choice D is incorrect because the professor’s response to the students doesn’t address the idea of reading the novel’s letters multiple times and in different orders.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID acdd0ba5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: acdd0ba5

The alpaca was domesticated by Indigenous peoples in the Andes about 7,000 years ago. But which wild species did it descend from, the vicuña or guanaco? A research team led by Ruiwen Fan may have solved the mystery, concluding that the alpaca is the domesticated form of the vicuña but that the modern alpaca gets only 64 percent of its genetic material from its wild ancestor. The rest comes from the domesticated llama. The llama, meanwhile, gets 95.5 percent of its genetic material from its own wild ancestor, the guanaco, and the rest from the alpaca. The llama and alpaca apparently interbred widely for only a handful of generations between 400 and 600 years ago. Assuming that the findings of Fan’s team are valid, it can be inferred that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. modern llama populations have a greater degree of genetic diversity, on average, than modern alpaca populations do.
- B. the domestication process of the alpaca may have involved some introduction of genetic material from the llama.
- C. the period of interbreeding resulted in a greater genetic difference between alpacas and their wild ancestors than between llamas and their wild ancestors.
- D. if they were subjected to genetic testing, modern populations of guanacos and vicuñas would likely show traces of ancient interbreeding as well.

ID: acdd0ba5 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents the inference that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of the genetic material of alpacas. The text states that modern alpacas get only 64 percent of their genetic material from their wild ancestor (the vicuña), while llamas get 95.5 percent of their genetic material from their wild ancestor (the guanaco). These data imply that relative to llamas, alpacas have experienced a much greater genetic shift away from their wild ancestors (36 percent of their genetic material derives from another source, compared to 4.5 percent of llamas’ genetic material). Moreover, the text establishes that the remainder of alpacas’ genetic material derives from llamas, and the remainder of llamas’ genetic material derives from alpacas, reflecting a period of interbreeding. Taken together, these details support the inference that the period of interbreeding had a more significant impact on the genetic material of alpacas than on that of llamas, thereby reducing the percentage of alpacas’ genetic material that derives from wild ancestors and placing alpacas at a greater remove from these ancestors.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t provide information about genetic diversity within modern llama and alpaca populations. While the text discusses the percentage of genetic material each domesticated species inherited from its wild ancestor and from interbreeding, it does not address the level of genetic variation within each species. Therefore, it isn’t logical to infer that modern llama populations have a greater degree of genetic diversity than modern alpaca populations do. Choice B is incorrect because it contradicts the chronology presented in the text. The text states that alpacas were domesticated about 7,000 years ago, but the interbreeding with llamas occurred "between 400 and 600 years ago." The genetic mixing happened thousands of years after domestication, not during it; in addition, the text does not provide details about what the process of domestication

might entail. Therefore, it isn't logical to infer that llama genetic material was introduced during the domestication process of alpacas. Choice D is incorrect because though the text notes that guanacos and vicuñas contributed to the genetic material of alpacas and llamas, it only discusses alpacas' and llamas' genetic composition. Therefore, the text does not support the inference that modern populations of guanacos and vicuñas would likely show traces of ancient interbreeding.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fd102528

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: fd102528

Paleontologist Lucas E. Fiorelli and colleagues have reported the discovery at a mine in Brazil of several egg clutches, partially preserved single eggs, and egg shells from the Late Cretaceous period. The researchers have concluded that the area was once a nesting and breeding site for titanosaurs, a group of sauropod dinosaurs. The finding is significant given the previous lack of known nesting sites in northern regions of South America, which led many paleontologists to assume that titanosaurs migrated south to lay eggs.

What does the text most strongly suggest about the site discovered by the researchers?

- A. It is the earliest known example of a titanosaur nesting and breeding site.
- B. It was very difficult to excavate given that it was discovered in a mine.
- C. It may have been occupied by other sauropods in addition to titanosaurs.
- D. It is farther north than any other nesting site discovered in South America.

ID: fd102528 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a statement about the site discovered by the researchers that is supported by the text. The text discusses Fiorelli and colleagues’ discovery of egg clutches, single eggs, and eggshells in a Brazilian mine. According to the text, the presence of these eggs, which are from the Late Cretaceous period, led the researchers to conclude that the location was once a nesting and breeding site for titanosaurs. The text then explains that the finding is important because of the “previous lack of known nesting sites in northern regions of South America.” If there haven’t been any other discoveries of a nesting site in South America’s northern regions and the site in the Brazilian mine is the first, then the text strongly suggests that the site is farther north than other nesting sites that have been discovered in South America.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the site discovered by Fiorelli and colleagues is the earliest titanosaur nesting and breeding site known to paleontologists but rather that it’s the first nesting site found in northern regions of South America. Moreover, the text doesn’t suggest how the timeline of the newly discovered site compares with that of other titanosaur nesting and breeding sites. Choice B is incorrect because there is no mention in the text about any difficulties that Fiorelli and colleagues faced when they were excavating the nesting and breeding site in the Brazilian mine. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t support the idea that the nesting and breeding site in the Brazilian mine was occupied by sauropods other than titanosaurs. The text simply mentions that titanosaurs are sauropod dinosaurs and presents the researchers’ conclusion that the site they discovered was for titanosaurs.

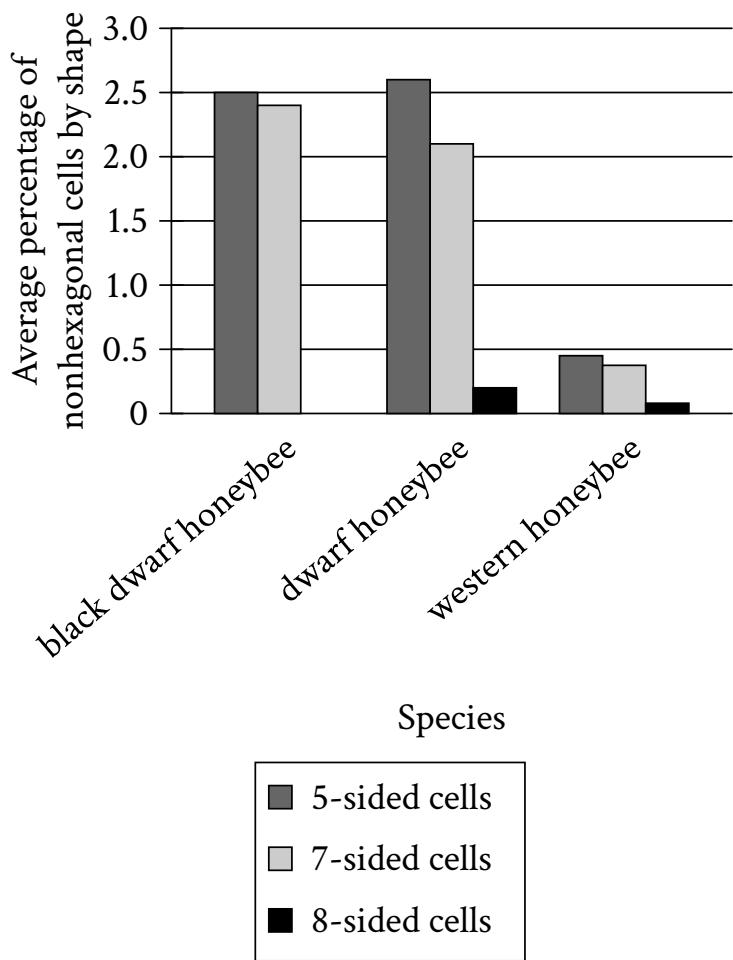
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dced0ae6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: dced0ae6

Percentage of Nonhexagonal Cells in Hives of Three Honeybee Species



Honeybee hives consist mainly of hexagonal (six-sided) units called cells, in which queens lay eggs. Hexagonal cells for eggs that develop into nonreproductive workers are smaller than those for eggs that develop into reproductive drones, though the size difference varies by species. Difference in cell size results in a construction problem—it’s hard to neatly connect sections of small cells to sections of large cells—that worsens as the difference increases. To fill in gaps between the sections when building a hive, bees rely on cells that have more or fewer than six sides. A student studying beehive structure consults data on three species, concluding that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the student’s conclusion?

- A. cells for worker eggs are probably closer in size to cells for drone eggs in the hives of the western honeybee than in the hives of the dwarf honeybee and the black dwarf honeybee.

- B. both the western honeybee and the black dwarf honeybee probably reserve eight-sided cells for drone eggs, while the dwarf honeybee likely deposits drone eggs in seven-sided cells.
- C. the western honeybee probably relies on many more geometrical shapes when constructing cells than either the dwarf honeybee or the black dwarf honeybee does.
- D. the percentage of hexagonal cells is probably slightly lower in the hives of the western honeybee than in the hives of the dwarf honeybee and the black dwarf honeybee.

ID: dced0ae6 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the student's conclusion about beehive structure. The text explains that in the hives of honeybees, the hexagonal cells housing drone eggs are larger than the hexagonal cells housing worker eggs, and that this size difference results in a construction problem that the bees address by using nonhexagonal cells to fill gaps between sections of drone-egg cells and worker-egg cells. The text also states that the size difference between drone-egg cells and worker-egg cells varies by species of honeybee. The graph displays data on the percentage of nonhexagonal cells in the hives of three species. In the hives of the western honeybee, the percentages of five-sided, seven-sided, and eight-sided cells are all less than 0.5%. But in the hives of the black dwarf honeybee, the percentages of five-sided and seven-sided cells are higher than those for the western honeybee: about 2.5% for both. And for the dwarf honeybee, the percentages of five-sided and seven-sided cells are also higher than those for the western honeybee: slightly over 2.5% and slightly over 2.0%, respectively; additionally, the dwarf honeybee possesses a higher percentage of eight-sided cells than the western honeybee does. Taken altogether, the graph shows that the hives of the western honeybee consist of a smaller percentage of nonhexagonal cells than the hives of the two other species do. Since the nonhexagonal cells exist only to solve the construction problem arising from the difference in size between drone-egg cells and worker-egg cells, a smaller percentage of nonhexagonal cells would be associated with a smaller size difference between the two types of cells. Therefore, it can be concluded from the data that worker-egg cells are probably closer in size to drone-egg cells in the hives of the western honeybee than in the hives of the other two species.

Choice B is incorrect because, as the text states, honeybee species deposit their eggs in hexagonal cells, not in nonhexagonal ones. Thus, the western honeybee and black dwarf honeybee wouldn't deposit drone eggs in eight-sided cells, and the dwarf honeybee wouldn't deposit drone eggs in seven-sided cells. Choice C is incorrect. The text explains that honeybees rely mainly on one geometric shape, the hexagon, when constructing their hives, and the graph shows that the western honeybee relies on the same nonhexagonal shapes as the dwarf honeybee does: five-sided, seven-sided, and eight-sided cells. In other words, the western honeybee and dwarf honeybee rely on the same number of geometric shapes. For the black dwarf honeybee, the graph displays data only for five-sided and seven-sided cells, which suggests a total absence of eight-sided cells. Yet this would be only one less nonhexagonal shape than is seen in the western honeybee. Thus, based on the graph, it would be inaccurate to say that the western honeybee relies on "many more" geometrical shapes than the other two species do. Choice D is incorrect. As the text explains, honeybee hives consist mainly of hexagonal cells, and sections of nonhexagonal cells are used to connect sections of hexagonal cells of different sizes. Since the graph indicates that the percentage of nonhexagonal cells is lower for the western honeybee than it is for the dwarf honeybee or black dwarf honeybee, the western honeybee would conversely have a *higher* percentage of hexagonal cells than the either the dwarf honeybee or black dwarf honeybee does, not a lower percentage.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 850e1b97

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 850e1b97

Silicon-based photovoltaic cells account for 95% of the cells used in solar panels worldwide despite converting an average of only 18–22% of the sunlight that reaches them. In a study addressing this relative inefficiency, a team led by Laura Miranda-Pérez demonstrated that the addition of a thin layer of the mineral perovskite—which captures the blue range of light in the solar spectrum, whereas silicon captures the red range—allows the cells to convert 29.5% or more of the Sun’s energy into usable electricity. Cells made with only perovskite, however, are no more efficient than silicon-based ones. It’s reasonable to conclude, then, that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. photovoltaic cells with both silicon and perovskite are more efficient because they make use of more of the solar spectrum.
- B. photovoltaic cells with only perovskite and no silicon would likely convert more than 29.5% of the Sun’s energy.
- C. solar power will remain elusive until photovoltaic cells are replaced with a more practical technology.
- D. researchers need to evaluate whether other minerals like perovskite are as effective as perovskite seems to be.

ID: 850e1b97 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically completes the text’s discussion of the efficiency of various photovoltaic cells. The text indicates that Miranda-Pérez and her team found that adding a layer of perovskite to silicon-based cells increased the percentage of sunlight converted to usable electricity relative to the percentage converted to electricity by silicon-based cells. Using cells with only perovskite and no silicon, however, resulted in no improvement in efficiency over silicon-based cells. The text also states that perovskite captures light in the blue range of the solar spectrum and silicon captures light in the red range of the spectrum. If perovskite and silicon capture different parts of the solar spectrum and the combination of perovskite and silicon results in greater efficiency than the use of either perovskite or silicon alone does, then it is reasonable to infer that the improved efficiency of perovskite-silicon cells could be attributable to their making use of more of the solar spectrum than perovskite-based or silicon-based cells do.

Choice B is incorrect because it is directly contradicted by the text, which says that silicon-based cells convert 18%–22% of the sunlight that reaches them to electricity and that cells with only perovskite are no more efficient than silicon-based cells are. Perovskite-only cells thus must convert 22% or less—not more than 29.5%—of the sunlight that reaches them to electricity. Choice C is incorrect because the text focuses on a possible improvement to photovoltaic cells and makes no mention of any alternatives to those cells, so there is no reason to conclude that photovoltaic cells must be replaced with some other technology. Additionally, the text presents solar power as something that currently exists, so it wouldn’t make sense to conclude that solar power will remain elusive. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that there is a need to evaluate the effectiveness of other minerals than perovskite. In fact, the text gives no indication that it is even possible to use other minerals

than silicon and perovskite in photovoltaic cells. Instead, the text is focused on the effect of combining perovskite and silicon and the different parts of the solar spectrum that perovskite and silicon capture.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ea240782

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: ea240782

Neural networks are computer models intended to reflect the organization of human brains and are often used in studies of brain function. According to an analysis of 11,000 such networks, Rylan Schaeffer and colleagues advise caution when drawing conclusions about brains from observations of neural networks. They found that when attempting to mimic grid cells (brain cells used in navigation), while 90% of the networks could accomplish navigation-related tasks, only about 10% of those exhibited any behaviors similar to those of grid cells. But even this approximation of grid-cell activity has less to do with similarity between the neural networks and biological brains than it does with the rules programmed into the networks.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the claim in the underlined sentence?

- A. The rules that allow for networks to exhibit behaviors like those of grid cells have no equivalent in the function of biological brains.
- B. The networks that do not exhibit behaviors like those of grid cells were nonetheless programmed with rules that had proven useful in earlier neural-network studies.
- C. Neural networks can often accomplish tasks that biological brains do, but they are typically programmed with rules to model multiple types of brain cells simultaneously.
- D. Once a neural network is programmed, it is trained on certain tasks to see if it can independently arrive at processes that are similar to those performed by biological brains.

ID: ea240782 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. While many networks can perform navigation tasks, or even mimic grid cells, it doesn't mean they're actually behaving like biological brains—this finding suggests that the rules that govern neural network behavior are completely unlike the way real brains work.

Choice B is incorrect. Although it mentions the rules that are programmed into the networks, this finding wouldn't clarify whether or not these rules have anything to do with the function of biological brains. Choice C is incorrect. This choice suggests that neural networks are modeled after multiple types of brain cells, which sidesteps the question of whether these rule-based networks are genuinely similar to biological brains. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn't address the key point of the claim, which is that the apparent similarity between neural networks and biological brains is only due to the rules programmed into the networks. It focuses on training tasks, not the originally programmed rules.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e1ea3484

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: e1ea3484

Tadpole Body Mass and Toxin Production after Three Weeks in Ponds

Population density	Average tadpole body mass (milligrams)	Average number of distinct bufadienolide toxins per tadpole	Average amount of bufadienolide per tadpole (nanograms)	Average bufadienolide concentration (nanograms per milligram of tadpole body mass)
High	193.87	22.69	5,815.51	374.22
Medium	254.56	21.65	5,525.72	230.10
Low	258.97	22.08	4,664.99	171.43

Ecologist Veronika Bókony and colleagues investigated within-species competition among common toads (*Bufo bufo*), a species that secretes various unpleasant-tasting toxins called bufadienolides in response to threats. The researchers tested *B. bufo* tadpoles’ responses to different levels of competition by creating ponds with different tadpole population densities but a fixed amount of food. Based on analysis of the tadpoles after three weeks, the researchers concluded that increased competition drove bufadienolide production at the expense of growth.

Which choice uses data from the table to most effectively support the researchers’ conclusion?

- A. The difference in average tadpole body mass was small between the low and medium population density conditions and substantially larger between the low and high population density conditions.
- B. Tadpoles in the low and medium population density conditions had substantially lower average bufadienolide concentrations but had greater average body masses than those in the high population density condition.
- C. Tadpoles in the high population density condition displayed a relatively modest increase in the average amount of bufadienolide but roughly double the average bufadienolide concentration compared to those in the low population density condition.
- D. Tadpoles produced approximately the same number of different bufadienolide toxins per individual across the population density conditions, but average tadpole body mass decreased as population density increased.

ID: e1ea3484 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. This data shows that the tadpoles in the high-density pond (meaning those with the most competition) didn’t grow as big as the other two groups but produced more bufadienolide.

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t fully support the conclusion. It doesn’t include any data about bufadienolide production. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t fully support the conclusion. It doesn’t include any data about growth. Choice D is incorrect. This

doesn't fully support the conclusion. It doesn't demonstrate that the tadpoles in the high-density pond produced more bufadienolide overall. The fact that they didn't produce more kinds of bufadienolide isn't relevant to the conclusion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID faea1302

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: faea1302

Elizabeth Asiedu has identified a negative correlation between the share of developing countries’ economies derived from natural-resource extraction and those countries’ receipts of foreign investment. This may appear counterintuitive—resource extraction requires initial investments (in extractive technology, for instance) at scales best met by multinational corporations—but Asiedu notes that natural-resource industries’ boom-bust cycle can destabilize local currencies and increase developing countries’ vulnerability to external shocks, creating levels of uncertainty to which foreign investors are typically averse.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Although it may seem surprising that foreign investment declines in developing countries as natural-resource extraction makes up a larger share of those countries’ economies, that decline happens because resource extraction requires initial investments too large for foreign investors to supply.
- B. Although developing countries tend to become less dependent on foreign investment as natural-resource industries make up a larger share of their economies, this change may not occur if the boom-bust cycle of those industries destabilizes local currencies or increases countries’ vulnerability to external shocks.
- C. Although one might expect that foreign investment would increase as natural-resource extraction makes up a larger share of developing countries’ economies, the opposite happens because heavy reliance on natural resources can lead to unattractive conditions for investors.
- D. Although foreign investors tend to avoid initial investments in natural-resource industries in developing countries, foreign investment may increase significantly as those industries stabilize and the risks associated with them decline.

ID: faea1302 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it accurately states the main idea of the text. According to the text, contrary to what some might expect, foreign investment is typically lower in developing countries whose economies are more dependent on natural-resource extraction. The text explains that high reliance on natural-resource extraction can subject a developing country to economic shocks that can destabilize the local currency and introduce economic uncertainty that tends to keep investors away. In other words, although we may think otherwise, foreign investors are less willing to invest in projects in developing countries whose economies are heavily dependent on natural-resource extraction because those economies tend to exhibit instability that investors want to avoid.

Choice A is incorrect. The text does indicate that foreign investment is typically lower in developing countries whose economies are more dependent on natural-resource extraction; the text further indicates that natural-resource extraction requires substantial initial investments (to acquire things like required technologies) for which there are fewer investors willing to participate at this stage than one might think. But the text does not implicate the cost of these initial investments as a reason why foreign investment is less widely available than some might think. Choice B is incorrect. The text indicates that greater dependence on

natural-resource extraction makes a developing country less appealing to foreign investors because of associated economic instability. Rather than arguing that the goal of developing countries is to become less dependent on foreign investment, as the phrasing of choice B suggests, the text focuses only on why foreign investors become less involved with such countries, which suggests that more investment would be preferable. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text indicates that natural-resource extraction requires substantial initial investments (to acquire things like required technologies) and that there are fewer likely investors willing to participate at this stage than one might think, the text does not address what investors are likely to do over time as the industry stabilizes itself.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 45985f7e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 45985f7e

Declining fishing technology costs and overexploitation of near-shore fishing grounds have made isolated oceanic reefs, which often lack regulatory protections, increasingly attractive to commercial and sport fishers. A team led by Octavio Aburto-Oropeza surveyed the biomass density and species composition of two isolated reefs: Alacranes, a protected (fishing prohibited) reef 135 kilometers from the Yucatan Peninsula, and Bajos del Norte, an unprotected reef 25 kilometers farther out to sea. Species at the highest level of the trophic pyramid constituted 34% of the biomass at Alacranes and 10% of the biomass at Bajos del Norte. Aburto-Oropeza and colleagues attribute this difference to the two reefs’ difference in regulatory status.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Aburto-Oropeza and colleagues’ explanation?

- A. Total biomass at Alacranes is much greater than total biomass at Bajos del Norte, though the reefs’ biomass densities are similar.
- B. Some of the species that compose the highest trophic level at Bajos del Norte are not found at Alacranes.
- C. It is somewhat more expensive for commercial and sport fishers to reach Bajos del Norte than it is to reach Alacranes.
- D. Commercial and sport fishers tend to disproportionately remove species at the highest trophic level.

ID: 45985f7e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it provides the finding that, if true, would most directly support Aburto-Oropeza and colleagues’ explanation that species composition differs between Alacranes and Bajos del Norte because of a difference in the regulation of fishing at the two reefs. The text explains that isolated oceanic reefs are often unprotected and are increasingly attracting commercial and sport fishing activity. According to the text, when Aburto-Oropeza and colleagues surveyed Alacranes, an isolated reef where fishing is prohibited, and Bajos del Norte, an isolated reef that is unprotected, they found that species at the highest trophic level (that is, top predators) make up a smaller proportion of the total mass of all living organisms at Bajos del Norte (10%) than they do at Alacranes (34%). If it were true that commercial and sport fishers tend to disproportionately remove top predators—that is, that they catch them at a higher rate than they catch other species—this would support the explanation that the allowance of fishing at Bajos del Norte and the prohibition of fishing at Alacranes has led to a lower proportion of top predator species remaining in the total biomass at Bajos del Norte.

Choice A is incorrect. To support the researchers’ claim that the role of fishing regulations accounts for Alacranes having a greater proportion of species at the highest trophic level (top predators) than Bajos del Norte does, a finding would need to help explain how fishing affects the presence of top predator species in particular; the finding that the two reefs have similar biomass densities (that is, about the same mass of living organisms per unit) and that Alacranes has a much greater total biomass (total mass of living organisms) wouldn’t reveal anything about the species composition at each reef or help explain why the *proportion* of top predators in the total biomass at each reef differs. This finding might simply suggest that Alacranes is a larger reef, with more units at that density. Choice B is incorrect because the finding that there are species at the highest trophic level (top

predators) at Bajos del Norte that aren't found at Alacranes would reveal only that there are some different species in the reefs' total biomasses (total mass of living organisms) but wouldn't explain why that's the case; this finding wouldn't be clearly connected to the role of fishing regulations, which is what, according to the researchers, accounts for the reefs having different proportions of top predators in their total masses. Choice C is incorrect. To support the researchers' claim that the role of fishing regulations accounts for Alacranes having a greater proportion of species at the highest trophic level (top predators) than Bajos del Norte does, a finding would need to help explain how fishing affects the presence of top predator species in particular, but different costs of reaching the two reefs wouldn't affect fishing behavior at all because fishing isn't even allowed on one of the reefs.

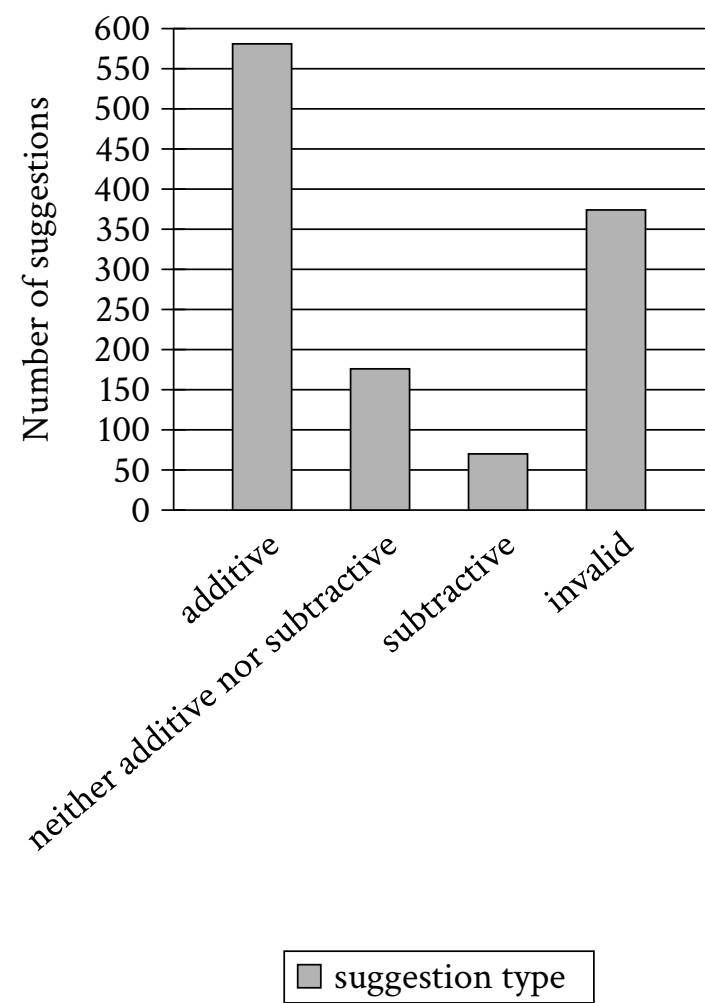
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 34317605

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 34317605

Suggestions for Improving a University



Gabrielle Adams and colleagues reviewed suggestions for improving a university that had been submitted to the university’s president. They coded each suggestion as additive (the idea suggested adding something new to the university), subtractive (the idea suggested removing something from the university), neither additive nor subtractive, or invalid (the idea was not comprehensible). The data illustrated people’s tendency to overlook the possibility of removing things to achieve improvements:

Which choice most effectively uses data in the graph to complete the statement?

- A. around 175 suggestions were coded as neither additive nor subtractive, whereas around 575 suggestions were coded as additive.
- B. more than 350 suggestions were coded as invalid, whereas fewer than 100 suggestions were coded as subtractive.

C. fewer than 100 suggestions were coded as subtractive, whereas more than 550 suggestions were coded as additive.

D. around 575 suggestions were coded as additive, whereas around 175 suggestions were coded as subtractive.

ID: 34317605 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. This choice shows that people suggested removing things to achieve improvements a lot less often than they suggested adding things, which supports the claim that people tend not to think of removing things as a likely way to improve the university.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn't support the claim. We are looking to prove that people suggested subtractive means of achieving improvements less often than other means, but this choice doesn't address how often people made subtractive suggestions. Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn't support the claim. Invalid responses were incomprehensible, so we can't compare what they were suggesting to what was being suggested in subtractive responses. Choice D is incorrect. This choice misreads the graph. Fewer than 100 suggestions were coded as subtractive. 175 is the approximate number of suggestions coded as "neither additive or subtractive."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 778226de

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 778226de

When digging for clams, their primary food, sea otters damage the roots of eelgrass plants growing on the seafloor. Near Vancouver Island in Canada, the otter population is large and well established, yet the eelgrass meadows are healthier than those found elsewhere off Canada’s coast. To explain this, conservation scientist Erin Foster and colleagues compared the Vancouver Island meadows to meadows where otters are absent or were reintroduced only recently. Finding that the Vancouver Island meadows have a more diverse gene pool than the others do, Foster hypothesized that damage to eelgrass roots increases the plant’s rate of sexual reproduction; this, in turn, boosts genetic diversity, which benefits the meadows’ health overall.

Which finding, if true, would most directly undermine Foster’s hypothesis?

- A. At some sites in the study, eelgrass meadows are found near otter populations that are small and have only recently been reintroduced.
- B. At several sites not included in the study, there are large, well-established sea otter populations but no eelgrass meadows.
- C. At several sites not included in the study, eelgrass meadows’ health correlates negatively with the length of residence and size of otter populations.
- D. At some sites in the study, the health of plants unrelated to eelgrass correlates negatively with the length of residence and size of otter populations.

ID: 778226de Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would weaken Foster’s hypothesis that damage to eelgrass roots improves the health of eelgrass meadows by boosting genetic diversity. The text indicates that sea otters damage eelgrass roots but that eelgrass meadows near Vancouver Island, where there’s a large otter population, are comparatively healthy. When Foster and her colleagues compared the Vancouver Island eelgrass meadows to those that don’t have established otter populations, the researchers found that the Vancouver Island meadows are more genetically diverse than the other meadows are. This finding led Foster to hypothesize that damage to the eelgrass roots encourages eelgrass reproduction, thereby improving genetic diversity and the health of the meadows. If, however, other meadows not included in the study are less healthy the larger the local otter population is and the longer the otters have been in residence, that would suggest that damage to the eelgrass roots, which would be expected to increase with the size and residential duration of the otter population, isn’t leading meadows to be healthier. Such a finding would therefore weaken Foster’s hypothesis.

Choice A is incorrect because finding that small, recently introduced otter populations are near other eelgrass meadows in the study wouldn’t weaken Foster’s hypothesis. If otter populations were small and only recently established, they wouldn’t be expected to have caused much damage to eelgrass roots, so even if those eelgrass meadows were less healthy than the Vancouver Island meadows, that wouldn’t undermine Foster’s hypothesis. In fact, it would be consistent with Foster’s hypothesis since it would suggest that the greater damage caused by larger, more established otter populations is associated with healthier

meadows. Choice B is incorrect because the existence of areas with otters but without eelgrass meadows wouldn't reveal anything about whether the damage that otters cause to eelgrass roots ultimately benefits eelgrass meadows. Choice D is incorrect because the health of plants other than eelgrass would have no bearing on Foster's hypothesis that damage to eelgrass roots leads to greater genetic diversity and meadow health. It would be possible for otters to have a negative effect on other plants while nevertheless improving the health of eelgrass meadows by damaging eelgrass roots.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3d1d4c89

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 3d1d4c89

Eighteenth-century economist Adam Smith is famed for his metaphor of the invisible hand, which he putatively used to illustrate a robust model of how individuals produce aggregate benefits by pursuing their own economic interests. Note “putatively”: as Gavin Kennedy has shown, Smith deploys this metaphor only once in his economic writings—to make a narrow point about the then-dominant economic theory of mercantilism—and it was largely ignored until some twentieth-century economists eager to secure an intellectual pedigree for their views elevated it to a fully-fledged paradigm.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Although Smith is famed for his metaphor of the invisible hand, the metaphor was largely ignored until economists in the twentieth century came to realize that the metaphor was a robust model that anticipated their own views.
- B. Some twentieth-century economists gave Smith’s metaphor of the invisible hand a significance it does not have in Smith’s work, but it is nevertheless a useful model of how individuals produce aggregate benefits by pursuing their own economic interests.
- C. Smith’s metaphor of the invisible hand has been interpreted as a model of how individuals acting in their own interest produce aggregate benefits, but it was intended as a subtle critique of the economic theory of mercantilism.
- D. The reputation of Smith’s metaphor of the invisible hand is not due to the importance of the metaphor in Smith’s work but rather to the promotion of the metaphor by some later economists for their own ends.

ID: 3d1d4c89 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. The text explains that economist Adam Smith’s famous metaphor of the invisible hand was putatively (that is, widely assumed but not proven) intended to illustrate a robust model (a consistently accurate generalization) of how individuals pursuing their own economic interests can create broader benefits for the population. The text then emphasizes the lack of affirmative evidence for this idea by calling out the term “putatively,” and explaining that, according to Gavin Kennedy, Smith used the metaphor only once in his works, in reference to specific circumstances related to the now-outdated economic view known as mercantilism, and that the metaphor didn’t garner much attention until economists in the twentieth century held it up as a paradigm (a theoretical framework in the field) and thereby implied that Smith shared some of their views on economics. By emphasizing “putatively,” the text implies that there is no independent reason to believe that Smith would agree with the metaphor’s use outside of the specific context for which he wrote it and that, therefore, the twentieth-century economists who used it did so to support their own views without regard for the metaphor’s importance to Smith’s work.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text indicates that Smith’s metaphor was largely ignored until some twentieth-century economists revived it and bolstered its status, the text suggests that the later economists used Smith’s metaphor to self-servingly boost their own work while ignoring the original context in which Smith wrote it. Moreover, the statement in this choice fails to

reflect the text's emphasis on Smith's limited use of the metaphor in his work. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text indicates that some twentieth-century economists altered the significance of Smith's metaphor, the text doesn't suggest that the metaphor is a "useful model" of how aggregate benefits arise from individuals' selfish actions, let alone that this usefulness is unaffected by taking the metaphor out of its original context. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text indicates that Smith's metaphor was intended as a model of how individuals acting in their own interest produce aggregate benefits and it was written within the context of the now-outdated economic theory of mercantilism, these points are subordinate to the primary idea in the text, which is that Smith's use of the metaphor was tightly constrained but twentieth-century economists ignored the original context so that they could use the metaphor to suggest, without support, that Smith would agree with their economic views.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 08d2f4c1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 08d2f4c1

Many governments that regularly transfer money to individuals—to provide supplemental incomes for senior citizens, for example—have long done so electronically, but other countries typically have distributed physical money and have only recently developed electronic transfer infrastructure. Researchers studied the introduction of an electronic transfer system in one such location and found that recipients of electronic transfers consumed a different array of foods than recipients of physical transfers of the same amount did. One potential explanation for this result is that individuals conceive of and allocate funds in physical money differently than they conceive of and allocate funds in electronic form.

Which finding from the study, if true, would most directly weaken the potential explanation?

- A. Recipients of electronic transfers typically spent their funds at a slower rate than recipients of physical transfers did.
- B. Nearly every recipient of an electronic transfer withdrew the entire amount in physical money shortly after receiving the transfer.
- C. Recipients of physical transfers tended to purchase food about as frequently as recipients of electronic transfers did.
- D. Some recipients of physical transfers received small amounts of money relatively frequently, while others received large amounts relatively infrequently.

ID: 08d2f4c1 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. This would weaken the explanation. If the recipients of electronic money immediately withdrew it all as physical money, then both kinds of recipients ended up spending physical money on food. So there must be some other explanation why those who initially received electronic money ate different kinds of food.

Choice A is incorrect. This wouldn't weaken the explanation. If anything, it actually supports it: it demonstrates that recipients of electronic money and recipients of physical money have different spending habits. Choice C is incorrect. This wouldn't weaken the explanation. The explanation we're testing this choice against is about the way that people might "conceive of and allocate" physical and electronic funds differently. This choice only focuses on the timing, not what they spend the money on. Choice D is incorrect. This would have no impact on the explanation. It doesn't tell us anything about possible differences between the spending habits of those who spend physical money and those who spend money electronically.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID de307886

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: de307886

Choctaw/Cherokee artist Jeffrey Gibson turns punching bags used by boxers into art by decorating them with beadwork and elements of Native dressmaking. These elements include leather fringe and jingles, the metal cones that cover the dresses worn in the jingle dance, a women’s dance of the Ojibwe people. Thus, Gibson combines an object commonly associated with masculinity (a punching bag) with art forms traditionally practiced by women in most Native communities (beadwork and dressmaking). In this way, he rejects the division of male and female gender roles.

Which choice best describes Gibson’s approach to art, as presented in the text?

- A. He draws from traditional Native art forms to create his original works.
- B. He has been influenced by Native and non-Native artists equally.
- C. He finds inspiration from boxing in designing the dresses he makes.
- D. He rejects expectations about color and pattern when incorporating beadwork.

ID: de307886 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes Gibson’s approach to art. As the text explains, Gibson, who is Cherokee and Choctaw, transforms punching bags into art pieces by applying (or attaching) to them beadwork and elements of Native dressmaking, including leather fringe and the jingles of the jingle dress. The text goes on to say that in most Native communities, the art forms of beadwork and dressmaking are traditionally practiced by women. Therefore, Gibson’s approach to art consists of creating original works by drawing from traditional Native art forms.

Choice B is incorrect. Because Gibson incorporates Native art forms into his own original artwork, it can be inferred that he has been influenced by other Native artists, but the text never suggests that non-Native artists have influenced him. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that Gibson designs dresses influenced by boxing but instead that he turns punching bags, which are used in boxing, into works of art by applying elements of Native dressmaking to them. Choice D is incorrect. Although Gibson does incorporate beadwork into his art, the text never mentions the colors or patterns that he uses or suggests that his art defies the expectations that people might have about color and pattern in beadwork.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bf26e4b4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: bf26e4b4

Effects of Mycorrhizal Fungi on 3 Plant Species

Plant species	Mycorrhizal host	Average mass of plants grown in soil containing mycorrhizal fungi (in grams)	Average mass of plants grown in soil treated to kill fungi (in grams)
Corn	yes	15.1	3.8
Marigold	yes	10.2	2.4
Broccoli	no	7.5	7

Mycorrhizal fungi in soil benefits many plants, substantially increasing the mass of some. A student conducted an experiment to illustrate this effect. The student chose three plant species for the experiment, including two that are mycorrhizal hosts (species known to benefit from mycorrhizal fungi) and one nonmycorrhizal species (a species that doesn't benefit from and may even be harmed by mycorrhizal fungi). The student then grew several plants from each species both in soil containing mycorrhizal fungi and in soil that had been treated to kill mycorrhizal and other fungi. After several weeks, the student measured the plants' average mass and was surprised to discover that _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement?

- A. broccoli grown in soil containing mycorrhizal fungi had a slightly higher average mass than broccoli grown in soil that had been treated to kill fungi.
- B. corn grown in soil containing mycorrhizal fungi had a higher average mass than broccoli grown in soil containing mycorrhizal fungi.
- C. marigolds grown in soil containing mycorrhizal fungi had a much higher average mass than marigolds grown in soil that had been treated to kill fungi.
- D. corn had the highest average mass of all three species grown in soil that had been treated to kill fungi, while marigolds had the lowest.

ID: bf26e4b4 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively uses data from the table to complete the statement. The text explains that mycorrhizal hosts are plants that benefit from the presence of mycorrhizal fungi in the soil and that some such plants produce more mass when grown in the presence of these fungi, while for nonmycorrhizal species the fungi either have no effect or may be harmful. The experiment included two mycorrhizal hosts (corn and marigold) and one nonmycorrhizal species (broccoli). Given the claim in the text that nonmycorrhizal species will see either no difference or a decrease in mass when exposed to mycorrhizal fungi, the student would likely have been surprised by the higher average mass for broccoli grown in the presence of the fungi than the broccoli grown in the soil treated to kill fungi.

Choice B is incorrect. Although this choice accurately describes the corn data from the table, the fact that the mycorrhizal host corn is more massive in the presence of the fungi likely fits with what the student expected and would therefore not be surprising. Choice C is incorrect. Although this choice accurately describes the marigold data from the table, the fact that the mycorrhizal host marigold is more massive in the presence of the fungi is likely what the student expected and thus would not be surprising. Choice D is incorrect because it does not accurately represent the data in the table—when grown in soil treated to kill fungi, corn had an average mass of 3.8 g while broccoli had an average mass of 7g—and because making comparisons among the plants in the no-fungi condition, by itself, does not provide a basis to compare the average mass of mycorrhizal hosts and nonmycorrhizal species grown in the presence of the fungi with those grown in the soil treated to kill fungi.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ab8da62b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: ab8da62b

In a study of new technology adoption, Davit Marikyan et al. examined negative disconfirmation (which occurs when experiences fall short of one’s expectations) to determine whether it could lead to positive outcomes for users. The team focused on established users of “smart home” technology, which presents inherent utilization challenges but tends to attract users with high expectations, often leading to feelings of dissonance. The researchers found that many users employed cognitive mechanisms to mitigate those feelings, ultimately reversing their initial sense of disappointment.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Research suggests that most users of smart home technology will not achieve a feeling of satisfaction given the utilization challenges of such technology.
- B. Although most smart home technology is aimed at meeting or exceeding users’ high expectations, those expectations in general remain poorly understood.
- C. Research suggests that users with high expectations for a new technology can feel content with that technology even after experiencing negative disconfirmation.
- D. Although negative disconfirmation has often been studied, little is known about the cognitive mechanisms shaping users’ reactions to it in the context of new technology adoption.

ID: ab8da62b Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The passage begins by describing the study, and concludes with its results: "many users employed cognitive mechanisms to mitigate those feelings [of negative disconfirmation]."

Choice A is incorrect. This is the opposite of what the text claims. Rather, the researchers found that "many users" reversed "their initial sense of disappointment." Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t reflect the text. What the expectations of smart home tech users are is not discussed. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t reflect the text. How often these topics have been studied is not mentioned.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0738ffb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 0738ffb

Marta Coll and colleagues’ 2010 Mediterranean Sea biodiversity census reported approximately 17,000 species, nearly double the number reported in Carlo Bianchi and Carla Morri’s 2000 census—a difference only partly attributable to the description of new invertebrate species in the interim. Another factor is that the morphological variability of microorganisms is poorly understood compared to that of vertebrates, invertebrates, plants, and algae, creating uncertainty about how to evaluate microorganisms as species. Researchers’ decisions on such matters therefore can be highly consequential. Indeed, the two censuses reported similar counts of vertebrate, plant, and algal species, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. Coll and colleagues reported a much higher number of species than Bianchi and Morri did largely due to the inclusion of invertebrate species that had not been described at the time of Bianchi and Morri’s census.
- B. some differences observed in microorganisms may have been treated as variations within species by Bianchi and Morri but treated as indicative of distinct species by Coll and colleagues.
- C. Bianchi and Morri may have been less sensitive to the degree of morphological variation displayed within a typical species of microorganism than Coll and colleagues were.
- D. the absence of clarity regarding how to differentiate among species of microorganisms may have resulted in Coll and colleagues underestimating the number of microorganism species.

ID: 0738ffb Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically completes the text’s discussion of the different counts of species in the Mediterranean Sea. The text states that Coll and colleagues reported almost double the number of species that Bianchi and Morri reported in their study ten years earlier. According to the text, this difference can only be partly attributed to new invertebrate species being described in the years between the two studies, which means there must be an additional factor that made Coll and colleagues’ count so much higher than Bianchi and Morri’s count. The text goes on to explain that factor: researchers have a relatively poor understanding of microorganisms’ morphological variability, or the differences in microorganisms’ structure and form. This poor understanding makes it hard to classify microorganisms by species and means that researchers’ decisions about classifying microorganisms can have a large effect on the overall species counts that researchers report. Additionally, the text says that the two censuses reported similar numbers of vertebrate, plant, and algal species, which means that the difference in overall species did not come from differences in those categories. Given all this information, it most logically follows that Coll and colleagues may have treated some of the differences among microorganisms as indicative of the microorganisms being different species, whereas Bianchi and Morri treated those differences as variations within species, resulting in Coll and colleagues reporting many more species than Bianchi and Morri did.

Choice A is incorrect because the text explicitly addresses this issue by stating that the description of new invertebrate species in the years between the two studies can explain only part of the difference in the number of species reported by the studies. The focus of the text is on explaining the difference between Coll and colleagues' count and Bianchi and Morri's count that cannot be accounted for by the inclusion of invertebrate species that had not been described at the time of Bianchi and Morri's study. Choice C is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that Bianchi and Morri may have been less sensitive to how much the form and structure of microorganisms vary within the same species than Coll and colleagues were. If Bianchi and Morri had been less sensitive to within-species variation than Coll and colleagues were, Bianchi and Morri would likely have reported more species than Coll and colleagues did, since less sensitivity to within-species variation would lead researchers to classify as different species microorganisms that more sensitive researchers would classify as variations within the same species. The text indicates, however, that Bianchi and Morri reported far fewer species than Coll and colleagues did; since the text also excludes other explanations for this difference, it suggests that in fact Bianchi and Morri were more sensitive to within-species variation than Coll and colleagues were, leading Bianchi and Morri to report fewer overall species. Choice D is incorrect because the text is focused on explaining why Coll and colleagues reported many more species than Bianchi and Morri did, and an underestimate of the number of microorganism species by Coll and colleagues would not explain that difference—it would suggest, in fact, that the difference in the number of species should have been even larger.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ffc5e579

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: ffc5e579

In episodes of high heat, corals expel symbiotic zooxanthellae from their tissues, leading to coral bleaching and heightened coral mortality. Some researchers have proposed a mitigation strategy of identifying, rearing, and disseminating corals that have evolved strong resistance to heat, but as Nia S. Walker et al. note, if genes conferring such resistance were exclusively advantageous, they should have already propagated through coral populations. Indeed, Walker et al. show that strongly heat-resistant corals display much less growth after heat stress than do moderately heat-resistant corals.

- Based on the text, Walker et al. would most likely agree with which statement about the strategy some researchers have proposed?
- A. It would involve promoting a trait that protects corals against high heat but that is associated with reduced thriving after episodes of high heat.
 - B. It would favor a trait that is advantageous now but would be disadvantageous if episodes of high heat become as infrequent as has been predicted.
 - C. It would benefit corals that are frequently exposed to episodes of high heat but would harm corals that are frequently exposed to episodes of moderate heat.
 - D. It would require manipulating a trait that is poorly understood and that may be linked to increased coral mortality during episodes of high heat.

ID: ffc5e579 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a statement about the proposed strategy that is consistent with Walker et al.’s position. The strategy involves identifying and disseminating corals with strong heat resistance as a means of mitigating coral mortality during episodes of high heat. According to the text, Walker et al. note that if this trait were “exclusively advantageous,” it would have already spread throughout coral populations—implying that the trait carries some evolutionary cost. The text then provides evidence of this cost: Walker et al. have found that strongly heat-resistant corals display much less growth after heat stress (indicative of reduced thriving) than do moderately heat-resistant corals. Given the apparent trade-off between strong heat resistance and growth after heat stress, Walker et al. would be likely to agree that the strategy entails promoting a trait that protects against high heat but is associated with reduced thriving afterward.

Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that episodes of high heat are predicted to become infrequent. Also, the text establishes that Walker et al. found that the trait of high heat tolerance is associated with a significant trade-off—reduced growth after heat stress. Given the cost that accompanies strong heat resistance, Walker et al. wouldn’t be likely to agree that the trait is advantageous now. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss the effects of moderate heat on corals or distinguish between corals that are exposed to different levels of heat. The text also doesn’t address the frequency of corals’ exposure to heat. Therefore, there is no basis for concluding that Walker et al. would agree that the strategy benefits corals that

are frequently exposed to high heat but harms those that are frequently exposed to moderate heat. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn't indicate that heat resistance in corals is poorly understood. On the contrary, Walker et al. present a specific finding about this trait, linking reduced growth after heat stress to strong heat resistance. In addition, the text indicates that strong heat resistance protects corals during episodes of high heat; while their research shows that heat resistance is linked to reduced growth after such episodes, Walker et al. likely wouldn't agree that it is linked to increased coral mortality during such episodes.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 22e78515

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 22e78515

Some geologists have proposed designating the period from 1950 to the present as a new geological epoch (the Anthropocene) characterized by human impact on Earth, but they have struggled to identify reliable stratigraphic markers of the epoch's onset. Inta Dimante-Deimantovica and a research team investigated whether the initial appearance of primary microplastics—invented and mass-produced for industrial and other purposes, beginning around the middle of the twentieth century—in sedimentary layers could serve this role. The researchers analyzed European lake sediment profiles from the late eighteenth century to the present. Microplastics were present in all layers, likely because certain microplastic shapes enabled rapid downward migration. The researchers therefore concluded that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the lowest sedimentary layer in which microplastics are found cannot be treated as indicative of the chronological beginning of the Anthropocene.
- B. the presence of microplastics in sediment dating to the late eighteenth century casts doubt on the appropriateness of designating 1950 as the onset of the Anthropocene.
- C. microplastics are not prevalent enough in sediment to serve as a reliable sign of the human impact characteristic of the Anthropocene.
- D. using the earliest presence of microplastics as a stratigraphic marker of the beginning of the Anthropocene is likely to be viable in some locations but is not viable in Europe.

ID: 22e78515 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of microplastics as a proposed stratigraphic marker for the onset of the Anthropocene. The text indicates that although primary microplastics (used for industrial and other purposes) were invented and mass-produced beginning only around the mid-twentieth century, researchers found microplastics throughout European lake sediment profiles dating from the late eighteenth century to the present. According to the text, microplastics were in all layers of sediment likely because microplastics of certain shapes can rapidly migrate downward—that is, they can move into sedimentary layers that predate their manufacture. Since it can't be assumed that the date of a layer in which microplastics are found indicates when the microplastics were first deposited, it follows that the lowest sedimentary layer containing microplastics can't be treated as indicative of the chronological beginning of the Anthropocene.

Choice B is incorrect. The text explains that microplastics appeared in layers of sediment long predating 1950 likely because certain shapes allowed them to rapidly migrate downward—that is, the particles physically moved into older layers. This finding doesn't cast doubt on the appropriateness of considering 1950 as the onset of the Anthropocene; it doesn't suggest a flaw in thinking that humans' impact on Earth shifted around 1950 but simply suggests that the position of microplastics in sediment isn't useful as an indicator of such a shift. Choice C is incorrect because the issue presented in the text isn't a lack of prevalence

of microplastics (and though no quantity is indicated, microplastics were found across all the layers) but rather the inability to determine when microplastics were originally deposited, since the particles can migrate rapidly into older sediment layers. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that the likely cause of microplastics being present in all layers of the sediment profiles is a property of microplastic particles themselves (certain shapes allowing them to rapidly move downward into older layers), not a characteristic of European lake sediment or anything else specific to Europe. There's no reason to think the issue of particle migration wouldn't occur in other locations.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2b0970f7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 2b0970f7

Tides can deposit large quantities of dead vegetation within a salt marsh, smothering healthy plants and leaving a salt panne—a depression devoid of plants that tends to trap standing water—in the marsh’s interior. Ecologist Kathryn Beheshti and colleagues found that burrowing crabs living within these pannes improve drainage by loosening the soil, leading the pannes to shrink as marsh plants move back in. At salt marsh edges, however, crab-induced soil loosening can promote marsh loss by accelerating erosion, suggesting that the burrowing action of crabs _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. can be beneficial to marshes with small pannes but can be harmful to marshes with large pannes.
- B. may promote increases in marsh plants or decreases in marsh plants, depending on the crabs’ location.
- C. tends to be more heavily concentrated in areas of marsh interiors with standing water than at marsh edges.
- D. varies in intensity depending on the size of the panne relative to the size of the surrounding marsh.

ID: 2b0970f7 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text says that crab burrowing in the pannes enables plants to grow there again. It also says that crab burrowing at the edges of the marsh speeds up marsh loss. This suggests that burrowing crabs can either help or hurt marshes, depending on where they’re located.

Choice A is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never discusses pannes of different sizes. Choice C is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never suggests that crabs do more burrowing in the pannes (the areas with standing water) than they do at the edges. Rather, the text says that the burrowing that happens in the pannes is beneficial, while the burrowing that happens at the edges is harmful. Choice D is incorrect. This inference isn’t supported. The text never discusses the intensity of crab burrowing, nor does it discuss the size of the panne relative to the size of the marsh.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c3dddb2d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: c3dddb2d

“On Virtue” is a 1766 poem by Phillis Wheatley. Wheatley addresses the poem directly to the quality of virtue, imploring it to assist her in reaching a future goal: _____

Which quotation from “On Virtue” most effectively illustrates the claim?

- A. “Attend me, *Virtue*, thro’ my youthful years! / O leave me not to the false joys of time! / But guide my steps to endless life and bliss.”
- B. “I cease to wonder, and no more attempt / Thine height t’explore, or fathom thy profound.”
- C. “O thou bright jewel in my aim I strive / To comprehend thee. Thine own words declare / Wisdom is higher than a fool can reach.”
- D. “But, O my soul, sink not into despair, / *Virtue* is near thee, and with gentle hand / Would now embrace thee, hovers o’er thine head.”

ID: c3dddb2d Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most effectively illustrates the claim that Wheatley addresses her poem "On Virtue" to the quality of virtue, imploring it to assist her in reaching a future goal. In the quotation, Wheatley begs virtue to accompany her, or "attend [her]," through her youth and to "guide [her] steps to" the future goal of "endless life and bliss."

Choice B is incorrect because this quotation suggests the difficulty of fully comprehending virtue. Rather than asking virtue for help, Wheatley presents it as a quality that is impossible to entirely understand because it is so grand and deep. Choice C is incorrect because this quotation describes Wheatley’s effort to comprehend virtue despite virtue itself declaring that such wisdom is beyond her grasp, or "higher than a fool can reach." Choice D is incorrect because rather than asking virtue for help in this quotation, Wheatley urges herself to "sink not into despair" because virtue is always nearby.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 945e7093

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 945e7093

Born in 1891 to a Quechua-speaking family in the Andes Mountains of Peru, Martín Chambi is today considered to be one of the most renowned figures of Latin American photography. In a paper for an art history class, a student claims that Chambi’s photographs have considerable ethnographic value—in his work, Chambi was able to capture diverse elements of Peruvian society, representing his subjects with both dignity and authenticity.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support the student’s claim?

- A. Chambi took many commissioned portraits of wealthy Peruvians, but he also produced hundreds of images carefully documenting the peoples, sites, and customs of Indigenous communities of the Andes.
- B. Chambi’s photographs demonstrate a high level of technical skill, as seen in his strategic use of illumination to create dramatic light and shadow contrasts.
- C. During his lifetime, Chambi was known and celebrated both within and outside his native Peru, as his work was published in places like Argentina, Spain, and Mexico.
- D. Some of the peoples and places Chambi photographed had long been popular subjects for Peruvian photographers.

ID: 945e7093 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would support the claim about Chambi’s photographs. The text describes a student advancing the claim that Chambi’s photographs “have considerable ethnographic value”—meaning that they are valuable as records of cultures—and that they “capture diverse elements of Peruvian society” in a respectful way. If it’s true that Chambi carefully photographed people from a range of different communities in Peru as well as photographed the customs and sites of different communities, that would lend support to the claim that the photographs have ethnographic value as depictions of diverse elements of society in Peru.

Choice B is incorrect because the student’s claim is that Chambi’s photographs have considerable ethnographic value because they depict diverse elements of Peruvian society; the student doesn’t claim anything about the technical skill demonstrated in the photographs. Choice C is incorrect because neither Chambi’s reputation nor the locations where his photographs may have been published would be relevant to the student’s claim that his photographs are valuable as an ethnographic record of Peru’s diverse society. Choice D is incorrect because the popularity among other photographers of the people and places that Chambi photographed would be irrelevant to the student’s claim that Chambi’s photographs are valuable as an ethnographic record of Peru’s diverse society.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ac76d96e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: ac76d96e

Belonging to neither the minimalist nor the abstract art movements but heavily influencing both, Constantin Brâncuși spent his sculpting career returning to the same few themes—a kiss, a sleeping head, and a bird in flight—each rendered in pristine, simple, almost abstract forms. Perhaps the most famous example is *Bird in Space* (1923), a tall, slender bronze sculpture that arcs upward in a manner suggestive of flight but that otherwise lacks any identifiable characteristics of a bird. Despite the seeming simplicity of his works, the exacting standards to which Brâncuși held his work meant that he produced relatively few pieces over his career. There is thus something of a disparity between _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. the nature of much of Brâncuși’s work and the abstraction of *Bird in Space*.
- B. Brâncuși’s relatively limited productivity and the diversity of his sculptures.
- C. the themes Brâncuși explored and the themes favored by artists he inspired.
- D. Brâncuși’s importance to the history of art and his total artistic output.

ID: ac76d96e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the sculptor Constantin Brâncuși. The text establishes Brâncuși’s significance by noting that although he belonged to neither the minimalist nor the abstract art movements, he heavily influenced both—a detail that signals his importance to the history of art. At the same time, the text notes that the exacting standards to which Brâncuși held his work meant that he produced relatively few pieces over his career. Because the text presents both Brâncuși’s major artistic influence and his limited output, it is reasonable to infer that the disparity the text identifies is between his importance to the history of art and his total artistic output.

Choice A is incorrect because the text explicitly identifies Brâncuși’s *Bird in Space* as “a famous example” of how the artist conveyed his preferred themes—in this case, a bird in flight—through simplicity bordering on abstraction. Thus, this particular sculpture is consistent with the nature of much of Brâncuși’s work instead of showing a disparity, or marked difference, with it. Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that Brâncuși returned to the same few themes, suggesting limited thematic diversity. Since his productivity and his thematic diversity were both limited, these two aspects of Brâncuși’s work are consistent with each other instead of showing a disparity, or a marked difference. Choice C is incorrect because although the text mentions that Brâncuși heavily influenced both the minimalist and abstract art movements, it doesn’t discuss the specific themes favored by artists in those movements. There is therefore no basis for identifying a disparity between Brâncuși’s themes and those of artists he inspired.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5598e59d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 5598e59d

Matthew D. Rocklage and team examined whether consumer ratings of movies can predict box office success. The team considered both numeric star ratings and written reviews in their research. To analyze the written reviews, the team measured the emotionality—the degree to which a written review expresses an emotional reaction—of user reviews on a movie rating website, assigning each review an emotionality score. After reviewing this research, a student argues that the emotionality of movie reviews is unrelated to a movie’s success at the box office.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken the student’s conclusion?

- A. Movies that had the highest average emotionality scores received the lowest average star ratings on the movie rating website.
- B. The average emotionality score of a movie’s reviews was a positive predictor of that movie’s box office earnings.
- C. More than half of the movies that the team examined received an average star rating of 3 out of 5 stars.
- D. The movies that were most successful at the box office tended to have high average star ratings.

ID: 5598e59d Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. This choice weakens the student’s conclusion by suggesting that the emotionality of movie reviews is related to box office success: the higher the emotionality score, the better the movie performs at the box office.

Choice A is incorrect. While this choice does mention emotionality scores, it only connects them to star ratings, not to box office success. Choice C is incorrect. The fact that many movies received an average star rating doesn’t tell us anything about the relationship between emotionality and box office success. Choice D is incorrect. While this choice suggests that star ratings can predict box office success, it doesn’t address the issue of emotionality in written reviews, which is the focus of the student’s conclusion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5fc3a3b6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 5fc3a3b6

Linguist Deborah Tannen has cautioned against framing contentious issues in terms of two highly competitive perspectives, such as pro versus con. According to Tannen, this debate-driven approach can strip issues of their complexity and, when used in front of an audience, can be less informative than the presentation of multiple perspectives in a noncompetitive format. To test Tannen’s hypothesis, students conducted a study in which they showed participants one of three different versions of local news commentary about the same issue. Each version featured a debate between two commentators with opposing views, a panel of three commentators with various views, or a single commentator.

Which finding from the students’ study, if true, would most strongly support Tannen’s hypothesis?

- A. On average, participants perceived commentators in the debate as more knowledgeable about the issue than commentators in the panel.
- B. On average, participants perceived commentators in the panel as more knowledgeable about the issue than the single commentator.
- C. On average, participants who watched the panel correctly answered more questions about the issue than those who watched the debate or the single commentator did.
- D. On average, participants who watched the single commentator correctly answered more questions about the issue than those who watched the debate did.

ID: 5fc3a3b6 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents the finding that, if true, would most strongly support Tannen’s hypothesis. According to the text, Tannen’s hypothesis is that multiple perspectives presented in a noncompetitive format is more informative than a debate between opposing viewpoints is. If participants who saw a panel of three commentators with various views about an issue answered more questions about the issue correctly than did participants who saw a debate, that would support Tannen’s hypothesis since it would show that participants who heard multiple varied perspectives were better informed than were participants who heard a debate between opposing viewpoints.

Choice A is incorrect because finding that participants perceived commentators in the debate as more knowledgeable than commentators in the panel is irrelevant to Tannen’s hypothesis, which is that presenting multiple perspectives on an issue is more informative to the audience than presenting opposing views of the issue is. Participants’ perception of how knowledgeable panelists are has no bearing on how much participants learn from the panelists. Choice B is incorrect because finding that participants perceived commentators in the panel as more knowledgeable than a single commentator is irrelevant to Tannen’s hypothesis, which is that presenting multiple perspectives on an issue is more informative to the audience than presenting opposing views of the issue is. Participants’ perception of how knowledgeable panelists are has no bearing on how much participants learn from the panelists, and Tannen’s hypothesis says nothing about how informative single commentators are.

Choice D is incorrect because finding that participants who watched a single commentator answered more questions correctly than participants who watched the debate did wouldn't be relevant to Tannen's hypothesis, which is that hearing multiple varying perspectives is more informative than hearing a debate. Tannen's hypothesis says nothing about how informative single commentators are.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d6ca3f31

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: d6ca3f31

In the 1980s, many musicians and journalists in the English-speaking world began to draw attention to music from around the globe—such as mbaqanga from South Africa and quan họ from Vietnam—that can’t be easily categorized according to British or North American popular music genres, typically referring to such music as “world music.” While some scholars have welcomed this development for bringing diverse musical forms to prominence in countries where they’d previously been overlooked, musicologist Su Zheng claims that the concept of world music homogenizes highly distinct traditions by reducing them all to a single category.

- Which finding about mbaqanga and quan họ, if true, would most directly support Zheng’s claim?
- A. Mbaqanga and quan họ developed independently of each other and have little in common musically.
 - B. Mbaqanga is significantly more popular in the English-speaking world than quan họ is.
 - C. Mbaqanga and quan họ are now performed by a diverse array of musicians with no direct connections to South Africa or Vietnam.
 - D. Mbaqanga and quan họ are highly distinct from British and North American popular music genres but similar to each other.

ID: d6ca3f31 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. Zheng’s claim is that the idea of world music “homogenizes” (meaning makes similar) distinct kinds of music by reducing them to one category. In other words, Zheng thinks the concept of world music is a harmful oversimplification of diverse musical forms. To support this claim, we need evidence that these musical traditions are so different from one another that they should not fall into the same category. If it’s true that mbaqanga and quan họ developed separately and have little in common musically, then it wouldn’t make sense to lump them into the same category.

Choice B is incorrect. If true, this wouldn’t affect the claim. To support the claim, we need evidence that these musical traditions are so different from one another that they should not fall into the same category. A difference in popularity doesn’t necessarily mean that the two musical traditions shouldn’t be categorized together: instead, we need to know if the music itself is similar or different. Choice C is incorrect. If true, this wouldn’t affect the claim. To support the claim, we need evidence that these musical traditions are so different from each other that they should not fall into the same category. This choice doesn’t do that. Choice D is incorrect. If true, this would actually weaken the claim. Zheng thinks it’s reductive or oversimplifying to put distinct musical traditions into a single category. But if mbaqanga and quan họ are similar to each other, then it would make sense to put them in the same category.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 65e04a48

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 65e04a48

The variety of species with adaptations to produce toxins is matched by the variety of uses of those toxins: northern stargazers, for example, use toxins for defense, whereas tiger snakes use toxins for predation and skeleton shrimp use toxins for intraspecific competition. In fact, a species may have adaptations enabling it to produce a toxin with multiple uses. Finding that the venom used by the Panamanian scorpion *Centruroides granosus* to subdue prey also inhibits growth of the pathogenic bacteria *Escherichia coli*, Dumas Gálvez and colleagues conclude that the particular form of venom production observed in *C. granosus* may have propagated through the species because it mitigates risk during feeding in addition to enhancing predation success.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Gálvez and colleagues’ conclusion?

- A. *E. coli* does not appear to be virulent for *C. granosus* even when transmitted from prey captured without the use of venom.
- B. *E. coli* is frequently found in species preyed on by *C. granosus* and can survive exposure to the digestive juices of *C. granosus*.
- C. *C. granosus* appears to be chemically sensitive to prey infected with *E. coli* and tends to favor uninfected individuals.
- D. Exposure to *C. granosus* venom also inhibits the growth of nonpathogenic bacteria species common in the native environment of *C. granosus*.

ID: 65e04a48 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it presents a finding that, if true, would most directly support Dumas Gálvez and colleagues’ conclusion that the venom produced by the scorpion species *Centruroides granosus* helps mitigate, or reduce, risk during feeding in addition to enhancing predation success. According to the text, Gálvez and colleagues found that the venom used by *C. granosus* both subdues prey and inhibits the growth of *Escherichia coli*, a pathogen that, if ingested by *C. granosus*, would presumably cause disease unless neutralized in some way. If it were true that *E. coli* is commonly found in species preyed on by *C. granosus* and, moreover, can withstand *C. granosus*’s digestive juices after ingestion, this would suggest that *C. granosus* likely relies on another mechanism to neutralize *E. coli* to make *E. coli*-infected prey safe for consumption by the scorpion species. Given that, as the text states, *C. granosus*’s venom was found to inhibit the pathogen’s growth, it therefore follows that the venom provides protection for *C. granosus* against *E. coli* that its digestive system wouldn’t otherwise provide, making it reasonable to conclude that the trait may have spread through the species because it mitigates risk during feeding.

Choice A is incorrect because a finding that *E. coli* doesn’t appear to be virulent, or dangerous, for *C. granosus* even when venom isn’t used would weaken rather than strengthen Gálvez and colleagues’ conclusion that a particular form of venom production spread in *C. granosus* in part because it helps reduce risk during feeding, since this finding would suggest that *E. coli* isn’t actually a risk to *C. granosus* when consuming prey. Choice C is incorrect because a finding that *C. granosus* can detect and avoid consuming *E. coli*-infected prey in the first place would suggest that an ability other than venom production is the primary factor that reduces *C. granosus*’s risk when feeding, which would suggest there has been less evolutionary pressure to develop venom that provides protection; thus, this finding wouldn’t clearly support the conclusion that *C. granosus*’s form of venom production

spread in the species in part because it helps reduce risk during feeding. Choice D is incorrect because Gálvez and colleagues' conclusion focuses on *C. granosus* venom in relation to the risk of *E. coli*, and a finding that the venom also inhibits nonpathogenic (not disease-causing) bacteria species, which presumably don't pose a risk if consumed, wouldn't be relevant to the conclusion that *C. granosus*'s particular form of venom production spread in the species in part because it helps reduce risk during feeding.

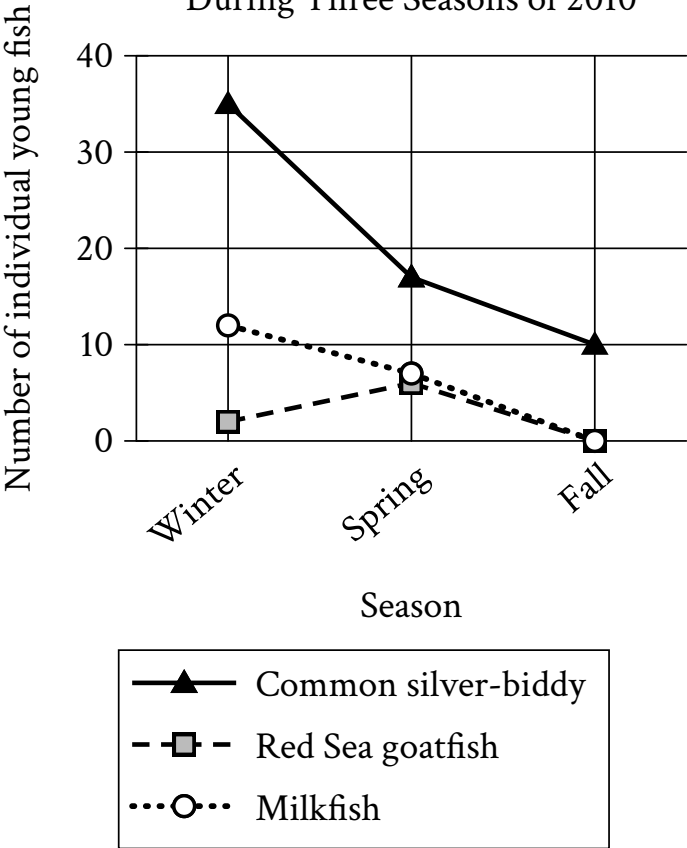
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 91717abe

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: 91717abe

Number of Young Fish Collected at Mangrove Sites in the Egyptian Red Sea During Three Seasons of 2010



Mangroves are trees or bushes that grow on the coastlines of seas and rivers. Areas with mangroves are great places for young fish since they help keep these fish fed and protected while they grow. To study the importance of mangroves to young fish, researchers Mohamed A.Abu El-Regal and Nesreen K. Ibrahim collected and identified young fish from three different mangrove sites in the Egyptian Red Sea. They collected fish in the winter, spring, and autumn of 2010, collecting a total of 269 fish from 21 different species. For some species, more fish were collected in the winter than the other two seasons, for instance: _____

Which choice most effectively uses the data in the graph to complete the example?

- A. more common silver-biddy and milkfish were collected in the winter than in either of the other two seasons.
- B. the common silver-biddy was collected more frequently than the other two species in all three seasons.
- C. in the spring, researchers collected more Red Sea goldfish than they collected from the other two species.
- D. in the fall, researchers collected 10 common silver-biddy but collected no milkfish or Red Sea goatfish.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The claim is about which fish were collected more in winter than in other seasons. By comparing the number of common silver-biddy and milkfish collected in each season, we can see that more of these fish were collected in winter than in any other season.

Choice B is incorrect. The claim is about which fish were collected more in winter than in other seasons. This statement compares collections across the three species of fish, rather than comparing collections of individual types of fish across seasons. Choice C is incorrect. The claim is about which fish were collected more in winter than in other seasons. This statement is about spring, rather than winter. Choice D is incorrect. The claim is about which fish were collected more in winter than in other seasons. This statement is about fall, rather than winter, fish collections.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ea9da3ef

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: ea9da3ef

Historians point to the rule of the Piast dynasty as crucial to the formation of the Polish state. However, some differentiate between members of the dynasty like Mieszko II Lambert, who ruled as king from 1025 to 1031 CE, and less well-documented figures like Siemomysł, who is said to have ruled in the 10th century but whose historical actuality is disputed. Siemomysł appears in the *Gesta principum Polonorum*, a chronicle of medieval Polish history written between 1112 and 1118. However, the chronicle’s documentation of Siemomysł relies on oral tradition, unlike its records of later rulers.

According to the text, what is a difference between how historians view Siemomysł and how they view Mieszko II Lambert?

- A. Historians agree that Mieszko II Lambert existed, but disagree about whether Siemomysł existed.
- B. Historians believe that the *Gesta principum Polonorum* provides more evidence for Siemomysł’s existence than it does for Mieszko II Lambert’s existence.
- C. Historians agree that Siemomysł ruled Poland much later than Mieszko II Lambert.
- D. Historians find the orally transmitted stories affirming the existence of Mieszko II Lambert to be more convincing than similar stories about Siemomysł.

ID: ea9da3ef Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a statement about how historians view Siemomysł and Mieszko II Lambert that is supported by the text. The text states that the Piast dynasty had a number of different members. The text refers to two of the rulers in the Piast dynasty by name: Mieszko II Lambert, whose rule was known to have occurred from 1025 to 1031 CE, and Siemomysł ("whose historical actuality is disputed"), for whom less is known and who therefore is the subject of debate among historians. The text further casts doubt about Siemomysł by stating that he is "said to have ruled" during the 10th century, or the 900s, which suggests the possibility that he didn’t rule. The text also mentions that the chronicle’s documentation of Siemomysł relies on oral tradition, unlike its records of later rulers, including Mieszko II Lambert. This indicates that historians agree that Mieszko II Lambert was an actual historical figure, but they disagree about whether Siemomysł existed.

Choice B is incorrect because the text states that the *Gesta principum Polonorum*’s documentation of Siemomysł comes from oral tradition—spoken rather than written documentation—unlike its records of rulers who came after Siemomysł. This suggests that the chronicle provides less reliable evidence rather than more evidence for Siemomysł’s existence in the 900s (or the 10th century) than it does for later rulers like Mieszko II Lambert, who ruled from 1025 to 1031 CE. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates the opposite: Siemomysł supposedly ruled earlier in the 10th century, while Mieszko II Lambert ruled from 1025 to 1031 CE. The 10th century spans the years from 901 to 1000 CE, so Siemomysł is believed to have ruled earlier than Mieszko II Lambert did, not later as this choice states. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text mentions that information in the written chronicle *Gesta principum Polonorum* draws its information about Siemomysł from the oral tradition, it doesn’t mention orally transmitted stories about Mieszko II Lambert. Instead, it states that the chronicle’s documentation of Siemomysł relies on oral

tradition unlike the records of later rulers do, which suggests that the documentation of later rulers such as Mieszko II Lambert did not rely on oral tradition. Thus, no comparison can be made about how convincing the orally transmitted stories of each ruler are to historians.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4c51e62e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 4c51e62e

In the early nineteenth century, some Euro-American farmers in the northeastern United States used agricultural techniques developed by the Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) people centuries earlier, but it seems that few of those farmers had actually seen Haudenosaunee farms firsthand. Barring the possibility of several farmers of the same era independently developing techniques that the Haudenosaunee people had already invented, these facts most strongly suggest that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. those farmers learned the techniques from other people who were more directly influenced by Haudenosaunee practices.
- B. the crops typically cultivated by Euro-American farmers in the northeastern United States were not well suited to Haudenosaunee farming techniques.
- C. Haudenosaunee farming techniques were widely used in regions outside the northeastern United States.
- D. Euro-American farmers only began to recognize the benefits of Haudenosaunee farming techniques late in the nineteenth century.

ID: 4c51e62e Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Euro-American farmers’ use of Haudenosaunee agricultural techniques. According to the text, some Euro-American farmers were using these techniques in the early nineteenth century despite few of the farmers having seen Haudenosaunee farms. One explanation for these facts might be that the farmers developed techniques on their own that already had been invented centuries earlier by the Haudenosaunee people, but the text explicitly bars, or rules out, this explanation. If Euro-American farmers didn’t learn these techniques from direct observation of Haudenosaunee practices and didn’t invent the techniques independently, then the most logical explanation is that they learned the techniques from other people who were more directly influenced by Haudenosaunee practices than the farmers themselves were. Once they learned about Haudenosaunee agricultural practices, Euro-American farmers could then apply those practices to their own farming.

Choice B is incorrect because the fact that some Euro-American farmers in the northeastern United States were using Haudenosaunee techniques suggests that the techniques were likely useful for the crops the farmers raised, not that the crops typically cultivated by the farmers were not well suited to Haudenosaunee farming techniques. If the farmers’ crops were ill suited to the techniques, it’s unlikely that the farmers would have used those techniques. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates only that Haudenosaunee agricultural techniques were used by Euro-American farmers in the northeastern United States, not that these techniques were widely used outside this region. Choice D is incorrect because the text states that some Euro-American farmers were using Haudenosaunee farming techniques early in the nineteenth century. This suggests that some Euro-American farmers were beginning to recognize the benefits of these techniques near the start of the century, not that such farmers only began to recognize the benefits of the techniques much later.

Question ID 73db5660

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 73db5660

In many of his sculptures, artist Richard Hunt uses broad forms rather than extreme accuracy to hint at specific people or ideas. In his first major work, *Arachne* (1956), Hunt constructed the mythical character Arachne, a weaver who was changed into a spider, by welding bits of steel together into something that, although vaguely human, is strange and machine-like. And his large bronze sculpture *The Light of Truth* (2021) commemorates activist and journalist Ida B. Wells using mainly flowing, curved pieces of metal that create stylized flame.

Which choice best states the text’s main idea about Hunt?

- A. He often depicts the subjects of his sculptures using an unrealistic style.
- B. He uses different kinds of materials depending on what kind of sculpture he plans to create.
- C. He tends to base his art on important historical figures rather than on fictional characters.
- D. He has altered his approach to sculpture over time, and his works have become increasingly abstract.

ID: 73db5660 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately states the main idea of the text. According to the text, many of Richard Hunt’s sculptures “use broad forms rather than extreme accuracy”—in other words, they are more abstract than realistic. To illustrate Hunt’s abstract approach, the text characterizes his sculpture of Arachne as “vaguely human” and his work in honor of Ida B. Wells as “using mainly flowing, curved pieces of metal that create stylized flame.” Thus, the main idea is that Hunt often depicts the subjects of his sculptures using an unrealistic style.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the text indicates that one of Hunt’s sculptures is made of steel and another of bronze, there is no mention of why he chose these materials. Choice C is incorrect because the text says nothing about how Hunt chose the subjects for his sculptures. Furthermore, of the two examples provided in the text, only Ida B. Wells is an important historical figure; Arachne is a “mythical character.” Choice D is incorrect because the text says nothing about how Hunt’s style changed over time. In fact, although the two examples of Hunt’s work discussed in the text were created 65 years apart, they are both described as heavily stylized rather than realistic, which may suggest that some aspects of Hunt’s style haven’t changed over that time.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a1d9b5ac

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: a1d9b5ac

Accomplished printmaker and sculptor Elizabeth Catlett (1915–2012) used her art to explore the Black experience in the United States. In a paper for an art history class, a student claims that Catlett had a particular talent for unifying various artistic traditions and styles in her work.

Which quotation from a scholar describing Catlett’s work would best support the student’s claim?

- A. “In *Mother and Child*, a sculpture of two Black figures, Catlett used an ancient Indigenous sculpting technique and combined the visual aesthetic of modern Mexican muralists with that of German artist Kathe Kollwitz.”
- B. “In her collage *New Generation*, Catlett overlaid fabric onto the canvas to represent the clothing of a father and his toddler, positioned to evoke classic images of a mother and child.”
- C. “Created in 1968, Catlett’s sculpture *Black Unity*, a stylized fist sculpted from mahogany and measuring two feet across, remains an important piece and has received renewed and well-deserved attention in recent years.”
- D. “One series of Catlett’s prints, made by the artist using the linoleum cut method, depicts several notable African American women, including Harriet Tubman and Sojourner Truth.”

ID: a1d9b5ac Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it presents a quotation about Elizabeth Catlett that supports the student’s claim that this artist had a talent for unifying various traditions and styles in her work. The quotation explains that to create the work, Catlett combined Indigenous sculpture with the visual aesthetic of modern muralists from Mexico as well as that of German artist Kathe Kollwitz. In other words, Catlett was able to unify several artistic traditions and styles within a single sculpture.

Choice B is incorrect because in discussing the technique and subject matter of Catlett’s collage, the quotation makes no reference to particular traditions or styles. Choice C is incorrect because in describing the sculpture, the quotation doesn’t mention any artistic traditions or styles that Catlett may have synthesized to create the work. Choice D is incorrect because in discussing Catlett’s prints of notable African American women, the quotation doesn’t characterize those prints as having fused different traditions or styles.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6e2c1b7b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 6e2c1b7b

The following text is Vita Sackville-West’s circa 1920 poem “Evening.” Spars are ships’ masts, moorings are ropes that hold docked ships in place, and a riding-light is a light that a ship shines when it is anchored.

When little lights in little ports come out,
Quivering down through water with the stars,
And all the fishing fleet of slender spars
Range at their moorings, veer with tide about;

When race of wind is stilled and sails are furled,
And underneath our single riding-light
The curve of black-ribbed deck gleams palely white,
And slumbrous waters pool a slumbrous world;

—Then, and then only, have I thought how sweet
Old age might sink upon a windy youth,
Quiet beneath the riding-light of truth,
Weathered through storms, and gracious in retreat.

- Which choice best states the main idea of the text?
- A. The tranquility of a port in the evening can incline a person to appreciate the stillness of old age.
 - B. The difficulty of bringing a ship into port is apt training for dealing with the types of struggles encountered in old age.
 - C. A person who leads a long life that is varied and active may find it difficult to stay in a calm place.
 - D. The contrast between the peacefulness of a port at night and its activity during the day reflects the contrast between the calm of old age and the vibrancy of youth.

ID: 6e2c1b7b Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it best states the main idea of the text. The speaker describes an evening scene observed from a boat: "little lights in little ports come out" and are reflected in the water’s surface "with the stars," fishing boats are moored, "sails are furled" (rolled up), and the riding-light is shining. The speaker emphasizes the calmness of the scene, noting that the "race of wind is stilled" and the atmosphere is sleepy ("slumbrous waters pool a slumbrous world"), and then indicates that the calmness prompts thoughts of how old age might be "sweet" and "quiet" and "gracious in retreat" after "a windy youth" with "storms." Thus, the main idea is that the tranquility of a port in the evening can lead a person to appreciate the potential stillness of old age.

Choice B is incorrect because the speaker isn't discussing the difficulty of bringing a ship into port but describing the calmness of the port at night. And rather than suggesting that old age involves struggles, the speaker suggests that after "a windy youth" with "storms" to be weathered, old age will be "sweet," "quiet," and "gracious"—that is, old age will be tranquil like a port at night. Choice C is incorrect because the speaker isn't suggesting that a person who has lived a varied and active life might find it difficult to stay in a calm place in old age. On the contrary, the speaker suggests that after a "windy youth" with "storms," old age can be welcomed as something "sweet," "quiet," and "gracious," just like a calm port at night. Choice D is incorrect. Although the speaker does touch on the idea of a "windy youth" followed by "sweet old age," the speaker doesn't tie that idea to a contrast between daytime activity and nighttime peacefulness at a port. The speaker doesn't address any activity during the day at a port, only briefly mentioning that the "race of wind is stilled" at the end of the day, and instead focuses on the tranquility of the port at night and how it prompts thoughts of "quiet" and "gracious" old age.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5b5d2553

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: 5b5d2553

Aptamers—synthetic DNA or RNA molecules that bind to target molecules—can be used to test for foodborne bacterial pathogens, though their specificity (the probability of returning a negative result in the absence of the focal pathogen) in real-world foods has been unclear. Sandeep Somvanshi et al. fabricated test paper incorporating aptamers targeting strain O157:H7 of the bacteria *Escherichia coli*; the paper shifts from pink to purple as the aptamers bind to target molecules. Somvanshi et al. tested the paper in store-bought pear juice they treated with *E. coli* O157:H7, other strains of *E. coli*, or other bacteria species. Following exposure, the paper from the O157:H7 test was purple while papers from the other tests were pink, suggesting that _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. aptamer-based tests in real-world foods are more likely to show a high degree of specificity if the focal pathogen is *E. coli* O157:H7 than if the focal pathogen is another strain of *E. coli* or another species.
- B. uncertainty about the specificity of aptamer-based tests for pathogens in real-world foods may be due to the similarity between *E. coli* O157:H7 and other *E. coli* strains.
- C. the specificity of the tests in a real-world food was unaffected by the aptamers’ tendency to bind to different strains of *E. coli*.
- D. the aptamers successfully bound to *E. coli* O157:H7 and the tests displayed a high degree of specificity in a real-world food.

ID: 5b5d2553 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of aptamers’ capacity to test for pathogens in food. The text explains that although synthetic aptamer molecules can be used to test for foodborne bacterial pathogens because they bind to target molecules, it hasn’t been clear how likely it is that they will indicate a negative result when a target pathogen is absent in real-world foods. The text then indicates that Somvanshi et al. created test paper that changes from pink to purple when aptamers in it bind to a particular strain of *E. coli* bacteria, O157:H7, and tested it with store-bought pear juice (that is, a real-world food); the paper changed to purple when exposed to juice to which the target pathogen *E. coli* O157:H7 had been added, but it remained pink when exposed to juice treated with other *E. coli* strains or other bacteria species. Based on this result, it seems the aptamers in the paper successfully bound to the target (O157:H7) and the tests had a high degree of specificity (providing negative results for samples where the target was absent even though other bacteria were present) when applied to a real-world food.

Choice A is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that *E. coli* O157:H7 differs from other pathogens in a way that makes it more suitable for aptamer-based testing of any kind and that specificity is likely to be lower when aptamer-based tests target other bacteria; the text simply indicates that Somvanshi et al. used O157:H7 as the target for aptamer-based test paper in their study and suggests that the paper had a high degree of specificity. Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that the specificity of aptamer-based tests in real-world foods is uncertain for pathogens broadly, not just for *E. coli*, and similarity

between strains (of *E. coli* or of other pathogens) isn't mentioned. Moreover, the results presented in the text suggest that aptamers are actually capable of distinguishing between strains of *E. coli*, since Somvanshi et al.'s paper turned purple when exposed to *E. coli* O157:H7 and remained pink when exposed to other strains. Choice C is incorrect because the text suggests that the aptamers in the test papers didn't bind to different strains of *E. coli*. The text explains that the test papers turn purple when the aptamers bind to the targeted pathogen and that in the pear juice tests, the test papers turned purple when exposed to samples with the targeted strain of *E. coli* (O157:H7) but remained pink when exposed to samples with other strains of *E. coli*. In other words, the aptamers bound only to the targeted strain, not to the other strains. Further, specificity would be affected if the aptamers had bound to multiple strains and not just the targeted one; that result would cause the specificity to be low.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f77b0e52

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Inferences	

ID: f77b0e52

The increased integration of digital technologies throughout the process of book creation in the late 20th and early 21st centuries lowered the costs of book production, but those decreased costs have been most significant in the manufacturing and distribution process, which occurs after the authoring, editing, and design of the book are complete. This suggests that in the late 20th and early 21st centuries, _____

Which choice most logically completes the text?

- A. digital technologies made it easier than it had been previously for authors to write very long works and get them published.
- B. customers generally expected the cost of books to decline relative to the cost of other consumer goods.
- C. publishers increased the variety of their offerings by printing more unique titles but also printed fewer copies of each title.
- D. the costs of writing, editing, and designing a book were less affected by the technologies used than were the costs of manufacturing and distributing a book.

ID: f77b0e52 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents the conclusion that most logically follows from the text’s discussion of how digital technologies affected the process of book creation. The text explains that in the late 20th and early 21st centuries digital technologies lowered book production costs most significantly in manufacturing and distribution. The text goes on to point out that authoring, editing, and book design are distinct steps in the process that occur before manufacturing and distribution. Because the savings connected to digital technologies have been most significant in manufacturing and distribution, it’s reasonable to infer that those technologies had less of an effect on writing, editing, and designing books.

Choice A is incorrect because the text focuses on lowered book production costs that occur after authoring has taken place; there’s no indication in the text whether digital technologies made writing and publishing lengthy books easier. Choice B is incorrect. Although it’s logical to conclude that customers would expect the cost of books to decline if production costs have declined, the text doesn’t address customer expectations for the cost of books or any other consumer goods. Choice C is incorrect because the text focuses broadly on how digital technologies have affected the cost of the publishing process; it doesn’t address the kinds of books being published or how many copies are printed.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5cb4bac4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 5cb4bac4

The following text is from Thomas Mann’s 1924 novel *The Magic Mountain*, translated by John E. Woods in 1995.

The story of Hans Castorp that we intend to tell here—not for his sake (for the reader will come to know him as a perfectly ordinary, if engaging young man), but for the sake of the story itself, which seems to us to be very much worth telling (although in Hans Castorp’s favor it should be noted that it is *his* story, and that not every story happens to everybody)—is a story that took place long ago, and is, so to speak, covered with the patina of history and must necessarily be told with verbs whose tense is that of the deepest past.

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What does the text most strongly suggest about the story of Hans Castorp?

- A. Though it is true that stories of even the most uninteresting people are themselves interesting because all people are unique, the reason this story is interesting is nonetheless difficult to understand because of the passage of time.
- B. Even though it is a story of a person of no particular importance, its age and the manner in which it therefore must be told are both indicators that the story itself is important.
- C. Like all stories about the lives of inconsequential people, this story must necessarily be related in a particular way if the reason the story is consequential is to be made evident to the audience.
- D. It is a remarkable story that happened to an unremarkable person, though one could plausibly argue that because the story is valuable, some of its value accrues to the person at its center.

ID: 5cb4bac4 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a statement about Hans Castorp’s story that is suggested by the text. The narrator of the text indicates that the story about Hans Castorp will be told not because there is something particularly notable about him, since he is pleasant but "perfectly ordinary," but because the story itself is remarkable ("very much worth telling"). The narrator then notes that there is a benefit in being at the heart of the story—that it is "in Hans Castorp’s favor" that the story is his, and maybe uniquely so ("not every story happens to everybody"). Thus, the text suggests both that the story that will be told is a remarkable one that happened to an unremarkable person and that it is reasonable to argue that the person at the center of a valuable story takes on some of the story’s value.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the narrator of the text makes the point that "not every story happens to everybody," the narrator doesn’t state that stories are interesting simply because the people they are about are unique. Rather, the narrator suggests that one particular story is "very much worth telling" on its own and that Hans Castorp benefits from the fact that the story is remarkable and may be unique to him. Further, the narrator never suggests that the story will be hard to understand even though it is old. Choice B is incorrect. Although the narrator of the text suggests that Hans Castorp is of no particular importance, since he is a "perfectly ordinary" person, the narrator never reveals what makes the story of Castorp important, just that "the story itself" is

"very much worth telling." The narrator states that the story "took place long ago," is "covered with the patina of history," and can be told only "with verbs whose tense is that of the deepest past," but the story's age and the way it must be told aren't presented as reasons the story is important; the narrator is simply providing details about how the story will be told. Choice C is incorrect because the narrator of the text doesn't suggest that all stories about people who are "perfectly ordinary" (like Hans Castorp) must be told in particular ways to make it clear why those stories are consequential. Further, the narrator suggests that Hans Castorp's story must be told "with verbs whose tense is that of the deepest past" because it took place so long ago, not because telling it that way will convey the story's importance.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3f990549

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	

ID: 3f990549

The following text is adapted from William Shakespeare’s 1598 play *Henry IV, Part 1*. King Henry is addressing several noblemen who are rumored to have been disloyal to him.

KING HENRY: My blood hath been too cold and temperate,
Unapt to stir at these indignities,
And you have found me, for accordingly
You tread upon my patience; but be sure
I will from henceforth rather be myself,
Mighty and to be fear’d, than my [disposition],
Which hath been smooth as oil, soft as young down,
And therefore lost that title of respect
Which the proud soul ne’er pays but to the proud.

- Which statement best describes how King Henry presents himself in the text?
- A. He declares that he has judged the noblemen’s conduct in an impartial manner, and that despite their attempts to regain his trust through professions of submissiveness, they have irrevocably lost his respect.
 - B. He acknowledges to the noblemen that his tolerance of their conduct has undermined their respect for him, and he resolves to display his genuine nature, which is more forceful and compels deference.
 - C. He defends his calm disposition, which he sees as fundamental to his personality, and vows to maintain his tranquil demeanor even if it causes him to lose the respect of overly proud noblemen.
 - D. He concedes that he has treated the noblemen with indifference, which in part explains why they have defied him, but he asserts that their disrespectful behavior is primarily driven by their excessive pride.

ID: 3f990549 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes King Henry’s self-presentation in the text. Henry states that his temperament has been “too cold and temperate, / Unapt to stir at these indignities” (that is, too calm and slow to react to insults), and he asserts that the noblemen have taken advantage of this: “accordingly / You tread upon my patience.” He then resolves to change, declaring he will “from henceforth rather be myself, / Mighty and to be fear’d,” since being lenient (“smooth as oil, soft as young down”) has caused him to lose “that title of respect / Which the proud soul ne’er pays but to the proud.” In other words, Henry recognizes that proud people like the noblemen respect only strength and resolves to show his more forceful, true nature.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t describe Henry as having judged the noblemen impartially, nor does it mention any attempts by the noblemen to regain his trust through submissiveness. Rather, Henry describes the noblemen as taking advantage of his patience and declares he will adopt a more commanding demeanor in the future. Choice C is incorrect. Although Henry

concedes that he has perhaps been too calm and mild, Henry does not defend or vow to maintain his calm disposition. On the contrary, he explicitly states he will “from henceforth rather be myself, / Mighty and to be fear’d,” resolving to abandon the mild manner that has cost him the respect of the noblemen. Choice D is incorrect because Henry characterizes his manner as patient and mild—“smooth as oil, soft as young down”—not indifferent. Indifference implies a lack of concern, whereas Henry describes himself as being overly lenient. Additionally, although the final lines mention “the proud soul,” the focus is not on the noblemen’s excessive pride but rather on how Henry’s apparent *lack* of pride has caused him to lose the noblemen’s respect.

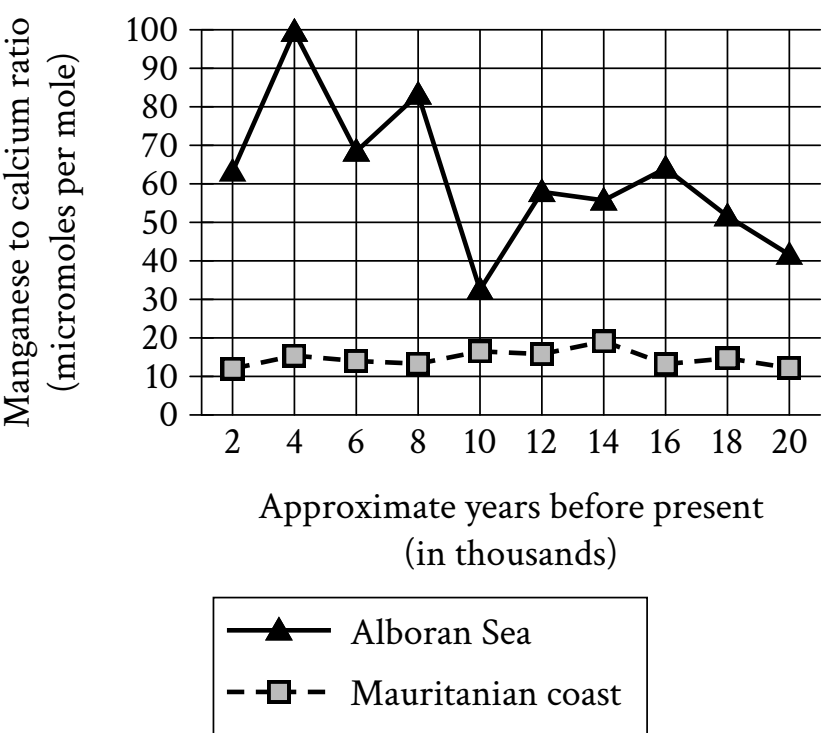
Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bb8f130e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Command of Evidence	

ID: bb8f130e

Ratio of Manganese to Calcium in Samples from Alboran Sea and Mauritanian Coast



The population of the coral *Lophelia pertusa* declined significantly around 9,000 years ago in the Alboran Sea and around 11,000 years ago near the Mauritanian coast. Using the ratio of manganese to calcium, which inversely correlates with ocean oxygenation levels, marine scientist Rodrigo da Costa Portilho-Ramos and colleagues evaluated whether oxygenation played a role in the declines of *L. pertusa*. The researchers concluded that oxygenation may have been important in the Alboran Sea but not near the Mauritanian coast, since _____

Which choice most effectively uses data from the graph to complete the statement?

- A. a substantial increase in oxygenation in the Alboran Sea corresponded with the local decline in *L. pertusa*, but the opposite relationship between oxygenation and *L. pertusa* was found near the Mauritanian coast.
- B. *L. pertusa* declined in the Alboran Sea during a period of substantial local decline in oxygenation, but *L. pertusa* declined near the Mauritanian coast during a period of little local change in oxygenation.
- C. oxygenation in the Alboran Sea was higher before the decline in *L. pertusa* than after the decline, whereas oxygenation near the Mauritanian coast was relatively low both before and after the decline in *L. pertusa*.
- D. oxygenation in the Alboran Sea tended to be substantially higher than oxygenation near the Mauritanian coast during the period studied.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it effectively uses data from the graph to complete the statement about Rodrigo da Costa Portilho-Ramos and colleagues' conclusion. The graph shows the ratio of manganese to calcium in *L. pertusa* coral samples from the Alboran Sea and the Mauritanian coast. The graph reflects time in approximate years before present: in other words, the greater the number in years noted on the graph's horizontal axis, the farther that moment is in the past. The text indicates that the researchers tested the samples to determine whether oxygenation played a role in the decline of *L. pertusa*. The text goes on to note that a change in the ratio of manganese to calcium would signal an inverse, or opposite, change in oxygenation. According to the graph, the ratio of manganese to calcium in samples from the Alboran Sea increased from about 30 micromoles per mole 10,000 years ago to about 80 micromoles per mole 8,000 years ago, which means that oxygenation decreased between 10,000 and 8,000 years ago. Meanwhile, there was almost no discernible change in the ratio of manganese to calcium in samples from the Mauritanian coast between 12,000 and 10,000 years ago. According to the text, the population of *L. pertusa* declined significantly around 9,000 years ago in the Alboran Sea and around 11,000 years ago near the Mauritanian coast. Thus, the increase in the ratio of manganese to calcium around 9,000 years ago in the Alboran Sea coincides with the decline in the *L. pertusa* population, suggesting an association between the decrease in oxygenation and the decline in population of the coral. No such relationship is suggested around 11,000 years ago near the Mauritanian coast. So, oxygenation likely played a role in the *L. pertusa* decline in the Alboran Sea but not in the coral's decline near the Mauritanian coast.

Choice A is incorrect because it asserts the opposite of what the graph indicates regarding oxygenation in the Alboran Sea, and it misrepresents what the graph indicates about oxygenation near the Mauritanian coast. The graph indicates that at the time of the decline in *L. pertusa* (approximately 9,000 years ago), the samples from the Alboran Sea contained a ratio of manganese to calcium that was increasing. According to the text, this ratio inversely correlates with ocean oxygenation levels, so if the ratio was increasing, oxygenation was decreasing, not substantially increasing. Furthermore, the graph shows that the ratio of manganese to calcium remained relatively stable in coral samples from the Mauritanian coast during the period studied, which suggests that there was no discernible relationship between oxygenation and the coral's population decline in that location, not that there was a substantial decrease in oxygenation corresponding to the coral's decline. Choice C is incorrect. Although the graph suggests that the level of oxygenation in the Alboran Sea was higher before the decline in *L. pertusa* than after—because the ratio of manganese to calcium inversely correlates with ocean oxygenation levels and this ratio was lower before the decline than after—the graph doesn't support the claim that oxygenation near the Mauritanian coast was consistently low before and after the coral's decline there. Rather, the graph indicates that relative to coral samples from the Alboran Sea, the ratio of manganese to calcium in samples from near the Mauritanian coast was consistently low, which suggests that oxygenation levels were relatively high both before and after the decline of *L. pertusa*. Choice D is incorrect because it states the opposite of what the graph indicates: the graph shows that throughout the period studied, the ratio of manganese to calcium was higher in coral samples from the Alboran Sea than it was in samples from near the Mauritanian coast. Since the text indicates that the ratio of manganese to calcium inversely correlates with ocean oxygenation levels, oxygenation in the Alboran Sea was therefore lower than, not higher than, oxygenation near the Mauritanian coast during the period studied. Moreover, even if choice D did accurately represent the graph, it wouldn't effectively complete the statement since a comparison of the ocean oxygenation levels at the two locations is not relevant to the claim that a decline in oxygenation levels was associated with the decline of *L. pertusa* in the Alboran Sea but not near the Mauritanian coast.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8f7afae9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 8f7afae9

Set in a world where science fiction tropes exist as everyday realities, Charles Yu’s 2010 novel *How to Live Safely in a Science Fictional Universe* traces a time traveler’s quest to find his father. Because the journey at the novel’s center is so _____, with the protagonist ricocheting chaotically across time, the reader often wonders whether the pair will ever be reunited.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. haphazard
- B. premeditated
- C. inspirational
- D. fruitless

ID: 8f7afae9 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Yu’s novel. In this context, “haphazard” means marked by a lack of plan or order. The text indicates that the quest featured in the novel, which involves the protagonist bouncing across time, is chaotic and causes the reader to often wonder what will happen. This context suggests that the protagonist’s journey seems to be marked by a lack of order.

Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that the journey featured in Yu’s novel involves a character “ricocheting chaotically,” or bouncing in a disordered way, across time and causes the reader to often wonder what will happen. It wouldn’t make sense to say that a chaotic journey seems “premeditated,” or characterized by forethought and planning. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t give any indication that readers regard the journey in Yu’s novel as “inspirational,” or as causing extraordinarily creative or brilliant thoughts or actions; instead, the text focuses on the idea that the protagonist’s journey is chaotic, or disordered, and doesn’t give readers a clear sense of what will happen. Choice D is incorrect. Rather than suggesting that the journey featured in Yu’s novel is “fruitless,” or has an unsuccessful outcome, the text focuses on the idea that while reading about the protagonist’s chaotic movements across time, readers are often unsure of what will happen—that is, they don’t know whether the protagonist will be successful in finding his father.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1fc1a8f1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 1fc1a8f1

During Rome’s republican period, which ended in the first century BCE, libraries were predominantly owned by wealthy individuals who tightly controlled access to their book collections. The first public library became available in Rome in 28 BCE and was soon followed by one commissioned by Emperor Augustus. As modern scholar Fabio Fernandes notes, however, these two traditions aren’t as distinct as they seem, as both the emperor and the private library owners viewed their libraries as extensions of their personal patronage, just on vastly differing scales.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To give a brief overview of public access to libraries throughout Rome’s republican period
- B. To contend that early imperial leaders in Rome wielded too much influence over libraries
- C. To assert that private and early public libraries in ancient Rome had an essential similarity
- D. To call into question the notion that private Roman libraries disappeared during the first century BCE

ID: 1fc1a8f1 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text. The text describes two types of libraries in first-century BCE Rome—private libraries controlled by wealthy individuals, and the public libraries like that commissioned by Emperor Augustus—and then notes that “these two traditions aren’t as distinct as they seem.” It explains that both private-library owners and the emperor saw their libraries as “extensions of their personal patronage, just on vastly differing scales,” because the emperor’s patronage extended to the whole citizenry of Rome. Thus, both private and public libraries in ancient Rome were fundamentally tied to relevant principles of patronage.

Choice A is incorrect because the text mentions that Rome’s republican period only to say that it “ended in the first century BCE,” thus it doesn’t support any conclusions about possible occurrences “throughout Rome’s republican period.” Choice B is incorrect. The text neither discusses “early imperial leaders in Rome,” nor whether their level of influence was appropriate. Rather it discusses the end of “Rome’s republican period” in relation to libraries, who created them, and who got to use them without passing judgment on propriety. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text indicates that Rome’s republican period “ended in the first century BCE,” a period that also saw the first public library come into use (28 BCE), nothing in the text suggests that private libraries disappeared at that time.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 222ff46e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 222ff46e

Scholarly accounts of the Chicano movement—a movement that advocated for the social, political, and cultural empowerment of Mexican Americans and reached its zenith in the 1960s and 1970s—tend to focus on the most militant, outspoken figures in the movement, making it seem uniformly radical. Geographer Juan Herrera has shown, however, that if we shift our focus toward the way the movement manifested in comparatively low-profile neighborhood institutions and projects, we see participants espousing an array of political orientations and approaches to community activism.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. It presents a trend in scholarship on the Chicano movement that the text claims has been reevaluated by researchers in light of Herrera’s work on the movement’s participants.
- B. It identifies an aspect of the Chicano movement that the text implies was overemphasized by scholars due to their own political orientations.
- C. It describes a common approach to studying the Chicano movement that, according to the text, obscures the ideological diversity of the movement’s participants.
- D. It summarizes the conventional method for analyzing the Chicano movement, which the text suggests creates a misleading impression of the effectiveness of neighborhood institutions and projects.

ID: 222ff46e Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes how the underlined portion functions in the text as a whole. The text begins by mentioning scholarly accounts of the Chicano movement, which the underlined portion describes as tending "to focus on the most militant, outspoken figures in the movement," making the movement as a whole seem uniformly radical. The text then indicates that the work of geographer Juan Herrera shows that focusing less on such militant figures and instead paying more attention to manifestations of the Chicano movement in less widely known neighborhood institutions and projects would reveal that the movement’s participants embraced a range of political orientations and approaches. Thus, the underlined portion describes a common approach to studying the Chicano movement that, according to the text, obscures the ideological diversity of the movement’s participants.

Choice A is incorrect. Though the underlined portion does present a trend in scholarship on the Chicano movement, the text does not indicate that other scholars have reevaluated their methods in light of Herrera’s work. It only indicates that Herrera’s work suggests that the work of those other scholars does not provide a complete picture of the Chicano movement. Choice B is incorrect. Though the underlined portion does identify an aspect of the Chicano movement that the text indicates has been overemphasized, the text does not discuss the political orientations of the scholars whose work is mentioned in the text. Choice D is incorrect. Though the underlined portion does summarize the conventional method for analyzing the Chicano movement, the

rest of the text does not address the effectiveness of "comparatively low-profile neighborhood institutions and projects." Instead, the text suggests that those projects were led by people with a variety of approaches to community activism.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a9cd4b1c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: a9cd4b1c

While recent scholarship has undermined claims that the works of twelfth-century Islamic philosopher Ibn Rushd were _____ other Muslim philosophers of his time, it is indisputable that his location in the Muslim-ruled area of what is now Spain meant that his works were primarily available thousands of miles west of the era’s center of Islamic thought.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. controversial among
- B. antagonistic toward
- C. imitated by
- D. inconsequential to

ID: a9cd4b1c Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the twelfth-century Islamic philosopher Ibn Rushd. As used in this context, "inconsequential to" means not significant to. According to the text, Ibn Rushd’s works were primarily available in Spain, where he lived, far from central areas of the Muslim world, a fact that could support the conclusion that his influence on Muslim contemporaries was limited. The text implies, however, that recent scholarship has shown that his works still had an impact on other Muslim philosophers of his time. This context supports the idea that his works weren’t inconsequential to Islamic thought in this period.

Choice A is incorrect because the issue under consideration in the text is whether other Muslim philosophers of Ibn Rushd’s time had access to his works, not whether his works were "controversial among," or causing dispute among, other philosophers. Choice B is incorrect. The text implies that other Muslim philosophers of Ibn Rushd’s era were aware of his works, not that they were "antagonistic toward," or hostile toward, them. There is no suggestion that Ibn Rushd’s writings elicited hostility from his contemporaries. Choice C is incorrect because in this context, "imitated by" would mean followed as a model by. Although the text implies that Ibn Rushd’s works were at least somewhat available in regions that were at the center of Islamic thought during the period, it doesn’t specifically address in what ways his works influenced contemporary Muslim philosophers. Thus, the text doesn’t support the idea that other philosophers modeled their own works after Ibn Rushd’s works.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 79beb4da

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 79beb4da

Michelene Pesantubbee, a historian and citizen of the Choctaw Nation, has identified a dilemma inherent to research on the status of women in her tribe during the 1600s and 1700s: the primary sources from that era, travel narratives and other accounts by male European colonizers, underestimate the degree of power conferred on Choctaw women by their traditional roles in political, civic, and ceremonial life. Pesantubbee argues that the Choctaw oral tradition and findings from archaeological sites in the tribe’s homeland supplement the written record by providing crucial insights into those roles.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It details the shortcomings of certain historical sources, then argues that research should avoid those sources altogether.
- B. It describes a problem that arises in research on a particular topic, then sketches a historian’s approach to addressing that problem.
- C. It lists the advantages of a particular research method, then acknowledges a historian’s criticism of that method.
- D. It characterizes a particular topic as especially challenging to research, then suggests a related topic for historians to pursue instead.

ID: 79beb4da Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text begins by stating a problem with research on the status of Choctaw women in the 1600s and 1700s: written primary sources underestimate the power they had in their traditional roles. Then it presents one historian’s solution: looking to oral tradition and archeological findings for more insight into these roles.

Choice A is incorrect. This isn’t the overall structure. The text never says that research should avoid written primary sources, just that research should also use oral tradition and archeological sites as sources. Choice C is incorrect. This isn’t the overall structure. The text never mentions the advantages of using written primary sources. Choice D is incorrect. This isn’t the overall structure. The text never says that the status of Choctaw women during the 1600s and 1700s is too challenging to research. And it doesn’t mention any other topics to research instead.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f6b74e80

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: f6b74e80

A number of Indigenous politicians have been elected to the United States Congress since 2000 as members of the country’s two established political parties. In Canada and several Latin American countries, on the other hand, Indigenous people have formed their own political parties to advance candidates who will advocate for the interests of their communities. This movement has been particularly successful in Ecuador, where Guadalupe Llori, a member of the Indigenous party known as Pachakutik, was elected president of the National Assembly in 2021.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To trace the history of an Indigenous political movement and speculate about its future development
- B. To argue that Indigenous politicians in the United States should form their own political party
- C. To highlight two approaches to achieving political representation for Indigenous people
- D. To consider how Indigenous politicians in the United States have influenced Indigenous politicians in Canada and Latin America

ID: f6b74e80 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to illustrate two approaches that Indigenous politicians have taken to achieve political representation for their communities. The text begins by explaining that one approach is exemplified by Indigenous politicians in the United States who, in an effort to ensure that the interests of their communities are represented in government, joined preexisting political parties and were subsequently elected to Congress. The text goes on to highlight a second approach adopted by Indigenous leaders in Canada and several Latin American countries: rather than joining established political parties, many Indigenous politicians in these countries have instead formed their own parties to promote candidates for office who support causes that are important to their communities.

Choice A is incorrect because the text’s focus is on the contrasting approaches adopted by different Indigenous political movements in different countries; thus, it isn’t accurate to say that the text traces the history of one political movement. Moreover, the text only discusses examples from 2000 to 2021, a relatively short period of time; therefore, it provides very little in the way of discussion of larger historical developments, nor does it make any predictions about how these movements might continue to develop in the future. Choice B is incorrect because the text never urges Indigenous politicians in the US to alter their strategy of striving for representation through the established political parties, nor does it suggest that this strategy is inferior to that of Indigenous politicians in Canada and Latin America, who have formed their own parties. In fact, the text notes that both strategies have resulted in the election of Indigenous politicians to national governments. Choice D is incorrect because the text never suggests that Indigenous politicians in the US have influenced those in Canada and Latin America; instead, it stresses how Indigenous politicians’ approach toward achieving representation in the US government has differed from the approach Indigenous politicians have taken to achieve representation in national governments elsewhere in the Americas.

Question ID c85dc4ff

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: c85dc4ff

The people of medieval Europe have traditionally been seen as uninterested in cleanliness and hygiene, but modern research has shown that this is largely a myth. According to historian Eleanor Janega, most medieval towns in Europe had at least one public bathhouse, which often offered both full-immersion baths and—more affordably—steam baths. While such amenities were available mainly to town dwellers, regular bathing in rivers and streams or daily sponge baths at home were common practices throughout medieval Europe.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion?

- A. It asserts that in medieval Europe steam baths were more popular in rural areas than in urban ones.
- B. It describes a limitation of earlier historians’ studies of medieval European bathing habits.
- C. It concedes that not all people in medieval Europe had access to public bathhouses.
- D. It explains why Janega decided to study the popularity of public bathhouses in medieval Europe.

ID: c85dc4ff Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most effectively describes the function of the underlined portion. The text discusses the long-standing misconception that people in medieval Europe were uninterested in cleanliness and hygiene. As evidence that this idea is false, the text cites historian Eleanor Janega’s assertion that in medieval Europe, towns usually had at least one bathhouse, where people could take immersion baths or steam baths for a fee. The underlined portion then notes that mainly town dwellers had access to these bathhouses. The remainder of the text explains that those who lacked such access were nonetheless able to bathe in outdoor waterways or take sponge baths at home. Therefore, the underlined portion concedes that some people in medieval Europe lacked access to public bathhouses.

Choice A is incorrect. The underlined portion establishes that amenities such as steam baths were mainly available to town dwellers, which suggests in turn that steam baths were largely unavailable to people in rural areas. Thus, the distinction made by the underlined portion is not between the popularity of steam baths in towns versus their lack of popularity in rural areas but instead between their presence in towns and absence in rural areas. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text does explain that recent historians have disproved the idea that medieval Europeans rarely bathed, it doesn’t attribute that misconception to earlier historians of medieval Europe or suggest that their research was subject to limitations. Moreover, the underlined portion addresses a limitation of life in medieval Europe, not of historical research. Choice D is incorrect because the underlined portion doesn’t address why historian Eleanor Janega decided to study the popularity of public bathhouses in medieval Europe—nor does any portion of the text. The text mentions Janega in passing, but it doesn’t go into detail about why she decided to study the popularity of public bathhouses in medieval Europe.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1903629b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 1903629b

In *Nature Poem* (2017), Kumeyaay poet Tommy Pico portrays his _____ the natural world by honoring the centrality of nature within his tribe’s traditional beliefs while simultaneously expressing his distaste for being in wilderness settings himself.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. responsiveness to
- B. ambivalence toward
- C. renunciation of
- D. mastery over

ID: 1903629b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s description of how Pico feels about the natural world. In this context, to say that Pico portrays his “ambivalence toward” nature would mean that he portrays his mixed feelings about nature. The text explains that Pico “honors the centrality of nature” and also makes it clear that he doesn’t enjoy being in nature. This context suggests that Pico feels ambivalence toward nature.

Choice A is incorrect because saying that Pico portrays his “responsiveness to” nature would mean that he portrays himself as quick to react to nature, which isn’t supported by the text. Instead, the text focuses on Pico’s mixed feelings toward nature, describing him as both honoring nature’s role in his tribe’s beliefs and expressing his personal dislike for being in nature. Choice C is incorrect because saying that Pico portrays his “renunciation of” nature would mean that he portrays himself as rejecting nature, which isn’t supported by the text. The text conveys that Pico demonstrates both positive and negative responses toward nature, not that he’s giving it up completely. Choice D is incorrect because saying that Pico portrays his “mastery over” nature would mean that he portrays himself as having control over nature, which isn’t supported by the text. The text focuses on Pico’s mixed feelings about nature; nothing in the text suggests that Pico feels mastery over nature.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f8685972

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: f8685972

Players of online games are largely aware that the games collect their data, and they’re often willing to trade some privacy for a fun experience. But the games are often quite _____ about what data they collect and why. Because of this, data-privacy advocates are seeking to expand online players’ knowledge of data collection practices and improve their ability to navigate privacy-setting features in games.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. opaque
- B. abrasive
- C. ambivalent
- D. outspoken

ID: f8685972 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of how online games disclose information about their data collection practices. In this context, “opaque” means that games deliberately avoid sharing clear information about data collection. The text indicates that data-privacy advocates are working to “expand online players’ knowledge of data collection practices” and improve players’ ability to navigate privacy settings. The fact that advocates are working to expand players’ knowledge about data collection and privacy settings implies that players currently lack clear information about these aspects of the games. This context therefore supports the idea that online games are often quite unclear, or opaque, about what data they collect and why.

Choice B is incorrect because describing online games as being “abrasive,” or harsh and irritating, about their data collection practices wouldn’t make sense in context. The text focuses on the clarity of the information about data collection that games share with players, not on the tone or manner in which this information is communicated. Choice C is incorrect because describing the games as “ambivalent,” or having mixed feelings, about their data collection practices wouldn’t make sense in context. The text isn’t discussing the game companies’ attitudes toward their own practices; it’s discussing the extent to which information about those practices is communicated to players. Choice D is incorrect because describing online games as “outspoken,” or frank and forthright, about their data collection practices would contradict the text. If the games were forthright about data collection, data-privacy advocates wouldn’t need to work to expand players’ awareness of this aspect of gaming. Instead, the text emphasizes the challenge of obtaining clear information about data collection in online games.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 13fc1248

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 13fc1248

Economist Marco Castillo and colleagues showed that nuisance costs—the time and effort people must spend to make donations—reduce charitable giving. Charities can mitigate this effect by compensating donors for nuisance costs, but those costs, though variable, are largely _____ donation size, so charities that compensate donors will likely favor attracting a few large donors over many small donors.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. supplemental to
- B. predictive of
- C. independent of
- D. subsumed in

ID: 13fc1248 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. We’re told that charities that pay donors back for nuisance costs will attract a few large donors instead of many small donors. This suggests that nuisance costs are not linked to donation size.

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t fit the logic of the text. If nuisance costs are supplemental to (meaning in addition to) donation size, that wouldn’t result in charities that compensate donors for those costs attracting a few large donors over many small donors. Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t fit the logic of the text. If nuisance costs can predict donation size, that wouldn’t necessarily result in charities that compensate donors for those costs attracting a few large donors over many small donors. Choice D is incorrect. This doesn’t fit the logic of the text. If nuisance costs are subsumed in (meaning included in) donation size, that wouldn’t result in charities that compensate donors for those costs attracting a few large donors over many small donors.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a396d9ed

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-text Connections	

ID: a396d9ed

Text 1

When companies in the same industry propose merging with one another, they often claim that the merger will benefit consumers by increasing efficiency and therefore lowering prices. Economist Ying Fan investigated this notion in the context of the United States newspaper market. She modeled a hypothetical merger of Minneapolis-area newspapers and found that subscription prices would rise following a merger.

Text 2

Economists Dario Focarelli and Fabio Panetta have argued that research on the effect of mergers on prices has focused excessively on short-term effects, which tend to be adverse for consumers. Using the case of consumer banking in Italy, they show that over the long term (several years, in their study), the efficiency gains realized by merged companies do result in economic benefits for consumers.

Based on the texts, how would Focarelli and Panetta (Text 2) most likely respond to Fan’s findings (Text 1)?

- A. They would recommend that Fan compare the near-term effect of a merger on subscription prices in the Minneapolis area with the effect of a merger in another newspaper market.
- B. They would argue that over the long term the expenses incurred by the merged newspaper company will also increase.
- C. They would encourage Fan to investigate whether the projected effect on subscription prices persists over an extended period.
- D. They would claim that mergers have a different effect on consumer prices in the newspaper industry than in most other industries.

ID: a396d9ed Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because, based on the information presented in the texts, it represents how Focarelli and Panetta would most likely respond to Fan’s findings. Text 1 indicates that Fan found that a newspaper merger would result in a rise in subscription prices. This rise wouldn’t benefit customers, who would have to pay more for news after a merger. Text 2 presents Focarelli and Panetta’s argument that merger research tends to focus too much on what happens immediately after the merger. Text 2 goes on to describe their finding that mergers can be economically beneficial for consumers over the long term. This suggests that Focarelli and Panetta would encourage Fan to investigate the long-term effect of the hypothetical newspaper merger on subscription prices.

Choice A is incorrect because Text 2 doesn’t indicate that Focarelli and Panetta connect the effects of mergers to specific locations. Instead, Focarelli and Panetta focus on the length of time over which the effects of mergers should be evaluated. Choice B is incorrect because Text 2 indicates that Focarelli and Panetta found that merged companies experience "efficiency

gains" over the long term, meaning that their expenses go down relative to their output, not that their expenses increase. Choice D is incorrect because there's no indication in Text 2 that Focarelli and Panetta believe that the newspaper industry is different from any other industry when it comes to the effects of mergers. Although their own research was about consumer banking, Text 2 suggests that they view their conclusions as applicable to mergers in general.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3be2be08

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 3be2be08

While scholars believe many Mesoamerican cities influenced each other, direct evidence of such influence is difficult to ascertain. However, recent excavations in a sector of Tikal (Guatemala) unearthed a citadel that shows _____ Teotihuacán (Mexico) architecture—including a near replica of a famed Teotihuacán temple—providing tangible evidence of outside influence in portions of Tikal.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. refinements of
- B. precursors of
- C. commonalities with
- D. animosities toward

ID: 3be2be08 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of architectural influences among Mesoamerican cities. In this context, “commonalities with” means similarities to or shared attributes with. The text indicates that a recently discovered citadel in Tikal includes a close imitation of a famous temple in Teotihuacán (another Mesoamerican city) and other evidence of Teotihuacán influence, which suggests that the citadel possesses features that resemble architectural features found in Teotihuacán. This context thus indicates that the Tikal citadel shows commonalities with Teotihuacán architecture.

Choice A is incorrect because there’s nothing in the text that suggests that the Tikal citadel shows “refinements of,” or improvements on, Teotihuacán architecture. Although the text suggests that the architecture of Teotihuacán influenced the architecture of the Tikal citadel, and although it’s possible that later architectural designs could make improvements on earlier designs, the text doesn’t discuss whether, in imitating Teotihuacán architecture, the Tikal citadel’s builders improved on it. Choice B is incorrect because describing the citadel in Tikal as showing “precursors of” Teotihuacán architecture—or features that preceded and foreshadowed those of Teotihuacán architecture—would imply the opposite of what the text suggests about the relationship between the architecture found in Tikal and Teotihuacán. The text claims that the discovery of similarities between the Tikal citadel and the architecture of Teotihuacán, including a replica of a temple in Teotihuacán, provides evidence of outside influences on Tikal architecture. If the Tikal citadel was influenced by Teotihuacán architecture, then the Teotihuacán architecture must predate the citadel, not the other way around. In this context, therefore, it wouldn’t make sense to say that the Tikal citadel shows precursors of Teotihuacán architecture. Choice D is incorrect because the text discusses how the citadel in Tikal indicates the influence of Teotihuacán architecture, which implies that the makers of the Tikal citadel likely admired aspects of Teotihuacán architecture enough to imitate it. Thus, there’s no reason to think that the Tikal citadel provides evidence of the Tikal people’s “animosities toward,” or feelings of strong dislike or hostility toward, Teotihuacán architecture.

Question ID d13dbc6a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: d13dbc6a

Text 1

The Cretaceous-Paleogene (K-Pg) mass extinction event is usually attributed solely to an asteroid impact near Chicxulub, Mexico. Some scientists argue that volcanic activity was the true cause, as the K-Pg event occurred relatively early in a long period of eruption of the Deccan Traps range that initially produced huge amounts of climate-altering gases. These dissenters note that other mass extinctions have coincided with large volcanic eruptions, while only the K-Pg event lines up with an asteroid strike.

Text 2

In a 2020 study, Pincelli Hull and her colleagues analyzed ocean core samples and modeled climate changes around the K-Pg event. The team concluded that Deccan Traps gases did affect global conditions prior to the event, but that the climate returned to normal well before the extinctions began—extinctions that instead closely align with the Chicxulub impact.

- Based on the texts, how would Hull’s team (Text 2) most likely respond to the argument in the underlined portion of Text 1?
- A. By agreeing that the Chicxulub impact changed the climate and that the Deccan Traps eruption caused the K-Pg event
 - B. By declaring that the changes in climate caused by the Deccan Traps eruption weren’t the main cause of the K-Pg event
 - C. By questioning why those scientists assume that the Chicxulub impact caused the Deccan Traps eruption
 - D. By asserting that the Deccan Traps eruption had a more significant effect on global conditions than those scientists claim

ID: d13dbc6a Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it describes how Hull’s team would most likely respond to the argument in the underlined portion of Text 1, which asserts that volcanic activity in the Deccan Traps range led to changes in the climate and caused the K-Pg mass extinction event. According to Text 2, although Hull’s team found that activity in the Deccan Traps did indeed alter the climate before the K-Pg event, the team determined that the climate had returned to normal before mass extinctions began. This finding and the observation that the K-Pg extinctions closely align with the Chicxulub asteroid impact suggest that Hull’s team would likely dispute the claim in the underlined portion of Text 1 and say that the climate changes caused by the Deccan Traps activity were not the main cause of the extinctions.

Choice A is incorrect because Text 2 describes how Hull’s team found that the climate had recovered from the changes brought about by the Deccan Traps activity before the K-Pg event occurred, which suggests that Hull’s team would disagree that the Deccan Traps activity caused the K-Pg event. Additionally, the claim in the underlined portion of Text 1 says nothing about how the Chicxulub impact changed the climate, so while Hull’s team might believe that the impact did in fact change the climate, they could not be said to agree with the claim in Text 1 on this point. Choice C is incorrect because there is no indication in either text that any scientists assume that the Chicxulub impact caused the Deccan Traps activity, so there is no reason to conclude that Hull’s team would question why the scientists referred to in Text 1 make such an assumption. Choice D is incorrect because Text

2 describes how Hull's team found that the climate had recovered from the changes brought about by the Deccan Traps activity before the K-Pg event occurred, which suggests that Hull's team would say that the Deccan Traps activity had a less enduring effect on global conditions than the scientists referenced in Text 1 believe, not that the effect on global conditions was more significant than those scientists claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c59c460f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: c59c460f

Text 1

Films and television shows commonly include a long list of credits naming the people involved in a production. Credit sequences may not be exciting, but they generally ensure that everyone’s contributions are duly acknowledged. Because they are highly standardized, film and television credits are also valuable to anyone researching the careers of pioneering cast and crew members who have worked in the mediums.

Text 2

Video game scholars face a major challenge in the industry’s failure to consistently credit the artists, designers, and other contributors involved in making video games. Without a reliable record of which people worked on which games, questions about the medium’s development can be difficult to answer, and the accomplishments of all but its best-known innovators can be difficult to trace.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 1 most likely respond to the discussion in Text 2?

- A. By recommending that the scholars mentioned in Text 2 consider employing the methods regularly used by film and television researchers
- B. By pointing out that credits have a different intended purpose in film and television than in the medium addressed by the scholars mentioned in Text 2
- C. By suggesting that the scholars mentioned in Text 2 rely more heavily on credits as a source of information than film and television researchers do
- D. By observing that a widespread practice in film and television largely prevents the kind of problem faced by the scholars mentioned in Text 2

ID: c59c460f Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 1 would most likely respond to Text 2 based on the information provided. Text 2 discusses how the inconsistent use of credits to identify the contributors to video games can pose an obstacle to scholars of the medium, who rely on such credits to answer questions about the medium’s development. Text 1 notes that in film and television, on the other hand, credits are used consistently and are valuable to researchers studying the cast and crew members in these mediums. Since Text 1 asserts how the consistent use of credits benefits scholars of film and television, it can be inferred that this text’s author would respond to the discussion in Text 2 by observing that the kind of problem faced by scholars of video games—the inability to know who contributed to a particular production and how—is, in film and television studies, largely prevented by the widespread practice of credits in these mediums.

Choice A is incorrect. Although Text 1 discusses a method used by film and television researchers—namely, relying on credits to research the careers of cast and crew members—the author doesn’t explicitly recommend that or any other method. Moreover, Text 1 states that films and television shows themselves, not their researchers, regularly use the method of listing credits. Choice B is incorrect. It can be inferred from Text 2 that when video games do feature credits, they have essentially the same function as credits in film and television—namely, to identify the individuals who worked on a particular production. Therefore, it is unlikely that the author of Text 1 would characterize video game credits as differing in purpose from film and television credits. Choice C is incorrect because, as Text 2 explains, credits are not consistently used in video games. Therefore, it is unlikely that the author of Text 1 would argue that scholars of the medium discussed in this text—video games—rely more heavily on credits than scholars of film and television, two mediums where credits consistently appear.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0c46aa9f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 0c46aa9f

Researcher Haesung Jung led a 2020 study showing that individual acts of kindness can _____ prosocial behavior across a larger group. Jung and her team found that bystanders who witness a helpful act become more likely to offer help to someone else, and in doing so, can inspire still others to act.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. require
- B. remember
- C. foster
- D. discourage

ID: 0c46aa9f Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Jung and her team’s study of acts of kindness. In this context, “foster” means encourage or promote the development of. The text indicates that Jung and her team found that seeing a helpful (or prosocial) act makes a bystander more likely to help someone else, which can in turn inspire additional people to help others. That is, the team showed that single acts of kindness can foster additional prosocial acts across a group.

Choice A is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that Jung and her team found that single acts of kindness “require,” or depend on or make obligatory, broader prosocial (or helpful) behavior across a group. There’s no suggestion in the text that individual acts of kindness can only occur if other prosocial acts have already occurred, and the text indicates only that an act of kindness *can* inspire additional helpful acts, not that it necessarily will do so. Choice B is incorrect because the text focuses on a possible direct effect of individual acts of kindness, or single helpful actions, and it wouldn’t make sense to suggest that actions can “remember,” or hold a memory of, something. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that Jung and her team found that single acts of kindness can “discourage,” or hinder, prosocial (or helpful) behavior across a group. On the contrary, the text states that Jung and her team found that seeing a helpful act makes a bystander *more* likely to help someone else, which can in turn inspire even more people to help others.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f6a04ddc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: f6a04ddc

Pteropods are small swimming snails with thin, delicate calcium carbonate shells. These animals are thought to be especially vulnerable to ocean acidification due to calcium carbonate’s susceptibility to dissolution at lower pH values. Victoria L. Peck and colleagues recently found that the periostracum (a protective coating on pteropods’ outer shells) prevents this dissolution when intact. Moreover, the team was surprised to discover that even when the periostracum is breached, pteropods can still mitigate damage by rebuilding the inner shell wall.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A. To call for additional research on biological mechanisms that improve pteropod survival rates
- B. To discuss a conclusion drawn in a study of calcium carbonate’s role in protecting the periostracum of pteropods
- C. To address some of the ways ocean acidification has altered pteropod behavior over time
- D. To present findings that suggest that a concern about the effects of ocean acidification on pteropod shells may be unwarranted

ID: f6a04ddc Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to present findings that suggest a previously held concern about the effects of ocean acidification on pteropod shells may be unwarranted. The text introduces the concern that pteropods are thought to be particularly vulnerable to ocean acidification, or lower pH levels, due to the susceptibility of their calcium carbonate shells to dissolution at lower pH levels. However, the text then describes findings from a recent study that suggest this concern may be unjustified, insofar as the protective periostracum coating on a pteropod’s shell prevents dissolution, and even when the coating is breached, a pteropod can rebuild the inner shell wall, reducing the damage.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t call for additional research or suggest that more research is needed on biological mechanisms that improve pteropod survival rates. Instead, the text discusses a recent study showing that pteropods may not be as vulnerable to ocean acidification as is feared. Choice B is incorrect because the study discussed in the text doesn’t address calcium carbonate’s role in protecting the periostracum of pteropods. According to the text, the study addresses the periostracum’s role in protecting pteropods’ calcium carbonate shells from dissolution due to ocean acidification. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t address how ocean acidification has altered pteropod behavior over time. Instead, the text focuses on the potential effects of ocean acidification on pteropods’ shells and the mechanisms protecting against those effects.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7df6d120

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 7df6d120

Whether the reign of a French monarch such as Hugh Capet or Henry I was historically consequential or relatively uneventful, its trajectory was shaped by questions of legitimacy and therefore cannot be understood without a corollary understanding of the factors that allowed the monarch to _____ his right to hold the throne.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. disengage
- B. annotate
- C. buttress
- D. reciprocate

ID: 7df6d120 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the legitimacy of the reigns of French monarchs such as Hugh Capet and Henry I. As used in this context, “buttress” means to strengthen or defend. The text indicates that regardless of whether a French monarch’s reign was significant or uneventful, each monarch faced questions about his right to the throne. The text goes on to say that in order to understand the path of a French monarch’s reign, it’s important to understand what contributed to the monarch’s ability to “hold the throne.” This context suggests that French monarchs such as Hugh Capet and Henry I had to buttress, or defend, their right to be monarch.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to discuss factors that enabled a monarch to “disengage,” or withdraw his right to the French throne. The text focuses on an examination of people who reigned as French monarchs, not on people who didn’t choose to rule. Choice B is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to discuss factors that enabled a monarch to “annotate,” or add notes to or explain, his right to the French throne. Nothing in the text suggests that the monarchs were writing notes about their right to the throne; instead, faced with questions about the legitimacy of their reign, the monarchs defended their right. Choice D is incorrect. Saying that a monarch who is faced with questions about the legitimacy of his reign was able to “reciprocate” his right to the French throne would mean that he either returned his right to the throne or that he responded in kind to the challenge. Neither of these meanings would make sense in context because the text focuses on people who did reign as French monarchs and defended their right to do so.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4336a617

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 4336a617

Among stock-market investors, the practice of diversification, or distributing investment funds across many different companies in many different industries, is regarded as _____ since it protects investors from major losses if the value of one particular company or industry sector falls.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. contentious
- B. prudent
- C. unworkable
- D. optimistic

ID: 4336a617 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of how stock-market investors regard diversification. In this context, “prudent” means showing sensible judgment. The text defines diversification as the practice of spreading investment funds across many different companies and industries and explains that this practice “protects investors from major losses” when a particular company or sector loses value. This context supports the idea that diversification is regarded as prudent—that is, as a sensible strategy because of the financial protection it provides.

Choice A is incorrect because describing diversification as “contentious,” or likely to cause disagreement, would contradict the text, which presents diversification as a practice valued by investors for its protective benefits, not as one that prompts dispute. Choice C is incorrect because describing diversification as “unworkable,” or unable to function effectively, would contradict the text, which indicates that diversification successfully protects investors from major losses. Choice D is incorrect because describing diversification as “optimistic,” or expressing confidence in a positive outcome, wouldn’t make sense in context. The text presents diversification as a defensive strategy designed to limit losses, not as one expressing confidence about future gains.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 660e7502

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 660e7502

In a study of residential mobility in Washington, DC, LaTanya Brown-Robertson et al. found that increases in household spending power (via tax credits) had mixed effects on mobility decisions, possibly because residential location choices are not fully reducible to economic factors but are also _____ noneconomic factors such as access to strong local social networks.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. transposed with
- B. mediated by
- C. decoupled from
- D. antecedent to

ID: 660e7502 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of residential mobility decisions. In this context, "mediated by" means influenced or affected by something. The text establishes that increasing household spending power (an economic factor) produced "mixed effects" on mobility decisions. The text then explains that residential choices are "not fully reducible to economic factors," which means that these decisions don’t simply rely on how much money is available to spend on a residential move but on other factors as well. According to the text, noneconomic considerations, such as access to social networks, also play a significant role. Thus, "mediated by" accurately captures this relationship where noneconomic factors influence what might otherwise be purely economic decisions.

Choice A is incorrect because "transposed with" would suggest that economic and noneconomic factors are being switched or interchanged when making residential mobility decisions, which wouldn’t make logical sense in this context. The text indicates that these factors coexist and jointly influence such decisions. Choice C is incorrect. The phrase "decoupled from" means separated or disconnected from, which would suggest that economic factors are completely separate from noneconomic factors. This would contradict the text’s main point that residential mobility decisions involve multiple factors being considered simultaneously rather than in isolation. Choice D is incorrect because "antecedent to," which means something prior or earlier, would indicate that noneconomic factors come before economic ones in time or sequence. The text doesn’t establish this chronological relationship. Instead, the text indicates that economic factors (household spending power) and noneconomic factors (access to social networks) simultaneously influence residential mobility decisions.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8eb93382

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 8eb93382

Musician Joni Mitchell, who is also a painter, uses images she creates for her album covers to emphasize ideas expressed in her music. For the cover of her album *Turbulent Indigo* (1994), Mitchell painted a striking self-portrait that closely resembles Vincent van Gogh’s *Self-Portrait with Bandaged Ear* (1889). The image calls attention to the album’s title song, in which Mitchell sings about the legacy of the postimpressionist painter. In that song, Mitchell also hints that she feels a strong artistic connection to Van Gogh—an idea that is reinforced by her imagery on the cover.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It presents a claim about Mitchell, then gives an example supporting that claim.
- B. It discusses Van Gogh’s influence on Mitchell, then considers Mitchell’s influence on other artists.
- C. It describes a similarity between two artists, then notes a difference between them.
- D. It describes the songs on *Turbulent Indigo*, then explains how they relate to the album’s cover.

ID: 8eb93382 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it accurately describes the organization of the elements within the text. The text begins with the claim that Joni Mitchell’s album covers use images she creates in order to emphasize ideas embedded in her albums. It then goes on to provide an example of how Mitchell’s self-portrait on the cover of *Turbulent Indigo* resembles a painting by Van Gogh, which the text indicates helps emphasize the strong connection Mitchell feels toward Van Gogh, a connection that is also expressed in the album’s title song.

Choice B is incorrect because there are no references in the text to artists other than Joni Mitchell and Van Gogh. Choice C is incorrect because there is nothing in the text that calls attention to any similarities or differences between Joni Mitchell and Van Gogh. Instead, it mentions that Mitchell feels a strong “artistic connection” to Van Gogh. Choice D is incorrect because the text discusses the cover before referring to any songs, and it only references one song from the album not all the songs.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8b8d3e76

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 8b8d3e76

The 1967 release of Harold Cruse’s book *The Crisis of the Negro Intellectual* isolated him from almost all other scholars and activists of the American Civil Rights Movement—though many of those thinkers disagreed with each other, he nonetheless found ways to disagree with them all. He thought that activists who believed that Black people such as himself should culturally assimilate were naïve. But he also sharply criticized Black nationalists such as Marcus Garvey who wanted to establish independent, self-contained Black economies and societies, even though Cruse himself identified as a Black nationalist.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- A. It describes a direction that Cruse felt the Civil Rights Movement ought to take.
- B. It indicates that Cruse’s reputation as a persistent antagonist of other scholars is undeserved.
- C. It describes a controversy that Cruse’s work caused within the Black nationalist movement.
- D. It helps explain Cruse’s position with respect to the community of civil rights thinkers.

ID: 8b8d3e76 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The text as a whole claims that Cruse disagreed with virtually all other Civil Rights scholars and activists. The underlined sentence describes one way that Cruse both did and didn’t fit in with those thinkers: he criticized Black nationalists, even though he identified as one.

Choice A is incorrect. The underlined sentence doesn’t do this. It describes Cruse’s criticisms—it never mentions what Cruse did want the movement to do instead. Choice B is incorrect. This conflicts with the text, which argues that Cruse did disagree with almost all other scholars of the Civil Rights Movement. Choice C is incorrect. This is a step too far. The text never says that Cruse’s work caused controversy within the Black nationalist movement.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d7b7ade5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: d7b7ade5

Early in the Great Migration of 1910–1970, which involved the mass migration of Black people from the southern to the northern United States, political activist and *Chicago Defender* writer Fannie Barrier Williams was instrumental in helping other Black women establish themselves in the North. Many women hoped for better employment opportunities in the North because, in the South, they faced much competition for domestic employment and men tended to get agricultural work. To aid with this transition, Barrier Williams helped secure job placement in the North for many women before they even began their journey.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To introduce and illustrate Barrier Williams’s integral role in supporting other Black women as their circumstances changed during part of the Great Migration
- B. To establish that Barrier Williams used her professional connections to arrange employment for other Black women, including jobs with the *Chicago Defender*
- C. To demonstrate that the factors that motivated the start of the Great Migration were different for Black women than they were for Black men
- D. To provide an overview of the employment challenges faced by Black women in the agricultural and domestic spheres in the southern United States

ID: d7b7ade5 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes the text’s purpose, which is to discuss the important role Barrier Williams played in supporting many other Black women as they relocated to the northern United States during the early years of the Great Migration. After introducing Barrier Williams, the text describes how she helped find jobs for other Black women, who in many cases relocated in search of better employment prospects than the South could offer at the time. The text indicates that by doing so, she eased these women’s transition as their circumstances changed.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the text mentions Barrier Williams’s work as a political activist and writer for the *Chicago Defender*, it doesn’t discuss any professional connections she made in these roles or indicate that she used any such connections in her work to secure employment for other Black women. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text discusses a factor that caused many women to relocate during the Great Migration, their difficulty finding employment in the South, the text doesn’t indicate that this factor motivated the start of the Great Migration. Moreover, the text doesn’t discuss the factors that motivated Black men to migrate. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text mentions the difficult employment prospects for Black women in the domestic and agricultural sectors in the South during the Great Migration, the text’s main purpose isn’t to provide an overview of the employment challenges Black women faced in these sectors. Rather, it provides this information to show that Barrier Williams played a crucial role in supporting many Black women who relocated to the North by helping them achieve one of their main goals, securing a job.

Question ID 7fd38534

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 7fd38534

Text 1

The fossil record suggests that mammoths went extinct around 11 thousand years (kyr) ago. In a 2021 study of environmental DNA (eDNA)—genetic material shed into the environment by organisms—in the Arctic, Yucheng Wang and colleagues found mammoth eDNA in sedimentary layers formed millennia later, around 4 kyr ago. To account for this discrepancy, Joshua H. Miller and Carl Simpson proposed that arctic temperatures could preserve a mammoth carcass on the surface, allowing it to leach DNA into the environment, for several thousand years.

Text 2

Wang and colleagues concede that eDNA contains DNA from both living organisms and carcasses, but for DNA to leach from remains over several millennia requires that the remains be perpetually on the surface. Scavengers and weathering in the Arctic, however, are likely to break down surface remains well before a thousand years have passed.

Which choice best describes how Text 1 and Text 2 relate to each other?

- A. Text 1 discusses two approaches to studying mammoth extinction without advocating for either, whereas Text 2 advocates for one approach over the other.
- B. Text 1 presents findings by Wang and colleagues and gives another research team’s attempt to explain those findings, whereas Text 2 provides additional detail that calls that explanation into question.
- C. Text 1 describes Wang and colleagues’ study and a critique of their methodology, whereas Text 2 offers additional details showing that methodology to be sound.
- D. Text 1 argues that new research has undermined the standard view of when mammoths went extinct, whereas Text 2 suggests a way to reconcile the standard view with that new research.

ID: 7fd38534 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Text 1 introduces Wang and colleagues’ study and its surprising results, and then mentions Miller and Simpson’s hypothesis as a possible way to explain them. Text 2, however, challenges Miller and Simpson’s hypothesis by pointing out the difficulties of preserving mammoth carcasses on the surface for thousands of years: “scavengers and weathering” are the additional details that complicate the Miller/Simpson hypothesis.

Choice A is incorrect. Neither text compares two different approaches for studying mammoth extinction. Text 1 describes one study and one hypothesis pertaining to it. Text 2 critiques that hypothesis. Choice C is incorrect. Text 1 does not describe a critique of Wang and colleagues’ methodology, but rather an interpretation of their results by Miller and Simpson. Text 2 does not offer additional details showing that methodology to be sound, but rather casts doubt on the Miller/Simpson explanation. Choice D is incorrect. Both components mentioned here (the new “undermining” research and the theory for reconciling this discovery)

are contained in Text 1. Text 2 then shows how the attempt to reconcile the standard view and new research is flawed, and still fails to explain the discrepancy.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ea706863

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: ea706863

Text 1

Like the work of Ralph Ellison before her, Toni Morrison’s novels feature scenes in which characters deliver sermons of such length and verbal dexterity that for a time, the text exchanges the formal parameters of fiction for those of oral literature. Given the many other echoes of Ellison in Morrison’s novels, both in structure and prose style, these scenes suggest Ellison’s direct influence on Morrison.

Text 2

In their destabilizing effect on literary form, the sermons in Morrison’s works recall those in Ellison’s. Yet literature by Black Americans abounds in moments where interpolated speech erodes the division between oral and written forms that literature in English has traditionally observed. Morrison’s use of the sermon is attributable not only to the influence of Ellison but also to a community-wide strategy of resistance to externally imposed literary conventions.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely characterize the underlined claim in Text 1?

- A. As failing to consider Ellison’s and Morrison’s equivalent uses of the sermon within the wider cultural context in which they wrote
- B. As misunderstanding the function of sermons in novels by Black American writers other than Ellison and Morrison
- C. As disregarding points of structural and stylistic divergence between the works of Ellison and those of Morrison
- D. As being indebted to the tradition of resisting literary conventions that privilege written forms, such as novels, over sermons and other oral forms

ID: ea706863 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The author of Text 2 argues that Morrison’s use of the sermon is not only influenced by Ellison, but also by a “community-wide strategy of resistance” to literary conventions practiced by Black American authors. Ellison, Text 2 alleges, is only one of many influences on Morrison.

Choice B is incorrect. Neither text specifically mentions sermons in works by authors other than Morrison or Ellison, only a tendency towards eroding “the division between oral and written forms” among Black American writers. Choice C is incorrect. Both texts describe similarities between the works of Ellison and Morrison, and neither points out instances of divergence. Text 2 simply suggests that Morrison was influenced by more than just Ellison. Choice D is incorrect. While Text 2 does discuss Morrison’s resistance to certain literary conventions, it’s unclear what it would mean for the underlined claim to be “indebted” to that tradition. This choice recycles language from the text, but not in a way that makes any coherent point.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 20bae589

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 20bae589

Rejecting the premise that the literary magazine *Ebony and Topaz* (1927) should present a unified vision of Black American identity, editor Charles S. Johnson fostered his contributors’ diverse perspectives by promoting their authorial autonomy. Johnson’s self-effacement diverged from the editorial stances of W.E.B. Du Bois and Alain Locke, whose decisions for their publications were more _____.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. proficient
- B. dogmatic
- C. ambiguous
- D. unpretentious

ID: 20bae589 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. A person who is "dogmatic" believes strongly that their principles and opinions are true. Because Du Bois and Locke are implied to have one "unified vision" of Black American identity that they prioritize over the "diverse perspectives" of different writers, they can be described as dogmatic.

Choice A is incorrect. "Proficient" means "skilled." Du Bois and Locke are contrasted with Johnson, but nothing in the text suggests that Johnson was not skilled at making editorial decisions. Based on the text, the three editors just have different styles; they’re not necessarily more or less skilled. Choice C is incorrect. "Ambiguous" means "unclear" or "open to multiple interpretations." However, it’s actually Johnson who encouraged multiple interpretations ("diverse perspectives"). Since Du Bois and Locke are said to "diverge" from Johnson, we can assume that the views they published were not ambiguous, but instead clear and firm (a "unified vision"). Choice D is incorrect. "Unpretentious" means "not trying to impress others with greater skill or importance than is actually possessed." Du Bois and Locke are contrasted with Johnson, but nothing in the text suggests that Johnson is pretentious (trying to impress others).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d3df4847

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: d3df4847

The following text is from William Shakespeare’s circa 1611 play *The Winter’s Tale*. Camillo has been away from his home in Sicily and serves in the court of Polixenes, the king of Bohemia. He has asked Polixenes for permission to return to Sicily.

POLIXENES: I pray thee, good Camillo, be no more importunate. ’Tis a sickness denying thee anything, a death to grant this.

CAMILLO: It is fifteen years since I saw my country. Though I have for the most part been aired abroad, I desire to lay my bones there. Besides, the penitent king, my master, hath sent for me, to whose feeling sorrows I might be some allay—or I o’erween [presume] to think so—which is another spur to my departure.

- Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?
- A. It establishes Camillo’s hope that Polixenes will be comforted knowing that Camillo isn’t departing at his own discretion.
 - B. It suggests that Camillo feels compelled to persuade Polixenes that Camillo’s decision to leave the court is justified.
 - C. It conveys Camillo’s recognition that one benefit his presence may afford the king of Sicily is merely speculative.
 - D. It bolsters the idea that Camillo’s primary motivation to return home is his concern for the king of Sicily’s well-being in his absence.

ID: d3df4847 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes how the underlined portion functions in the text as a whole. In the text, Camillo explains to Polixenes that he wants to return home after his long absence and that Sicily’s king has summoned him. In the underlined portion, Camillo adds that he also wants to return because he might provide comfort to the king’s sorrows (“to whose feeling sorrows I might be some allay”) but then clarifies that his belief about being able to comfort the king is a presumption—that is, something he thinks is true but can’t be certain of. Thus, the underlined portion indicates that Camillo recognizes that one benefit his presence may offer is merely speculative.

Choice A is incorrect because the underlined portion conveys Camillo’s hope that he might comfort the king of Sicily, which does suggest a personal choice contributing to Camillo’s decision to leave; the idea that Camillo isn’t choosing to leave is established in a different part of the text, when he says “the penitent king, my master, hath sent for me.” Choice B is incorrect because the underlined portion doesn’t suggest Camillo feels compelled to justify his decision to leave. Rather than expressing a need to persuade Polixenes that his departure is warranted, Camillo’s statement simply reveals his awareness that he assumes rather

than knows with certainty that his presence will comfort the king of Sicily. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text indicates that Camillo's primary motivation for returning to Sicily is his concern for the king's well-being; Camillo mentions first that he wants to return home because he has been away for so long, then adds that the king has summoned him and that he hopes his presence will comfort the king. The underlined portion simply conveys Camillo's awareness that offering comfort is a hope rather than a certainty; it doesn't suggest that the king's well-being is his main concern.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f2b7e360

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: f2b7e360

The following text is adapted from George Eliot’s 1857 short story “The Sad Fortunes of the Rev. Amos Barton.” Mr. Ely is a clergyman in the town of Milby.

By the laity of Milby and its neighbourhood [Mr. Ely] was regarded as a man of quite remarkable powers and learning, who must make a considerable sensation in London pulpits and drawing-rooms on his occasional visit to the metropolis; and by his brother clergy he was regarded as a discreet and agreeable fellow. Mr. Ely never got into a warm discussion; he suggested what might be thought, but rarely said what he thought himself; he never let either men or women see that he was laughing at them, and he never gave any one an opportunity of laughing at *him*.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It shows that Mr. Ely had originally been held in high regard by his friends and then details the events that caused their regard for him to subside.
- B. It implies that Mr. Ely’s neighbors are more naïve in their estimation of him than people in London are and then explains why his neighbors have been so easily misled.
- C. It stresses the discrepancy between Mr. Ely’s public and private conduct and then alludes to his motivation for hiding his true personality.
- D. It presents the favorable opinion of Mr. Ely that other people hold and then describes the behaviors of Mr. Ely that enable him to maintain that favorable opinion.

ID: f2b7e360 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it best describes the overall structure of the text. The first part of the text presents the favorable opinions that others hold of Mr. Ely: the laity of Milby regard him as having "remarkable powers and learning" and assume that he also impresses people in London, while his fellow clergy see him as "a discreet and agreeable fellow." The text then goes on to describe Mr. Ely’s behaviors that enable him to cultivate and preserve his positive reputation. The text conveys that he avoids confrontations, abstaining from "warm discussion[s]" (that is, heated or contentious ones); that he avoids offending anyone by "rarely [saying] what he thought himself" and by refraining from openly ridiculing anyone; and that he doesn’t give anyone any reason to ridicule or belittle his own character ("he never gave any one an opportunity of laughing at *him*"). In other words, these are all behaviors that suggest that Mr. Ely avoids doing anything that might make people dislike him or think poorly of him. Thus, the text begins by presenting the favorable view that people have of Mr. Ely and then describes the behaviors that enable him to maintain that favorable view.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t describe any events that caused people’s regard for Mr. Ely to diminish. Instead, the text explains that the people of Milby hold him in high regard and describes behaviors that suggest how he cultivates that regard. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that Mr. Ely’s neighbors are more naïve than Londoners are or that they’ve

been misled. Although the text suggests that Mr. Ely is very guarded in his outward behavior and conceals from people when he may be internally mocking them, which might suggest that people know him less well than they think they do, there's nothing in the text to suggest that Londoners are less naïve and therefore less easily misled than Mr. Ely's neighbors are. The text states that the people of Milby believe Mr. Ely to be "remarkable" and that they assume that people in London must find him so, too; it doesn't say anything about what Londoners actually think of him. Choice C is incorrect. While the text discusses Mr. Ely's public conduct at length, describing the ways in which he carefully cultivates an agreeable public persona, the text doesn't discuss how Mr. Ely behaves in private at all; it therefore wouldn't be accurate to say that the text begins by emphasizing a discrepancy between his public and private conduct. Furthermore, although the text concludes with examples illustrating that Mr. Ely typically doesn't share his true thoughts, indicating that he may be hiding aspects of his true personality when in public, and although the text as a whole conveys the idea that Mr. Ely benefits from this behavior, which might hint at his motives for doing so, the text doesn't conclude by alluding to those motives. Instead, the text merely concludes with a description of the behaviors he engages in to win his neighbors' and colleagues' approval.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a4bd7a28

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: a4bd7a28

The following text is adapted from Jane Austen’s 1814 novel *Mansfield Park*. The speaker, Tom, is considering staging a play at home with a group of his friends and family.

We mean nothing but a little amusement among ourselves, just to vary the scene, and exercise our powers in something new. We want no audience, no publicity. We may be trusted, I think, in choosing some play most perfectly unexceptionable; and I can conceive no greater harm or danger to any of us in conversing in the elegant written language of some respectable author than in chattering in words of our own.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To offer Tom’s assurance that the play will be inoffensive and involve only a small number of people
- B. To clarify that the play will not be performed in the manner Tom had originally intended
- C. To elaborate on the idea that the people around Tom lack the skills to successfully stage a play
- D. To assert that Tom believes the group performing the play will be able to successfully promote it

ID: a4bd7a28 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately portrays the main purpose of the text. At the beginning of the text, Tom asserts that he and the other people staging the play are doing so only for “a little amusement among ourselves” and aren’t interested in attracting an audience or any attention with the production. Then, Tom promises that the play they chose is modest and appropriate, and he further reasons that using the well-written prose of “some respectable author” is better than using their own words. Overall, the main purpose of the text is to convey Tom’s promise that the play will be inoffensive and involve only a few people.

Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that Tom had earlier intentions for the play’s performance or that anything has changed since the group first decided to stage a play. Instead, the text focuses on how harmless the entire endeavor will be. Choice C is incorrect. Although Tom mentions that using the words of a “respectable author” will be better than using their own words, he never addresses the idea that the people around him generally aren’t skilled enough to stage a play. Choice D is incorrect because in the text Tom specifically says that they “want no audience, no publicity,” which indicates that they don’t plan on promoting the play at all.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4c3cda87

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 4c3cda87

Science fiction has long served as a _____ real-world technological advancements. Indeed, from Jules Verne’s 1865 novel *From the Earth to the Moon* inspiring developments in aerospace engineering to the television show *Star Trek* sparking the design of the ancestor of today’s smartphones, these narratives have spurred many actual innovations.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. constraint to
- B. sponsor of
- C. catalyst of
- D. diversion from

ID: 4c3cda87 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of science fiction’s relationship to real-world technological advancements. In this context, “catalyst of” means something that prompts the development of. The text indicates that science fiction narratives have “spurred many actual innovations,” giving as examples Verne’s *From the Earth to the Moon* “inspiring” aerospace engineering developments and *Star Trek* “sparking” the design of early analogues of smartphones. Thus, this context supports the idea that science fiction has prompted the development of, or served as a catalyst of, real-world technological advancements.

Choice A is incorrect because saying that science fiction has served as a “constraint to,” or limitation on, real-world technological advancements would contradict the text, which indicates that science fiction has inspired technological innovation rather than inhibited it. Choice B is incorrect because describing science fiction as a “sponsor of,” or an entity who takes on responsibility for, real-world technological advancements wouldn’t make sense in context. A sponsor provides material support for an undertaking, often by providing funds for the undertaking or by overseeing its management, but the text describes science fiction as inspiring or sparking ideas for innovation, not as financially backing technological development or taking direct responsibility for overseeing it. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, a “diversion from” would mean either a distraction from or a deviation from, which contradicts the text’s examples of science fiction inspiring real-world technological advancements. It therefore wouldn’t make sense to say that science fiction has distracted people from such advancements or that the innovations science fiction depicts deviate from actual innovations.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 533929e9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 533929e9

Some studies have suggested that posture can influence cognition, but we should not overstate this phenomenon. A case in point: In a 2014 study, Megan O’Brien and Alaa Ahmed had subjects stand or sit while making risky simulated economic decisions. Standing is more physically unstable and cognitively demanding than sitting; accordingly, O’Brien and Ahmed hypothesized that standing subjects would display more risk aversion during the decision-making tasks than sitting subjects did, since they would want to avoid further feelings of discomfort and complicated risk evaluations. But O’Brien and Ahmed actually found no difference in the groups’ performance.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. It argues that research findings about the effects of posture on cognition are often misunderstood, as in the case of O’Brien and Ahmed’s study.
- B. It presents the study by O’Brien and Ahmed to critique the methods and results reported in previous studies of the effects of posture on cognition.
- C. It explains a significant problem in the emerging understanding of posture’s effects on cognition and how O’Brien and Ahmed tried to solve that problem.
- D. It discusses the study by O’Brien and Ahmed to illustrate why caution is needed when making claims about the effects of posture on cognition.

ID: 533929e9 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text. The text notes that although some studies have suggested that posture may have an effect on cognition, this phenomenon should not be overstated. In other words, the text begins by urging caution and restraint when discussing the effects of posture on cognition, implying that even though some studies have shown posture to affect cognition, we should not assume that posture always affects cognition or does so in a strong way. The text goes on to discuss O’Brien and Ahmed’s study as a "case in point" (that is, as an example of the point made previously). According to the text, O’Brien and Ahmed hypothesized that since standing is more cognitively demanding than sitting, standing subjects in their experiment would respond differently to decision-making tasks than sitting subjects would, which would show an effect of posture on cognition. What the researchers actually found, however, was that the standing and sitting subjects performed the same—posture did not affect cognition. By presenting a circumstance in which posture does not appear to affect cognition, the discussion of O’Brien and Ahmed’s study shows why it is important not to overstate the phenomenon. The purpose of the text, therefore, is to discuss O’Brien and Ahmed’s study to illustrate why caution is needed when making claims about posture’s effects on cognition.

Choice A is incorrect because the text discusses O’Brien and Ahmed’s study as an example of why caution is needed when discussing posture’s effects on cognition, not as an example of how research findings related to posture and cognition are often

misunderstood. Although the text does warn against misunderstanding the scope of the relationship between posture and cognition that has been reported in some previous studies, O'Brien and Ahmed's study is not one of those studies, and there is no suggestion that anyone has misunderstood O'Brien and Ahmed's findings. Choice B is incorrect because the text makes no mention of the methods used in previous studies of the effects of posture on cognition. Although the text does urge caution when discussing posture's effects on cognition, it does not critique the results of studies that suggested that posture can affect cognition. Instead, the text suggests that such results should not be exaggerated or taken too broadly. Choice C is incorrect because although the text implies that overstating posture's effects on cognition would be a problem, nothing in the text suggests that O'Brien and Ahmed share that view or that they attempted to solve that problem. O'Brien and Ahmed are presented as hypothesizing that posture would affect cognition in their study, not as trying to resolve the problem the text describes.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e4fa7055

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: e4fa7055

In 2016, Gabriela González and team announced that a chirping sound captured by Laser Interferometer Gravitational-Wave Observatory antennas was direct evidence of gravitational waves, which skeptics had argued would be too faint for detection. Detailed statistical analysis helped preclude claims of the event’s _____, confirming the signal at a confidence level of over 99%.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. inconspicuousness
- B. discretion
- C. ambiguity
- D. probability

ID: e4fa7055 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Gabriela González and team’s detection of gravitational waves. In this context, "ambiguity" means uncertainty or doubtfulness. The text explains that although skeptics had thought that direct evidence of gravitational waves would be too faint to be detected, researchers led by González claimed that a chirping sound captured by Laser Interferometer Gravitational-Wave Observatory antennas nevertheless provided such evidence. The text goes on to say that detailed statistical analysis confirmed the observation of gravitational waves with a high degree of confidence—that is, with near certainty—a finding that helped to preclude, or rule out, any claims that the signal’s attribution to gravitational waves might be ambiguous or doubtful.

Choice A is incorrect. In this context, "inconspicuousness" would mean the quality of being unnoticeable or difficult to detect. Although the text indicates that skeptics had doubted whether gravitational waves could be observed directly because of their presumed faintness (which suggests that gravitational waves were expected to be difficult to detect), the blank portion of the text isn’t referring to the possibility that gravitational waves are unnoticeable or undetectable. Instead, the focus of the last sentence is González’s team’s observation of a chirping sound that they attributed to gravitational waves, and it wouldn’t make sense to say that through statistical analysis, they ruled out the possibility that the sound they observed was undetectable. Rather, the skeptical view presented in the text suggests that there could be some ambiguity about the source of the chirping, but statistical analysis virtually eliminated this uncertainty. Choice B is incorrect because in this context, "discretion" would mean good judgment, and it wouldn’t make sense to say that an event, such as the detection of gravitational waves, would show judgment, much less that the event’s capacity to exercise good judgment would be precluded by statistical analysis confirming its attribution. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, "probability" would mean likelihood, and the text states that statistical analysis, which confirmed the signal with a high degree of confidence, suggests the likelihood that the chirping sound was produced by gravitational waves, not that the analysis helped to preclude this likelihood.

Question ID 93aaf0ab

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 93aaf0ab

The following text is from John Dryden’s 1697 translation of Virgil’s poem the *Aeneid*, written in the first century BCE. Queen Dido has just heard the Trojan hero Aeneas recount a sad tale.

But anxious cares already seiz’d the queen:
She fed within her veins a flame unseen;
The hero’s valor, acts, and birth inspire
Her soul with love, and fan the secret fire.
His words, his looks, imprinted in her heart,
Improve the passion, and increase the smart.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To indicate that Dido is hiding her skepticism of Aeneas’s account
- B. To emphasize that Dido has been deeply affected by Aeneas’s story
- C. To imply that Dido engages both emotionally and intellectually with Aeneas
- D. To suggest that Dido is worried that Aeneas might discover a secret she is keeping from him

ID: 93aaf0ab Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to foreground Queen Dido’s strong emotional response to Aeneas’s story. Throughout, the text emphasizes how deeply the queen is affected by both Aeneas’s tale and persona. At the outset, the speaker explicitly states that "anxious cares...seiz’d the queen" and then uses the metaphor of fire ("within her veins a flame unseen" and "secret fire") to evoke the warmth of Dido’s feelings for Aeneas. In addition, the line "His words, his looks, imprinted in her heart" suggests the deep impression that Aeneas’s story makes on Dido, eliciting passion for him ("improv[ing] the passion") and empathy for his suffering ("increas[ing] the smart").

Choice A is incorrect because there’s no indication in the text that Dido is skeptical of Aeneas’s account, much less that she’s trying to conceal that skepticism. On the contrary, the text shows her being moved by his words and developing feelings for him. Choice C is incorrect. While the text mentions that Dido is impressed by Aeneas’s "valor, acts, and birth," which might suggest (but doesn’t necessarily entail) intellectual engagement, the text doesn’t represent Dido’s engagement with Aeneas in a manner that suggests a balance between emotion and intellect. Rather, the text primarily emphasizes her emotional response—specifically her attraction to Aeneas and her emotional investment in his story, indicating that his "valor, acts, and birth inspire / Her soul with love, and fan the secret fire" and that his words and looks elicit passion and empathy. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that Dido is worried about Aeneas discovering a secret she is concealing from him. Though the text begins by mentioning Dido’s "anxious cares," this refers to her growing passion for Aeneas and pity for his suffering, not to worry about a secret she is concealing. The text’s reference to a "flame unseen" and "secret fire" points to Dido’s growing feelings for Aeneas

that develop as he recounts his tale, not to a secret that existed before their encounter; moreover, the text provides no indication that Dido is worried Aeneas might discover these feelings.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 257a71c4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 257a71c4

K.D. Leka and colleagues found that the Sun’s corona provides an advance indication of solar flares—intense eruptions of electromagnetic radiation that emanate from active regions in the Sun’s photosphere and can interfere with telecommunications on Earth. Preceding a flare, the corona temporarily exhibits increased brightness above the region where the flare is _____.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. antecedent
- B. impending
- C. innocuous
- D. perpetual

ID: 257a71c4 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of advance indications of solar flares. In this context the word "impending" means imminent or approaching. The text mentions a study by Leka and colleagues that found that the Sun’s corona provides an advance indication of solar flares. The text then points out why such an advance indication would be useful—solar flares can interfere with communications on Earth—and concludes by describing the characteristic of the corona that gives warning of a solar flare. The text indicates that this characteristic—increased brightness in a particular region of the corona—comes before the appearance of the flare. Therefore, in context, the best answer would indicate that the flare is approaching, or impending.

Choice A is incorrect. The best answer would be one that indicates that the increased brightness of the Sun’s corona precedes the appearance of the flare. But if the flare were "antecedent," or previous, then the flare would instead precede the appearance of the increased brightness of the corona, a statement that is logically inconsistent. Choice C is incorrect. The word "innocuous," or harmless, does not logically complete the text; since solar flares can interfere with communications on Earth, they cannot reasonably be described as innocuous. Choice D is incorrect. If the solar flares have an advance indication of their appearance, then there must therefore be a time before the appearance of the flares when they do not exist. But the word "perpetual," or never-ending, would in context indicate that the flare exists at the same time as the advance indication provided by the Sun’s corona, which would not make logical sense.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1cc51bd0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 1cc51bd0

The following text is from the 1923 poem “Black Finger” by Angelina Weld Grimké, a Black American writer. A cypress is a type of evergreen tree.

I have just seen a most beautiful thing,
Slim and still,
 Against a gold, gold sky,
 A straight black cypress,
Sensitive,
Exquisite,
A black finger
Pointing upwards.
Why, beautiful still finger, are you black?
And why are you pointing upwards?

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. The speaker assesses a natural phenomenon, then questions the accuracy of her assessment.
- B. The speaker describes a distinctive sight in nature, then ponders what meaning to attribute to that sight.
- C. The speaker presents an outdoor scene, then considers a human behavior occurring within that scene.
- D. The speaker examines her surroundings, then speculates about their influence on her emotional state.

ID: 1cc51bd0 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes the overall structure of the text. First, the speaker describes observing a “most beautiful” sight: a tree (“black cypress”) standing out from the golden sky behind it, looking like a person’s finger “pointing upwards” and appearing “sensitive” and “exquisite.” Then the speaker wonders about the image’s meaning, asking why the finger is black and why it’s pointing upward. Thus, the text moves from the speaker’s description of a distinctive sight in nature to her pondering about what meaning to attribute to that sight.

Choice A is incorrect because the speaker assesses a natural sight—a “black cypress” tree standing “against a gold, gold sky” like a pointed finger—but doesn’t question the accuracy of her own assessment. Although she wonders why the finger, which is really a tree, is black and why it’s pointing, the speaker doesn’t suggest that her belief that the tree resembles a finger is wrong. Choice C is incorrect. Although the speaker describes seeing a “black cypress” tree standing “against a gold, gold sky” like a pointed finger, she wonders about that natural image (asking why the finger, which is really a tree, is black and why it’s pointing) and doesn’t give any indication that any people are present in the scene. Choice D is incorrect. Although the speaker examines and wonders about

one thing in her surroundings—a “black cypress” tree standing “against a gold, gold sky” like a pointed finger—she doesn’t address her own emotional state or consider how it’s affected by her surroundings.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b2b0ed19

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: b2b0ed19

According to Indian economist and sociologist Radhakamal Mukerjee (1889–1968), the Eurocentric concepts that informed early twentieth-century social scientific methods—for example, the idea that all social relations are reducible to struggles between individuals—had little relevance for India. Making the social sciences more responsive to Indians’ needs, Mukerjee argued, required constructing analytical categories informed by India’s cultural and ecological circumstances. Mukerjee thus proposed the communalist “Indian village” as the ideal model on which to base Indian economic and social policy.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. The text recounts Mukerjee’s early training in the social scientific disciplines and then lists social policies whose implementation Mukerjee oversaw.
- B. The text mentions some of Mukerjee’s economic theories and then traces their impact on other Indian social scientists of the twentieth century.
- C. The text presents Mukerjee’s critique of the social sciences and then provides an example of his attempts to address issues he identified in his critique.
- D. The text explains an influential economic theory and then demonstrates how that theory was more important to Mukerjee’s work than other social scientists have acknowledged.

ID: b2b0ed19 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The text does indeed present Mukerjee’s critique of the social sciences—that they were too Eurocentric—and then provides an example of how he attempted to address the issues he identified: by suggesting a social science model based on the Indian village.

Choice A is incorrect. The text doesn’t discuss Mukerjee’s early training or his oversight of the implementation of social policies at all. Choice B is incorrect. The text never discusses any other Indian social scientists. Choice D is incorrect. The text never mentions other social scientists’ responses to Mukerjee’s work.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3b216fad

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 3b216fad

The following text is from Walt Whitman’s 1860 poem “Calamus 24.”

I HEAR it is charged against me that I seek to destroy institutions;
But really I am neither for nor against institutions
(What indeed have I in common with them?—Or what with the destruction of them?),
Only I will establish in the Mannahatta [Manhattan] and in every city of These States, inland and seaboard,
And in the fields and woods, and above every keel [ship] little or large, that dents the water,
Without edifices, or rules, or trustees, or any argument,
The institution of the dear love of comrades.

- Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?
- A. The speaker questions an increasingly prevalent attitude, then summarizes his worldview.
 - B. The speaker regrets his isolation from others, then predicts a profound change in society.
 - C. The speaker concedes his personal shortcomings, then boasts of his many achievements.
 - D. The speaker addresses a criticism leveled against him, then announces a grand ambition of his.

ID: 3b216fad Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it best describes the overall structure of the text. The speaker begins by stating that he has heard that others are accusing him of seeking to destroy institutions. The speaker then addresses this criticism by stating that he is “neither for nor against institutions.” Instead, the speaker states that his ultimate goal is to instill “the institution of the dear love of comrades” everywhere in the country. Therefore, the overall structure of the text is best described as an address of criticism followed by an announcement of a grand ambition.

Choice A is incorrect. While the speaker does address an opinion of him that he believes to be untrue, he doesn’t indicate that this attitude has become increasingly prevalent. The speaker also concludes by explaining his goal for the future rather than his current worldview. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t portray the speaker as isolated or regretful, and the speaker gestures toward a hope for societal change but doesn’t offer an explicit prediction that it will happen. Choice C is incorrect because the speaker addresses a criticism of him that he believes to be false; he doesn’t admit any personal shortcomings. Moreover, the speaker concludes by stating a goal he has rather than showcasing his achievements.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7e1a0d46

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 7e1a0d46

Before the Mariner 2 mission completed a successful flyby of Venus in 1962, astronomers’ ideas about the planet were little more than _____. Venus’s atmosphere is so thick that Earth-based observations had yielded very little information about the planet.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. summations
- B. conjectures
- C. conclusions
- D. exemplifications

ID: 7e1a0d46 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of pre-Mariner 2 ideas about Venus. In this context, “conjectures” means guesses or inferences formed without sufficient evidence. The text indicates that before the successful 1962 flyby, Earth-based observations of Venus had produced “very little information” because of the planet’s thick atmosphere. The limited scope of astronomers’ earlier knowledge of Venus is also emphasized by the text’s description of their ideas as being “little more than” something before the flyby. This context conveys that before Mariner 2 flew close to Venus, astronomers lacked the evidence needed for their ideas about the planet to be much more than conjectures, or guesses.

Choice A is incorrect. In this context, “summations” would be final conclusions reached by putting all information together. Because the text emphasizes that very *little* information about Venus was available before the 1962 flyby, it wouldn’t make sense to describe astronomers’ pre-Mariner 2 ideas about Venus as summations; the text suggests that astronomers didn’t have enough information to draw solid conclusions about Venus. Choice C is incorrect. In this context, “conclusions” would be reasoned final judgments or outcomes. Because the text emphasizes that very *little* information about Venus was available before the 1962 flyby, it wouldn’t make sense to describe astronomers’ pre-Mariner 2 ideas about Venus as conclusions; the text suggests that astronomers didn’t have what they would have needed to make informed judgments about Venus. Choice D is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to describe astronomers’ pre-Mariner 2 ideas about Venus as “exemplifications,” or examples that illustrate something; people’s ideas about a subject are the ideas themselves, not illustrations. Further, the text emphasizes that the astronomers had little information before 1962, suggesting they didn’t have much to work with to form examples.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ee446194

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: ee446194

Text 1

Good art often challenges and disrupts social and aesthetic norms, but the creation of public art—paintings, sculptures, and performance pieces displayed in nonmuseum or nontheatrical public settings—typically requires broad agreement among artists, civic officials, and community members about the works’ message and artistic goals. Public art that fails to appease everyone by being sufficiently aesthetically and conceptually bland almost inevitably provokes backlash.

Text 2

Public art is commonly displayed in spaces intended for purposes other than meaningful aesthetic engagement. Some critics of public art therefore note that norm-defying pieces that aren’t effectively integrated within their surroundings in a manner that primes passersby to appreciate the pieces’ merits (as is often the case) tend to be regarded more unfavorably than similarly provocative art encountered in museums is.

Based on the texts, how would the critics mentioned in Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1?

- A. By arguing that the reason members of the general public might disagree about a public artwork’s merits is unrelated to the unconventionality of its appearance and ideas
- B. By agreeing with the idea that only works of art that are universally appealing are suitable for displaying in public spaces
- C. By disputing the notion that civic leaders and community members are easily placated by art that is intended mainly to reinforce social norms
- D. By contending that the kinds of reactions controversial public artworks often receive aren’t exclusively the result of attributes inherent in the works themselves

ID: ee446194 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because the critics mentioned in Text 2 would argue that negative reactions to controversial public art are not solely the result of the nature of the art itself. The claim in Text 1 suggests that public artworks tend to provoke backlash when they are not “aesthetically and conceptually bland.” This implies that the content of public art alone can cause backlash. However, the critics in Text 2 offer a more nuanced explanation. They argue that norm-defying pieces of public art that are not “effectively integrated within their surroundings” are more likely to be judged harshly by the public. They also imply that a museum provides a context that prepares viewers to expect challenging art, while public environments that serve other purposes often do not. This indicates that the critics in Text 2 would contend that factors beyond the attributes of the art, like environment and presentation, play a significant role in how public art is received.

Choice A is incorrect because the critics in Text 2 do not argue that unconventionality is unrelated to public disagreement about a public artwork’s merits. Rather, they acknowledge that norm-defying pieces do face unfavorable reactions, but they attribute such

reactions to contextual factors like poor integration with the environment rather than dismissing the role of unconventionality entirely. Choice B is incorrect because the critics in Text 2 do not advocate for restricting public art to universally appealing works. Instead, they argue that better integration with the surroundings and situating the work in appropriate contexts could help norm-defying art be better received by passersby. Choice C is incorrect because the critics in Text 2 do not address whether civic leaders and community members are easily satisfied by norm-reinforcing art. The critics in Text 2 instead argue that installation and integration with the surrounding environment factor into how norm-defying art is received by the general public, rather than disputing how people respond to conventional art.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 99f671a7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 99f671a7

The following text is from Charlotte Forten Grimké’s 1888 poem “At Newport.”

Oh, deep delight to watch the gladsome waves
Exultant leap upon the rugged rocks;
Ever repulsed, yet ever rushing on—
Filled with a life that will not know defeat;
To see the glorious hues of sky and sea.
The distant snowy sails, glide spirit like,
Into an unknown world, to feel the sweet
Enchantment of the sea thrill all the soul,
Clearing the clouded brain, making the heart
Leap joyous as it own bright, singing waves!

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. It portrays the surroundings as an imposing and intimidating scene.
- B. It characterizes the sea’s waves as a relentless and enduring force.
- C. It conveys the speaker’s ambivalence about the natural world.
- D. It draws a contrast between the sea’s waves and the speaker’s thoughts.

ID: 99f671a7 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes how the underlined portion functions in the text as a whole. The text presents the speaker’s experience of viewing the sea. In the underlined portion, the speaker focuses on the idea that the waves hitting rocks on the shore are a relentless and enduring force: they are constantly pushed back (“ever repulsed”) but always return (“ever rushing on”), as though they have an energy that can’t be overcome (“a life that will not know defeat”).

Choice A is incorrect. Although the underlined portion characterizes the waves as a relentless force (always “repulsed” but still “rushing on” and never being defeated), the speaker doesn’t suggest that the surroundings are intimidating. Instead, the speaker presents the scene in a positive way, describing the “deep delight” of the “gladsome,” or cheerful, waves and feeling “the heart / Leap joyous” while viewing the sea. Choice C is incorrect because the underlined portion doesn’t suggest that the speaker is ambivalent, or has mixed feelings about, the natural world. Instead, it presents a single view of one part of the immediate surroundings: the speaker characterizes the sea’s waves as an unstoppable force, since they are constantly pushed back but always return (“ever repulsed, yet ever rushing on”). Choice D is incorrect. Although the text later suggests the speaker’s view of her own thoughts by referring to a “clouded brain” and a heart that leaps joyously, this reference neither occurs within the

underlined portion nor establishes a clear contrast with the relentless determination of the waves. The underlined portion addresses only the speaker's view of the waves and doesn't suggest what her own thoughts might be.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 282645dd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 282645dd

Recent measurements of the mass of the *W* boson (a subatomic particle) were notable not only for the mere fact that the particle’s mass differed from expectations but for the _____ of that difference: the measured mass of the *W* boson was seven standard deviations higher than predicted by the standard model of particle physics.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. cause
- B. existence
- C. implication
- D. scale

ID: 282645dd Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the *W* boson. In this context, "scale" means size or extent. The text indicates that recent measurements of the *W* boson were remarkable because they revealed the subatomic particle’s mass to be much greater ("seven standard deviations higher") than had been expected based on a standard model. This context conveys not only that the measurements differed from predictions but also that the extent of the difference was very large.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text indicates that there was a very large difference between the predicted mass and the actual measured mass of the subatomic particle, it doesn’t explain the cause of, or reason behind, that difference. Choice B is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that the measurements of the subatomic particle were notable because they differed from expectations and also because a difference existed between the measurements and what had been predicted; the text would be repeating the idea that there was a difference instead of adding to that idea. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t convey any implications of, or consequences of or conclusions drawn from, the fact that the mass of the subatomic particle differed from expectations; the context indicates only that the actual measured mass was much higher than the predicted mass.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 55faec5b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 55faec5b

Text 1

For decades, bluegrass musicians have debated whether their genre should exclude influences from mainstream genres such as rock. Many insist that bluegrass is defined by its adherence to the folk music of the US South, out of which bluegrass emerged. Such “purists,” as they are known, regard the recordings of Bill Monroe, which established the bluegrass sound in the 1940s, as a standard against which the genre should still be measured.

Text 2

Bluegrass isn’t simply an extension of folk traditions into the era of recorded music. In reality, Bill Monroe created the bluegrass sound in the 1940s by combining Southern folk music with commercial genres that had arisen only a few decades before, such as jazz and the blues. Since bluegrass has always been a mixed genre, contemporary bluegrass musicians should not be forbidden from incorporating into it influences from rock and other mainstream genres.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely regard the perspective of bluegrass purists, as described in Text 1?

- A. As inconsistent, since bluegrass purists themselves enjoy other musical genres
- B. As unrealistic, since bluegrass purists have no way of enforcing their musical preferences
- C. As shortsighted, because bluegrass could enlarge its audience by including influences from mainstream genres
- D. As illogical, because the purists overlook crucial aspects of how the bluegrass sound first originated.

ID: 55faec5b Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. According to Author 1, the “purists” argue that bluegrass should stick to its folk music roots. But Author 2 points out that this isn’t how bluegrass emerged: it actually got its sound from a mix of folk, jazz, and blues.

Choice A is incorrect. There’s nothing in Text 2 about what other genres the purists enjoy, so this inference about Author 2’s views isn’t supported. Choice B is incorrect. There’s nothing in Text 2 about whether or how purists can enforce their preferences, so this inference about Author 2’s views isn’t supported. Choice C is incorrect. There’s nothing in Text 2 about the size of bluegrass’s audience, so this inference about Author 2’s views isn’t supported.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b346694a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: b346694a

The work of Kiowa painter T.C. Cannon derives its power in part from the tension among his _____ influences: classic European portraiture, with its realistic treatment of faces; the American pop art movement, with its vivid colors; and flatstyle, the intertribal painting style that rejects the effect of depth typically achieved through shading and perspective.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. complementary
- B. unknown
- C. disparate
- D. interchangeable

ID: b346694a Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the artistic styles that have influenced Cannon’s work. As used in this context, “disparate” means distinct or dissimilar. The text indicates that a tension exists among the styles that have influenced Cannon’s work and goes on to describe how those styles differ: classic European portraiture favors realism, American pop art uses vivid colors, and intertribal flatstyle rejects the use of shading and perspective to achieve depth. This context suggests that the styles that have influenced Cannon’s work are disparate.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that there is a tension among the influences on Cannon’s artwork, so it wouldn’t make sense to say that the influences are “complementary,” or that they complete one another or make up for one another’s deficiencies. Choice B is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to characterize Cannon’s influences as “unknown,” or not familiar; it’s clear that the influences are known because the text goes on to list them. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that there is a tension among the influences on Cannon’s work, not that they are “interchangeable,” or capable of being used in one another’s place.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4ecb18e7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 4ecb18e7

Raymond Antrobus, an accomplished poet and writer of prose, recently released his debut spoken word poetry album, *The First Time I Wore Hearing Aids*, in collaboration with producer Ian Brennan. The album contains both autobiographical and reflective pieces combining Antrobus’s spoken words with Brennan’s fragmented audio elements and pieces of music to convey how people who are deaf may experience sound, both its presence and absence. Some critics suggest that the album questions the function of sound in the world, highlighting that the experience of sound is multifaceted.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It introduces a collaborative spoken word poetry project, details the approach taken to produce the work, and then provides an example of critique the album received upon release.
- B. It mentions a collection of spoken word poems, distinguishes one poem as being an exemplar on the album, and then offers a summary of the subject matter of the whole collection.
- C. It summarizes the efforts to produce a collection of spoken word poems, presents biographies of two people who worked on the album, and speculates about the meaning behind the poetry.
- D. It connects two artists to the same spoken word poetry project, explains the extent of their collaboration on each poem, and then provides an overview of the technique used to produce the work.

ID: 4ecb18e7 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The text first introduces the album as being a collaboration between Antrobus and Brennan, then describes the approach taken to produce it, then mentions how critics have said that it calls into question the function of sound.

Choice B is incorrect. While the text does mention a collection of spoken word poems, it doesn’t single out one poem as being particularly noteworthy. Additionally, the text doesn’t simply summarize the subject matter—it goes into detail about the content and production of the album. Choice C is incorrect. The text doesn’t provide biographical information about the two artists, and the text doesn’t speculate about the meaning behind the poetry—instead, it relays what some critics have said about the album. Choice D is incorrect. The text doesn’t provide just an overview of the production techniques used but instead goes into more detail about the content and audio elements of the album, as well as critical response to the album.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3a2cad84

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 3a2cad84

One popular theory of the origin of the Moon, the “big whack,” posits that a protoplanet called Theia collided with Earth, flinging debris into orbit that eventually coalesced into the Moon. Until recently, Theia was _____, but researcher Qian Yuan and colleagues now claim to have identified pieces of the protoplanet in the lowermost section of Earth’s mantle.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. desultory
- B. spurious
- C. veritable
- D. notional

ID: 3a2cad84 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Theia and the origin of the Moon. In this context, "notional" means theoretical or only an idea. The text indicates that although something was once true of Theia, the protoplanet one theory holds collided with Earth and created debris that became the Moon, researchers now claim to have identified pieces of it deep in Earth’s mantle. In other words, having direct evidence of Theia is a new development. This context suggests that before evidence was found, Theia was only theoretical—that is, that it was notional.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that Theia, a protoplanet, was "desultory," which in this context would mean moving away from the matter at hand; indeed, the text focuses on the "big whack" theory of the origin of the Moon and indicates that Theia is a central part of that theory. Choice B is incorrect because the text makes the point that something was true of Theia until recently and suggests that this has changed now that researchers believe they have found pieces of the protoplanet deep in Earth’s mantle. It wouldn’t make sense to say that Theia was actually "spurious," or false, until researchers found direct evidence of the protoplanet. (Although Theia’s existence might not have been certain, it would not have been false simply because there was no evidence of it.) Choice C is incorrect because the text makes the point that something was true of Theia until recently and suggests that this has changed now that researchers believe they have found pieces of the protoplanet deep in Earth’s mantle. It wouldn’t make sense to say that Theia was "veritable," or real, before researchers found direct evidence of its existence: the evidence would instead confirm that Theia was real.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6eabd93d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 6eabd93d

Economist Jingting Fan argues that the effects of international trade may display spatial variation at sub-national levels. For instance, imported goods may reduce expenses for a country’s average consumer, but for consumers living far from ports, high intranational transport costs could _____ the price advantages associated with imports.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. nullify
- B. denigrate
- C. underestimate
- D. misconstrue

ID: 6eabd93d Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it logically completes the text’s discussion of imported goods and consumer prices. In this context, "nullify" most nearly means negate or undermine. The text indicates that importing goods to a country can reduce consumer prices in that country, then cautions that the costs of transporting goods within the country is also a factor. These transportation costs likely raise the prices that must be paid by people who live far from the ports of entry. Therefore, the intranational transportation costs could nullify the price advantages to consumers of importing goods.

Choice B is incorrect. In this context, "denigrate" would most nearly mean disparage or deny the importance of. Since transportation costs would not be capable of denying the importance of price advantages, it would not make sense to state that intranational transportation costs denigrate the price advantages of importing goods. Choice C is incorrect. In this context, "underestimate" would most nearly mean predict a lower value for, or to undervalue, someone or something. Though transportation costs might be undervalued, they cannot themselves undervalue something else, so it would not make sense to state that intranational transportation costs underestimate the price advantages of importing goods. Choice D is incorrect. In this context, "misconstrue" would most nearly mean misunderstand. Since transport costs are not capable of understanding, it would not make sense to claim that intranational transportation costs misconstrue the price advantages of importing goods.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7c28b511

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 7c28b511

Text 1

Hycean planets are a class of exoplanets (planets outside our solar system) with oceans of liquid water—critical to supporting life—and atmospheres rich in hydrogen. Computer models have determined that for potential hycean planets, the range of the habitable zone (HZ), the distance from a star that allows a planet to retain liquid water on its surface, begins at about 1 astronomical unit (AU). In 2021, Nikku Madhusudhan et al. identified K2-18 b as a hycean candidate, noting that the planet is located right on the inner edge of the HZ.

Text 2

In a 2023 paper, Shang-Min Tsai et al. claimed that the hydrogen-rich atmospheres of K2-18 b and other hycean candidates admit wavelengths of light that cause elevated surface temperatures and increased water evaporation. Unlike earlier assessments, Tsai et al.’s calculations therefore placed the inner edge for these planets’ HZ as far out as 3.85 AU.

- Based on the texts, how would Tsai et al. (Text 2) most likely respond to Madhusudhan et al.’s research, as presented in Text 1?
- A. By stating that the chemical composition of the atmosphere of the hycean candidate Madhusudhan et al. identified suggests that this planet’s surface is unlikely to harbor liquid water
 - B. By maintaining that Madhusudhan et al. relied on a model whose estimates of surface temperatures on hycean candidates are likely too high
 - C. By observing that unlike the hycean candidate Madhusudhan et al. discovered, most other types of planets with hydrogen-rich atmospheres are likely located within the HZ
 - D. By arguing that K2-18 b and other hycean candidates are unlikely to support life because these planets are located too far from the stars they orbit

ID: 7c28b511 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it reflects how Tsai et al. would most likely respond to Madhusudhan et al.’s identification of K2-18 b as a hycean candidate. Text 1 establishes that the habitable zone (HZ) for potential hycean planets, which are typified by abundant liquid water and hydrogen-rich atmospheres, represents “the distance from a star that allows a planet to retain liquid water on its surface” and is estimated to begin at about 1 astronomical unit (AU). Based on this characterization of the HZ, Madhusudhan et al. identified K2-18 b as a hycean candidate whose location falls on the “inner edge” of the HZ—implying that its distance from its star is about 1 AU. However, Text 2 presents Tsai et al.’s claim that the same hydrogen-rich atmospheres that typify K2-18 b and other hycean candidates “admit wavelengths of light that cause elevated surface temperatures and increased water evaporation,” phenomena that would be exacerbated by proximity to their host stars. Tsai et al. instead placed the inner edge of the HZ “as far out as 3.85 AU,” implying that hycean candidates at lesser distances from their stars would be unlikely to maintain liquid oceans because of elevated surface temperatures and subsequent water evaporation. According to Tsai et al.’s HZ

estimate, K2-18 b—at roughly 1 AU—would be too close to its star to retain liquid water. Therefore, based on the details in the texts, Tsai et al. would most likely respond that the very atmospheric composition that defines K2-18 b as a hycean candidate suggests that it is unlikely to harbor liquid water on its surface.

Choice B is incorrect. In contrast to the suggestion that Madhusudhan et al.’s estimates of the surface temperature of hycean candidates are “likely too high,” Tsai et al.’s findings suggest the opposite: earlier assessments of the HZ didn’t fully account for the warming effect of wavelengths of light admitted by these planets’ hydrogen-rich atmospheres, which is why Tsai et al. placed the edge of the HZ farther out. The information in Text 2 therefore suggests that Tsai et al. would view Madhusudhan et al.’s temperature estimates as too low rather than as too high. Choice C is incorrect because neither text discusses other types of planets with hydrogen-rich atmospheres or compares them to hycean candidates. It therefore doesn’t follow from the information in the texts that Tsai et al. would observe that most other hydrogen-rich planets are likely within the HZ. Text 2 only indicates that the HZ for hycean candidates begins at about 3.85 AU and that K2-18 b therefore isn’t likely to be within the HZ, not that other planets with hydrogen-rich atmospheres are mostly located within the HZ. Choice D is incorrect because it mischaracterizes Tsai et al.’s findings. Rather than indicating that K2-18 b and other hycean candidates are “too far from the stars they orbit,” Tsai et al.’s findings suggest the opposite problem. Because these planets’ hydrogen-rich atmospheres admit wavelengths of light that cause elevated temperatures and water evaporation at distances of less than 3.85 AU, Tsai et al. would be more likely to argue that K2-18 b (at a distance of about 1 AU) and planets like it are too close to their stars, not too far from them. Moreover, Text 2 doesn’t suggest anything about hycean candidates more generally being unable to support life, only that hycean candidates at distances less than 3.85 AU from their stars, like K2-18 b, likely don’t have the liquid water needed to sustain life. Presumably, hycean candidates that are within the HZ described by Tsai et al. could harbor liquid oceans necessary for supporting life.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID baab6d04

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: baab6d04

Vadamalai Elangovan and Ganapathi Marimuthu showed that high moonlight intensity inhibits the activity of the greater short-nosed fruit bat (*Cynopterus sphinx*), a result explicable in terms of benefits and costs: greater lunar intensity may not enable the bats to increase foraging success enough to offset the higher chance of detection by predatory owls or hawks. Most other nocturnal mammals respond to lunar intensity variations similarly to greater short-nosed fruit bats, but mongoose lemurs (*Eulemur mongoz*) display the opposite pattern, as their heavy reliance on visual foraging results in a different balance of reward and risk.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It discusses two different responses to the same natural phenomenon, explains why one of those responses occurs, and then suggests that the other response still needs to be explained.
- B. It describes and accounts for a finding, characterizes the finding as representative of a general pattern, and then describes and accounts for an exception to that pattern.
- C. It presents and explains a study result, indicates that the result is similar to the results of many other studies, and then attributes a conflicting study result to a difference in that study’s methods.
- D. It introduces an observation of a behavioral pattern, presents an explanation for the pattern, and then describes an exception to the pattern that casts doubt on that explanation.

ID: baab6d04 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes the overall structure of the text. The text begins by describing a study’s finding about greater short-nosed fruit bats—namely, that high moonlight intensity inhibits the bats’ activity—and also accounts for that finding, stating that this occurs because the potential increase in foraging success that greater lunar intensity enables doesn’t offset these bats’ increased vulnerability to predators (whose vision is also implied to become more acute under intense moonlight). The text goes on to characterize this finding as representative of a general pattern, stating that many nocturnal mammals behave similarly in response to changes in lunar intensity. The text concludes by describing an exception to this pattern, explaining that mongoose lemurs display an opposite tendency because they rely heavily on visual foraging. This strategy presumably would allow them to derive more benefit from greater lunar intensity than many other nocturnal mammals would, resulting in a "different balance of reward and risk" than exists for other nocturnal mammals. Therefore, the overall structure of the text is best described as a description and account of a finding, a characterization of that finding as representative of a pattern, and then a description and account of an exception to that pattern.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text discusses two different responses to variations in moonlight intensity, explaining that as moonlight intensity increases, greater short-nosed fruit bats and many other nocturnal mammals decrease their foraging activity but mongoose lemurs increase their foraging activity, it doesn’t leave one of these responses unexplained. The text accounts for

both the typical response to increased lunar intensity (reduced activity due to predation risk) and the exception (increased activity due to a reliance on visual foraging) by making reference to a cost-benefit framework. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text presents a study's finding about the effect of increased lunar intensity on greater short-nosed fruit bats' activity before going on to contrast this behavior with the fact that mongoose lemurs display the opposite response to increased lunar intensity, the text doesn't explicitly invoke other studies and doesn't attribute this difference in observed behavior to the fact that the study of greater short-nosed fruit bats used different methods than studies of mongoose lemurs did. Rather, the text explains that the different observed behaviors can be attributed to differences in species' foraging strategies. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text characterizes the behavior of mongoose lemurs in response to increased lunar intensity as an exception to a pattern of behavior observed in other nocturnal mammal species, this exception doesn't cast any doubt on the explanation that is offered for the general pattern observed among other species. Instead, the text uses the same cost-benefit framework to explain why increased lunar intensity is associated with decreased activity by greater short-nosed fruit bats and other nocturnal mammals but with increased activity by mongoose lemurs.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6041bb40

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 6041bb40

The following text is from Joseph Conrad’s 1907 novel *The Secret Agent: A Simple Tale*. Mr. Verloc is navigating the London streets on his way to a meeting.

Before reaching Knightsbridge, Mr. Verloc took a turn to the left out of the busy main thoroughfare, uproarious with the traffic of swaying omnibuses and trotting vans, in the almost silent, swift flow of hansoms [horse-drawn carriages]. Under his hat, worn with a slight backward tilt, his hair had been carefully brushed into respectful sleekness; for his business was with an Embassy. And Mr. Verloc, steady like a rock—a soft kind of rock—marched now along a street which could with every propriety be described as private.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined phrase in the text as a whole?

- A. It qualifies an earlier description of Mr. Verloc.
- B. It emphasizes an internal struggle Mr. Verloc experiences.
- C. It contrasts Mr. Verloc with his surroundings.
- D. It reveals a private opinion Mr. Verloc holds.

ID: 6041bb40 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The underline phrase qualifies (meaning adds limits or conditions to) the description of Mr. Verloc as “steady like a rock,” adding that he is a “soft” rock.

Choice B is incorrect. In fact, the passage never mentions Mr. Verloc experiencing any internal struggles. Choice C is incorrect. The underlined phrase doesn’t contrast Mr. Verloc with his surroundings, but is instead modifying the description of him as a rock. Choice D is incorrect. The underlined phrase doesn’t reveal a private opinion Mr. Verloc holds: instead, it further describes his character for the reader.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e56287a1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: e56287a1

Text 1

Ecologists have long wondered how thousands of microscopic phytoplankton species can live together near ocean surfaces competing for the same resources. According to conventional wisdom, one species should emerge after outcompeting the rest. So why do so many species remain? Ecologists’ many efforts to explain this phenomenon still haven’t uncovered a satisfactory explanation.

Text 2

Ecologist Michael Behrenfeld and colleagues have connected phytoplankton’s diversity to their microscopic size. Because these organisms are so tiny, they are spaced relatively far apart from each other in ocean water and, moreover, experience that water as a relatively dense substance. This in turn makes it hard for them to move around and interact with one another. Therefore, says Behrenfeld’s team, direct competition among phytoplankton probably happens much less than previously thought.

Based on the texts, how would Behrenfeld and colleagues (Text 2) most likely respond to the “conventional wisdom” discussed in Text 1?

- A. By arguing that it is based on a misconception about phytoplankton species competing with one another
- B. By asserting that it fails to recognize that routine replenishment of ocean nutrients prevents competition between phytoplankton species
- C. By suggesting that their own findings help clarify how phytoplankton species are able to compete with larger organisms
- D. By recommending that more ecologists focus their research on how competition among phytoplankton species is increased with water density

ID: e56287a1 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because based on Text 2, it represents how Behrenfeld and colleagues would most likely respond to the “conventional wisdom” discussed in Text 1. The conventional wisdom cited holds the opinion that when there is species diversity within a phytoplankton population, “one species should emerge after outcompeting the rest”—that is, after being so successful in competing for resources that the other species vanish from the population. However, Text 2 explains that according to Behrenfeld and colleagues, phytoplankton are so small and spaced so far apart in the water that there is “much less” direct competition for resources within phytoplankton populations than scientists had previously thought.

Choice B is incorrect because Text 2 never discusses whether routine replenishment of ocean nutrients affects competition between phytoplankton species. Choice C is incorrect because the interspecies competition discussed in both texts is specifically between phytoplankton species, and neither text considers whether phytoplankton compete for resources with larger

nonphytoplankton species. Choice D is incorrect because according to Text 2, Behrenfeld and colleagues argue that water density decreases, not increases, competition between phytoplankton species.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 439191e9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 439191e9

For her 2021 art installation *Anthem*, Wu Tsang joined forces with singer and composer Beverly Glenn-Copeland to produce a piece that critics found truly _____. they praised Tsang for creatively transforming a museum rotunda into a dynamic exhibit by projecting filmed images of Glenn-Copeland onto a massive 84-foot curtain and filling the space with the sounds of his and other voices singing.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. restrained
- B. inventive
- C. inexplicable
- D. mystifying

ID: 439191e9 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the art installation *Anthem*. In this context, “inventive” means characterized by invention and creativity. The text explains that critics’ responses to the installation involved praise for Tsang’s creative transformation of a space into a dynamic exhibit with huge images and lots of sound. This context conveys that the critics found the piece particularly creative.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that critics praised the installation for being dynamic and including huge images and lots of sound, and it wouldn’t make sense to describe such an exhibit as “restrained,” or limited and not extravagant or showy. Choice C is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that critics found the installation “inexplicable,” or incapable of being explained or interpreted, since the critics were able to explain their praise for the installation’s transformation of a space with huge images and lots of sound. Choice D is incorrect because the text focuses on the idea that critics praised Tsang for creatively transforming a space into a dynamic exhibit, not that they found the installation “mystifying,” or bewildering and hard to understand. Nothing in the text suggests that the critics couldn’t understand the piece.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b45b53c3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: b45b53c3

Changes to vegetation cover and other human activities influence carbon and nitrogen levels in soil, though how deep these effects extend is unclear. Hypothesizing that differences in land use lead to differences in carbon and nitrogen levels that are not restricted to the topsoil layer (0–30 cm deep), Chukwuebuka Okolo and colleagues sampled soils across multiple land-use types (e.g., grazing land, cropland, forest) within each of several Ethiopian locations. They found, though, that across land-use types, carbon and nitrogen decreased to comparably low levels beyond depths of 30 cm.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It describes a phenomenon that scientists do not fully understand, explains a research team’s hypothesis about that phenomenon, and then describes a finding that led the team to refine the hypothesis.
- B. It introduces an unresolved scientific question, presents a research team’s hypothesis pertaining to that question, and then describes an observation made by the team that conflicts with that hypothesis.
- C. It discusses a process that scientists are somewhat unclear about, introduces competing hypotheses about that process, and then explains how a research team concluded that one of those hypotheses is likely correct.
- D. It explains a hypothesis that has been the subject of scientific debate, discusses how a research team tested that hypothesis, and then presents data the team collected that validate the hypothesis.

ID: b45b53c3 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes the overall structure of the text. The text begins by explaining that human activities influence carbon and nitrogen levels in soil, but how deeply these effects are seen in the soil remains an unresolved question. Next, the text summarizes Okolo and colleagues’ hypothesis regarding this question—which is that the different effects on carbon and nitrogen levels associated with different types of land use would also be observed below the topsoil layer—and then briefly explains the methods they used to test this hypothesis. Finally, the text states that the researchers found that at depths below the topsoil layer, carbon and nitrogen decreased to similarly low levels across all land-use types, a finding that conflicts with the team’s hypothesis presented earlier in the text. Thus, the text introduces an unresolved scientific question, presents a research team’s hypothesis pertaining to that question, and then describes an observation that the team made that conflicted with their hypothesis.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text introduces a phenomenon (the fact that human activities influence carbon and nitrogen levels in the soil) that isn’t fully understood by scientists and explains a research team’s hypothesis about the phenomenon, the text doesn’t describe how the team refined their hypothesis when a research finding contradicted it. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t discuss a process at all; rather, it poses an unsolved scientific question and presents a hypothesis that Okolo and colleagues tested to answer that question. Moreover, the text only describes one hypothesis; it doesn’t mention any competing hypotheses, nor does it suggest that Okolo’s team was able to determine which hypothesis was correct. Choice D is incorrect

because the text doesn't begin by presenting a hypothesis that is under scientific debate; rather, it presents a question that scientists have been unable to answer and then introduces a hypothesis formulated by Okolo and colleagues. While the text does explain how Okolo's team tested their hypothesis, the text goes on to say that their data conflicted with their hypothesis, not that the data validated, or supported, their hypothesis.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 56366ec0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 56366ec0

Astronomers are confident that the star Betelgeuse will eventually consume all the helium in its core and explode in a supernova. They are much less confident, however, about when this will happen, since that depends on internal characteristics of Betelgeuse that are largely unknown. Astrophysicist Sarafina El-Badry Nance and colleagues recently investigated whether acoustic waves in the star could be used to determine internal stellar states but concluded that this method could not sufficiently reveal Betelgeuse’s internal characteristics to allow its evolutionary state to be firmly fixed.

Which choice best describes the function of the second sentence in the overall structure of the text?

- A. It describes a serious limitation of the method used by Nance and colleagues.
- B. It presents the central finding reported by Nance and colleagues.
- C. It identifies the problem that Nance and colleagues attempted to solve but did not.
- D. It explains how the work of Nance and colleagues was received by others in the field.

ID: 56366ec0 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it best describes how the second sentence functions in the text as a whole. The first sentence establishes something astronomers believe with some certainty: that Betelgeuse will explode in a supernova. The second sentence then introduces a problem: astronomers aren’t certain *when* Betelgeuse will explode because they don’t have enough information about the star’s internal characteristics. Finally, the third sentence indicates that researcher Sarafina El-Badry Nance and colleagues investigated a possible method of obtaining the necessary information about Betelgeuse’s internal characteristics, though they found that the method wouldn’t be sufficient. Thus, the function of the second sentence is to identify the problem that Nance and colleagues attempted to solve but didn’t.

Choice A is incorrect because the second sentence introduces the general problem Nance and colleagues hoped to solve, not a serious limitation of how Nance and colleagues tried to solve it. It is the third sentence that introduces Nance and colleagues, but no serious limitation of their approach to studying a method of determining internal stellar states is described. Choice B is incorrect because the second sentence introduces the general problem Nance and colleagues hoped to solve, not the central finding they ultimately reported. It is the third sentence that presents Nance and colleagues’ conclusion that a potential method for determining internal stellar states would be insufficient. Choice D is incorrect because the second sentence doesn’t indicate how other astronomers or astrophysicists responded to the work done by Nance and colleagues; the text doesn’t address this information at all.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 42e42474

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 42e42474

To demonstrate that the integrity of underground metal pipes can be assessed without unearthing the pipes, engineer Aroba Saleem and colleagues _____ the tendency of some metals’ internal magnetic fields to alter under stress: the team showed that such alterations can be measured from a distance and can reveal concentrations of stress in the pipes.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. hypothesized
- B. discounted
- C. redefined
- D. exploited

ID: 42e42474 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of using magnetism to detect stress in buried metal pipes. In this context, "exploited" means made productive use of. The text indicates that the magnetic fields of some metals change under stress and that Saleem and colleagues showed that it is possible to measure those changes from a distance, thereby demonstrating that the integrity of underground metal pipes can be evaluated without having to unearth them. This context thus indicates that Saleem and colleagues made productive use of, or exploited, this tendency of the metals’ magnetic fields.

Choice A is incorrect because in this context, "hypothesized" would mean made a tentative assumption to be evaluated in a study or experiment. Although Saleem and colleagues may have had one or more hypotheses for these experiments, the text presents the information about the tendency of some metals’ magnetic fields to change under stress as a known fact that the researchers made productive use of, not as a hypothesis to be evaluated. The text after the colon indicates that the researchers were not evaluating whether such changes occur but whether those changes can be measured at a distance. Choice B is incorrect because in this context, "discounted" would mean downplayed or ignored, but the text does not suggest that Saleem and colleagues minimized or ignored the tendency of the magnetic fields of some metals to change under stress. Rather, the text indicates that this tendency is the basis for Saleem and colleagues’ method of assessing the pipes’ integrity. Choice C is incorrect because nothing in the text indicates that Saleem and colleagues "redefined," or reevaluated or reformulated, the tendency of some metals’ magnetic fields to change under stress. Instead, the text indicates that the researchers made use of that tendency to demonstrate that it is possible to evaluate the integrity of underground pipes without unearthing them.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3bf49ffc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 3bf49ffc

Containing over 160 billion base pairs of DNA resulting from polyploidy (whole genome duplication) and accumulation of noncoding DNA without significant deletion, the genome of *Tmesipteris oblaneolata* (New Caledonian fork fern) is the largest known among eukaryotes—and, given the high biological costs of extremely large genomes, is unlikely to be _____.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. protracted
- B. superseded
- C. curtailed
- D. obviated

ID: 3bf49ffc Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the fork fern’s enormous genome. In this context, "superseded" means surpassed or exceeded by something else. The text establishes that this plant has "the largest known" genome among eukaryotes and mentions "the high biological costs of extremely large genomes," suggesting there are natural constraints that make it biologically disadvantageous to maintain such massive genetic material. This context supports the idea that it’s unlikely another organism will evolve an even larger genome that would replace this plant’s record—that is, its status as having the largest genome is unlikely to be superseded.

Choice A is incorrect because in this context, "protracted" would mean drawn out over time or space, and the text focuses on the record size of the New Caledonian fork fern’s genome and the fact that extremely large genomes carry "high biological costs." This information suggests that the biological upper limit for genome size may have been reached and that the New Caledonian fork fern’s genome is therefore unlikely to be surpassed, or superseded, not that it’s unlikely to be protracted. Choice C is incorrect because in this context, "curtailed" would mean cut short or reduced, and the text focuses on the record size of the New Caledonian fork fern’s genome and the fact that extremely large genomes carry "high biological costs." This information suggests that the biological upper limit for genome size may have been reached and that the New Caledonian fork fern’s genome is therefore unlikely to be surpassed, or superseded, not that it’s unlikely to be curtailed. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, "obviated" would mean made unnecessary or redundant, and the text focuses on the record size of the New Caledonian fork fern’s genome and the fact that extremely large genomes carry "high biological costs." This information suggests that the biological upper limit for genome size may have been reached and that the New Caledonian fork fern’s genome is therefore unlikely to be surpassed, or superseded, not that it’s unlikely to be obviated.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b3bfc1d2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: b3bfc1d2

The following text is from George Marion McClellan’s 1895 poem “Eternity.”

My spirit swoons, and all my senses cry
For Ocean’s breast and covering of the sky.
Rock me to sleep, ye waves, and outward bound,
Just let me drift far out from toil and care,
Where lapping of the waves shall be the sound,
Which mingled with the winds that gently bear
Me on between a peaceful sea and sky,
To make my soothing slumberous lullaby.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To illustrate the increasing intensity of the speaker’s desire to escape ongoing hardship by gliding on the ocean
- B. To contrast the demands of the speaker’s everyday life with the serenity of being rocked to sleep by the ocean
- C. To convey the speaker’s longing for the ocean to impart a sense of inner tranquility
- D. To justify the speaker’s qualms about being transported by the ocean to a quiet destination

ID: b3bfc1d2 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately states the main purpose of the text, which is to convey the speaker’s longing for the ocean to impart a sense of inner tranquility, or peace. The text begins by expressing the speaker’s strong desire to be on the ocean, appealing directly to the waves to rock the speaker to sleep. The poem then describes the "slumberous lullaby" formed by the sound of the waves and the winds on which the speaker wishes to be carried "gently...between a peaceful sea and sky." All these details serve to emphasize the speaker’s desire for the ocean to give them a sense of inner tranquility.

Choice A is incorrect. Given the poem’s expression of a longing to achieve tranquility by drifting on the ocean, it can be inferred that the speaker desires to escape something unpleasant in daily life. However, the poem doesn’t refer directly to any such hardship—ongoing or otherwise. And since the poem doesn’t establish that the speaker is experiencing a desire to escape ongoing hardship, it can’t be said that such a desire increases in intensity. Choice B is incorrect. The speaker does express a desire for the serenity of being rocked to sleep by the ocean, and it can be inferred that this desire is a response to demands that make the speaker’s daily life stressful. However, the poem doesn’t refer directly to such demands or contrast them with the tranquility of drifting on the ocean. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest the speaker has any qualms, or reservations, about being transported by the ocean. On the contrary, the speaker actively desires to "drift far out" and be carried by the waves and wind. Moreover, the poem doesn’t suggest that this drifting would have any particular destination.

Question ID 9ffe9ddc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 9ffe9ddc

To entice study participants, psychology researchers commonly offer a gift card or other compensation. However, this practice may undercut the applicability of the study’s results: people who join a study in response to _____ may differ in important ways from a representative sample of the population of interest.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. a propensity
- B. an inducement
- C. a paradigm
- D. an appeasement

ID: 9ffe9ddc Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of how compensation in psychology studies may affect the applicability of results. In this context, “an inducement” means a reward offered to encourage a person to take a particular action. The text indicates that psychology researchers commonly offer rewards such as gift cards to encourage people to participate in their studies, potentially rendering the participant pool unrepresentative of the target population. This context supports the idea that participants are joining studies in response to an inducement.

Choice A is incorrect. While participants might join a study in response to “a propensity,” or a natural inclination, to do so, the text isn’t focused on participants’ predispositions. Rather, the text is concerned with the external rewards that researchers offer to attract participants. Choice C is incorrect because saying that participants join studies in response to “a paradigm,” or a typical model or framework, wouldn’t make sense in context. The text doesn’t address any such framework. Instead, it focuses on tangible rewards that researchers offer to attract study participants. Choice D is incorrect because saying that participants join a study in response to “an appeasement,” or a concession made to pacify a person, wouldn’t make sense in context. The text describes researchers offering gift cards and other forms of compensation to attract willing study participants, not to address anyone’s grievance or dissatisfaction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 70e0e025

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 70e0e025

The güiro, a musical instrument traditionally made from a dried and hollowed gourd, is thought to have originated with the Taíno people of Puerto Rico. Players use a wooden stick to scrape along ridges cut into the side of the gourd, creating sounds that are highly ____: the sounds produced by güiros can differ based on the distance between the ridges, the types of strokes the player uses, and the thickness of the gourd.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. overlooked
- B. powerful
- C. routine
- D. variable

ID: 70e0e025 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the sounds made by güiros. In this context, “variable” means able to change. The text begins by explaining that güiros are instruments made out of hollowed gourds with ridges cut into their sides and that players scrape the ridges with wooden sticks to produce sounds. The text goes on to say that güiros’ sounds can change depending on gourd thickness, the distance between ridges, and the types of strokes the player uses, thus supporting the idea that the sounds created by these instruments are variable.

Choice A is incorrect because “overlooked” means not being seen or noticed, and there is nothing in the text to suggest that the sounds produced by güiros are overlooked or not noticed. Choice B is incorrect because in this context, “powerful” would mean having a great ability to produce an effect. While it’s possible that the sounds produced by güiros have a strong effect on listeners, the text doesn’t discuss this aspect of their sounds. Choice C is incorrect because “routine” means usual and unvarying, and there is nothing in the text to suggest that the sounds produced by güiros are unvarying. In fact, the text describes how the sounds produced by güiros can differ based on several factors.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9a66fab6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 9a66fab6

The following text is from the 1989 novel *The Ancient Child* by Kiowa writer N. Scott Momaday. The main character has achieved tremendous commercial success as a painter.

More and more often he was asked to compromise his art or himself in one way or another, and more often than not he did so, for he was inclined to be passive and naïve; it was difficult for him to say no. Those who exhibited his work, who praised and purchased it, and who demanded its proliferation began to determine it.

©1989 by N. Scott Momaday

As used in the text, what does the word “determine” most nearly mean?

- A. Conclude
- B. Dictate
- C. Evaluate
- D. Select

ID: 9a66fab6 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because as used in the text "determine" most nearly means "dictate." The text describes the relationship between the main character and those who exhibit, praise, and purchase his artwork. The text states that the main character is often asked to change his art or himself based on outside influences, and he usually acquiesces. Because the main character admits that those who support his work often shape it based on their demands, it follows that those outside influences dictate, or guide or dominate, the direction his work takes.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn't suggest that outside influences "conclude," or end, the main character's work. The text states that many supporters of the main character's art "demand its proliferation," not its conclusion. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn't suggest that outside influences are "evaluating," or judging the main character's work. According to the text, the main character's art has already achieved great commercial success, with many people exhibiting, purchasing, and praising his work. Thus, outsiders have already supported the main character's work and are not questioning or evaluating its success or worth. They are instead influencing its initial direction. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn't suggest that outside influences "select," or choose the main character's work. According to the text, the main character's art has already achieved great commercial success, with many people exhibiting, purchasing, and praising his work. Thus, outsiders have already supported the main character's work and are not selecting it. They are instead influencing its initial direction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3d7380b6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 3d7380b6

People tend to assume that being happy is the ideal emotional state and should be an ongoing aspiration; recently, however, research has suggested that it is at times beneficial to embrace negative emotions. To test whether anger can contribute to problem-solving abilities, researcher Heather Lench led an experiment in which participants were randomly assigned to view images designed to create an emotional condition—either neutral or one of anger, amusement, desire, or sadness. When asked to then solve a series of challenging puzzles, the participants in the anger condition had greater success than those in the other conditions.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. It describes a general psychological tendency that the study discussed in the text was designed to explain.
- B. It explains an assumption underlying the hypothesis investigated in the study discussed in the text.
- C. It notes a generally accepted belief that is called into question by a finding of the experiment outlined in the text.
- D. It suggests a psychological basis for the behaviors of the participants in the experiment reported in the text.

ID: 3d7380b6 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole. The underlined portion states that people commonly believe happiness is the ideal emotional state. However, the text then notes that recent research suggests that negative emotions can be beneficial, as demonstrated by an experiment by Heather Lench in which participants primed to feel anger did better at solving puzzles than did those primed to feel other emotions. This finding calls into question the belief that happiness is always the ideal state. Thus, the underlined portion notes a generally accepted belief that is called into question by a finding from the experiment.

Choice A is incorrect because the study does not address why people assume happiness is ideal. Rather, the text indicates the study was designed to test whether anger can contribute to problem-solving abilities. Choice B is incorrect because rather than underlying the study’s hypothesis that anger could be beneficial in some circumstances, the underlined portion presents the widely held belief that happiness is always preferable to negative emotions, which directly conflicts with that hypothesis. Choice D is incorrect because the underlined portion presents a common belief that happiness is the ideal emotional state, not an explanation for the participants’ behavior in the experiment. The text reports that participants in the anger condition performed better on the puzzles but does not explain the psychological reason for this outcome.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 09fcea12

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 09fcea12

Text 1

Astronomer Mark Holland and colleagues examined four white dwarfs—small, dense remnants of past stars—in order to determine the composition of exoplanets that used to orbit those stars. Studying wavelengths of light in the white dwarf atmospheres, the team reported that traces of elements such as lithium and sodium support the presence of exoplanets with continental crusts similar to Earth’s.

Text 2

Past studies of white dwarf atmospheres have concluded that certain exoplanets had continental crusts. Geologist Keith Putirka and astronomer Siyi Xu argue that those studies unduly emphasize atmospheric traces of lithium and other individual elements as signifiers of the types of rock found on Earth. The studies don’t adequately account for different minerals made up of various ratios of those elements, and the possibility of rock types not found on Earth that contain those minerals.

Based on the texts, how would Putirka and Xu (Text 2) most likely characterize the conclusion presented in Text 1?

- A. As unexpected, because it was widely believed at the time that white dwarf exoplanets lack continental crusts
- B. As premature, because researchers have only just begun trying to determine what kinds of crusts white dwarf exoplanets had
- C. As questionable, because it rests on an incomplete consideration of potential sources of the elements detected in white dwarf atmospheres
- D. As puzzling, because it’s unusual to successfully detect lithium and sodium when analyzing wavelengths of light in white dwarf atmospheres

ID: 09fcea12 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it reflects how Putirka and Xu (Text 2) would likely characterize the conclusion presented in Text 1. Text 1 discusses a study by Mark Holland and colleagues in which they detected traces of lithium and sodium in the atmospheres of four white dwarf stars. The team claims that this supports the idea that exoplanets with continental crusts like Earth’s once orbited these stars. Text 2 introduces Putirka and Xu, who indicate that sodium and lithium are present in several different minerals and that some of those minerals might exist in types of rock that are not found on Earth. Therefore, Putirka and Xu would likely describe the conclusion in Text 1 as questionable because it does not consider that lithium and sodium are also found in rocks that are not like Earth’s continental crust.

Choice A is incorrect because the texts do not indicate how widely held any of the viewpoints described are. Choice B is incorrect because neither text discusses how new this area of study is. Choice D is incorrect because neither text discusses how likely lithium and sodium are to be detected by analyzing wavelengths of light.

Question ID dccc8971

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: dccc8971

Text 1

In 2007, a team led by Alice Storey analyzed a chicken bone found in El Arenal, Chile, dating it to 1321–1407 CE—over a century before Europeans invaded the region, bringing their own chickens. Storey also found that the El Arenal chicken shared a unique genetic mutation with the ancient chicken breeds of the Polynesian Islands in the Pacific. Thus, Polynesian peoples, not later Europeans, probably first introduced chickens to South America.

Text 2

An Australian research team weakened the case for a Polynesian origin for the El Arenal chicken by confirming that the mutation identified by Storey has occurred in breeds from around the world. More recently, though, a team led by Agosto Luzuriaga-Neira found that South American chicken breeds and Polynesian breeds share other genetic markers that European breeds lack. Thus, the preponderance of evidence now favors a Polynesian origin.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1?

- A. By broadly agreeing with the claim but objecting that the timeline it presupposes conflicts with the findings of the genetic analysis conducted by Storey’s team
- B. By faulting the claim for implying that domestic animals couldn’t have been transferred from South America to the Polynesian Islands as well
- C. By critiquing the claim for being based on an assumption that before the European invasion of South America, the chickens of Europe were genetically uniform
- D. By noting that while the claim is persuasive, the findings of Luzuriaga-Neira’s team provide stronger evidence for it than the findings of the genetic analysis conducted by Storey do

ID: dccc8971 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it accurately describes how the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1. Text 1 indicates that Storey found a genetic mutation in South American chickens from before the European invasion and in Polynesian chickens, which implies that chickens were first brought to South America by Polynesian people. Text 2 explains that the genetic mutation Storey found is in chickens from all over the world, thus undercutting the mutation as evidence of a Polynesian origin. However, Text 2 goes on to say “[m]ore recently” Luzuriaga-Neira and colleagues found multiple genetic markers shared by South American and Polynesian chickens but “that European breeds lack,” which strongly suggests a Polynesian origin for the South American chickens. This indicates that the author of Text 2 believes Luzuriaga-Neira’s evidence for a Polynesian origin is compelling while Storey’s evidence has been undermined. Thus, the author of Text 2 would most likely agree

with the underlined statement and believes Luzuriaga-Neira and colleagues' evidence for the statement is stronger than Storey's evidence is.

Choice A is incorrect because both texts indicate that chickens were introduced to South America before the arrival of Europeans. Text 1 states that the El Arenal chicken bone dates from "1321–1407 CE—over a century before Europeans invaded the region" and concludes that these chickens were likely brought to South America by Polynesians. While Text 2 is not as explicit about the time period as Text 1 is, nothing in Text 2 undermines the timing of events ascribed to Storey's account in Text 1. Choice B is incorrect because both texts agree that chickens were first brought to South America by Polynesian peoples (the underlined claim), and nothing in Text 2 suggests that this claim is in any way deficient because the possibility that animals could have been transferred from South America to Polynesia was not explicitly addressed. Choice C is incorrect because the criticism that Text 2 raises about the ideas in Text 1 is specifically about whether the single genetic mutation cited by Storey in fact supports the idea of a Polynesian origin for South American chickens. There is nothing in Text 2 to suggest that the underlined sentence (Storey's conclusion) is deficient because it is based on an assumption about the genetic uniformity of European chickens.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bfcd19cb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: bfcd19cb

In 2020, rap artist and professor A.D. Carson published the first peer-reviewed rap album about his experiences with Black masculinity called “i used to love to dream.” Typically in peer review, experts evaluate scholarly articles prior to publication. For Carson’s album, dubbed a “mixtap/e/ssay,” peer review involved both scholars and rap artists. In combining elements of a mixtape album with scholarly essays that connect Carson’s lyrics to historical and contemporary contexts for listeners both inside and outside academia, Carson’s album helped redefine how scholarship is created and shared.

- Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?
- A. To compare the relative public impact of scholarly articles and albums
 - B. To capture one scholar’s opinion of a new rap album
 - C. To explain why a certain rap album is particularly innovative
 - D. To describe how each step of the peer review process unfolds

ID: bfcd19cb Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it best describes the main purpose of the text, which is to explain why a certain rap album is particularly innovative. The text mentions rap artist and professor A.D. Carson, who published “the first peer-reviewed rap album.” The text also describes the unusual process of having the work evaluated by both scholars and rap artists before its release, and details how the album combines elements of a mixtape album with elements of scholarly essays. All of these characteristics of the album and the way in which it was developed help to demonstrate the album’s novelty.

Choice A is incorrect because though the text mentions an album that combines elements of scholarly essays and mixtapes, it does not compare the relative public impact of scholarly articles and albums. Choice B is incorrect because the text does not present the opinion of a scholar regarding the rap album. Choice D is incorrect because though the text mentions that the album was peer reviewed, it does not detail the steps of the review.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID af3bcb89

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: af3bcb89

Typically, synthetic leather is petroleum based, but materials scientists searching for an ecologically sustainable alternative have used various bacteria that secrete linear chains of glucose, forming a dense mesh of cellulose called a pellicle, which is leatherlike except in color. The standard process for dyeing leather generates substantial wastewater and other undesirable byproducts, so adopting such a regimen would run counter to the ecological promise of the pellicle approach. To address this, Kenneth T. Walker and colleagues worked to modify *Komagataeibacter rhaeticus* bacteria to produce a pellicle with embedded pigmentation cells, thereby allowing the pellicle to “dye” itself from the inside.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. To concede that the researchers’ main goal as described in the text will be challenging to achieve due to the standard coloring approach being impractical for use on a pellicle
- B. To indicate the characteristic of conventional synthetic leathers that makes those leathers poorly suited to achieve the researchers’ main goal as presented in the text
- C. To describe a consideration that led the researchers to employ an alternative approach to coloring a pellicle that allowed them to achieve their main goal as presented in the text
- D. To illustrate how the researchers adapted the pellicle approach to overcome a potential impediment to their main goal as presented in the text

ID: af3bcb89 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole. The text establishes that scientists developed a pellicle (a dense cellulose mesh) as an ecologically sustainable alternative to petroleum-based synthetic leather, noting that the pellicle is leatherlike except in color. The text then notes that the standard dyeing process for leather generates wastewater and other byproducts, and the underlined portion states that using such a process would be inconsistent with the ecological promise of the pellicle approach. The sentence that follows the underlined portion describes how Walker and colleagues addressed this problem by modifying bacteria to produce a pellicle with embedded pigmentation. Thus, the underlined portion describes a consideration—the incompatibility of standard dyeing methods with ecological aims—that led the researchers to employ an alternative coloring approach consistent with their goal of ecological sustainability.

Choice A is incorrect because the text presents the underlined portion not as a concession that the researchers’ main goal, developing an ecologically sustainable alternative to synthetic leather, will be difficult to achieve, but as a reason why adopting a particular method of dyeing would be inconsistent with that goal. Choice B is incorrect because the underlined portion addresses a problem with the standard process for dyeing leather, not a characteristic of conventional synthetic leathers themselves. The issue identified in the underlined portion concerns the environmental impact of the standard method used to dye leather, not the petroleum-based nature of conventional synthetics. Choice D is incorrect because the underlined portion identifies the problem

that motivated the researchers' search for an alternative method of coloring the pellicle, not the method of coloring itself. The method of modifying bacteria to embed pigmentation is described in the sentence that follows the underlined portion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 47ce0a7f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-text Connections	

ID: 47ce0a7f

Text 1

What factors influence the abundance of species in a given ecological community? Some theorists have argued that historical diversity is a major driver of how diverse an ecological community eventually becomes: differences in community diversity across otherwise similar habitats, in this view, are strongly affected by the number of species living in those habitats at earlier times.

Text 2

In 2010, a group of researchers including biologist Carla Cáceres created artificial pools in a New York forest. They stocked some pools with a diverse mix of zooplankton species and others with a single zooplankton species and allowed the pool communities to develop naturally thereafter. Over the course of four years, Cáceres and colleagues periodically measured the species diversity of the pools, finding—contrary to their expectations—that by the end of the study there was little to no difference in the pools’ species diversity.

Based on the texts, how would Cáceres and colleagues (Text 2) most likely describe the view of the theorists presented in Text 1?

- A. It is largely correct, but it requires a minor refinement in light of the research team’s results.
- B. It is not compelling as a theory regardless of any experimental data collected by the research team.
- C. It may seem plausible, but it is not supported by the research team’s findings.
- D. It probably holds true only in conditions like those in the research team’s study.

ID: 47ce0a7f Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. This is how Cáceres and co. would most likely describe the view presented in Text 1. The view in Text 1 is that historical diversity affects how diverse an ecological community eventually becomes. But Cáceres and co. did not get this result: they found no difference in eventual diversity between a zooplankton pool that started out diverse and a zooplankton pool that started out with only a single species.

Choice A is incorrect. Cáceres and co. would probably not describe the view presented in Text 1 this way. The view in Text 1 is that historical diversity affects how diverse an ecological community eventually becomes. Cáceres and co’s findings directly undermine this view: they found no difference in eventual diversity between a zooplankton pool that started out diverse and a zooplankton pool that started out with only a single species. Choice B is incorrect. Cáceres and co. would probably not describe the view presented in Text 1 this way. Their experiment was designed to test this hypothesis, and their findings were "contrary to their expectations." In other words, before the study, they predicted the theory was correct. Choice D is incorrect. Cáceres and co. would not describe the view presented in Text 1 this way. Their research finding directly undermines the view presented in Text 1: so it definitely doesn’t hold true in conditions like those in the study.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 70000459

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 70000459

Text 1

Fossils of the hominin *Australopithecus africanus* have been found in the Sterkfontein Caves of South Africa, but assigning an age to the fossils is challenging because of the unreliability of dating methods in this context. The geology of Sterkfontein has caused soil layers from different periods to mix, impeding stratigraphic dating, and dates cannot be reliably imputed from those of nearby animal bones since the bones may have been relocated by flooding.

Text 2

Archaeologists used new cosmogenic nuclide dating techniques to reevaluate the ages of *A. africanus* fossils found in the Sterkfontein Caves. This technique involves analyzing the cosmogenic nucleotides in the breccia—the matrix of rock fragments immediately surrounding the fossils. The researchers assert that this approach avoids the potential for misdating associated with assigning ages based on Sterkfontein’s soil layers or animal bones.

Based on the texts, how would the researchers in Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined portion in Text 1?

- A. They would emphasize the fact that the *A. africanus* fossils found in the Sterkfontein Caves may have been corrupted in some way over the years.
- B. They would contend that if analyses of surrounding layers and bones in the Sterkfontein Caves were combined, then the dating of the fossils there would be more accurate.
- C. They would argue that their techniques are better suited than other methods to the unique challenges posed by the Sterkfontein Caves.
- D. They would claim that cosmogenic nuclide dating is reliable in the context of the Sterkfontein Caves because it is applied to the fossils directly.

ID: 70000459 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. Text 2 states that the researchers used cosmogenic nuclide dating to "avoid the potential for misdating" caused by the geology of Sterkfontein, which Text 1 describes as "challenging" and unreliable.

Choice A is incorrect. Neither text suggests that the *A. africanus* fossils have been "corrupted," but only that traditional dating methods are difficult in Sterkfontein because of floods and soil mixing where the fossils were found. Nothing is implied to have compromised the fossils themselves. Choice B is incorrect. This choice misreads Text 2. Text 2 agrees that stratigraphy and other methods are prone to error in the context of Sterkfontein: there’s a "potential for misdating" when evaluating age based on soil layers and bones. Choice D is incorrect. Text 2 does not state that cosmogenic nuclide dating is applied to the fossils directly but rather to the breccia that surrounds them.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 750bc3ee

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 750bc3ee

Text 1

Soy sauce, made from fermented soybeans, is noted for its umami flavor. Umami—one of the five basic tastes along with sweet, bitter, salty, and sour—was formally classified when its taste receptors were discovered in the 2000s. In 2007, to define the pure umami flavor scientists Rie Ishii and Michael O’Mahony used broths made from shiitake mushrooms and kombu seaweed, and two panels of Japanese and US judges closely agreed on a description of the taste.

Text 2

A 2022 experiment by Manon Jünger et al. led to a greater understanding of soy sauce’s flavor profile. The team initially presented a mixture of compounds with low molecular weights to taste testers who found it was not as salty or bitter as real soy sauce. Further analysis of soy sauce identified proteins, including dipeptides, that enhanced umami flavor and also contributed to saltiness. The team then made a mix of 50 chemical compounds that re-created soy sauce’s flavor.

Based on the texts, if Ishii and O’Mahony (Text 1) and Jünger et al. (Text 2) were aware of the findings of both experiments, they would most likely agree with which statement?

- A. On average, the diets of people in the United States tend to have fewer foods that contain certain dipeptides than the diets of people in Japan have.
- B. Chemical compounds that activate both the umami and salty taste receptors tend to have a higher molecular weight than those that only activate umami taste receptors.
- C. Fermentation introduces proteins responsible for the increase of umami flavor in soy sauce, and those proteins also increase the perception of saltiness.
- D. The broths in the 2007 experiment most likely did not have a substantial amount of the dipeptides that played a key part in the 2022 experiment.

ID: 750bc3ee Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Ishii and O’Mahony were trying to isolate the pure umami flavor, while Jünger was trying to recreate soy sauce, which has a mix of flavors that includes umami. Accordingly, the broths from Text 1 are not described as having any soy sauce in them—just “shiitake mushrooms and kombu seaweed.” So they probably don’t have as much of the dipeptides described in Text 2, which were found to be a key part of soy sauce’s umami-ness and its saltiness.

Choice A is incorrect. Neither text supports this. Neither text gets into the diets of people in the United States, nor the diets of people in Japan. Choice B is incorrect. Neither text supports this. Text 2 does talk about the molecular weights of chemical compounds, but there isn’t enough information provided about molecular weights in Text 1 to make an inference about what the scientists in Text 1 would say. Choice C is incorrect. Neither text supports this. Text 1 briefly mentions that soy sauce is “made

from fermented soybeans,” but it never claims that fermentation is responsible for its flavor in any way. And Text 2 never mentions fermentation at all.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cb4361d5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: cb4361d5

A casual description of Scherezade García's 2019 mural *Blame It on the Bean: The Power of Coffee* can make the work seem _____—a painting that is housed in a coffee shop and that depicts three women drinking coffee may not sound particularly ambitious—but in fact the work is a complex, dynamic meditation on gender and the legacy of colonialism that demands serious attention.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. unassuming
- B. shrewd
- C. incongruous
- D. pretentious

ID: cb4361d5 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Scherezade García’s mural *Blame It on the Bean: The Power of Coffee*. In this context, “unassuming” means ordinary or unremarkable. The text draws a contrast between a “casual description” of the mural’s ordinary location (a coffee shop) and subject matter (three women drinking coffee)—details that would make it seem relatively unambitious—and a characterization of the painting as a “dynamic meditation” on gender and colonialism deserving of “serious attention.” This context suggests that the mural has significant depth and complexity, but a superficial description of it might make the mural seem ordinary and unremarkable—that is, unassuming.

Choice B is incorrect because in this context, “shrewd” would mean clever or astute, and there’s nothing in the text to suggest that a casual yet misleading description that only mentions the apparent simplicity of the mural’s location and subject matter would make the mural seem particularly clever or astute. Though it’s possible that the text’s assertion that the mural is a “complex, dynamic meditation” demanding “serious attention” might convey the idea that it’s a particularly clever or astute—that is, shrewd—artwork, the text wouldn’t suggest that a casual description that fails to account for the work’s complexity would likewise characterize the work as shrewd. Choice C is incorrect because in this context, “incongruous” would mean unsuitable for its surroundings or internally inconsistent. The “casual description” presented in the text indicates that the painting is housed in a coffee shop and depicts women drinking coffee, which would imply that the mural may in fact be well suited to its surroundings, not that it’s ill suited to its location. Moreover, none of the details mentioned in this description would suggest that the painting contains internal inconsistencies of any kind. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, “pretentious” would mean expressive of exaggerated importance, which wouldn’t fit the contrast established in the text between a “casual description” of the painting and the work’s deeper themes. Though the text argues that the painting is worthy of “serious attention,” which would suggest its importance, the text doesn’t suggest that the casual description would by contrast imply that the painting’s importance is exaggerated. Rather, by merely mentioning the mural’s relatively ordinary location and subject matter without reference to this

complexity, the casual description conveys that the painting is more unassuming and understated than it actually is, not that it expresses an exaggerated self-importance.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 51143154

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 51143154

Text 1

Growth in the use of novel nanohybrids—materials created from the conjugation of multiple distinct nanomaterials, such as iron oxide and gold nanomaterials conjugated for use in magnetic imaging—has outpaced studies of nanohybrids’ environmental risks. Unfortunately, risk evaluations based on nanohybrids’ constituents are not reliable: conjugation may alter constituents’ physiochemical properties such that innocuous nanomaterials form a nanohybrid that is anything but.

Text 2

The potential for enhanced toxicity of nanohybrids relative to the toxicity of constituent nanomaterials has drawn deserved attention, but the effects of nanomaterial conjugation vary by case. For instance, it was recently shown that a nanohybrid of silicon dioxide and zinc oxide preserved the desired optical transparency of zinc oxide nanoparticles while mitigating the nanoparticles’ potential to damage DNA.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the assertion in the underlined portion of Text 1?

- A. By concurring that the risk described in Text 1 should be evaluated but emphasizing that the risk is more than offset by the potential benefits of nanomaterial conjugation
- B. By arguing that the situation described in Text 1 may not be representative but conceding that the effects of nanomaterial conjugation are harder to predict than researchers had expected
- C. By denying that the circumstance described in Text 1 is likely to occur but acknowledging that many aspects of nanomaterial conjugation are still poorly understood
- D. By agreeing that the possibility described in Text 1 is a cause for concern but pointing out that nanomaterial conjugation does not inevitably produce that result

ID: 51143154 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The author of Text 2 acknowledges that nanohybrids may be more toxic than their constituent parts, but also provides an example of a nanohybrid that has reduced toxicity compared to its components: silicon dioxide and zinc oxide together have all the benefits of zinc oxide nanoparticles without any of the DNA harm zinc oxide has on its own.

Choice A is incorrect. While the author of Text 2 gives an example of a nanohybrid that isn’t as toxic as its constituent parts, they don’t argue that the benefit outweighs the risk. They merely argue that “the effects of nanomaterial conjugation vary by case.” Choice B is incorrect. The author of Text 2 states that the effects of nanomaterial conjugation “vary by case,” and that the attention that their potential toxicity has drawn is warranted. If the situation in Text 1 weren’t representative, then there would be less attention to the potential danger of these materials. Furthermore, neither passage suggests that researchers had expected that they could predict the effects of nanomaterial conjugation. Choice C is incorrect. The author of Text 2 agrees that the potential toxicity of nanohybrids “has drawn deserved attention,” so they aren’t denying the problem.

Question ID 30649b58

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 30649b58

The field of study called affective neuroscience seeks instinctive, physiological causes for feelings such as pleasure or displeasure. Because these sensations are linked to a chemical component (for example, the release of the neurotransmitter dopamine in the brain when one receives or expects a reward), they can be said to have a partly physiological basis. These processes have been described in mammals, but Jingnan Huang and his colleagues have recently observed that some behaviors of honeybees (such as foraging) are also motivated by a dopamine-based signaling process.

- What choice best describes the main purpose of the text?
- A. It describes an experimental method of measuring the strength of physiological responses in humans.
 - B. It illustrates processes by which certain insects can express how they are feeling.
 - C. It summarizes a finding suggesting that some mechanisms in the brains of certain insects resemble mechanisms in mammalian brains.
 - D. It presents research showing that certain insects and mammals behave similarly when there is a possibility of a reward for their actions.

ID: 30649b58 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to summarize a finding suggesting that some mechanisms in the brains of certain insects resemble mechanisms in mammalian brains. The text begins by explaining that feelings such as pleasure and displeasure are linked to chemical processes in the brain, such as the release of dopamine when one receives a reward. The text then indicates that such processes have been seen in mammals but that researchers have recently observed similar processes involving dopamine in honeybees. Taken together, this information serves to sum up the discovery that some mechanisms in the brains of certain insects may resemble mechanisms linked to feelings such as pleasure and displeasure in mammals.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn't describe any experiments or experimental methods. Instead, the text describes a phenomenon that has been observed in mammals and then presents the recent observations of Huang and colleagues that this phenomenon is also seen in honeybees. Choice B is incorrect because there's nothing in the text to suggest that certain insects can express how they're feeling through particular processes. The text does indicate that certain honeybee behaviors such as foraging are linked to dopamine, but it doesn't suggest that these behaviors enable honeybees to communicate feelings or sensations. Choice D is incorrect because the text presents research showing that certain honeybee behaviors such as foraging are linked to dopamine and therefore may be motivated by similar mechanisms to those in mammalian brains, not that honeybees and mammals behave similarly when there is the possibility of reward for their actions.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6f0282ec

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 6f0282ec

Text 1

Italian painters in the 1500s rarely depicted themselves in their work. Even more rare were self-portrait paintings that portrayed the artist as a painter. At the time, painting was not yet respected as a profession, so painters mostly chose to emphasize other qualities in their self-portraits, like their intellect or social status. In the city of Bologna, the first artist to depict himself painting was a man named Annibale Carracci. A painting of his from around 1585 shows Carracci in front of an easel holding a palette.

Text 2

In their self-portraits, Bolognese artists typically avoided referring to the act of painting until the mid-1600s. However, Lavinia Fontana’s 1577 painting, *Self-Portrait at the Keyboard*, stands out as the earliest example of such a work by an artist from Bologna. Although the artist is depicted playing music, in the background, one can spot a painting easel by a window.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1?

- A. Carracci and Fontana were among the most well-respected painters in Bologna at the time.
- B. The depiction of Fontana in *Self-Portrait at the Keyboard* was intended to underscore the artist’s creativity.
- C. Fontana likely inspired the reference to an easel and palette in Carracci’s painting.
- D. *Self-Portrait at the Keyboard* was painted earlier than Carracci’s painting and also refers to the artist’s craft.

ID: 6f0282ec Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The author of Text 2 states that Fontana’s painting, which depicts a painting easel in the background, was made in 1577, eight years before Carracci’s painting. Therefore, they might argue that Carracci was not “the first artist” to depict himself as a painter.

Choice A is incorrect. The texts don’t support this choice. Neither text mentions the reputation or status of either Carracci or Fontana. Choice B is incorrect. The author of Text 2 does not comment on the intention or meaning of Fontana’s self-depiction in *Self-Portrait at the Keyboard*. This choice also holds little connection to the underlined claim. Choice C is incorrect. The texts don’t support this choice. The author of Text 2 does not suggest any inspirational relationship between Fontana and Carracci. The author of Text 2 is concerned with showing that Fontana’s painting is the earliest example of an artist referring to painting in their self-portrait, but makes no mention of her influence on others.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 95368fa3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 95368fa3

Critics have asserted that fine art and fashion rarely _____ in a world where artists create timeless works for exhibition and designers periodically produce new styles for the public to buy. Luiseño/Shoshone-Bannock beadwork artist and designer Jamie Okuma challenges this view: her work can be seen in the Metropolitan Museum of Art and purchased through her online boutique.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. prevail
- B. succumb
- C. diverge
- D. intersect

ID: 95368fa3 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion about the relationship between fine art and fashion. As used in this context, “intersect” means to connect or overlap. The text indicates that Jamie Okuma challenges the position held by critics because her work can be seen at an art museum and can be bought by the public from her online boutique. The text also presents the critics’ view as being influenced by a perception that fine artists create works that are “timeless” and meant for exhibition, whereas fashion designers periodically produce new styles that are meant for purchase. This context suggests that the critics believe that fine art and fashion tend not to overlap—in other words, that they rarely intersect.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to say that critics contend that fine art and fashion rarely “prevail,” or prove to be triumphant or widespread. The text indicates that Okuma is an example of an artist who demonstrates that it’s possible to make fine art that is also available to the public as fashion. Choice B is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to say that fine art and fashion rarely “succumb,” or surrender. The text establishes that unlike what critics believe, Okuma creates works that are in art museums and available for the public to purchase, suggesting that critics believe fine art and fashion rarely overlap, not that they rarely succumb. Choice C is incorrect because saying that critics believe that fine art and fashion rarely “diverge,” or disagree or move in different directions, wouldn’t make sense in context. The text presents Okuma’s work as both fine art and fashion, thereby undermining what the critics assert. This suggests that the critics believe that fine art and fashion rarely intersect rather than that the two rarely diverge.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 73f942b3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 73f942b3

Text corpora such as the Bank of English are enormous collections of electronically stored texts that can be used for empirical testing of hypotheses regarding the frequency of typical word usage. If one has a _____ that the word “get” has a high incidence in English, for example, an analysis of a corpus can support that hypothesis by showing that “get” is the fifth most commonly used verb.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. recognition
- B. scheme
- C. supposition
- D. synopsis

ID: 73f942b3 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of testing hypotheses regarding usage by means of text corpora. In this context, "supposition" refers to an assumption or hypothesis that is not yet proven. The text explains that text corpora can be used for "empirical testing of hypotheses regarding the frequency of typical word usage" and then provides a specific example of using corpus analysis to support a claim about the word "get." The word "supposition" precisely conveys this idea of an assumption or hypothesis about word frequency that can then be tested against empirical data.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that someone has a "recognition" that the word "get" has a high incidence in English. Recognition implies acknowledging something already established as true or valid, but the text indicates that corpus analysis is needed to support the claim about "get," suggesting its high frequency wasn’t already established or previously known. Choice B is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that someone has a "scheme" that the word "get" has a high incidence in English. A scheme is a plan or systematic arrangement, but the context indicates what’s needed is a preliminary hypothesis that can be tested with corpus data, not a plan related to word frequency. Choice D is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that someone has a "synopsis" that the word "get" has a high incidence in English. A synopsis is a summary or outline, but the text is discussing an initial hypothesis about word frequency that requires testing, not a condensed statement of existing information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8713e5fd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 8713e5fd

The work of molecular biophysicist Enrique M. De La Cruz is known for _____ traditional boundaries between academic disciplines. The university laboratory that De La Cruz runs includes engineers, biologists, chemists, and physicists, and the research the lab produces makes use of insights and techniques from all those fields.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. epitomizing
- B. transcending
- C. anticipating
- D. reinforcing

ID: 8713e5fd Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Based on the text, we’re looking for a word that means something similar to "mak[ing] use of insights and techniques from all those fields." "Transcending" means "going beyond," so "transcending traditional boundaries" would mean crossing into all those various fields of research, which is exactly the meaning we want.

Choice A is incorrect. This isn’t a logical word choice. Based on the text, we’re looking for a word that means something similar to "mak[ing] use of insights and techniques from all those fields." To "epitomize" means to "be a perfect example of," so "epitomizing traditional boundaries" would mean the opposite of what we want: keeping the fields of research separate. Choice C is incorrect. This isn’t a logical word choice. Based on the text, we’re looking for a word that means something similar to "mak[ing] use of insights and techniques from all those fields." "Anticipating" means "expecting" or "waiting for," and would result in a confusing sentence with an unclear meaning. Choice D is incorrect. This isn’t a logical word choice. Based on the text, we’re looking for a word that means something similar to "mak[ing] use of insights and techniques from all those fields." "Reinforcing traditional boundaries" would mean the opposite: keeping the fields of research separate.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 11b906e0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 11b906e0

Close analysis of the painting *Girl with a Flute*, long attributed to the seventeenth-century Dutch painter Johannes Vermeer, has revealed subtle deviations from the artist’s signature techniques. These variations suggest that the work may be that of a student under Vermeer’s tutelage—potentially _____ our understanding of Vermeer as a solitary artist.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. negating
- B. prefiguring
- C. entrenching
- D. substantiating

ID: 11b906e0 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. "Negating" means "reversing" or "making invalid." Proving that Vermeer worked with students would reverse the view of him as a solitary artist.

Choice B is incorrect. "Prefiguring" means "being an early indicator of." There already existed views of Vermeer as a solitary painter, so a new painting would not be an early indicator of those views. Rather, a painting proving that Vermeer had a student would contradict those earlier views. Choice C is incorrect. "Entrenching" means "solidifying." A painting proving that Vermeer had a student would not solidify views of him as solitary, but would rather contradict those views. Choice D is incorrect. "Substantiating" means "supporting with proof." A painting proving that Vermeer had a student would not support views of him as solitary, but would rather contradict those views.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b73ac8e3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: b73ac8e3

Asteroid 6478 Gault has experienced intermittent mass loss since at least 2013, but in contrast to some other asteroids with repeated mass-loss episodes, 6478 Gault has not lost mass at its perihelion (the closest point of its orbit to the Sun), and thus the loss is not attributable to solar energy–driven ice vaporization. And as Jane X. Luu et al. point out, the singular nature of impact ejection makes it untenable as an account of multiple loss episodes of similar duration over several years. Instead, Luu et al. are likely correct that 6478 Gault is shedding mass due to rotational instability.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It presents a scientific observation, describes a contrast between that observation and other observations, and then explains why those other observations should not be considered credible.
- B. It describes an astronomical finding, discusses competing theories about that finding that the author regards as flawed, and then describes new evidence that supports an alternative theory.
- C. It introduces a natural phenomenon, refutes two potential explanations for that phenomenon, and then presents a third explanation for that phenomenon that the author regards as plausible.
- D. It discusses a physical process, evaluates possible causes of that process, and then states that a persuasive account of the process has yet to be put forward.

ID: b73ac8e3 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the overall structure of the text. The text begins by introducing the natural phenomenon of intermittent mass loss with regard to Asteroid 6478 Gault and notes that it curiously has not lost mass at its perihelion like other asteroids typically do. The text then refutes "solar energy–driven ice vaporization" and "the singular nature of impact ejection" as two possible explanations for Asteroid 6478 Gault’s intermittent mass loss. Finally, the text presents Luu et al.’s explanation that "6478 Gault is shedding mass due to rotational instability," which the author says is "likely correct." Thus, the overall structure of the text is that it introduces a natural phenomenon, refutes two potential explanations for that phenomenon, and then presents a third explanation for that phenomenon that the author regards as plausible.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t distinguish between multiple observations. It focuses on the single observation that Asteroid 6478 Gault is losing mass and evaluates multiple explanations for the phenomenon. The text also asserts that Luu et al.’s explanation is credible and "likely correct." Choice B is incorrect because the text describes a natural phenomenon, not a specific astronomical finding. In addition, although the text does note flawed reasons for Asteroid 6478 Gault’s intermittent mass loss, it doesn’t mention that Asteroid 6478 Gault’s intermittent mass loss is based on new evidence. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text does evaluate explanations for the cause of Asteroid 6478 Gault’s intermittent mass loss, the text also asserts that Luu et al.’s explanation that they have put forth is persuasive and "likely correct."

Question ID 0b6a52d3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 0b6a52d3

Text 1

The idea that time moves in only one direction is instinctively understood, yet it puzzles physicists. According to the second law of thermodynamics, at a macroscopic level some processes of heat transfer are irreversible due to the production of entropy—after a transfer we cannot rewind time and place molecules back exactly where they were before, just as we cannot unbreak dropped eggs. But laws of physics at a microscopic or quantum level hold that those processes *should* be reversible.

Text 2

In 2015, physicists Tiago Batalhão et al. performed an experiment in which they confirmed the irreversibility of thermodynamic processes at a quantum level, producing entropy by applying a rapidly oscillating magnetic field to a system of carbon-13 atoms in liquid chloroform. But the experiment “does not pinpoint ... what causes [irreversibility] at the microscopic level,” coauthor Mauro Paternostro said.

Based on the texts, what would the author of Text 1 most likely say about the experiment described in Text 2?

- A. It would suggest an interesting direction for future research were it not the case that two of the physicists who conducted the experiment disagree on the significance of its findings.
- B. It provides empirical evidence that the current understanding of an aspect of physics at a microscopic level must be incomplete.
- C. It is consistent with the current understanding of physics at a microscopic level but not at a macroscopic level.
- D. It supports a claim about an isolated system of atoms in a laboratory, but that claim should not be extrapolated to a general claim about the universe.

ID: 0b6a52d3 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Author 1 describes the puzzle that physicists still can’t solve: at a microscopic level, the “laws of physics” suggest that we should be able to reverse processes that are not reversible at a macroscopic level (and, maybe, turn back time!). The experiment confirmed that those processes are not reversible even on the microscopic level, but it didn’t explain why. This supports Author 1’s point that physicists still don’t fully understand how things work at a microscopic level—maybe the laws need to be revised.

Choice A is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to the experiment. Text 2 does name two of the physicists involved in the experiment, but it never suggests that they disagree on anything. Choice C is incorrect. This is the opposite of what the experiment suggests. The experiment confirmed that the macroscopic-level law (“these things can’t be reversed—like time”) was still true on the microscopic level—meaning it supports the current understanding of physics at a

macroscopic level. Choice D is incorrect. We can't infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to the experiment. Neither text makes this distinction between laboratory findings and the way the universe works in general.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 31cf3265

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 31cf3265

The following text is from Charlotte Perkins Gilman’s 1910 poem “The Earth’s Entail.”

No matter how we cultivate the land,
Taming the forest and the prairie free;
No matter how we irrigate the sand,
Making the desert blossom at command,
We must always leave the borders of the sea;
The immeasurable reaches
Of the windy wave-wet beaches,
The million-mile-long margin of the sea.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. The speaker argues against interfering with nature and then gives evidence supporting this interference.
- B. The speaker presents an account of efforts to dominate nature and then cautions that such efforts are only temporary.
- C. The speaker provides examples of an admirable way of approaching nature and then challenges that approach.
- D. The speaker describes attempts to control nature and then offers a reminder that not all nature is controllable.

ID: 31cf3265 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. This best describes the overall structure of the text. In the first half of the text, the speaker describes our attempts to control nature: cultivating, taming, and irrigating different kinds of land. In the second half, the speaker states that we can never tame the sea or the beach.

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t describe the overall structure of the text. The speaker never argues that we should not interfere with nature. Rather, the speaker says that we are able to tame many different kinds of land, but we are unable to tame the sea or beaches. Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t describe the overall structure of the text. The speaker never describes our cultivation, taming, and irrigation of land as “temporary.” Rather, the speaker says that we are able to tame many different kinds of land, but we are unable to tame the sea or beaches. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t describe the overall structure of the text. The speaker never describes our cultivation, taming, and irrigation of land as an “admirable” approach to nature.” Rather, the speaker says that we are able to tame many different kinds of land, but we are unable to tame the sea or beaches.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5c9eb4c2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 5c9eb4c2

The artisans of the Igun Eronmwon guild in Benin City, Nigeria, typically _____ the bronze- and brass-casting techniques that have been passed down through their families since the thirteenth century, but they don’t strictly observe every tradition; for example, guild members now use air-conditioning motors instead of handheld bellows to help heat their forges.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. experiment with
- B. adhere to
- C. improve on
- D. grapple with

ID: 5c9eb4c2 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of bronze- and brass-casting techniques used by the Igun Eronmwon guild. In this context “adhere to” would mean to act in accordance with. The text states that although members of the Igun Eronmwon guild typically do something with techniques that have been passed down since the thirteenth century, they “don’t strictly observe every tradition.” By establishing a contrast with not always following traditions, the context suggests that guild members do typically adhere to traditional techniques.

Choice A is incorrect because in this context “experiment with” would mean to do something new with. Although using motors rather than manual bellows is presented as a new approach, the text establishes a contrast between what the guild members typically do with techniques that have been passed down over centuries and the idea that the members “don’t strictly observe every tradition.” The phrase “experiment with” wouldn’t support the contrast because regularly trying new things with the techniques would be an example of not strictly following all traditions. Choice C is incorrect because in this context “improve on” would mean to make better. Although using motors rather than manual bellows might be an improved approach, the text establishes a contrast between what the guild members typically do with techniques that have been passed down over centuries and the idea that the members “don’t strictly observe every tradition.” The phrase “improve on” wouldn’t support the contrast because regularly making changes to the techniques would be an example of not strictly following all traditions. Choice D is incorrect because in this context “grapple with” would mean to try hard to solve a difficult problem. Although bronze- and brass-casting are likely challenging tasks, nothing in the text suggests that the guild members have any particular difficulties with the techniques passed down since the thirteenth century.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 824e2d0a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 824e2d0a

Proposals to raise the age at which retirees begin receiving government transfers of funds are generally discussed in terms of the effects on transfer recipients, but Andria Smythe has argued that delaying such transfers could _____ wealth creation among working adults by lengthening the period in which they are providing financial support to their nonworking parents.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. stymie
- B. compound
- C. disparage
- D. outstrip

ID: 824e2d0a Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the consequences of raising the age at which retirees begin receiving government funds. The text indicates that raising the age for these funds is usually discussed in terms of effects on fund recipients but that Andria Smythe is instead considering the effects on working family members who care for retirees. Smythe notes that raising the age for the funds would increase the length of time retirees are dependent on financial assistance from working family members. This is suggested to have an effect on wealth creation for those workers, and most logically, that effect would be disadvantageous. Thus, "stymie," which means to prevent or greatly hinder, is the most logical choice in context.

Choice B is incorrect because in this context, "compound" would most nearly mean multiply or greatly enhance. The text indicates that raising the age at which retirees are eligible for government funds will increase the amount of time retirees are dependent on working family members for financial support. This would likely have a negative rather than a positive effect on wealth creation. Choice C is incorrect because in this context, "disparage" would most nearly mean criticize or defame. Nothing in the text suggests that raising the age at which retirees are eligible for government funds would defame wealth creation among working adults. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, "outstrip" would most nearly mean to exceed, and nothing in the text indicates that the financial support provided to retirees would exceed the amount of wealth these workers can create. The text does suggest that workers providing funds to retirees works against those workers’ wealth accumulation, but not that the support to retirees exceeds the workers’ accumulated wealth.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 68bf48ac

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 68bf48ac

Several studies have found negligible electoral consequences for governments that impose fiscal austerity measures, yet some European governments recently suffered electorally due to their austerity programs. Evelyne Huebscher and colleagues attribute this incongruity to governments’ tendency—not followed in the recent European cases—to implement austerity programs strategically to avoid electoral costs (e.g., setting spending cuts to take effect only after the next election), which has obscured the inherent political risks of austerity measures in the election data scholars have examined.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- A. It explains a discrepancy between what has been observed in study settings and what has been observed in real-world settings that the text goes on to assert is attributable to the studies not using real-world data.
- B. It identifies a conflict between research findings and recent events that the text goes on to suggest is a consequence of a complicating factor in the data used to generate those findings.
- C. It presents a long-standing divergence in research findings that the text goes on to say is due to different groups of researchers using data that derive from different electoral circumstances.
- D. It describes a recent exception to a general pattern in research findings that the text goes on to explain is a result of researchers underestimating the significance of inconsistencies in the data they’ve analyzed.

ID: 68bf48ac Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it best describes how the underlined sentence functions in the text as a whole. The underlined sentence explains that contrary to what several studies would suggest, recent European governments suffered electorally after the launch of fiscal austerity programs. The text goes on to indicate that the researchers generated their findings from data that didn’t reveal the true political risk of austerity measures because the data were based on cases in which governments had set austerity programs to take effect after the next election, a practice the European governments that recently suffered electorally didn’t adhere to, thus introducing a complicating factor resulting in a conflict between the research findings and recent events.

Choice A is incorrect because the underlined sentence doesn’t indicate that the discrepancy described in the text is between observations made in study settings and observations made in real-world settings. Rather, the underlined sentence indicates that the outcome of recent events is contrary to what would be expected based on the findings of several studies. Additionally, there is nothing in the text to suggest that the studies mentioned did not use real-world data; instead, the text indicates that the data used was generated under potentially different circumstances than the recent events. Choice C is incorrect because the underlined sentence doesn’t present a long-standing divergence in research findings but rather a discrepancy between past research findings and recent events that the text goes on to attribute to researchers’ use of data that didn’t reveal the true political risk of austerity measures. Choice D is incorrect because while the underlined sentence notes that there have been some recent exceptions to a

general pattern observed in several research studies, it does not go on to attribute this exception to the researchers underestimating inconsistencies in the data. Rather, the text goes on to attribute this to a circumstance (fiscal austerity measures being implemented before an election rather than after) which adds a complicating factor into the data not accounted for in past studies.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9adc5ab5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 9adc5ab5

Text 1

An excavation in Chiquihuite Cave in central Mexico has upended the belief that approximately 13,000 years ago, a group known as the Clovis people were the first human inhabitants of North America. More than 200 crude stone tools were found embedded in a layer of earth that is up to 33,150 years old, revealing that humans occupied the cave thousands of years before the Clovis people reached the continent.

Text 2

The objects uncovered in Chiquihuite Cave are intriguing, but it is premature to characterize them as tools. The stone pieces are so roughly shaped that they may have simply fractured from rocks during natural geological activity in the cave. Moreover, their unearthing has thus far not been accompanied by discoveries of other signs of human activity or even traces of human DNA from surfaces.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the underlined claim in Text 1?

- A. By suggesting that it draws a plausible connection between two groups of people but will need to be confirmed with further study
- B. By asserting that it rests on an assumption about the stone pieces that is not sufficiently supported by available evidence
- C. By acknowledging that it will most likely be proved correct when the stone pieces undergo more detailed analysis
- D. By pointing out that it fails to account for evidence that the Clovis people were active on the continent as early as is commonly thought

ID: 9adc5ab5 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to the underlined claim about the Clovis people in Text 1. Text 1 explains that the idea that the Clovis people were the first human inhabitants of North America has been overturned by the unearthing of stone tools in Chiquihuite Cave in Mexico. The tools were found in a layer of earth that is over 33,000 years old—much older than the Clovis people’s arrival 13,000 years ago. The text ends with the claim that the tools reveal that humans lived in the cave long before the Clovis people reached the continent. Text 2, on the other hand, disputes the idea that the stone pieces are definitely tools. Text 2 states that the pieces are so roughly shaped that they may have simply naturally broken off from rocks and, moreover, that no other signs of human activity have been found in the cave. In other words, Text 2 argues that there is no proof yet that humans made the pieces as tools or were even present in the cave. Therefore, the author of Text 2 would most likely say that the claim that humans occupied Chiquihuite Cave long before the Clovis people reached North America rests on an assumption about the stone pieces—that they are human-made tools—that is not sufficiently supported by available evidence.

Choice A is incorrect because Text 1 doesn't claim that human inhabitants of Chiquihuite Cave and the Clovis people had any connection; the author of Text 1 focuses only on the timing of each group's presence in North America. Further, the author of Text 2 makes no mention of the Clovis people and indicates that it isn't clear yet that any human group did inhabit Chiquihuite Cave. Choice C is incorrect because nothing in Text 2 suggests that the author believes the stone pieces probably are human-made tools and will be confirmed as such by further analysis; instead, the author of Text 2 emphasizes the current lack of evidence of human activity in the cave. Choice D is incorrect because Text 2 focuses on the issue of characterizing the stone pieces as tools made by humans, not on the timing of any particular group's activity in North America; further, Text 1 seems to support the common belief that the Clovis people reached North America 13,000 years ago and challenges only the idea that they were the continent's first inhabitants. Therefore, there's no reason to think the author of Text 2 would say that the author of Text 1 overlooks evidence that the Clovis people were active as early as is commonly thought.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4b18b230

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 4b18b230

The following text is adapted from James Baldwin’s 1956 novel *Giovanni’s Room*. The narrator is riding in a taxi down a street lined with food vendors and shoppers in Paris, France.

The multitude of Paris seems to be dressed in blue every day but Sunday, when, for the most part, they put on an unbelievably festive black. Here they were now, in blue, disputing, every inch, our passage, with their wagons, handtrucks, their bursting baskets carried at an angle steeply self-confident on the back.

©1956 by James Baldwin

As used in the text, what does the word “disputing” most nearly mean?

- A. Arguing about
- B. Disapproving of
- C. Asserting possession of
- D. Providing resistance to

ID: 4b18b230 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because as used in the text, "disputing" most nearly means providing resistance to. The narrator is in a taxi as it drives down a street lined with so many food vendors and shoppers that the narrator describes them as "the multitude of Paris," meaning an immense group of people. The street is essentially a large open-air market, and there are so many people pushing small wagons of goods and carrying shopping baskets that "every inch" of the taxi’s progress is impeded. In other words, the people are providing resistance to the taxi’s attempt to drive down the street.

Choice A is incorrect. Although in some contexts, "disputing" can mean arguing, the narrator doesn’t portray the shoppers and vendors as arguing with the driver of the taxi or, indeed, arguing at all. Choice B is incorrect. Although in some contexts, "disputing" can mean expressing disapproval, the narrator doesn’t suggest that the shoppers and vendors necessarily disapprove of the taxi’s attempt to drive down the street. Instead, their combined presence along the street has the effect of impeding the taxi’s progress. Choice C is incorrect because, as the narrator explains, both the multitude of people and the taxi are using a public space (a street) at the same time. The narrator doesn’t go so far as to suggest that the people feel that they, and not the taxi, possess exclusive access to the street.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8d40b6da

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 8d40b6da

In the search for new impact craters on Mars, the roles of seismic monitoring and orbital imaging as data sources are ____: when vibrations detected with seismic monitoring indicate roughly where an impact has occurred, researchers can use orbital images of that relatively limited area of the rocky surface to precisely locate a new crater.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. interchangeable
- B. complementary
- C. exhaustive
- D. redundant

ID: 8d40b6da Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of how seismic monitoring and orbital imaging are used to find impact craters on Mars. In this context, “complementary” means combining in such a way that each contributes something the other lacks. The text describes how two data sources work together: seismic monitoring detects vibrations that indicate the rough location of an impact, and orbital imaging is then used to examine that limited area in detail to pinpoint the exact location of the crater. Each method does something the other does not—seismic monitoring narrows the search area, while orbital imaging provides the precise location—and together they accomplish what neither could alone. This context supports the idea that the two methods’ roles are complementary.

Choice A is incorrect because describing the roles of seismic monitoring and orbital imaging as “interchangeable,” or able to be substituted for each other, would contradict the text. The text indicates that the two methods perform different functions in sequence (seismic monitoring narrows the area; orbital imaging pinpoints the crater), so they cannot be substituted for each other. Choice C is incorrect because describing the roles of seismic monitoring and orbital imaging as “exhaustive,” or comprehensive in covering all possibilities, wouldn’t be logical in context. The text describes how the two methods work together to perform a particular two-step task (locating new impact craters), not whether they collectively address every possible aspect of Mars research. Choice D is incorrect because describing the roles of seismic monitoring and orbital imaging as “redundant,” or unnecessarily duplicative, would contradict the text. The text indicates that each method performs a distinct function in finding impact craters on Mars—rough localization versus precise localization—so neither method duplicates the other’s contribution.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 43174f10

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 43174f10

Despite stated claims of global relevance, much major research on income inequality performed in the 2010s suffered from a myopic focus on a few countries in North America and Western Europe, partly due to limited data availability. Researchers would later _____ this shortcoming after gaining new access to banking records located in nations in Africa, such as Tunisia, and Eastern Europe, such as Hungary.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. presuppose
- B. categorize
- C. mitigate
- D. validate

ID: 43174f10 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of research on income inequality in the 2010s. In this context, "mitigate" means to make less severe or reduce the negative effects of something. The text first identifies a shortcoming in the research: a "myopic focus on a few countries" despite claims of "global relevance." The text then explains that researchers later gained access to new data from previously excluded regions (Africa and Eastern Europe). This context supports the idea that with these new data, researchers would be able to reduce, or mitigate, the identified shortcoming by incorporating a broader range of geographic regions into their studies of income inequality.

Choice A is incorrect because in this context, "presuppose" would mean to assume in advance that something is true, and it wouldn't make logical sense to say that researchers later assumed as true in advance a shortcoming they had already encountered. Choice B is incorrect because in this context, "categorize" would mean to classify or place into groups. The text indicates that researchers did something about the shortcoming that characterized research on income inequality in the 2010s—limited geographic scope—after they gained access to new data from previously excluded regions. Categorizing a shortcoming doesn't require access to or analysis of new data; it could be done without any new information, but by analyzing new data, researchers went beyond merely categorizing the shortcoming and instead took action to address it. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, "validate" would mean to confirm or substantiate something. The text indicates that researchers did something about a known shortcoming of research on income inequality in the 2010s—limited geographic scope—after they gained access to new data from previously excluded regions. Confirming an already known shortcoming doesn't require access to or analysis of new data; it could be done without any new information, but by analyzing new data, researchers went beyond merely validating the shortcoming and instead took action to make the shortcoming less severe.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bf9ae59a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: bf9ae59a

The following text is from Charlotte Brontë’s 1847 novel *Jane Eyre*. Jane, the narrator, works as a governess at Thornfield Hall.

I went on with my day’s business tranquilly; but ever and anon vague suggestions kept wandering across my brain of reasons why I should quit Thornfield; and I kept involuntarily framing advertisements and pondering conjectures about new situations: these thoughts I did not think to check; they might germinate and bear fruit if they could.

- Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?
- A. To convey a contrast between Jane’s outward calmness and internal restlessness
 - B. To emphasize Jane’s loyalty to the people she works for at Thornfield Hall
 - C. To demonstrate that Jane finds her situation both challenging and deeply fulfilling
 - D. To describe Jane’s determination to secure employment outside of Thornfield Hall

ID: bf9ae59a Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to show that while Jane calmly goes about her daily tasks, she is experiencing internal agitation about possibly seeking a new job. At the start of the text, Jane says, “I went on with my day’s business tranquilly,” indicating that she is outwardly calm. This outward calmness is then contrasted with her intense internal restlessness, as Jane says that thoughts of leaving her job keep running through her mind, that she is “involuntarily framing advertisements” (meaning that she can’t stop herself from thinking up potential listings for jobs), and that she often wonders what new “situations” (or jobs) would be like.

Choice B is incorrect because the text gives no indication of Jane’s feelings, either positive or negative, about the people she works for at Thornfield Hall. And rather than emphasizing that Jane feels particularly loyal to her employers, the text focuses on her constant consideration of leaving her job. Choice C is incorrect because the text gives no indication that Jane finds her current situation fulfilling, or satisfying. Given that much of the text is focused on Jane’s thoughts about possibly leaving her job for a new one, it might be the case that she finds her situation challenging, but there is no evidence in the text that Jane also finds that situation satisfying—she says nothing positive about her current job at all, in fact. Choice D is incorrect because the text describes Jane as wondering about getting a new job, not as determined to definitely do so. Jane keeps thinking about reasons why she “should” quit her current job (indicating that she hasn’t yet decided to) and imagining possible new situations she could find, but she says at the end of the text that these thoughts “might germinate and bear fruit if they could,” meaning that the thoughts haven’t yet led to a decision—that Jane isn’t yet determined to get a new job somewhere else.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f3acb03d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: f3acb03d

The following text is adapted from Aphra Behn’s 1689 novel *The Lucky Mistake*. Atlante and Rinaldo are neighbors who have been secretly exchanging letters through Charlot, Atlante’s sister.

[Atlante] gave this letter to Charlot; who immediately ran into the balcony with it, where she still found Rinaldo in a melancholy posture, leaning his head on his hand: She showed him the letter, but was afraid to toss it to him, for fear it might fall to the ground; so he ran and fetched a long cane, which he cleft at one end, and held it while she put the letter into the cleft, and stayed not to hear what he said to it. But never was man so transported with joy, as he was at the reading of this letter; it gives him new wounds; for to the generous, nothing obliges love so much as love.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It describes the delivery of a letter, and then portrays a character’s happiness at reading that letter.
- B. It establishes that a character is desperate to receive a letter, and then explains why another character has not yet written that letter.
- C. It presents a character’s concerns about delivering a letter, and then details the contents of that letter.
- D. It reveals the inspiration behind a character’s letter, and then emphasizes the excitement that another character feels upon receiving that letter.

ID: f3acb03d Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes the overall structure of the text. The narrator begins by explaining how Charlot carefully delivers Atlante’s letter to Rinaldo, and then relates that Rinaldo feels “transported with joy” after reading the letter. Therefore, the overall structure of the text is best described as a description of the delivery of a letter followed by the portrayal of a character’s happiness after reading the letter.

Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that the letter has been written; there’s no explanation why another character hasn’t written one. In addition, the text’s description of Rinaldo “in a melancholy posture” suggests that he’s sad and thoughtful, not that he’s desperate to receive the letter. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text states that Charlot won’t toss the letter to Rinaldo because she doesn’t want it to fall, the text doesn’t refer to the contents of the letter. Instead, the text describes how happy Rinaldo feels after reading it. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text does describe Rinaldo’s reaction to the letter, the text doesn’t begin by discussing Atlante’s inspiration for writing the letter. Instead, the text begins by discussing the delivery of the letter.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 36f8d65c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 36f8d65c

Eighteenth-century historian Edward Gibbon thought the only character defect of the Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius was his mild temperament—though the emperor was widely considered virtuous, his overly permissive nature led him to _____ the vices of those who surrounded him.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. indulge
- B. despise
- C. moderate
- D. criticize

ID: 36f8d65c Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius. In this context, "indulge" means treat with excessive leniency. The text states that according to historian Edward Gibbon, Marcus Aurelius, who was widely considered virtuous, had only a single character flaw: his mild temperament. The text suggests that because of this flaw, Marcus Aurelius had an overly permissive nature. This context, in turn, supports the idea that Marcus Aurelius treated the vices, or evils, of those around him with excessive leniency, indulging rather than punishing those vices.

Choice B is incorrect. While the text does state that Marcus Aurelius was widely considered virtuous, it gives no indication that he was inclined to "despise," or hate, others’ vices. Rather, the text suggests that he showed undue tolerance for these vices because of his overly permissive nature—that is, his inclination to allow others to do as they wished. Choice C is incorrect because the text’s description of Marcus Aurelius as overly permissive suggests that he showed undue tolerance for others’ vices, not that he tried to "moderate" those vices, or lessen their intensity. Choice D is incorrect because the text’s description of Marcus Aurelius as overly permissive suggests that he showed undue tolerance for others’ vices, not that he attempted to "criticize," or speak disapprovingly of, those vices.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 81defd85

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 81defd85

Archeological excavation of Market Street Chinatown, a nineteenth-century Chinese American community in San Jose, California, provided the first evidence that Asian food products were imported to the United States in the 1800s: bones from a freshwater fish species native to Southeast Asia. Jinshanzhuang—Hong Kong—based import/export firms—likely coordinated the fish’s transport from Chinese-operated fisheries in Vietnam and Malaysia to North American markets. This route reveals the (often overlooked) multinational dimensions of the trade networks linking Chinese diaspora communities.

- Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?
- A. It explains why efforts to determine the country of origin of the items mentioned in the previous sentence remain inconclusive.
 - B. It provides information that helps support a claim about a discovery’s significance that is presented in the following sentence.
 - C. It traces the steps that were taken to locate and recover the objects that are described in the previous sentence.
 - D. It outlines a hypothesis that additional evidence discussed in the following sentence casts some doubt on.

ID: 81defd85 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The underlined sentence provides information about import/export firms, showing how Chinese communities across the world were connected by trade routes.

Choice A is incorrect. The underlined sentence never suggests that the countries of origin of the fish are in question—in fact, it tells us exactly where they came from. Choice C is incorrect. The passage never describes the steps taken to discover the fish bones described in the previous sentence. Choice D is incorrect. The underlined sentence doesn’t outline a hypothesis but instead provides evidence. And the following sentence agrees with the underlined sentence, so we could eliminate this choice just for saying that the following sentence “casts some doubt on” the underlined one—partly wrong is all wrong.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f280a30a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: f280a30a

Industrial activity is often assumed to be a threat to wildlife, but that isn’t always so. Consider the silver-studded blue butterfly (*Plebejus argus*): as forest growth has reduced grasslands in northern Germany, many of these butterflies have left meadow habitats and are now thriving in active limestone quarries. In a survey of multiple active quarries and patches of maintained grassland, an ecologist found silver-studded blue butterflies in 100% of the quarries but only 57% of the grassland patches. Moreover, butterfly populations in the quarries were four times larger than those in the meadows.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. It challenges a common assumption about the species under investigation in the research referred to in the text.
- B. It introduces discussion of a specific example that supports the general claim made in the previous sentence.
- C. It suggests that a certain species should be included in additional studies like the one mentioned later in the text.
- D. It provides a definition for an unfamiliar term that is central to the main argument in the text.

ID: f280a30a Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes how the underlined portion functions in the text as a whole. The first sentence presents the general claim that industrial activity is not always a threat to wildlife. The underlined portion of the sentence that follows suggests that the silver-studded blue butterfly is an example of wildlife thriving in areas of industrial activity: active limestone quarries. Thus, the function of the underlined portion is to introduce a specific example in support of the general claim in the previous sentence.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the first sentence indicates that “industrial activity is often assumed” to harm wildlife, in the case of the silver-studded blue butterfly the text mentions neither an assumption about this species nor any challenge to such an assumption. Choice C is incorrect because the text mentions only one study: the “survey.” Additional studies are not mentioned in the text. Choice D is incorrect because neither the underlined portion nor any other portion of the text provides a definition for any of the terms used in the text’s argument.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 776b8c1f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 776b8c1f

Given that the conditions in binary star systems should make planetary formation nearly impossible, it’s not surprising that the existence of planets in such systems has lacked _____ explanation. Roman Rafikov and Kedron Silsbee shed light on the subject when they used modeling to determine a complex set of factors that could support planets’ development.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. a discernible
- B. a straightforward
- C. an inconclusive
- D. an unbiased

ID: 776b8c1f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s description of efforts to explain the existence of planets in binary star systems. As used in this context, describing an explanation as “a straightforward” one would mean that the explanation is direct and uncomplicated. The text asserts that since it should be “nearly impossible” for planets to form in binary star systems, it’s “not surprising” that there isn’t a straightforward explanation for the existence of planets in such systems; the fact that one potential approach involves “complex” factors offers further contextual support for this idea.

Choice A is incorrect because it would not make sense in context to say that there isn’t “a discernible” explanation—meaning an explanation capable of being perceived—for the existence of planets in binary star systems. The text discusses just such an explanation offered by Roman Rafikov and Kedron Silsbee, which indicates that their explanation can be discerned. Choice C is incorrect because the text emphasizes how difficult it is to explain the existence of planets in binary star systems, suggesting that the situation isn’t marked by the lack of “an inconclusive” explanation—an explanation that does not resolve the issue—but rather that if any explanations have been offered, they’ve likely been inconclusive ones. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that there is a lack of “an unbiased,” or impartial and unprejudiced, explanation for the existence of planets in binary star systems. The text indicates that it’s difficult to explain the existence of planets in such systems and it describes one attempt to do so, but there is no evidence that explanations from Roman Rafikov and Kedron Silsbee or others are biased.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3a3fd0e2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 3a3fd0e2

Austin McCoy has argued that historians have tended to _____ rank-and-file workers in analyses of changes in organized labor in the United States in the decades following the Second World War, presenting political, business, and labor leaders as the major actors and ordinary workers as nearly devoid of agency.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. epitomize
- B. marginalize
- C. extol
- D. substantiate

ID: 3a3fd0e2 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of how historians have treated rank-and-file (ordinary) workers in their analyses. In this context, "marginalize" means treat as unimportant or relatively powerless within a group or society. The text explains that according to Austin McCoy, historians have tended to treat "political, business, and labor leaders" as the "major actors" involved in making changes in organized labor in the period after the Second World War. By emphasizing the contributions of these leaders, historians have in effect minimized the contributions of ordinary workers, treating them as relatively unimportant and "nearly devoid of agency," thereby marginalizing them.

Choice A is incorrect. In this context, "epitomize" would mean either serve as an ideal example of something or make into an example of something, neither of which would make sense. In stating that historians have tended to characterize political, business, and labor leaders as the primary actors responsible for changes in the post-Second World War labor movement in a manner that minimizes the influence of ordinary workers, the text suggests that historians have tended to present ordinary workers as unimportant to or uninfluential within the movement, not that historians themselves serve as examples of ordinary workers, or that historians in their analyses have made ordinary workers into examples of the changes that occurred. Choice C is incorrect because in this context, "extol" would mean praise highly or glorify. The text states that historians have tended to present ordinary workers as being "nearly devoid of agency," thereby minimizing their importance. It therefore wouldn’t make sense to say that in doing so, historians have tended to praise or glorify them. Choice D is incorrect because "substantiate" would mean verify with evidence, and nothing in the text suggests that historians have verified rank-and-file workers or their contributions in their analyses. If anything, the text suggests the opposite, implying that by minimizing workers’ agency in organized labor, historians have likely overlooked evidence demonstrating their influence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1cb7ce62

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 1cb7ce62

In studying the use of external stimuli to reduce the itching sensation caused by an allergic histamine response, Louise Ward and colleagues found that while harmless applications of vibration or warming can provide a temporary distraction, such _____ stimuli actually offer less relief than a stimulus that seems less benign, like a mild electric shock.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. deceptive
- B. innocuous
- C. novel
- D. impractical

ID: 1cb7ce62 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Ward and colleagues’ findings. As used in this context, “innocuous” means mild or unharmed. The text describes the vibration and warming that Ward and colleagues used to alleviate itching as “harmless applications” and goes on to contrast these applications with another stimulus that actually offers more relief even though it seems to be stronger and “less benign.” This context conveys the idea that vibration and warming were innocuous stimuli.

Choice A is incorrect because the text focuses on a distinction between harmless stimuli and those that seem to be less benign. Nothing in the text suggests that any of the treatments are “deceptive,” or misleading; indeed, even the less effective ones are described as offering some relief. Choice C is incorrect because the text focuses on the amount of relief from itching offered by harmless stimuli and those that seem to be less benign. The text doesn’t suggest that any of these stimuli are “novel,” or original and new; heat, vibration, and electricity aren’t new inventions. Choice D is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to describe an application of vibration or warming as “impractical,” or not suitable for use. The text indicates that these harmless applications are useful in that they offer at least some temporary relief.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c84cc907

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: c84cc907

In many agricultural environments, the banks of streams are kept forested to protect water quality, but it’s been unclear what effects these forests may have on stream biodiversity. To investigate the issue, biologist Xingli Giam and colleagues studied an Indonesian oil palm plantation, comparing the species richness of forested streams with that of nonforested streams. Giam and colleagues found that species richness was significantly higher in forested streams, a finding the researchers attribute to the role leaf litter plays in sheltering fish from predators and providing food resources.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. It discusses research intended to settle a debate about how agricultural yields can be increased without negative effects on water quality.
- B. It explains the differences between stream-protection strategies used in oil palm plantations and stream-protection strategies used in other kinds of agricultural environments.
- C. It describes findings that challenge a previously held view about how fish that inhabit streams in agricultural environments attempt to avoid predators.
- D. It presents a study that addresses an unresolved question about the presence of forests along streams in agricultural environments.

ID: c84cc907 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The author first describes an unresolved question: what effect do bank forests have on stream biodiversity? Then the author presents a study that answers the question: bank forests increase stream biodiversity.

Choice A is incorrect. This isn’t the main purpose of the text. The text never mentions agricultural yields. Choice B is incorrect. This isn’t the main purpose of the text. The text never mentions other kinds of agricultural environments. Choice C is incorrect. This isn’t the main purpose of the text. The text never mentions any previously held view about how fish in these streams try to avoid predators.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1dfcc06f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 1dfcc06f

In editor Lisa Yaszek’s introduction to her anthology *The Future Is Female! More Classic Science Fiction Stories by Women*, Yaszek identifies an increasing sense of _____ feminist mode of writing in the 1970s, in contrast to many woman-authored science fiction stories of the 1920s to 1960s whose politics were less deliberately signaled.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. a prudently
- B. an overtly
- C. a cordially
- D. an inadvertently

ID: 1dfcc06f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Yaszek’s introduction to her science fiction anthology. In this context "overtly" means openly or without concealment. The text draws a contrast between the lack of "deliberately signaled" political themes in woman-authored science fiction from the 1920s to the 1960s and what Yaszek notes about woman-authored science fiction from the 1970s. This contrast implies that the work from the 1970s did clearly reflect feminist political themes. In other words, the text indicates that unlike women who wrote science fiction in the 1920s to the 1960s, the women who wrote science fiction in the 1970s expressed overtly feminist themes.

Choice A is incorrect. In this context "prudently" would mean cautiously, which might plausibly describe the women who wrote science fiction from the 1920s to the 1960s, in that they tended to avoid revealing their political views; however, the text contrasts these authors with the women writing science fiction in the 1970s, thereby suggesting that the authors writing in the 1970s were not restrained in that way. Choice C is incorrect because in this context "cordially" would mean politely, and nothing in the text indicates that politeness was a significant factor for women writing science fiction either from the 1920s to the 1960s or in the 1970s. The text draws a contrast between the lack of "deliberately signaled" political themes in woman-authored science fiction from the 1920s to the 1960s and what Yaszek notes about woman-authored science fiction from the 1970s. It’s unclear how "less deliberately signaled" politics and an increasing sense of politeness toward feminism would constitute a meaningful contrast. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, "inadvertently" would mean unintentionally, and nothing in the text suggests that Yaszek thought the feminist elements of the woman-authored science fiction from the 1970s arose without deliberate effort.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 44709064

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 44709064

Text 1

In a study of the benefits of having free time, Marissa Sharif found that the reported sense of life satisfaction tended to plateau when participants had two hours of free time per day and actually began to fall when they had five hours of free time per day. After further research, Sharif concluded that this dip in life satisfaction mainly occurred when individuals spent all their free time unproductively, such as by watching TV or playing games.

Text 2

Psychologist James Maddux cautions against suggesting an ideal amount of free time. The human desire for both free time and productivity is universal, but Maddux asserts that individuals have unique needs for life satisfaction. Furthermore, he points out that there is no objective definition for what constitutes productivity; reading a book might be considered a productive activity by some, but idleness by others.

Based on the texts, how would Maddux (Text 2) most likely respond to the conclusion Sharif (Text 1) reached after her further research?

- A. By acknowledging that free time is more likely to enhance life satisfaction when it is spent productively than when it is spent unproductively
- B. By challenging the reasoning in Text 1, as it has not been proved that productivity commonly contributes to individuals’ life satisfaction
- C. By warning against making an overly broad assumption, as there is no clear consensus in distinguishing between productive and unproductive activities
- D. By claiming that the specific activities named in Text 1 are actually examples of productive activities rather than unproductive ones

ID: 44709064 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it characterizes how Maddux would most likely respond to the conclusion Sharif reached after her research. Text 1 describes Sharif’s study of the benefits of free time, saying that the reported sense of satisfaction plateaued at two hours per day and began to decline at five hours per day. Further research led Sharif to conclude that time spent doing tasks she defines as unproductive, such as watching TV or playing games, correlated with a drop in life satisfaction. However, in Text 2 Maddux says that there is no objective definition of what constitutes productive behavior, giving the example that reading a book might be considered productive by some but unproductive by others. It can be inferred that Maddux would also assert that whether watching TV or playing games is productive or unproductive is a matter of subjective judgment. Thus,

Maddux would most likely caution against making an overly broad assumption, as there is no clear consensus in distinguishing between productive and unproductive activities.

Choice A is incorrect because Maddux asserts that individuals have unique needs for life satisfaction: some may want to spend that time productively, others unproductively, and what counts as productive is subjective. Therefore, Maddux would likely not consider it universally true that free time is more likely to enhance life satisfaction when it is spent productively. Choice B is incorrect because the study described in Text 1 concerns whether free time contributes to life satisfaction, not whether productivity contributes to life satisfaction. The dip in life satisfaction that Sharif claims to observe in Text 1 happens only after five hours, and mainly if the time is spent unproductively—that is, two hours of free time spent productively might increase life satisfaction just as much as two hours spent unproductively. Choice D is incorrect because Maddux holds the opinion that whether an activity is productive or unproductive is subjective and depends on the individual; therefore, he would most likely claim that watching TV or playing games might be productive for some and unproductive for others.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ff6698c1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: ff6698c1

During a 2014 archaeological dig in Spain, Vicente Lull and his team uncovered the skeleton of a woman from El Algar, an Early Bronze Age society, buried with valuable objects signaling a high position of power. This finding may persuade researchers who have argued that Bronze Age societies were ruled by men to _____ that women may have also held leadership roles.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. waive
- B. concede
- C. refute
- D. require

ID: ff6698c1 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the significance of the 2014 archaeological finding at El Algar. In this context, “concede” means to admit something is true after first resisting that admission. The text indicates that some researchers believe “Bronze Age societies were ruled by men.” But the Bronze Age burial of a woman at El Algar included “valuable objects signaling a high position of power,” which would raise the possibility that “women may have also held leadership roles.” Thus, the text is calling into question the notion that only men were leaders in these societies and speculating that people holding this view may reconsider their opinion.

Choice A is incorrect because “waive” means to refrain from insisting that something, such as a right or a requirement, be observed; the word isn’t used, however, in contexts where someone acknowledges that an opinion they hold may be invalid, as is the case in the text. Choice C is incorrect. According to the text, the finding from the El Algar burial site undermines the view that Bronze Age societies were exclusively ruled by men. However, “refute” means to demonstrate that something is false and would not make sense in context. Lull and team’s finding supports the view that women may have also held leadership roles, not that they did not participate in such roles. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, “require” means to demand or specify as mandatory. However, it would not make sense for contemporary researchers to demand that Bronze Age “women may have also held leadership roles.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a06d5b2b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: a06d5b2b

Works of moral philosophy, such as Plato’s *Republic* or Aristotle’s *Nicomachean Ethics*, are partly concerned with how to live a morally good life. But philosopher Jonathan Barnes argues that works that present a method of living such a life without also supplying a motive are inherently useful only to those already wishing to be morally good—those with no desire for moral goodness will not choose to follow their rules. However, some works of moral philosophy attempt to describe what constitutes a morally good life while also proposing reasons for living one.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It provides a characterization about a field of thought by noting two works in it and then details a way in which some works in that field are more comprehensive than others.
- B. It mentions two renowned works and then claims that despite their popularity it is impossible for these works to serve the purpose their authors intended.
- C. It summarizes the history of a field of thought by discussing two works and then proposes a topic of further research for specialists in that field.
- D. It describes two influential works and then explains why one is more widely read than the other.

ID: a06d5b2b Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The text starts by stating what moral philosophy is concerned with and naming two examples of works in the field. Then it describes a shortcoming of some works in that field (they say how but not why), and finally it states that other works try to avoid that shortcoming (by including both how and why to live a morally good life).

Choice B is incorrect. This is too extreme. The text never mentions whether the two works are popular or not, and it never argues that these works don’t serve their intended purpose of describing how to live a morally good life. Rather, the text claims that works of moral philosophy that don’t include both how and why to be moral are not useful to readers who don’t already want to be moral. Choice C is incorrect. This isn’t the overall structure. The text never discusses the history of moral philosophy at all, and it doesn’t propose any topic for further research. Choice D is incorrect. This isn’t the overall structure. The text never discusses which of the two works is more widely read.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ab2387d7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: ab2387d7

Bicycle sharing systems allow users to rent a bicycle at one location within a city and return it to any other designated location in that city, which can cause serious problems of bicycle supply and user demand within the city’s system. Tohru Ikeguchi uses open-source data and statistical modeling to identify when a high number of users making one-way trips is likely to leave some locations within the system _____ bicycles and other areas with insufficient supply.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. susceptible to
- B. contingent on
- C. saturated with
- D. depleted of

ID: ab2387d7 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Ikeguchi’s model of bicycle supply. In this context, “saturated with” means thoroughly or completely supplied with. The text explains a problem encountered by some bicycle-sharing programs: users can return bicycles to different locations than where the users picked up the bicycles to start, which can result in a mismatch between bicycle supply (that is, where the bicycles are currently located) and user demand (that is, the locations where users are hoping to pick up bicycles). The text goes on to explain that Ikeguchi developed a way to identify when this mismatch is likely to occur. This context suggests that Ikeguchi’s method will show when it is likely that some locations have an insufficient supply and other locations, by implicit contrast, are saturated with bicycles.

Choice A is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that some locations are “susceptible to,” or sensitive to or easily influenced by, bicycles. The text describes the phenomenon of bicycles being redistributed away from locations where users want them, not anything about those locations being influenced by the bicycles. Choice B is incorrect because the text describes situations in which some locations have an insufficient supply of bicycles because the bicycles have been relocated elsewhere, which suggests that the other locations have many bicycles, not that the other locations are “contingent on,” or dependent on, the bicycles. Nothing in the text suggests that the locations themselves depend on the bicycles for anything. Choice D is incorrect because it would not make sense in context to say that some locations are “depleted of,” or empty of, bicycles while others have an insufficient supply. The text describes situations in which bicycles have been relocated such that there is a mismatch between bicycle supply and user demand—the bicycles are no longer at the locations where users want to pick them up. This means that some locations do not have enough bicycles, while other locations must have many bicycles, not be depleted of bicycles.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3fdeb11a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 3fdeb11a

Text 1

Philosopher G.E. Moore’s most influential work entails the concept of common sense. He asserts that there are certain beliefs that all people, including philosophers, know instinctively to be true, whether or not they profess otherwise: among them, that they have bodies, or that they exist in a world with other objects that have three dimensions. Moore’s careful work on common sense may seem obvious but was in fact groundbreaking.

Text 2

External world skepticism is a philosophical stance supposing that we cannot be sure of the existence of anything outside our own minds. During a lecture, G.E. Moore once offered a proof refuting this stance by holding out his hands and saying, “Here is one hand, and here is another.” Many philosophers reflexively reject this proof (Annalisa Coliva called it “an obviously annoying failure”) but have found it a challenge to articulate exactly why the proof fails.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 1 most likely respond to proponents of the philosophical stance outlined in Text 2?

- A. By agreeing with those proponents that Moore’s treatment of positions that contradict his own is fundamentally unserious
- B. By suggesting that an instinctive distaste for Moore’s position is preventing external world skeptics from constructing a sufficiently rigorous refutation of Moore
- C. By arguing that if it is valid to assert that some facts are true based on instinct, it is also valid to assert that some proofs are inadequate based on instinct
- D. By pointing out that Moore would assert that external world skepticism is at odds with other beliefs those proponents must unavoidably hold

ID: 3fdeb11a Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. According to the author of Text 1, Moore’s definition of common sense—things we instinctively know are true—includes the belief that we all “exist in a world with other objects.” The author of Text 1 describes this notion as both “obvious” and “groundbreaking.” So it’s safe to infer that the author would observe that Moore would respond to external world skeptics by arguing that since everyone instinctively knows that things exist outside of their own minds, then external world skepticism must be wrong.

Choice A is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to external world skeptics. If anything, the author of Text 1 seems to agree with Moore. Choice B is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to external world skeptics. The author of Text 1 never mentions external world skeptics directly, let alone why they have a hard time refuting Moore’s position. Choice C is incorrect. We can’t infer that the author of Text 1 would respond this way to external

world skeptics. Text 1's presentation of Moore's concept of common sense only includes the idea that some facts are true based on instinct—it doesn't mention the idea that some proofs are inadequate based on instinct.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0bf311a6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 0bf311a6

Interruptions in the supply chain for microchips used in personal electronics have challenged an economist’s assertion that retailers can expect robust growth in sales of those devices in the coming months. The delays are unlikely to _____ her projection entirely but will almost certainly extend its time frame.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. dispute
- B. withdraw
- C. underscore
- D. invalidate

ID: 0bf311a6 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the economist’s claim about sales of personal electronic devices. In this context, “invalidate” most nearly means nullify or make invalid. The text indicates that interruptions in the supply of microchips for personal electronics “have challenged” the economist’s claim that sales of personal electronics will show strong growth in the coming months. The text goes on to clarify the effect of the delays on the economist’s projection, stating that the delays are very likely to extend the time frame over which the projected growth in sales will occur. This context suggests that the delays are unlikely to invalidate the economist’s projection entirely—the delays will probably alter the time frame of the projection, not nullify it or make it invalid.

Choice A is incorrect because saying that the delays are unlikely to “dispute,” or argue against, the economist’s projection wouldn’t make sense. Since the delays are an inanimate circumstance, they couldn’t argue against a prediction about the sales of personal electronics. Choice B is incorrect because saying that the delays are unlikely to “withdraw,” or remove from consideration, the economist’s projection wouldn’t make sense. Although the economist could withdraw her projection because of the delays, the delays themselves couldn’t withdraw her projection since they’re an inanimate circumstance and thus can’t choose to remove something from consideration. Choice C is incorrect because there’s nothing in the text to suggest that the delays will “underscore,” or emphasize, the economist’s projection. Instead, the text suggests that the delays are likely to extend the time frame of the economist’s projection but not to undermine the projection entirely.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e48d0707

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: e48d0707

A study by Dr. Paul Hanel and colleagues concluded that people are more likely to behave politely when listening to ideas they disagree with if they think about values before they engage in a discussion. Study participants were assigned to one of two groups. The experimental group spent a few minutes writing about one of their personal values before they had a group discussion on a controversial topic. And the control group spent a few minutes writing about a drink (tea, milk, etc.) before their group discussion on that topic. Hanel and colleagues found that the experimental group’s discussion was more civil than the control group’s discussion was.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A. To describe a widely held belief and how a study’s results support that belief
- B. To argue that researchers were surprised by the results of a certain study
- C. To suggest ways to improve a certain study’s experimental design
- D. To explain a study’s conclusion and how a research team arrived at that conclusion

ID: e48d0707 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to explain a study’s conclusion and how researchers involved in the study arrived at that conclusion. The text begins by summarizing the main conclusion of the study conducted by Paul Hanel and colleagues: when confronted with ideas they disagree with in discussions about controversial topics, people are more likely to respond politely if they think about their personal values before engaging in such discussions. The text then goes on to describe the design of Hanel and colleagues’ experiment. By comparing interactions between members of an experimental group (who had been prompted to write about their personal values beforehand) to those between members of a control group (who had been prompted to write about a beverage), the team found that people in the experimental group behaved more civilly, or politely, than people in the control group did during discussions about a controversial topic. This finding led to the conclusion described at the beginning of the text.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text discusses the results of a study, it doesn’t provide any indication that the conclusion the study supported—that when facing disagreement, people behave more politely when they have thought about their values—is a belief that is widely held. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that the researchers found the results of their study to be surprising, or contrary to what they expected. In fact, there’s no indication provided in the text about how the researchers felt about the study’s results or that the results should be considered surprising. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text discusses the experimental design of a study, it doesn’t suggest any improvements to that design; instead, it focuses on how the design enabled the researchers to draw a particular conclusion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 41530f05

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 41530f05

In *Habitat Threshold*, Chamoru (Chamorro) poet Craig Santos Perez practices what he calls “recycling,” in which he preserves the syntactical and rhetorical structures of canonical poems but replaces their content to evoke current environmental issues. The form of these poems is thus _____ to their meaning, inviting readers to consider how climate change alters ostensibly familiar experiences.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. antithetical
- B. resigned
- C. invulnerable
- D. integral

ID: 41530f05 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Craig Santos Perez’s poetic practice in *Habitat Threshold*. In this context, “integral” means essential or fundamentally connected. The text describes Perez’s “recycling” technique, in which he retains the syntactical and rhetorical structures (i.e., formal elements) of canonical poems but alters their content to address current environmental issues. The text further indicates that this technique invites readers to recognize how climate change has transformed seemingly familiar experiences—an effect that depends on the contrast between a poem’s recognizable inherited form and its new content. Because meaning derives from the particular way in which form and content interact in Perez’s poems, the context supports the idea that the form of these poems is integral to their meaning—in other words, form is fundamentally bound up with what the poems convey.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to say that the form of Perez’s poems is “antithetical,” or directly opposed, to their meaning. The text indicates that the inherited form and the new content work together to produce the poems’ effect, so the form is essential, not opposed, to the poems’ meaning. Choice B is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to say that the form of Perez’s poems is “resigned,” or passively accepting. “Resigned” describes an attitude held by a person, not a relationship between a poem’s form and its meaning. Moreover, the poems’ form actively contributes to their meaning; it would contradict the text to suggest that the poems’ form merely serves as a passive vehicle for meaning. Choice C is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to say that the form of Perez’s poems is “invulnerable,” or incapable of being harmed. The text doesn’t characterize the poems’ meanings as threats to their form; instead, it discusses how form and meaning relate.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c9c4a616

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: c9c4a616

The Polynesian languages, a group of related languages originating on islands in the Pacific, typically have _____ array of consonant sounds. For example, the Mangareva language of the South Pacific has nine consonants, and ‘Ōlelo Hawai‘i, the language of the Native Hawaiian people, has eight. Globally, however, the median number of consonants per language is over twenty-two.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. an unvarying
- B. a musical
- C. an exclusive
- D. a modest

ID: c9c4a616 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Polynesian languages. In this context, “modest” means relatively limited or small. The text begins with a statement about the array, or number, of consonant sounds in these languages. It then gives examples of one Polynesian language that has nine consonants and one that has eight consonants before noting that the global median number of consonants per language is more than twenty-two; in other words, the numbers of consonants in the Polynesian examples are well below the global median number. This context conveys that the text is making the point that the Polynesian languages have a modest array of consonant sounds.

Choice A is incorrect. In this context, “unvarying” would mean unchanging. The text focuses on comparing the typical numbers of consonant sounds in Polynesian languages to the global median number of consonants per language, not on conveying that the number of consonant sounds in Polynesian languages typically doesn’t vary; the text makes no mention of the number of consonants changing within a language or language group. Choice B is incorrect because the text is focused on the quantity of consonant sounds in Polynesian languages, not the idea that those consonants are “musical,” or pleasantly harmonious and like music; the text discusses only the numbers of consonants in Polynesian languages and the global median number of consonants per language, not the way consonants sound. Choice C is incorrect. In this context, “exclusive” would mean limited to a single group. The text discusses the typical numbers of consonant sounds in Polynesian languages and gives two examples of languages with consonant numbers below the global median number of consonants per language, but it doesn’t suggest that the array, or number, of consonant sounds in Polynesian languages is exclusive to those languages—that is, that Polynesian languages are the only ones with eight to nine consonants.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7ff10082

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 7ff10082

In the 2010s, the price of pop music cassette tapes from the 1980s and 1990s rose dramatically, which had the counterintuitive effect of _____ demand: buyers who hadn’t previously wanted to purchase vintage cassettes thronged the market, believing prices would continue to rise and the tapes could be resold later at a profit.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. exploiting
- B. monetizing
- C. appraising
- D. engendering

ID: 7ff10082 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of how rising prices affected demand for vintage cassette tapes. In this context, "engendering" means producing or causing to exist. The text indicates that the effect of a dramatic increase in the price of vintage cassettes was counterintuitive, or contrary to what would typically be expected. Generally, when prices rise, demand falls—but the text indicates that in this case, buyers who previously had no interest in cassettes "thronged the market" (that is, many of them began purchasing cassettes) because they saw the cassettes as potential investments. This context conveys that the rising prices surprisingly produced significant demand, producing many new buyers for vintage cassettes.

Choice A is incorrect because the text focuses on a rise in prices of vintage cassettes, and it wouldn’t make sense to describe the price increase itself—rather than sellers of vintage cassettes—as "exploiting," or unfairly or selfishly taking advantage of, demand. Further, wanting to take advantage of new demand would be a motivation for a price increase, not a counterintuitive effect of it. Choice B is incorrect. In this context, "monetizing" would mean utilizing as a source of profit, and it wouldn’t make sense to describe a price increase itself, rather than sellers of vintage cassettes, as using demand as a source of profit; moreover, seeking to profit when there’s new demand would be a reason for price increases, not a counterintuitive effect of them. Choice C is incorrect. In this context, "appraising" would mean assessing the value or significance of something. The text focuses on a rise in prices of vintage cassettes, and while it would be reasonable to suggest that sellers might have appraised demand for those cassettes, it wouldn’t make sense to suggest that a price increase itself could do such an assessment; moreover, an appraisal of demand would most likely precede a price increase rather than be an effect of it.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c6837300

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: c6837300

Text 1

When the 50-second-long film *Arrival of the Train*—which depicts what its title says, a train pulling into a station—was first shown publicly in 1896, spectators, naïve to the new medium of film and seeing a train appearing to come directly at them, leaped from their seats and fled the room. This moment marks a major cultural shift: a new way of representing and seeing the world had arrived with that train, and nothing would ever be the same.

Text 2

The fact that there is no contemporary evidence that the first audience of *Arrival of the Train* was alarmed has not stopped the story from becoming canonical, even among film historians. But that phenomenon itself is highly revealing. Our belief that the coming of film was transformative is so strong that we invented and keep retelling a founding myth that divides cultural history into a (naïve) “before” and (sophisticated) “after.”

Based on the texts, the author of Text 2 would most likely agree with which statement about the description of the first showing of *Arrival of the Train* in Text 1?

- A. It is more motivated by a perception of the significance of the invention of film than by facts.
- B. It expresses a view about the transformative nature of film that film historians tend to regard as naïve.
- C. It is not based on evidence and reflects film historians’ belief that they are more sophisticated than today’s audiences.
- D. It reflects a misconception that is widely believed because it captures early film audiences’ sense that the new medium was alarming.

ID: c6837300 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it provides a statement about the description of the first showing of *Arrival of the Train* in Text 1 that, based on the texts, the author of Text 2 would most likely agree with. Text 1 indicates that members of the audience, unaccustomed to the new medium of film and believing that they were looking at a real oncoming train, allegedly reacted to the film with alarm. Text 1 then goes on to treat this anecdote as a factual account of the film’s first showing, interpreting it as a moment that marked a “major cultural shift.” In contrast, the author of Text 2 indicates that though the story of the film’s first showing has become “canonical,” or widely accepted, there is no contemporary evidence to support the idea that the audience reacted as Text 1 describes. Text 2 goes on to explain that this factually questionable description likely persists because it functions as a “founding myth” that reinforces a widespread belief in the profoundly transformative nature of the invention of film. This indicates that the author of Text 2 would likely see the description in Text 1 as motivated primarily by cultural perceptions about film’s significance rather than by documented historical facts.

Choice B is incorrect because the author of Text 2 doesn't suggest that film historians regard the view about film's transformative nature as naïve. On the contrary, Text 2 states that the story of the first showing of *Arrival of the Train* has become "canonical, even among film historians," indicating that historians broadly accept this narrative as a compelling illustration of film's impact, not that they regard either the narrative or the views it conveys about the transformative nature of film as naïve. Text 2 refers to a " (naïve) 'before'" in cultural history, but this is describing how the myth itself characterizes pre-film audiences, not how historians regard views about the transformative nature of film. Choice C is incorrect. While the author of Text 2 does indicate that the story of the audience's reaction to *Arrival of the Train* described in Text 1 is a myth that lacks evidence, the text doesn't suggest that the story reflects the fact that film historians believe themselves to be more sophisticated than modern audiences are. Rather, Text 2 suggests that the story persists because of a collective cultural belief, which historians share, in the profound impact of the invention of film. Moreover, the "naïve" versus "sophisticated" distinction mentioned in Text 2 refers to how the myth characterizes audiences before and after the invention of film; it doesn't characterize modern audiences versus film historians. Choice D is incorrect. Although the author of Text 2 would agree that the description of the first showing of *Arrival of the Train* in Text 1 reflects a misconception, the author wouldn't agree that widespread belief in the misconception can be attributed to the fact that it accurately captures early audiences' actual sense of alarm. In fact, the misconception identified by the author of Text 2 concerns the accuracy of the audience's alleged reaction; the author questions whether early audiences were alarmed at all, stating there is "no contemporary evidence" that they reacted in this way. According to Text 2, the description is widely believed not because it accurately captures historical reactions but because it serves as a "founding myth" that supports a belief in film's transformative cultural impact.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b33eff0f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: b33eff0f

Archaeologists have identified a plethora of beads fashioned from *Tritia gibbosula* shells in many Middle Stone Age (MSA) sites across western North Africa, including El Mnasra Cave, Morocco. In a 2021 paper, El Mehdi Sehasseh et al. attribute these artifacts’ apparent _____ to the evolution and propagation of symbolic behavior (e.g., use of personal ornaments) in humans and the widespread availability of *T. gibbosula* during the MSA.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. heterogeneity
- B. ubiquity
- C. expediency
- D. fecundity

ID: b33eff0f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of beads found in Middle Stone Age sites. In this context, “ubiquity” means widespread presence or commonness. The text states that archaeologists have encountered “a plethora,” or an abundance, of beads made from *Tritia gibbosula* shells “in many Middle Stone Age (MSA) sites across western North Africa.” In this context, the abundance of beads therefore suggests their ubiquity.

Choice A is incorrect because in this context, “heterogeneity” would mean variety or diversity among the beads. The text doesn’t suggest that the beads varied significantly from one another; rather, it focuses on their widespread presence across multiple sites. Moreover, the text mentions that all the beads were “fashioned from *Tritia gibbosula* shells,” suggesting consistency rather than heterogeneity. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t emphasize the beads’ “expediency,” or convenience or practicality. The text doesn’t support the idea of convenience (there’s no indication, for example, that the beads were easy to use or make) but rather focuses on the beads’ abundant presence at MSA sites. Choice D is incorrect. While “fecundity” can suggest abundant production, it specifically refers to fertility, and the text doesn’t connect the beads to this theme. Instead, the text attributes their widespread presence to the development of symbolic behavior in humans and the natural availability of *Tritia gibbosula* during the MSA.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 78847e5f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 78847e5f

The following text is from Edith Wharton’s 1905 novel *The House of Mirth*. Lily Bart and a companion are walking through a park. Lily had no real intimacy with nature, but she had a passion for the appropriate and could be keenly sensitive to a scene which was the fitting background of her own sensations. The landscape outspread below her seemed an enlargement of her present mood, and she found something of herself in its calmness, its breadth, its long free reaches. On the nearer slopes the sugar-maples wavered like pyres of light; lower down was a massing of grey orchards, and here and there the lingering green of an oak-grove.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- A. It creates a detailed image of the physical setting of the scene.
- B. It establishes that a character is experiencing an internal conflict.
- C. It makes an assertion that the next sentence then expands on.
- D. It illustrates an idea that is introduced in the previous sentence.

ID: 78847e5f Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it best describes how the underlined sentence functions in the text as a whole. The first sentence of the text establishes that Lily can be “keenly sensitive to” scenes that serve as a “fitting background” for her feelings—that is, she’s very aware of when a setting seems to reflect her mood. The next sentence, which is underlined, then demonstrates this awareness: Lily views the landscape she’s in as a large-scale reflection of her current mood, identifying with elements such as its calmness. Thus, the function of the underlined sentence is to illustrate an idea introduced in the previous sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because the underlined sentence describes the scene only in very general terms, referring to its calmness, breadth, and long stretches of land. It’s the next sentence that adds specific details about colors, light, and various trees nearby. Choice B is incorrect because nothing in the underlined sentence suggests that Lily is experiencing an internal conflict. In fact, the sentence indicates that Lily thinks the landscape reflects her own feeling of calmness. Choice C is incorrect because the only assertion in the underlined sentence is that Lily feels that broad aspects of the landscape, such as its calmness, reflect her current mood, and that assertion isn’t expanded on in the next sentence. Instead, the next sentence describes specific details of the scene without connecting them to Lily’s feelings.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ce5ebcf6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: ce5ebcf6

The following text is adapted from Upton Sinclair’s 1906 novel *The Jungle*. Marija is helping to manage her sister’s wedding.

It was [Marija’s] task to see that all things went in due form, and after the best home traditions; and, flying wildly hither and thither, bowling every one out of the way, and scolding and exhorting all day with her tremendous voice, Marija was too eager to see that others conformed to the proprieties to consider them herself.

As used in the text, what does the word “consider” most nearly mean?

- A. Take into account and follow
- B. Admire steadily and praise
- C. Come to a decision about
- D. Have an opinion on

ID: ce5ebcf6 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because as used in the text, "consider" most nearly means to take into account and follow. The text explains that Marija’s job was to make sure that her sister’s wedding proceeded in certain ways ("in due form") and that she loudly directed everyone’s actions all day. The text then indicates that Marija was so focused on ensuring that others "conformed to the proprieties"—that is, that they behaved in appropriate ways—that she failed to "consider them herself"; that is, she didn’t take standards of appropriate behavior into account and follow them in her own actions.

Choice B is incorrect. In some contexts, "consider" can mean to think about something in a positive way—which can involve admiration—but the text doesn’t suggest that Marija was so busy imposing "proprieties" (standards of appropriate behavior) on others that she didn’t admire and praise them herself. The context suggests it’s more likely that Marija did speak positively of "due form" and "the best home traditions" while ensuring others behaved in certain ways. Choice C is incorrect. In some contexts, "consider" can mean to come to a decision, but the text doesn’t suggest that Marija wasn’t able to make a decision for herself about the "proprieties" (standards of appropriate behavior) she ensured everyone else conformed to. Rather, the context conveys that Marija knew very clearly which behaviors others should follow as "due form" and "the best home traditions." Choice D is incorrect. In some contexts, "consider" can mean to have an opinion, but the text doesn’t suggest that Marija wasn’t able to have an opinion on the "proprieties" (standards of appropriate behavior) she was ensuring others conformed to. Rather, the context conveys that Marija had strong feelings about which behaviors were "due form" and "the best home traditions."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b0e95fe4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: b0e95fe4

Curious about how people visually perceive objects in their dreams, Stephen LaBerge and team recruited lucid dreamers—people aware that they’re dreaming as it’s happening—for a research study. These participants were reliably able to signal when they had entered a dream state; the team then observed participants’ eye movements as they slept. The smoothness with which participants’ eyes tracked objects in their dreams closely matched how sighted people who are awake visually track objects around them, suggesting to the team that the brain perceives dream objects as the product of something other than pure imagination.

Which choice best states the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. To offer key evidence that undermines LaBerge and team’s initial hypothesis
- B. To show the unexpected result that led LaBerge and team to change the focus of their study
- C. To illustrate an important real-world implication of LaBerge and team’s main finding
- D. To identify a comparable circumstance that helps justify LaBerge and team’s conclusion

ID: b0e95fe4 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most accurately describes how the underlined portion functions in the text as a whole. The text first establishes that in order to investigate visual perception of objects in dreams, LaBerge and team observed the eye movements of lucid dreamers (people who are aware of their dreaming as it occurs) when these participants signaled that they were in a dream state. The underlined portion then describes a finding that rests on a comparison: the way participants’ eyes tracked objects in dream states was very similar to how sighted people track real objects when awake. Finally, the text states that the team concluded from this finding that objects in dreams are perceived as more than just products of imagination—implying that the team thinks the eye movements are an indication that the brain treats dream objects as more real than imaginary. Thus, the function of the underlined portion is to identify a circumstance that is comparable to one in the study and that helps justify LaBerge and team’s conclusion, presenting the close similarity of visual tracking in wakeful and dreaming scenarios as support for the implicit idea that the brain perceives dream objects not as imaginary but as somewhat or fully real objects.

Choice A is incorrect because the text never presents LaBerge and team’s initial hypothesis, only what question they were interested in studying and what they found. So although the underlined portion does present evidence, that evidence doesn’t serve to undermine any hypothesis in the text. Choice B is incorrect because the text gives no indication that LaBerge and team changed the focus of their study at any point or that the finding described in the underlined portion (or any other finding) was unexpected or surprising. Choice C is incorrect. Rather than illustrating an implication of the main finding by LaBerge and team, the underlined portion only presents the finding itself, stating that the team found that the movements of lucid dreamers’ eyes while dreaming were very similar to those of sighted people visually tracking objects while awake. The next part of the text indicates what the finding implied to the team but still doesn’t offer a real-world example as illustration.

Question ID 59971f10

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 59971f10

The mimosa tree evolved in East Asia, where the beetle *Bruchidius terrenus* preys on its seeds. In 1785, mimosa trees were introduced to North America, far from any *B. terrenus*. But evolutionary links between predators and their prey can persist across centuries and continents. Around 2001, *B. terrenus* was introduced in southeastern North America near where botanist Shu-Mei Chang and colleagues had been monitoring mimosa trees. Within a year, 93 percent of the trees had been attacked by the beetles.

Which choice best describes the function of the third sentence in the overall structure of the text?

- A. It states the hypothesis that Chang and colleagues had set out to investigate using mimosa trees and *B. terrenus*.
- B. It presents a generalization that is exemplified by the discussion of the mimosa trees and *B. terrenus*.
- C. It provides context that clarifies why the species mentioned spread to new locations.
- D. It offers an alternative explanation for the findings of Chang and colleagues.

ID: 59971f10 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes the function of the third sentence within the overall structure of the text. The third sentence makes a generalization, asserting that evolutionary links between predators and prey can persist across great expanses of time and distance. This generalization is exemplified by the text’s discussion of the relationship between mimosa trees and *B. terrenus* beetles. When mimosa trees were introduced to North America in 1785, no *B. terrenus* beetles were present, so the relationship between the trees and the beetles that exists in their native East Asia was disrupted. When the beetles were introduced to North America more than 200 years later, however, they quickly attacked mimosa trees, illustrating the generalization that links between predators and prey "can persist across centuries and continents."

Choice A is incorrect because the third sentence doesn’t indicate that Chang and colleagues were investigating any hypothesis. According to the text, Chang and colleagues were simply monitoring mimosa trees when the beetles happened to be introduced to the area. Choice C is incorrect because the third sentence doesn’t discuss any particular species, let alone the species mentioned elsewhere in the text, nor does the sentence explain why species spread to new locations. Choice D is incorrect because the third sentence offers a generalization about the relationship between predators and prey, not an explanation for the findings by Chang and colleagues that’s an "alternative" to an explanation presented elsewhere in the text.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e813cfd7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: e813cfd7

The percentage of US forest land that a 2023 federal report identified as being either mature or old growth exceeds other recent estimates. Given how little _____ there is among scientists regarding the scope of these categories, this discrepancy shouldn't be surprising: forest researchers regularly dispute one another's classifications.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. deliberation
- B. vigilance
- C. interest
- D. consensus

ID: e813cfd7 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text's discussion of US forest land classifications. In this context, "consensus" means agreement. The text indicates that a percentage given in a US forest land report differs from other estimates and that this discrepancy isn't surprising, given that forest researchers regularly dispute one another's classifications of parts of US forest land as either mature or old growth. This context conveys that there is little agreement when it comes to these categories.

Choice A is incorrect because the text states that there is often dispute among forest researchers about classifications of US forest land as either mature or old growth, which directly indicates that when it comes to these categories, there is much "deliberation," or discussion and consideration, not little deliberation. Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that there is often dispute among forest researchers about classifications of US forest land as either mature or old growth; this doesn't imply that there is little "vigilance," or careful attention, among researchers when it comes to these categories but rather conveys that researchers do pay attention to forest land classifications and question one another's decisions. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates that there is often dispute among forest researchers about classifications of US forest land as either mature or old growth; this doesn't imply that there is little "interest," or concern, among researchers when it comes to these categories but rather conveys that researchers are concerned with forest land classifications and pay attention to one another's classifications.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3f40d4cb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 3f40d4cb

To develop a method for measuring snow depth with laser beams, NASA physicist Yongxiang Hu relied on ____; identifying broad similarities between two seemingly different phenomena, Hu used information about how ants move inside colonies to calculate how the particles of light that make up laser beams travel through snow.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. a collaboration
- B. an accessory
- C. a contradiction
- D. an analogy

ID: 3f40d4cb Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The text after the semicolon tells us that Hu "identif[ied] broad similarities between two seemingly different phenomena," comparing ants with light particles. Since an analogy seeks similarities between seemingly unrelated phenomena, this fits the context perfectly.

Choice A is incorrect. "A collaboration" refers to "an act of working with others," but what comes after the semicolon doesn't describe collaboration with other researchers. Instead, it shows a comparison between two different (but ultimately similar) scientific phenomena. Choice B is incorrect. "An accessory" can refer to "something added to increase attractiveness or usefulness." No accessories are described in this text. Choice C is incorrect. "A contradiction" means "a set of ideas or things that are opposed to or inconsistent with each other." The text describes how Hu used the similarity between ant and light particle movement to develop his method, so a word that refers to difference would not make sense here.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b06a1758

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: b06a1758

Birds sing to communicate over potentially great distances. For this reason, many researchers believe that birds in densely vegetated habitats generally sing at lower frequencies than birds living in comparatively sparse habitats, since dense vegetation tends to _____ the distance that high-frequency sounds can travel.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. exceed
- B. diminish
- C. encompass
- D. conceal

ID: b06a1758 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of birdsong. In this context, "diminish" means reduce or lessen. The text establishes that birds sing to communicate over potentially large distances and that researchers believe that birds that live in densely vegetated habitats sing at lower frequencies than birds that live in comparatively sparsely vegetated habitats. The text then explains that researchers hold this belief due to some effect of dense vegetation on the distance that high-frequency sounds can travel. If birds sing to communicate over long distances, it would be logical to conclude that researchers believe that birds in densely vegetated habitats sing at lower frequencies than birds in relatively sparse habitats do because dense vegetation diminishes the distance that high-frequency sounds can travel.

Choice A is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that dense vegetation can "exceed," or surpass or go beyond, the distance that high-frequency sounds can travel. The text suggests that dense vegetation reduces the distance that high-frequency sounds can travel, not that dense vegetation goes farther than that distance. Choice C is incorrect because it would not be sensible to say that dense vegetation can "encompass," or enclose or encircle, the distance that high-frequency sounds can travel. The distance that sounds can travel is not an object that can be enclosed or encircled by vegetation. Choice D is incorrect because there is no information in the text indicating that dense vegetation can "conceal," or hide or keep from being observed, the distance that high-frequency sounds travel. Instead, the text suggests that dense vegetation reduces the distance that high-frequency sounds can travel.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 848b7a05

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 848b7a05

The fossil remains of the individual known as Oase 1, discovered in Romania in 2002, can help paleoanthropologists not only _____ steps in the evolution of hominids but also illuminate the Pleistocene epoch generally, revealing important details about the time in which Oase 1 lived.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. exploit
- B. discern
- C. prioritize
- D. yield

ID: 848b7a05 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the utility of the Oase 1 fossil to paleoanthropologists. As used in this context, "discern" means to detect or recognize something, especially something hidden or obscure. The text indicates that the Oase 1 fossil can help paleoanthropologists recognize patterns in the evolutionary process and shed light on ("illuminate") the period in which Oase 1 lived. Thus, the fossil will enable researchers to gain insights into, or discern, facts that are still not well understood.

Choice A is incorrect because in this context, "exploit" would suggest that the paleoanthropologists are using "steps in the evolution of hominids," which does not make logical sense. Rather, the text is about how the Oase 1 fossil could help paleoanthropologists learn about hominid evolution and the Pleistocene epoch more generally. Choice C is incorrect because in this context, "prioritize" would suggest that either the paleoanthropologists are placing more importance on "steps in the evolution of hominids" than they are on something else not identified in the text or that they are placing these steps in some sort of order. Rather, the text is about how the Oase 1 fossil could help paleoanthropologists learn about hominid evolution and the Pleistocene epoch more generally. Choice D is incorrect because to say that paleoanthropologists could "yield" or generate "steps in the evolution of hominids" doesn’t make sense. The researchers may develop new insights into those evolutionary steps, but they do not create those steps themselves. Rather, the context makes it clear that they are detecting or discovering patterns based on their study of the Oase 1 fossil.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID af526314

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: af526314

A study by a team including finance professor Madhu Veeraraghavan suggests that exposure to sunshine during the workday can lead to overly optimistic behavior. Using data spanning from 1994 to 2010 for a set of US companies, the team compared over 29,000 annual earnings forecasts to the actual earnings later reported by those companies. The team found that the greater the exposure to sunshine at work in the two weeks before a manager submitted an earnings forecast, the more the manager’s forecast exceeded what the company actually earned that year.

Which choice best states the function of the underlined sentence in the overall structure of the text?

- A. To summarize the results of the team’s analysis
- B. To present a specific example that illustrates the study’s findings
- C. To explain part of the methodology used in the team’s study
- D. To call out a challenge the team faced in conducting its analysis

ID: af526314 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it best describes how the underlined sentence functions in the text as a whole. The first sentence presents the implications of Veeraraghavan’s team’s study: sunshine exposure during work hours can cause overly optimistic behavior. The underlined sentence then describes the data the team consulted and how they were used (comparing predictions about earnings to what the companies actually earned), and the final sentence presents what the team found in their examination of the data. Thus, the underlined sentence mainly functions to explain part of the methodology used in the team’s study.

Choice A is incorrect because the underlined sentence explains in part how the team conducted their analysis of the effect of sunshine but doesn’t address what the team found; a broad summary is instead given in the other two sentences. Choice B is incorrect because the underlined sentence doesn’t present any specific examples from the team’s comparisons of 29,000 earnings predictions to actual earnings; it simply explains in part how the team conducted their analysis. Choice D is incorrect because the underlined sentence simply explains in part how the team conducted their analysis; the text never mentions any challenges that the team encountered in their study.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 86802789

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 86802789

Text 1

Chemically analyzing bulk rock-core samples from Australia’s Mount McRae Shale, Ariel Anbar et al. found a transient but significant increase in molybdenum (Mo) at a point corresponding to roughly 2.5 billion years ago (Ga). On Earth, Mo is released mainly through oxidative weathering of minerals; Anbar et al. therefore concluded that atmospheric oxygen briefly increased 2.5 Ga, then returned to its earlier negligible level.

Text 2

Sarah Slotznick et al. reexamined the Mount McRae Shale core. Since chemically analyzing bulk samples can occlude contextual details, Slotznick et al. also employed high-resolution microscopy, which revealed volcanic debris—a known Mo host—around 2.5 Ga and microfractures in the surrounding matrix. The researchers assert that fluid could have reached the debris through the microfractures and initiated oxidative weathering long after debris deposition.

Based on the texts, Anbar et al. (Text 1) and Slotznick et al. (Text 2) would most likely disagree about the answer to which question about the portion of the Mount McRae Shale rock-core corresponding to 2.5 Ga?

- A. Does the increase in Mo in that portion suggest that atmospheric oxygen levels were not negligible before 2.5 Ga?
- B. Is the increase in Mo in that portion indicative of an increase in atmospheric oxygen dating to the same time?
- C. Is the increase in Mo in that portion attributable to oxidative weathering of the material found in that portion?
- D. Did chemically analyzing bulk samples lead to a false impression that there is an increase in Mo in that portion?

ID: 86802789 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because Anbar et al. and Slotznick et al. would most likely disagree about whether the molybdenum (Mo) increase indicates atmospheric oxygen levels specifically at 2.5 Ga. Anbar et al. conclude that the Mo increase they found “at a point corresponding to roughly 2.5 billion years ago” means that “atmospheric oxygen briefly increased 2.5 Ga, then returned to its earlier negligible level,” directly linking the timing of the Mo increase to contemporaneous atmospheric oxygen levels. In contrast, Slotznick et al. discovered volcanic debris and microfractures in the rock core and “assert that fluid could have reached the debris through the microfractures and initiated oxidative weathering long after debris deposition.” If, as Slotznick asserts, the Mo detected at the 2.5 Ga portion could have been deposited there much later through weathering processes, then the Mo increase wouldn’t necessarily indicate atmospheric oxygen levels at 2.5 Ga specifically. Thus, Anbar et al. and Slotznick et al. disagree on whether the increase in Mo in the portion of the rock core corresponding to 2.5 Ga is indicative of an increase in atmospheric oxygen dating to the same time.

Choice A is incorrect because neither research team’s findings directly address atmospheric oxygen levels before 2.5 Ga. Anbar et al. conclude that oxygen “returned to its earlier negligible level” after 2.5 Ga, implying low pre–2.5 Ga levels, while Slotznick et al.

focus on explaining the Mo increase through later weathering processes rather than making claims about earlier atmospheric conditions. Choice C is incorrect because both research teams would likely agree that the Mo increase is attributable to oxidative weathering. Anbar et al. state that “Mo is released mainly through oxidative weathering of minerals,” and Slotznick et al. also reference “oxidative weathering” as the process that released Mo from the volcanic debris. Their disagreement concerns the timing of this weathering, not whether oxidative weathering is responsible. Choice D is incorrect because Slotznick et al. don’t suggest that bulk chemical analysis created a false impression about the presence of increased Mo. They acknowledge that the Mo increase exists but offer a different explanation for its timing and source. They critique bulk analysis for occluding “contextual details” that would require another kind of analysis to uncover, not for producing inaccurate measurements of Mo levels.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5824ff74

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 5824ff74

Text 1

Virginia Woolf’s 1928 novel *Orlando* is an oddity within her body of work. Her other major novels consist mainly of scenes of everyday life and describe their characters’ interior states in great detail, whereas *Orlando* propels itself through a series of fantastical events and considers its characters’ psychology more superficially. Woolf herself sometimes regarded the novel as a minor work, even admitting once that she “began it as a joke.”

Text 2

Like Woolf’s other great novels, *Orlando* portrays how people’s memories inform their experience of the present. Like those works, it examines how people navigate social interactions shaped by gender and social class. Though it is lighter in tone—more entertaining, even—this literary “joke” nonetheless engages seriously with the themes that motivated the four or five other novels by Woolf that have achieved the status of literary classics.

- Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the assessment of *Orlando* presented in Text 1?
- A. By conceding that Woolf’s talents were best suited to serious novels but asserting that the humor in *Orlando* is often effective
 - B. By agreeing that *Orlando* is less impressive than certain other novels by Woolf but arguing that it should still be regarded as a classic
 - C. By acknowledging that *Orlando* clearly differs from Woolf’s other major novels but insisting on its centrality to her body of work nonetheless
 - D. By concurring that the reputation of *Orlando* as a minor work has led readers to overlook this novel but maintaining that the reputation is unearned

ID: 5824ff74 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to the assessment of *Orlando* in Text 1. Both authors agree that *Orlando* is unusual for Woolf: Text 1 states that the novel examines its characters’ psychologies more superficially than Woolf’s other novels do, and Text 2 describes it as being lighter in tone. However, while Text 1 calls *Orlando* an “oddity” and mentions that Woolf “began it as a joke,” Text 2 asserts that *Orlando* engages the same themes as Woolf’s other great novels. Hence, the author of Text 2 would most likely accept that *Orlando* differs from Woolf’s other novels but would also insist on its importance in the context of Woolf’s work as a writer.

Choice A is incorrect. Text 2 does suggest that the humor in *Orlando* is effective. However, there’s nothing in Text 2 to suggest that the author would agree that Woolf’s talents were best suited to serious novels. Rather, the author of Text 2 compares *Orlando* favorably to other novels by Woolf that are implied to be darker in tone. Choice B is incorrect because the author of Text 2 does not indicate that *Orlando* is less impressive than Woolf’s other novels, but instead points out that it engages the same themes as

other novels by Woolf that are considered classics. Choice D is incorrect because there's nothing in Text 1 or Text 2 to suggest that readers have generally ignored *Orlando* because of its reputation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e8bfd2c5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: e8bfd2c5

Stephen Hannock’s luminous landscape paintings are appealing to viewers but have elicited little commentary from contemporary critics, a phenomenon that may be due to the very fact that the paintings seem so _____. Many critics focus their attention on art that is cryptic or overtly challenging.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. innovative
- B. subversive
- C. profound
- D. accessible

ID: e8bfd2c5 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. When talking about a thing, “accessible” means “easy to understand.” This sets up the contrast in the next sentence, which tells us that critics mostly focus on art that is “cryptic or challenging” (meaning not easy to understand).

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t fit the logic of the text. The next sentence tells us that critics focus on art that is mysterious and challenging. If Hannock’s paintings are “innovative” (meaning advanced and original), then critics probably would comment on them. Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t fit the logic of the text. The next sentence tells us that critics focus on art that is mysterious and challenging. If Hannock’s paintings are “subversive” (meaning disruptive and revolutionary), then critics probably would comment on them. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t fit the logic of the text. The next sentence tells us that critics focus on art that is mysterious and challenging. If Hannock’s paintings are “profound” (meaning very deep and insightful), then critics probably would comment on them.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a4361392

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: a4361392

Text 1

Despite its beautiful prose, *The Guns of August*, Barbara Tuchman’s 1962 analysis of the start of World War I, has certain weaknesses as a work of history. It fails to address events in Eastern Europe just before the outbreak of hostilities, thereby giving the impression that Germany was the war’s principal instigator. Had Tuchman consulted secondary works available to her by scholars such as Luigi Albertini, she would not have neglected the influence of events in Eastern Europe on Germany’s actions.

Text 2

Barbara Tuchman’s *The Guns of August* is an engrossing if dated introduction to World War I. Tuchman’s analysis of primary documents is laudable, but her main thesis that European powers committed themselves to a catastrophic outcome by refusing to deviate from military plans developed prior to the conflict is implausibly reductive.

- Which choice best describes a difference in how the authors of Text 1 and Text 2 view Barbara Tuchman’s *The Guns of August*?
- A. The author of Text 1 argues that Tuchman should have relied more on the work of other historians, while the author of Text 2 implies that Tuchman’s most interesting claims result from her original research.
 - B. The author of Text 1 believes that the scope of Tuchman’s research led her to an incorrect interpretation, while the author of Text 2 believes that Tuchman’s central argument is overly simplistic.
 - C. The author of Text 1 asserts that the writing style of *The Guns of August* makes it worthwhile to read despite any perceived deficiency in Tuchman’s research, while the author of Text 2 focuses exclusively on the weakness of Tuchman’s interpretation of events.
 - D. The author of Text 1 claims that Tuchman would agree that World War I was largely due to events in Eastern Europe, while the author of Text 2 maintains that Tuchman would say that Eastern European leaders were not committed to military plans in the same way that other leaders were.

ID: a4361392 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Both texts are critical of *The Guns of August*, but for different reasons: the author of Text 1 argues that Tuchman missed an important factor leading up to the war because she didn’t consult secondary sources, and the author of Text 2 argues that Tuchman’s main thesis is "reductive," which is a close synonym for "overly simplistic."

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t accurately describe the difference. This choice’s summary of Text 1 is accurate, but Text 2 never says that Tuchman’s most interesting claims result from her original research. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t accurately describe the difference. Text 1 never says that *The Guns of August* is worthwhile to read despite its research weaknesses. Text 2 does call out a weakness of Tuchman’s interpretation of events, but it also praises her analysis of primary sources. Choice D is incorrect. This doesn’t accurately describe the difference. Text 1 actually says that Tuchman "fails to address" the influence of

events in Eastern Europe, while Text 2 says that Tuchman's thesis was that European powers (not Eastern European leaders) were committed to military plans.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fe53b5ac

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: fe53b5ac

Businesses typically try to promote themselves, but research by Michael Luca, Abhishek Nagaraj, and Gauri Subramani suggests that some do not _____ their marketing. The researchers studied restaurants in Texas and found that those listed on a popular review website (which can be done at no cost) had revenue increases of 5 percent on average, but 33 percent of restaurants studied never listed on the site.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. adorn
- B. optimize
- C. endorse
- D. counteract

ID: fe53b5ac Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of business marketing practices. In this context, "optimize" means make the most effective possible use of available opportunities. The text indicates that though businesses typically try to promote themselves, they don’t always make use of effective tools for doing so, pointing to research showing that 33 percent of restaurants failed to use a free listing service that increased revenue by 5 percent on average for restaurants that did use the service. The text therefore suggests that by foregoing a free and effective marketing tool, some businesses aren’t making the best use of, or optimizing, marketing opportunities.

Choice A is incorrect because in this context, "adorn" would mean decorate or enhance the appearance of, and there’s nothing in the text to suggest that by failing to use a free and effective promotional tool, some businesses aren’t enhancing the appearance of their own marketing. The example in the text illustrates that some businesses aren’t utilizing an effective marketing opportunity, not that they aren’t improving the appearance of their marketing. Choice C is incorrect because in this context, "endorse" would mean openly approve or recommend, and the text’s discussion of the fact that some businesses have overlooked an effective marketing tool doesn’t support the idea that those businesses therefore don’t approve of their own marketing. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, saying that businesses don’t "counteract" their marketing would suggest that they don’t actively undermine it or make it ineffective. The text begins by stating that businesses typically try to promote themselves but then continues to imply that some businesses fail to take advantage of good opportunities to do so, citing the example of businesses that failed to use a free and effective marketing tool. Though it’s possible that those businesses that did use the site therefore didn’t unintentionally counteract their own marketing, the first sentence conveys that the text’s focus is on things that some businesses do and that some businesses don’t do when trying to promote themselves, and it wouldn’t make sense to say that any businesses would actively try to undermine their own marketing in pursuit of that goal.

Question ID 565161be

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 565161be

Barring major archaeological discoveries, we are unlikely to ever have _____ account of ancient Egypt under the female pharaoh Hatshepsut, as much of the evidence of her reign was deliberately destroyed by her successors.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. an imaginative
- B. a superficial
- C. an exhaustive
- D. a questionable

ID: 565161be Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of historical evidence about ancient Egypt under the reign of the pharaoh Hatshepsut. In this context, "an exhaustive" account would be a thorough one. The text states that much of the evidence from her reign was purposely destroyed—in other words, there is a lack of surviving records. This context conveys that unless there are major new archaeological discoveries, an exhaustive account of Hatshepsut’s reign is unlikely.

Choice A is incorrect because in this context, "an imaginative" account would be an account based on imagination, or ideas and speculation, rather than facts. The text indicates that much of the evidence of Hatshepsut’s reign was deliberately destroyed, and a lack of evidence actually makes it more likely that accounts will be imaginative to some degree and not strictly factual. Choice B is incorrect because in this context, "a superficial" account would be one that is lacking in depth or concerned only with what is obvious. The text indicates that most evidence of Hatshepsut’s reign was purposely destroyed, which suggests that accounts of that time are likely already somewhat superficial, since there is little information available to support deeper knowledge. Further, it would be illogical to suggest that discovering major new evidence would make it more likely that accounts would be superficial. Choice D is incorrect because "a questionable" account would be one likely to be challenged or doubted, and since the text suggests that little evidence of Hatshepsut’s reign has survived, accounts of that time probably involve some speculation and thus may already be open to doubt. Further, it would be illogical to suggest that discovering major new evidence would make it more likely that accounts would be questionable.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 212b4d86

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 212b4d86

The north celestial pole (NCP)—the fixed point around which stars in the Northern Hemisphere (including the Sun) appear to rotate—is discernible only at night. Inspired by the navigational strategies of some insects and birds, researchers devised a method for locating the NCP in daytime using skylight polarization, which occurs as atmospheric particles scatter sunlight. A polarimetric camera captures images of polarization patterns, which rotate as the Sun’s position in the sky changes; temporal variances across images can then be used to determine an observer’s latitude and bearing relative to the NCP.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It illustrates how most navigational tools utilize the NCP, recounts how researchers discovered that certain animals are able to navigate without using the NCP, and then proposes that this discovery could be used to avoid problems in navigation associated with reliance on the NCP.
- B. It presents a celestial-based method of navigation, enumerates the comparative benefits of an alternative method used by certain animals that is based on an unrelated natural occurrence, and then indicates how researchers assessed the relative accuracy of the two methods.
- C. It explains how the NCP is typically located, emphasizes a key difference between how humans and certain animals use the NCP for navigation, and then suggests an alternative way of using the NCP to improve existing navigational instruments.
- D. It notes an obstacle to observing an astronomical phenomenon, mentions a navigational ability of certain animals that inspired a solution to that obstacle, and then explains how researchers used an optical device to mimic that ability.

ID: 212b4d86 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it accurately describes the overall structure of the text. The text begins by pointing out an obstacle to observing the astronomical phenomenon of the NCP: the NCP is visible only at night. The text then indicates that, inspired by the ability of some insects and birds to navigate using visualizations of polarized sunlight, researchers devised a way to locate the NCP during daylight. The text then indicates that the researchers mimicked the insects’ and birds’ polarized-light visualization capabilities using a polarimetric camera. Thus, the text notes an obstacle to observing an astronomical phenomenon, mentions a navigational ability of certain animals that inspired a solution to that obstacle, and then explains how researchers used an optical device to mimic that ability.

Choice A is incorrect. Although it’s reasonable to conjecture that humans have used the NCP for navigation, the text doesn’t indicate this is the case, let alone that the NCP is relevant to a majority of navigational tools. Furthermore, the text doesn’t state that researchers discovered that insects and birds navigate without the NCP; rather, it indicates that it’s known that some animals navigate by using skylight polarization to locate the NCP during the day and that this knowledge inspired the method the researchers devised. Choice B is incorrect. Although it’s reasonable to conjecture that humans have used the NCP for navigation, the text doesn’t state that this is the case. Furthermore, the text discusses how some animals’ use of navigational strategies

based on the same celestial occurrence served as the inspiration for the researchers' polarized-light approach, not as the basis for a comparison of the relative effectiveness of animal and human methods of navigation. Choice C is incorrect. Although the text implies that humans have typically been able to locate the NCP visually at night and indicates that some animals use the NCP to navigate, the text doesn't state that humans use the NCP for navigation. The text therefore doesn't emphasize a difference between how humans and animals use the NCP for this purpose. Furthermore, the text doesn't suggest that existing navigational instruments will be augmented with polarimetric technologies.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 32dc2794

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 32dc2794

The subscription model in which consumers who do not deliberately cancel their subscriptions automatically pay recurring fees for access to products and services benefits retailers when consumer _____ is high. Many of the 8.5 percent of subscribers who canceled their food and beverage subscriptions in January 2022 had stopped valuing their subscriptions long before then, but sellers profited from those customers’ passivity in the interim.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. inertia
- B. decisiveness
- C. evasion
- D. turnover

ID: 32dc2794 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of when the subscription model benefits retailers. In this context, “inertia” means a tendency to remain inactive or unchanged. The text describes a subscription model in which consumers continue to pay recurring fees unless they actively cancel and indicates that retailers profit when consumers fail to cancel even after they have stopped valuing the subscription. The text reinforces this by stating that sellers profited from canceling customers’ “passivity in the interim”—that is, the period during which those customers had ceased valuing their subscriptions but had not yet acted to cancel. This context supports the idea that the model benefits retailers when consumer inertia is high—that is, when consumers tend to remain inactive rather than take action to cancel.

Choice B is incorrect because saying that the subscription model benefits retailers when consumer “decisiveness,” or quick and firm action, is high would contradict the text. The text indicates that retailers profit from consumer “passivity”—the failure to act—and decisive consumers would presumably cancel subscriptions promptly once they stopped valuing them, eliminating the retailers’ benefit. Choice C is incorrect because saying that the subscription model benefits retailers when consumer “evasion,” or active avoidance, is high wouldn’t make sense in this context. Evasion implies deliberate action to avoid something, but the text describes consumers as passive—they fail to cancel not because they actively avoid doing so but because they don’t take action at all. Choice D is incorrect because saying that the subscription model benefits retailers when consumer “turnover,” or the rate at which customers are replaced by new ones, is high would contradict the text. The text indicates that retailers profit when consumers continue paying without canceling, which means retailers benefit from retaining consumers, not from a high rate of consumer replacement.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a1911403

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: a1911403

The results of randomized clinical trials testing the efficacy of common medical interventions sometimes fail to _____ conclusions that practitioners reach based on their real-world observations of patients. While there are several possible reasons for this, one is that practitioners may overlook confounding variables that account for the results they attribute to the interventions in question.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. circumvent
- B. corroborate
- C. disseminate
- D. implement

ID: a1911403 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of a relationship between the results of randomized clinical tests of how effective common medical interventions are and the conclusions practitioners reach about such interventions in real-world settings. In this context, "corroborate" means confirm or support with evidence. The text indicates that one possible explanation for the relationship being discussed is that practitioners may overlook confounding variables—that is, additional factors other than the medical interventions being investigated that affect the observed outcomes. This means that practitioners may assume that an outcome is the direct result of a medical intervention when it is actually the result of a combination of factors. Clinical trials take steps to rule out factors other than the one being studied, so if those extra factors are actually having an effect on real-world outcomes, the trials are likely to produce conclusions different from those practitioners reach in their real-world observations. In other words, clinical trials may fail to corroborate practitioners’ conclusions.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that the results of clinical trials could "circumvent," or find a way around or bypass, conclusions practitioners reach in real-world scenarios with patients; it’s possible that researchers conducting the trials might avoid engaging with practitioners’ conclusions, but findings from a study can’t choose to get around something. Choice C is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that the results of clinical trials could "disseminate," or spread widely, conclusions practitioners reach in real-world scenarios with patients; the researchers conducting the trials might choose to draw attention to practitioners’ conclusions, but findings from a study can’t spread anything. Choice D is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that the results of clinical trials could "implement," or put into effect, conclusions practitioners reach in real-world scenarios with patients; the researchers conducting the trials might consider practitioners’ conclusions, but findings from a study can’t put anything into effect.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 62e0d018

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 62e0d018

The familial structure of the black swan (*Cygnus atratus*) shows tremendous ____: breeding pairs with demonstrated success in rearing cygnets (young swans) have been observed to foster those of less successful pairs, and while rearing by female-male pairs is most common, male-male pairs sometimes rear cygnets too, achieving a significantly higher rate of survival to adulthood than female-male pairs.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. cohesion
- B. elasticity
- C. affection
- D. reciprocity

ID: 62e0d018 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of black swan familial structures. In this context, “elasticity” means flexibility or adaptability. The text provides examples of flexible family arrangements among black swans: successful male-female breeding pairs are known to foster other pairs’ cygnets, and while they are less common, male-male pairs also successfully rear cygnets. This context therefore emphasizes the flexibility or elasticity of black swan familial structures, showing how this trait contributes to the success of the species.

Choice A is incorrect. Although close family units may show “cohesion,” which refers to unity or harmony within a group, the text’s focus is on the variety and adaptability of black swan family structures. The examples given—fostering other pairs’ cygnets and forming male-male as well as female-male pairs—highlight flexibility rather than cohesion, emphasizing family structures that vary from the model in which a breeding pair raises its own young. Choice C is incorrect. While “affection,” or fondness, might be present in black swan relationships, the text doesn’t focus on emotional bonds but rather on the structural flexibility of black swan familial arrangements. The examples provided demonstrate adaptable breeding and rearing practices rather than affectionate behaviors. Choice D is incorrect because “reciprocity” would suggest mutual exchange or cooperation between parties. Although the text mentions the fostering of cygnets by different successful breeding pairs, it doesn’t establish that this is based on reciprocal exchanges. The focus is instead on the flexibility of family structures and the effectiveness of these varied structures in rearing young.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9903c0da

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 9903c0da

Historians have argued that a crucial component of the Civil Rights Movement’s success in the 1960s was the Southern Christian Leadership Conference’s Citizen Education Program (CEP), which invited promising activists from across the South to its one-week training sessions in Dorchester, Georgia. Led by experienced organizers such as Dorothy Cotton and Septima Clark, CEP attendees—more than 7,000 in all—participated in workshops on topics ranging from public speaking to legal doctrine before returning home and using their newly acquired knowledge to spearhead local civil rights initiatives.

- Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?
- A. It underscores the extent of the CEP’s impact on the Civil Rights Movement of the 1960s.
 - B. It illustrates the CEP organizers’ efforts to educate participants on a wide variety of topics.
 - C. It suggests that CEP attendees held a diverse array of opinions about the Southern Christian Leadership Conference’s political philosophy.
 - D. It establishes that criticism of the CEP was limited to a few individuals in the Southern Christian Leadership Conference.

ID: 9903c0da Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes how the underlined portion functions in the text as a whole. The first sentence of the text states that the CEP had a positive impact on the Civil Rights Movement in the 1960s. The next sentence explains that the CEP organized workshops for attendees, who later used the knowledge they gained to lead civil rights initiatives. And the underlined portion indicates the number of activists—more than 7,000—who participated in the workshops. Thus, the underlined portion provides a number that underscores the extent of the CEP’s impact on the Civil Rights Movement in the 1960s.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the sentence that contains the underlined portion mentions some CEP workshop topics, the underlined portion itself addresses the number of participants in the CEP workshops, not the number of topics covered. Choice C is incorrect. Although the underlined portion refers to attendees of the CEP workshops, nothing in the underlined portion or the text as a whole addresses the Southern Christian Leadership Conference’s philosophy or the attendees’ opinions thereof. Choice D is incorrect because neither the underlined portion nor the text as a whole mentions any criticism of the CEP by members of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5a13e00c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 5a13e00c

Scholarly discussions of gender in Shakespeare’s comedies often celebrate the rebellion of the playwright’s characters against the rigid expectations _____ by Elizabethan society. Most of the comedies end in marriage, with characters returning to their socially dictated gender roles after previously defying them, but there are some notable exceptions.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. interjected
- B. committed
- C. illustrated
- D. prescribed

ID: 5a13e00c Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of gender roles in Shakespeare’s comedies. As used in this context, “prescribed” would mean laid down as rules. The text indicates that the characters in the comedies often defy gender roles that are “socially dictated” (even if most characters do return to those roles eventually) and that scholars have been very interested in these acts of defiance. This context indicates that what the characters are rebelling against are standards of behavior prescribed by the society of the time.

Choice A is incorrect because saying that expectations about gender were “interjected,” or suddenly inserted between other things, wouldn’t make sense in context. There’s no suggestion in the text that the issue of gender roles was inserted between other things or was an interruption in a larger discussion. Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that Shakespeare depicts characters rebelling against expectations about gender that have been “socially dictated,” not expectations that society has “committed,” or carried out, entrusted, or promised. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates that Shakespeare depicts characters rebelling against expectations about gender that have been “socially dictated,” not expectations that have been “illustrated,” or clarified with examples. Although it’s possible for expectations about gender roles to be illustrated, there’s nothing in the text to indicate that characters in Shakespeare’s comedies rebel against illustrations of gender expectations.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 765d74c4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 765d74c4

Drivers who strongly believe that the toll they must pay to use the Lewis and Clark Bridge, which spans the Ohio River to connect Indiana and Kentucky, is currently too high are unlikely to be _____ a proposal to increase the toll. Advocates for a higher toll are likely to have more success if they instead direct their arguments toward a more persuadable segment of the population.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. receptive to
- B. apprised of
- C. incensed by
- D. cited in

ID: 765d74c4 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of driver attitudes toward a toll increase. In this context, "receptive to" would mean open to or willing to consider something. The text focuses on drivers who think the current toll for the Lewis and Clark Bridge is too high, suggesting that advocates for increasing that toll would have better success presenting their arguments to "a more persuadable segment of the population" rather than to those drivers. This context suggests that the drivers who strongly believe the toll is already too high are not persuadable—that is, that they are unlikely to be willing to consider the toll-increase proposal.

Choice B is incorrect because "apprised of" means informed about or made aware of something, and nothing in the text suggests that the drivers who think a toll is already too high wouldn’t be informed of a proposal for an even higher toll; in fact, the text implies that advocates of the proposal would "direct their arguments" in favor of the increase to those drivers, even though they would likely be more successful focusing on people who are more open to hearing their arguments. Choice C is incorrect. In this context, "incensed by" would mean angered or outraged by something. The text focuses on drivers who feel that a current toll is too high, and it wouldn’t make sense to suggest that those drivers would be *unlikely* to be angered by a proposal for the toll to be increased; indeed, drivers who think the toll is already too high likely would be angered by a move to raise it even higher. Choice D is incorrect. In this context, "cited in" would mean referred to or mentioned in something. Although it’s reasonable to suggest that a proposal to raise a toll might not make any mention of drivers who think the toll is already too high, the text focuses on how those drivers and other people are likely to react to arguments in favor of the proposal, not on whether those drivers would be cited in the proposal itself.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 19ffc195

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 19ffc195

New and interesting research conducted by Suleiman A. Al-Sweedan and Moath Alhaj is inspired by their observation that though there have been many studies of the effect of high altitude on blood chemistry, there is a _____ studies of the effect on blood chemistry of living in locations below sea level, such as the California towns of Salton City and Seeley.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. quarrel about
- B. paucity of
- C. profusion of
- D. verisimilitude in

ID: 19ffc195 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically and precisely completes the text’s discussion of studies of altitude’s effect on blood chemistry. In this context, “paucity of” means lack of. In describing the inspiration behind Al-Sweedan and Alhaj’s research, the text uses the word “though” to suggest a contrasting relationship between two types of studies: those examining the effect on blood chemistry of living at a high altitude and those examining the effect on blood chemistry of living in locations below sea level. This contrasting relationship and the text’s use of the word “many” provide context suggesting that there are few, if any, examples of the second type of study, whereas there are numerous examples of the first type.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context for there to be a “quarrel about,” or open disagreement about, studies of the effect on blood chemistry of living in locations below sea level. The text’s use of the words “though” and “many” suggests a contrasting relationship in terms of amount between two types of studies: those examining the effect on blood chemistry of living at a high altitude and those examining the effect on blood chemistry of living in locations below sea level. There’s nothing in the text to suggest that the contrast between the two types of studies involves the extent to which researchers broadly agree or disagree about the contents of either type. Choice C is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context for there to be a “profusion of,” or great abundance of, studies of the effect on blood chemistry of living in locations below sea level. The text’s use of the words “though” and “many” suggests a contrasting relationship in terms of amount between two types of studies: those examining the effect on blood chemistry of living at a high altitude and those examining the effect on blood chemistry of living in locations below sea level. Rather than logically completing this contrast, “profusion of” would indicate that the two types of studies are similar in terms of amount, with many examples existing of both types. Choice D is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context for there to be a “verisimilitude in,” or appearance of truth in, studies of the effect on blood chemistry of living in locations below sea level. The text’s use of the words “though” and “many” suggests a contrasting relationship in terms of amount between two types of studies: those examining the effect on blood chemistry of living at a high altitude and those examining the effect on blood chemistry of living in locations below sea level. There’s nothing in the text to

suggest that the contrast between the two types of studies involves the extent to which either type of study presents an appearance of truth.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f213cbda

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: f213cbda

As discussed by scholar Anna Mladentseva, many artworks produced in the mid-1990s to the early 2000s exclusively for exhibition on the internet, such as Sinae Kim’s *Genesis* (2001), have become inaccessible because viewing them requires the use of _____ software (most notably Adobe Flash, discontinued in 2021).

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. defunct
- B. arcane
- C. ubiquitous
- D. extraneous

ID: f213cbda Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of artworks that were produced for exhibition on the internet. In this context, "defunct" means no longer existing or functioning. According to the text, many artworks that were produced in the mid-1990s to the early 2000s for exhibition on the internet have become inaccessible due to their reliance on certain software. As an example, the text cites Sinae Kim’s *Genesis*, which relied on software that was discontinued in 2021. This context supports the idea that the software is defunct.

Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that viewing artworks produced in the mid-1990s to the early 2000s for exhibition on the internet requires the use of software. Artists generally want their works to be seen by many people, so it wouldn’t make sense for creators of internet art to require the use of software that is "arcane," or known or knowable to only a few people. Moreover, the text states that a prominent example of software used to view these artworks is Adobe Flash, which was discontinued in 2021, meaning it’s now defunct. Choice C is incorrect because "ubiquitous" would mean found everywhere, which wouldn’t make sense in this context. The text indicates that the reason why many artworks that were produced in the mid-1990s to the early 2000s for exhibition on the internet have become inaccessible has to do with the software required for viewing them. According to the text, one example of such software is Adobe Flash, which was discontinued in 2021, meaning it’s now defunct. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that the software used to view artworks produced in the mid-1990s to the early 2000s for exhibition on the internet is "extraneous," or irrelevant. Instead, the text indicates that use of specific software is required to view certain artworks from this period and that the discontinuation of the software renders the works inaccessible.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f74ff48b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: f74ff48b

The author’s claim about the relationship between Neanderthals and *Homo sapiens* is _____, as it fails to account for several recent archaeological discoveries. To be convincing, his argument would need to address recent finds of additional hominid fossils, such as the latest Denisovan specimens and *Homo longi*.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. disorienting
- B. tenuous
- C. nuanced
- D. unoriginal

ID: f74ff48b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the author’s claim about the relationship between Neanderthals and *Homo sapiens*. As used in this context, “tenuous” means lacking substance. The end of the first sentence states that the author’s claim didn’t consider certain key pieces of evidence—“recent archaeological discoveries”—and is therefore weak.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to refer to the author’s claim as “disorienting,” or confusing. The text suggests that the author’s claim is insubstantial, not that it’s difficult to grasp. Choice C is incorrect because referring to the claim as “nuanced,” or subtle, wouldn’t make sense in context. According to the text, the claim is incomplete because it didn’t consider certain key information about recent archaeological finds; it doesn’t suggest that what’s in the claim lacks precision. Choice D is incorrect because saying that the claim is “unoriginal,” or imitative, wouldn’t make sense in context. The text faults the claim because it doesn’t consider certain key information about recent archaeological finds; it doesn’t suggest that the author’s claim lacks originality.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dce15e08

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: dce15e08

Text 1

Mycoprotein is a fungal biomass that can be eaten as an alternative to meat. Studies of the environmental impact of its manufacture generally agree it is lower than that of beef and closer to that of chicken or pork. But the expense of producing mycoprotein restricts its availability to a few countries with postindustrial economies. Knowing that cost reductions would expand access to mycoprotein, biochemists are exploring solutions, such as a cheaper substrate to feed the mycoprotein as it grows.

Text 2

Cattle farming is a principal cause of global deforestation, and a study by Florian Humpenöder and his colleagues found that replacing 20% of beef consumption worldwide with consumption of mycoprotein would cut deforestation by half if accomplished over the next thirty years. However, this would likely involve only a small change in agricultural water consumption, since water once dedicated to raising cattle would be diverted to raising crops instead.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 1 most likely respond to the study findings mentioned in Text 2?

- A. By emphasizing that since agricultural water consumption would remain static in the event of replacing beef consumption with mycoprotein consumption, an effort must be made to substitute mycoprotein for chicken and pork in diets as well
- B. By asserting that the development of a more inexpensive substrate for mycoprotein production would contribute to the goal of decreasing worldwide deforestation over time
- C. By noting that most people would be more likely to use mycoprotein as a substitute for chicken or pork in their diets than as a substitute for beef
- D. By pointing out that some countries are responsible for greater deforestation than others and thus, to have any significant effect on the environment, will have to replace more than 20% of their beef consumption with mycoprotein

ID: dce15e08 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 1 would most likely respond to the study findings described in Text 2. The author of Text 2 discusses a study by Florian Humpenöder and his colleagues that found that deforestation would be reduced by half over the next thirty years if 20% of the beef consumed worldwide were replaced with mycoprotein. The author of Text 1 points out that mycoprotein is not widely available because of its high production cost, but goes on to note that this problem could be addressed by the creation of a cheaper substrate to feed mycoprotein. This suggests that the author of Text 1 would assert that the development of a less expensive mycoprotein substrate would contribute to the reduction in deforestation described in the study findings discussed in Text 2: if reducing the cost of mycoprotein increases people’s access to it, then mycoprotein may be able to replace beef in more people’s diets, thereby reducing the deforestation associated with beef production.

Choice A is incorrect because the author of Text 1 indicates that the environmental impact of mycoprotein production is close to that of chicken or pork production, so there is no reason to think that the author would assert that replacing chicken or pork with mycoprotein would be environmentally beneficial: such a replacement would not lessen the total environmental impact of food manufacture. Additionally, the specific issue of agricultural water consumption is never mentioned in Text 1, so there is no evidence indicating what the author of Text 1 would say about that issue. Choice C is incorrect. Although Text 1 does compare the environmental effects of producing mycoprotein to those of producing chicken or pork, nothing in Text 1 suggests that the author believes that people are more likely to replace chicken or pork with mycoprotein than they are to replace beef with mycoprotein. Choice D is incorrect because Text 1 makes no mention of countries' varying contributions to deforestation, so there is no evidence that the author of Text 1 would respond to the finding described in Text 2 by saying that some countries will have to replace more than 20% of their beef consumption with mycoprotein.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 08d53726

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 08d53726

In a 2022 study, Nicolás M. Morato and colleagues attempted to resolve a long-standing paradox: although water is critical to most reactions that enable life, during the earliest stages of Earth’s history—when most of the planet’s surface was covered by oceans—the presence of water likely _____ the formation of proteins and other biomolecules that are found in all living organisms.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. reflected
- B. hampered
- C. imitated
- D. exploited

ID: 08d53726 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of a scientific paradox regarding water and life during Earth’s early history. In this context, “hampered” means hindered or impeded. The text discusses a paradox, or a situation that seems to contradict itself, and indicates that one half of the paradox is that the presence of water is necessary to support most biochemical reactions that enable life. The contradictory idea, then, would be a case of the presence of water not supporting such reactions; this context suggests that the other half of the paradox is that when oceans covered most of the planet, the water likely hindered or impeded a biochemical process (the formation of biomolecules) that is important for all living organisms.

Choice A is incorrect. In this context, “reflected” would mean showed or gave an indication. The text focuses on a paradox, or a seemingly self-contradictory situation, having to do with the role of water in supporting life; since the first part of the paradox has to do with water usually being essential for enabling life, the second part of the paradox should have to do with water having a negative effect on life, and water being an indication of a biomolecular process important for life wouldn’t be a negative thing. Choice C is incorrect. In this context, “imitated” would mean mimicked or copied, and it isn’t clear what it would mean to say that water being present on early Earth’s surface somehow copied the creation of biomolecules in living organisms. Choice D is incorrect. In this context, “exploited” would mean used or took advantage of, and it isn’t clear what it would mean to say that the presence of water—the fact of water being present—on early Earth’s surface somehow took advantage of a biomolecular process occurring in living organisms.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fd5172e7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: fd5172e7

Mineralogical differences are detectable in samples collected from two locations on the near-Earth asteroid Ryugu, but such differences may not indicate substantial compositional variations in the asteroid. Cosmochemist Kazuhide Nagashima and colleagues note that at the small scale of the samples, the distribution of minerals is unlikely to be _____.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. neglected
- B. redundant
- C. ongoing
- D. uniform

ID: fd5172e7 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The text tells us that the samples are too "small scale" to reflect the composition of the asteroid, which probably doesn't show the same variation on a large scale. This suggests that the mineral composition of the samples are unlikely to be exactly the same from sample to sample.

Choice A is incorrect. "Neglected" means "suffering a lack of proper care" or "abandoned," which doesn't work here. The text never suggests that the distribution of minerals in the samples would be neglected, so this statement doesn't logically follow. Choice B is incorrect. "Redundant" means "not or no longer useful or needed," which is too strong. The text doesn't suggest that the variation between the samples isn't a useful finding at all—just that we can't assume that the large-scale composition of the asteroid will show the same variation. But the composition of the samples might be useful for something else. Choice C is incorrect. "Ongoing" means "still in progress," which doesn't make sense: the distribution of minerals in a sample can't be "ongoing."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 212234b2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 212234b2

Text 1
Many studies in psychology have shown that people seek out information even when they know in advance that they have no immediate use for it and that they won't directly benefit from it. Such findings support the consensus view among researchers of curiosity: namely, that curiosity is not instrumental but instead represents a drive to acquire information for its own sake.

Text 2
While acknowledging that acquiring information is a powerful motivator, Rachit Dubey and colleagues ran an experiment to test whether emphasizing the usefulness of scientific information could increase curiosity about it. They found that when research involving rats and fruit flies was presented as having medical applications for humans, participants expressed greater interest in learning about it than when the research was not presented as useful.

- Based on the texts, how would Dubey and colleagues (Text 2) most likely respond to the consensus view discussed in Text 1?
- A. By suggesting that curiosity may not be exclusively motivated by the desire to merely acquire information
 - B. By conceding that people may seek out information that serves no immediate purpose only because they think they can use it later
 - C. By pointing out that it is challenging to determine when information-seeking serves no goal beyond acquiring information
 - D. By disputing the idea that curiosity can help explain apparently purposeless information-seeking behaviors

ID: 212234b2 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The researchers in Text 2 recognize that acquiring information is a powerful motivator, but showed that this motivation can still be affected by other factors, like whether or not the information is expected to be useful or not. This suggests that other desires may play a part in driving people to acquire information.

Choice B is incorrect. The consensus view in Text 1 is that people acquire information regardless of whether they think they can use it later. Dubey and colleagues acknowledge this fact (so they don't claim people seek out information "only" because it might be useful later). Choice C is incorrect. This choice misreads the results of Dubey and colleagues' study in Text 2. Neither text discusses the difficulty of determining the motivation for information-seeking. Choice D is incorrect. This choice contradicts Text 2, which starts with Dubey and colleagues "acknowledging that acquiring information is a powerful motivator" (i.e., agreeing that curiosity explains the seeking of apparently purposeless information). The research in Text 2 simply suggests that more than just curiosity can motivate information-seeking behavior when the information has a purpose.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3799ba66

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 3799ba66

As an undergraduate researcher in anthropology, Jennifer C. Chen contributed to a groundbreaking study challenging the accepted view that among prehistoric peoples, female participation in hunting was _____. The research team’s review of data from late Pleistocene and early Holocene burials in the Americas revealed that, in fact, as many as half of the hunters in those populations were female.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. inevitable
- B. satisfactory
- C. negligible
- D. commonplace

ID: 3799ba66 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the study of female participation in hunting among prehistoric peoples. In this context, “negligible” means not significant enough to be worth considering. The text says that the study challenged the accepted view of female participation in hunting among prehistoric peoples. The text goes on to say that the researchers found that “in fact, as many as half” the hunters in the groups studied were female. The phrase “in fact” establishes a contrast indicating that the finding that as many as half the hunters were female differs from the accepted view. This context suggests, then, that the accepted view is that female participation in hunting was negligible.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that the study challenged the accepted view by showing that as many as half of hunters among prehistoric peoples were female, which suggests that the accepted view is that female participation was low, not that female participation was “inevitable,” or unavoidable. Nothing in the text suggests that the accepted view is that prehistoric peoples could not avoid female participation in hunting. Choice B is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that the accepted view of female participation in hunting among prehistoric peoples is that such participation was “satisfactory,” or sufficient to meet a requirement or demand. There is no information in the text about any demands or requirements regarding female participation in hunting, let alone any information about how much female participation in hunting would be enough to satisfy those demands or requirements. Instead, the text indicates that the study challenged the accepted view by showing that as many as half the hunters in the groups studied were female, suggesting that the accepted view is that female participation in hunting was low. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that the study challenged the accepted view by showing that as many as half of hunters among the prehistoric peoples studied were female, which suggests that the accepted view is that female participation was low, not that female participation was “commonplace,” or ordinary or unremarkable. Although the study under discussion suggests that female participation may have been commonplace, that study is presented as challenging the accepted view, not as reinforcing the accepted view.

Question ID e4afc195

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: e4afc195

Text 1

Most animals can regenerate some parts of their bodies, such as skin. But when a three-banded panther worm is cut into three pieces, each piece grows into a new worm. Researchers are investigating this feat partly to learn more about humans’ comparatively limited abilities to regenerate, and they’re making exciting progress. An especially promising discovery is that both humans and panther worms have a gene for early growth response (EGR) linked to regeneration.

Text 2

When Mansi Srivastava and her team reported that panther worms, like humans, possess a gene for EGR, it caused excitement. However, as the team pointed out, the gene likely functions very differently in humans than it does in panther worms. Srivastava has likened EGR to a switch that activates other genes involved in regeneration in panther worms, but how this switch operates in humans remains unclear.

Based on the texts, what would the author of Text 2 most likely say about Text 1’s characterization of the discovery involving EGR?

- A. It is reasonable given that Srivastava and her team have identified how EGR functions in both humans and panther worms.
- B. It is overly optimistic given additional observations from Srivastava and her team.
- C. It is unexpected given that Srivastava and her team’s findings were generally met with enthusiasm.
- D. It is unfairly dismissive given the progress that Srivastava and her team have reported.

ID: e4afc195 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to Text 1 based on the information provided. Text 1 discusses the discovery of a regeneration-linked gene, EGR, in both three-banded panther worms (which are capable of full regeneration) and humans (who have relatively limited regeneration abilities). Text 1 characterizes this discovery as “especially promising” and a sign of “exciting progress” in understanding human regeneration. The author of Text 2, on the other hand, focuses on the fact that the team that reported the EGR finding pointed out that while EGR’s function in humans isn’t yet known, it’s likely very different from its function in panther worms. Therefore, the author of Text 2 would most likely say that Text 1’s enthusiasm about the EGR discovery is overly optimistic given Srivastava’s team’s observations about EGR in humans.

Choice A is incorrect because the author of Text 2 explains that Srivastava and her team explicitly reported that they haven’t yet identified how EGR functions in humans; therefore, the author of Text 2 wouldn’t say that Text 1’s excitement is reasonable for the stated reason. Instead, the author of Text 2 would likely characterize Text 1’s excitement as premature and overly optimistic. Choice C is incorrect because Text 1 does treat Srivastava’s team’s findings with enthusiasm; it describes the discovery of EGR in

both three-banded panther worms and humans as promising and exciting. It would be illogical for the author of Text 2 to say that because most others treat the discovery with enthusiasm, Text 1's enthusiastic characterization of the discovery is unexpected. Choice D is incorrect because Text 1 isn't at all dismissive of Srivastava's team's findings; instead, Text 1 is optimistic about the EGR discovery, characterizing it as promising and exciting. There's nothing in Text 2 to suggest that the author of Text 2 would say that Text 1's praise for the discovery is dismissive, or disdainful.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3bfd2264

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 3bfd2264

According to a US tax policy expert, state taxes are _____ other factors when considering an interstate move. Even significant differences in state taxation have almost no effect on most people’s decisions, while differences in employment opportunities, housing availability, and climate are strong influences.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. consistent with
- B. representative of
- C. overshadowed by
- D. irrelevant to

ID: 3bfd2264 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the factors that influence peoples’ decisions to move to a different state. As used in this context, “overshadowed by” means to be surpassed by or caused to seem less important than other factors affecting a move. The text indicates that, according to a US tax policy expert, when people think about an interstate move, state taxes have little effect on their decisions, while employment opportunities, housing availability, and climate have a very strong effect. This context suggests that people consider these other factors to be more important than state taxes.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that state taxes aren’t as important a consideration as other factors when people are thinking of moving to another state. The context doesn’t suggest that state taxes are “consistent with,” or in agreement with these other factors. Choice B is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to say that state taxes are “representative of,” or typical of, other factors. Taxes aren’t an example of employment opportunities, housing availability, and climate, which are the other factors listed in the text. Choice D is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to say that state taxes are “irrelevant to,” or unconnected or unimportant to other factors. State taxes are irrelevant to peoples’ decisions, not to other factors. In other words, although the text suggests that state taxes may be irrelevant to people considering a move to another state, the other factors mentioned in the text, such as employment opportunities, are unable to have an opinion about state taxes. Furthermore, the text indicates that significant differences in state taxes have almost no effect on peoples’ choices to move, but they aren’t completely unimportant.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID af7873e0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: af7873e0

Some scientists have suggested that mammals in the Mesozoic era were not a very _____ group, but paleontologist Zhe-Xi Luo’s research suggests that early mammals living in the shadow of dinosaurs weren’t all ground-dwelling insectivores. Fossils of various plant-eating mammals have been found in China, including species like *Vilevolodon diplomylos*, which Luo says could glide like a flying squirrel.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. predatory
- B. obscure
- C. diverse
- D. localized

ID: af7873e0 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the kinds of mammals alive during the Mesozoic era. As used in this context, “diverse” means to have a significant amount of variety. The text indicates that some scientists have suggested that Mesozoic mammals can’t be characterized in a certain way, then contrasts the view put forward by those scientists with Luo’s research, which shows that Mesozoic mammals “weren’t all ground-dwelling insectivores” and instead were “various.” This context suggests that some scientists have viewed Mesozoic mammals as being all alike, or not a very diverse group.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that some scientists have suggested that Mesozoic mammals weren’t very “predatory,” or that they didn’t prey on other animals, since the text establishes a contrast between what some scientists have suggested and Luo’s research showing that Mesozoic mammals “weren’t all ground-dwelling insectivores.” This context suggests that some scientists have regarded Mesozoic mammals as all being insectivores, or animals that prey on insects, not that some scientists have suggested that Mesozoic mammals didn’t prey on other animals. Choice B is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that some scientists have suggested that Mesozoic mammals weren’t very “obscure,” or concealed or not well known, since the text establishes a contrast between what some scientists have suggested and Luo’s research showing that Mesozoic mammals were a varied group. There’s no contrast between saying that the mammals weren’t concealed or well known and the mammals being varied. Choice D is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that some scientists have suggested that Mesozoic mammals weren’t very “localized,” or confined to a particular area, since the text establishes a contrast between what some scientists have suggested and Luo’s research showing that Mesozoic mammals were a varied group. There’s no contrast between saying that the mammals weren’t localized and the mammals being varied. Although the text mentions mammal fossils found in China, nothing in the discussion of Luo’s research addresses the limits of Mesozoic mammal habitats.

Question ID 6e3565a1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 6e3565a1

Text 1

Literary scholars have struggled with the vastness of Nigerian writer Wole Soyinka’s collective works of drama (spanning over 20 plays in total). It is best, however, to understand Soyinka’s body of work as a dramatist chronologically. Soyinka’s progression as a playwright can be considered to fall into three periods, with each one representing a particular thematic and stylistic cohesion: the 1960s, the two decades between 1970 and 1990, and lastly, from roughly 1990 onwards.

Text 2

It is tempting to impose a linear sense of order on the expanse of Wole Soyinka’s body of work as a dramatist. However, critics who have considered Soyinka’s plays to fit neatly into three phases overlook potential commonalities in Soyinka’s work that span across these phases. Additionally, this view may discount significant differences in the styles and content of plays written around the same time.

Which choice best describes a difference in how the author of Text 1 and the author of Text 2 view the study of Soyinka’s works of drama?

- A. While the author of Text 1 believes that thinking about Soyinka’s works of theater in phases is useful, the author of Text 2 views such an approach as limiting.
- B. Although the author of Text 1 claims that Soyinka’s style as a dramatist has evolved over time, the author of Text 2 argues that Soyinka’s style has remained consistent throughout his career.
- C. The author of Text 1 considers Soyinka’s plays to showcase his strongest writing, whereas the author of Text 2 believes that Soyinka’s poetry is where he is most skilled.
- D. The author of Text 1 argues that Soyinka’s early plays were his most politically charged, whereas the author of Text 2 claims that Soyinka’s most recent plays are the most politicized.

ID: 6e3565a1 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The author of Text 1 states that Soyinka’s progression as a playwright can be considered to fall into three periods, implying that this is a helpful way to understand his works. The author of Text 2, on the other hand, challenges this view and says that it overlooks potential commonalities and differences in Soyinka’s work across what Text 1 calls distinctive stylistic phases.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice overstates the central claim of Text 2. The author of Text 2 argues against the chronological progression supported in Text 1, but does not go so far as to say that Soyinka’s style remained consistent. In fact, Text 2 points out “significant differences in styles and content” among Soyinka’s plays. Choice C is incorrect. Neither of the texts mention

Soyinka's poetry, nor do they rank his dramatic writing relative to his other work. Choice D is incorrect. Neither text discusses the political aspects of Soyinka's plays, nor do they make any claims about whether they have changed over time.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 58397fed

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 58397fed

On painter William H. Johnson’s return to the United States in 1938 after a decade in Europe, his style underwent an abrupt transformation. Turning away from landscapes painted in an expressionist style—a style that often involves using fluid, distorted shapes and thick, textured brushstrokes to express the artist’s subjective experience of reality—Johnson began painting portraits of Black Americans in a bold new way. Evocative of African sculpture and American and Scandinavian folk art, these portraits feature flat, deliberately oversimplified figures in a vibrant but limited color palette.

- Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?
- A. It elaborates on the previous sentence’s statement about a transitional moment in Johnson’s artistic career.
 - B. It provides information about Johnson’s travels in support of a claim about his artistic influences, which is advanced in the following sentence.
 - C. It recounts a moment in Johnson’s personal life that enabled the success of his subsequent career, which is summarized in the following sentence.
 - D. It presents evidence that calls into question the previous sentence’s characterization of Johnson’s artistic development.

ID: 58397fed Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole. The first sentence of the text indicates that Johnson returned to the US in 1938 at which time his painting style suddenly changed. The second sentence is underlined and gives more detail about this stylistic change, noting that his earlier work consisted largely of landscapes in an expressionist style and his new works were highly stylized portraits of Black Americans. In other words, the function of the underlined sentence is to elaborate on a transitional moment in Johnson’s painting career.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the text does mention that Johnson spent a decade in Europe, it does not discuss what other travel Johnson might have done. Furthermore, although the text mentions African, American, and Scandinavian artistic elements in Johnson’s work, it does not indicate that he traveled to different locations to learn about these practices. Choice C is incorrect because the text does not focus on Johnson’s personal life nor does it address how successful his career was in general. Choice D is incorrect because, rather than call it into question, the underlined sentence continues the discussion of Johnson’s career by adding further relevant detail of Johnson’s artistic transformation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 771b44ba

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 771b44ba

The following text is from Rachel Heng’s 2023 novel *The Great Reclamation*. Ah Boon is fishing off the coast of Singapore.

When he pulled up the nets, they contained only one kind of fish—black pomfrets, the flat diamonds of their bodies slick in the morning light. This uniformity did not surprise him; over the years, he’d learned that the waters here were temperamental. They could be relied upon for a good catch, but from time to time threw up only prawns or squid, and other times colorful varieties of fish that weren’t even supposed to be found in this region. He’d grown to accept the unpredictability, embracing it as a game to be played, like the reading of tea leaves or the grooves of a palm.

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Taken together, the three underlined portions most clearly serve which function in the text as a whole?

- A. They provide examples of what Ah Boon most frequently catches in the area.
- B. They illustrate the changeable nature of the fishing grounds where Ah Boon is.
- C. They emphasize the wide variety of sea creatures that Ah Boon has caught on this particular fishing trip.
- D. They underscore Ah Boon’s lack of surprise at seeing sea creatures that aren’t usually found in the region.

ID: 771b44ba Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most accurately describes the function that the three underlined portions serve in the text as a whole. The text states that Ah Boon’s nets contained only one kind of fish and explains that he is unsurprised because the waters are “temperamental.” The three underlined portions name different types of catch yielded by the waters on different occasions, demonstrating how the catch varies unpredictably. Thus, taken together, the three underlined portions illustrate the changeable nature of the waters where Ah Boon fishes.

Choice A is incorrect because the text does not indicate which types of catch are most frequent; it describes the waters as unpredictable and varying over time. Instead of illustrating frequency, the underlined portions that mention different kinds of sea creatures illustrate variability. Choice C is incorrect because the text states that on this particular trip, Ah Boon caught only one kind of fish—black pomfrets. The other two underlined portions refer to catches from other occasions, not from the present trip. Instead of emphasizing variety on one trip, the underlined portions illustrate the unpredictability of the waters over time. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text notes that Ah Boon is unsurprised by his catch of black pomfrets, only one of the three underlined portions—“colorful varieties of fish”—refers to creatures not usually found in the region. The underlined portions collectively convey the range of what Ah Boon has caught while fishing in the waters, illustrating their changeable nature rather than underscoring Ah Boon’s emotional response.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a828070d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: a828070d

Yanzhe Fu et al. suggest that the extinct aquatic insect *Karataviella popovi* utilized a brood care strategy that mitigated the risk of oxygen deficiency. This determination rests on the researchers’ analysis of fossils uncovered at a particularly _____ site: China’s Haifanggou Formation, which has yielded a vast diversity of fossils, including those of long-proboscid scorpionflies.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. fruitful
- B. unassailable
- C. obscure
- D. quantified

ID: a828070d Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the fossil site from which the evidence about brood care in *K. popovi* was recovered. In this context, “fruitful” means abundantly productive. The text indicates that the researchers drew their evidence from fossils found in China’s Haifanggou Formation, a location that has yielded a vast diversity of fossils. The information about the site yielding a vast diversity of fossils supports the characterization of the Haifanggou Formation as particularly productive, or fruitful.

Choice B is incorrect because there is nothing in the text to support characterizing the Haifanggou Formation as a site that is particularly “unassailable,” or not open to attack, question, or criticism. The text emphasizes that the site has yielded a vast diversity of fossils, suggesting that it is a particularly productive location for fossil hunters, not that it cannot be challenged. Choice C is incorrect because there is nothing in the text to support characterizing the Haifanggou Formation as a site that is particularly “obscure,” or poorly understood or relatively unknown. In fact, the text notes that the Haifanggou Formation has yielded a vast diversity of fossils, suggesting that the site is not an obscure one. Choice D is incorrect because “quantified” means expressed or measured as a quantity, which does not describe the productiveness the context calls for. Although the text indicates that the Haifanggou Formation has yielded a vast diversity of fossils, that fact suggests that the site can be characterized as particularly productive, not as particularly quantified.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1b937810

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 1b937810

In response to concerns that some recent financial crises were exacerbated by consumers misunderstanding risks associated with credit cards, loans, and other financial products, policymakers in many countries have instituted risk-disclosure requirements on sellers of those products. Enrique Seira et al. investigated a variety of risk-disclosure messages sent to thousands of credit card customers and found that the messages had only small and short-lived effects on behavior. Seira et al. asserted that such effects may nevertheless be worth pursuing, given the negligible cost of messaging.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. It notes a factor that led Seira et al. to not dismiss risk-disclosure messaging altogether despite their evidence of its limited utility.
- B. It acknowledges a type of risk-disclosure messaging that Seira et al. may not have fully accounted for in their study.
- C. It describes a consideration that explains why Seira et al. recommended risk-disclosure messaging even though its effects may be small relative to its costs.
- D. It points out a circumstance that Seira et al. conceded may make risk-disclosure messaging more effective than their study suggests.

ID: 1b937810 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole. The text establishes that many countries have adopted risk-disclosure requirements for financial products due to concerns that consumers don't understand the risks associated with the products. According to the text, Seira et al. found that the effects of such messaging on consumer behavior were small and temporary. The text then adds that the researchers assert that because the cost of the messaging is negligible, the approach may be worth doing even if the effects are limited. Thus, the underlined portion notes a factor—very low cost—that led the researchers to not completely dismiss risk-disclosure messaging despite their evidence of its limited utility.

Choice B is incorrect because the underlined portion doesn't refer to a particular type of risk-disclosure messaging, whether Seira et al. considered it or not; the underlined portion simply indicates that the cost of the messaging (broadly) is very low, which makes the approach worth pursuing even if its effects are limited. Choice C is incorrect. Although the underlined portion does describe a consideration that led the researchers to recommend risk-disclosure messaging despite the messaging's small effects on consumer behavior, it directly states that the cost of such messaging is negligible, or very low—meaning that both the effects and the costs are small, not that the effects are small only relative to the costs. Choice D is incorrect because there's no indication that Seira et al. suggest that risk-disclosure messaging could be more effective if it had lower costs; rather, the underlined portion indicates that Seira et al. believe the already negligible cost of messaging makes the approach worth pursuing even if its effects are limited.

Question ID e0487fbc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: e0487fbc

“How lifelike are they?” Many computer animators prioritize this question as they strive to create ever more realistic environments and lighting. Generally, while characters in computer-animated films appear highly exaggerated, environments and lighting are carefully engineered to mimic reality. But some animators, such as Pixar’s Sanjay Patel, are focused on a different question. Rather than asking first whether the environments and lighting they’re creating are convincingly lifelike, Patel and others are asking whether these elements reflect their films’ unique stories.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined question in the text as a whole?

- A. It reflects a primary goal that many computer animators have for certain components of the animations they produce.
- B. It represents a concern of computer animators who are more interested in creating unique backgrounds and lighting effects than realistic ones.
- C. It conveys the uncertainty among many computer animators about how to create realistic animations using current technology.
- D. It illustrates a reaction that audiences typically have to the appearance of characters created by computer animators.

ID: e0487fbc Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes the function of the underlined question in the text as a whole. The text begins with the underlined question, “How lifelike are they?” The text then explains that many computer animators pose this question about the environments and lighting that they create for animated films, striving for realistic animation of those components even if the characters themselves aren’t portrayed in realistic terms. The focus of the text then shifts to describe how some animators strive to create environments and lighting that reflect the film’s unique stories rather than making them appear realistic. Therefore, the function of the underlined question is to reflect a primary goal that many computer animators have for certain components of the animations they produce.

Choice B is incorrect because, as the text makes clear, the underlined question is one posed by computer animators who wish to create realistic backgrounds and lighting effects, not by those who, instead, wish to create effects that reflect films’ unique stories and aren’t necessarily realistic; this latter group of animators is discussed later in the text. Choice C is incorrect. As the text explains, many computer animators strive for realistic environments and lighting, while others do not; this difference of approach relates to whether these components should be realistic, not to how realism can be achieved using current technology, and the text never suggests that animators are uncertain how to achieve it. Choice D is incorrect because the underlined question pertains to the perspective of computer animators, not the audience, and the text never considers audience’s reactions to characters in animated films.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 40f40503

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 40f40503

The following text is adapted from Herman Melville’s 1855 novel *Israel Potter*. Israel is a young man wandering through New England during the late eighteenth century.

He hired himself out for three months; at the end of that time to receive for his wages two hundred acres of land lying in New Hampshire. [...] His employer proving false to the contract in the matter of the land, and there being no law in the country to force him to fulfil it, Israel—who, however brave-hearted, and even much of a dare-devil upon a pinch, seems nevertheless to have evinced, throughout many parts of his career, a singular patience and mildness—was obliged to look round for other means of livelihood than clearing out a farm for himself in the wilderness.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. It implies that Israel treasures a particular characteristic of his personality when that characteristic should usually be regarded as a flaw.
- B. It suggests that if not for a certain aspect of his character, Israel might not have been as easily thwarted in his ambition to establish a farm.
- C. It shows why Israel would not have been able to undertake the enormous amount of labor necessary to run a farm even if he had owned the necessary property.
- D. It explains why, when the situation requires it, Israel is able to undertake courageous acts that others would generally avoid.

ID: 40f40503 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole. The text describes the failed attempt of Israel Potter to establish a farm in New England during the late eighteenth century: according to his contract, he was to receive two hundred acres in exchange for three months’ work, but his employer then refused to fulfill the bargain and Israel had no recourse to law to obtain the land he was owed. Israel was therefore forced to find another means of supporting himself. To explain why Israel was particularly susceptible to his employer’s dishonesty, the underlined portion states that though Israel was "brave-hearted, and even much of a dare-devil upon a pinch," he also possessed "a singular patience and mildness." In other words, Israel could be courageous in certain circumstances, but he was usually meek and disinclined to argument, from which it is reasonable to infer that Israel was often taken advantage of. Thus, the underlined portion suggests that if not for a certain aspect of his character, Israel might not have been as easily thwarted in his ambition to establish a farm.

Choice A is incorrect because although the underlined portion describes aspects of Israel’s personality, it does not address how he feels about his own personality. Choice C is incorrect because the underlined portion addresses Israel’s occasional courage and frequent meekness but does not address whether he would have the skills and resolve necessary to operate a farm if he owned sufficient property. Choice D is incorrect. Though the underlined portion does indicate that Israel could be courageous in certain circumstances, it does not say that he undertook acts of courage that others avoided, but rather that he was habitually

meek. Even if the underlined portion did say that Israel was more courageous than most, this would not explain why he found himself under the circumstances described in the text—that is, as a consequence of his meek nature, cheated of the property to which he had a right.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8f784550

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 8f784550

The following text is from a 1955 translation of Samuel Beckett’s 1951 novel *Molloy* (translated by the author and Patrick Bowles). In the text, Molloy has arrived at the town ramparts, an elevated walkway atop the city walls.

And having cleared the ramparts I had to confess the sky was clearing, prior to its winding in the other shroud, night. Yes, the great cloud was ravelling, discovering here and there a pale and dying sky, and the sun, already down, was manifest in the livid tongues of fire darting towards the zenith, falling and darting again, ever more pale and languid, and doomed no sooner lit to be extinguished.

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As used in the text, what does the word “manifest” most nearly mean?

- A. Realized
- B. Perceptible
- C. Situated
- D. Dwindling

ID: 8f784550 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because as used in the text, “manifest” most nearly means perceptible or detectable. The text indicates that the sun was “already down,” meaning it was below the horizon and not directly visible. However, the sun’s presence was nonetheless perceptible or manifest in the “tongues of fire” (or beams of light) that still flickered in the darkening sky.

Choice A is incorrect. Although in some contexts “manifest” can mean “realized” or “brought into being,” that is not the context here. Rather, the text is about how the sun’s presence was perceptible or manifest in the “darting” beams of light that could still be seen in the sky. Choice C is incorrect. This choice would suggest that the sun is situated, or located, in the light it emits, which is not supported by the surrounding context. Rather, the text is about how the sun’s presence was perceptible or manifest in the remaining light that could still be seen in the sky. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text is about the decreasing light in the scene at sunset, the text’s use of “manifest” is about how the sun’s presence was nonetheless perceptible or manifest in the “tongues of fire” still visible in the sky as night approached.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 731d15d8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 731d15d8

Text 1

Dominique Potvin and colleagues captured five Australian magpies (*Gymnorhina tibicen*) to test a new design for attaching tracking devices to birds. As the researchers fitted each magpie with a tracker attached by a small harness, they noticed some magpies without trackers pecking at another magpie’s tracker until it broke off. The researchers suggest that this behavior could be evidence of magpies attempting to help another magpie without benefiting themselves.

Text 2

It can be tempting to think that animals are deliberately providing help when we see them removing trackers and other equipment from one another, especially when a species is known to exhibit other cooperative behaviors. At the same time, it can be difficult to exclude the possibility that individuals are simply interested in the equipment because of its novelty, curiously pawing or pecking at it until it detaches.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely respond to the researchers’ perspective in Text 1 on the behavior of the magpies without trackers?

- A. That behavior might have been due to the novelty of the magpies’ captive setting rather than to the novelty of the tracker.
- B. That behavior likely indicates that the magpies were deliberately attempting to benefit themselves by obtaining the tracker.
- C. That behavior may not be evidence of selflessness in *Gymnorhina tibicen* because not all the captured magpies demonstrated it.
- D. That behavior might be adequately explained without suggesting that the magpies were attempting to assist the other magpie.

ID: 731d15d8 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it reflects how the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to the researchers’ perspective in Text 1 on the behavior of the magpies without trackers. According to Text 1, Dominique Potvin and colleagues observed magpies without trackers pecking at a tracker on another magpie until the device fell off. The researchers suggested that the birds might have been attempting to help the other bird, with no benefit to themselves. Text 2 generally discusses scenarios in which animals have been observed removing trackers from each other. The text cautions that it shouldn’t be assumed that these animals are helping one another deliberately, since they might simply be pecking at trackers out of curiosity, causing them to fall off eventually. Therefore, the author of Text 2 would most likely respond to Potvin and colleagues’ perspective in Text 1 by saying that the behavior of the magpies without trackers could be adequately explained without suggesting that they were attempting to assist the other magpie.

Choice A is incorrect because Text 2 never discusses the novelty, or the newness and unusual quality, of the captive settings in which animals have been observed to remove trackers from other animals, nor does it suggest that such novelty might account for this behavior. Instead, the text suggests that it's the novelty of the tracking equipment itself that might cause the behavior: interested in the trackers because they're unusual, animals might paw or peck at them until they fall off. Choice B is incorrect because Text 2 never suggests that when animals remove trackers from other animals, they do so because they wish to obtain the trackers for themselves. Instead, Text 2 argues that animals paw or peck at trackers because they are merely curious about them. Choice C is incorrect because Text 2 doesn't argue that when captured animals are observed removing trackers from each other, their behavior should be regarded as selfless only if all of them participate in it. Instead, the text argues that the behavior may not be selfless at all and may instead be attributed to animals' curiosity about the new and unusual trackers.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bb64a176

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: bb64a176

People sometimes dismiss a claim if it comes from a source they regard as self-interested, but from a strictly logical perspective, the source of a claim is ____: it has no direct bearing on whether the claim is true.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. indistinct
- B. irrelevant
- C. indisputable
- D. implicit

ID: bb64a176 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion about people’s tendency to dismiss claims from sources perceived as self-interested, or acting for their own advantage. In this context, "irrelevant" means not applicable to the matter at hand. The text explains that as a matter of logical reasoning, the source of a claim has nothing to do with the claim’s truthfulness—a claim is either true or false in actuality, regardless of where it originates. This context suggests that even though people may distrust a claim based on its source, the source of the claim is actually irrelevant.

Choice A is incorrect because in this context, "indistinct" would mean uncertain or not clearly recognizable. Instead of suggesting that the source of a claim can’t be determined with certainty, the text suggests that recognizing a source and having an opinion of it simply doesn’t matter because as a matter of logic, a claim is true or false in actuality, regardless of where it originates. Choice C is incorrect because in this context, "indisputable" would mean impossible to question or deny. Although the text suggests that it isn’t logical to assume a claim is false just because its source appears to be self-interested, it doesn’t go so far as to suggest that the source of a claim can’t be questioned—the text instead makes the point that from a logical standpoint, the source of a claim doesn’t matter because the claim is either true or false in and of itself. Choice D is incorrect because in this context, "implicit" would mean suggested or understood without being directly expressed. Nothing in the text suggests that logically, the source of a claim is only suggested; instead of addressing whether sources can be directly identified, the text focuses on the idea that sources don’t matter because a claim is true or false in actuality, regardless of where it originates.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID Obf83692

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: Obf83692

Studying late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century artifacts from an agricultural and domestic site in Texas, archaeologist Ayana O. Flewellen found that Black women employed as farm workers utilized hook-and-eye closures to fasten their clothes at the waist, giving themselves a silhouette similar to the one that was popular in contemporary fashion and typically achieved through more restrictive garments such as corsets. Flewellen argues that this sartorial practice shows that these women balanced hegemonic ideals of femininity with the requirements of their physically demanding occupation.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To describe an unexpected discovery that altered a researcher’s view of how rapidly fashions among Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas changed during the period
- B. To discuss research that investigated the ways in which Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas used fashion practices to resist traditional gender ideals
- C. To evaluate a scholarly work that offers explanations for the impact of urban fashion ideals on Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas
- D. To summarize the findings of a study that explored factors influencing a fashion practice among Black female farmworkers in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century Texas

ID: Obf83692 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The text provides an overview of a scholarly work discussing the fashion practices of Black female farmworkers in late 19th- and early 20th-century Texas, and how these practices were influenced by both the fashion ideals of the time and the demands of farmwork.

Choice A is incorrect. The text never discusses the rate of fashion change among Black female farmworkers. The text also never categorizes Flewellen’s findings as "unexpected." Choice B is incorrect. The text actually explains that Black female farmworkers were trying to achieve traditional feminine ideals, not resist them. Choice C is incorrect. The text doesn’t evaluate a scholarly work but rather simply describes it. Furthermore, the text is focused on "agricultural and domestic" fashion, not urban fashion as this choice suggests.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3826835a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 3826835a

Text 1

Many teleost fish species are protogynous, meaning that fertile females can become fertile males. One model holds that protogyny occurs when body size confers a greater reproductive advantage on males than on females. In teleost fish, body size is irrelevant to female reproduction, but among males (which tend to be larger than females), only individuals comparatively large enough to defend territory reproduce. An individual could thus maximize its lifetime reproductive success by staying female when small and becoming male upon reaching a critical size threshold.

Text 2

Investigating protogyny in teleost fish, Alexander Goikoetxea and colleagues placed captured spotty wrasses of typical size distributions into two mixed-sex tanks. During the breeding season, they removed all males from tank 1 but none from tank 2. They observed that sexual change began in 81 percent of females in tank 1 but in no females in tank 2.

Based on the texts, which choice best explains the difference in the outcomes of the two tanks in Goikoetxea and colleagues' experiment (Text 2) using the model presented in Text 1?

- A.

Once the males were removed from tank 1, territories in the tank were undefended and thus even small females could maximize their reproductive success by becoming male and taking over those territories, whereas only the largest females in tank 2 could successfully take over territories due to the ongoing presence of males in the tank.
- B.

With no males left in tank 1, females were potentially large enough to defend territory as males and thus could gain an advantage by becoming male at their current size, whereas females in tank 2 may not have been large enough to outcompete the males in the tank and thus would have greater reproductive success by remaining female.
- C.

Differences in body size among the females in tank 1 became irrelevant to reproductive success once the males were removed, thereby eliminating any advantage to becoming male, whereas the ongoing presence of males in tank 2 made differences in body size among the females in that tank relevant to their reproductive success.
- D.

Since all males were removed from tank 1, the females in the tank could not reproduce regardless of their size and thus some became male, whereas the presence of males in tank 2 meant that females in that tank could reproduce without first becoming male and thus they remained female.

ID: 3826835a Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it correctly applies the model presented in Text 1 to explain the different outcomes in the two tanks described in Text 2. Text 1 begins by explaining that fertile female teleost fish will sometimes become fertile males through protogyny. The model, or explanation, of protogyny advanced in Text 1 holds that among female teleost fish, size doesn't confer any reproductive advantage, but among male teleost fish, "only individuals comparatively large enough to defend territory reproduce"—in other words, there is a direct relationship between relative body size and reproductive success, but only among

male fish. Text 1 concludes by saying that, according to this model, individuals can maximize their reproductive success by “staying female when small” (when size has no relevance to reproduction) and only becoming male when they reach a certain size threshold by becoming large enough relative to other male fish to be able to defend territory. In sum, according to the model, whether protogyny is advantageous depends on a female’s body size relative to the males currently present. Text 2 describes an experiment in which fish of “typical size distributions” (meaning, size distributions consistent with Text 1’s note about the tendency of males to be larger than females) were placed in two tanks. Applying Text 1’s model, once the males (that is, the typically larger fish) were removed from tank 1, the remaining females would no longer be at a size disadvantage and could potentially defend territory as males at their current size, making sex change advantageous for some of the fish in tank 1. This would therefore explain the finding that 81 percent of female fish began changing into males. In tank 2, however, the continued presence of larger males meant that on average, females would not be large enough to outcompete the males for territory and would therefore have greater reproductive success by remaining female. In this way, the size-advantage model presented in Text 1 would also account for why no fish changed sex in tank 2.

Choice A is incorrect because it claims that “even small females” could succeed as males once territories were undefended, contradicting Text 1’s emphasis on there being a “critical size threshold” for male reproductive success, wherein only male fish who were sufficiently large to defend territory would have a reproductive advantage. Under this model, small females would have more reproductive success by remaining female than by becoming male and being unable to compete with larger fish for territory. Additionally, this choice’s claim about tank 2—that “only the largest females” could take over territories—implies either that females defend territory (when the model in Text 1 makes no such claim) or that at least some females were sufficiently large to change sex and compete for territory with fish that began the experiment as males, yet the results show that no females in tank 2 did so. Choice C is incorrect. Not only is it based on a flawed understanding of the model presented in Text 1, it flatly contradicts the experimental results summarized in Text 2. While Text 1 clearly states that body size is irrelevant to female reproductive success, choice C states that the presence of males in tank 2 made differences in body size relevant to the females’ reproductive success. This choice also claims that the removal of males from tank 1 eliminated any advantage to becoming male, yet the researchers reported that 81 percent of females in tank 1 began changing sex. Choice D is incorrect because it doesn’t use the model proposed in Text 1 to explain the findings described in Text 2. It is common sense that a certain number of male fish are required for reproduction to occur in tank 1, but the model presented by Text 1 focuses on the individual reproductive benefits of protogyny, not on its potential to benefit the population by maintaining a favorable sex ratio.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6577e51c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 6577e51c

Text 1

Conventional wisdom long held that human social systems evolved in stages, beginning with hunter-gatherers forming small bands of members with roughly equal status. The shift to agriculture about 12,000 years ago sparked population growth that led to the emergence of groups with hierarchical structures: associations of clans first, then chiefdoms, and finally, bureaucratic states.

Text 2

In a 2021 book, anthropologist David Graeber and archaeologist David Wengrow maintain that humans have always been socially flexible, alternately forming systems based on hierarchy and collective ones with decentralized leadership. The authors point to evidence that as far back as 50,000 years ago some hunter-gatherers adjusted their social structures seasonally, at times dispersing in small groups but also assembling into communities that included esteemed individuals.

Based on the texts, how would Graeber and Wengrow (Text 2) most likely respond to the “conventional wisdom” presented in Text 1?

- A. By conceding the importance of hierarchical systems but asserting the greater significance of decentralized collective societies
- B. By disputing the idea that developments in social structures have followed a linear progression through distinct stages
- C. By acknowledging that hierarchical roles likely weren’t a part of social systems before the rise of agriculture
- D. By challenging the assumption that groupings of hunter-gatherers were among the earliest forms of social structure

ID: 6577e51c Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it describes the most likely way that Graeber and Wengrow (Text 2) would respond to the “conventional wisdom” presented in Text 1. According to Text 1, the conventional wisdom about human social systems is that they developed through stages, beginning with hunter-gatherer bands, then moving to clan associations, then chiefdoms, and finally arriving at states with bureaucratic structures. Text 2 indicates that Graeber and Wengrow believe that human social systems have been flexible, shifting between different types of structures, including both hierarchical and collective systems, and that these shifts may have even occurred seasonally. This suggests that Graeber and Wengrow would dispute the idea that developments in social structures have followed a linear progression through distinct stages.

Choice A is incorrect because nothing in Text 2 suggests that Graeber and Wengrow believe that decentralized collective societies are more significant than hierarchical systems. Text 2 is focused on Graeber and Wengrow’s view that humans have flexibly shifted among various social structures, not on the importance of particular structures relative to others. Choice C is incorrect

because Text 2 doesn't include any information suggesting that Graeber and Wengrow believe that hierarchies didn't emerge until after the rise of agriculture. In fact, Text 2 indicates that Graeber and Wengrow cite evidence suggesting that some hunter-gatherer groups formed social structures with hierarchical elements ("communities that included esteemed individuals") 50,000 years ago, long before the rise of agriculture, which Text 1 says occurred around 12,000 years ago. Choice D is incorrect because there's no information in Text 2 suggesting that Graeber and Wengrow would challenge the assumption that groupings of hunter-gatherers were among the earliest forms of social structure. Although Text 1 does indicate that hunter-gatherer groups are assumed to be the earliest human social system, Text 2 says only that Graeber and Wengrow believe that some hunter-gatherer groups made use of different social structures at different times. Text 2 doesn't imply that Graeber and Wengrow doubt that hunter-gatherer groups preceded most other social structures.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a2a55753

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: a2a55753

Text 1

American sculptor Edmonia Lewis is best known for her sculptures that represent figures from history and mythology, such as *The Death of Cleopatra* and *Hagar*. Although Lewis sculpted other subjects, her career as a sculptor is best represented by the works in which she depicted these historical and mythical themes.

Text 2

Art historians have typically ignored the many portrait busts Edmonia Lewis created. Lewis likely carved these busts (sculptures of a person’s head) frequently throughout her long career. She is known for her sculptures that represent historical figures, but Lewis likely supported herself financially by carving portrait busts for acquaintances who paid her to represent their features. Thus, Lewis’s portrait busts are a central aspect of her career as a sculptor.

Based on the texts, both authors would most likely agree with which statement?

- A. Lewis’s portrait busts have overshadowed her other work.
- B. *The Death of Cleopatra* is Lewis’s most famous piece.
- C. Sculpting representations of historical figures was a short-lived trend.
- D. Lewis’s works are varied in the subjects they depict.

ID: a2a55753 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Author 1 acknowledges that Lewis sculpted other subjects besides historical and mythical figures, suggesting a variety of subjects depicted. Author 2 mentions that Lewis carved portrait busts as well as historical sculptures, which also implies variation among Lewis’s subjects.

Choice A is incorrect. Neither text suggests that Lewis’s portrait busts have received more attention or appreciation than her other work. Author 1 briefly mentions her “other works,” but mostly focuses on her historical and mythical works. Author 2 states that art historians have typically ignored her portrait busts, which suggests that they haven’t overshadowed her other work. Choice B is incorrect. Neither text explicitly states that *The Death of Cleopatra* is Lewis’s most famous piece. Author 1 mentions it as one example of her historical works, but does not single it out as being more important or influential than *Hagar*. Author 2 does not mention it at all, focusing instead on her portrait busts. Choice C is incorrect. This choice isn’t supported by the texts. Neither text suggests that sculpting historical figures was a trend that faded quickly.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 459a2c80

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 459a2c80

Text 1

A tiny, unusual fossil in a piece of 99-million-year-old amber is of the extinct species *Oculudentavis khaungraae*. The *O. khaungraae* fossil consists of a rounded skull with a thin snout and a large eye socket. Because these features look like they are avian, or related to birds, researchers initially thought that the fossil might be the smallest avian dinosaur ever found.

Text 2

Paleontologists were excited to discover a second small fossil that is similar to the strange *O. khaungraae* fossil but has part of the lower body along with a birdlike skull. Detailed studies of both fossils revealed several traits that are found in lizards but not in dinosaurs or birds. Therefore, paleontologists think the two creatures were probably unusual lizards, even though the skulls looked avian at first.

Based on the texts, what would the paleontologists in Text 2 most likely say about the researchers’ initial thought in Text 1?

- A. It is understandable because the fossil does look like it could be related to birds, even though *O. khaungraae* is probably a lizard.
- B. It is confusing because it isn’t clear what caused the researchers to think that *O. khaungraae* might be related to birds.
- C. It is flawed because the researchers mistakenly assumed that *O. khaungraae* must be a lizard.
- D. It is reasonable because the *O. khaungraae* skull is about the same size as the skull of the second fossil but is shaped differently.

ID: 459a2c80 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it reflects what the paleontologists in Text 2 would most likely say about what the researchers in Text 1 initially thought. Text 1 focuses on the discovery of a strange fossil consisting of the skull of the extinct species *Oculudentavis khaungraae*. According to Text 1, the fossil has features that appear to be avian, or related to birds, which led researchers to initially think that the fossil might be a very small avian dinosaur. Text 2 begins by noting the discovery of a second fossil similar to the one discussed in Text 1, then explains that based on detailed studies of both fossils, paleontologists think that the two creatures were probably unusual lizards, even though the skulls appeared avian at first. This suggests that the paleontologists in Text 2 recognize that the fossils do indeed look like they could be related to birds. For this reason, the paleontologists in Text 2 would most likely say that the initial thought of the researchers in Text 1—that the fossil was avian—is understandable, even if the fossil is probably not avian but rather is from a lizard.

Choice B is incorrect because Text 2 indicates that the fossils initially looked avian, so the paleontologists described in Text 2 wouldn’t be confused by the researchers in Text 1 initially thinking that *O. khaungraae* might be related to birds. The

paleontologists would find that initial thought understandable, not confusing. Choice C is incorrect because Text 1 never mentions lizards, so it wouldn't make sense for the paleontologists in Text 2 to say that the researchers in Text 1 mistakenly assumed that *O. khaungraae* must be a lizard. Choice D is incorrect. Although the paleontologists in Text 2 might agree that the initial thought of the researchers in Text 1 was reasonable, nothing in Text 2 suggests that the two skulls were shaped differently.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 879626ee

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 879626ee

The work of Tobias Gerstenberg et al. on tracking eye movements supports a theory that people envision _____ scenarios when making causal judgments: when subjects were asked to look at two colliding billiard balls and judge whether one caused or prevented the other’s movement through a gate, their eyes looked at where the target ball would have gone if the ball that altered its path did not exist.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. ambivalent
- B. retrospective
- C. counterfactual
- D. analogical

ID: 879626ee Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of what people envision when making causal judgments, or judgments of cause and effect. In this context, “counterfactual” means contrary to fact. The text explains that in an experiment in which subjects judged whether one billiard ball caused or prevented another billiard ball’s movement through a gate, researchers found that the subjects looked at where the target ball would have gone if the other ball hadn’t been there at all—that is, the subjects pictured the path the target ball would have taken in a scenario contrary to the one they actually saw. This would be an example of people envisioning counterfactual scenarios when considering causes and effects.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to describe scenarios people envision when making judgments of cause and effect as “ambivalent,” or characterized by conflicting feelings. People might have conflicting feelings in response to a scenario, but a scenario itself can’t have feelings. Choice B is incorrect. In this context, “retrospective” would mean looking back at something that occurred in the past. The text indicates that when asked to make a judgment about the movement of the target billiard ball, subjects envisioned what would have happened if only one ball had been present—that is, the text indicates that they envisioned a scenario that hadn’t actually happened, not that they examined only what had already actually happened. Choice D is incorrect. The text indicates that in an experiment involving the interaction of two billiard balls, eye movements showed that subjects pictured the path one ball would have taken if the other hadn’t been present. Because the subjects were picturing a scenario in the same context (the movement of the target billiard ball), just with a different arrangement of details (only one ball present), this wouldn’t be an example of people envisioning “analogical” scenarios, or hypothetical scenarios that are comparable to the scenario in question despite having different contexts.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 077808ae

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 077808ae

Some foraging models predict that the distance bees travel when foraging will decline as floral density increases, but biologists Shalene Jha and Claire Kremen showed that bees’ behavior is inconsistent with this prediction if flowers in dense patches are ____: bees will forage beyond patches of low species richness to acquire multiple resource types.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. depleted
- B. homogeneous
- C. immature
- D. dispersed

ID: 077808ae Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Jha and Kremen’s finding about bees’ foraging behavior. In this context, “homogeneous” means uniform or of the same kind. The text indicates that some models predict that the distance that bees travel when they’re foraging declines as the density of flowers increases. The text goes on to say, however, that Jha and Kremen identified a circumstance in which bees don’t behave this way. Specifically, if bees encounter “patches of low species richness”—that is, patches in which the flowers are largely from the same species—they’ll travel beyond those patches to get varied food resources. This context thus suggests that bees don’t behave as some models predict if the dense patches of flowers the bees encounter are homogeneous.

Choice A is incorrect because the text indicates that Jha and Kremen found that bees will behave differently than some models predict if the bees encounter flower patches that are not rich in species, not if the flowers are “depleted,” or emptied or reduced in quality or quantity. Although it could be true that bees are likely to leave depleted patches in search of more resources, the text doesn’t indicate that Jha and Kremen investigated that possibility. Choice C is incorrect because there’s no information in the text suggesting that bees will not behave as some models predict if flowers in patches are “immature,” or not fully developed. Instead, the text indicates that Jha and Kremen found that bees will behave contrary to some models’ predictions if the flower patches are not rich in species. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that bees’ behavior will be inconsistent with the predictions of some models if the flower patches that the bees encounter are of low species richness, not if the flowers are in patches that are “dispersed,” or widely scattered. Although the text does describe bees as leaving patches that are not rich in species to forage elsewhere, there’s no suggestion that Jha and Kremen found that the distance between dense flower patches affects whether the bees behave as some models predict.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9ab7c4e8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 9ab7c4e8

Seminole/Muscogee director Sterlin Harjo _____ television’s tendency to situate Native characters in the distant past: this rejection is evident in his series *Reservation Dogs*, which revolves around teenagers who dress in contemporary styles and whose dialogue is laced with current slang.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. repudiates
- B. proclaims
- C. foretells
- D. recants

ID: 9ab7c4e8 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Sterlin Harjo’s approach to representing Native characters on television. As used in this context, “repudiates” means rejects or refuses to have anything to do with. The text indicates that television shows tend to depict Native characters as living long ago, but that Harjo’s series *Reservation Dogs* focuses on Native teenagers in the present day, representing a “rejection” of the typical approach to depicting Native characters. This context thus indicates that Harjo repudiates television’s general tendency regarding Native characters.

Choice B is incorrect because the text describes Harjo’s “rejection” of the typical approach to representing Native characters on television, so it wouldn’t make sense to say that Harjo “proclaims,” or declares or affirms, television’s general tendency regarding Native characters. Harjo is described as refusing to follow the pattern of depicting Native characters in the distant past, not as proclaiming that pattern. Choice C is incorrect because the text describes television’s tendency to represent Native characters in the distant past as something that is already occurring, not as something that Harjo “foretells,” or predicts will happen in the future. The text is focused on Harjo’s “rejection” of this pattern, not on any predictions he may have about it. Choice D is incorrect because saying that Harjo “recants” something would mean that he withdraws a previously held belief, and it wouldn’t make sense to say that Harjo recants television’s tendency to represent Native characters as living in the past. No beliefs previously held by Harjo are mentioned. Additionally, a tendency isn’t a belief and thus isn’t something that can be recanted.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9d538982

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 9d538982

According to historian Vicki L. Ruiz, Mexican American women made crucial contributions to the labor movement during World War II. At the time, food processing companies entered into contracts to supply United States armed forces with canned goods. Increased production quotas conferred greater bargaining power on the companies’ employees, many of whom were Mexican American women: employees insisted on more favorable benefits, and employers, who were anxious to fulfill the contracts, complied. Thus, labor activism became a platform for Mexican American women to assert their agency.

- Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?
- A. It elaborates on a claim about labor relations in a particular industry made earlier in the text.
 - B. It offers an example of a trend in the World War II–era economy discussed earlier in the text.
 - C. It notes a possible exception to the historical narrative of labor activism sketched earlier in the text.
 - D. It provides further details about the identities of the workers discussed earlier in the text.

ID: 9d538982 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it best describes how the underlined portion functions in the text as a whole. The text says that the increased production quotas of food processing companies during World War II enabled employees to make better bargains in exchange for their labor. The underlined portion presents an example of this increased bargaining power: employees requested more favorable benefits, and employers complied because they were under pressure to fulfill the demanding terms of their contracts. Thus, the underlined portion of the text elaborates on a claim about labor relations in a particular industry (food processing) made earlier in the text.

Choice B is incorrect because there is no indication in the text that the economic factors that influenced food processing also influenced other parts of the economy; thus, the bargaining described in the underlined portion of the text cannot be called an example of a trend. Choice C is incorrect because the underlined portion supports the historical narrative of labor activism in food processing that is sketched in the text, instead of noting an exception to that narrative. Choice D is incorrect because while the underlined portion does discuss the demands that workers made in exchange for their labor, it does not discuss the identities of the workers.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 97d3bd78

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 97d3bd78

Diadromous fish migrate between freshwater and marine biomes during their life cycle. The migration's obligate nature is why diadromous fish can be _____ those that are merely euryhaline (able to tolerate high salinity): the euryhaline blackchin tilapia can survive high salinity, but its life cycle does not involve relocation to a different biome, as does that of the diadromous wild salmon.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. demarcated from
- B. reconstituted as
- C. conflated with
- D. derived from

ID: 97d3bd78 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of diadromous fish. In this context, "demarcated from" means separate or set apart from. The text indicates that diadromous fish differ from euryhaline fish in that diadromous fish "migrate between freshwater and marine biomes during their life," whereas euryhaline fish do not relocate to a different biome because they can tolerate higher salinity environments. Therefore, this context suggests that because of differences between their migration patterns, diadromous fish are distinct and can be demarcated from euryhaline fish.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the text states that diadromous fish migrate and relocate, the text does not suggest that diadromous fish would be "reconstituted as," or formed again as, anything new. Only their environments change and not the fish themselves. Choice C is incorrect because the text does not suggest that diadromous fish can be "conflated with," or combined with, euryhaline fish. Instead, the text distinguishes the two types of fish by pointing out their differences with regard to migration and tolerance for salinity. Choice D is incorrect because the text indicates that based on migration habits and tolerance for salinity, diadromous fish are different from euryhaline fish; so it would not make logical sense to say that diadromous fish would be "derived from," or be an extension of or result from, euryhaline fish.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9322bb61

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 9322bb61

Steiger Butte Drum, a family ensemble from the Klamath Tribes of the Pacific Northwest, collaborated with composer Michael Gordon to create *Natural History*, a work featuring traditional drumming and vocals alongside an orchestra and chorus. Steiger Butte Drum’s participation is _____ to the piece: members not only contributed to its composition but also must be included in all performances.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. tangential
- B. subsequent
- C. analogous
- D. integral

ID: 9322bb61 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Steiger Butte Drum’s contributions to the musical work *Natural History*. In this context, “integral” means essential or necessary to the whole. The text states that Steiger Butte Drum not only took part in the piece’s creation, collaborating with composer Michael Gordon on it, but also “must be included in all performances.” This context clearly indicates that the ensemble’s participation is essential, or integral, to the piece, both in its creation and its performance.

Choice A is incorrect because in this context, “tangential” would mean peripheral or of little relevance to something. The text emphasizes the importance of Steiger Butte Drum’s involvement in both the composition and performance of *Natural History*, indicating their role is central, not tangential. Choice B is incorrect because in this context, “subsequent” would mean following after or coming later than something else. The text doesn’t establish a temporal sequence where the participation of Steiger Butte Drum followed after the creation of *Natural History*; rather, it indicates that the ensemble was involved with the piece from the beginning, having worked with Michael Gordon during the creation process. Choice C is incorrect because in this context, “analogous” would mean similar or comparable to something else, and the text doesn’t compare Steiger Butte Drum’s participation in the creation and performances of *Natural History* to anything else; instead, it describes the nature and importance of the ensemble’s involvement.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f02726fb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: f02726fb

In Jane Austen’s novel *Mansfield Park*, an almost imperceptible smile from potential suitor Henry Crawford causes the protagonist Fanny Price to blush; her embarrassment grows when she suspects that he is aware of it. This moment—in which Fanny not only infers Henry’s mental state through his gestures, but also infers that *he* is drawing inferences about *her* mental state—illustrates what literary scholar George Butte calls “deep intersubjectivity,” a technique for representing interactions between consciousnesses through which Austen’s novels derive much of their social and psychological drama.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- A. It states a claim about Austen’s skill at representing psychological complexity that is reinforced by an example presented in the following sentence.
- B. It advances an interpretation of an Austen protagonist who is contrasted with protagonists from other Austen novels cited in the following sentence.
- C. It describes a recurring theme in Austen’s novels that is the focus of a literary scholar’s analysis summarized in the following sentence.
- D. It provides a synopsis of an interaction in an Austen novel that illustrates a literary concept discussed in the following sentence.

ID: f02726fb Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The underlined sentence provides a concrete example to ground readers’ understanding of the “deep intersubjectivity” described in the next sentence as central to Austen’s work.

Choice A is incorrect. There is no evaluation made of Austen’s skill in this sentence, and no examples are given in the following sentence. This choice essentially flips the paragraph: it’s this first sentence that provides an example. Choice B is incorrect. There are no other Austen protagonists mentioned in this passage, so this couldn’t be the answer. Choice C is incorrect. The underlined sentence doesn’t identify any “recurring theme,” but instead simply describes one interaction from one book. This interaction exemplifies the literary technique of “deep intersubjectivity” that is introduced in the next sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID eb0cf607

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: eb0cf607

The creation of Lotte Reiniger’s 1926 animated film *The Adventures of Prince Achmed* was _____ process. Over the course of three years, Reiniger and her collaborators painstakingly made more than 250,000 individual images of hand-cut paper silhouettes and repeatedly had to invent entirely new methods and tools to create the special effects Reiniger envisioned.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. a haphazard
- B. a contentious
- C. an ineffectual
- D. an arduous

ID: eb0cf607 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the creation of *The Adventures of Prince Achmed*. In this context, "arduous" means that the process is marked by great labor or effort. According to the text, the creation of the 1926 animated film *The Adventures of Prince Achmed* took three years and was a painstaking process. Since the process was so long and required great efforts by Lotte Reiniger and her team, the creation of the film was therefore an arduous process.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t indicate that the creation of Reiniger’s film was "a haphazard," or disorganized, process. In fact, the text suggests that the creation process was quite meticulous and the team worked hard together to produce the envisioned effects. Choice B is incorrect. While the text does suggest that the creation of Reiniger’s film was a long and difficult process, it doesn’t suggest that the process was "a contentious" one, or one causing controversy or argument. The text suggests that the team worked together to produce the envisioned effects. Choice C is incorrect because rather than describing the process of creating the film as "ineffectual," or not having the effect it was intended to have, the text describes the process as ultimately successful despite the difficulty it involved.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3416a884

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 3416a884

Guadalupe Romero Villanueva et al. conducted radiocarbon analysis of paint used in rock art at the Patagonian archaeological site Cueva Huenul 1, revealing that images of a comblike motif date to as early as 8,000 years ago, predating other paintings in the region by several millennia. The motif was subsequently reproduced multiple times at the site over the next 3,000 years, a period coinciding with extremely arid conditions and slightly negative population growth. The motif may therefore have functioned to help preserve cultural knowledge during a time of ecological and demographic stress.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. It identifies a consideration that factored into an interpretation of the rock art at Cueva Huenul 1 that is presented in the text.
- B. It provides context that informs the text’s claim about why the peoples of Patagonia chose Cueva Huenul 1 as a culturally significant site.
- C. It emphasizes the historical conditions that explain why production of the painted motif described in the text abruptly ceased after 3,000 years of continued use.
- D. It explains the environmental circumstances that account for the rarity of rock art dating to the same period as the motif discussed in the text.

ID: 3416a884 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole. The text first reports that a comblike motif at Cueva Huenul 1 dates to 8,000 years ago and was reproduced over the next 3,000 years. The underlined portion then indicates that this 3,000-year period corresponds to a span of very dry environmental conditions and a slowly declining human population in the area. The text then suggests that the chronological overlap between use of the comblike motif and the ecological and demographic conditions might suggest that what the motif is meant to communicate is related to those specific factors. Thus, the underlined portion identifies a consideration that factored into an interpretation of the rock art at Cueva Huenul 1 that is presented in the text.

Choice B is incorrect. Although the text suggests that Cueva Huenul 1 may have been an important site because it enabled the peoples of Patagonia to preserve cultural knowledge, nothing in the text addresses why they chose the site for their paintings. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates that the motif was reproduced over a period of 3,000 years (beginning 8,000 years ago) without directly addressing the cessation of its use. Furthermore, nothing in the text suggests that the motif was abandoned abruptly. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the underlined portion or the text as a whole addresses the rarity of rock art during the period in question.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID eea3e2f0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: eea3e2f0

The following text is adapted from Zora Neale Hurston’s 1921 short story “John Redding Goes to Sea.” John is a child who lives in a town in the woods.

Perhaps ten-year-old John was puzzling to the folk there in the Florida woods for he was an imaginative child and fond of day-dreams. The St. John River flowed a scarce three hundred feet from his back door. On its banks at this point grow numerous palms, luxuriant magnolias and bay trees. On the bosom of the stream float millions of delicately colored hyacinths. [John Redding] loved to wander down to the water’s edge, and, casting in dry twigs, watch them sail away down stream to Jacksonville, the sea, the wide world and [he] wanted to follow them.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- A. It provides an extended description of a location that John likes to visit.
- B. It reveals that some residents of John’s town are confused by his behavior.
- C. It illustrates the uniqueness of John’s imagination compared to the imaginations of other children.
- D. It suggests that John longs to experience a larger life outside the Florida woods.

ID: eea3e2f0 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it accurately describes how the underlined sentence functions in the text as a whole. The text establishes that John has a strong imagination and then goes on to describe the St. John River near John’s home in the Florida woods. The underlined sentence depicts John sending twigs sailing down the river while he imagines them reaching “Jacksonville, the sea, the wide world,” where he wishes he could follow. This suggests that John longs to expand his life experiences beyond the Florida woods.

Choice A is incorrect because the second and third sentences of the text provide an extended description of the riverbank where John likes to go, whereas the underlined sentence describes what John does at that location. Choice B is incorrect because the first sentence of the text suggests that John’s behavior “was puzzling” to others around him, whereas the underlined sentence concerns the content of John’s imaginings. Choice C is incorrect because the underlined sentence elaborates on John’s imagination but doesn’t mention any other children to whom John could be compared.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c0b3aa09

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: c0b3aa09

Despite how _____ they may seem on first glance, the works of the philosopher Georg Hegel have proven to be quite influential. Readers who manage to penetrate Hegel’s frustratingly dense prose often find that his thrillingly original and profound ideas wind up shaping their own thinking.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. authoritative
- B. opaque
- C. empirical
- D. facile

ID: c0b3aa09 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Hegel’s works. In this context, "opaque" means difficult to understand or unclear. The text creates a contrast between the initial impression given by Hegel’s works and their influence and insight, noting that readers must "penetrate Hegel’s frustratingly dense prose" to access his important ideas. This context clearly establishes that Hegel’s writing is initially challenging to comprehend, or opaque.

Choice A is incorrect because "authoritative" means influential or clearly accurate. Hegel’s works may be authoritative, but it wouldn’t make logical sense in context to say that although his works seem authoritative, they have been influential. Instead, the text focuses on the fact that Hegel’s works are challenging to read, but that working through the dense prose can be rewarding. Choice C is incorrect because referring to Hegel’s works as "empirical," which means factual or verifiable, would suggest that they are based on observation or experience rather than theory. The text, however, doesn’t address this aspect of Hegel’s philosophy. Instead, it focuses on the difficulty of understanding his writing. Choice D is incorrect because describing Hegel’s works as "facile," which means superficial or simplistic, would directly contradict the text’s characterization of his writing as "frustratingly dense" and requiring effort to understand.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9b9e86ef

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 9b9e86ef

The province of Xoconochco was situated on the Pacific coast, hundreds of kilometers southeast of Tenochtitlan, the capital of the Aztec Empire. Because Xoconochco’s location within the empire was so _____, cacao and other trade goods produced there could reach the capital only after a long overland journey.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. unobtrusive
- B. concealed
- C. approximate
- D. peripheral

ID: 9b9e86ef Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the location of the province of Xoconochco within the Aztec Empire. As used in this context, “peripheral” means situated toward the outer bounds rather than the center. The text indicates that Xoconochco was located on a coast, hundreds of kilometers away from the capital of the Aztec Empire. The text also states that trade between the province and the capital required “a long overland journey.” This context suggests that Xoconochco was situated toward an edge of the empire’s territory rather than near its center.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense in context to refer to Xoconochco’s location within the Aztec Empire as “unobtrusive,” or not blatant or undesirably prominent; it’s not clear how a province’s physical location would or wouldn’t be blatant. Instead of focusing on how noticeable Xoconochco’s location was, the text emphasizes the province’s distance from the capital of the empire, pointing out that because of this distance trade between the two required “a long overland journey.” Choice B is incorrect because the text indicates that the province of Xoconochco was located on a coast far from the capital of the Aztec Empire, not that it was “concealed,” or kept out of sight or hidden from view. Nothing in the text suggests that Xoconochco was actually hidden such that people couldn’t see it, and being hidden wouldn’t necessarily result in trade between the province and the capital requiring “a long overland journey.” Choice C is incorrect because to say that Xoconochco’s location within the Aztec Empire was “approximate” would mean that the location either wasn’t precisely correct or was close to some other location. Neither of these meanings would make sense in context because the text indicates that Xoconochco’s location is known and that it was far from the empire’s capital, so there’s no reason to characterize the location as either not precisely correct or close to another location.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f9f62464

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: f9f62464

Text 1

Microbes are tiny organisms in the soil, water, and air all around us. They thrive even in very harsh conditions. That’s why Noah Fierer and colleagues were surprised when soil samples they collected from an extremely cold, dry area in Antarctica didn’t seem to contain any life. The finding doesn’t prove that there are no microbes in that area, but the team says it does suggest that the environment severely restricts microbes’ survival.

Text 2

Microbes are found in virtually every environment on Earth. So it’s unlikely they would be completely absent from Fierer’s team’s study site, no matter how extreme the environment is. There were probably so few organisms in the samples that current technology couldn’t detect them. But since a spoonful of typical soil elsewhere might contain billions of microbes, the presence of so few in the Antarctic soil samples would show how challenging the conditions are.

Based on the texts, Fierer’s team and the author of Text 2 would most likely agree with which statement about microbes?

- A. Most microbes are better able to survive in environments with extremely dry conditions than in environments with harsh temperatures.
- B. A much higher number of microbes would probably be found if another sample of soil were taken from the Antarctic study site.
- C. Microbes are likely difficult to detect in the soil at the Antarctic study site because they tend to be smaller than microbes found in typical soil elsewhere.
- D. Most microbes are probably unable to withstand the soil conditions at the Antarctic study site.

ID: f9f62464 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a statement about microbes with which Fierer’s team (Text 1) and the author of Text 2 would most likely agree. Text 1 states that microbes usually thrive in very harsh conditions, and so Fierer’s team was surprised when samples collected from an extremely cold and dry area of Antarctica didn’t appear to contain any life. Fierer’s team says that though this doesn’t conclusively prove there are no microbes in the area, it suggests that microbes would have a notably difficult time surviving in the environment. The author of Text 2 says it’s unlikely that there would be no microbes at all in the Antarctic study site from which Fierer’s team retrieved soil samples and that there may have been hard-to-detect microbes in the samples. However, the presence of only a few microbes in the Antarctic samples rather than the billions found in a typical soil sample (which would presumably be much easier to detect) would illustrate conditions in the Antarctic soil that make it difficult for microbes to thrive. Since Fierer’s team says that the seeming absence of microbes in the Antarctic samples suggests an unusually harsh environment and the author of Text 2 says that even if there are a few undetectable microbes in the samples, the

relatively tiny number of microbes would also suggest an unusually harsh environment, then Fierer's team and the author of Text 2 would most likely agree that most microbes are unable to withstand the soil conditions at the Antarctic study site.

Choice A is incorrect. The samples taken by Fierer's team were from an area of Antarctica that is described in part as extremely dry, and these samples didn't appear to have any life. Therefore, even though these samples also came from an extremely cold area, Fierer's team wouldn't argue based on the evidence available that microbes were better able to survive in dry conditions than in areas with harsh temperatures. Moreover, the author of Text 2 says that microbes are found in virtually every environment on Earth but doesn't compare dry environments and harsh environments. Choice B is incorrect. Nothing in Text 1 indicates that another collection of samples from the Antarctic study site might yield different results from the samples already taken by Fierer's team. The author of Text 2 does state that microbes are found in virtually every environment on Earth and suggests that new technology may be better able to detect so few microbes in a soil sample, but the author of Text 2 concludes that the unusual absence of microbes in the Antarctic samples is evidence of the harsh Antarctic environment. Therefore, there is no reason to believe that the author of Text 2 thinks that another sample drawn from that same harsh environment would yield a much higher number of microbes. Choice C is incorrect. The author of Text 2 does speculate that there may have been so few microbes in the Antarctic samples that current technology couldn't detect them, but the author doesn't speculate that this is due to the size of the microbes. Moreover, nothing that Fierer's team says suggests that they are speculating that their samples might have microbes that are smaller than microbes in typical soil samples.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d2a4ec94

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: d2a4ec94

Text 1

The live music festival business is growing in event size and genre variety. With so many consumer options, organizers are finding ways to cement festival attendance as a special experience worth sharing. This phenomenon is linked to the growing “experiential economy,” where many find it gratifying to purchase lived experiences. To ensure a profitable event, venues need to consider the overall consumer experience, not just the band lineup.

Text 2

Music festival appearances are becoming a more important part of musicians’ careers. One factor in this shift is the rising use of streaming services that allow access to huge numbers of songs for a monthly fee, subsequently reducing sales of full-length albums. With this shift in consumer behavior, musicians are increasingly dependent on revenue from live performances.

Based on the texts, both authors would most likely agree with which statement?

- A. Consumers are more interested in paying subscription fees to stream music than in attending music festivals in person.
- B. Consumers’ growing interest in purchasing experiences is mostly confined to the music industry.
- C. Changing consumer behaviors are leading to changes in music-related businesses.
- D. The rising consumer demand for live music festivals also generates higher demand for music streaming platforms.

ID: d2a4ec94 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents the statement about music consumers that both authors would most likely agree with. The author of Text 1 indicates that because consumers are increasingly interested in purchasing experiences (the “growing ‘experiential economy’”), live music festivals are growing in size and variety and are being designed to stand out as special among many consumer options. The author of Text 2 indicates that as streaming service use increases and album sales decrease, live performances and music festival appearances are becoming more important to musicians as a source of revenue. Thus, both authors would most likely agree that changing consumer behaviors (greater interest in purchasing experiences and greater use of streaming services) are leading to changes in music-related businesses (music festivals).

Choice A is incorrect because the author of Text 1 makes no mention of streaming services and the author of Text 2 indicates only that the use of such services is rising, not that consumers prefer paying for streaming music over attending music festivals. Choice B is incorrect because the author of Text 1 indicates that the “growing ‘experiential economy’” is affecting the music industry but gives no indication that it is largely limited to that industry and the author of Text 2 makes no mention of consumers’ growing interest in purchasing experiences (focusing instead on musicians’ greater reliance on revenue from festivals and other live performances). Choice D is incorrect because the author of Text 1 makes no mention of music streaming platforms and the author of Text 2 suggests not that rising demand for live music festivals is driving demand for music streaming platforms, but

rather that as streaming services become more widely used and reduce album sales, musicians become more dependent on festivals and other live performances for revenue.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b04da6bc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: b04da6bc

It is by no means _____ to recognize the influence of Dutch painter Hieronymus Bosch on Ali Banisadr’s paintings; indeed, Banisadr himself cites Bosch as an inspiration. However, some scholars have suggested that the ancient Mesopotamian poem *Epic of Gilgamesh* may have had a far greater impact on Banisadr’s work.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. substantial
- B. satisfying
- C. unimportant
- D. appropriate

ID: b04da6bc Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most logically completes the sentence about the influences on Banisadr’s work. In context, “It is by no means” followed by “unimportant” conveys how it is relevant to recognize Bosch’s influence on Banisadr. The text points out that the artist himself cites Bosch as an inspiration, and then goes on to claim that *The Epic of Gilgamesh* has had a more significant influence than Bosch.

Choice A is incorrect because “substantial,” which means weighty or meaningful, incorrectly suggests that it wouldn’t be meaningful to acknowledge Bosch’s influence on Banisadr. The phrase “indeed, Banisadr himself cites Bosch as an inspiration” doesn’t support this suggestion. Choice B is incorrect because “satisfying,” which means pleasing, incorrectly suggests that it wouldn’t be pleasing to acknowledge Bosch’s influence on Banisadr. The phrase “indeed, Banisadr himself cites Bosch as an inspiration” doesn’t support this suggestion. Choice D is incorrect because “appropriate,” which means suitable, incorrectly suggests that it wouldn’t be proper to acknowledge Bosch’s influence on Banisadr. The phrase “indeed, Banisadr himself cites Bosch as an inspiration” doesn’t support this suggestion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d370fb6c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: d370fb6c

In a 2019 study, Jeremy Gunawardena and colleagues found that the single-celled protozoan *Stentor roeseli* not only uses strategies to escape irritating stimuli but also switches strategies when one fails. This evidence of protozoans sophisticatedly “changing their minds” demonstrates that single-celled organisms may not be limited to _____ behaviors.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. aggressive
- B. rudimentary
- C. evolving
- D. advantageous

ID: d370fb6c Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of single-celled organism behavior. As used in this context, “rudimentary” means basic or unsophisticated. According to the text, a study of the single-celled protozoan *Stentor roeseli* showed that the organisms can switch strategies for escaping certain stimuli, “sophisticatedly ‘changing their minds’” and using new strategies should other strategies fail. This context suggests that single-celled organisms may not be limited to behaviors that are basic or rudimentary, since the study showed that single-celled protozoans can respond complexly to irritating stimuli.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that single-celled organisms may not be limited to behavior that is “aggressive,” or threatening. Rather, the text suggests that single-celled organisms may not be limited to behaviors that are basic, since the study of *Stentor roeseli* showed that single-celled protozoans can respond complexly to irritating stimuli. Choice C is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that single-celled organisms may not be limited to behavior that is “evolving,” or advancing. Rather, the text suggests that single-celled organisms may not be limited to behaviors that are basic, since the study of *Stentor roeseli* showed that single-celled protozoans can respond complexly to irritating stimuli. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that single-celled organisms may not be limited to behavior that is “advantageous,” or helpful. Rather, the text suggests that single-celled organisms may not be limited to behaviors that are basic, since the study of *Stentor roeseli* showed that single-celled protozoans can respond complexly to irritating stimuli.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 62ac3a8a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 62ac3a8a

Among saltwater fish species, there is a clear association between habitat latitude and morphological variety. While tropical species are _____ deep-bodied physical forms (body shapes that are laterally compressed but vertically extended), polar and temperate species are highly dispersed across the morphological spectrum.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. authenticated by
- B. habituated to
- C. contemporary with
- D. concentrated among

ID: 62ac3a8a Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the relationship between habitat latitude and body shape in saltwater fish species. In this context, “concentrated among” means largely confined to. The text sets up a contrast between tropical species, which are generally characterized by a single shape—deep-bodied forms—and polar and temperate species, which are “highly dispersed across the morphological spectrum” (meaning they exhibit a wide range of body shapes). This context supports the idea that tropical species are concentrated among deep-bodied physical forms—that is, largely confined to this single morphological category rather than spread across many.

Choice A is incorrect because saying that tropical species are “authenticated by,” or proven genuine by, deep-bodied physical forms wouldn’t make sense. Instead, the text describes the typical morphology (body shape) of tropical fish species and how that differs from the typical morphologies of polar and temperate fish species. Choice B is incorrect because saying that tropical species are “habituated to,” or accustomed through repeated exposure to, deep-bodied physical forms wouldn’t make sense. Instead, the text describes the typical morphology (body shape) of tropical fish species and how that differs from the typical morphologies of polar and temperate fish species. Choice C is incorrect because saying that tropical species are “contemporary with,” or existing at the same time as, deep-bodied physical forms indicates that the species exist at the same time as their body shapes do, which, if it is a meaningful statement at all, is at best trivially true and unrelated to the text’s discussion of the typical morphology (body shape) of tropical fish species and how that differs from the typical morphologies of polar and temperate fish species.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8e59bf41

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 8e59bf41

Political blogs with conspicuous ideological alignments became an integral component of US media in the early 2000s. While some commentators lauded this development, asserting that such blogs had a welcome transparency missing from traditional news, less _____ observers countered that such blogs tended to ideological extremes that exacerbated political polarization to problematic levels.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. sanguine
- B. recalcitrant
- C. misanthropic
- D. earnest

ID: 8e59bf41 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of political blogs. In this context, "sanguine" means optimistic. The text begins by noting the rise of political blogs with readily identifiable ideological alignments in the early 2000s. The text then indicates that some commentators saw this as a positive development, citing a reason why (their difference from traditional news). Finally, the text goes on to contrast those commentators with others who have a negative opinion of the rise of political blogs (because they increase political polarization among their readers). This context supports the idea that the second group of commentators is less positive than the first: thus, the second group of commentators is less optimistic, or sanguine.

Choice B is incorrect because it would not make sense in this context to describe those commentators who have a negative opinion of political blogs as less "recalcitrant," or obstinately uncooperative, than those commentators who supported political blogs. Choice C is incorrect because the text gives no indication that those commentators who have a negative opinion of political blogs are less "misanthropic," or less contemptuous of humankind, than those commentators who have a positive opinion of political blogs—there is no indication in the text that those commentators who like political blogs would be contemptuous of humankind at all. Choice D is incorrect because there is no evidence that those commentators who have a negative opinion of political blogs are less "earnest," or sincere, than those who have a positive opinion of such blogs—presumably, both groups of commentators hold their beliefs with equal conviction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f78732ae

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: f78732ae

Though copies of *The Adventures of Indiana Jones in Wenceslas Square in Prague on January 16, 1989*—an underground computer game that was created anonymously in 1989 as an act of political protest against the authoritarian regime of what was then Czechoslovakia—were originally distributed _____, the game is now readily available online for anyone to play.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. succinctly
- B. dispassionately
- C. disingenuously
- D. surreptitiously

ID: f78732ae Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of how *The Adventures of Indiana Jones in Wenceslas Square in Prague on January 16, 1989* was originally distributed. In this context, “surreptitiously” means in a secret manner. The text describes the game as being underground and created anonymously as a way to oppose the regime of what was then Czechoslovakia. The text goes on to contrast the game’s original distribution with its current broader availability. This context supports the idea that copies were originally distributed surreptitiously—that is, secretly, as would be necessary for an act of protest against an authoritarian regime.

Choice A is incorrect because saying that copies of the game were originally distributed “succinctly,” or in a brief and concise manner, wouldn’t make sense in this context. “Succinctly” describes the manner in which something is expressed, not the manner in which physical copies of a game are circulated. Choice B is incorrect because saying that copies of the game were originally distributed “dispassionately,” or without emotion, wouldn’t make sense in this context. The text describes the game as an act of political protest, suggesting that its creation and distribution were motivated by strong feelings about the then Czechoslovakian regime. Moreover, the text establishes the contrast between secretive distribution and open availability, not between emotional and unemotional distribution. Choice C is incorrect because saying that copies of the game were originally distributed “disingenuously,” or in an insincere manner, wouldn’t make sense in this context. The text characterizes the game as a sincere act of political protest, and the contrast the text sets up concerns secrecy (“underground” and “anonymously”) versus openness (“readily available”).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 42f1b5b8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 42f1b5b8

Within baleen whale species, some individuals develop an accessory spleen—a seemingly functionless formation of splenic tissue outside the normal spleen. Given the formation’s greater prevalence among whales known to make deeper dives, some researchers hypothesize that its role isn’t ____; rather, the accessory spleen may actively support diving mechanisms.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. replicable
- B. predetermined
- C. operative
- D. latent

ID: 42f1b5b8 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of baleen whale accessory spleens. In this context, “latent” means dormant or functionless. The text sets up a contrast between the idea that baleen whale accessory spleens appear not to have a function and the research indicating that the accessory spleen may actually have a role in supporting the whales’ diving mechanisms. This context therefore conveys the idea that the assumption that baleen whale accessory spleens are latent may be incorrect.

Choice A is incorrect because it wouldn’t make sense to say that the role of the accessory spleen is “replicable,” or capable of being reproduced. The text indicates that the role of the accessory spleen seems to have no function, but some researchers think it does have a role; the text doesn’t address whether the role of the accessory spleen could or couldn’t be reproduced. Choice B is incorrect because suggesting that the role of the accessory spleen is “predetermined,” or decided in advance, wouldn’t make sense in context. Although the researchers may agree that the role of the accessory spleen or any other organ hasn’t been determined in advance, the text focuses on the idea that the accessory spleen was thought to have been functionless but may in fact serve an active role for baleen whales. Choice C is incorrect because it’s the opposite of what the context of the text is conveying. The second sentence of the text indicates that baleen whale accessory spleens may not be useless, not that they aren’t “operative,” or functional.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 80fbbe0e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 80fbbe0e

Dubautia carrii is a species in a family of plants known collectively as the silversword alliance, all of which grow only on the Hawaiian Islands. Members of this alliance exhibit an extraordinary range of phenotypes, with some species maturing into vines and others into shrubs and trees. All species in the alliance descended from a single ancestral tarweed plant that arrived on the islands around 5 million years ago. The tarweed’s descendants diversified into distinct species as they adapted to live in the wide variety of habitats found on the Hawaiian Islands.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. To indicate the specific tarweed ancestor of all plants that grow on the Hawaiian Islands and explain why the plants have such varied physical characteristics
- B. To describe the specific habitat where *Dubautia carrii* are found and identify other plants that share a common ancestor with them
- C. To describe the silversword alliance and explain how the plant family became so varied
- D. To advance the claim that all plants on the Hawaiian Islands are part of the silversword alliance and list possible ancestors of the plants that make up the alliance

ID: 80fbbe0e Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the main purpose of the text, which is to describe the family of plants known as the silversword alliance and explain why the plants came to exhibit "an extraordinary range of phenotypes." The text introduces the silversword alliance as a family of plants unique to the Hawaiian Islands, presenting those that mature into vines and those that mature into shrubs and trees as examples of different phenotypes. The text concludes by explaining that these plants are all descendants of "a single ancestral tarweed plant" that arrived 5 million years ago in the Hawaiian Islands, where a "wide variety of habitats" drove the plant’s descendants to adapt and thus differentiate themselves, diversifying into a group of related but distinct species with different physical characteristics.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text explains why the plants within the silversword alliance have varied physical characteristics, the text doesn’t suggest that tarweed is the ancestor of all plants on the Hawaiian Islands. The text states instead that all members of the silversword alliance descend from a single tarweed ancestor. Choice B is incorrect because while *Dubautia carrii* is mentioned as an example of a species in the silversword alliance, no details about its particular habitat are provided. And although the text indicates that the Hawaiian Islands are home to "a wide variety of habitats," it doesn’t describe the specific habitat where *Dubautia carrii* is found. The text discusses the silversword alliance as a whole rather than focusing on *Dubautia carrii* or any one species within this family. Choice D is incorrect. Although the silversword alliance is only found on the Hawaiian Islands and includes "an extraordinary range of phenotypes," the text doesn’t claim that all plants on the Hawaiian

Islands are part of the alliance. Furthermore, the text indicates that these plants all "descended from a single ancestral tarweed plant," not that there are multiple possible candidates for that ancestor plant.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fa581ec9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: fa581ec9

In a 2020 paper, Arya Udry et al. cautioned that although similarities in the isotopic signatures of elements detected in Mars’s atmosphere and in Martian meteorites recovered on Earth make it tempting to treat the geochemical properties of the meteorites as _____ those of Mars’s interiors, Mars’s geology cannot be ascertained based solely on meteorite-sample analyses.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. contrivances of
- B. proxies for
- C. catalysts of
- D. deterrents to

ID: fa581ec9 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the relationship between Martian meteorites and Mars’s interior geology. In this context, “proxies for” means substitutes used to represent something else. The text describes Udry and colleagues as cautioning against a tempting line of reasoning: because the isotopic signatures (chemical fingerprints) of elements in Mars’s atmosphere resemble those in Martian meteorites recovered on Earth, researchers might be inclined to treat the meteorites’ geochemical properties as reasonably standing in for those of Mars’s interiors. The text indicates that Udry and colleagues argue against this reasoning, noting that Mars’s geology cannot be determined solely from meteorite analysis. This context conveys that it is tempting to treat the meteorites’ properties as proxies for those of Mars’s interiors.

Choice A is incorrect because “contrivances of” would mean things artificially devised or produced by something, and it wouldn’t make sense to say that it’s tempting to treat the geochemical properties of meteorites as having been artificially produced by the planet the meteorites came from; it’s not clear how a planet could fabricate such properties. Further, the text is focused on the idea that it’s tempting to treat the meteorites’ properties as standing in for those of Mars’s interiors, which likely wouldn’t be the case if the meteorite’s properties were considered artificial in any way. Choice C is incorrect because “catalysts of” something are things that trigger or accelerate its change or action. The text focuses on the idea of analyzing samples of Martian meteorites found on Earth to determine Mars’s geology; this suggests that the temptation is to view the geochemical properties of the meteorites as direct evidence of those of Mars’s interior, not to treat them as though they had caused changes in Mars’s interior geology. Choice D is incorrect because “deterrents to” something would mean things that discourage or prevent it, and it wouldn’t make sense to say that it’s tempting to treat the geochemical properties of Martian meteorites as preventing the geochemical properties of Mars’s interiors; the meteorites came from Mars and are no longer there, so their properties can’t have any effect on those of the planet.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 44242abe

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 44242abe

The following text is from H.D.'s 1916 poem "Mid-Day." In the poem, the speaker is on a path in an outdoor setting.

A slight wind shakes the seed-pods—
my thoughts are spent
as the black seeds.
My thoughts tear me,
I dread their fever.
I am scattered in its whirl.
I am scattered like
the hot shrivelled seeds.

- Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?
- A. It illustrates a change in the natural environment that the speaker implies is responsible for the growing misgivings described in the text.
 - B. It establishes an example of consistency in the natural landscape that the speaker then contrasts with the unpredictability of human emotions.
 - C. It presents an observation of an occurrence in the natural world that the speaker then expands on to convey a sense of a turbulent interior state.
 - D. It evokes the ordinariness of an event in nature to suggest that the critical self-evaluation the speaker engages in is a common pursuit.

ID: 44242abe Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole. In the text, the speaker mentions the occurrence in nature of seedpods being shaken by a slight wind. The speaker then goes on to compare the black seeds to thoughts, using language that indicates that the speaker's state of mind is unsettled (e.g., "my thoughts are spent"; "My thoughts tear me, I dread their fever"). The text concludes with a comparison between the speaker's "scattered" state of mind and the "hot shrivelled seeds." Thus, the underlined portion of the text presents an observation of an occurrence in the natural world that the speaker then expands on to convey a sense of a turbulent interior state.

Choice A is incorrect because the text does not indicate that the seedpods are the cause of the speaker's state of mind; thus, they could not be responsible for any misgivings the speaker has. Choice B is incorrect because the text does not contrast the natural landscape with the speaker's state of mind or describe the wind shaking the seedpods as consistent; rather, the text suggests that the state of the natural world and the speaker's state of mind are similar in that both are unsettled. Choice D is incorrect because

there is no indication in the text that the speaker regularly engages in critical self-evaluation, only that in this particular instance the speaker's state of mind is turbulent.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e837aa42

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: e837aa42

Some economic historians _____ that late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century households in the United States experienced an economy of scale when it came to food purchases—they assumed that large households spent less on food per person than did small households. Economist Trevon Logan showed, however, that a close look at the available data disproves this supposition.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. surmised
- B. contrived
- C. questioned
- D. regretted

ID: e837aa42 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century household food purchases. In this context, “surmised” means formed an idea or assumption with little evidence. The text explains that certain economic historians “assumed” that large and small households spent different amounts on food per person, but that another economist found this supposition to be false based on evidence from available data. This context suggests that the economic historians made an incorrect assumption without enough consideration of evidence.

Choice B is incorrect. In this context, “contrived” would mean brought about or created through trickery. Nothing in the text suggests that the economic historians were deliberately trying to trick people with a claim about food purchasing behaviors in late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century households; the text simply suggests that they made an assumption about those behaviors that another historian believes isn’t supported by the available data. Choice C is incorrect because the text indicates that it’s Logan and not the economic historians who “questioned,” or doubted, the assumption that large and small households in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries spent different amounts on food per person; the economic historians are the ones who made that assumption to begin with. Choice D is incorrect because nothing in the text suggests that some economic historians “regretted,” or felt sad or remorseful about, the food purchasing behaviors of late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century households. The text focuses on the idea that the economic historians made an assumption about those behaviors that may not be supported by available data, not on the historians’ emotional response to what households did in the past.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c75abc0a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: c75abc0a

Technological advances have prompted companies to increasingly rely on automation to streamline production. Armin Granulo and colleagues, however, found that for products with higher symbolic value (those viewed as contributing to individual self-expression), consumers prefer products made by humans rather than by robots, likely because human-made products are more strongly associated with uniqueness. When considering automation, therefore, companies—especially those specializing in products of symbolic value—should weigh trade-offs between efficiency gains and consumer preferences.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- A. It presents evidence supporting the text’s argument that consumers prefer products with high symbolic value over products with low symbolic value.
- B. It refers to a finding presented in the previous sentence to recommend that companies that value product quality reconsider automating their production processes.
- C. It illustrates the need for additional research to evaluate the claim in the previous sentence that automation affects how consumers rate product uniqueness.
- D. It emphasizes that a research finding discussed in the text has practical implications that are particularly relevant for businesses making a certain class of product.

ID: c75abc0a Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole. The text begins by noting that companies increasingly depend on automation to improve production efficiency. The text then presents Granulo and colleagues’ finding that consumers think it’s preferable for one category of products (those “with higher symbolic value”) to be human made rather than machine made. The underlined sentence highlights a practical consequence of that finding: companies, especially those specializing in such products, should balance the efficiency of automation against consumer preferences. Thus, the underlined sentence emphasizes that the research finding has practical implications that are especially relevant for businesses making a certain class of product.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text indicates that among products with high symbolic value, people prefer those made by humans over those made by machines, it doesn’t address whether products with high symbolic value are preferred over those with low symbolic value. Choice B is incorrect because rather than reiterate the finding in the previous sentence—that people tend to prefer “products with higher symbolic value” that are human made over those that are machine made—the underlined sentence instead makes a recommendation to companies that sell such products to carefully consider a potential drawback of making their products with machines. Choice C is incorrect because nothing in the underlined sentence or the text as a whole suggests that additional research is needed to evaluate Granulo and colleagues’ claim. Moreover, the researchers’ finding is that consumers

prefer “products with higher symbolic value” to be human made, not that automation affects consumers’ ratings of how unique products are.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 92d77da3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 92d77da3

The following text is adapted from Edith Wharton’s 1911 novella *Ethan Frome*. The narrator has asked the woman he rents a room from about Ethan Frome, a town resident he encountered recently.

Her mind was a store-house of innocuous anecdote and any question about her acquaintances brought forth a volume of detail; but on the subject of Ethan Frome I found her unexpectedly reticent. There was no hint of disapproval in her reserve; I merely felt in her an insurmountable reluctance to speak of him.

As used in the text, what does the word “reserve” most nearly mean?

- A. Modesty
- B. Misgiving
- C. Constraint
- D. Composure

ID: 92d77da3 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because as used in the text, “reserve” most nearly means constraint, or repression of one’s behavior or actions. The text indicates that although the narrator’s landlady is ordinarily “a store-house of innocuous anecdote” who readily produces “a volume of detail” in response to questions about her acquaintances—that is, she usually tells harmless stories and is willing to share details about people she knows—she is “unexpectedly reticent,” or surprisingly unwilling to speak, when it comes to Ethan Frome. The narrator then observes that the landlady doesn’t appear to disapprove of Ethan, she simply seems completely reluctant to speak of him. In this context, then, “reserve” refers to the landlady’s constraint—her repression of her usual willingness to share details in conversation.

Choice A is incorrect. “Modesty” can refer to being appropriate in speech or behavior, and one might consider it appropriate to decline to speak of someone, but the text gives no indication that the narrator thinks the landlady is acting out of modesty. The narrator suggests that the landlady generally isn’t concerned about the appropriateness of discussing others (she’s usually “a store-house of innocuous anecdote” and shares many details) and isn’t holding back to avoid saying something negative about Ethan Frome (there’s “no hint of disapproval”); indeed, the narrator suggests he can’t tell why the landlady is so unwilling to speak of Ethan. Choice B is incorrect because the text never suggests that the landlady has any “misgiving,” or feeling of doubt or apprehension, about Ethan Frome. In fact, the text explicitly states that there is “no hint of disapproval” in her surprising unwillingness to discuss Ethan. Choice D is incorrect because the narrator doesn’t suggest that the landlady is acting with “composure,” or calmness and control of her emotions. Instead of describing the landlady’s emotional state or presenting her as calm, the narrator simply conveys her surprising unwillingness to discuss Ethan Frome.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 934aef1b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 934aef1b

In 2023 literary scholar Jeremy Douglass cautioned technology investors and enthusiasts who predict conventional books’ ultimate displacement by newer forms of media. Douglass observed that the concept of an “interactive” text is much older than technologists assume, extending back to the first time readers scratched notes into a text’s margins. In addition, newer media, such as video games, haven’t replaced older forms of entertainment, such as comic books, but rather exist alongside them. Douglass believes that rather than supplanting books, technology is simply making new forms of expression possible.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A. It challenges the stance of the investors and enthusiasts who are mentioned earlier in the text.
- B. It explains the basis for the claim made by the technologists mentioned in the text.
- C. It suggests that academics are better suited than investors to see the potential uses of contemporary interactive texts.
- D. It provides a historical anecdote about the technological challenges involved in reading the earliest interactive texts.

ID: 934aef1b Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes how the underlined portion functions in the text as a whole. The first sentence of the text introduces literary scholar Jeremy Douglass’s warning to technology investors and enthusiasts against predicting the displacement of conventional books by newer media forms. The next sentence, which is underlined in part, presents Douglass’s observation that interactive texts are hardly new; they have been available for longer than technologists assume, beginning with the first time readers wrote notes in texts’ margins. Thus, the function of the underlined portion is to challenge the stance of the technology investors and enthusiasts mentioned earlier in the text. As the remainder of the text points out, newer media doesn’t necessarily replace older media, but rather, as Douglass believes, leads to new forms of expression.

Choice B is incorrect because the underlined portion challenges the position taken by investors and enthusiasts; it doesn’t provide context for their claims. Choice C is incorrect because the underlined portion doesn’t mention academics or compare them to investors regarding their ability to see potential in using contemporary interactive texts; instead, the underlined portion challenges the position of investors and enthusiasts who predict that conventional books will be replaced by newer forms of media. Choice D is incorrect because the underlined portion doesn’t address technological challenges; instead, it disputes the stance taken by investors and enthusiasts, suggesting that conventional books haven’t been displaced by traditional interactions with texts, such as writing in the margins, and won’t be supplanted by newer forms of media either.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 56d6920b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 56d6920b

The following text is adapted from *Indian Boyhood*, a 1902 memoir by Ohiyesa (Charles A. Eastman), a Santee Dakota writer. In the text, Ohiyesa recalls how the women in his tribe harvested maple syrup during his childhood.

Now the women began to test the trees—moving leisurely among them, axe in hand, and striking a single quick blow, to see if the sap would appear. The trees, like people, have their individual characters; some were ready to yield up their life-blood, while others were more reluctant. Now one of the birchen basins was set under each tree, and a hardwood chip driven deep into the cut which the axe had made. From the corners of this chip—at first drop by drop, then more freely—the sap trickled into the little dishes.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text as a whole?

- A. It portrays the range of personality traits displayed by the women as they work.
- B. It foregrounds the beneficial relationship between humans and maple trees.
- C. It demonstrates how human behavior can be influenced by the natural environment.
- D. It elaborates on an aspect of the maple trees that the women evaluate.

ID: 56d6920b Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it best describes the function of the underlined sentence in the text’s overall portrayal of how the women in Ohiyesa’s tribe harvested maple syrup. The text states that the women used an axe to strike the maple trees in order to find out which ones would produce sap. The underlined sentence compares the trees to people, with the sap described as the trees’ “life-blood.” Some of the trees are ready to give out their sap, while others are unwilling to do so. Using personification, the sentence provides greater detail about the aspect of the maple trees—their potential to give sap—that the women are evaluating.

Choice A is incorrect because the personalities of the women are not discussed in the text. Although the underlined sentence does mention “individual characters,” this reference is not to the women in the text but rather to the maple trees, which the sentence compares to people with individual character traits. Choice B is incorrect because the underlined sentence focuses on the trees’ willingness or refusal to yield sap, not on the beneficial relationship between the women and the trees. Additionally, although the text does suggest that the women and their tribe benefit from the maple trees since the trees allow the women to harvest syrup, there is nothing in the text to suggest that the trees benefit from this relationship in turn. Choice C is incorrect because the underlined sentence is comparing maple trees to humans, not addressing the influence of the natural environment on how the actual humans in the text, the women, behave.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 21857285

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 21857285

Text 1 is adapted from E.M. Forster’s 1910 novel *Howards End*. Text 2 discusses *Howards End*. King’s Cross and St. Pancras are adjacent railway terminals in London from which trains travel to the countryside.

Text 1

To Margaret the station of King’s Cross had always suggested Infinity. Its very situation—withdrawn a little behind the facile splendours of St. Pancras—implied a comment on the materialism of life. Those two great arches, colourless, indifferent, shouldering between them an unlovely clock, were fit portals for some eternal adventure, whose issue might be prosperous, but would certainly not be expressed in the ordinary language of prosperity.

Text 2

The interplay between opposing ideological positions in *Howards End* is broadly articulated in the novel’s organization of geographic space. On the one hand, the modern metropolis of London represents capitalism’s emphasis on pragmatism and the accumulation of material wealth; on the other, the English countryside, accessible via King’s Cross, fosters an idealism that values tradition, authentic personal connection, and the aesthetic—what the novel calls “the infinite.”

Based on the texts, the author of Text 2 would most likely agree with which statement about King’s Cross, as it is depicted in Text 1?

- A. King’s Cross has a relatively unassuming appearance whose sharp contrast with the more aesthetically pleasing appearance of St. Pancras suggests to Margaret the ascendancy of the pragmatic capitalistic outlook among London’s inhabitants.
- B. Because it is situated at the beginning of Margaret’s journey from the city to the country, King’s Cross emblemizes the intrusion of the forces of materialism and modernity into the rural spaces that the novel associates with idealism and tradition.
- C. The austerity conveyed by King’s Cross’s appearance mirrors Margaret’s disillusionment with the prospect of having authentic connections with other people in a world that chiefly values more conventional forms of prosperity.
- D. As a point of connection between London and the countryside, King’s Cross suggests to Margaret the possibility of experiencing the intangible abundance promised by the kinds of authentic engagements that the novel’s rural spaces seem to offer.

ID: 21857285 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because it presents a statement about King’s Cross, as depicted in Text 1, that the author of Text 2 would most likely agree with. In Text 1, Margaret associates King’s Cross with “Infinity” and sees its arches as portals for an adventure whose value transcends London’s mundane materialism. The author of Text 2 provides an interpretation of the novel’s geography that is consistent with Margaret’s vision, explaining that London represents capitalist materialism while the

countryside—"accessible via King's Cross"—fosters idealism, authentic connection, and the aesthetic ("the infinite"). By characterizing King's Cross as a "point of connection between London and the countryside" that offers access to the "intangible abundance" promised by "the novel's rural spaces," choice D provides a reading of the railway terminal that aligns with the interpretive framework set up by the author of Text 2.

Choice A is incorrect because Margaret views King's Cross positively—as evoking infinity and eternal adventure—not as a sign of capitalism's dominance. Text 1 characterizes St. Pancras's splendors as "facile," or superficial, so that the contrast elevates King's Cross rather than signaling materialism's ascendancy. Choice B is incorrect because the author of Text 2 positions King's Cross as a gateway to the countryside's idealism, not as a vehicle for materialism intruding into rural spaces. Margaret's sense of wonder at the station arises from her sense that it offers access to the countryside's idealism rather than to London's materialism. Choice C is incorrect because nothing in Text 1 suggests Margaret is disillusioned; her perception of King's Cross is defined by expansive possibility, not resignation. Moreover, Margaret finds the austerity of King's Cross (relative to St. Pancras) appealing—its unpretentious appearance resonates with her attitude toward the "materialism of life."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 935fef97

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 935fef97

The following text is adapted from Herman Melville’s 1857 novel *The Confidence-Man*. Humphry Davy was a prominent British chemist and inventor.

Years ago, a grave American savant, being in London, observed at an evening party there, a certain coxcombical fellow, as he thought, an absurd ribbon in his lapel, and full of smart [banter], whisking about to the admiration of as many as were disposed to admire. Great was the savant’s disdain; but, chancing ere long to find himself in a corner with the jackanapes, got into conversation with him, when he was somewhat ill-prepared for the good sense of the jackanapes, but was altogether thrown aback, upon subsequently being [informed that he was] no less a personage than Sir Humphry Davy.

Which choice best states the main purpose of the text?

- A. It portrays the thoughts of a character who is embarrassed about his own behavior.
- B. It presents an account of a misunderstanding.
- C. It offers a short history of how a person came to be famous.
- D. It explains why one character dislikes another.

ID: 935fef97 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text tells a story of a first impression that turned out to be wrong: a serious American savant was dismissive of a goofy-looking, wisecracking guest at a British party, and then was shocked to learn that the guest was actually a prominent British chemist and inventor.

Choice A is incorrect. This is too strong and too narrow. Only at the very end is the savant "thrown aback" by the fact that the man was Sir Humphry Davy—he’s not "embarrassed about his own behavior." Choice C is incorrect. This isn’t the main purpose. The text never provides the history of how Sir Humphry Davy came to be famous. Nor does it provide any history for the American savant. Choice D is incorrect. This is too narrow. It doesn’t include the second half of the text, where the savant gets into a conversation with the man and then finds out that the man is Sir Humphry Davy.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4fdb40fc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 4fdb40fc

In 1891, design artist William Morris cofounded the Kelmscott Press, which printed editions of books using preindustrial methods. Historians argue that Morris’s repudiation of industrialization is _____ the Kelmscott editions’ use of handmade materials and intricate ornamentation reminiscent of medieval manuscripts: these meticulously handcrafted elements exemplify the artistry involved.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. insensible to
- B. manifest in
- C. scrutinized by
- D. complicated by

ID: 4fdb40fc Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of the Kelmscott Press’s books. In this context, "manifest in" means evident or apparent from. The text states that the Kelmscott Press, which was cofounded by William Morris, produced its books using preindustrial methods. The text notes the similarity between those methods, which include the use of handmade materials and intricate ornamentation, and methods used in the creation of medieval manuscripts. This context suggests that Morris’s repudiation of industrialization is apparent from, or manifest in, the methods and materials his company employed.

Choice A is incorrect because there is nothing in the text to suggest that Morris’s repudiation of industrialization is "insensible to," or unaware of or lacking perception of, the use of handmade materials and intricate ornamentation in the production of the Kelmscott editions. Instead, the text suggests that the methods and materials used to produce the Kelmscott editions are evidence of Morris’s repudiation of industrialization. Choice C is incorrect because it would not make sense to say that Morris’s repudiation of industrialization was "scrutinized by," or examined closely by, the Kelmscott editions’ use of handmade materials and intricate ornamentation. Although creating the Kelmscott editions may have involved examining the books closely, the text does not mention this aspect of Morris’s work, and in any case, the action of using certain materials to create those editions cannot scrutinize Morris’s attitude toward industrialization. Choice D is incorrect because the text gives no indication that Morris’s repudiation of industrialization is "complicated by," or made more complex or difficult by, the Kelmscott Press’s use of preindustrial methods and handcrafted elements to produce books. Instead, the text presents those methods as exemplifying Morris’s repudiation of industrialization.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7c43c03d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 7c43c03d

Despite potential independent confirmation, the apparent detection in 2020 of phosphine (PH₃)—a gas that on Earth almost exclusively derives from biological sources—in Venus’s cloud deck remains controversial, in part because Venus is thought to be uninhabitable. To evaluate such a finding’s plausibility, William Bains et al. modeled multiple abiotic PH₃ pathways, including geochemical, atmospheric, and photochemical reactions, but none adequately explain the observed levels of PH₃. If Venusian PH₃ does exist, it would indicate insufficiencies in the current consensus on Venus’s chemistry.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It outlines recent efforts to confirm the presence of a particular gas in Venus’s atmosphere, summarizes a research team’s evaluations of those efforts’ methodological shortcomings, and then explains why that team remains skeptical of the gas’s future detection.
- B. It explains why the consensus view of a particular gas in Venus’s atmosphere has recently become controversial, expands on a scientific team’s reasons for questioning that consensus, and then suggests that future observations of Venus’s atmosphere will likely be needed to settle the controversy.
- C. It introduces an unexpected observation of a particular gas in Venus’s atmosphere, presents an effort to investigate possible mechanisms that could explain that observation, and then notes an implication of that investigation’s findings.
- D. It compares the levels of a particular gas on Venus and Earth, sketches the chemical processes that account for differences in these levels, and then addresses some of the practical challenges of studying the presence of this gas on Venus more closely.

ID: 7c43c03d Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the overall structure of the text. The text begins by discussing the detection of phosphine gas in Venus’s atmosphere, indicating that it is unexpected because on Earth, phosphine derives from biological sources, and Venus is thought to be uninhabitable, thereby lacking in biological sources. The text then presents the effort by Bains et al. to determine whether one or more abiotic (nonbiological) pathways could explain the observed levels of phosphine on Venus, noting that none could. Finally, the text notes an implication: if phosphine exists on Venus, its presence would indicate that our current understanding of chemical processes on Venus that could produce it is inadequate. Thus, the text introduces an unexpected observation about Venus’s atmosphere, presents an effort to investigate mechanisms related to that observation, and notes an implication of that effort’s findings.

Choice A is incorrect. The text starts by mentioning that phosphine has been detected in Venus’s atmosphere. Rather than discuss whether the presence of phosphine on Venus can be confirmed, the text focuses on the efforts of one team of researchers, Bains et al., who are trying to explain the observed amount of phosphine on Venus. Furthermore, the text doesn’t suggest that the research team was skeptical about the presence of phosphine on Venus. Choice B is incorrect because, rather than indicating a consensus view about the phosphine detected on Venus, the text focuses on the fact that the detection “remains

controversial,” a framing that suggests the controversy is not a new phenomenon. The text also doesn’t suggest that future atmospheric observations would be needed to settle the controversy. There is no consensus view about the presence of phosphine on Venus. Choice D is incorrect because the text does not compare levels of phosphine on Venus with levels on Earth, nor does it address practical challenges of studying the gas on Venus.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 699dad5b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Words in Context	

ID: 699dad5b

In addition to being an accomplished psychologist himself, Francis Cecil Sumner was a _____ increasing the opportunity for Black students to study psychology, helping to found the psychology department at Howard University, a historically Black university, in 1930.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. proponent of
- B. supplement to
- C. beneficiary of
- D. distraction for

ID: 699dad5b Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most logically completes the text’s discussion of Francis Cecil Sumner. As used in this context, “proponent of” means supporter of. The text says that Sumner helped to found the psychology department at historically Black Howard University in 1930. This is evidence that Sumner supported increasing the opportunity for Black students to study psychology.

Choice B is incorrect because the phrase “supplement to,” or addition to, wouldn’t make sense in context. The text discusses Sumner’s efforts to increase the number of Black psychology students, but it doesn’t make sense to describe him as an addition to his efforts. Choice C is incorrect because Sumner was already an accomplished psychologist himself when he helped to found the Howard University psychology department. While Black students were the beneficiaries of his efforts—that is, they received help because of his efforts—it wouldn’t make sense in this context to describe Sumner as a “beneficiary of” opportunities, because he was the one doing the helping. Choice D is incorrect because founding a psychology department at Howard University wouldn’t be a “distraction for” Sumner’s aim to increase the opportunity for Black students to study psychology—that is, it wouldn’t be something that draws Sumner’s attention away from that goal, but rather the opposite.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6dc0eb4e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Cross-Text Connections	

ID: 6dc0eb4e

Text 1

Because literacy in Nahuatl script, the writing system of the Aztec Empire, was lost after Spain invaded central Mexico in the 1500s, it is unclear exactly how meaning was encoded in the script’s symbols. Although many scholars had assumed that the symbols signified entire words, linguist Alfonso Lacadena theorized in 2008 that they signified units of language smaller than words: individual syllables.

Text 2

The growing consensus among scholars of Nahuatl script is that many of its symbols could signify either words or syllables, depending on syntax and content at any given site within a text. For example, the symbol signifying the word *huipil* (blouse) in some contexts could signify the syllable “pil” in others, as in the place name “Chipiltepec.” Thus, for the Aztecs, reading required a determination of how such symbols functioned each time they appeared in a text.

Based on the texts, how would the author of Text 2 most likely characterize Lacadena’s theory, as described in Text 1?

- A. By praising the theory for recognizing that the script’s symbols could represent entire words
- B. By arguing that the theory is overly influenced by the work of earlier scholars
- C. By approving of the theory’s emphasis on how the script changed over time
- D. By cautioning that the theory overlooks certain important aspects of how the script functioned

ID: 6dc0eb4e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Lacadena’s theory is that Nahuatl script symbols signified syllables, but the consensus described in Text 2 is that they can signify either symbols or full words, depending on the context. So the author of Text 2 would likely consider Lacadena’s theory too simplistic: it’s missing the importance of the context in determining the meaning of a symbol.

Choice A is incorrect. This conflicts with Text 1’s description of Lacadena’s theory. Lacadena’s theory is that Nahuatl script symbols signified syllables. Choice B is incorrect. This conflicts with Text 1’s description of Lacadena’s theory. Text 1 states that Lacadena’s theory differed from what earlier scholars believed. Choice C is incorrect. We can’t infer that this is how the author of Text 2 would characterize Lacadena’s theory. Neither text mentions how or even if the script changed over time.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 17eda244

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: 17eda244

To produce *batik*, an Indonesian textile that originated as early as the 6th century CE, an artist creates patterns on fabric by skillfully applying wax to the surface and then dyeing it. Traditionally, the artist draws on the cloth using a *canting*, a pen-shaped tool that applies wax in fine lines or dots. To expedite this laborious process, the *cap*, a copper stamp that applies preset wax patterns, was introduced. Although the *cap* made the process of producing batiks much quicker, the *canting* is often preferred because it results in unique pieces.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the text?

- A. It introduces a traditional type of textile, suggests that it is a variation of an even older type of textile, and then explains a significant difference in how those types of textiles are produced.
- B. It establishes how a textile production technique originated, indicates how the technique has changed over time, and then suggests that renewed interest in the original technique is growing.
- C. It presents a method of textile production, identifies two approaches to that method, and then addresses the relative advantage of each approach.
- D. It conveys admiration of a certain style of textile, emphasizes the level of skill needed to produce the textile, and then urges broader recognition of the skill involved in producing the textile.

ID: 17eda244 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it most accurately describes the overall structure of the text. The text begins by describing batik fabric and the method for producing it—designs are applied in wax on the fabric, after which the fabric is dyed. The text then indicates that a “canting” (a pen-shaped tool) is traditionally used to apply the wax finely in lines or dots, and that “the cap” (a copper stamp of an entire pattern) is another, faster way to apply the wax design. Finally, the text states that the cap has the advantage of making batik production quicker, whereas a canting tends to produce a more unique design, which often makes a batik created using a canting more desirable than a mass-produced one. Thus, the text presents a method of textile production, identifies two approaches to that method, and addresses the relative advantage of each approach.

Choice A is incorrect. Although the text describes making the textile batik with a canting and with the cap, both approaches are for making the same type of textile (batik). No other type of textile is mentioned in the text. Choice B is incorrect. Although the text indicates when batik originated (perhaps the 6th century CE), it doesn’t describe how it originated. And although the text indicates that a batik created using a canting “is often preferred” over mass-produced batiks, nothing in the text suggests that this preference is a recent trend. Choice D is incorrect. Although the text indicates that the batik artists “skillfully” apply the wax designs that create the batik patterns, the overall discussion in the text describes factual aspects of the process of batik production without seeming to advocate for greater recognition of the art form.

Question ID d0cc2bf8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Craft and Structure	Text Structure and Purpose	

ID: d0cc2bf8

Individual elephants and Arctic herbivores such as caribou tend to have fixed geographic ranges throughout their lifetimes, which had prompted some researchers to speculate that the Arctic woolly mammoth, an extinct elephantid, might have exhibited similar behavior. Mammoth tusks grew in sequential layers, incorporating ingested minerals and organics, and so each ivory stratum reflects the ratio of strontium isotopes ($^{87}\text{Sr}/^{86}\text{Sr}$) in the local environment; thus, the sequence of strata shows where the animal roamed during life. Recent analysis of the strontium ratios in the strata of one Arctic woolly mammoth tusk in relation to the geographic distribution of strontium ratios in the environment shows the animal's range begin to expand as it reached sexual maturity, only to contract again in its final 1.5 years.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined statement in the text as a whole?

- A. It discusses a characteristic shared by certain animals in order to explain why researchers raised a possibility that turned out not to be supported by data described later in the text.
- B. It illustrates a pattern of behavior among certain animals in order to present a theory about exceptions to that pattern that is weakened by a finding described later in the text.
- C. It describes a similarity in the behavior of certain animals in order to show why a method described later in the text did not reveal whether another animal also showed that behavior.
- D. It introduces a trait shared by certain animals in order to contextualize a hypothesis about the origin of that trait that is advanced later in the text.

ID: d0cc2bf8 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer because it most accurately describes how the underlined statement functions in the text as a whole. The underlined statement mentions a category of animals that have a feature in common: they tend to have fixed geographic ranges throughout their lifetimes. The text then presents the speculation of some researchers that the Arctic woolly mammoth might also share this characteristic. However, an examination of the content of strontium in the strata (or layers) of a woolly mammoth tusk indicated that contrary to the researchers' hypothesis, the mammoth had an expanding range in its environment that contracted in its last 1.5 years of life. Thus, the underlined statement discusses a characteristic shared by certain animals in order to explain why researchers raised a possibility that turned out not to be supported by data described later in the text.

Choice B is incorrect. Though the underlined statement presents a pattern of behavior (the habit of certain animals of staying within a fixed geographic range), the rest of the text does not present a theory of exceptions to that pattern; rather, the researchers are merely concerned with whether one particular animal has behavior consistent with the pattern. Choice C is incorrect. Though the underlined statement does describe a similarity in the behavior of certain animals (their tendency to stay within a fixed geographic range), this is not done in order to show why a method described later in the text failed to show whether another animal showed that behavior; rather, the method of analysis of strata of a woolly mammoth tusk showed that the mammoth's

behavior was different from that of the animals mentioned in the underlined statement. Choice D is incorrect. Though the underlined statement mentions a trait shared by a number of animals (their fixed geographic range), the rest of the text does not present a hypothesis regarding the origin of that trait; rather, the researchers are concerned with whether another particular animal shares that trait.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 43942bc8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 43942bc8

If the formation of Earth’s mantle had been purely a product of core differentiation—whereby heavier elements sink toward the core and lighter elements rise—the upper mantle would be depleted of heavy siderophile elements. Siderophiles are much more abundant in the mantle than predicted in that model, however. _____ extraterrestrial material containing siderophiles, likely from asteroid or comet impacts, almost certainly accreted to Earth following core differentiation.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. That said,
- B. Hence,
- C. For example,
- D. Likewise,

ID: 43942bc8 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. "Hence" correctly signals that the claim in this sentence regarding extraterrestrial material follows logically from the information in the previous sentences. The previous sentences establish that siderophile elements in the mantle are more abundant than predicted in the core-differentiation model. This sentence claims, logically, that these elements came from extraterrestrial material that accreted to Earth *after* core differentiation.

Choice A is incorrect because "that said" illogically signals that the information in this sentence regarding extraterrestrial material is an exception to the previous information about siderophiles’ abundance in the mantle. Instead, it is a new claim that follows logically from the previous information. Choice C is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the information in this sentence regarding extraterrestrial material exemplifies the previous information about siderophiles’ abundance in the mantle. Instead, it is a new claim that follows logically from the previous information. Choice D is incorrect because "likewise" illogically signals that the information in this sentence regarding extraterrestrial material is merely similar to the previous information about siderophiles’ abundance in the mantle. Instead, it is a new claim that follows logically from the previous information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a247d90b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: a247d90b

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The melting rate of glaciers varies based on air temperature.
- In the warm summer months, massive glaciers on the coast of Greenland melt into the surrounding water.
- The melting glaciers contribute to rising sea levels each summer.
- Huge icebergs also break off Greenland’s glaciers into the water and melt.
- In 2017, geoscientist Twila Moon found that the iceberg melting rate depends not on air temperature but on water temperature.
- Because water temperature is consistent, melting icebergs contribute to rising sea levels all year.

The student wants to emphasize a similarity between glaciers and icebergs in Greenland. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Because icebergs break off Greenland’s glaciers into the water, their melting rate depends on water temperature.
- B. Greenland’s glaciers and icebergs both melt during the year, contributing to rising sea levels.
- C. Geoscientist Twila Moon found that the melting rate of Greenland’s icebergs, unlike that of glaciers, does not depend on air temperature.
- D. Glaciers on the coast of Greenland melt during the warm summer months into the surrounding water, the temperature of which remains consistent throughout the year.

ID: a247d90b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between glaciers and icebergs in Greenland, noting that both melt and thereby contribute to rising sea levels.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence provides information about the melting rate of icebergs in Greenland; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity between glaciers and icebergs in Greenland. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes a difference between glaciers and icebergs in Greenland, noting that their melting rates depend on different factors; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence explains the conditions under which glaciers in Greenland melt; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity between glaciers and icebergs in Greenland.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 015de7e0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 015de7e0

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The factors that affect clutch size (the number of eggs laid at one time) have been well studied in birds but not in lizards.
- A team led by Shai Meiri of Tel Aviv University investigated which factors influence lizard clutch size.
- Meiri’s team obtained clutch-size and habitat data for over 3,900 lizard species and analyzed the data with statistical models.
- Larger clutch size was associated with environments in higher latitudes that have more seasonal change.
- Lizards in higher-latitude environments may lay larger clutches to take advantage of shorter windows of favorable conditions.

The student wants to emphasize the aim of the research study. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Researchers wanted to know which factors influence lizard egg clutch size because such factors have been well studied in birds but not in lizards.
- B. After they obtained data for over 3,900 lizard species, researchers determined that larger clutch size was associated with environments in higher latitudes that have more seasonal change.
- C. We now know that lizards in higher-latitude environments may lay larger clutches to take advantage of shorter windows of favorable conditions.
- D. Researchers obtained clutch-size and habitat data for over 3,900 lizard species and analyzed the data with statistical models.

ID: 015de7e0 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the aim of the research study by highlighting what the researchers conducting the study wanted to know—specifically, which factors influence clutch size among lizards.

Choice B is incorrect because the sentence emphasizes what researchers determined at the end of the study, not what the study’s aim was. Choice C is incorrect because the sentence emphasizes a finding from the research study, not the aim of the study. Choice D is incorrect because the sentence emphasizes the research study’s methodology, not its aim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 670150dd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 670150dd

When, in the 1800s, geologists first realized that much of Earth had once been covered by great sheets of ice, some theorized that the phenomenon was cyclical, occurring at regular intervals. Each Ice Age is so destructive, though, that it largely erases the geological evidence of its predecessor. _____ geologists were unable to confirm the theory of cyclical Ice Ages until the 1960s.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Hence,
- B. Moreover,
- C. Nevertheless,
- D. Next,

ID: 670150dd Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “Hence” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that geologists couldn’t confirm the theory of cyclical Ice Ages until the 1960s—is a consequence of the previous information about the destructiveness of each Ice Age and the erasure of necessary geological evidence.

Choice B is incorrect because “moreover” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is merely additional to the previous information about the destructiveness of each Ice Age. Instead, the sentence identifies a specific consequence of that information. Choice C is incorrect because “nevertheless” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is true despite the previous information about the destructiveness of each Ice Age. Instead, the sentence identifies a specific consequence of that information. Choice D is incorrect because “next” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is the next step in a process. Instead, the sentence identifies a specific consequence of the previous information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4c435b31

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 4c435b31

In 2009, the Craft and Folk Art Museum in Los Angeles hosted a special exhibition, *Sueños/Yume*, showcasing the works of local sculptor Dora de Larios. As suggested by the show’s title (*sueños* and *yume* mean “dreams” in Spanish and Japanese, respectively), de Larios’s art reflects a mix of cultural influences. _____ her work is grounded in the artistic traditions of both Mexico and Japan.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. In addition,
- B. In contrast,
- C. Specifically,
- D. Therefore,

ID: 4c435b31 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. “Specifically” logically signals that this sentence provides specific, precise details elaborating on the previous sentence’s claim that de Larios’s art reflects a mix of cultures. This sentence specifies which cultures the previous sentence is referring to: the artistic traditions of both Mexico and Japan.

Choice A is incorrect because “in addition” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a separate point that follows the previous claim about de Larios’s art. Instead, it provides specific details elaborating on that claim. Choice B is incorrect because “in contrast” illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the previous claim about de Larios’s art. Instead, it provides specific details elaborating on that claim. Choice D is incorrect because “therefore” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result of the previous claim about de Larios’s art. Instead, it provides specific details elaborating on that claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dc6f6daa

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: dc6f6daa

Mary Ellen Pleasant, a successful entrepreneur during the gold rush era, earned the moniker “Mother of Human Rights in California” after successfully challenging discrimination in the state. _____ in 1866, she sued a streetcar company for denying her and other Black riders service, a suit she eventually won when the California Supreme Court declared it illegal for carriers to exclude passengers based on race.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. For this reason,
- B. Then,
- C. In addition,
- D. Specifically,

ID: dc6f6daa Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "Specifically" logically signals that the information about Pleasant’s 1866 lawsuit provides specific, precise details elaborating on the previous point that Pleasant successfully challenged discrimination in California.

Choice A is incorrect because "for this reason" illogically signals that Pleasant’s 1866 lawsuit was a result of her successful challenge to discrimination in California. Instead, this sentence provides specific details elaborating on her challenge to discrimination in the state. Choice B is incorrect because "then" illogically signals that Pleasant’s 1866 lawsuit was subsequent to or resulted from her successful challenge to discrimination in California. Instead, this sentence provides specific, precise details elaborating on how she challenged discrimination in the state. Choice C is incorrect because "in addition" illogically signals that the information about Pleasant’s 1866 lawsuit is merely additional to the previous point that Pleasant successfully challenged discrimination in California. Instead, this sentence provides specific details elaborating on how she did so.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d51ea585

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: d51ea585

In a 2022 analysis of 200 terms, researchers found a broad pattern of valence-dependent mutation for which negative words saw a faster rate of cognate replacement—_____ the rate at which a word will be replaced over time with a noncognate form. Adjectives (e.g., “afraid”) saw the largest effect; nouns (e.g., “attack”), meanwhile, saw the smallest.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. for example,
- B. likewise,
- C. in addition,
- D. that is,

ID: d51ea585 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "That is" logically signals that the information that follows in the sentence clarifies a term used in the previous discussion of the researchers’ findings: cognate replacement.

Choice A is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the information that follows in the sentence provides a specific example of the research findings described earlier. Instead, it clarifies a term introduced earlier in the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because "likewise" illogically signals that the information that follows in the sentence is similar to the previous information about the researchers’ findings. Instead, it clarifies a term introduced earlier in the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because "in addition" illogically signals that the information that follows in the sentence merely adds to the previous information about the researchers’ findings. Instead, it clarifies a term introduced earlier in the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a4bd9315

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: a4bd9315

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 1851, German American artist Emanuel Leutze painted *Washington Crossing the Delaware*.
- His huge painting (149 × 255 inches) depicts the first US president crossing a river with soldiers in the Revolutionary War.
- In 2019, Cree artist Kent Monkman painted *mistikôsiwak (Wooden Boat People): Resurgence of the People*.
- Monkman’s huge painting (132 × 264 inches) was inspired by Leutze’s.
- It portrays Indigenous people in a boat rescuing refugees.

The student wants to emphasize a similarity between the two paintings. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Monkman, a Cree artist, finished his painting in 2019; Leutze, a German American artist, completed his in 1851.
- B. Although Monkman’s painting was inspired by Leutze’s, the people and actions the two paintings portray are very different.
- C. Leutze’s and Monkman’s paintings are both huge, measuring 149 × 255 inches and 132 × 264 inches, respectively.
- D. Leutze’s painting depicts Revolutionary War soldiers, while Monkman’s depicts Indigenous people and refugees.

ID: a4bd9315 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the two paintings, noting that Leutze’s painting (which measures 149 × 255 inches) and Monkman’s painting (which measures 132 × 264 inches) are both very large.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence mentions that Monkman’s painting was completed in 2019 and Leutze’s was completed in 1851; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity between the two paintings. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence acknowledges that one painting was inspired by the other, it emphasizes differences between the two paintings; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity between them. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence mentions a difference between the two paintings; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity between them.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 48677ab6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 48677ab6

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In geology, an Aeolian landform is one that has been created by the wind.
- In Greek mythology, Aeolus is the keeper of the winds.
- Aeolian landforms are created when the wind erodes, transports, or deposits material.
- A mushroom rock is a rock formation in which the top is wider than the base.
- A mushroom rock can be formed when the wind erodes the base and the top at different rates.

The student wants to provide an explanation and an example of Aeolian landforms. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Aeolian landforms are created by different wind-based processes; for example, some are created by wind erosion.
- B. Aeolian landforms—landforms created by the wind—include the mushroom rock, a rock formation in which the wind erodes the base of the rock faster than the top.
- C. Erosion, transportation, and deposition are three examples of how the wind can create Aeolian landforms and mushroom rocks.
- D. A mushroom rock is a rock formation that owes its shape to the wind, a natural force associated with Aeolus in Greek mythology.

ID: 48677ab6 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence provides an explanation and an example of Aeolian landforms, explaining that they are landforms created by wind and offering the mushroom rock as an example.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence explains that Aeolian landforms are created by wind but does not provide an example of any specific Aeolian landforms. Rather, the example it provides is of a wind-based process. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence provides a partial explanation of Aeolian landforms, noting that they are created by the wind, it does not effectively provide an example. The sentence seems to indicate that mushroom rocks, rather than being an example of Aeolian landforms, are distinct from them. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence provides an explanation of a mushroom rock, which is a specific example of an Aeolian landform, it doesn't provide an explanation of Aeolian landforms in general.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b4bfb7d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: b4bfb7d

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Archaeologist Jon Erlandson and colleagues argue that humans first arrived in the Americas by sea.
- They propose that humans traveled between Pacific Ocean islands and coastlines from northeast Asia to the Americas.
- Many of these islands and coastal zones were later submerged as glaciers melted and sea levels rose.
- The researchers think that “a coastal route, including kelp forests and estuaries, would have provided a rich mix of marine, estuarine, riverine, and terrestrial resources” such as seaweeds, fish, and birds.
- This proposed scenario is known as the kelp highway hypothesis.

The student wants to summarize the kelp highway hypothesis. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Pacific Ocean islands and coastlines likely contained “a rich mix of marine, estuarine, riverine, and terrestrial resources” such as seaweeds, fish, and birds, according to researchers.
- B. One argument about how humans first arrived in the Americas is the kelp highway hypothesis proposed by Jon Erlandson and colleagues.
- C. Humans may have first arrived in the Americas by sea, traveling between Pacific Ocean islands and coastlines and subsisting on a variety of resources.
- D. As glaciers melted and sea levels rose, many Pacific Ocean islands and coastal zones were submerged.

ID: b4bfb7d Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. This choice summarizes the main idea of the kelp highway hypothesis, providing a high-level overview of how the hypothesis explains human migration to the Americas.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice describes one aspect of the proposed scenario but doesn’t discuss human migration, which is the main focus of the kelp highway hypothesis. Choice B is incorrect. This choice introduces the kelp highway hypothesis but doesn’t explain what it entails. Choice D is incorrect. This choice describes one element of the proposed scenario but doesn’t discuss human migration, which is the main focus of the kelp highway hypothesis.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b90e67d3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: b90e67d3

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Gravitational waves are powerful ripples that originate in deep space and eventually pass through Earth.
- The Laser Interferometer Gravitational Wave Observatory (LIGO) is a physics study that began in 2002.
- LIGO’s goal is to detect and analyze gravitational waves.
- LIGO uses a pair of massive gravitational wave detectors called interferometers that are thousands of miles apart.
- In 2015, for the first time in history, LIGO researchers detected a gravitational wave passing through Earth.

The student wants to present LIGO’s aim and methodology. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. In 2015, LIGO’s massive interferometers detected a powerful ripple that originated in deep space and eventually passed through Earth.
- B. Though the physics study LIGO began in 2002, its massive interferometers didn’t detect a gravitational wave until 2015.
- C. To achieve its aims, LIGO uses a pair of massive interferometers that are thousands of miles apart.
- D. A physics study designed to detect and analyze gravitational waves, LIGO uses a pair of massive interferometers that are thousands of miles apart.

ID: b90e67d3 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence effectively presents the LIGO study’s aim, noting that it is designed to detect and analyze gravitational waves, and its methodology (it uses two interferometers to detect the waves).

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes a finding from the LIGO study; it doesn’t effectively present the study’s aim or its methodology. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence provides background information about the LIGO study’s timeline; it doesn’t effectively present the study’s aim or its methodology. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence touches on LIGO’s methodology, noting that it uses two interferometers, but doesn’t indicate what the study’s aims are.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ef4dd7a4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: ef4dd7a4

In astrophysics, a ring of debris orbiting a larger object within the object’s Roche limit is expected to persist as a ring, whereas a ring of debris orbiting outside this limit would likely accrete into a satellite (e.g., a moon). Bruno Morgado and colleagues, _____ detected a dense ring of material orbiting the trans-Neptunian object Quaoar at a distance of 2,500 miles, well outside the calculated Roche limit of 1,100 miles, that has remained intact.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. though,
- B. for example,
- C. fittingly,
- D. likewise,

ID: ef4dd7a4 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “Though” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Morgado and colleagues detected a dense ring orbiting outside the Roche limit that remained intact—presents an exception to the previous sentence’s claim about debris orbiting outside an object’s Roche limit. Such debris would be expected to accrete into a satellite, not remain intact as a ring.

Choice B is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the information about Morgado’s discovery exemplifies the previous sentence’s claim about debris orbiting outside an object’s Roche limit. Instead, the sentence presents an exception to the claim. Choice C is incorrect because “fittingly” illogically signals that the information about Morgado’s discovery aligns with the previous sentence’s claim about debris orbiting outside an object’s Roche limit. Instead, the sentence presents an exception to the claim. Choice D is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the information about Morgado’s discovery is similar to the previous sentence’s claim about debris orbiting outside an object’s Roche limit. Instead, the sentence presents an exception to the claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b4447c13

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: b4447c13

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two opposing theories of vision divided scholars for many centuries.
- The ancient Greek mathematician Euclid (circa 300 BCE) supported the extramission theory.
- This theory held that the eyes emit a form of radiation that illuminates objects in its range.
- The ancient Greek philosopher Aristotle (384–322 BCE) supported the intromission theory.
- This theory held that objects emit a form of radiation that reaches the eyes.
- In the eleventh century, Arab mathematician Ibn al-Haytham (965–1040 CE) largely settled the debate with the first conclusive experiments supporting intromission.

The student wants to provide a historical overview of the two theories. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Scholars were divided between the extramission and intromission theories of vision until Ibn al-Haytham’s eleventh-century experiments largely settled the debate in support of intromission.
- B. Through two opposing theories of vision—extramission and intromission—Euclid, Aristotle, and Ibn al-Haytham held that a form of radiation is emitted either from objects or from the eyes.
- C. While Ibn al-Haytham largely settled the debate in the eleventh century, Aristotle supported the theory of intromission centuries before.
- D. Before the eleventh century, the ancient Greek philosopher Aristotle supported the intromission theory, which held that objects emit a form of radiation that reaches the eyes.

ID: b4447c13 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence provides a historical overview of the two theories, noting that scholars were divided between them before Ibn al-Haytham’s experiments supporting intromission largely settled the debate in the eleventh century.

Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence identifies the two theories and the scholars that supported them, it doesn’t provide a historical overview of the theories. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence indicates Aristotle supported intromission theory centuries before Ibn al-Haytham settled the debate, it doesn’t mention extramission theory or provide a historical overview of both theories. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence provides information about intromission theory but doesn’t mention extramission theory or provide a historical overview of both theories.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e25284d4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: e25284d4

Charles Demuth’s 1931 painting *Chimney and Water Tower* is a classic Precisionist work. The Precisionists strove for cold, machine-like perfection, with crisp lines, geometric shapes, and smooth, brushstroke-free surfaces. _____ Precisionist works often feature skyscrapers, bridges, and factories, highlighting these angular structures’ engineered symmetry.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Accordingly,
- B. In the end,
- C. That said,
- D. However,

ID: e25284d4 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “Accordingly” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Precisionist works often feature angular, symmetrical structures, such as skyscrapers, bridges, and factories—is in accordance with the previous claim about the Precisionist style of “cold, machine-like perfection, with crisp lines, geometric shapes, and smooth, brushstroke-free surfaces.”

Choice B is incorrect because “in the end” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a final conclusion or summary of the previous claim about the Precisionist style. Instead, the sentence describes features in Precisionist works that are in accordance with that style. Choice C is incorrect because “that said” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is an exception to or qualification of the previous claim about the Precisionist style. Instead, the sentence describes features in Precisionist works that are in accordance with that style. Choice D is incorrect because “however” illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the previous claim about the Precisionist style. Instead, the sentence describes features in Precisionist works that are in accordance with that style.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b3e8d221

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: b3e8d221

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The meter of a poem is the rhythmic structure or pattern of accents in its lines.
- Alliterative meter is structured by a pattern of repeated sounds.
- Quantitative meter is structured by a pattern of long and short syllables.
- The Old English poem *Widsith* uses an alliterative meter.
- The Sanskrit poem *Meghadūta* uses a quantitative meter.

The student wants to emphasize a difference between the meters of the two poems. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The poem *Widsith* is written in Old English, but *Meghadūta* is written in Sanskrit.
- B. Alliterative meter is a pattern of repeated sounds, but quantitative meter is a rhythmic structure or pattern of accents.
- C. The Sanskrit poem *Meghadūta* uses a quantitative meter, while the meter of the Old English poem *Widsith* uses a pattern of long and short syllables.
- D. The lines of the poem *Meghadūta* use a pattern of long and short syllables, whereas *Widsith*’s lines use a pattern of repeated sounds.

ID: b3e8d221 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Noting that *Meghadūta* uses a pattern of long and short syllables in its lines (quantitative meter) and *Widsith* uses a pattern of repeated sounds in its lines (alliterative meter), and signaling a contrast with “whereas,” the sentence emphasizes a difference between the meters of the two poems.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence indicates that the two poems were written in different languages; it doesn’t emphasize a difference between the meters of the two poems. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence mentions the meters of the two poems but misrepresents information from the notes; the overall definition of a meter (the rhythmic structure or pattern of accents in a poem’s lines) applies to both alliterative and quantitative meters, not just quantitative. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence emphasizes a difference between the meters of the two poems, it misrepresents information from the notes; *Widsith* uses an alliterative meter, which is structured by a pattern of repeated sounds, not a pattern of long and short syllables.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0d625e09

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 0d625e09

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Cambodia’s Angkor Wat was built in the 1100s to honor the Hindu god Vishnu.
- It has been a Buddhist temple since the sixteenth century.
- Decorrelation stretch analysis is a novel digital imaging technique that enhances the contrast between colors in a photograph.
- Archaeologist Noel Hidalgo Tan applied decorrelation stretch analysis to photographs he had taken of Angkor Wat’s plaster walls.
- Tan’s analysis revealed hundreds of images unknown to researchers.

The student wants to present Tan’s research to an audience unfamiliar with Angkor Wat. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Tan photographed Angkor Wat’s plaster walls and then applied decorrelation stretch analysis to the photographs.
- B. Decorrelation stretch analysis is a novel digital imaging technique that Tan used to enhance the contrast between colors in a photograph.
- C. Using a novel digital imaging technique, Tan revealed hundreds of images hidden on the walls of Angkor Wat, a Cambodian temple.
- D. Built to honor a Hindu god before becoming a Buddhist temple, Cambodia’s Angkor Wat concealed hundreds of images on its plaster walls.

ID: 0d625e09 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence effectively presents Tan’s research to an audience unfamiliar with Angkor Wat, explaining the results of the research and identifying Angkor Wat as a temple in Cambodia.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence presents Tan’s research, it fails to explain what Angkor Wat is for an audience unfamiliar with the temple. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the role that decorrelation stretch analysis played in Tan’s research; it doesn’t present the research, which would require specifying where it was conducted. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence explains what Angkor Wat is, it fails to present Tan’s research.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cccce93e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: cccce93e

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- John Carver was one of the 41 signatories of the Mayflower Compact.
- The Mayflower Compact was a legal agreement among the pilgrims that immigrated to Plymouth Colony.
- It was created in 1620 to establish a common government.
- It states that the pilgrims who signed it wanted to “plant the first colony in the northern parts of Virginia” under King James.
- Carver became the first governor of Plymouth Colony.

The student wants to specify the reason the Mayflower Compact was created. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Stating that its signatories wanted to “plant the first colony in the northern parts of Virginia,” the Mayflower Compact was a legal agreement among the pilgrims that immigrated to Plymouth Colony.
- B. Created in 1620, the Mayflower Compact states that the pilgrims wanted to “plant the first colony in the northern parts of Virginia.”
- C. The Mayflower Compact was created to establish a common government among the pilgrims that immigrated to Plymouth Colony.
- D. The Mayflower Compact had 41 signatories, including John Carver, the first governor of Plymouth Colony.

ID: cccce93e Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence specifies the reason the Mayflower Compact was created, noting that it was created to establish a common government among the pilgrims that immigrated to Plymouth Colony.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence provides background information about the Mayflower Compact and notes the signatories’ goal for the colony, it doesn’t specify why the compact was created. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence provides background information about the Mayflower Compact and notes the signatories’ goal for the colony, it doesn’t specify why the compact was created. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence specifies the number of pilgrims that signed the Mayflower Compact; it doesn’t specify the reason the compact was created.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 29bd8a46

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 29bd8a46

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Leaders of the Province of Guatemala proclaimed independence for Central America from the Spanish Empire on September 15, 1821.
- The accompanying Declaration of Independence was written by Honduran scholar and politician José Cecilio del Valle.
- The 1812 Spanish Constitution had provided some degree of independence for Central America, but it was repealed by the Spanish king in 1814.
- Valle, a loyal advisor to the Spanish Empire’s administrators in Central America, had long opposed independence.
- He changed his mind after Colonel Rafael del Riego’s 1820 revolt, which demanded the return of rights lost in 1814.

The student wants to place the 1821 Declaration of Independence in the context of Valle’s changing political beliefs. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Colonel Riego’s revolt was the inspiration that Valle, a long-standing opponent of Central American independence, needed to change his political beliefs.
- B. Long an opponent of Central American independence, Valle changed his mind after an 1820 revolt and wrote the 1821 declaration.
- C. A change in Valle’s political beliefs that occurred when the Spanish king repealed the 1812 constitution led to Valle writing Central America’s Declaration of Independence.
- D. The writing of Central America’s Declaration of Independence may not have happened were it not for Colonel Riego’s 1820 revolt.

ID: 29bd8a46 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence places the Declaration of Independence in the context of Valle’s changing political beliefs, noting that Valle was long an opponent of Central American independence but changed his mind after an 1820 revolt and then wrote the Declaration of Independence in 1821.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence states that Valle’s political beliefs changed after Riego’s revolt but doesn’t indicate how these changed beliefs provide context for the 1821 Declaration of Independence. Choice C is incorrect because it misrepresents information from the notes. Valle’s political beliefs changed after Riego’s 1820 revolt, not when the Spanish king repealed the 1812 constitution. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence indicates a relationship between Colonel Riego’s 1820 revolt and Central America’s Declaration of Independence, it doesn’t mention Valle’s changing political beliefs.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e9fc1b36

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: e9fc1b36

In the late twentieth century, scholars directed much discussion toward issues of spatiality. Adherents to quantitative analytical approaches delineated space with the use of GIS spatial technologies; _____ cultural geographer Doreen Massey defined space as the product of “an ever-shifting social geometry of power and signification,” focusing instead on socio-political forces.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. for example,
- B. by contrast,
- C. as such,
- D. likewise,

ID: e9fc1b36 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. "By contrast" logically signals that the information about how Massey defined space—by focusing on socio-political forces—contrasts with the information in the previous clause, which discusses quantitative analytical approaches and spatial technologies.

Choice A is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the information that follows in the sentence exemplifies the quantitative analytical approaches to defining space described previously. Instead, the information about Massey’s socio-political focus presents a contrasting approach. Choice C is incorrect because "as such" illogically signals that the information that follows in the sentence is a direct result or logical consequence of the quantitative analytical approaches to defining space described previously. Instead, the information about Massey’s socio-political focus presents a contrasting approach. Choice D is incorrect because "likewise" illogically signals that the information that follows in the sentence is similar to the quantitative analytical approaches to defining space described previously. Instead, the information about Massey’s socio-political focus presents a contrasting approach.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 35cbd6ec

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 35cbd6ec

Seismologists Kaiqing Yuan and Barbara Romanowicz have proposed that the magma fueling Iceland’s more than 30 active volcano systems emerges from deep within Earth. The great depths involved—nearly 3,000 km—mark Iceland’s volcanoes as extreme outliers; _____ many of Earth’s volcanoes are fed by shallow pockets of magma found less than 15 km below the surface.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. indeed,
- B. nevertheless,
- C. in addition,
- D. consequently,

ID: 35cbd6ec Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The second part of the sentence says that many volcanoes use shallow pockets of magma. This is an elaboration of the same underlying idea from the first part of the sentence, which says that the super deep magma of Icelandic volcanoes’ makes them outliers. “Indeed” is a transition used for elaborating on the same idea, so it fits the context perfectly.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice uses a disagreement transition. But these two parts of the sentence agree with each other, so “nevertheless” doesn’t make sense. Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates the addition of a new idea. But the second part of the sentence isn’t adding a new idea: it’s elaborating on the same idea expressed in the first part of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses a cause-and-effect transition, which doesn’t make sense here. The fact that Iceland’s deep-magma volcanoes are outliers doesn’t cause many other volcanoes to get fed by shallow pockets of magma.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 92d0f66d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 92d0f66d

When one looks at the dark craggy vistas in Hitoshi Fugo’s evocative photo series, one’s mind might wander off to the cratered surfaces of faraway planets. _____ it’s the series’ title, *Flying Frying Pan*, that brings one back to Earth, reminding the viewer that each photo is actually a close-up view of a familiar household object: a frying pan.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Consequently,
- B. Alternatively,
- C. Ultimately,
- D. Additionally,

ID: 92d0f66d Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The first sentence describes an experience that the viewer has when they’re looking at the photos: they imagine other planets. This sentence describes an experience that the viewer has afterward: the title reminds them that the photos are of frying pans, bringing them back to reality. “Ultimately” is a transition that means “eventually” or “in the end,” so it fits the context perfectly.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice uses a cause-and-effect transition, which doesn’t make sense here. The viewer imagining other planets when they’re looking at the photos doesn’t cause the title to bring them back to reality. Choice B is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates another option or possibility, which doesn’t make sense here. Rather, the viewer has both experiences: first the viewer imagines that they’re looking at another planet, and then the title reminds them that it’s just a frying pan. Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates the addition of an agreeing idea. But the viewer’s experience in the second sentence is actually the opposite of the viewer’s experience in the first sentence. In the first sentence, the viewer is imagining that they’re seeing a landscape from another planet. In the second sentence, the viewer is reminded that they’re looking at a frying pan.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7a327c16

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 7a327c16

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Modularity of mind is the notion that the mind is at least partly composed of innate neural structures (modules) that perform fast, necessary tasks.
- 1983: cognitive scientist Jerry A. Fodor hypothesized that low-level cognitive systems (e.g., perception, language) are modular.
- In Fodorian modularity, high-level systems (e.g., reasoning) are not modular.
- 2003: cognitive scientist Peter Carruthers proposed the massive modularity hypothesis (MMH).
- MMH expands modularity to include all cognitive systems.

The student wants to compare Fodor’s hypothesis with Carruthers’s. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. In considering some but not all cognitive systems modular, Fodorian modularity is not as expansive in its definition of modularity as MMH is.
- B. Following Fodor’s 1983 hypothesis, Carruthers proposed that modularity of mind includes all cognitive systems.
- C. The hypotheses of Fodor and Carruthers differ in whether they consider low-level cognitive systems, such as perception and language, modular.
- D. In 2003, Carruthers proposed the massive modularity hypothesis, disagreeing with Fodor’s earlier hypothesis that the mind is composed of innate neural structures.

ID: 7a327c16 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence compares Fodor’s hypothesis with Carruthers’s, noting that because Fodorian modularity considers some but not all cognitive systems modular, it is not as expansive in its definition of modularity as Carruthers’s MMH, which includes all cognitive systems.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence describes Carruthers’s hypothesis—that modularity of mind includes all cognitive systems—but indicates only that this hypothesis followed Fodor’s 1983 hypothesis rather than making a comparison between the hypotheses. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents a difference between Fodor’s and Carruthers’s hypotheses. According to the information in the notes, both Fodor and Carruthers consider low-level cognitive systems modular, and their difference lies in whether they also consider high-level systems modular. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents a difference between Fodor’s and Carruthers’s hypotheses. According to the information in the notes, both Fodor and Carruthers consider the mind to be at least partly composed of innate neural structures (modules). Their difference lies in whether they consider high-level systems modular.

Question ID f7167cdb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: f7167cdb

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The fifth Solvay Conference on Physics was held in 1927.
- It brought together twenty-nine of the era’s preeminent scientists to discuss the emerging field of quantum theory.
- The conference famously featured a debate between physicists Albert Einstein and Niels Bohr.
- Bohr proposed that subatomic entities like electrons had only probable realities until they were observed.
- Einstein argued that subatomic entities like electrons had a reality independent of observation.
- Bohr’s position, later called the Copenhagen interpretation, remains the most widely accepted theory of quantum mechanics.

The student wants to place Einstein’s argument within its historical context. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. During the dawn of quantum theory, Einstein maintained the independent reality of some subatomic entities, although Bohr’s opposing interpretation would become the widely accepted view.
- B. At the 1927 Solvay Conference on Physics, Einstein disagreed with Bohr’s argument that subatomic entities like electrons had a reality independent of observation.
- C. The attendees of the 1927 Solvay Conference were among the preeminent scientists of their era, including Einstein, who opposed Bohr’s proposal.
- D. In 1927, Einstein and Bohr engaged in a famous debate; Bohr’s argument, later called the Copenhagen interpretation, would remain popular decades after.

ID: f7167cdb Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence places Einstein’s argument within the historical context of the development of quantum theory, noting that his argument—made during the dawn of the field—conflicted with Bohr’s argument, which became the widely accepted view.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents information from the notes, attributing the argument that electrons had a reality independent of observation to Bohr, not Einstein. In addition, while the sentence provides the date of the conference, it doesn’t place Einstein’s argument in the context of the development of quantum theory. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence indicates that Einstein attended the 1927 Solvay Conference; it doesn’t identify Einstein’s argument or place it in the historical context of the development of quantum theory. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence explains that Einstein and Bohr had a famous debate in 1927 and that Bohr’s argument remained popular decades afterward; it doesn’t identify Einstein’s argument or place it in the context of the development of quantum theory.

Question ID 7c7c053e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 7c7c053e

Economist Elinor Ostrom’s studies of communities around the world have empirically demonstrated that common pool resources, such as grazing lands, can be sustainably managed by the people who use them (rather than through private entities or centralized governments). _____ Ostrom’s work is a repudiation of the “tragedy of the commons,” the view that individuals will inevitably overexploit a finite shared resource if given unfettered access to it.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. By contrast,
- B. For example,
- C. That said,
- D. As such,

ID: 7c7c053e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "As such" correctly signals that the claim in this sentence—that Ostrom’s work is a repudiation of the "tragedy of the commons" view—follows logically from the information about Ostrom’s studies in the previous sentence. According to that sentence, Ostrom’s studies demonstrate that common pool resources can in fact be sustainably managed by the people who use them.

Choice A is incorrect because "by contrast" illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the information about Ostrom’s studies in the previous sentence. Instead, the claim that Ostrom’s work repudiates the "tragedy of the commons" view follows logically from that information. Choice B is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the claim in this sentence exemplifies the information about Ostrom’s studies in the previous sentence. Instead, the claim that Ostrom’s work repudiates the "tragedy of the commons" view follows logically from that information. Choice C is incorrect because "that said" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is an exception or caveat to the information about Ostrom’s studies in the previous sentence. Instead, the claim that Ostrom’s work repudiates the "tragedy of the commons" view follows logically from that information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ecf184ed

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: ecf184ed

Upon first approaching artist Kurt Wenner’s *Dies Irae*, a colorful scene painted on the surface of a cobblestone street in Mantua, Italy, one might assume a deep hole filled with life-sized, classically styled sculptures had opened up in the street. _____ by expertly applying the principles of perspective, Wenner created merely the illusion of depth.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Additionally,
- B. On the contrary,
- C. As a result,
- D. Next,

ID: ecf184ed Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. "On the contrary" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that *Dies Irae*’s appearance of depth is merely an illusion—contrasts with the previous statement about a viewer’s possible assumption regarding the street painting.

Choice A is incorrect because "additionally" illogically signals that this sentence is simply additional information about a viewer’s possible assumption regarding the street painting. Instead, the information about how Wenner achieved the illusion of depth contrasts with the previous sentence’s description of the illusion. Choice C is incorrect because "as a result" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result of, or caused by, a viewer’s possible assumption regarding the street painting. Instead, the information about how Wenner achieved the illusion of depth contrasts with the previous sentence’s description of the illusion. Choice D is incorrect because "next" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is the next step in a process. Instead, the information about how Wenner achieved the illusion of depth contrasts with the previous sentence’s description of the illusion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9349cbaa

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 9349cbaa

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Soo Sunny Park is a Korean American artist who uses light as her primary medium of expression.
- She created her work *Unwoven Light* in 2013.
- *Unwoven Light* featured a chain-link fence fitted with iridescent plexiglass tiles.
- When light passed through the fence, colorful prisms formed.

The student wants to describe *Unwoven Light* to an audience unfamiliar with Soo Sunny Park. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Park’s 2013 installation *Unwoven Light*, which included a chain-link fence and iridescent tiles made from plexiglass, featured light as its primary medium of expression.
- B. Korean American light artist Soo Sunny Park created *Unwoven Light* in 2013.
- C. The chain-link fence in Soo Sunny Park’s *Unwoven Light* was fitted with tiles made from iridescent plexiglass.
- D. In *Unwoven Light*, a 2013 work by Korean American artist Soo Sunny Park, light formed colorful prisms as it passed through a fence Park had fitted with iridescent tiles.

ID: 9349cbaa Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence effectively describes *Unwoven Light* to an audience unfamiliar with Park, noting that Soo Sunny Park is a Korean American artist and that the 2013 work consists of colorful prisms formed by light passing through iridescent tiles.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes aspects of *Unwoven Light* but doesn’t mention who Park is; it thus doesn’t effectively describe the work to an audience unfamiliar with Park. Choice B is incorrect. Although the sentence indicates when the work was created and who Park is, it lacks descriptive details and thus doesn’t effectively describe *Unwoven Light*. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence mentions Park and describes an aspect of *Unwoven Light*—the chain-link fence—but doesn’t effectively describe the overall work to an audience unfamiliar with the artist.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7955038f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 7955038f

With her room-sized installation *The Interstitium*, Iranian American artist Laleh Mehran succeeded in creating a space that felt, as intended, both “familiar and distant.” _____ with a video screen placed at the far end of the coal slag-encrusted room, her installation was reminiscent of a typical movie theater—albeit one found in a subterranean coal mine.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Next,
- B. Nevertheless,
- C. Indeed,
- D. Instead,

ID: 7955038f Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "Indeed" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Laleh Mehran’s installation resembled both a typical movie theater and a coal mine—supports the previous sentence’s claim that the space Mehran created felt both "familiar and distant."

Choice A is incorrect because "next" illogically signals that the description of Laleh Mehran’s installation in this sentence is the next step in a process. Rather, it supports the previous sentence’s claim about Mehran’s installation. Choice B is incorrect because "nevertheless" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is true despite the claim about Laleh Mehran’s installation in the previous sentence. Rather, it supports that claim. Choice D is incorrect because "instead" illogically signals that this sentence presents an alternative to the previous sentence’s claim about Laleh Mehran’s installation. Rather, it supports that claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d5608759

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: d5608759

The more diverse and wide ranging an animal’s behaviors, the larger and more energy demanding the animal’s brain tends to be. _____ from an evolutionary perspective, animals that perform only basic actions should allocate fewer resources to growing and maintaining brain tissue. The specialized subtypes of ants within colonies provide an opportunity to explore this hypothesis.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Subsequently,
- B. Besides,
- C. Nevertheless,
- D. Thus,

ID: d5608759 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “Thus” logically signals that the claim in this sentence—that animals performing only basic actions should allocate relatively few resources to their brain tissue—is a consequence of the previous sentence’s claim about the energy demands of animal brains (namely, that the more diverse an animal’s behaviors, the more energy its brain needs).

Choice A is incorrect because “subsequently” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence occurs later in a chronological sequence of events than the previous sentence’s claim about the energy demands of animal brains. Instead, the second claim is a consequence of the first. Choice B is incorrect because “besides” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence provides a separate point in addition to, or apart from, the previous sentence’s claim about the energy demands of animal brains. Instead, the second claim is a consequence of the first. Choice C is incorrect because “nevertheless” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence is true in spite of the previous sentence’s claim about the energy demands of animal brains. Instead, the second claim is a consequence of the first.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 22372289

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 22372289

A research team led by Gal Badihi has discovered that chimpanzees communicate through exchanges of gestures occurring at a pace similar to that of human conversations. _____ chimpanzee gesture exchanges have short pauses of about 120 milliseconds between communications, comparable to the 200-millisecond average pause between turns in human speech.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. As a result,
- B. Specifically,
- C. By contrast,
- D. Nevertheless,

ID: 22372289 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Specifically” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that pauses between chimpanzee gestures average about 120 milliseconds, comparable to the 200-millisecond average pause in human speech—provides specific, precise details elaborating on the previous sentence’s claim about the pace of chimpanzee communication being similar to that of human conversations.

Choice A is incorrect because “as a result” illogically signals that this sentence presents a result or consequence of the claim about chimpanzee communication described in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence provides specific details elaborating on that claim. Choice C is incorrect because “by contrast” illogically signals that the information about chimpanzee gesture exchanges in this sentence contrasts with the previous sentence’s claim about the pace of chimpanzee communication being similar to that of human conversations. Instead, the sentence provides specific details elaborating on that claim. Choice D is incorrect because “nevertheless” illogically signals that the information about chimpanzee gesture exchanges in this sentence is true despite the previous claim about the pace of chimpanzee communication. Instead, the sentence provides specific details elaborating on that claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID db9625a7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: db9625a7

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Neuroscientists Krishnan Padmanabhan and Zhen Chen sought to better understand the workings of the brain’s olfactory system.
- They devised a study using mathematical models.
- They found that certain fibers allow the brain to toggle from one method of processing smells to another.
- In one method, cells in the piriform cortex (where the perception of odor forms) capture olfactory information at a given moment.
- In the other, the cells track changes in olfactory information over time.

The student wants to summarize the study’s findings. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. To arrive at these findings, which describe dual methods of processing smells in the piriform cortex, Padmanabhan and Chen devised a study using mathematical models.
- B. Padmanabhan and Chen showed that olfactory information is captured by cells in the piriform cortex, where the perception of odor forms.
- C. Using mathematical models, Padmanabhan and Chen devised a study to better understand the workings of the brain’s olfactory system.
- D. According to Padmanabhan and Chen, the brain can toggle between capturing olfactory information at a given moment and tracking changes in that information over time.

ID: db9625a7 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence effectively summarizes the study’s findings, explaining what Padmanabhan and Chen found: that the brain can toggle between one method of processing smells (capturing information at a given moment) and another (tracking changes in information over time).

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence mentions findings, it mainly focuses on Padmanabhan and Chen’s methodology. It doesn’t effectively summarize the study’s findings. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence notes a fact about the olfactory system—that the perception of odor forms in the piriform cortex—but doesn’t summarize the findings of Padmanabhan and Chen’s study. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence presents the goal of Padmanabhan and Chen’s study; it doesn’t summarize the study’s findings.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d46f10a9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: d46f10a9

The Madison is a type of line dance that involves neat rows of dancers performing a repeated sequence of steps in unison. _____ many other dances are also defined by order, repetition, and synchronicity, but the Madison is distinguished by its extreme uniformity; when an auditorium full of dancers performs the Madison, one almost gets the impression of a military march.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. However,
- B. Of course,
- C. Specifically,
- D. Moreover,

ID: d46f10a9 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. "Of course" logically signals that the information that follows—about many dances being "defined by order, repetition, and synchronicity"—acknowledges an obvious similarity between these dances and the previous description of the Madison. The sentence then goes on to emphasize a distinguishing feature of the Madison.

Choice A is incorrect because "however" illogically signals that the information that follows contrasts with the previous description of the Madison. Instead, the information about many dances’ features acknowledges an obvious similarity between these dances and the Madison. The sentence then goes on to emphasize a distinguishing feature of the Madison. Choice C is incorrect because "specifically" illogically signals that the information that follows specifies or elaborates on the previous description of the Madison. Instead, the information about many dances’ features acknowledges an obvious similarity between these dances and the Madison. The sentence then goes on to emphasize a distinguishing feature of the Madison. Choice D is incorrect because "moreover" illogically signals that the information that follows adds to or expands on the previous description of the Madison. Instead, the information about many dances’ features acknowledges an obvious similarity between these dances and the Madison. The sentence then goes on to emphasize a distinguishing feature of the Madison.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9d130949

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 9d130949

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In North America, woodlands have expanded into areas that were once grasslands.
- Thomas Rogers and F. Leland Russell of Wichita State University investigated whether woodland expansion is related to changes in climate.
- Rogers and Russell analyzed core samples from oak trees on a site that was not wooded in the past and indexed the age of the trees with historical climate data to see if tree populations and climate were correlated.
- Tree population growth was associated with dry intervals.
- Droughts may have played a role in woodland expansion.

The student wants to emphasize the aim of the research study. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Thomas Rogers and F. Leland Russell, researchers at Wichita State University, wanted to know if woodland expansion is related to changes in climate.
- B. Thanks to the work done by Thomas Rogers and F. Leland Russell, we now know that droughts may have played a role in woodland expansion.
- C. Wichita State University researchers have determined that tree population growth was associated with dry intervals.
- D. Thomas Rogers and F. Leland Russell analyzed core samples from oak trees on a site that was not wooded in the past, indexing the age of the trees with historical climate data.

ID: 9d130949 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence effectively emphasizes the aim, or goal, of the research study (in other words, what the researchers hoped to learn from the study): Rogers and Russell wanted to know if woodland expansion is related to changes in climate.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the researchers’ findings; it doesn’t emphasize the aim of the study. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the results of the study; it doesn’t emphasize the aim. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the methodology of the study; it doesn’t emphasize the aim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 32c0164e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 32c0164e

One poll taken after the first 1960 presidential debate suggested that John Kennedy lost badly: only 21 percent of those who listened on the radio rated him the winner. _____ the debate was ultimately considered a victory for the telegenic young senator, who rated higher than his opponent, Vice President Richard Nixon, among those watching on the new medium of television.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. In other words,
- B. Therefore,
- C. Likewise,
- D. Nevertheless,

ID: 32c0164e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “Nevertheless” logically signals that the claim in this sentence—that the telegenic Kennedy was ultimately considered the winner of the debate—is true despite the previous information about the poll of radio listeners.

Choice A is incorrect because “in other words” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence is a paraphrase of the previous information about the poll of radio listeners. Instead, Kennedy was ultimately considered the winner despite what that poll suggested about his performance. Choice B is incorrect because “therefore” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence is a result of the previous information about the poll of radio listeners. Instead, Kennedy was ultimately considered the winner despite what that poll suggested about his performance. Choice C is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence is similar to the previous information about the poll of radio listeners. Instead, Kennedy was ultimately considered the winner despite what that poll suggested about his performance.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8b671531

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 8b671531

According to Duverger’s law, countries with single-ballot majoritarian elections for single-member districts tend to polarize into two-party systems, wherein dueling political parties consistently dominate the political system. _____ countries with proportional-representation electoral systems tend to support multi-partyism, under which power gets distributed among many political parties.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Subsequently,
- B. Conversely,
- C. For instance,
- D. In other words,

ID: 8b671531 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. "Conversely" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that countries with proportional-representation electoral systems tend toward multi-partyism—contrasts with the previous information about countries with single-ballot majoritarian elections, which tend to have two-party systems.

Choice A is incorrect because "subsequently" illogically signals that the information in this sentence about countries with proportional-representation electoral systems occurs later in a chronological sequence of events than the information in the previous sentence. Instead, it contrasts with the previous information. Choice C is incorrect because "for instance" illogically signals that the information in this sentence about countries with proportional-representation electoral systems is an example supporting the previous statement about countries with single-ballot majoritarian elections. Instead, it contrasts with the previous statement. Choice D is incorrect because "in other words" illogically signals that the information in this sentence about countries with proportional-representation electoral systems is a paraphrase or restatement of the previous information about countries with single-ballot majoritarian elections. Instead, it contrasts with the previous information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d371a874

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: d371a874

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- 1914: British explorer Ernest Shackleton and a small crew embarked on an expedition to Antarctica.
- 1915: Shackleton’s ship *Endurance* became stuck in ice before eventually breaking apart and sinking.
- 1916: After more harrowing sea-ice adventures, the entire crew was rescued.
- 1959: Historian Alfred Lansing wrote a book called *Endurance: Shackleton’s Incredible Voyage*.
- 2001: Filmmaker George Butler released a documentary called *The Endurance: Shackleton’s Legendary Antarctic Expedition*.
- 2022: The wreckage of *Endurance* was discovered at the bottom of Antarctica’s Weddell Sea.

The student wants to provide a historical overview of the Shackleton expedition. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Leaving in 1914 for Antarctica, Shackleton and his crew underwent many harrowing sea-ice adventures, including losing their ship in 1915, before being rescued in 1916.
- B. In 1914, the Shackleton expedition sailed to Antarctica, where, in 1916, they rescued the crew of a ship that had sunk, *Endurance* (the wreckage of which was discovered in 2022).
- C. Shackleton’s expedition has inspired a 1959 book, a 2001 film, and a 2022 discovery.
- D. Alfred Lansing wrote about the history of Shackleton’s 1914–16 expedition in the book *Endurance: Shackleton’s Incredible Voyage* (1959); years later, in 2001, George Butler released a documentary about the expedition.

ID: d371a874 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence provides a historical overview of the Shackleton expedition, noting that the explorers left for Antarctica in 1914, lost their ship in 1915, and were rescued in 1916.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents information from the notes; Shackleton and his crew were themselves rescued in 1916—they weren’t rescuing others. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence provides examples of works and discoveries inspired by the expedition; it doesn’t provide an overview of the expedition itself. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence provides examples of works made about the expedition; it doesn’t provide an overview of the expedition itself.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5d80a54b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 5d80a54b

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Cecilia Vicuña is a multidisciplinary artist.
- In 1971, her first solo art exhibition, *Pinturas, poemas y explicaciones*, was shown at the Museo Nacional de Bellas Artes in Santiago, Chile.
- Her poetry collection *Precario/Precarious* was published in 1983 by Tanam Press.
- Her poetry collection *Instan* was published in 2002 by Kelsey St. Press.
- She lives part time in Chile, where she was born, and part time in New York.

The student wants to introduce the artist’s 1983 poetry collection. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Before she published the books *Precario/Precarious* (1983) and *Instan* (2002), Cecilia Vicuña exhibited visual art at the Museo Nacional de Bellas Artes in Santiago, Chile.
- B. Cecilia Vicuña is a true multidisciplinary artist whose works include numerous poetry collections and visual art exhibitions.
- C. Published in 1983 by Tanam Press, *Precario/Precarious* is a collection of poetry by the multidisciplinary artist Cecilia Vicuña.
- D. In 1971, Cecilia Vicuña exhibited her first solo art exhibition, *Pinturas, poemas y explicaciones*, in Chile, her country of birth.

ID: 5d80a54b Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence effectively introduces the poetry collection *Precario/Precarious*, noting that it is a collection by Vicuña that was published in 1983 by Tanam Press.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence mentions the 1983 poetry collection *Precario/Precarious*, it focuses mainly on Vicuña’s visual art. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence doesn’t introduce the 1983 poetry collection *Precario/Precarious*; instead, it introduces Vicuña. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the location of Vicuña’s 1971 exhibition *Pinturas, poemas y explicaciones*; it doesn’t introduce the 1983 poetry collection *Precario/Precarious*.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 665e1575

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 665e1575

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- *Las sergas de Esplandián* was a novel popular in sixteenth-century Spain.
- The novel featured a fictional island inhabited solely by Black women and known as California.
- That same century, Spanish explorers learned of an “island” off the west coast of Mexico.
- They called it California after the island in the novel.
- The “island” was actually the peninsula now known as Baja California (“Lower California”), which lies to the south of the US state of California.

The student wants to emphasize the role a misconception played in the naming of a place. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The novel *Las sergas de Esplandián* featured a fictional island known as California.
- B. To the south of the US state of California lies Baja California (“Lower California”), originally called California after a fictional place.
- C. In the sixteenth century, Spanish explorers learned of a peninsula off the west coast of Mexico and called it California.
- D. Thinking it was an island, Spanish explorers called a peninsula California after an island in a popular novel.

ID: 665e1575 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the role a misconception played in the naming of a place, explaining that Spanish explorers mistook a peninsula for an island and, as a result, named the peninsula after a fictional island, California.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence mentions a novel that featured a fictional island, California; it doesn’t emphasize the role a misconception played in the naming of a place. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence notes that Baja California was originally named after a fictional place; it doesn’t emphasize the role a misconception—specifically, the Spanish explorers’ mistaken belief that the peninsula was an island—played in the naming of a place. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence indicates when Spanish explorers learned of the peninsula they called California; it doesn’t emphasize the role a misconception played in the naming of a place.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0bd674da

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 0bd674da

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Generally, an object will heat up when twisted.
- The twisting of an object is known as torsion.
- A 2019 study led by Zunfeng Liu and Ray Baughman tested the torsional heating of various fibers.
- When a 3-millimeter-thick sample of thermoplastic polyurethane (TPU) fiber was twisted, its average surface temperature increased by 6°C.
- When a 4-millimeter-thick sample of styrene-ethylene-butylene-styrene (SEBS) rubber fiber was twisted, its average surface temperature increased by 3.5°C.

The student wants to contrast the two samples. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. When the fibers were twisted as part of the 2019 study, the surface temperature of both samples increased.
- B. In 2019, researchers studied the effect of torsional heating on various fibers, including samples of SEBS rubber and TPU.
- C. Twisting an object will generally cause its temperature to increase, a process known as torsional heating.
- D. The SEBS rubber sample used in the 2019 study was thicker than the TPU sample.

ID: 0bd674da Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence contrasts the two samples, noting that the SEBS rubber sample, at 4 millimeters thick, was thicker than the TPU sample, which was 3 millimeters thick.

Choice A is incorrect because the sentence mentions a similarity between the TPU fiber and the SEBS rubber; it doesn't contrast the two samples. Choice B is incorrect because the sentence indicates that both the SEBS rubber and TPU samples were part of the 2019 study; it doesn't contrast the two samples. Choice C is incorrect because the sentence describes the process of torsional heating; it doesn't contrast the two samples.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5278d41f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 5278d41f

Many historical accounts of the 1930s focus on the widespread movement of people from dust bowl–ravaged Great Plains states to faraway California. However, a 2016 study of 1940 census data complicates this popular narrative; _____ researchers determined, migrants in states hardest hit by prolonged droughts and dust storms—Colorado, Kansas, Oklahoma, and Texas—merely relocated within the region.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. for this reason,
- B. more often,
- C. additionally,
- D. nevertheless,

ID: 5278d41f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “More often” logically signals that the historical outcome in this clause—dust bowl migrants’ relocation within the Great Plains region—was more common than the movement to California described in many historical accounts.

Choice A is incorrect because “for this reason” illogically signals that the historical outcome in this clause was caused by either the narrative about widespread movement to California or the 2016 study’s complication of that narrative. Instead, dust bowl migrants’ regional relocation was found to be more common than the movement to California described in many historical accounts. Choice C is incorrect because “additionally” illogically signals that the historical outcome in this clause merely adds to either the narrative about widespread movement to California or the 2016 study’s complication of that narrative. Instead, dust bowl migrants’ regional relocation was found to be more common than the movement to California described in many historical accounts. Choice D is incorrect because “nevertheless” illogically signals that the historical outcome in this clause is true despite either the narrative about widespread movement to California or the 2016 study’s complication of that narrative. While the findings about dust bowl migrants’ regional relocation did challenge the previous narrative, they did not challenge the study’s findings, and this choice creates a confusing ambiguity. Instead, dust bowl migrants’ regional relocation was found to be more common than the movement to California described in many historical accounts.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9d938f92

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 9d938f92

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- A sestina is a thirty-nine-line poetic form.
- Each line of the poem ends with one of six end words, which alternate according to a set pattern.
- “Forage Sestina” is a sestina by Marilyn Hacker.
- Its end words are *words, structure, wire, beam, wall, and room*.
- “Towards Autumn” is a sestina by Marilyn Hacker.
- Its end words are *daughter, friend, bread, mother, lover, and myself*.

The student wants to use one of the poems to illustrate the sestina form. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Hacker employs the sestina, a poetic form with thirty-nine lines and six end words, in both “Forage Sestina” and “Towards Autumn.”
- B. As a sestina, “Towards Autumn” contains thirty-nine lines and six end words—in this case, *daughter, friend, bread, mother, lover, and myself*—that alternate in a set pattern.
- C. The thirty-nine-line sestina form uses the words *daughter, friend, bread, mother, lover, and myself*, which are found in the poem “Forage Sestina.”
- D. Hacker has used the sestina form multiple times, as in “Towards Autumn,” which contains these six words: *words, structure, wire, beam, wall, and room*.

ID: 9d938f92 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence uses the poem "Towards Autumn" to illustrate the form of a sestina, explaining that a sestina's thirty-nine lines all end in one of six alternating words and showcasing that poem's specific end words.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence identifies both of Hacker's poems as sestinas; it doesn't use one of the poems to illustrate the form of a sestina. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence appears to use the poem "Forage Sestina" to illustrate a feature of the sestina form, it misrepresents the information in the notes. According to the notes, "Forage Sestina" doesn't use these six end words; it uses six other words instead. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence uses the poem "Towards Autumn" as an example of one of Hacker's sestinas, it misrepresents the information in the notes. According to the notes, "Towards Autumn" doesn't use these six end words; it uses six other words instead.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6ec6396a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 6ec6396a

Modernista architects championed nature in their designs. _____ the wavy staircase and ornate floral tilework of Hospital de Sant Pau, a Modernista hospital designed by Lluís Domènech i Montaner, couldn't exactly grow in a forest. Still, one sees natural influences in Domènech i Montaner's penchant for curves (rather than right angles) and plant- and animal-inspired flourishes.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Furthermore,
- B. Similarly,
- C. Of course,
- D. Thus,

ID: 6ec6396a Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "Of course" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that "the wavy staircase and ornate floral tilework" of the Modernista hospital couldn't actually grow in a forest—acknowledges an obvious limitation of, or qualification to, the previous claim that Modernista architects championed nature in their designs.

Choice A is incorrect because "furthermore" illogically signals that the information in this sentence merely adds to the previous claim that Modernista architects championed nature in their designs. Instead, the sentence acknowledges an obvious limitation in how literally that natural influence was expressed in the hospital's features. Choice B is incorrect because "similarly" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is similar to the previous claim that Modernista architects championed nature in their designs. Instead, the sentence acknowledges an obvious limitation in how literally that natural influence was expressed in the hospital's features. Choice D is incorrect because "thus" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result of the previous claim that Modernista architects championed nature in their designs. Instead, the sentence acknowledges an obvious limitation in how literally that natural influence was expressed in the hospital's features.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d13c02e4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: d13c02e4

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Producing the nutrient-rich cyanobacterium *L. maxima* at industrial scale requires high-quality samples of *L. maxima* DNA.
- Yirlis Yadeth Pineda-Rodriguez and a team of researchers at the University of Córdoba, Colombia, evaluated the quantity and purity of *L. maxima* DNA extracted using three different DNA extraction kits.
- CTAB 2X (kit 1) had a DNA yield of 2,134 nanograms per microliter (ng/μL) and a purity ratio of 2.2.
- Pbact (kit 2) had a DNA yield of 157 ng/μL and a purity ratio of 1.6.
- Pplant (kit 3) had a DNA yield of 12.5 ng/μL and a purity ratio of 1.5.
- According to the researchers, Pbact was the most effective because it was the only one with both a sufficiently high yield and a purity rate close to the ideal of 1.8.

The student wants to emphasize the significance of a similarity between two of the kits. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Due to their insufficient yield or purity, CTAB 2X and Pplant were deemed by the researchers to be less effective than Pbact.
- B. Compared to CTAB 2X, which had a DNA yield of 2,134 ng/μL, both Pbact and Pplant had insufficient yields; Pplant, in particular, was ineffective due to its low yield.
- C. CTAB 2X and Pplant both had a DNA yield above 10 and a purity ratio above 1.4.
- D. With the ideal purity ratio being 1.8, CTAB 2X and Pbact were equal in purity, according to the researchers.

ID: d13c02e4 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the significance of a similarity between CTAB 2X and Pplant, noting that both were deemed less effective than Pbact due to their insufficient yield or purity. According to the notes, the researchers concluded that Pbact was the most effective kit because it was the only one with both a sufficiently high yield and a purity ratio close to 1.8. Since Pbact was the only kit to meet both criteria, it follows that CTAB 2X and Pplant each fell short on at least one critical measure.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence presents a similarity between two of the kits (Pbact and Pplant), but in doing so, it misrepresents information from the notes. The researchers deemed Pbact the most effective kit overall, not one with an insufficient yield. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence identifies a similarity between CTAB 2X and Pplant (that both had a DNA yield above 10 and a purity ratio above 1.4), it doesn't emphasize the significance of that similarity. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence presents a similarity between the CTAB 2X and Pbact kits, but in doing so, it misrepresents information from the notes. CTAB 2X had a purity ratio of 2.2, while Pbact had a purity ratio of 1.6, so they were not equal in purity.

Question ID 1bb13094

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 1bb13094

Al-Andalus, the historical region of the Iberian Peninsula that includes most of modern-day Spain, was ruled by various Arabic-speaking Muslim states between the eighth and fifteenth centuries. _____ many Arabic words, such as “alacrán”—meaning “scorpion”—made their way into the Spanish language.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. For example,
- B. Instead,
- C. Specifically,
- D. Consequently,

ID: 1bb13094 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “Consequently” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that many Arabic words entered the Spanish language—is a result or consequence of the previous information about Arabic-speaking Muslim states ruling Al-Andalus for centuries.

Choice A is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the information about Arabic words entering Spanish exemplifies the Arabic-speaking history of Al-Andalus mentioned in the previous sentence. Instead, Arabic words entering Spanish is a consequence of that history. Choice B is incorrect because “instead” illogically signals that the information about Arabic words entering Spanish provides an alternative to the Arabic-speaking history of Al-Andalus mentioned in the previous sentence. The information about Arabic words entering Spanish is a consequence of that history. Choice C is incorrect because “specifically” illogically signals that the information about Arabic words entering Spanish provides specific details elaborating on the Arabic-speaking history of Al-Andalus mentioned in the previous sentence. Instead, Arabic words entering Spanish is a consequence of that history.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 629e3f53

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 629e3f53

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Annie Wu is a prominent American flutist who graduated from the New England Conservatory.
- She has won multiple national flute competitions.
- She is best known for a 2011 YouTube video that has been viewed over two million times.
- The video shows her performing *Three Beats for Beatbox Flute*, an original work by composer Greg Pattillo.
- Wu combines flute playing and beatboxing in the video.

The student wants to emphasize Wu’s most well-known achievement. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Annie Wu, who has won multiple national flute competitions, has also combined flute playing and beatboxing.
- B. Among her many achievements, prominent American flutist Annie Wu graduated from the New England Conservatory and has won multiple national flute competitions.
- C. Annie Wu is best known for a 2011 YouTube video performance of *Three Beats for Beatbox Flute* that has been viewed over two million times.
- D. Composer Greg Pattillo’s original work *Three Beats for Beatbox Flute* combines flute playing and beatboxing.

ID: 629e3f53 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. This describes the achievement for which Wu is best known.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t emphasize Wu’s most well-known achievement. It mentions some of her general achievements, but not the one for which she is “best known.” Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t emphasize Wu’s most well-known achievement—it describes several of her achievements equally. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t emphasize Wu’s most well-known achievement. It describes a piece of music featured in her most well-known achievement.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 01735bdb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 01735bdb

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Ulaanbaatar is the capital of Mongolia.
- The city’s population is 907,802.
- Ulaanbaatar contains 31.98 percent of Mongolia’s population.
- Hanoi is the capital of Vietnam.
- The city’s population is 7,781,631.
- Hanoi contains 8.14 percent of Vietnam’s population.

The student wants to emphasize the relative sizes of the two capitals’ populations. Which choice most effectively uses information from the given sentences to emphasize the relative sizes of the two capitals’ populations?

- A. Mongolia’s capital is Ulaanbaatar, which has 907,802 people, and Vietnam’s capital is Hanoi, which has 7,781,631 people.
- B. Comparing Vietnam and Mongolia, 7,781,631 is 8.14 percent of Vietnam’s population, and 907,802 is 31.98 percent of Mongolia’s.
- C. Even though Hanoi (population 7,781,631) is larger than Ulaanbaatar (population 907,802), Ulaanbaatar accounts for more of its country’s population.
- D. The populations of the capitals of Mongolia and Vietnam are 907,802 (Ulaanbaatar) and 7,781,631 (Hanoi), respectively.

ID: 01735bdb Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the relative sizes of the capital cities’ populations, noting that even though Hanoi has more people overall, Ulaanbaatar accounts for a larger percentage of the people in its country.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence indicates the population size of each capital, it fails to emphasize their sizes relative to each other or to their countries’ overall population sizes. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the population sizes of the two countries; it fails to mention the capitals. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence indicates the population size of each capital, it fails to emphasize their sizes relative to each other or to their countries’ overall population sizes.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f557b14f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: f557b14f

In *Color Charts: A History* (2024), anthropologist Anne Varichon uses vivid prose to describe various systems and tools that have been used over the past few centuries for categorizing colors. _____ Varichon’s book features many high-quality images of these color presentation tools—from fanlike arrangements of hued fabric swatches to clusters of dyed feathers.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Consequently,
- B. Additionally,
- C. That said,
- D. Specifically,

ID: f557b14f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Additionally” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Varichon’s book features many high-quality images of color presentation tools—is an additional feature of the book, supplementing the vivid prose descriptions of these tools mentioned in the previous sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because “consequently” illogically signals that the information about the book’s high-quality images is a result or consequence of the previous statement about Varichon’s vivid prose descriptions. Instead, the images are an additional feature of the book. Choice C is incorrect because “that said” illogically signals that the information about the book’s high-quality images is an exception to or qualification of the previous statement about Varichon’s vivid prose descriptions. Instead, the images are an additional feature of the book. Choice D is incorrect because “specifically” illogically signals that the information about the book’s high-quality images provides specific, precise details about the vivid prose descriptions mentioned in the previous sentence. Instead, the images are an additional feature of the book.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8c4e107a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 8c4e107a

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Bike-share programs provide bicycles for shared use.
- In docked bike sharing, riders rent a bike and return it to designated docking stations.
- Docked programs are orderly and offer consistency to riders but require significant space and money to implement.
- In dockless bike sharing, riders locate a bike and leave it wherever they choose.
- Dockless programs are relatively simple and inexpensive to implement and offer flexibility to riders.
- Dockless programs can be disorganized.

The student wants to compare some disadvantages of docked and dockless bike-share programs. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Dockless programs can be disorganized; docked programs, on the other hand, offer order and consistency.
- B. Worth noting is that while dockless programs are relatively easy and inexpensive to implement, they are less flexible than docked programs.
- C. Docked programs are more resource-intensive than dockless programs, but they avoid some of the latter’s organizational challenges.
- D. Though dockless programs offer flexibility, docked bike-share programs provide bicycles for shared use.

ID: 8c4e107a Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence compares some disadvantages of docked and dockless bike-share programs, explaining that while docked programs are more resource-intensive (requiring significant space and money), dockless programs have greater organizational challenges.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence compares dockless programs to docked programs, noting an advantage of docked programs: they offer order and consistency. It doesn’t compare disadvantages of the two types of programs. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence compares dockless programs to docked programs, noting an advantage of dockless programs: they are easy and inexpensive to implement. However, it misrepresents information from the notes, stating that dockless programs are less flexible than docked programs. In addition, it doesn’t compare disadvantages of the two types of programs. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes an advantage of dockless programs, then makes a general statement that applies to both types of programs; it doesn’t compare disadvantages of the two types of programs.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f9897bd2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: f9897bd2

With his room-sized installation *Unicorn/My Private Sky*, Norwegian artist Børre Sæthre succeeds in creating a whimsical yet perplexing experience. _____ when visitors set foot inside the fantastically blue room and encounter the life-sized stuffed unicorn preening at the far end of it, they are both dazzled and confused—as if stepping into a strange and enchanting new world.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Second,
- B. Instead,
- C. Indeed,
- D. Nevertheless,

ID: f9897bd2 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "Indeed" logically signals that the description of the art installation in this sentence—its blue room and preening unicorn that leave visitors "dazzled and confused"—offers additional emphasis in support of the previous sentence's claim about the installation's "whimsical yet perplexing experience."

Choice A is incorrect because "second" illogically signals that the description in this sentence is a second, separate claim from the previous sentence's claim about the installation's "whimsical yet perplexing experience." Instead, the specific details describing the installation emphasize and support the previous claim. Choice B is incorrect because "instead" illogically signals that the description in this sentence is an alternative to the previous sentence's claim about the installation's "whimsical yet perplexing experience." Rather, the specific details describing the installation emphasize and support that claim. Choice D is incorrect because "nevertheless" illogically signals that the description in this sentence is true despite the previous sentence's claim about the installation's "whimsical yet perplexing experience." Instead, the specific details describing the installation emphasize and support that claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bfd4a00d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: bfd4a00d

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Researchers in a 2021 study wanted to determine the rate at which 17 languages conveyed both information and syllables.
- They calculated the bits of information conveyed per second (the IR, or information rate).
- The IR was found to be approximately consistent across the 17 languages (an average of 39 bits per second).
- They calculated the number of syllables spoken per second (the SR, or syllable rate).
- Spanish had the second-fastest SR (7.7 syllables per second).
- Vietnamese had the sixteenth-fastest SR (5.3 syllables per second).

The student wants to present an overview of the study’s findings. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The 2021 study determined the information rate (IR) of 17 languages in bits of information conveyed per second.
- B. Researchers found that information was conveyed more quickly in Spanish, at 7.7 syllables per second, than in Vietnamese, at 5.3 syllables per second.
- C. Vietnamese had the sixteenth-fastest syllable rate, lower than that of Spanish, which had the second-fastest; however, Spanish had the lower information rate of the two.
- D. Though some of the languages differed in number of syllables spoken per second, all 17 conveyed information at roughly the same rate.

ID: bfd4a00d Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence presents an overview of the study’s findings, noting that, for some of the languages (the examples of Spanish and Vietnamese are given in the notes), the number of syllables spoken per second varied, while the amount of information conveyed per second remained roughly constant across all 17 languages.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence describes one of the metrics the study assessed, it doesn’t present any of the study’s findings. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence compares specific findings about two of the languages studied, it doesn’t provide an overview of the study’s findings across all 17 languages. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence compares specific findings about two of the languages studied; it doesn’t provide an overview of the study’s findings across all 17 languages. It also misrepresents the information from the notes about Spanish’s information rate.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 63d820b4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 63d820b4

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In meteorology, an air mass is a large body of air with generally uniform humidity and temperature.
- Air masses are commonly classified by two-letter names.
- The first letter indicates the humidity of the air mass, while the second letter indicates the temperature.
- cA (continental arctic) means dry and cold, for example.
- mT (maritime tropical) means moist and warm.
- This classification system is based on the work of a Swedish meteorologist named Tor Bergeron (1891–1977).

The student wants to provide an example of an air mass. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Air masses are large bodies of air with generally uniform humidity and temperature.
- B. The air mass classification system uses two-letter names and is based on the work of Tor Bergeron, a Swedish meteorologist.
- C. Air masses are commonly classified by a two-letter name that indicates humidity and temperature.
- D. One type of air mass is known as a cA, or continental arctic, air mass because it is dry and cold.

ID: 63d820b4 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence provides an example of an air mass: the cA, or continental arctic, air mass.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence provides a general definition of air masses; it doesn’t provide an example of a specific air mass. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence describes the system used to classify air masses; it doesn’t provide an example of a specific air mass. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence explains how air masses are classified; it doesn’t provide an example of a specific air mass.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5d81cb8e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 5d81cb8e

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Shanawdithit (1801–1829) was a Beothuk cartographer (mapmaker).
- Her maps of Newfoundland’s Beothuk Lake outline both the lake and various points around the lake where encounters between the Indigenous Beothuk people and British colonists occurred.
- Her maps are notable for depicting the experiences the Beothuk had within the landscape.
- Contemporary Potawatomi cartographer Margaret Pearce: Indigenous cartography emphasizes “experienced space, or place, as opposed to the Western convention of depicting space as universal, homogenized, and devoid of human experience.”
- Pearce: “Indigenous cartographies are as diverse as Indigenous cultures, from Hawaiian performative cartographies to Navajo verbal maps and sand paintings.”

The student wants to describe Shanawdithit’s approach and explain its significance. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Shanawdithit’s maps are part of a broader tradition of Indigenous cartography that, according to Pearce, ranges from “Hawaiian performative cartographies to Navajo verbal maps and sand paintings.”
- B. Shanawdithit mapped Beothuk Lake through significant encounters that occurred there, an approach described as “depicting space as universal [and] homogenized.”
- C. According to Pearce, Indigenous cartography, such as Shanawdithit’s maps of Beothuk Lake, emphasizes “experienced space, or place,” with a variety of approaches that reflect the diversity of Indigenous cultures.
- D. By depicting experiences of the Beothuk that occurred around Beothuk Lake, Shanawdithit’s maps reflect Indigenous cartography’s emphasis on “experienced space, or place” rather than the landscape alone.

ID: 5d81cb8e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence accomplishes both parts of the goal. It describes Shanawdithit’s approach by noting that she depicted experiences of the Beothuk that occurred around Beothuk Lake, and it explains the significance of that approach by connecting it to Indigenous cartography’s emphasis on “experienced space, or place.”

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence places Shanawdithit’s maps within the broader tradition of Indigenous cartography, it doesn’t describe her specific approach to mapmaking or explain its significance. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence does describe Shanawdithit’s approach to mapmaking, it misrepresents information in the notes when explaining the significance of that approach. “Depicting space as universal [and] homogenized” is described as a Western convention, not a convention of Indigenous cartography. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence mentions Shanawdithit’s maps as an example of Indigenous

cartography, it focuses primarily on the broader tradition rather than describing Shanawdithit’s specific approach and explaining its significance.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3f499ef0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 3f499ef0

When designing costumes for film, American artist Suttirat Larlarb typically custom fits the garments to each actor. _____ for the film *Sunshine*, in which astronauts must reignite a dying Sun, she designed a golden spacesuit and had a factory reproduce it in a few standard sizes; lacking a tailor-made quality, the final creations reflected the ungainliness of actual spacesuits.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Nevertheless,
- B. Thus,
- C. Likewise,
- D. Moreover,

ID: 3f499ef0 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “Nevertheless” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that the spacesuits Suttirat Larlarb designed for the film *Sunshine* were made in standard sizes in a factory—presents a notable exception to Larlarb’s typical approach of custom-fitting garments to actors, which is described in the previous sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because “thus” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result or consequence of the previous information about Larlarb’s typical approach of custom-fitting garments to actors. Instead, it presents a notable exception to Larlarb’s typical approach. Choice C is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is similar to the previous information about Larlarb’s typical approach of custom-fitting garments to actors. Instead, it presents a notable exception to Larlarb’s typical approach. Choice D is incorrect because “moreover” illogically signals that the information in this sentence merely adds to the previous information about Larlarb’s typical approach of custom-fitting garments to actors. Instead, it presents a notable exception to Larlarb’s typical approach.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7d1f9125

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 7d1f9125

When printing paper money for the colony of Pennsylvania in the 1730s, Benjamin Franklin—then a Philadelphia shop owner—took steps to combat the circulation of counterfeit notes, such as weaving blue threads and muscovite (a reflective mineral) into the paper he used. _____ he stamped the notes with detailed imprints of sage leaves that proved difficult for forgers to replicate.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Specifically,
- B. That said,
- C. For example,
- D. Moreover,

ID: 7d1f9125 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "Moreover" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Franklin stamped imprints on paper money to make forgery more difficult—adds to the previous information by describing Franklin’s other strategy for combatting forgers: weaving materials into the paper used for printing money.

Choice A is incorrect because "specifically" illogically signals that the information in this sentence provides specific, precise details elaborating on the previous information about Franklin’s other strategy for combatting forgers (weaving materials into paper). Instead, this information about stamping imprints on money adds new information. Choice B is incorrect because "that said" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is an exception to the previous information about Franklin’s other strategy for combatting forgers (weaving materials into paper). Instead, this information about stamping imprints on money adds new information. Choice C is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the information in this sentence serves as an example of the previous information about Franklin’s other strategy for combatting forgers (weaving materials into paper). Instead, this information about stamping imprints on money adds new information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fb2ee1bb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: fb2ee1bb

Jhumpa Lahiri’s story collection *Interpreter of Maladies* features multiple stories about romantic relationships. In “This Blessed House,” newlyweds argue over whether to replace items left by the previous owners of their new home. _____ in “A Temporary Matter,” a husband and wife attempt to rekindle their relationship during a four-night blackout.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Granted,
- B. For example,
- C. Likewise,
- D. Hence,

ID: fb2ee1bb Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "Likewise" is a transition that indicates the addition of a new but related idea. In this sentence, the author is providing another similar example to that discussed in the previous sentence. Therefore, "likewise" works best in this context.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that means "admittedly." But the text isn’t admitting or conceding anything here. Instead, these two examples work together to support the claim made in the first sentence. Choice B is incorrect. This choice uses an exemplification transition, which doesn’t make sense here. The second story is not an example of the story in the previous sentence—it’s another, similar story. And while both stories exemplify the first sentence in the text, the transition we’re looking for isn’t actually connected to that sentence. Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses a cause-and-effect transition, which doesn’t make sense here. The first story didn’t result in the events of the second story.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0552f6a7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 0552f6a7

In hindsight, given the ideas about the natural world circulating among British scientists in the 1800s, the theory of natural selection was an obvious next step. It may not have been a coincidence, _____ that Charles Darwin and Alfred Wallace arrived at the concept independently. Indeed, contrary to the popular myth of the lone genius, theirs is not the first paradigm-shifting theory to have emerged from multiple scholars working in parallel.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. however,
- B. then,
- C. moreover,
- D. for example,

ID: 0552f6a7 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. "Then" signals that this sentence’s claim about Darwin and Wallace follows logically from the previous information. In other words, both scientists independently arriving at the theory of natural selection was, arguably, an expected outcome of the circumstances mentioned in the previous sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because "however" illogically signals that the claim in this sentence contrasts with the previous information about the ideas circulating among British scientists in the 1800s. Instead, this claim follows logically from that information. Choice C is incorrect because "moreover" illogically signals that the claim in this sentence merely adds to the previous information about the ideas circulating among British scientists in the 1800s. Instead, this claim follows logically from that information. Choice D is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that this sentence provides an example supporting the previous information about the ideas circulating among British scientists in the 1800s. Instead, it presents a claim that follows logically from that information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 08632fae

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 08632fae

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Texture analysis and historical analysis are two approaches to art criticism.
- Texture analysis examines how surfaces are visually represented in an artwork.
- Such an analysis of Giorgione’s *Youth Holding an Arrow* might consider how the painting’s blended colors make the subject’s skin appear smooth in texture.
- Historical analysis considers the historical context in which a work was created.
- Such an analysis of Diego Velázquez’s *Las Meninas* might consider how the painting’s depiction of the artist with King Philip IV symbolizes art’s historical ties to power.

The student wants to present historical analysis to an audience unfamiliar with the concept. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. A texture analysis of *Youth Holding an Arrow* might consider how the painting’s blended colors make the subject’s skin appear smooth in texture.
- B. Texture analysis differs from historical analysis in that texture analysis examines how surfaces are visually represented in an artwork.
- C. An approach to art criticism, historical analysis considers the historical context in which a work was created.
- D. *Las Meninas*’s depiction of the artist with King Philip IV symbolizes art’s historical ties to power.

ID: 08632fae Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence presents historical analysis to an audience unfamiliar with the concept by defining it as an approach to art criticism that considers the historical context in which a work was created.

Choice A is incorrect because it provides an example of texture analysis; it doesn’t present historical analysis to an audience unfamiliar with the concept. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence explains a difference between texture analysis and historical analysis; it doesn’t present historical analysis to an audience unfamiliar with the concept. Choice D is incorrect. It provides an example of historical analysis; it doesn’t present historical analysis to an audience unfamiliar with the concept.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6c1349af

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 6c1349af

With their distinctive cone shapes and steeply sloping sides, the volcanoes Hverfjall (Iceland) and Toliman (Guatemala) may look similar from afar. Tehnuka Ilanko and other volcanologists, _____ can tell by how each was formed that Hverfjall is a cinder cone volcano, while Toliman is a composite volcano.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. for example,
- B. in addition,
- C. therefore,
- D. though,

ID: 6c1349af Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "Though" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that volcanologists can distinguish the two volcanoes by how they were formed—presents a qualification or exception to the previous statement that the volcanoes look similar. The volcanoes are actually of two different types.

Choice A is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the information in this sentence exemplifies the previous information about the volcanoes looking similar. Instead, the sentence presents a qualification to that apparent similarity—the volcanoes are actually of two different types. Choice B is incorrect because "in addition" illogically signals that the information in this sentence merely adds to the previous information about the volcanoes looking similar. Instead, the sentence presents a qualification to that apparent similarity—the volcanoes are actually of two different types. Choice C is incorrect because "therefore" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result of the previous information about the volcanoes looking similar. Instead, the sentence presents a qualification to that apparent similarity—the volcanoes are actually of two different types.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7bfbcd da

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 7bfbcd da

Jeffrey Gibson’s sculptural object *KNOW YOUR MAGIC, BABY*, an Everlast-brand exercise bag embroidered with multicolored beads and a fringe associated with the dances of the Ojibwe people, stitches together—literally and figuratively—recognizable symbols from both Native and non-Native cultures. _____ Gibson’s piece also blurs the distinction between contemporary art and traditional crafts.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Conversely,
- B. In so doing,
- C. For instance,
- D. In particular,

ID: 7bfbcd da Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. "In so doing" logically signals that the information in this sentence about Gibson’s piece—that it blurs the distinction between contemporary art and traditional crafts—is a result or consequence of the piece’s blending of particular Native and non-Native cultural symbols.

Choice A is incorrect. "Conversely" illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the previous information about the blending of particular cultural symbols in Gibson’s piece. Instead, it presents a result or consequence of that information. Choice C is incorrect. "For instance" illogically signals that this sentence provides an example supporting the previous information about the blending of particular cultural symbols in Gibson’s piece. Instead, it presents a result or consequence of that information. Choice D is incorrect. "In particular" illogically signals that this sentence provides specific details elaborating on the previous information about the blending of particular cultural symbols in Gibson’s piece. Instead, it presents a result or consequence of that information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c2e7b272

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: c2e7b272

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Astronomers estimate that the number of comets orbiting the Sun is in the billions.
- 81P/Wild is one of many comets whose orbit has changed over time.
- 81P/Wild’s orbit once lay between the orbits of Uranus and Jupiter.
- The comet’s orbit is now positioned between the orbits of Jupiter and Mars.

The student wants to make and support a generalization about the orbits of comets. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish these goals?

- A. Astronomers estimate that the number of comets orbiting the Sun is in the billions; the comets’ orbits may change over time.
- B. Like Uranus, Jupiter, and Mars, billions of comets orbit the Sun.
- C. One example of a comet is 81P/Wild, whose orbit around the Sun once lay between Uranus’s and Jupiter’s orbits but is now positioned between those of Jupiter and Mars.
- D. A comet’s orbit around the Sun may change over time: the orbit of comet 81P/Wild once lay between the orbits of Uranus and Jupiter but is now positioned between those of Jupiter and Mars.

ID: c2e7b272 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence makes a generalization—that a comet’s orbit around the Sun may change over time—and supports the generalization with the example of the orbit of comet 81P/Wild, which once lay between the orbits of Uranus and Jupiter but is now positioned between the orbits of Jupiter and Mars.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the number of comets orbiting the Sun and makes a generalization about their orbits, but it doesn’t support the generalization with an example. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence makes a generalization about comets and compares them to the planets Uranus, Jupiter, and Mars; it doesn’t make and support a generalization about comets’ orbits. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence provides an example of a comet whose orbit has changed, it doesn’t make a generalization about the orbits of comets.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 158830fd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 158830fd

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Organisms release cellular material into their environment by shedding substances such as hair or skin.
- The DNA in these substances is known as environmental DNA, or eDNA.
- Researchers collect and analyze eDNA to detect the presence of species that are difficult to observe.
- Geneticist Sara Oyler-McCance’s research team analyzed eDNA in water samples from the Florida Everglades to detect invasive constrictor snake species in the area.
- The study determined a 91% probability of detecting Burmese python eDNA in a given location.

The student wants to present the study to an audience already familiar with environmental DNA. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Sara Oyler-McCance’s researchers analyzed eDNA in water samples from the Florida Everglades for evidence of invasive constrictor snakes, which are difficult to observe.
- B. An analysis of eDNA can detect the presence of invasive species that are difficult to observe, such as constrictor snakes.
- C. Researchers found Burmese python eDNA, or environmental DNA, in water samples; eDNA is the DNA in released cellular materials, such as shed skin cells.
- D. Sara Oyler-McCance’s researchers analyzed environmental DNA (eDNA)—that is, DNA from cellular materials released by organisms—in water samples from the Florida Everglades.

ID: 158830fd Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice presents the study in a way that assumes the audience is already familiar with eDNA.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t present the study. It only states a general fact about eDNA analysis. Choice C is incorrect. This choice isn’t suited for an audience already familiar with eDNA. A familiar audience wouldn’t need to have the term defined or explained. Choice D is incorrect. This choice isn’t suited for an audience already familiar with eDNA. A familiar audience wouldn’t need to have the term defined or explained. It also doesn’t present the study.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1f41cb87

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 1f41cb87

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- A small number of US Navy sailors of Filipino descent served during the US Civil War (1861–1865).
- Stephen Amos was born in the Philippines around 1830.
- He enlisted in the US Navy in November 1863.
- Raphael Ignases was born in the Philippines around 1834.
- He enlisted in the US Navy in July 1861.

The student wants to emphasize the historical significance of Stephen Amos’s enlistment date. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Both Stephen Amos and Raphael Ignases were US Navy sailors of Filipino descent, but Amos enlisted in the Navy in 1863, two years later than Ignases.
- B. Stephen Amos was a US Navy sailor of Filipino descent, along with Raphael Ignases, who was born in the Philippines around 1834.
- C. Stephen Amos enlisted in the US Navy in 1863, making him one of the few sailors of Filipino descent to serve in the US Civil War (1861–1865).
- D. When Stephen Amos enlisted in the US Navy in November 1863, he joined sailors such as Raphael Ignases, who had been born in the Philippines around 1834.

ID: 1f41cb87 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. Noting the time frame of the US Civil War and the fact that Amos enlisted during this time frame, the sentence emphasizes that Amos’s enlistment date places him among the historically significant group of US Navy sailors of Filipino descent who served during the Civil War.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence identifies Amos and Ignases and notes that Amos’s enlistment date was later than Ignases’s; the sentence doesn’t explain the historical significance of the date. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence identifies Amos and Ignases as US Navy sailors of Filipino descent, noting Ignases’s birth year; the sentence doesn’t provide Amos’s enlistment date or its historical significance. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence provides Amos’s enlistment date and mentions that he served alongside a sailor of Filipino descent; it doesn’t explain the historical significance of the date.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID df3646ff

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: df3646ff

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The nautical mile (6,076 feet) is the measure of distance used in seafaring navigation.
- A nautical mile directly correlates to one minute (1/60th of a degree) of latitude.
- The curvature of Earth affects the accurate measurement of long distances when using flat maps.
- Measuring distances with latitude and longitude coordinates takes into account Earth’s curvature.
- Mariners use nautical charts marked with latitude and longitude to quickly calculate distances and positions.

The student wants to explain why nautical miles are used to measure distances in seafaring navigation. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Nautical miles are a measure of distance equal to one minute of latitude, which is a feature nautical charts use to calculate distances and positions.
- B. Since they directly correlate to the coordinates on nautical charts, which take into account Earth’s curvature, nautical miles are an efficient way to calculate distances at sea.
- C. Using nautical miles for navigation at sea takes Earth’s curvature into account, whereas measuring distances with latitude and longitude coordinates does not.
- D. Nautical charts use latitude and longitude to measure long distances; these charts are more accurate than flat maps for measuring distances in seafaring navigation because they account for Earth’s curvature.

ID: df3646ff Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence explains why nautical miles are used to measure distances in seafaring navigation, noting that they directly correlate to the coordinates on nautical charts that take into account Earth’s curvature, making them an efficient way to calculate distances at sea.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence describes what nautical miles are and their relationship to nautical charts, it doesn’t explain why nautical miles are used to measure distances in seafaring navigation. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence indicates a reason why nautical miles are used, it misrepresents information from the notes: measuring distances with latitude and longitude does in fact account for Earth’s curvature. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence explains why nautical charts are more accurate than flat maps; it doesn’t explain why nautical miles specifically are used to measure distances in seafaring navigation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3b47e159

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 3b47e159

Ugandan American professor Peter Nazareth believed that Elvis Presley’s music is best understood not as a homogeneous collection but as an anthology (because Elvis showcased the contributions of a wide range of gospel, blues, and rock artists). _____ Nazareth entitled his college course on Elvis and his music, which focused on Elvis’s many musical influences, “Elvis as Anthology.”

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. To that end,
- B. In sum,
- C. That is,
- D. In addition,

ID: 3b47e159 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. "To that end" logically signals that the activity described in this sentence—Nazareth titling his course "Elvis as Anthology"—is meant to further Nazareth’s goal of helping others understand Presley’s music as an anthology with a wide range of influences.

Choice B is incorrect. "In sum" illogically signals that the activity described in this sentence summarizes Nazareth’s view of Presley’s music as an anthology. Instead, titling his course "Elvis as Anthology" is a way for him to promote this view. Choice C is incorrect. "That is" illogically signals that the activity described in this sentence is a clarification or interpretation of Nazareth’s view of Presley’s music as an anthology. Instead, titling his course "Elvis as Anthology" is a way for him to promote this view. Choice D is incorrect. "In addition" illogically signals that the activity described in this sentence is merely an additional fact about Nazareth. Instead, titling his course "Elvis as Anthology" is a way for him to promote his view of Presley’s music as an anthology.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3042bebc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 3042bebc

In his 2023 collection *The Diaspora Sonnets*, Filipino American poet Oliver de la Paz leverages the sonnet form’s “diamond-like quality of precision,” as he describes it. The poems often adhere scrupulously to the form’s centuries-old conventions, such as its characteristic fourteen-line length. In the twelve-line poem “Diaspora Sonnet at the Feeders Before the Freeze,” _____ de la Paz playfully subverts sonnet conventions, the poem’s truncated length conveying a sense of abruptness.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. fittingly,
- B. similarly,
- C. for example,
- D. by contrast,

ID: 3042bebc Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “By contrast” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that one of de la Paz’s poems subverts sonnet conventions—contrasts with the previous information that his poems often adhere to sonnet conventions.

Choice A is incorrect because “fittingly” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is an appropriate or expected outcome of the previous information about de la Paz’s adherence to sonnet conventions. Instead, de la Paz’s subversion of sonnet conventions contrasts with that information. Choice B is incorrect because “similarly” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is similar to the previous information about de la Paz’s adherence to sonnet conventions. Instead, de la Paz’s subversion of sonnet conventions contrasts with that information. Choice C is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the information in this sentence exemplifies the previous information about de la Paz’s adherence to sonnet conventions. Instead, de la Paz’s subversion of sonnet conventions contrasts with that information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9881a479

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 9881a479

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Suzanne K. Birner led a study analyzing rocks on the seafloor to better understand the history of Earth’s mantle.
- Rock samples were collected from two seafloor ridges.
- The researchers determined the samples’ period of formation (the Archean eon) and oxidation level (extremely low).
- High temperatures in the Archean likely caused the rocks’ low oxidation.
- Birner’s team suggests the oxidation of Earth’s mantle has remained stable over time, contrary to previous theories.
- The findings help explain the unique conditions that allowed life to develop on Earth.

The student wants to present the study’s research methods. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Birner led a study to better understand the history of Earth’s mantle and explain the conditions that allowed life to develop.
- B. To further analyze the origins of Earth’s unique conditions, researchers focused on rocks from the Archean eon, when Earth’s temperatures were extremely high.
- C. By studying these ancient rocks, the team aimed to challenge previous theories about changes in Earth’s mantle over time.
- D. Birner’s team analyzed the age and oxidation levels of rock samples collected from two seafloor ridges.

ID: 9881a479 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence presents the study’s research methods, explaining that Birner’s team analyzed the age and oxidation levels of rock samples collected from two seafloor ridges.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes the purpose of the study (to understand the history of Earth’s mantle and explain conditions for life); it doesn’t present the study’s research methods. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence notes the study’s focus on rocks from the Archean eon and a characteristic of the eon; it doesn’t present the study’s research methods. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence indicates the goal of the study (to challenge previous theories); it doesn’t present the study’s research methods.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 69481483

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 69481483

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The background colors of US and UK road signs are used to denote each sign’s purpose.
- Directional signs are a type of sign containing information such as route names, distance to a destination, etc.
- Highways, major roadways, and minor roadways in the US generally use green for directional signs.
- Highways in the UK generally use blue for directional signs.
- Major roadways in the UK generally use green for directional signs.

The student wants to contrast how green backgrounds are used in US and UK road signs. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Blue backgrounds are generally used on directional highway signs in the UK, in contrast to the green highway signs used in the US.
- B. In the US, green signs indicate directional information on both highways and major roadways, but in the UK, directional signs of this color generally appear only on major roadways.
- C. Green road signs are used in both the US and UK to denote directional information on major roadways, like distance to a destination or route names.
- D. Both the UK and the US use directional signs, which include information on route names and distance to a destination.

ID: 69481483 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence contrasts how green backgrounds are used in US and UK road signs, noting that the US uses them for both highways and major roadways while the UK uses them only for major roadways.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence does contrast US and UK road signs, the contrast focuses on the use of blue versus green backgrounds rather than on the use of green backgrounds specifically. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence indicates a similarity between the uses of green road signs in the US and the UK rather than contrasting them. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence indicates a similarity between road signs in the US and those in the UK; it doesn’t contrast how green backgrounds are used in each country’s signs.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ef4b1647

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: ef4b1647

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Architect Julian Abele studied Gregorian and neo-Gothic architecture in Europe.
- Abele worked for an architecture firm that was hired in 1924 to design buildings for Duke University’s new campus.
- Most of the buildings on Duke’s campus were designed in the Gregorian or neo-Gothic architectural styles.
- At the time, Abele was not formally credited with designing the buildings.
- Based on the buildings’ architectural styles, historians believe Abele designed most of the campus buildings.

The student wants to specify why historians believe Abele designed most of Duke’s campus buildings. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Given that most of the buildings on Duke’s campus feature architectural styles that Abele had studied in Europe, historians believe Abele is the one who designed them.
- B. Though Abele wasn’t formally credited at the time, historians believe he designed most of the buildings on Duke’s campus.
- C. Most of Duke’s campus buildings, which were designed by a firm Abele worked for, were designed in the Gregorian and neo-Gothic architectural styles.
- D. Abele, an architect who studied Gregorian and neo-Gothic architecture in Europe, is believed to have designed most of the buildings on Duke’s campus.

ID: ef4b1647 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence specifies why historians believe Abele designed most of Duke’s campus buildings, noting that most of the buildings feature architectural styles that Abele had studied.

Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence explains that historians believe Abele designed most of Duke’s campus buildings, it doesn’t specify why historians hold that belief. Choice C is incorrect because the sentence emphasizes the architectural styles of Duke’s campus buildings; it doesn’t specify why historians believe Abele designed the buildings. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence explains that Abele is believed to have designed most of the buildings on Duke’s campus, it doesn’t specify why historians believe that he designed the buildings.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f82dae6b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: f82dae6b

The mineral mtorolite is most commonly found in Zimbabwe. Mtorolite is cryptocrystalline, meaning that its crystalline structure is so fine that the individual crystals cannot be distinguished by the naked eye or even under a microscope. The crystals in microcrystalline minerals are also not visible to the naked eye; _____ they can usually be seen under a microscope.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. thus,
- B. for example,
- C. that said,
- D. similarly,

ID: f82dae6b Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because "that said" logically signals that the information that follows—that the crystals of microcrystalline minerals can be seen with a microscope—is an exception to the previous information about the crystalline structure of minerals not being visible under a microscope.

Choice A is incorrect because "thus" illogically signals that the information that follows is a direct result or consequence of the fact that the crystals of microcrystalline minerals aren't visible to the naked eye. Instead, the fact that they can be seen under a microscope is an exception to the previous information about crystalline minerals. Choice B is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the information that follows exemplifies the fact that the crystals of microcrystalline minerals aren't visible to the naked eye. Instead, the fact that they can be seen under a microscope is an exception to the previous information about crystalline minerals. Choice D is incorrect because "similarly" illogically signals that the information that follows is similar or comparable to the fact that the crystals of microcrystalline minerals aren't visible to the naked eye. Instead, the fact that they can be seen under a microscope is an exception to the previous information about crystalline minerals.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bd1b7705

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: bd1b7705

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Ukiyo-e woodblock prints were a popular artistic form in Japan from the 1600s through the 1800s.
- Ukiyo-e prints were produced by teams of artisans that included artists, wood-carvers, printers, and publishers.
- Sōsaku-hanga was a popular Japanese printmaking movement that emerged in the early 1900s.
- Sōsaku-hanga prioritized individual artistic expression.
- An artist working in this style typically handled all aspects of print creation, from drawing to wood carving to printing.

The student wants to contrast ukiyo-e and sōsaku-hanga production methods. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. One notable distinction between ukiyo-e and sōsaku-hanga prints is sōsaku-hanga’s emphasis on individual artistic expression.
- B. Ukiyo-e prints were popular in Japan from the 1600s through the 1800s, while sōsaku-hanga prints emerged later, in the early 1900s.
- C. Teams of artisans produced ukiyo-e prints, whereas individual artists typically handled all aspects of sōsaku-hanga printmaking themselves.
- D. In contrast to ukiyo-e prints, sōsaku-hanga prints were produced using methods such as drawing and wood carving.

ID: bd1b7705 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence contrasts the two production methods, noting that ukiyo-e prints are produced by teams of artisans, whereas sōsaku-hanga prints are typically produced by an individual artist.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence indicates a difference between the two styles, noting that sōsaku-hanga emphasizes individual artistic expression, but it doesn’t provide sufficient information about ukiyo-e prints to contrast the two styles’ production methods. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence contrasts when the two styles were popular; it doesn’t contrast their production methods. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence mischaracterizes information from the notes: both styles include drawing and wood carving in their production, not just sōsaku-hanga.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 58d527eb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 58d527eb

In her poetry collection *Thomas and Beulah*, Rita Dove interweaves the titular characters’ personal stories with broader historical narratives. She places Thomas’s journey from the American South to the Midwest in the early 1900s within the larger context of the Great Migration. _____ Dove sets events from Beulah’s personal life against the backdrop of the US Civil Rights Movement.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Specifically,
- B. Thus,
- C. Regardless,
- D. Similarly,

ID: 58d527eb Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “Similarly” logically signals that the information in the sentence—that Dove situates Beulah’s life in the context of the US Civil Rights Movement—is similar to the previous information about Thomas and the Great Migration. Both sentences support the first sentence’s claim that Dove portrays her characters in the context of broader historical narratives.

Choice A is incorrect because “specifically” illogically signals that the information about Beulah in this sentence provides specific details elaborating on the previous information about Thomas. Instead, it’s similar to the previous information about Thomas. Choice B is incorrect because “thus” illogically signals that the information about Beulah in this sentence is a result or consequence of the previous information about Thomas. Instead, it’s similar to the previous information about Thomas. Choice C is incorrect because “regardless” illogically signals that the information about Beulah in this sentence is true despite the previous information about Thomas. Instead, it’s similar to the previous information about Thomas.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b9236c75

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: b9236c75

Upper-atmospheric jets—phenomena whereby electrical discharges cause narrow cones of blue light to briefly burst upward from the tops of thunderclouds—have been observed reaching the ionosphere. The extreme altitudes involved (the ionosphere begins about 80 km above Earth) mark these gigantic jets as outliers; _____ the majority of jets reach heights of only 20 to 50 km.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. nevertheless,
- B. consequently,
- C. indeed,
- D. in addition,

ID: b9236c75 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. “Indeed” logically signals that the information that follows—that the majority of jets reach heights of only 20 to 50 km—offers additional emphasis in support of the previous claim that jets reaching the ionosphere (about 80 km above Earth) are outliers.

Choice A is incorrect because “nevertheless” illogically signals that the information about most jets reaching heights of only 20 to 50 km contrasts with the previous claim that jets reaching the ionosphere are outliers. Instead, it provides additional emphasis in support of that claim. Choice B is incorrect because “consequently” illogically signals that the information about most jets reaching heights of only 20 to 50 km is a consequence, or result, of some jets being outliers. Instead, it offers additional emphasis in support of the claim that jets reaching the ionosphere are outliers. Choice D is incorrect because “in addition” illogically signals that the information about most jets reaching heights of only 20 to 50 km merely adds to the previous claim that jets reaching the ionosphere are considered outliers. Instead, it provides additional emphasis in support of that claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3e95432b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 3e95432b

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In the early 1960s, the US had a strict national-origins quota system for immigrants.
- The number of new immigrants allowed from a country each year was based on how many people from that country lived in the US in 1890.
- This system favored immigrants from northern Europe.
- Almost 70% of slots were reserved for immigrants from Great Britain, Ireland, and Germany.
- The 1965 Hart-Celler Act abolished the national-origins quota system.

The student wants to present the significance of the Hart-Celler Act to an audience unfamiliar with the history of US immigration. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Almost 70% of slots were reserved for immigrants from Great Britain, Ireland, and Germany at the time the Hart-Celler Act was proposed.
- B. Prior to the Hart-Celler Act, new immigration quotas were based on how many people from each country lived in the US in 1890.
- C. The quota system in place in the early 1960s was abolished by the 1965 Hart-Celler Act.
- D. The 1965 Hart-Celler Act abolished the national-origins quota system, which favored immigrants from northern Europe.

ID: 3e95432b Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence presents the significance of the Hart-Celler Act to an audience unfamiliar with the history of US immigration, noting that the 1965 act abolished the national-origins quota system and explaining why that mattered, historically: because the old quota system had favored immigrants from northern Europe.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes an aspect of immigration policy at the time the Hart-Celler Act was proposed; it doesn't present the significance of the Hart-Celler Act to an audience unfamiliar with the history of US immigration. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence describes an aspect of immigration policy before the Hart-Celler Act; it doesn't describe or present the significance of the act to an audience unfamiliar with the history of US immigration. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence indicates that the Hart-Celler Act abolished the old quota system, it doesn't explain the act or the quota system to an audience unfamiliar with the history of US immigration.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 743025e4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 743025e4

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Leigh Torres is a marine ecologist.
- She conducted a study of blue whales in New Zealand’s South Taranaki Bight region.
- She wanted to know how ocean temperature affects where the whales forage for krill in that region.
- She found that during a marine heat wave, the whales foraged farther offshore than they had during cooler periods.
- The offshore waters, which were colder than areas closer to shore, had a higher relative abundance of krill.

The student wants to emphasize the aim of the research study. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Analyzing ocean temperature data, Torres found that during a marine heat wave, blue whales foraged farther offshore than they had during cooler periods.
- B. In her study, Torres sought to determine how ocean temperature affects where blue whales forage for krill in the South Taranaki Bight region.
- C. Torres’s study revealed that blue whales were attracted to offshore waters with a relatively high abundance of krill.
- D. Torres, a marine ecologist, studied blue whales in the South Taranaki Bight region, where the whales forage.

ID: 743025e4 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the aim, or goal, of the research study, noting that Torres sought to determine how ocean temperature affects where blue whales forage for krill.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the results of the study, noting what Torres found at the end; it doesn’t emphasize the aim, or goal, of the study, which is what Torres sought at the beginning. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence makes a claim about the study’s results; it doesn’t emphasize the aim, or goal, of the study. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence indicates the location of Torres’s study; it doesn’t emphasize the aim, or goal, of the study.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fc371659

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: fc371659

To perform a quad axel, a figure skater must leap into the air and complete four and a half rotations before landing, an extreme feat. _____ in 2022, when 17-year-old Ilia Malinin landed the first quad axel—considered the most difficult quad jump—in a high-level competition, the audience was left awestruck.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Moreover,
- B. Fittingly,
- C. Next,
- D. However,

ID: fc371659 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. "Fittingly" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that the audience was amazed when Malinin landed the first quad axel—describes a suitable or appropriate reaction to the completion of this extremely difficult jump.

Choice A is incorrect. "Moreover" illogically signals that the information in this sentence merely adds to the previous information about the difficulty of completing a quad axel. Instead, the audience’s amazement is a suitable or appropriate reaction to this accomplishment. Choice C is incorrect. "Next" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is simply the next step in a process. Instead, the audience’s amazement is a suitable or appropriate reaction to the accomplishment. Choice D is incorrect. "However" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is in contrast or an exception to the difficulty of completing a quad axel. Instead, the audience’s amazement is a suitable or appropriate reaction to this accomplishment.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e1defd85

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: e1defd85

In a heated debate in biogeography, the field is divided between dispersalists and vicariancists. _____ there are those who argue that dispersal is the most crucial determining factor in a species’ distribution, and those who insist that vicariance (separation due to geographic barriers) is. Biogeographer Isabel Sanmartín counts herself among neither.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Furthermore,
- B. By contrast,
- C. Similarly,
- D. That is,

ID: e1defd85 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “That is” logically signals that the information in this sentence, which explains the difference between the dispersalists’ position and the vicariancists’ position, clarifies the terms of the debate between dispersalists and vicariancists introduced in the previous sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because “furthermore” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is merely additional to (and separate from) the information in the previous sentence about the debate between dispersalists and vicariancists. Instead, the sentence clarifies the terms of the debate, explaining the difference between the dispersalists’ position and the vicariancists’ position. Choice B is incorrect because “by contrast” illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the information in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence clarifies the terms of the debate between dispersalists and vicariancists introduced in the previous sentence. Choice C is incorrect because “similarly” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is merely similar to (and separate from) the information in the previous sentence about the debate between dispersalists and vicariancists. Instead, the sentence clarifies the terms of the debate, explaining the difference between the dispersalists’ position and the vicariancists’ position.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b3717224

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: b3717224

When soil becomes contaminated by toxic metals, it can be removed from the ground and disposed of in a landfill. _____ contaminated soil can be detoxified via phytoremediation: plants that can withstand high concentrations of metals absorb the pollutants and store them in their shoots, which are then cut off and safely disposed of, preserving the health of the plants.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Alternatively,
- B. Specifically,
- C. For example,
- D. As a result,

ID: b3717224 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “Alternatively” logically signals that the soil decontamination method described in this sentence—removing toxic metals from the soil via phytoremediation—offers an alternative to the previously described method (removing the contaminated soil from the ground).

Choice B is incorrect because “specifically” illogically signals that the soil decontamination method described in this sentence specifies or elaborates on an aspect of the previously described method (removing the contaminated soil from the ground). Instead, phytoremediation is an alternative to that method. Choice C is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the soil decontamination method described in this sentence is an example of the previously described method (removing the contaminated soil from the ground). Instead, phytoremediation is an alternative to that method. Choice D is incorrect because “as a result” illogically signals that the soil decontamination method described in this sentence is a result or consequence of the previously described method (removing the contaminated soil from the ground). Instead, phytoremediation is an alternative to that method.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d8c5be17

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: d8c5be17

Magnetic levitation (maglev) trains are suspended above a track by powerful electromagnets, reducing friction and thus allowing for much faster speeds. Though maglev advocates in the US have long imagined these trains crisscrossing the country, their dream remains unrealized. _____ of the handful of maglev trains currently in operation, all are in Asia.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. In fact,
- B. To that end,
- C. Nevertheless,
- D. That said,

ID: d8c5be17 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This sentence emphasizes just how far maglev advocates’ dreams are from coming true. “In fact” is a transition used to emphasize the truth of a statement that modifies the previous statement and therefore fits perfectly in this context.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice uses a cause-and-effect transition, which doesn’t make sense here. Maglev advocates’ dream remaining unrealized would not cause there to be only a few maglev trains, all located in Asia. Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses a disagreement transition, which doesn’t make sense here. In fact, this sentence agrees with the previous sentence—both talk about how maglev trains are far from becoming common in the US. Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses a disagreement transition, which doesn’t make sense here. In fact, this sentence agrees with the previous sentence—both talk about how maglev trains are far from becoming common in the US.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7e601b64

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 7e601b64

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The magnificent frigatebird (*fregata magnificens*) is a species of seabird that feeds mainly on fish, tuna, squid, and other small sea animals.
- It is unusual among seabirds in that it doesn't dive into the water for prey.
- One way it acquires food is by using its hook-tipped bill to snatch prey from the surface of the water.
- Another way it acquires food is by taking it from weaker birds by force.
- This behavior is known as kleptoparasitism.

The student wants to emphasize a similarity between the two ways a magnificent frigatebird acquires food. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. A magnificent frigatebird never dives into the water, instead using its hook-tipped bill to snatch prey from the surface.
- B. Neither of a magnificent frigatebird's two ways of acquiring food requires the bird to dive into the water.
- C. Of the magnificent frigatebird's two ways of acquiring food, only one is known as kleptoparasitism.
- D. In addition to snatching prey from the water with its hook-tipped bill, a magnificent frigatebird takes food from other birds by force.

ID: 7e601b64 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the two ways a magnificent frigatebird acquires food, noting that neither way requires the seabird to dive into the water.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes how a magnificent frigatebird captures prey without diving into water; it doesn't emphasize a similarity between the two ways the seabird acquires food. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence notes the term used to describe one of the two ways that magnificent frigatebirds acquire food; it doesn't emphasize a similarity between the two ways. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence describes the two ways that a magnificent frigatebird acquires food; it doesn't emphasize a similarity between the two ways.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 92e3143d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 92e3143d

The prime meridian, the global indicator of zero degrees longitude established in 1884, was originally determined using astronomically derived coordinates. _____ as decades passed, new calculations would reveal increasingly precise coordinates, yet the prime meridian remained unchanged; it wasn't until the 1980s that, spurred by improved geodetic data, the prime meridian was officially moved—roughly one hundred meters east.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Specifically,
- B. To that end,
- C. Again and again,
- D. Granted,

ID: 92e3143d Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "Again and again" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that new calculations revealed increasingly precise coordinates for the location of the prime meridian—refers to events that occurred multiple times in the decades after the establishment of the prime meridian in 1884 (which is described in the preceding sentence).

Choice A is incorrect because "specifically" illogically signals that the information in this sentence provides specific, precise details elaborating on the description of the prime meridian's establishment in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence indicates that increasingly precise coordinates were revealed on multiple occasions in the decades following the meridian's establishment. Choice B is incorrect because "to that end" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a means of accomplishing a goal established in the previous sentence about the prime meridian's establishment. Instead, the sentence indicates that increasingly precise coordinates were revealed on multiple occasions in the decades following the meridian's establishment. Choice D is incorrect because "granted" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is in opposition to the information about the prime meridian's establishment in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence indicates that increasingly precise coordinates were revealed on multiple occasions in the decades following the meridian's establishment.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID da736bf1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: da736bf1

A turtle shell appears external to the animal, protecting its body like armor. _____ the shell is often incorrectly assumed to be an exoskeleton, a rigid outer casing like that of a crustacean or an insect, when in fact it is an endoskeleton, a part of the turtle’s internal bone structure, more akin to a spine or a pair of ribs.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. That being said,
- B. However,
- C. For instance,
- D. Hence,

ID: da736bf1 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "Hence" logically signals that the information in this sentence about turtle shells—that people incorrectly assume they are exoskeletons—is a consequence of the shells appearing external to the animal.

Choice A is incorrect because "that being said" illogically signals that this sentence qualifies or contrasts with the previous information about turtle shells appearing external to the animal. Instead, it presents a consequence of that information. Choice B is incorrect because "however" illogically signals that this sentence contrasts with the previous information about turtle shells appearing external to the animal. Instead, it presents a consequence of that information. Choice C is incorrect because "for instance" illogically signals that this sentence provides an example supporting the previous information about turtle shells appearing external to the animal. Instead, it presents a consequence of that information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 00c2a8f6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 00c2a8f6

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Lighthouses send out crucial light signals to help ships and other watercraft navigate at night.
- Before automation, lighthouses were run by lighthouse keepers.
- Maria Younghans was the lighthouse keeper at Biloxi Light in Mississippi.
- She held this position from 1867 to 1918.
- Flora McNeil was the lighthouse keeper at Bridgeport Breakwater Light in Connecticut.
- She held this position from 1904 to 1920.

The student wants to emphasize the order in which the two lighthouse keepers began their careers. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. From 1867 to 1918, the nighttime waters of Mississippi were more navigable thanks to lighthouse keepers Flora McNeil and Maria Younghans.
- B. Before automation, lighthouse keepers like Maria Younghans and Flora McNeil were crucial to ensuring safe navigation for watercraft.
- C. Flora McNeil began her career as a lighthouse keeper years after Maria Younghans did.
- D. Maria Younghans’s career as a lighthouse keeper ended in 1918, whereas Flora McNeil’s ended in 1920.

ID: 00c2a8f6 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the order in which the two lighthouse keepers began their careers, noting that McNeil, who became the keeper at Bridgeport Breakwater Light in 1904, began her career years after Younghans, who became the keeper at Biloxi Light in 1867.

Choice A is incorrect because it makes a generalization about the effects of McNeil’s and Younghans’s work; it doesn’t emphasize the order in which the two keepers began their careers. In addition, the sentence misrepresents information from the notes; McNeil was the keeper at a lighthouse in Connecticut from 1904 to 1920, not at a lighthouse in Mississippi from 1867 to 1918. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence claims that Younghans and McNeil were crucial to ensuring the safety of watercraft before lighthouses became automated; it doesn’t emphasize the order in which the two keepers began their careers. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes when the lighthouse keepers’ respective careers ended; it doesn’t emphasize the order in which the two keepers began their careers.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 965536b0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 965536b0

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Digital Light Synthesis (DLS) is a form of additive manufacturing that utilizes light to rapidly cure liquid resin into high-quality, 3D objects.
- Step 1: Ultraviolet (UV) light images are projected up into a pool of liquid resin, where the object’s first layer takes shape.
- Step 2: The partially cured resin object is raised, leaving a thin space (a “dead zone”) beneath it for oxygen and liquid resin to flow through.
- Step 3: The UV light passes through the dead zone—maintaining the flow of resin—and partially cures additional layers of the object.
- Step 4: When the resin object is complete, it is baked in an oven to complete the curing.

The student wants to describe how DLS cures 3D objects. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. DLS is a form of additive manufacturing that creates a “dead zone” in which UV light solidifies layer by layer before being baked in an oven, creating a high-quality, 3D object.
- B. DLS cures 3D objects by passing through a “dead zone,” adding layers to the object, then curing the object in an oven.
- C. In DLS, UV light images are projected into a liquid resin pool to cure a 3D object layer by layer; once solidified, the object is baked in an oven.
- D. In DLS, UV light is projected into layers of liquid resin until the resin solidifies and passes through a “dead zone,” wherein the curing is completed.

ID: 965536b0 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence describes how DLS cures 3D objects, noting that UV light is projected into resin to cure the object in layers, after which the object is baked to complete the curing process.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence does describe some elements of the curing process, the description misrepresents information in the notes; this sentence suggests that the UV light, rather than the 3D object, is baked in an oven. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence does describe some elements of the curing process, the description misrepresents information in the notes: the UV light, not DLS, passes through the dead zone. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence does describe some elements of the curing process, the description misrepresents information in the notes. This sentence suggests that curing is complete when the already-solidified resin passes through the dead zone; rather, liquid resin passes through the dead zone and is solidified in layers, after which curing is completed in the oven.

Question ID 88d2dd07

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 88d2dd07

Researchers Helena Mihaljević-Brandt, Lucía Santamaría, and Marco Tullney report that while mathematicians may have traditionally worked alone, evidence points to a shift in the opposite direction. _____ mathematicians are choosing to collaborate with their peers—a trend illustrated by a rise in the number of mathematics publications credited to multiple authors.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Similarly,
- B. For this reason,
- C. Furthermore,
- D. Increasingly,

ID: 88d2dd07 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “Increasingly” logically signals that the claim in this sentence—that mathematicians are collaborating with their peers—marks a change relative to what was traditionally done. As the previous sentence explains, while mathematicians may have traditionally worked alone, evidence points to a shift in the opposite direction. The claim describes the shift: a rise in collaboration.

Choice A is incorrect because “similarly” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence is similar to, but separate from, the previous claim about the shift away from mathematicians working alone. Instead, the claim about the rise in collaboration elaborates on the previous claim, describing the shift. Choice B is incorrect because “for this reason” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence is caused by the previous claim about the shift away from mathematicians working alone. Instead, the claim about the rise in collaboration elaborates on the previous claim, describing the shift. Choice C is incorrect because “furthermore” illogically signals that the claim in this sentence is in addition to the previous claim about the shift away from mathematicians working alone. Instead, the claim about the rise in collaboration elaborates on the previous claim, describing the shift.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9697e723

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 9697e723

A staunch supporter of women’s voting rights, Wilhelmina Kekelaokalaninui Widemann Dowsett sought to coordinate the efforts of suffragists in her native Hawai’i. _____ in 1912, she founded the National Women’s Equal Suffrage Association of Hawai’i, an organization that lobbied for women’s voting rights in the US territory.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. In other words,
- B. Conversely,
- C. To that end,
- D. Alternatively,

ID: 9697e723 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. “To that end” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Dowsett founded the National Women’s Equal Suffrage Association of Hawai’i—describes an action Dowsett took to achieve the goal stated in the previous sentence: to coordinate the efforts of suffragists in Hawai’i.

Choice A is incorrect because “in other words” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about Dowsett founding a women’s suffrage association is a paraphrase or restatement of the previous information about Dowsett seeking to coordinate suffragists’ efforts. Instead, the sentence describes a specific action Dowsett took to achieve this goal. Choice B is incorrect because “conversely” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about Dowsett founding a women’s suffrage association contrasts with the previous information about Dowsett seeking to coordinate suffragists’ efforts. Instead, the sentence describes a specific action Dowsett took to achieve this goal. Choice D is incorrect because “alternatively” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about Dowsett founding a women’s suffrage association presents an alternative to her seeking to coordinate suffragists’ efforts. Instead, the sentence describes a specific action Dowsett took to achieve this goal.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7c65a1d2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 7c65a1d2

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Abdulrazak Gurnah was awarded the 2021 Nobel Prize in Literature.
- Gurnah was born in Zanzibar in East Africa and currently lives in the United Kingdom.
- Many readers have singled out Gurnah’s 1994 book *Paradise* for praise.
- *Paradise* is a historical novel about events that occurred in colonial East Africa.

The student wants to introduce *Paradise* to an audience unfamiliar with the novel and its author. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Abdulrazak Gurnah, who wrote *Paradise* and later was awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature, was born in Zanzibar in East Africa and currently lives in the United Kingdom.
- B. Many readers have singled out Abdulrazak Gurnah’s 1994 book *Paradise*, a historical novel about colonial East Africa, for praise.
- C. A much-praised historical novel about colonial East Africa, *Paradise* (1994) was written by Abdulrazak Gurnah, winner of the 2021 Nobel Prize in Literature.
- D. *Paradise* is a historical novel about events that occurred in colonial East Africa, Abdulrazak Gurnah’s homeland.

ID: 7c65a1d2 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence effectively introduces *Paradise* to an audience unfamiliar with the novel and its author, describing *Paradise* as a historical novel about colonial East Africa and its author as the winner of the 2021 Nobel Prize in Literature.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence introduces Abdulrazak Gurnah to an audience unfamiliar with the author, it doesn’t effectively introduce *Paradise*. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence provides background information about *Paradise*, it doesn’t effectively introduce the novel to an audience unfamiliar with its author. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence provides background information about *Paradise*, it doesn’t effectively introduce the novel to an audience unfamiliar with its author.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 52493edb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 52493edb

Historically, most conductors of major orchestras and opera companies have been European men, but a new, more diverse generation of artists is stepping up to the podium. Mexico’s Alondra de la Parra took over as conductor for the Queensland Symphony Orchestra in 2017, _____ and Colombia’s Lina Gonzalez-Granados did the same for the Los Angeles Opera in 2022.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. in addition,
- B. lastly,
- C. granted,
- D. for instance,

ID: 52493edb Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “For instance” logically signals that the details in this sentence—that Mexican conductor Alondra de la Parra and Colombian conductor Lina Gonzalez-Granados took new conducting positions—are examples supporting the previous claim about the new generation of artists.

Choice A is incorrect because “in addition” illogically signals that the details in this sentence about de la Parra and Gonzalez-Granados are merely additional facts related to the previous claim about the new generation of artists. Instead, they are examples supporting that claim. Choice B is incorrect because “lastly” illogically signals that the details in this sentence about de la Parra and Gonzalez-Granados are the last step or a concluding summary of the previous claim about the new generation of artists. Instead, they are examples supporting that claim. Choice C is incorrect because “granted” illogically signals that the details in this sentence about de la Parra and Gonzalez-Granados are exceptions to the previous claim about the new generation of artists. Instead, they are examples supporting that claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 56c484c4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 56c484c4

In Annie Dillard’s *Pilgrim at Tinker Creek*—where, early on, the author marvels at a single goldfish’s delicate fins but later winces when imagining a horde of goldfish laying and eating their own eggs—Dillard struggles to reconcile the complicated juxtapositions of the natural world. _____ nature’s mesmerizing intricacy and pitiless harshness prove inextricably linked for Dillard, like “two branches of the same creek.”

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. To that end,
- B. Ultimately,
- C. Moreover,
- D. Hence,

ID: 56c484c4 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Ultimately” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that, for Dillard, nature’s mesmerizing intricacy and pitiless harshness are inextricably linked—is the final conclusion or realization reached after her struggle to reconcile the juxtapositions of the natural world mentioned in the previous sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because “to that end” illogically signals that linking nature’s intricacy and harshness was Dillard’s deliberate goal or purpose in struggling to reconcile nature’s juxtapositions. Instead, the sentence presents her final realization after that struggle. Choice C is incorrect because “moreover” illogically signals that the information in this sentence merely adds to Dillard’s struggle to reconcile nature’s juxtapositions mentioned in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence presents her final realization after that struggle. Choice D is incorrect because “hence” illogically signals that nature’s intricacy and harshness being linked is a direct consequence of Dillard’s struggle to reconcile the juxtapositions mentioned in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence presents her final realization after that struggle.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9976fc79

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 9976fc79

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Cities tend to have a wide range of flowering vegetation in parks, yards, and gardens.
- This vegetation provides a varied diet for honeybees, strengthening bees’ immune systems.
- On average, 62.5 percent of bees in an urban area will survive a harsh winter.
- Rural areas are often dominated by monoculture crops such as corn or wheat.
- On average, only 40 percent of honeybees in a rural area will survive a harsh winter.

The student wants to make and support a generalization about honeybees. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Cities tend to have a wider range of flowering vegetation than do rural areas, which are often dominated by monoculture crops.
- B. In urban areas, over 60 percent of honeybees, on average, will survive a harsh winter, whereas in rural areas, only 40 percent will.
- C. The strength of honeybees’ immune systems depends on what the bees eat, and a varied diet is more available to bees in an urban area than to those in a rural area.
- D. Honeybees are more likely to thrive in cities than in rural areas because the varied diet available in urban areas strengthens the bees’ immune systems.

ID: 9976fc79 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer because the sentence makes and supports a generalization about honeybees. It claims that honeybees living in urban areas are more likely to thrive than rural bees, and it supports the claim with information about the effect of a varied diet on urban bees’ immune systems.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence makes a generalization, it doesn’t mention honeybees. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence provides data about honeybee survival, it doesn’t make a generalization about honeybees based on this information. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence makes a generalization about honeybees’ diets and immune systems, it doesn’t provide adequate support for this generalization.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f1f5731f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: f1f5731f

In Asiya Wadud’s 2022 poem “Shorn, Treaded Red,” the poet contemplates a painting that has inspired her: Etel Adnan’s 2020 work *Satellites* 27. The painting, which features overlapping geometric shapes, fuels the poem’s exploration of temporality and identity. _____ in responding to Adnan’s artwork, Wadud’s poem reflects on the relationship between poetry and other art forms.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. In other words,
- B. For instance,
- C. What’s more,
- D. Conversely,

ID: f1f5731f Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "What’s more" logically signals that this sentence introduces an additional aspect of Wadud’s poem beyond what was previously discussed. While the previous sentence establishes that Adnan’s painting has inspired "the poem’s exploration of temporality and identity," this sentence provides a separate, additional claim about the poem: that it reflects on poetry’s relationship to other art forms.

Choice A is incorrect because "in other words" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a paraphrase or restatement of the previous point about how Adnan’s painting has inspired "the poem’s exploration of temporality and identity." Instead, the sentence provides a separate, additional claim about the poem. Choice B is incorrect because "for instance" illogically signals that the information in this sentence supports the previous point about "the poem’s exploration of temporality and identity" by providing an example. Instead, the sentence provides a separate, additional claim about the poem. Choice D is incorrect because "conversely" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is contrary to the previous point about how Adnan’s painting has inspired "the poem’s exploration of temporality and identity." Instead, the sentence provides a separate, additional claim about the poem.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b9427863

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: b9427863

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Some powerful works of literature have so influenced readers that new legislation has been passed as a result.
- *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano* (1789) is the autobiography of a man who endured slavery on both sides of the Atlantic.
- Equiano’s book contributed to the passage of the Slave Trade Act of 1807.
- *The Jungle* (1906) is a fictional work by Upton Sinclair that describes unsanitary conditions in US meatpacking plants.
- Sinclair’s book contributed to the passage of the Pure Food and Drug Act in 1906.

The student wants to emphasize a difference between the two books. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Although both are powerful works of literature that contributed to new legislation, Equiano’s book is an autobiography, while Sinclair’s is fictional.
- B. They may have written about different topics, but Equiano and Sinclair both influenced readers.
- C. The 1807 Slave Trade Act resulted in part from a book by Equiano, while the 1906 Pure Food and Drug Act resulted in part from a book by Sinclair.
- D. *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano* and *The Jungle* are two works of literature that contributed to new legislation (concerning the slave trade and food safety, respectively).

ID: b9427863 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice emphasizes a difference between the two books by using relevant information from the notes to contrast their genres.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice mentions a difference between the books (their different topics), but it emphasizes a similarity between the books (their influence on readers). Choice C is incorrect. This choice provides information about the books that reflects both a similarity (both resulted in new laws) and a difference (the specific laws that resulted), without emphasizing either. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t emphasize a difference between the two books. Instead, it *emphasizes a similarity*.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 918ce664

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 918ce664

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The National Congress of American Indians (NCAI) was founded in 1944 by representatives of fifty tribal governments.
- The NCAI was created to protect the sovereignty of Indigenous tribes.
- Napoleon B. Johnson (Cherokee) was the NCAI’s first president.
- In 1975, the US Congress passed the Indian Self-Determination and Education Assistance Act (Public Law 96-638).
- This legislation formally acknowledged tribes’ right to self-governance.
- The advocacy of the NCAI was a key factor in the law’s passing.

The student wants to identify an accomplishment of the NCAI. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The NCAI, founded by representatives of fifty tribal governments, had Napoleon B. Johnson (Cherokee) as its first president.
- B. Founded in 1944, the NCAI was created by representatives of tribal governments from fifty sovereign Indigenous tribes.
- C. The NCAI’s advocacy was key to the passing of Public Law 96-638, legislation formally acknowledging Indigenous tribes’ right to self-governance.
- D. In 1975, the NCAI passed the Indian Self-Determination and Education Assistance Act, which was created to protect the sovereignty of Indigenous tribes.

ID: 918ce664 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence directly identifies an accomplishment of the NCAI: that its advocacy was key to the passing of Public Law 96-638, which formally acknowledged Indigenous tribes’ right to self-governance.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence provides information about the NCAI’s founding and its first president, but it doesn’t identify an accomplishment of the organization. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence describes the NCAI’s founding, but it doesn’t identify an accomplishment of the organization. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents the information in the notes: the US Congress, not the NCAI, passed the Indian Self-Determination and Education Assistance Act.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 407c4732

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 407c4732

Karel Čapek’s 1920 play *R.U.R. (Rossum’s Universal Robots)*, in which artificial workers overthrow their masters, left an indelible mark on the science fiction genre, and the English language, by introducing the term “robot” (derived from the Czech word *robota*, meaning “indentured labor” or “drudgery”). _____ Čapek’s play also contributed to a venerable literary and mythological tradition: using artificial beings as mirrors and foils for humanity.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Beyond the simple coining of a term,
- B. By achieving such a lofty goal,
- C. Ultimately limited in its lasting influence,
- D. Despite its creation of such an iconic trope,

ID: 407c4732 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “Beyond the simple coining of a term” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Čapek’s play contributed to a literary and mythological tradition of using artificial beings as mirrors and foils for humanity—describes contributions that extend beyond the previously described achievement of introducing the term “robot” to the English language.

Choice B is incorrect because “by achieving such a lofty goal” illogically signals that the play’s contribution to a literary and mythological tradition was accomplished through the means of the previously described achievement of introducing the term “robot.” Instead, the sentence describes an additional contribution that goes beyond that achievement. Choice C is incorrect because “ultimately limited in its lasting influence” illogically minimizes the play’s influence, which is inconsistent with the text’s other claims about the play. Instead, the sentence describes contributions that go beyond the previously described achievement of introducing the term “robot.” Choice D is incorrect because “despite its creation of such an iconic trope” illogically signals that the play’s contribution to a literary and mythological tradition is surprising given the play’s creation of an iconic trope. Instead, the sentence describes contributions that go beyond the previously described achievement of introducing the term “robot.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ab3df18e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: ab3df18e

One proposed boundary between Earth’s atmosphere and outer space is the Kármán line, 100 km above sea level. Based on the work of physicist Theodore von Kármán, this line marks the theoretical height at which an aircraft no longer remains aloft using the force of lift. _____ an aircraft sustains flight past this altitude primarily by its velocity, reaching a speed sufficient to maintain an orbit but not to generate enough lift from the thin air.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. For instance,
- B. Instead,
- C. Granted,
- D. Regardless,

ID: ab3df18e Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Instead” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that an aircraft sustains flight past the Kármán line primarily by its velocity—is an alternative means of sustaining flight past this line, which the previous sentence indicates is the theoretical height at which an aircraft no longer remains aloft by using the force of lift.

Choice A is incorrect because “for instance” illogically signals that the information about an aircraft sustaining flight by velocity exemplifies the previous information about the Kármán line marking the theoretical height at which an aircraft no longer remains aloft using lift. Rather, the sentence describes an alternative means of sustaining flight past this line. Choice C is incorrect because “granted” illogically signals that the information about an aircraft sustaining flight by velocity is a concession or acknowledgment that qualifies the previous information about the Kármán line marking the theoretical height at which an aircraft no longer remains aloft using lift. Rather, the sentence describes an alternative means of sustaining flight past this line. Choice D is incorrect because “regardless” illogically signals that the information about an aircraft sustaining flight by velocity is true despite the previous information about the Kármán line marking the theoretical height at which an aircraft no longer remains aloft using lift. Rather, the sentence describes an alternative means of sustaining flight past this line.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1d4ca1e1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 1d4ca1e1

A team of ornithologists documented patterns of conspecific brood parasitism among wood ducks (*Aix sponsa*) in California. The researchers observed several female wood ducks visiting dozens of nesting sites and laying eggs to be incubated by other nesting *A. sponsa*. Subject 7F64B, _____ visited a select few nesting sites before laying and incubating her eggs herself.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. in particular,
- B. alternatively,
- C. for example,
- D. similarly,

ID: 1d4ca1e1 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Alternatively” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that Subject 7F64B incubated her own eggs—describes a contrasting alternative to the brood parasitism behavior described in the previous sentence, in which female wood ducks laid eggs to be incubated by other nesting ducks.

Choice A is incorrect because “in particular” illogically signals that Subject 7F64B’s behavior provides a specific, focused detail about, or example of, the brood parasitism behavior described in the previous sentence. Instead, Subject 7F64B’s behavior represents a contrasting alternative to that brood parasitism. Choice C is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that Subject 7F64B’s behavior provides a specific example of the brood parasitism behavior described in the previous sentence. Instead, Subject 7F64B’s behavior represents a contrasting alternative to that brood parasitism. Choice D is incorrect because “similarly” illogically signals that Subject 7F64B’s behavior is similar to the brood parasitism behavior described in the previous sentence. Instead, Subject 7F64B’s behavior represents a contrasting alternative to that brood parasitism.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e5a30b6d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: e5a30b6d

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Malapportionment is the over- or underrepresentation (relative to population size) of electoral districts in a governing body.
- It is a common feature of representative governments.
- There are 169 seats in Norway’s supreme legislature (the Storting).
- Seats are distributed by a formula that awards 1 point per resident and 1.8 points per unit of land.
- Less populated rural districts with large tracts of land receive a disproportionate number of seats compared to smaller but more populated urban districts.

The student wants to refute a claim that malapportionment in the Storting favors small urban districts. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Less populated rural districts are disproportionately underrepresented in the Storting, creating an unfair advantage for smaller but more populated urban districts.
- B. It’s untrue that malapportionment in the 169-seat Storting favors small urban districts; rather, the formula for distributing seats overrepresents more populated districts.
- C. A common feature of representative governments, malapportionment occurs when electoral districts are over- or underrepresented.
- D. Awarding more points per unit of land than points per resident, the formula for distributing Storting seats overrepresents less populated rural districts with large tracts of land.

ID: e5a30b6d Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. By noting that the formula for distributing Storting seats overrepresents less populated rural districts, the sentence effectively refutes a claim that malapportionment in the Storting favors small urban districts.

Choice A is incorrect because the sentence claims that malapportionment in the Storting favors small urban districts; it doesn’t refute such a claim. Moreover, it misrepresents information in the notes. According to the notes, the formula for distributing seats overrepresents less populated, not more populated, districts. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence appears to refute a claim that malapportionment in the Storting favors small urban districts, it misrepresents information in the notes. According to the notes, the formula for distributing seats overrepresents less populated, not more populated, districts. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence explains what malapportionment is but doesn’t address malapportionment in the Storting specifically.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f0f77b41

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: f0f77b41

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- British musicians John Lennon and Paul McCartney shared writing credit for numerous Beatles songs.
- Many Lennon-McCartney songs were actually written by either Lennon or McCartney, not by both.
- The exact authorship of specific parts of many Beatles songs, such as the verse for “In My Life,” is disputed.
- Mark Glickman, Jason Brown, and Ryan Song used statistical methods to analyze the musical content of Beatles songs.
- They concluded that there is 18.9% probability that McCartney wrote the verse for “In My Life,” stating that the verse is “consistent with Lennon’s songwriting style.”

The student wants to make a generalization about the kind of study conducted by Glickman, Brown, and Song. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Based on statistical analysis, Glickman, Brown, and Song claim that John Lennon wrote the verse of “In My Life.”
- B. There is only an 18.9% probability that Paul McCartney wrote the verse for “In My Life”; John Lennon is the more likely author.
- C. It is likely that John Lennon, not Paul McCartney, wrote the verse for “In My Life.”
- D. Researchers have used statistical methods to address questions of authorship within the field of music.

ID: f0f77b41 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence uses information from the notes to make a generalization about the kind of study Glickman, Brown, and Song conducted. Specifically, the sentence indicates that the study was of a kind that used statistical methods to address questions of authorship within the field of music.

Choice A is incorrect because the sentence summarizes the methodology and findings of a particular analysis of a single song; it doesn’t make a generalization about the kind of study conducted. Choice B is incorrect because the sentence mentions the data and conclusion of a particular analysis of a single song; it doesn’t make a generalization about the kind of study conducted. Choice C is incorrect because the sentence focuses on a specific conclusion from a particular analysis of a single song; it doesn’t make a generalization about the kind of study conducted.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 92a79a55

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 92a79a55

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- British scholar Robert Plot described fossilized dinosaur bones in his 1676 book *The Natural History of Oxfordshire*.
- Plot earned a reputation for being the first person to have discovered dinosaur remains.
- In 1990, archaeologists in Lesotho, in southern Africa, discovered a fossilized phalanx of a *Massospondylus carinatus* dinosaur in a cave once inhabited by humans.
- Indigenous Khoesan and Basotho peoples had inhabited the cave beginning around 1100 CE.
- According to paleontologist Julien Benoit, these peoples may have found the phalanx and brought it to the cave centuries before Plot’s descriptions.

The student wants to emphasize the significance of the 1990 discovery to Plot’s reputation. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Benoit challenged Plot’s reputation for being the first person to have discovered *M. carinatus* remains.
- B. Evidence that Khoesan and Basotho peoples may have found an *M. carinatus* phalanx as long ago as 1100 CE suggests that Plot may not have been the first person to have discovered dinosaur remains.
- C. According to Benoit’s analysis of the 1990 discovery, Indigenous peoples in southern Africa may have brought the fossilized phalanx to the cave as long ago as 1100 CE.
- D. In 1990, more than three centuries after Plot claimed in his book that he had found fossilized dinosaur bones, archaeologists uncovered evidence in southern Africa that disproved his claims.

ID: 92a79a55 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Noting that the evidence suggests Indigenous peoples may have found dinosaur remains in 1100 CE, the sentence emphasizes how the 1990 discovery challenged Plot’s reputation as the first person to discover dinosaur remains.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence does emphasize that Benoit challenged Plot’s reputation, it misrepresents information in the notes; Plot was reputed to be the first person to discover dinosaur remains in general, not the first person to discover *M. carinatus* remains specifically. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence only partially explains the significance of the 1990 discovery, noting that it suggests Indigenous people brought dinosaur remains to the cave in 1100 CE; it doesn’t explain the discovery’s significance to Plot’s reputation. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence does emphasize that the discovery challenged Plot’s reputation, it misrepresents information in the notes. The notes don’t indicate that the 1990 discovery cast any doubt on Plot’s claims to have found fossilized dinosaur bones; rather, the discovery challenged Plot’s reputation for being the first to discover dinosaur bones.

Question ID 5d5fce94

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 5d5fce94

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Researchers Gwangsu Kim et al. sought to explore the relationship between the brain’s ability to process natural sounds and its ability to process music.
- They used an artificial deep neural network (DNN) that models how the brain processes auditory information.
- The DNN had been trained to detect natural sounds (excluding music).
- Finding: The DNN spontaneously developed neurons that responded to music but not to other auditory stimuli.
- Conclusion: The brain’s ability to process music may arise as a by-product of natural sound processing.

The student wants to present the aim of the study. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. In their study, the researchers evaluated whether an artificial deep neural network could model how the brain processes auditory information.
- B. By training an artificial deep neural network, the researchers aimed to establish that the brain’s ability to process natural sounds arises as a by-product of processing music.
- C. The researchers used an artificial deep neural network, which spontaneously developed neurons that responded to music but not to other auditory stimuli.
- D. Using an artificial deep neural network, the researchers sought to explore the relationship between the brain’s ability to process natural sounds and its ability to process music.

ID: 5d5fce94 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence presents the aim of the study, noting that the researchers sought to explore the relationship between the brain’s ability to process natural sounds and its ability to process music.

Choice A is incorrect. The researchers used the DNN to achieve their aim of exploring the relationship between the brain’s ability to process natural sounds and its ability to process music; evaluating the DNN itself was not their aim. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents the researchers’ conclusion as their aim and also misrepresents that conclusion. The researchers’ aim was to explore the relationship between the brain’s ability to process natural sounds and its ability to process music; their conclusion was that the brain’s ability to process music arises as a by-product of natural sound processing, not the other way around. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence merely describes a finding from the study; it doesn’t present the aim of the study.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 11950801

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 11950801

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Stars form in a galaxy when gravity causes a massive cloud of dust and gas to collapse.
- A galaxy in a phase of rapid star formation is called a starburst galaxy.
- Quenching is a process in which a galaxy loses star-forming gas.
- A galaxy that no longer forms stars is called a quenched galaxy.
- A quenched galaxy has entered the poststarburst phase.

The student wants to explain what a quenched galaxy is. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Before quenching, a starburst galaxy will form stars at a rapid rate.
- B. When it becomes quenched, a starburst galaxy enters the poststarburst phase.
- C. Having entered the poststarburst phase, a quenched galaxy is one that no longer forms stars.
- D. A starburst galaxy will lose star-forming gas and eventually become quenched.

ID: 11950801 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. This choice defines a quenched galaxy as “one that no longer forms stars.”

Choice A is incorrect. This choice only describes what happens before quenching. Choice B is incorrect. This choice only describes what happens after quenching. Choice D is incorrect. This choice only describes what causes quenching.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6a4641d4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 6a4641d4

A 2017 study of sign language learners tested the role of iconicity—the similarity of a sign to the thing it represents—in language acquisition. The study found that the greater the iconicity of a sign, the more likely it was to have been learned. _____ the correlation between acquisition and iconicity was lower than that between acquisition and another factor studied: sign frequency.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. In fact,
- B. In other words,
- C. Granted,
- D. As a result,

ID: 6a4641d4 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. “Granted” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that iconicity is not as highly correlated with acquisition as sign frequency is—is true in spite of the information in the previous sentence about the positive correlation between iconicity and acquisition.

Choice A is incorrect because “in fact” illogically signals that this sentence either emphasizes or refutes the information in the previous sentence about the positive correlation between acquisition and iconicity. Instead, it provides information about a different correlation—that between acquisition and sign frequency. Choice B is incorrect because “in other words” illogically signals that this sentence merely restates the information in the previous sentence about the positive correlation between acquisition and iconicity. Instead, this sentence provides information about a different correlation—that between acquisition and sign frequency. Choice D is incorrect because “as a result” illogically signals that this sentence is a consequence of the information in the previous sentence about the positive correlation between acquisition and iconicity. Instead, this sentence provides information about a different correlation—that between acquisition and sign frequency.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1d524ae8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 1d524ae8

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In the midst of the US Civil War, Susie Taylor escaped slavery and fled to Union-army-occupied St. Simons Island off the Georgia coast.
- She began working for an all-Black army regiment as a nurse and teacher.
- In 1902, she published a book about the time she spent with the regiment.
- Her book was the only Civil War memoir to be published by a Black woman.
- It is still available to readers in print and online.

The student wants to emphasize the uniqueness of Taylor’s accomplishment. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Taylor fled to St. Simons Island, which was then occupied by the Union army, for whom she began working.
- B. After escaping slavery, Taylor began working for an all-Black army regiment as a nurse and teacher.
- C. The book Taylor wrote about the time she spent with the regiment is still available to readers in print and online.
- D. Taylor was the only Black woman to publish a Civil War memoir.

ID: 1d524ae8 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. By indicating that Taylor’s book was the only Civil War memoir published by a Black woman, this sentence emphasizes the uniqueness, or one-of-a-kind nature, of Taylor’s accomplishment.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence describes some of Taylor’s accomplishments, it doesn’t emphasize the uniqueness of them. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence describes some of Taylor’s accomplishments, it doesn’t emphasize that they were unique. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence provides information about Taylor’s book, it doesn’t emphasize what made the book unique.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1085ebb3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 1085ebb3

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The farm-size transition hypothesis predicts that economic pressures associated with modernization result in smaller farms amalgamating into larger-scale commercial farms.
- Masters et al. (2013): The average farm size in Asia “already has or will soon begin to rise.”
- Promkhambut et al. (2023) argue that small rice farms in Thailand have adopted modern farming methods without a significant scaling-up of farm size.
- Promkhambut et al.: “The persistence of [small] rice farms [in Thailand] does not represent a ‘failure’ to modernize...or a ‘truncated’ transition—it is a *response* to modernization.”

The student wants to make and support a claim regarding the applicability of the farm-size transition hypothesis to Thailand. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Taken together, the studies by Masters et al. and Promkhambut et al. suggest that rice farms in Thailand have responded to the economic pressures associated with modernization by expanding in size.
- B. Masters et al. report that the average farm size “already has or will soon begin to rise” in Asia, a finding that is consistent with the farm-size transition hypothesis.
- C. The predicted shift to large-scale commercial farming may not hold true for rice farms in Thailand, where, according to Promkhambut et al., rice farms have remained small as they’ve modernized.
- D. Although the farm-size transition hypothesis may be applicable to some countries in Asia, it is inconsistent with the development of rice farming in Thailand.

ID: 1085ebb3 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence makes a claim about the applicability of the farm-size transition hypothesis—the prediction that smaller farms will amalgamate into larger-scale commercial farms as a response to the economic pressures of modernization—to Thailand, noting that the hypothesis may not hold true for Thailand. It supports the claim with the argument from Promkhambut et al. that Thailand’s rice farms have remained small despite modernizing.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence makes a claim about the applicability of the farm-size transition hypothesis to Thailand, it mischaracterizes information from the notes: Promkhambut et al. argue that, despite modernizing in response to economic pressures, rice farms in Thailand have not expanded in size. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence connects a claim from Masters et al. to the farm-size transition hypothesis; it doesn’t make and support a claim about the applicability of the hypothesis to Thailand, specifically. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence makes a claim about the applicability of the farm-size transition hypothesis to Thailand, it doesn’t support the claim.

Question ID 47080327

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 47080327

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 2020, theater students at Radford and Virginia Tech chose an interactive, online format to present a play about woman suffrage activists.
- Their “Women and the Vote” website featured an interactive digital drawing of a Victorian-style house.
- Audiences were asked to focus on a room of their choice and select from that room an artifact related to the suffrage movement.
- One click took them to video clips, songs, artwork, and texts associated with the artifact.
- The play was popular with audiences because the format allowed them to control the experience.

The student wants to explain an advantage of the “Women and the Vote” format. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. “Women and the Vote” featured a drawing of a Victorian-style house with several rooms, each containing suffrage artifacts.
- B. To access video clips, songs, artwork, and texts, audiences had to first click on an artifact.
- C. The “Women and the Vote” format appealed to audiences because it allowed them to control the experience.
- D. Using an interactive format, theater students at Radford and Virginia Tech created “Women and the Vote,” a play about woman suffrage activists.

ID: 47080327 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence explains an advantage of the “Women and the Vote” format, noting that the format appealed to audiences because it allowed them to control the experience.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes a digital drawing on the “Women and the Vote” website; it doesn’t explain an advantage of the play’s format. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence explains how audiences interacted with the “Women and the Vote” website; it doesn’t explain an advantage of the play’s format. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence mentions that “Women and the Vote” had an interactive format, it doesn’t explain what advantage this format might have.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a01b0798

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: a01b0798

In retrospect, one of the lessons of the 2003 Human Genome Project is that a gene is affected by many factors, not the least of which is its interactions with the protein products of other genes. _____ rather than just focusing on the human genome, efforts to better understand gene mutations related to disease have begun to consider the human proteome, the complete set of proteins expressed by human genes.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. In other words,
- B. That said,
- C. For example,
- D. Accordingly,

ID: a01b0798 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "Accordingly" logically signals that this sentence states a result or consequence of the previous information about the 2003 Human Genome Project. Taking into account an important lesson of the 2003 project (that a gene is affected by interactions with the protein products of other genes), research has begun to consider the human proteome instead of just the genome.

Choice A is incorrect because "in other words" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a paraphrase or restatement of the previous information about the 2003 Human Genome Project. Instead, this sentence states a result or consequence of that information. Choice B is incorrect because "that said" illogically signals that the information in this sentence qualifies or contrasts with the previous information about the 2003 Human Genome Project. Instead, this sentence states a result or consequence of that information. Choice C is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that this sentence provides an example supporting the previous information about the 2003 Human Genome Project. Instead, this sentence states a result or consequence of that information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 09b0e29a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 09b0e29a

A firefly uses specialized muscles to draw oxygen into its lower abdomen through narrow tubes, triggering a chemical reaction whereby the oxygen combines with chemicals in the firefly’s abdomen to produce a glow. _____ when the firefly stops drawing in oxygen, the reaction—and the glow—cease.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. For instance,
- B. By contrast,
- C. Specifically,
- D. In conclusion,

ID: 09b0e29a Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “By contrast” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that a firefly’s glow ceases when it stops drawing in oxygen—contrasts with the previous sentence’s discussion of the processes that cause a firefly to begin to glow.

Choice A is incorrect because “for instance” illogically signals that the information in the sentence exemplifies the previous sentence’s discussion of how a firefly begins to glow. Instead, it contrasts with the previous sentence’s discussion. Choice C is incorrect because “specifically” illogically signals that the information in the sentence provides specific details elaborating on the previous sentence’s discussion of how a firefly begins to glow. Instead, it contrasts with the previous sentence’s discussion. Choice D is incorrect because “in conclusion” illogically signals that the information in the sentence sums up the previous sentence’s discussion of how a firefly begins to glow. Instead, it contrasts with the previous sentence’s discussion.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e6333ad0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: e6333ad0

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Albert Einstein’s theory of general relativity allows for potential shortcuts through spacetime.
- These hypothetical spacetime tunnels are known as wormholes.
- For matter to travel through a wormhole, it would need to have negative energy density.
- Negative energy density means that the matter would have less energy than empty space.
- Such matter has not been shown to exist.

The student wants to acknowledge a complication affecting travel through wormholes. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Einstein’s theory of general relativity allows for potential spacetime shortcuts called wormholes but does not explain how matter with negative energy density could travel through them.
- B. For matter to travel through a wormhole, the matter would need to have less energy than empty space; such matter has not been shown to exist.
- C. The hypothetical tunnels known as wormholes would be potential shortcuts through spacetime were it not for one complication: they have less energy than empty space.
- D. For wormholes to be possible, according to Einstein’s theory of general relativity, they would have to allow for potential shortcuts through spacetime.

ID: e6333ad0 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence acknowledges a complication affecting travel through wormholes, noting that the matter traveling through a wormhole would need to have less energy than empty space and that such matter has not been shown to exist.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence notes that Einstein’s theory doesn’t explain how matter with negative energy density can travel through wormholes; it doesn’t acknowledge a complication affecting travel through wormholes. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence acknowledges a complication affecting travel through wormholes, it misrepresents information from the notes; matter traveling through wormholes, not the wormholes themselves, would need to have negative energy density. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence presents a misleading interpretation of Einstein’s theory (confusing the definition of a wormhole with a condition a wormhole must fulfill); it doesn’t acknowledge a complication affecting travel through wormholes.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6a8c88e8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 6a8c88e8

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Tibetan mastiffs are large dogs native to the Himalayas.
- A mutation in their EPAS1 gene prevents excess hemoglobin production.
- A mutation in their HBB gene boosts hemoglobin’s oxygen-carrying ability.
- These mutations enable the dogs to withstand hypoxic (low-oxygen) conditions at high altitudes.
- In a 2016 study, Zhen Wang and colleagues noted that Tibetan wolves’ DNA has the same EPAS1 and HBB mutations.
- Wang and colleagues determined that the dogs first acquired these mutations by interbreeding with Tibetan wolves around 24,000 years ago.

The student wants to present the conclusion of Zhen Wang and colleagues’ 2016 study. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Like Tibetan mastiffs, Tibetan wolves can withstand hypoxic conditions at high altitudes.
- B. Both Tibetan mastiffs and Tibetan wolves have mutations in their EPAS1 and HBB genes, which prevent excess hemoglobin production and boost hemoglobin’s oxygen-carrying ability, respectively.
- C. In addition to preventing excess hemoglobin production, a mutation in Tibetan mastiffs’ HBB gene boosts hemoglobin’s oxygen-carrying ability.
- D. By interbreeding with Tibetan wolves around 24,000 years ago, Tibetan mastiffs acquired the genetic mutations that enable them to withstand hypoxic conditions.

ID: 6a8c88e8 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence presents the conclusion of Zhen Wang and colleagues’ 2016 study: Tibetan mastiffs are able to withstand hypoxic conditions due to their interbreeding with Tibetan wolves 24,000 years ago (which allowed the mastiffs to acquire the necessary genetic mutations).

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between Tibetan mastiffs and Tibetan wolves; it doesn’t present the conclusions of the 2016 study. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the genes of Tibetan mastiffs and Tibetan wolves; it doesn’t present the conclusions of the 2016 study. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents information from the notes by indicating that a mutation in mastiffs’ HBB gene prevents excess hemoglobin production; moreover, it doesn’t present the conclusions of the 2016 study.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 55022c09

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 55022c09

Roughly once an hour, a torrent of boiling water shoots up 100 feet or more from Yellowstone’s Old Faithful geyser before plunging back to the surface—a cycle seemingly inhospitable to life. _____ as microbiologist Eric Boyd attests, “the geyser is... almost like a cradle for biodiversity,” home to numerous bacteria species that thrive in its sulfurous waters.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Thus,
- B. Specifically,
- C. Still,
- D. In other words,

ID: 55022c09 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "Still" logically signals that the information in this sentence about Old Faithful’s thriving bacteria species is true despite the previous claim that conditions at the geyser seem as if they would be inhospitable to life.

Choice A is incorrect because "thus" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result or consequence of the previous claim about Old Faithful’s seemingly inhospitable conditions. Instead, this information about the geyser’s many thriving bacteria species is true despite the previous claim. Choice B is incorrect because "specifically" illogically signals that the information in this sentence provides specific, precise details elaborating on the previous claim about Old Faithful’s seemingly inhospitable conditions. Instead, this information about the geyser’s many thriving bacteria species is true despite the previous claim. Choice D is incorrect because "in other words" illogically signals that the information in this sentence serves as a paraphrase or restatement of the previous claim about Old Faithful’s seemingly inhospitable conditions. Instead, this information about the geyser’s many thriving bacteria species is true despite the previous claim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 65b1cb04

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 65b1cb04

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 1999, astronomer Todd Henry studied the differences in surface temperature between the Sun and nearby stars.
- His team mapped all stars within 10 parsecs (approximately 200 trillion miles) of the Sun.
- The surface temperature of the Sun is around 9,800°F, which classifies it as a G star.
- 327 of the 357 stars in the study were classified as K or M stars, with surface temperatures under 8,900°F (cooler than the Sun).
- 11 of the 357 stars in the study were classified as A or F stars, with surface temperatures greater than 10,300°F (hotter than the Sun).

The student wants to emphasize how hot the Sun is relative to nearby stars. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. At around 9,800°F, which classifies it as a G star, the Sun is hotter than most but not all of the stars within 10 parsecs of it.
- B. Astronomer Todd Henry determined that the Sun, at around 9,800°F, is a G star, and several other stars within a 10-parsec range are A or F stars.
- C. Of the 357 stars within ten parsecs of the Sun, 327 are classified as K or M stars, with surface temperatures under 8,900°F.
- D. While most of the stars within 10 parsecs of the Sun are classified as K, M, A, or F stars, the Sun is classified as a G star due to its surface temperature of 9,800°F.

ID: 65b1cb04 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. Noting that the Sun (9,800°F) is hotter than most stars within 10 parsecs of it, the sentence emphasizes how hot the Sun is relative to nearby stars.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence explains that astronomer Todd Henry determined the classifications for the Sun and several other stars nearby; it doesn't emphasize how hot the Sun is relative to nearby stars. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence explains that the majority of stars near the Sun are classified as K or M stars; it doesn't indicate the Sun's temperature or emphasize how hot it is relative to nearby stars. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence indicates that the Sun is classified differently than most nearby stars due to its surface temperature, it doesn't emphasize how hot the Sun is relative to nearby stars.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b0f720f9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: b0f720f9

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Most, but not all, of the Moon’s oxygen comes from the Sun, via solar wind.
- Cosmochemist Kentaro Terada from Osaka University wondered if some of the unaccounted-for oxygen could be coming from Earth.
- In 2008, he analyzed data from the Japanese satellite Kaguya.
- Kaguya gathered data about gases and particles it encountered while orbiting the Moon.
- Based on the Kaguya data, Terada confirmed his suspicion that Earth is sending oxygen to the Moon.

The student wants to emphasize the aim of the research study. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. As it orbited the Moon, the Kaguya satellite collected data that was later analyzed by cosmochemist Kentaro Terada.
- B. Before 2008, Kentaro Terada wondered if the Moon was receiving some of its oxygen from Earth.
- C. Cosmochemist Kentaro Terada set out to determine whether some of the Moon’s oxygen was coming from Earth.
- D. Kentaro Terada’s study determined that Earth is sending a small amount of oxygen to the Moon.

ID: b0f720f9 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the aim, or goal, of the research study, noting what Terada set out to do: determine whether some of the Moon’s oxygen was coming from Earth.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence focuses on how the Kaguya satellite collected data; it doesn’t emphasize the aim of the research study. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence mentions what Terada was curious about before conducting the research study, it doesn’t emphasize his study’s aim. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence presents the research study’s conclusion; it doesn’t emphasize the study’s aim.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2029c417

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 2029c417

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The *Atlantic Monthly* magazine was first published in 1857.
- The magazine focused on politics, art, and literature.
- In 2019, historian Cathryn Halverson published the book *Faraway Women and the “Atlantic Monthly.”*
- Its subject is female authors whose autobiographies appeared in the magazine in the early 1900s.
- One of the authors discussed is Juanita Harrison.

The student wants to introduce Cathryn Halverson’s book to an audience already familiar with the *Atlantic Monthly*. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Cathryn Halverson’s *Faraway Women and the “Atlantic Monthly”* discusses female authors whose autobiographies appeared in the magazine in the early 1900s.
- B. A magazine called the *Atlantic Monthly*, referred to in Cathryn Halverson’s book title, was first published in 1857.
- C. *Faraway Women and the “Atlantic Monthly”* features contributors to the *Atlantic Monthly*, first published in 1857 as a magazine focusing on politics, art, and literature.
- D. An author discussed by Cathryn Halverson is Juanita Harrison, whose autobiography appeared in the *Atlantic Monthly* in the early 1900s.

ID: 2029c417 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence effectively introduces Cathryn Halverson’s book to an audience already familiar with the *Atlantic Monthly*, noting the title of Halverson’s book and describing its content without providing background information about the *Atlantic Monthly*.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence introduces the *Atlantic Monthly* and mentions that it’s referred to in Cathryn Halverson’s book title; it doesn’t effectively introduce Halverson’s book. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence assumes that the audience is unfamiliar with the *Atlantic Monthly*, providing background information about the magazine; it doesn’t effectively introduce Halverson’s book to an audience already familiar with the *Atlantic Monthly*. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence assumes that the audience is familiar with the *Atlantic Monthly*, it doesn’t effectively introduce Cathryn Halverson’s book.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ddc2648c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: ddc2648c

With its clichéd imagery of suburban lawns and power lines, John Ashbery’s 2004 poem “Ignorance of the Law Is No Excuse” may seem barren terrain for critical analysis. _____ cultural critic Lauren Berlant finds fertile ground in just its first two stanzas, devoting most of a book chapter to deciphering the “weight of the default space” Ashbery creates in this poem.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Likewise,
- B. Nonetheless,
- C. In turn,
- D. That is,

ID: ddc2648c Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Nonetheless” is a transition that indicates disagreement. The first sentence describes the unlikelihood of finding much for critical analysis in Ashbery’s poem (“barren terrain”), while the second sentence describes how Berlant did in fact find much to analyze in Ashbery’s poem (“fertile ground”), so the transition “nonetheless” fits perfectly.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates the addition of a new but similar idea, which doesn’t make sense here. The idea in this sentence directly contradicts the idea in the previous sentence. Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses a cause-and-effect transition, which doesn’t make sense in this context—a poem seemingly having little opportunity for critical analysis would not cause someone to write an extensive critical analysis (in fact, we might expect the opposite). Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates a restatement of the same idea in other words. But the text isn’t restating the first idea here. Instead, it’s offering a contradiction to the idea expressed in the first sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 978d7ebd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 978d7ebd

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Thailand’s annual Songkran Water Festival is held each April.
- It marks Songkran, the traditional Thai New Year.
- People splash and spray each other for fun at the festival’s community-wide water fights.
- In Bangkok, thousands gather along Silom Road for the city’s largest water fight.
- In Chiang Mai, thousands gather at a historical monument called the Tha Phae Gate for the city’s largest water fight.

The student wants to emphasize a similarity in how people in Bangkok and Chiang Mai celebrate Songkran. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The largest water fight in Bangkok takes place along a city street, whereas the largest water fight in Chiang Mai takes place at a historical monument.
- B. In both Bangkok and Chiang Mai, thousands gather to celebrate Songkran with water fights.
- C. People in both Bangkok and Chiang Mai celebrate Songkran, but they don’t do so in exactly the same way.
- D. Each April, people in Thailand celebrate Songkran, the traditional Thai New Year.

ID: 978d7ebd Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes a similarity in how people in Bangkok and Chiang Mai celebrate Songkran, indicating that people in both cities gather to celebrate with water fights.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence notes the different locations of the largest water fight in Bangkok and the largest water fight in Chiang Mai; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity in how people in Bangkok and Chiang Mai celebrate Songkran. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence indicates that people in Bangkok and Chiang Mai don’t celebrate Songkran in exactly the same way; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity in how people in the two cities celebrate Songkran. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence explains when people in Thailand celebrate Songkran; it doesn’t emphasize a similarity in how people in Bangkok and Chiang Mai celebrate Songkran.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b63124c4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: b63124c4

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Pedestrian malls are outdoor streets in a city or town where vehicle traffic is prohibited.
- Many pedestrian malls were built in the 19th and 20th centuries in Europe and Asia.
- Qianmen Dajie is a famous pedestrian mall in Beijing.
- It has existed since the Ming dynasty (1368–1644 CE).
- Rue Mouffetard is a famous pedestrian mall in Paris.
- It has existed since the mid-Roman Empire (117–235 CE).

The student wants to emphasize a similarity between the ages of the malls. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The Qianmen Dajie pedestrian mall has roots as far back as the Ming dynasty; likewise, Rue Mouffetard has existed for centuries.
- B. Both Qianmen Dajie and Rue Mouffetard are famous pedestrian malls, the former in Beijing and the latter in Paris.
- C. Qianmen Dajie and Rue Mouffetard are pedestrian malls, outdoor streets closed to vehicle traffic.
- D. Qianmen Dajie and Rue Mouffetard are examples of pedestrian malls, which proliferated in Europe in the 19th and 20th centuries.

ID: b63124c4 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the ages of the two pedestrian malls, noting that both are relatively old—Qianmen Dajie has roots that go back hundreds of years and Rue Mouffetard has existed for centuries.

Choice B is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes that both locations are famous pedestrian malls and notes that they are in different locations; it doesn't emphasize a similarity in their ages. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence emphasizes that both locations are pedestrian malls, it doesn't emphasize a similarity in their ages. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence explains that Qianmen Dajie and Rue Mouffetard are examples of pedestrian malls and gives information about pedestrian malls in general; it doesn't emphasize a similarity in the ages of these two malls specifically.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f393b70b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: f393b70b

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- When medical students mention their patients on social media, they may violate patient confidentiality.
- Terry Kind led a study to determine how many medical schools have student policies that mention social media use.
- Kind and her team reviewed 132 medical school websites, examining publicly available student policies.
- Only thirteen medical schools had guidelines that explicitly mention social media, and only five defined what constitutes acceptable social media use.

The student wants to emphasize the study’s methodology. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The student policies of 132 medical schools can be found online, according to research by Terry Kind.
- B. To find out how many medical schools have guidelines about student social media use, Terry Kind and her team examined the student policies of 132 medical schools.
- C. Out of 132 medical schools, only thirteen had student policies that mentioned social media, and only five specified what use was acceptable.
- D. Terry Kind and her team wanted to know how many medical schools have student social media policies in place about protecting patient confidentiality.

ID: f393b70b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence effectively emphasizes Kind’s methodology: examining the student policies of 132 medical schools for guidelines about student social media use.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence specifies how many medical schools’ student policies are available online; it doesn’t emphasize the study’s methodology. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the study’s results, not the study’s methodology. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the aim of the study, not the study’s methodology.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 716aa220

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 716aa220

Imagine a magazine that a reader has thrown away. This magazine is post-consumer waste, as it became waste after reaching the consumer. _____ the paper scraps left over from printing the magazine are pre-consumer waste, as they became waste before reaching the consumer.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. By contrast,
- B. For example,
- C. As a result,
- D. Specifically,

ID: 716aa220 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “By contrast” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that paper scraps left over from printing a magazine are pre-consumer waste—contrasts with the previous information about magazines being post-consumer waste.

Choice B is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the information in this sentence exemplifies the previous information about post-consumer waste. Instead, the paper scraps being pre-consumer waste contrasts with the previous information. Choice C is incorrect because “as a result” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result or consequence of the previous information about post-consumer waste. Instead, the paper scraps being pre-consumer waste contrasts with the previous information. Choice D is incorrect because “specifically” illogically signals that the information in this sentence provides specific, precise details elaborating on the previous information about post-consumer waste. Instead, the paper scraps being pre-consumer waste contrasts with the previous information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 54e3aa19

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 54e3aa19

A 2022 study by researchers Hala Altamimi and Qiaozhen Liu investigated the relationship between nonprofit arts organizations’ spending and performance. _____ the researchers examined the correlation between how much 22,328 US arts nonprofits spent on overhead—operational costs such as equipment and fundraising—and how many people attended their events (a measure of overall success).

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Thus,
- B. In addition,
- C. By comparison,
- D. Specifically,

ID: 54e3aa19 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "Specifically" logically signals that the information in this sentence—that the researchers examined the overhead costs and attendance at events of 22,328 nonprofits—provides specific, precise details elaborating on how the researchers investigated the relationship between nonprofits’ spending and performance.

Choice A is incorrect. "Thus" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a result or consequence of the researchers’ investigation of nonprofits’ spending and performance. Instead, it specifies how they examined that correlation. Choice B is incorrect. "In addition" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is merely an additional fact about the researchers’ investigation of nonprofits’ spending and performance. Instead, it specifies how they examined that correlation. Choice C is incorrect. "By comparison" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is being compared to the researchers’ investigation of nonprofits’ spending and performance. Instead, it specifies how they examined that correlation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 69a788f5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 69a788f5

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- African American women played prominent roles in the Civil Rights Movement, including at the famous 1963 March on Washington.
- Civil rights activist Anna Hedgeman, one of the march’s organizers, was a political adviser who had worked for President Truman.
- Civil rights activist Daisy Bates was a well-known journalist and advocate for school desegregation.
- Hedgeman worked behind the scenes to make sure a woman was included in the lineup of speakers at the march.
- Bates was the sole woman to speak, delivering a brief but memorable address to the cheering crowd.

The student wants to compare the two women’s contributions to the March on Washington. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Hedgeman and Bates contributed to the march in different ways; Bates, for example, delivered a brief but memorable address.
- B. Hedgeman worked in politics and helped organize the march, while Bates was a journalist and school desegregation advocate.
- C. Although Hedgeman worked behind the scenes to make sure a woman speaker was included, Bates was the sole woman to speak at the march.
- D. Many African American women, including Bates and Hedgeman, fought for civil rights, but only one spoke at the march.

ID: 69a788f5 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence compares the two women’s contributions to the march: Hedgeman worked behind the scenes to make sure a woman speaker was included, whereas Bates actually spoke at the event.

Choice A is incorrect. While it acknowledges that the two women both contributed to the march, it doesn’t indicate what Hedgeman did, so no comparison is made. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence provides information about the two women, it doesn’t mention anything about Bates’s contribution to the march. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence indicates that the two women both fought for civil rights, it doesn’t compare their individual contributions to the march.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dd488e72

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: dd488e72

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Phobetor, a name drawn from Greek mythology, is an exoplanet that orbits the star PSR B1257+12, also known as Lich.
- Phobetor’s mass is 0.01 times that of Jupiter, or 0.01 Jupiter masses.
- Mastika, which means “gem” or “jewel” in Malay, is an exoplanet that orbits the star HD 179949, also known as Gumala.
- Mastika’s mass is 0.92 Jupiter masses.

The student wants to make and support a generalization about exoplanets. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A. Exoplanets that are named Phobetor orbit Lich, and those that are named Mastika orbit Gumala.

B. Even though Phobetor and Mastika are both exoplanets, their masses are different: Phobetor’s mass is 0.01 Jupiter masses, and Mastika’s is 0.92 Jupiter masses.

C. Many stars have both a designation and a proper name; for instance, PSR B1257+12 is also known as Lich, and HD 179949 is also known as Gumala.

D. Exoplanet names have diverse origins, a fact that can be seen in the cases of Phobetor, a name drawn from Greek mythology, and Mastika, which means “gem” or “jewel” in Malay.

ID: dd488e72 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence makes and supports a generalization about exoplanets, noting that the names of exoplanets have diverse origins and supporting this with the examples of the origins of "Phobetor" and "Mastika."

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents information from the notes, implying that there are multiple exoplanets with the same names. Additionally, the sentence provides no support for its generalization. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence contrasts the masses of two specific exoplanets; it doesn’t make and support a generalization about exoplanets. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence makes and supports a generalization about stars, not exoplanets.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b18a1a3d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: b18a1a3d

Brain imaging research led by neuroscientist Dwaynica Greaves found that actors showed suppressed responses in the left anterior prefrontal cortex (the portion of the brain associated with self-awareness) when their names were called during performances; _____ the actors’ responses were normal in nonacting contexts. These findings suggest that when embodying characters, performers may temporarily set aside their personal identities.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. specifically,
- B. conversely,
- C. likewise,
- D. thus,

ID: b18a1a3d Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Conversely” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that the actors’ responses were normal in nonacting contexts—presents the opposite of the previous finding that actors showed suppressed responses when their names were called during performances.

Choice A is incorrect because “specifically” illogically signals that the information about the actors’ normal responses in nonacting contexts provides specific details elaborating on the previous finding of suppressed responses during performances. Instead, the sentence presents the responses as opposites. Choice C is incorrect because “likewise” illogically signals that the actors’ normal responses in nonacting contexts are similar to the suppressed responses observed during performances. Instead, the sentence presents the responses as opposites. Choice D is incorrect because “thus” illogically signals that the actors’ normal responses in nonacting contexts are a result or consequence of the suppressed responses observed during performances. Instead, the sentence presents the responses as opposites.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 18d5fd61

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 18d5fd61

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- A commodity chain is the series of links connecting the production and purchase of a commodity on the world market.
- Chinese American anthropologist Anna Tsing studies the contemporary commodity chain of matsutake mushrooms.
- At one end of the matsutake chain are mushroom pickers in Oregon.
- At the other end are wealthy consumers who buy the costly matsutake in Japan.
- According to Tsing, “Japanese traders began importing matsutake in the 1980s, when the scarcity of matsutake in Japan first became clear.”

The student wants to provide an overview of the matsutake commodity chain. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The contemporary matsutake commodity chain has its origins in the 1980s when, according to Tsing, “the scarcity of matsutake in Japan first became clear.”
- B. Commodity chains include the linked production and purchase of commodities, such as the matsutake mushroom, on the world market.
- C. Decades after the Japanese import of matsutake began, a commodity chain now links matsutake pickers in Oregon with wealthy consumers of the costly mushrooms in Japan.
- D. Wealthy consumers who buy the costly mushrooms in Japan are at one end of the matsutake commodity chain.

ID: 18d5fd61 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence provides an overview of the matsutake commodity chain, connecting the Oregon mushroom pickers at one end to the Japanese consumers at the other.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence mentions the matsutake commodity chain, it focuses only on its origins; it does not provide an overview. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence provides a general definition of commodity chains, not an overview of the matsutake chain. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence mentions the matsutake commodity chain, it focuses only on one end of the chain (the consumers); it does not provide an overview.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b313c9df

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: b313c9df

When, in 2017, Cambridge University students Lucy Moss and Toby Marlow decided they wanted to develop a musical together, one of their goals was for their female actor friends to have good parts to play. _____ they created the show *Six*, a retelling of the history of King Henry VIII’s wives in which each of the six queens has a starring role.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. In other words,
- B. In summary,
- C. For example,
- D. To that end,

ID: b313c9df Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. "To that end" logically signals that the information in this sentence—the students’ creation of a show with six starring female roles—is the product of a goal or desire in the previous sentence (the students’ wish to develop a musical with roles for female actors).

Choice A is incorrect because "in other words" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a paraphrase or restatement of the previous information about the students’ wish to develop a musical with roles for female actors. Instead, the students’ show is the product of that desire. Choice B is incorrect because "in summary" illogically signals that the information in this sentence summarizes the previous information about the students’ wish to develop a musical with roles for female actors. Instead, the students’ show is the product of that desire. Choice C is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the information in this sentence is merely an example of the previous information about the students’ wish to develop a musical with roles for female actors. Instead, the students’ show is the direct product of that desire.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1d085a9b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 1d085a9b

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The ancient Arab dhow was a sailing vessel distinguishable by its triangular sails and stitched hull construction.
- Dhows were used primarily for trade along the coasts of Arab, South Asian, and East African countries.
- Contemporary shipbuilders in Oman use a mix of modern and traditional materials to build replicas of ancient dhows.
- Most of the materials used are traditional.
- Replica hulls are stitched together using the same traditional coconut palm fiber rope used on the hulls of ancient dhows.

The student wants to make a generalization about the materials used in dhow replicas. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. A traditional material that was used to stitch together the hulls of ancient dhows, coconut palm fiber rope is still used by shipbuilders.
- B. The ancient Arab dhow was a sailing vessel used primarily for trade and distinguishable by its triangular sails.
- C. Although most materials used in dhow replicas are traditional, some modern materials are used.
- D. Contemporary shipbuilders in Oman build replicas of the dhow, which was an ancient sailing vessel with a stitched hull construction.

ID: 1d085a9b Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence makes a generalization about the materials used in dhow replicas, noting that while some modern materials are used, most of the materials are traditional.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence provides an example of a traditional material used in ancient dhows; it doesn't indicate that the material is used in dhow replicas or make any other generalization about materials used in those replicas. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence explains what an ancient dhow was; it doesn't make a generalization about materials used to make dhow replicas. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence introduces the construction of dhow replicas to an audience unfamiliar with the vessel; it doesn't make a generalization about the materials used in those replicas.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6d8243c2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 6d8243c2

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Marcela Guerrero is a curator at the Whitney Museum of American Art in New York.
- She curated the Whitney’s 2018 exhibition *Pacha, Llaqta, Wasichay: Indigenous Space, Modern Architecture, New Art*.
- This exhibition featured works by seven emerging Latino artists.
- She curated the Whitney’s 2020 exhibition *Vida Americana: Mexican Muralists Remake American Art, 1925–1945*.
- This exhibition included nearly 200 works by twentieth-century Latino and Mexican artists.

The student wants to describe the exhibition that Guerrero curated in 2018. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Held at the Whitney Museum of American Art, the exhibition *Vida Americana: Mexican Muralists Remake American Art, 1925–1945* included nearly 200 works by twentieth-century Mexican and Latino artists.
- B. *Pacha, Llaqta, Wasichay: Indigenous Space, Modern Architecture, New Art*, an exhibition at the Whitney Museum of American Art, featured works by seven emerging Latino artists.
- C. In both 2018 and 2020, Marcela Guerrero curated exhibitions at the Whitney Museum of American Art in New York.
- D. While one exhibition that Marcela Guerrero curated featured works by emerging artists, another included works by twentieth-century artists.

ID: 6d8243c2 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence describes the 2018 exhibition Guerrero curated, noting that the exhibition, which was titled *Pacha, Llaqta, Wasichay: Indigenous Space, Modern Architecture, New Art*, featured the works of seven emerging Latino artists.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes the exhibition Guerrero curated in 2020; it doesn’t describe her 2018 exhibition. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes a similarity between the two exhibitions Guerrero curated; it doesn’t describe her 2018 exhibition. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes a difference between the two exhibitions Guerrero curated; it doesn’t describe her 2018 exhibition.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5b6a3221

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 5b6a3221

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Gullah are a group of African Americans who have lived in parts of the southeastern United States since the 18th century.
- Gullah culture is influenced by West African and Central African traditions.
- Louise Miller Cohen is a Gullah historian, storyteller, and preservationist.
- She founded the Gullah Museum of Hilton Head Island, South Carolina, in 2003.
- Vermelle Rodrigues is a Gullah historian, artist, and preservationist.
- She founded the Gullah Museum of Georgetown, South Carolina, in 2003.

The student wants to emphasize the duration and purpose of Cohen’s and Rodrigues’s work. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. At the Gullah Museums in Hilton Head Island and Georgetown, South Carolina, visitors can learn more about the Gullah people who have lived in the region for centuries.
- B. Louise Miller Cohen and Vermelle Rodrigues have worked to preserve the culture of the Gullah people, who have lived in the United States since the 18th century.
- C. Since 2003, Louise Miller Cohen and Vermelle Rodrigues have worked to preserve Gullah culture through their museums.
- D. Influenced by the traditions of West and Central Africa, Gullah culture developed in parts of the southeastern United States in the 18th century.

ID: 5b6a3221 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes both the duration (the length of time) and the purpose of Cohen’s and Rodrigues’s work by noting that the women have been working since 2003 to preserve Gullah culture.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence emphasizes what visitors to Cohen’s and Rodrigues’s museums can learn, it doesn’t mention the duration or purpose of the women’s work. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence emphasizes the purpose of Cohen’s and Rodrigues’s work, it doesn’t mention the duration of that work (the length of time the women have been working to preserve Gullah culture). Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence emphasizes where and when Gullah culture developed, it doesn’t mention the duration or purpose of Cohen’s and Rodrigues’s work.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 209ab087

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 209ab087

Long thought to be sessile (immobile), adult *Chelonibia testudinaria*, barnacles that adhere to sea turtle shells, have been observed to shift slightly in position over time—a phenomenon that has been attributed to the barnacles’ passive displacement by water currents. _____ a research team found that adult *C. testudinaria* moved toward the heads of their sea turtle hosts and thus against the prevailing water flow, behavior consistent with self-initiated locomotion.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Contrary to this phenomenon,
- B. Undermining this explanation,
- C. Drawing a similar conclusion,
- D. Confirming this hypothesis,

ID: 209ab087 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Undermining this explanation” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that adult *Chelonibia testudinaria* showed behavior consistent with self-initiated locomotion—undermines or weakens the previous explanation that barnacle movement was a result of passive displacement by water currents.

Choice A is incorrect because “contrary to this phenomenon” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about barnacles exhibiting behavior consistent with self-initiated locomotion opposes the previous information about barnacles shifting slightly in position over time. Instead, the sentence undermines or weakens the previous claim about passive displacement. That is, the sentence doesn’t oppose the fact that the barnacles shifted position: it challenges the previous sentence’s explanation for the movement. Choice C is incorrect because “drawing a similar conclusion” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about barnacles exhibiting behavior consistent with self-initiated locomotion is similar to the previous conclusion that barnacle movement is the result of passive displacement. Instead, the sentence undermines or weakens the previous sentence’s explanation for how the barnacles moved. Choice D is incorrect because “confirming this hypothesis” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about barnacles exhibiting behavior consistent with self-initiated locomotion confirms the hypothesis in the previous sentence that the barnacle movement was the result of passive displacement. Instead, the sentence undermines or weakens the previous sentence’s explanation for how the barnacles moved.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bf222541

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: bf222541

The Sun and other stars are powered by nuclear fusion reactions, in which two atoms collide to form a single heavier atom, releasing energy. Scientists have long believed that fusion has the potential to meet humanity’s clean energy needs. _____ prior to December 2022, no fusion reaction in a laboratory setting had ever generated a net energy gain.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. For this reason,
- B. Moreover,
- C. Specifically,
- D. That said,

ID: bf222541 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. Scientists believe in fusion’s potential as an energy source, but have struggled to actually make it work—in other words, there is a contradiction between scientists’ beliefs and their reality. “That said” is a disagreement transition that works perfectly in this context.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice uses a cause-and-effect transition, which doesn’t make sense here. Scientists not being able to generate extra energy from lab fusion reactions isn’t an effect of them believing in fusion’s potential. Choice B is incorrect. This transition indicates the addition of another supporting point. But this sentence is not adding a supporting point to the previous sentence—scientists not being able to successfully generate energy from fusion isn’t another point in favor of fusion meeting humanity’s clean energy needs. Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that introduces or elaborates on a particular example. But this sentence doesn’t give an example of scientists’ belief in fusion’s potential to meet humanity’s clean energy needs—in fact, it contrasts that optimistic belief with the reality of past failures to successfully employ fusion for energy production.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID eb2a11b5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: eb2a11b5

In response to adverse environmental conditions, many plants produce abscisic acid (ABA), a stress hormone. ABA triggers a slowdown in the biological processes of most plants. _____ when the mustard plant *Schrenkiella parvula* produces ABA in response to an environmental stressor, the hormone triggers accelerated growth.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Moreover,
- B. In contrast,
- C. For example,
- D. Thus,

ID: eb2a11b5 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “In contrast” logically signals that the information in this sentence—that ABA triggers accelerated growth in the mustard plant *Schrenkiella parvula*—contrasts with the previous information about ABA triggering a slowdown in most plants’ biological processes.

Choice A is incorrect because “moreover” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about the mustard plant merely adds to the previous information about the effects of ABA. Instead, it contrasts with that information. Choice C is incorrect because “for example” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about the mustard plant provides an example consistent with the previous information about the effects of ABA. Instead, it contrasts with that information. Choice D is incorrect because “thus” illogically signals that the information in this sentence about the mustard plant is a consequence, or result, of the previous information about the effects of ABA. Instead, it contrasts with that information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d9bdbb86

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: d9bdbb86

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Nissologists are scientists who study islands.
- Some nissologists define an island as any piece of land surrounded by water.
- Using that definition, they determined that Sweden has 221,000 islands.
- Other nissologists define an island as being 1 kilometer square, a certain distance from the mainland, and having at least 50 permanent residents.
- Using that definition, they determined that Sweden has 24 islands.

The student wants to make and support a generalization about nissologists’ definition of an island. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish these goals?

- A. The definition of an island as any piece of land surrounded by water is supported by some nissologists, scientists who study islands.
- B. Multiple counts of Sweden’s islands have been based on different definitions of an island.
- C. Based on a recent count, Sweden has a relatively small number of islands with at least 50 permanent residents.
- D. Nissologists’ different definitions can result in huge disparities in counts of islands, as the example of Sweden shows.

ID: d9bdbb86 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence makes a generalization about nissologists’ definition of an island—specifically, that the use of one definition rather than another can result in huge disparities in the number of islands counted—and supports that generalization by citing Sweden as an example.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence introduces one definition of an island to an audience unfamiliar with nissologists; it doesn’t make a generalization about nissologists’ definition of an island. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence synthesizes information from the notes about counts of Sweden’s islands, it doesn’t make and support a generalization about nissologists’ definition of an island. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence makes an inference about islands in Sweden; it doesn’t mention nissologists’ definition of an island or make a generalization about it.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5e673ea4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 5e673ea4

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- A 2024 study analyzed the facial expressions of wolves and domestic dogs.
- In the study, facial expressions were coded under 46 different facial actions.
- The “ears rotator” facial action is seen in wolves.
- Dog breeds with erect (wolf-like) ears can produce the “ears rotator” facial action.
- Dog breeds with flopped or semi-flopped (non-wolf-like) ears cannot produce the “ears rotator” facial action.

The student wants to compare dog breeds with wolf-like ears to dog breeds with non-wolf-like ears. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. In a 2024 study, dog breeds with non-wolf-like ears were able to produce the same facial movements that wolves could.
- B. One difference between dog breeds with wolf-like ears and dog breeds without them is that wolf-like breeds cannot produce the “ears rotator” facial action.
- C. Non-wolf-like ears are flopped or semi-flopped, but wolf-like ears are different: they are erect and can produce the “ears rotator” facial action.
- D. Like wolves, dog breeds with erect ears can produce the “ears rotator” facial action, while those with flopped or semi-flopped ears cannot.

ID: 5e673ea4 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence compares dog breeds with wolf-like (erect) and non-wolf-like (flopped or semi-flopped) ears, noting that breeds with erect ears are able to produce the same “ears rotator” facial action as wolves, while breeds with flopped or semi-flopped ears cannot.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence compares dog breeds with non-wolf-like ears to wolves, not to other dog breeds. It also misrepresents information from the notes: breeds with non-wolf-like ears cannot produce the “ears rotator” facial action. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence appears to compare dog breeds with wolf-like and non-wolf-like ears, it misrepresents information from the notes: breeds with wolf-like ears can produce the “ears rotator” facial action. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence compares the physical characteristics of the two ear types, it doesn’t compare the dog breeds that have these ear types.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 631f5be8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 631f5be8

The Coastal Virginia Offshore Wind project is anticipated to generate 2.6 gigawatts of energy, enough to power almost one million homes. As its name indicates, the project—currently in development—consists of wind turbines located off the Virginia coast. _____ the project plan calls for 176 large turbines to be placed at a site 27 miles east of Virginia Beach.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. To be exact,
- B. In conclusion,
- C. As a result,
- D. In contrast,

ID: 631f5be8 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. "To be exact" logically signals that this sentence about the Coastal Virginia Offshore Wind project plan provides specific, precise details—number of turbines, location of site—elaborating on the more general information about the project in the previous sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because "in conclusion" illogically signals that the information in this sentence about the Coastal Virginia Offshore Wind project plan concludes or summarizes the discussion of the project in the previous sentences. Instead, the sentence provides specific, precise details elaborating on the previous information. Choice C is incorrect because "as a result" illogically signals that the information in this sentence about the Coastal Virginia Offshore Wind project plan is caused by, or occurs as a result of, the information about the project in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence provides specific, precise details elaborating on the previous information. Choice D is incorrect because "in contrast" illogically signals that the information in this sentence about the Coastal Virginia Offshore Wind project plan contrasts with information about the project in the previous sentence. Instead, the sentence provides specific, precise details elaborating on the previous information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5b925ff9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 5b925ff9

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In a 2023 study, environmental scientist Jazmin Locke-Rodriguez and colleagues tested the use of floating treatment wetlands (FTWs) in Florida.
- FTWs are artificial floating platforms of plants used to remediate polluted or nutrient-imbalanced water.
- Finding: FTWs using marigold flowers removed 52% more total phosphorus than the control.
- Finding: The test yielded 65 market-quality blooms per square meter.
- The authors concluded marigolds showed “promising potential as a commercially viable remediating crop cultivated on FTWs in South Florida.”

The student wants to present the findings of the study. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The authors concluded that marigolds grown on FTWs were “commercially viable,” having produced 65 blooms per square meter of market-quality blooms in a 2023 study.
- B. In a 2023 study, Locke-Rodriguez and colleagues found that marigolds cultivated on FTWs produced 52% more market-quality flower blooms than the control.
- C. Locke-Rodriguez and colleagues found that FTWs using marigolds not only helped remove phosphorus from the water but also yielded market-quality blooms.
- D. FTWs using marigolds, Locke-Rodriguez and colleagues found, yielded 65 flower blooms and removed 52% of phosphorus from the water.

ID: 5b925ff9 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence presents both findings from the study, noting that FTWs using marigolds both removed phosphorus from the water and yielded market-quality blooms.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence presents a finding from the study, the presentation is incomplete; the study found that marigolds cultivated on FTWs both removed phosphorus from the water and yielded market-quality blooms. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents information in the notes. The figure of 52% refers to the amount of phosphorus removed by FTWs using marigolds when compared to the control; the marigolds’ bloom yield was 65 market-quality blooms per square meter, and it was not compared to the control. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence misrepresents information in the notes. The FTWs using marigolds removed 52% more phosphorus from the water than did the control, not 52% of the total phosphorus. Additionally, the bloom figure is incomplete; the figure is 65 market-quality flower blooms per square meter.

Question ID 9acd9903

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 9acd9903

To discover which fruit varieties were grown in Italy’s Umbria region before the introduction of industrial farming, botanist Isabella Dalla Ragione often turns to centuries-old lists of cooking ingredients. _____ she analyzes Renaissance paintings of Umbria, as they can provide accurate representations of fruits that were grown there long ago.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. In sum,
- B. Instead,
- C. Thus,
- D. Additionally,

ID: 9acd9903 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “Additionally” logically signals that the painting analysis discussed in this sentence is an additional part of the botany research discussed in the previous sentence. That is, to research which fruits Umbrians grew in the past, the botanist analyzes old paintings in addition to looking at old lists of ingredients.

Choice A is incorrect because “in sum” illogically signals that the painting analysis discussed in this sentence is a concluding summary of the botany research discussed in the previous sentence. Instead, the painting analysis is an additional part of that research. Choice B is incorrect because “instead” illogically signals that the painting analysis discussed in this sentence is an alternative to the botany research discussed in the previous sentence. Rather, the painting analysis is an additional part of that research. Choice C is incorrect because “thus” illogically signals that the painting analysis discussed in this sentence is a result of the botany research discussed in the previous sentence. Instead, the painting analysis is an additional part of that research.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6460bd84

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 6460bd84

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In the late 1890s, over 14,000 unique varieties of apples were grown in the US.
- The rise of industrial agriculture in the mid-1900s narrowed the range of commercially grown crops.
- Thousands of apple varieties considered less suitable for commercial growth were lost.
- Today, only 15 apple varieties dominate the market, making up 90% of apples purchased in the US.
- The Lost Apple Project, based in Washington State, attempts to find and grow lost apple varieties.

The student wants to emphasize the decline in unique apple varieties in the US and specify why this decline occurred. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish these goals?

- A. The Lost Apple Project is dedicated to finding some of the apple varieties lost following a shift in agricultural practices in the mid-1900s.
- B. While over 14,000 apple varieties were grown in the US in the late 1890s, only 15 unique varieties make up most of the apples sold today.
- C. Since the rise of industrial agriculture, US farmers have mainly grown the same few unique apple varieties, resulting in the loss of thousands of varieties less suitable for commercial growth.
- D. As industrial agriculture rose to prominence in the mid-1900s, the number of crops selected for cultivation decreased dramatically.

ID: 6460bd84 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the decline in unique apple varieties in the US and specifies why this decline occurred, noting that thousands of apple varieties were lost because US farmers started mainly growing the same few unique varieties.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence introduces the Lost Apple Project; it doesn't emphasize the decline in unique apple varieties in the US and specify why this decline occurred. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence emphasizes the decline in unique apple varieties in the US, it doesn't explain why this decline occurred. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence emphasizes the general decline of crop varieties in the mid-1900s; it doesn't emphasize the specific decline in unique apple varieties in the US.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 98021b7d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 98021b7d

Because an achiral molecule is symmetrical, flipping it yields a structurally identical molecule. A flipped chiral molecule, _____ can be compared to a glove that has been turned inside out: it produces a structurally inverted molecule rather than an identical one.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. in other words,
- B. by contrast,
- C. for example,
- D. similarly,

ID: 98021b7d Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. This sentence compares a chiral molecule to an achiral one. It discusses how when a chiral molecule is flipped, it results in something very different than when an achiral molecule is flipped. So the transition "by contrast" fits the context perfectly.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates a restatement of the same idea in different words. But this sentence doesn't restate the same idea as the previous sentence. Instead, it makes a new point about a different type of molecule (chiral instead of achiral). Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that introduces an example, which doesn't make sense here. The second sentence isn't an example of the first sentence's claim about achiral molecules: it actually introduces an entirely different idea that focuses on chiral molecules. Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses a transition that indicates the addition of an agreeing idea. But this sentence shows a contrast with the first sentence—namely, that a chiral molecule acts very differently from an achiral molecule when flipped.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 96551536

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 96551536

Iraqi artist Nazik Al-Malaika, celebrated as the first Arabic poet to write in free verse, didn’t reject traditional forms entirely; her poem “Elegy for a Woman of No Importance” consists of two ten-line stanzas and a standard number of syllables. Even in this superficially traditional work, _____ Al-Malaika was breaking new ground by memorializing an anonymous woman rather than a famous man.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. therefore,
- B. in fact,
- C. moreover,
- D. though,

ID: 96551536 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The first sentence tells us that Al-Malaika sometimes used "traditional forms". The second tells us that even when she used traditional forms, Al-Malaika was "breaking new ground". To connect these ideas, we need a contrast word like "but." "Though" is a contrast word similar to "but."

Choice A is incorrect. This isn’t a logical transition. The first sentence tells us that Al-Malaika sometimes used "traditional forms". The second tells us that even when she used traditional forms, Al-Malaika was "breaking new ground". To connect these ideas, we need a contrast word like "but." "Therefore" doesn’t show contrast; it shows cause and effect. Choice B is incorrect. This isn’t a logical transition. The first sentence tells us that Al-Malaika sometimes used "traditional forms". The second tells us that even when she used traditional forms, Al-Malaika was "breaking new ground". To connect these ideas, we need a contrast word like "but." "In fact" is a phrase that usually emphasizes the truth of the previous statement. Choice C is incorrect. This isn’t a logical transition. The first sentence tells us that Al-Malaika sometimes used "traditional forms". The second tells us that even when she used traditional forms, Al-Malaika was "breaking new ground". To connect these ideas, we need a contrast word like "but." "Moreover" doesn’t show contrast—it introduces additional information that continues or supports the previous idea.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7cad9277

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 7cad9277

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Ducklings expend up to 62.8% less energy when swimming in a line behind their mother than when swimming alone.
- The physics behind this energy savings hasn’t always been well understood.
- Naval architect Zhiming Yuan used computer simulations to study the effect of the mother duck’s wake.
- The study revealed that ducklings are pushed in a forward direction by the wake’s waves.
- Yuan determined this push reduces the effect of wave drag on the ducklings by 158%.

The student wants to present the study and its methodology. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. A study revealed that ducklings, which expend up to 62.8% less energy when swimming in a line behind their mother, also experience 158% less drag.
- B. Seeking to understand how ducklings swimming in a line behind their mother save energy, Zhiming Yuan used computer simulations to study the effect of the mother duck’s wake.
- C. Zhiming Yuan studied the physics behind the fact that by being pushed in a forward direction by waves, ducklings save energy.
- D. Naval architect Zhiming Yuan discovered that ducklings are pushed in a forward direction by the waves of their mother’s wake, reducing the effect of drag by 158%.

ID: 7cad9277 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence presents both the study and its methodology (that is, the researcher’s approach to the problem), explaining that Yuan used computer simulations to study the effect of the mother duck’s wake on the ducklings’ energy expenditure.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence describes the findings of Yuan’s study; it doesn’t present the study and its methodology. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence provides general information about Yuan’s study, it doesn’t present the study’s methodology. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence describes the findings of Yuan’s study; it doesn’t present the study and its methodology.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fc1ef352

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: fc1ef352

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 1978, Sámi activists staged protests to block the construction of a dam on the Alta River in Norway.
- The dam would disrupt Sámi fishing and reindeer herding.
- The dam was ultimately built, but the Alta conflict had a lasting impact.
- It brought international attention to the issue of Sámi rights.
- It led to a set of 2005 legal protections establishing Sámi rights to lands, waters, and resources.

The student wants to make and support a generalization about the Alta conflict. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. During the Alta conflict, Sámi activists staged protests to block the construction of a dam on the Alta River in Norway that would disrupt local fishing and reindeer herding.
- B. Although the dam that the Sámi activists had protested was ultimately built, the Alta conflict had a lasting impact.
- C. Sámi rights to lands, waters, and resources received international attention and legal protections as a result of the Alta conflict.
- D. The Alta conflict had a lasting impact, resulting in international attention and legal protections for Sámi rights to lands, waters, and resources.

ID: fc1ef352 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. It makes a generalization—the conflict had a lasting impact—and then supports it with evidence—the attention and protections were results of the conflict.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t make a generalization about the conflict. It describes a specific event from the conflict. Choice B is incorrect. This choice makes a generalization about the Alta conflict, but doesn’t support it. Choice C is incorrect. This choice makes a statement about the aftermath of the conflict, but doesn’t support it. The statement is also a little too specific to be a generalization.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID aa629aeb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: aa629aeb

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Pueblo of Zuni is located about 150 miles west of Albuquerque, New Mexico.
- It is the traditional home of the A:shiwi (Zuni) people.
- The A:shiwi A:wan Museum and Heritage Center was established by tribal members in 1992.
- Its mission is stated on its website: “As a tribal museum and heritage center for the Zuni people and by the Zuni people we work to provide learning experiences that emphasize A:shiwi ways of knowing, as well as exploring modern concepts of knowledge and the transfer of knowledge.”

The student wants to emphasize how long the museum has existed. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The Pueblo of Zuni is home to the A:shiwi A:wan Museum and Heritage Center, which was founded by tribal members.
- B. The A:shiwi A:wan Museum and Heritage Center has served the Pueblo of Zuni since 1992.
- C. According to its website, the A:shiwi A:wan Museum and Heritage Center (founded in the 1990s) works to “emphasize A:shiwi ways of knowing.”
- D. Knowledge has been one of the central themes of the A:shiwi A:wan Museum and Heritage Center from its founding.

ID: aa629aeb Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. This choice effectively uses information from the notes to emphasize how long the museum has existed. It says that the museum has existed since 1992.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice doesn’t emphasize how long the museum has existed. It doesn’t say when the museum was founded. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t emphasize how long the museum has existed. It doesn’t say the exact date of the museum’s founding. Rather, it emphasizes the museum’s mission. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t emphasize how long the museum has existed. It doesn’t say when the museum was founded.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 50969f48

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 50969f48

The Inca of South America used intricately knotted string devices called quipus to record countable information, like population data and payments. _____ they may have used quipus to record more complex information, like stories and myths, according to researchers.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. As a result,
- B. In other words,
- C. In addition,
- D. For example,

ID: 50969f48 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "In addition" logically signals that the claim in this sentence—that the Inca of South America may have used quipus to record more complex information—is an additional point related to the previous statement about the Inca using quipus to record countable information.

Choice A is incorrect because "as a result" illogically signals that the claim in the sentence is a consequence or result of the previous statement about the Inca using quipus to record countable information. Instead, the possibility that the Inca used quipus to record more complex information is an additional point about how the quipus were used. Choice B is incorrect because "in other words" illogically signals that the claim in the sentence is merely a paraphrase or restatement of the previous statement about the Inca using quipus to record countable information. Instead, the possibility that the Inca used quipus to record more complex information is an additional point about how the quipus were used. Choice D is incorrect because "for example" illogically signals that the claim in the sentence exemplifies the previous statement about the Inca using quipus to record countable information. Instead, the possibility that the Inca used quipus to record more complex information is an additional point about how the quipus were used.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f911db45

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: f911db45

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- One of history’s greatest libraries was the House of Wisdom in Baghdad, Iraq.
- It was founded in the eighth century with the goal of preserving all the world’s knowledge.
- Scholars at the House of Wisdom collected ancient and contemporary texts from Greece, India, and elsewhere and translated them into Arabic.
- Writings included those of the Greek philosopher Aristotle and the Indian mathematician Aryabhata.
- The House of Wisdom used Chinese papermaking technology to create paper versions to be studied and shared.

The student wants to explain how the House of Wisdom preserved the world’s knowledge. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The House of Wisdom was known for bringing together knowledge from around the world, including from Greece, India, and China.
- B. Founded in Iraq in the eighth century, the House of Wisdom employed many scholars as translators.
- C. Writings from the Greek philosopher Aristotle and the Indian mathematician Aryabhata were preserved at the House of Wisdom.
- D. The House of Wisdom collected writings from different countries and created paper versions in Arabic to be studied and shared.

ID: f911db45 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence explains how the House of Wisdom preserved the world’s knowledge, noting that the library collected, translated, and printed writings from different countries.

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence indicates that the House of Wisdom was known for bringing together knowledge from around the world, it doesn’t explain how the library preserved this knowledge. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence makes a generalization about the scholars who were employed by the House of Wisdom; it doesn’t explain how the library preserved the world’s knowledge. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence identifies two authors whose writings were preserved at the House of Wisdom; it doesn’t explain how the library preserved the world’s knowledge.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1dc3a731

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 1dc3a731

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Freddie Wong (born 1985) is a director and special effects artist from the United States.
- He is best known for the action-comedy web series *Video Game High School* (VGHS).
- VGHS premiered in 2012 on RocketJump, a YouTube channel that Wong cocreated.
- The series was celebrated for its inventive video game–centric world and high-quality special effects.
- VGHS was nominated for a Producers Guild Award for Outstanding Digital Series.

The student wants to begin a narrative about Wong’s award-nominated web series. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. In 2012, director and visual effects artist Freddie Wong launched a new action-comedy web series: *Video Game High School*.
- B. *Video Game High School* was celebrated for its inventive video game–centric world and high-quality special effects, and it was nominated for a Producer’s Guild Award for Outstanding Digital Series.
- C. Wong, cocreator of the YouTube channel RocketJump, would go on to see his web series be nominated for a Producers Guild Award.
- D. In 2012, *Video Game High School* premiered on RocketJump; it would later be nominated for an award.

ID: 1dc3a731 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice introduces Wong and VGHS in an active and specific way, as if to an audience unfamiliar with the series. It also sets up the time and genre of the web series, which are useful ways to introduce the series of events in a narrative.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice isn’t suited for beginning a narrative. A narrative is a story that follows a sequence of events and creates interest and suspense for the reader. This choice jumps to the end, explaining the success of VGHS without explaining what it is. Choice C is incorrect. This choice isn’t suited for beginning a narrative. It doesn’t actually introduce the web series by name. It just jumps to later in the story without sufficient explanation. Choice D is incorrect. This choice is not very effective for beginning a narrative. It doesn’t explain what VGHS is, and it doesn’t mention Wong.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e5b0c865

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: e5b0c865

For years, biologists have experimented with using grime-eating bacteria rather than harsh chemicals to clean artworks, and results have been impressive overall. _____ these bacterial strains—which can metabolize centuries’ worth of oil, glue, dirt, and other surface impurities without creating harmful byproducts—have proven more effective than traditional chemical cleaning methods.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. However,
- B. In many cases,
- C. As a result,
- D. Additionally,

ID: e5b0c865 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “In many cases” logically links the information that follows to the previous sentence’s claim that the results of bacterial cleaning “have been impressive overall.” This sentence supports that claim by indicating that the bacteria “have proven more effective than traditional chemical cleaning methods.” Noting that this is true “in many cases” appropriately frames the information in the sentence and thus completes the text with the most logical transition.

Choice A is incorrect because “however” illogically signals that the information in this sentence contrasts with the previous information. Instead, this sentence supports the previous sentence’s claim that the results of bacterial cleaning “have been impressive overall,” noting that the bacteria “have proven more effective than traditional chemical cleaning methods.” Choice C is incorrect because “as a result” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is a consequence of the claim about the results of bacterial cleaning. Instead, this sentence supports the previous sentence’s claim that the results of bacterial cleaning “have been impressive overall,” noting that the bacteria “have proven more effective than traditional chemical cleaning methods.” Choice D is incorrect because “additionally” illogically signals that the information in this sentence is merely additional to (and separate from) the previous information about the results of bacterial cleaning. Instead, this sentence supports the previous sentence’s claim that the results of bacterial cleaning “have been impressive overall,” noting that the bacteria “have proven more effective than traditional chemical cleaning methods.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b137bf90

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: b137bf90

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- As engineered structures, many bird nests are uniquely flexible yet cohesive.
- A research team led by Yashraj Bhosale wanted to better understand the mechanics behind these structural properties.
- Bhosale’s team used laboratory models that simulated the arrangement of flexible sticks into nest-like structures.
- The researchers analyzed the points where sticks touched one another.
- When pressure was applied to the model nests, the number of contact points between the sticks increased, making the structures stiffer.

The student wants to present the primary aim of the research study. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Bhosale’s team wanted to better understand the mechanics behind bird nests’ uniquely flexible yet cohesive structural properties.
- B. The researchers used laboratory models that simulated the arrangement of flexible sticks and analyzed the points where sticks touched one another.
- C. After analyzing the points where sticks touched, the researchers found that the structures became stiffer when pressure was applied.
- D. As analyzed by Bhosale’s team, bird nests are uniquely flexible yet cohesive engineered structures.

ID: b137bf90 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. It describes the reason Bhosale’s team wanted to study the structures of bird nests—that is to say, the study’s primary aim.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice doesn’t present the primary aim of the research study. It describes how the study worked, but not why it was done. Choice C is incorrect. This choice doesn’t present the primary aim of the research study. It describes a result of the experiment, but not why it was carried out. Choice D is incorrect. This choice doesn’t present the primary aim of the research study.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8fbbb96c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 8fbbb96c

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Jordan Bennett is a Mi’Kmaq visual artist.
- The Mi’Kmaq are a First Nations people in North America.
- Bennett’s paintings pay homage to traditional Mi’Kmaq craftsmanship and have been displayed in over 75 exhibitions.
- His 2017 exhibition *Wije’wi* was held at the Grenfell Art Gallery.
- His 2018 exhibition *Ketu’elmita’jik* was held at the Art Gallery of Nova Scotia.

The student wants to emphasize the order in which two of Jordan Bennett’s exhibitions were held. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Jordan Bennett’s 2017 exhibition *Wije’wi* was followed a year later by his exhibition *Ketu’elmita’jik*.
- B. Jordan Bennett’s paintings, some of which appeared in 2017 and 2018 exhibitions, pay homage to traditional Mi’Kmaq craftsmanship.
- C. Mi’Kmaq visual artist Jordan Bennett has displayed his work in over 75 exhibitions, including *Wije’wi* and *Ketu’elmita’jik*.
- D. Jordan Bennett’s 2018 exhibition *Ketu’elmita’jik* was held at the Art Gallery of Nova Scotia; another was held at the Grenfell Art Gallery.

ID: 8fbbb96c Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the order in which two of Jordan Bennett’s exhibitions were held, indicating that *Wije’wi* took place in 2017 and *Ketu’elmita’jik* took place a year later (2018).

Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence mentions that exhibitions of Jordan Bennett’s paintings took place in 2017 and 2018, it doesn’t identify the exhibitions or emphasize the order in which they were held. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence mentions two of Jordan Bennett’s exhibitions, it doesn’t indicate the order in which they were held. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence mentions two of Jordan Bennett’s exhibitions and specifies when one of them was held, it doesn’t state when the exhibition at the Grenfell Art Gallery occurred. Thus, the order in which the two exhibitions were held isn’t clearly established in the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c81ce4b7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: c81ce4b7

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Scientists have developed a “freeze-thaw” battery that can retain 92% of its charge after twelve weeks.
- The battery contains molten salt (a type of salt that liquifies when heated and solidifies at room temperature).
- When the salt is in a liquid state, energy flows through the battery.
- When the salt is in a solid state, energy stops flowing and is stored in the battery.
- The stored (frozen) energy can be used by reheating (thawing) the battery.

The student wants to specify how the salt enables energy storage. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Scientists have developed a freeze-thaw battery that contains molten salt, which liquifies when heated and solidifies at room temperature.
- B. The stored energy in a freeze-thaw battery, which contains molten salt, can be used by reheating the battery.
- C. When the molten salt in a freeze-thaw battery solidifies at room temperature, energy stops flowing and can be stored in the battery.
- D. Molten salt allows a freeze-thaw battery to retain 92% of its charge after twelve weeks.

ID: c81ce4b7 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The sentence specifies how the salt in a freeze-thaw battery enables energy storage, explaining that energy stops flowing and can be stored when the salt solidifies at room temperature.

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence explains some properties of molten salt; it doesn’t specify how that salt enables energy storage. Choice B is incorrect. The sentence indicates how the energy in a freeze-thaw battery can be released; it doesn’t specify how the salt in the battery enables energy storage. Choice D is incorrect. The sentence specifies how much charge the freeze-thaw battery retains when storing energy; it doesn’t specify how the salt in the battery enables energy storage.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 72f3281c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: 72f3281c

Mountain climbing routes that incorporate metal rungs and cables are known as via ferratas, from the Italian phrase for “iron path.” As climbing these routes has shifted from a mode of travel to a sporting activity, modern via ferratas are rarely designed to simply reach a summit. _____ new routes favor recreation over utility, aiming to provide a challenging climb or showcase dramatic scenery.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Additionally,
- B. On the other hand,
- C. More often,
- D. Nonetheless,

ID: 72f3281c Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. "More often" logically signals that the claim in this sentence—that new via ferratas favor recreation over utility—explains a difference between the new "sporting activity" routes and the older "mode of travel" routes. In so doing, it emphasizes and reinforces the previous claim ("modern via ferratas are rarely designed to simply reach a summit").

Choice A is incorrect because "additionally" illogically signals that this sentence’s claim about new via ferratas adds a new, separate point to the previous claim ("modern via ferratas are rarely designed to simply reach a summit"). Instead, the second claim—that new routes favor recreation over utility—emphasizes and reinforces the previous one. Choice B is incorrect because "on the other hand" illogically signals that this sentence’s claim about new via ferratas contrasts with or opposes the previous claim ("modern via ferratas are rarely designed to simply reach a summit"). Instead, the second claim—that new routes favor recreation over utility—emphasizes and reinforces the previous one. Choice D is incorrect because "nonetheless" illogically signals that this sentence’s claim about new via ferratas is true despite the previous claim ("modern via ferratas are rarely designed to simply reach a summit"). Instead, the second claim—that new routes favor recreation over utility—emphasizes and reinforces the previous one.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 566271e4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: 566271e4

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In the early 1900s, suffragists organized marches for women’s voting rights.
- Suffragists in the United Kingdom marched from Edinburgh to London.
- This march began on October 12, 1912, and ended on November 16, 1912.
- Suffragists in the United States marched from New York City to Albany, New York.
- This march began on December 16, 1912, and ended on December 28, 1912.

The student wants to emphasize the order in which the two marches occurred. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. After suffragists in the UK marched from Edinburgh to London, suffragists in the US marched from New York City to Albany, New York.
- B. In the early 1900s, suffragists in the UK and the US marched for women’s voting rights.
- C. A march from New York City to Albany, New York, was followed by one that began in Edinburgh and ended in London.
- D. From October 12 to November 16, 1912, suffragists in the UK marched from Edinburgh to London.

ID: 566271e4 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The sentence emphasizes the order in which the two marches occurred, correctly indicating that the US march (December 16 to December 28, 1912) occurred after the march in the UK (October 12 to November 16, 1912).

Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence mentions that both marches took place in the early 1900s, it doesn’t emphasize the order in which the two marches occurred. Choice C is incorrect. While the sentence does emphasize the order in which the two marches occurred, the order is incorrect. The UK march took place from October 12 to November 16, 1912, which was before the US march (December 1912). Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence specifies the dates of the UK march, it doesn’t mention the US march or emphasize the order in which the two marches occurred.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e246911f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: e246911f

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- *Here I Have Returned* is a sculpture by Egyptian American artist Sherin Guirguis.
- It is a large, curved strip of wood inspired by the shape of a sistrum.
- A sistrum is a curved musical instrument played by ancient Egyptian priestesses in ceremonies.
- Guirguis says that the sculpture symbolizes “women who have lifted and supported Egyptian society and culture.”
- Overall, Guirguis wants her works to “engage audiences in a dialogue about power, agency, and social transformation.”

The student wants to use a quotation from Guirguis to explain what the sculpture represents. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Guirguis, whose works include a sculpture that is a large, curved strip of wood, has explained that she wants her work to create a dialogue with audiences.
- B. Inspired by the sistrum played by Egyptian priestesses, *Here I Have Returned* symbolizes “women who have lifted and supported Egyptian society and culture,” according to Guirguis.
- C. According to Guirguis, the curved strip of wood used in *Here I Have Returned* was inspired by the sistrum, a musical instrument played by ancient Egyptian priestesses in ceremonies.
- D. Guirguis, the sculptor of *Here I Have Returned*, wants her works to “engage audiences in a dialogue about power, agency, and social transformation.”

ID: e246911f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The sentence uses a quotation from Guirguis to explain what *Here I Have Returned* represents, noting that Guirguis said the sculpture symbolizes "women who have lifted and supported Egyptian society and culture."

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence explains what Guirguis says she wants her work to achieve and provides an example of her work; it doesn't use a quotation to explain what the sculpture represents. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence mentions the instrument whose shape inspired the sculpture but doesn't use a quotation to explain what the sculpture represents. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence does use a quotation from Guirguis, the quotation explains what she hopes her works in general achieve, not what the sculpture in particular represents.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ba489f3a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	

ID: ba489f3a

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Political scientist Graham Allison is known for his Thucydides trap theory.
- Allison’s theory states that whenever “a rising power is threatening to displace a ruling power,” conflict is likely.
- The theory is based on Thucydides’s explanation of the conflict between Athens and Sparta.
- Thucydides wrote that “the rise of Athens and the fear this instilled in Sparta” made conflict “inevitable.”
- History professor Edmund Stewart recently challenged the historical basis of the theory.
- Stewart claimed that Athens was not a rising power and that the rivals experienced a “clash of cultures” instead.

The student wants to use a quotation to challenge Thucydides’s explanation of the conflict between Athens and Sparta. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. According to Allison’s Thucydides trap theory, whenever “a rising power is threatening to displace a ruling power,” conflict is likely.
- B. Thucydides wrote that conflict between the two powers was “inevitable,” although Stewart later challenged the historical basis of this claim.
- C. According to Stewart, a “clash of cultures” between Athens and Sparta caused the conflict, not Athens’s rise.
- D. Thucydides explained that conflict was caused by “the rise of Athens and the fear this instilled in Sparta,” but Allison disagreed, seeing the conflict as an example of the Thucydides trap.

ID: ba489f3a Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. Using a quotation from Stewart, the sentence challenges Thucydides’s explanation that the rise of Athens caused the conflict, suggesting that it was instead caused by a "clash of cultures."

Choice A is incorrect. While the sentence uses a quotation, the quotation doesn’t challenge Thucydides’s explanation of the conflict. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence mentions that Stewart challenged Thucydides’s explanation of the conflict, it doesn’t use a quotation to challenge Thucydides’s explanation: the quoted word "inevitable" is from Thucydides. Choice D is incorrect. While the sentence appears to refute Thucydides’s explanation, it does so in a way that misrepresents the information in the notes; Allison’s Thucydides trap theory is based on Thucydides’s explanation of the conflict. Thus, Allison’s theory affirms, rather than challenges, Thucydides’s explanation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b4175838

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Transitions	

ID: b4175838

“Tulip mania”—the rapid rise and sudden fall of the price of tulip bulbs in seventeenth-century Amsterdam—is often cited as an example of the perils of rampant market speculation. However, recent research has demonstrated that the episode was neither as frenzied nor as disastrous as has been thought. The popular myth surrounding it, _____ should be regarded with some skepticism.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. for example,
- B. by contrast,
- C. nevertheless,
- D. therefore,

ID: b4175838 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. This sentence is arguing that new evidence contradicting popular beliefs about “tulip mania” should cast doubt on those beliefs. “Therefore” is a cause-and-effect transition, which fits perfectly in this context.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice uses an exemplification transition, which doesn’t make sense here. Skepticism about the popular beliefs is not an example of recent evidence contradicting those beliefs—rather, skepticism is an effect of that recent evidence. Choice B is incorrect. This choice uses a disagreement transition. But this sentence doesn’t disagree with the previous sentence. Instead, it connects a cause from the previous sentence (new evidence that tulip mania was not as disastrous as thought) to an effect (that we should look with skepticism upon the myth about its disastrousness). Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses a disagreement transition. But this sentence doesn’t disagree with the previous sentence. Instead, it connects a cause from the previous sentence (new evidence that tulip mania was not as disastrous as thought) to an effect (that we should look with skepticism upon the myth about its disastrousness).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 11522a42

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 11522a42

Consider the mechanics of the pinhole camera: light passes through a small hole, resulting in a focused projected image. A ray diagram reveals how this _____ the hole’s small size restricts light to a single ray, all light passing through the hole can only arrive at a single destination, eliminating diffraction and ensuring a clear image.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. works because
- B. works. Because
- C. works, it’s because
- D. works: it’s because

ID: 11522a42 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used to correctly mark the boundary between one sentence ("A ray...works") and another ("Because...image").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two sentences ("A ray...works" and "Because...image") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Since the contraction "it’s" creates a main clause, the comma after "single ray" can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between two main clauses ("it’s...ray" and "all light...image").

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6ade94ee

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 6ade94ee

Long attributed to Jacques-Louis David, the preeminent Neoclassical painter of his day, the 1801 painting *Marie Joséphine Charlotte du Val d’Ognes* gained fresh attention in the 1990s when art historians discovered that the painting—which depicts a solitary young woman sketching—was actually the work of little-known French portrait _____ Marie-Denise Villers (1774–1821).

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. artist—
- B. artist
- C. artist:
- D. artist,

ID: 6ade94ee Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed to set off the proper noun "Marie-Denise Villers" from the title that describes Villers, "little-known French portrait artist."

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c57fdaec

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: c57fdaec

With some 16,000 in attendance, the Second World Black and African Festival of Arts and _____ or FESTAC '77, as the event was more commonly known—became the largest pan-African event on record. FESTAC drew people from around the world to Lagos, Nigeria, for a monthlong celebration of Black and African art, scholarship, and activism.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Culture:
- B. Culture—
- C. Culture,
- D. Culture

ID: c57fdaec Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The text uses a dash to introduce a nonessential element that explains the acronym FESTAC. The dash matches the dash that comes after “known,” ending the descriptive aside.

Choice A is incorrect. A colon can only come after an independent clause, which isn’t the case here. Choice C is incorrect. While punctuation is required to set off “or FESTAC...known” from the rest of the sentence, nonessential elements must be separated from the sentence with matching punctuation. Since a dash appears on the other side of the element, we can’t use a comma here. Choice D is incorrect. The descriptive aside “or FESTAC...known” is a nonessential element that must be separated with punctuation from the rest of the sentence. This choice fails to add the necessary punctuation before the nonessential element.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e0240083

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: e0240083

A government body officially known as the Althing, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. the world’s oldest parliaments include one which first met in 930 CE, Iceland’s.
- B. Iceland’s parliament is one of the oldest in the world, first meeting in 930 CE.
- C. the first meeting of one of the oldest parliaments in the world, Iceland’s, was in 930 CE.
- D. 930 CE was the year when Iceland’s parliament, one of the oldest parliaments in the world, first met.

ID: e0240083 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "Iceland’s parliament" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "a government body officially known as the Althing." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that Iceland’s parliament—and not another noun in the sentence—is the government body known as the Althing.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "the world’s oldest parliaments" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the world’s oldest parliaments are a government body known as the Althing. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "the first meeting" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the first meeting of Iceland’s parliament was a government body known as the Althing. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "930 CE" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the year 930 CE is a government body known as the Althing.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0136623f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 0136623f

To fully describe the motion of an object requires knowing each of five _____ movement: displacement, time, initial velocity, final velocity, and acceleration. These are called kinematic variables.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. variable’s that characterize objects’
- B. variables that characterize objects’
- C. variables that characterize object’s
- D. variables that characterize objects

ID: 0136623f Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The conventions being tested are the use of plural and possessive nouns. The plural noun "variables" correctly indicates that there are multiple variables, and the plural possessive noun "objects'" correctly indicates that the movement of objects in general is being discussed.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the plural noun "variables," not the singular possessive noun "variable's." Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun "objects'," not the singular possessive noun "object's." Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun "objects'," not the plural noun "objects."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a7246802

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: a7246802

Author Madeline L’Engle, _____ to create a suspenseful tone that draws the reader in, begins her novel *A Wrinkle in Time* with descriptions of “wraithlike shadows” and “the frenzied lashing of the wind.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. looked
- B. looks
- C. is looking
- D. looking

ID: a7246802 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle verb “looking” is correctly used to form a subordinate clause that describes the intent behind how L’Engle begins her novel.

Choice A is incorrect because the finite past tense verb “looked” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause. Choice B is incorrect because the finite present tense verb “looks” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause. Choice C is incorrect because the finite present progressive tense verb “is looking” can’t be used in this way to form a subordinate clause.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3cd53efd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 3cd53efd

In 2018, the innovative works of Congolese sculptor and architect Bodys Isek _____ were featured in *City Dreams*, a solo exhibition at New York’s Museum of Modern Art.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Kingelez;
- B. Kingelez,
- C. Kingelez
- D. Kingelez:

ID: 3cd53efd Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a subject and a verb. No punctuation is needed when the subject of a sentence is immediately followed by a main verb. In this case, the sentence’s subject (“the innovative works of Congolese sculptor and architect Bodys Isek Kingelez”) is followed by the main verb “were featured,” and no punctuation should come between them.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fdff2716

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: fdff2716

Using satellite remote sensing, Dr. Catherine Nakalembe, director of NASA’s Harvest Africa initiative, gathers important data on crop health. Nakalembe doesn’t just compile the _____ she also shares her findings with African farmers, enabling them to make data-driven decisions about managing critical food crops.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. information, though;
- B. information, though,
- C. information; though
- D. information though,

ID: fdff2716 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice uses a semicolon to join two independent clauses ("Nakalembe doesn’t just...though" and "she also shares..."). This choice also appropriately includes "though" in the first clause, where it logically belongs.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a comma splice. It incorrectly joins two independent clauses with only a comma instead of a comma and a coordinating conjunction like "and" or "but." "Though" is a transition word, but it’s not a coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. A semicolon can only be used to link two independent clauses. However, if "though" is included in the second clause, it turns the second clause into a dependent clause, so a semicolon can’t be used after "information." Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a comma splice. It incorrectly joins two independent clauses with only a comma instead of a comma and a coordinating conjunction like "and" or "but."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 250288b9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 250288b9

In Death Valley National Park’s Racetrack Playa, a flat, dry lakebed, are 162 rocks—some weighing less than a pound but others almost 700 pounds—that move periodically from place to place, seemingly of their own volition. Racetrack-like trails in the _____ mysterious migration.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. playas sediment mark the rock’s
- B. playa’s sediment mark the rocks
- C. playa’s sediment mark the rocks’
- D. playas’ sediment mark the rocks’

ID: 250288b9 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of plural and possessive nouns. The singular possessive noun “playa’s” and the plural possessive noun “rocks’” correctly indicate that the sediment is that of one playa (the Racetrack Playa) and that there are multiple rocks that have mysteriously migrated across the sediment.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun “playa’s” and the plural possessive noun “rocks’,” not the plural noun “playas” and the singular possessive noun “rock’s.” Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun “rocks’,” not the plural noun “rocks.” Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun “playa’s,” not the plural possessive noun “playas’.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 26b3f4a6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 26b3f4a6

Swedish scientists Eva Engvall and Peter Perlmann developed a method for measuring the concentration of different proteins in a biological sample. Their _____ ELISA (enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay), is used to detect and measure proteins that indicate the presence of certain diseases.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. method (called
- B. method—called
- C. method, called
- D. method called

ID: 26b3f4a6 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The comma after “method” pairs with the comma after the closing parenthesis to separate the supplementary element “called ELISA (enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay)” from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to identify the name of Engvall and Perlmann’s method, and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because an opening parenthesis can’t be paired with a comma to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because a dash can’t be paired with a comma to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a31a4647

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: a31a4647

That the geographic center of North America lay in the state of North Dakota was conceded by all _____ establishing its precise coordinates proved more divisive.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. involved:
- B. involved,
- C. involved
- D. involved;

ID: a31a4647 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause ("That the...involved") and the second main clause ("establishing...divisive"). Further, the semicolon is the most appropriate choice when joining two separate, parallel statements, such as here, where the information following the semicolon contrasts with the information before.

Choice A is incorrect because placing a colon after "involved" illogically indicates that the information in the second main clause (the precise location was the subject of disagreement) explains or amplifies the information in the previous main clause (the general location was agreed upon by all). Instead, the information in the second clause contrasts with the previous information. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c8c6c6b4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: c8c6c6b4

To humans, it does not appear that the golden orb-weaver spider uses camouflage to capture its ____ the brightly colored arachnid seems to wait conspicuously in the center of its large circular web for insects to approach. Researcher Po Peng of the University of Melbourne has explained that the spider’s distinctive coloration may in fact be part of its appeal.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. prey, rather,
- B. prey rather,
- C. prey, rather;
- D. prey; rather,

ID: c8c6c6b4 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. The semicolon is correctly used to join the first main clause (“To humans...prey”) and the second main clause (“rather...approach”). Further, the comma after the adverb “rather” is correctly used to separate the adverb from the main clause (“the brightly...approach”) it modifies, logically indicating that the information in this clause (how the spider’s behavior appears to humans) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (how the spider’s behavior does not appear to humans).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without appropriate punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect. Placing the comma between the first main clause “To humans...prey” and the adverb “rather” illogically indicates that the information in the first main clause is contrary to what came before, which doesn’t make sense in this context.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID da68cd92

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: da68cd92

In October of 1648, representatives from 96 different parties convened to sign the final treaties of the Peace of Westphalia. The treaties, which brought an end to the Thirty Years’ War, _____ signed in the cities of Osnabrück and Münster, both located in the Holy Roman Empire–controlled region of Westphalia.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. were
- B. is
- C. was
- D. has been

ID: da68cd92 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb “were signed” agrees in number with the plural subject “the treaties.”

Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb “is signed” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “the treaties.” Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb “was signed” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “the treaties.” Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb “has been signed” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “the treaties.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3f1b2684

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 3f1b2684

Artist Yto Barrada’s exhibition *Ways to Baffle the Wind* incorporates sculptures, textiles, and films. Barrada’s pieces, utilizing elements as disparate as plant-dyed fabrics, wire crab traps filled with stones, and cotton balls dangling above a fan, _____ the ways humans attempt to organize and regulate nature.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. explore
- B. has explored
- C. explores
- D. exploring

ID: 3f1b2684 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb “explore” agrees in number with the plural subject “Barrada’s pieces.”

Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb phrase “has explored” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “Barrada’s pieces.” Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb “explores” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “Barrada’s pieces.” Choice D is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “exploring” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4341e518

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 4341e518

In the eastern Chinese city of Suzhou, known as a hub for silk manufacturing, a unique tradition of embroidery _____ back over two thousand years—one that includes iconic double-sided stitching with different images on each side—remains popular with modern audiences, preserving the city’s cultural heritage.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. dates
- B. date
- C. dating
- D. has dated

ID: 4341e518 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The sentence’s subject is “a unique tradition of embroidery,” and its finite main verb is “remains.” This choice correctly uses the nonfinite present participle “dating” to form an integrated participial phrase (“dating...years”) that modifies the subject, providing additional information about how far back the tradition goes.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. Using the finite present tense verb “dates” creates a second finite verb in the main clause, which already has the finite verb “remains” as its main verb. Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. Using the finite present tense verb “date” creates a second finite verb in the main clause, which already has the finite verb “remains” as its main verb. Furthermore, the plural verb “date” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject, “a unique tradition of embroidery.” Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. Using the finite present perfect tense verb “has dated” creates a second finite verb in the main clause, which already has the finite verb “remains” as its main verb.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a1225adb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: a1225adb

The artistic talents of Barbara Chase-Riboud, most known for her 1979 historical novel *Sally Hemings* and the conversation it inspired, _____ limited to the realm of prose: she first excelled in sculpture, where her affinity for bronze—a material she described as “timeless” due to its use across eras and cultures—became part of her artistic identity.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. hasn't been
- B. wasn't
- C. isn't
- D. aren't

ID: a1225adb Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The subject "talents" is plural, and so is the verb "aren't": "the artistic talents...aren't limited."

Choice A is incorrect. The subject "talents" is plural, but the verb "hasn't been" is singular. Choice B is incorrect. The subject "talents" is plural, but the verb "wasn't" is singular. Choice C is incorrect. The subject "talents" is plural, but the verb "isn't" is singular.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 01c615f6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 01c615f6

In rural Minnesota, ecologist Leroy Walston conducted a study to determine whether seeding solar panel fields with wildflowers could bolster pollinator populations in nearby food crops. Walston’s findings indicate that—assuming solar panel installers’ _____ practice has the potential to increase the number of native bees in crops near solar fields throughout the Midwest by up to 20 percent.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. cooperation, this
- B. cooperation—this
- C. cooperation: this
- D. cooperation this

ID: 01c615f6 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a dash after “cooperation” to pair with the dash after “that” to separate the supplementary element “assuming solar panel installers’ cooperation” from the rest of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a colon can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplemental element from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8844b527

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 8844b527

The present-day city of Dushanbe, Tajikistan, was for years the capital of the Tajik Autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic, one of many nominally autonomous republics within the Soviet Union. Like _____ peer autonomous Soviet socialist republics, the Tajik Republic was established along ethnolinguistic lines: most of the republic’s residents spoke Persian.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. their
- B. they’re
- C. its
- D. it’s

ID: 8844b527 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive determiners. The singular possessive determiner "its" agrees in number with the singular subject "the Tajik Republic" and thus indicates that the other republics were its peers.

Choice A is incorrect because the plural possessive determiner "their" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "the Tajik Republic." Choice B is incorrect because "they’re" is the contraction for "they are," not a possessive determiner. Choice D is incorrect because "it’s" is the contraction for "it is" or "it has," not a possessive determiner.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a1805541

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: a1805541

Journalists have dubbed Gil Scott-Heron the “godfather of rap,” a title that has appeared in hundreds of articles about him since the 1990s. Scott-Heron himself resisted the godfather _____ feeling that it didn’t encapsulate his devotion to the broader African American blues music tradition as well as “bluesologist,” the moniker he preferred.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. nickname, however
- B. nickname, however;
- C. nickname, however,
- D. nickname; however,

ID: a1805541 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and two supplementary elements. In this choice, the commas after “nickname” and “however” are correctly used to separate the supplementary adverb “however” from the main clause (“Scott-Heron...nickname”) on one side and the supplementary participial phrase (“feeling...bluesologist”) on the other.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary adverb “however” and the supplementary phrase (“feeling...bluesologist”). Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the supplementary adverb “however” and the supplementary phrase (“feeling...bluesologist”). Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“Scott-Heron...nickname”) and the supplementary word and phrase (“however” and “feeling...bluesologist”). Moreover, placing the semicolon after “nickname” illogically signals that the following information (Scott-Heron’s feeling that the nickname didn’t encapsulate his devotion to the blues tradition) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (Scott-Heron’s resistance to the nickname).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5eb6ea08

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 5eb6ea08

The Proto-Nilotic language, common ancestor of fifty-five African languages with similar linguistic properties, _____ like all protolanguages, hypothetical: there’s no direct evidence these ancestral languages actually existed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. is,
- B. are,
- C. have been,
- D. were,

ID: 5eb6ea08 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "is" agrees in number with the singular subject "the Proto-Nilotic language."

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "are" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "the Proto-Nilotic language." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "have been" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "the Proto-Nilotic language." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "were" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "the Proto-Nilotic language."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 172a8388

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 172a8388

Photosynthesis, the mechanism by which plants use sunlight to turn carbon dioxide and water into _____ is fueled in part by an enzyme called Photosystem II that harvests energy-giving electrons from water molecules.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. nutrients
- B. nutrients and
- C. nutrients,
- D. nutrients—

ID: 172a8388 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The comma after “nutrients” pairs with the comma after “photosynthesis” to separate the supplementary element “the mechanism by which plants use sunlight to turn carbon dioxide and water into nutrients” from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to define the term “photosynthesis,” and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because a conjunction can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a dash can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f86dccce

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: f86dccce

Ten of William Shakespeare’s plays are classified as histories. Although each one of these plays, which include *Henry V* and *Richard III*, _____ on a single historical figure (specifically, an English king), some, such as *Henry VI Part One* and *Henry VI Part Two*, feature different episodes from the same monarch’s life.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. focuses
- B. focus
- C. are focused
- D. were focused

ID: f86dccce Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb “focuses” agrees in number with the singular subject “each one of these plays.” While the prepositional phrase “of these plays” within the subject contains a plural noun, the head of the subject (“each one”) is singular, indicating that each individual play focuses on a single historical figure.

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “focus” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “each one of these plays.” Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “are focused” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “each one of these plays.” Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb “were focused” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “each one of these plays.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 92cb51c6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 92cb51c6

Star actress Kiki Omeili, who has appeared in 47 Nollywood films, is one of numerous luminaries to be pictured in Nigerian portraitist Iké Udé’s exhibition *Nollywood Portraits*. _____ referred to Nollywood—Nigeria’s \$3 billion film industry—as “Africa’s vivid mirror par excellence,” honors its legacy with his vivid classical portraits of Omeili and her peers.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Udé, has
- B. Udé has
- C. Udé
- D. Udé, having

ID: 92cb51c6 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms and punctuation within a sentence. The sentence’s subject is “Udé,” and its finite main verb is “honors.” This choice correctly uses the nonfinite participle “having referred” to form a supplementary element (“having...excellence”) describing Udé. The comma after “Udé” appropriately marks the boundary before that supplementary element.

Choice A is incorrect because using the finite verb “has referred” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “honors,” so “has referred” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions. Moreover, no punctuation is needed when a subject (“Udé”) is immediately followed by a finite verb (“has referred”). Choice B is incorrect because using the finite verb “has referred” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “honors,” so “has referred” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions. Choice C is incorrect because using the finite verb “referred” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “honors,” so “referred” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0c7f9099

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 0c7f9099

As cheesemaking practices spread throughout Europe and Asia during and after the Neolithic, divergent strategies for preserving milk _____ whereas rennet-coagulated cheesemaking became key to milk preservation in Europe and Southwest Asia, acid-heat coagulation methods became common among nomadic herding populations of the northeastern Eurasian steppe.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. emerged
- B. emerged and
- C. emerged:
- D. emerged,

ID: 0c7f9099 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use within a sentence. A colon can be used between two main clauses to signal that what follows is an elaboration of what came before. In this choice, the colon correctly introduces the following explanation of the divergent milk preservation strategies that emerged.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The main clause ("As...emerged") and the subordinate clause followed by another main clause ("whereas...steppe") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join a main clause ("As...emerged") and a subordinate clause followed by another main clause ("whereas...steppe"). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join a main clause ("As...emerged") and a subordinate clause followed by another main clause ("whereas...steppe").

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID af1d7690

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: af1d7690

Woven from recycled yarn and hand tufted using a carpet weaving technique passed down by the artist’s Turkish grandmother, _____ so lush and tactilely inviting that you are tempted to reach out and touch them.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. the topological tapestries of Argentine textile artist Alexandra Kehayoglou are
- B. the Argentine textile artist Alexandra Kehayoglou creates topological tapestries that are
- C. when she creates her topological tapestries, Argentine textile artist Alexandra Kehayoglou makes them
- D. Alexandra Kehayoglou is an Argentine textile artist whose topological tapestries are

ID: af1d7690 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "topological tapestries" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "woven...grandmother." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the topological tapestries—and not another noun in the sentence—are being described as woven from recycled yarn and hand tufted.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "Argentine textile artist Alexandra Kehayoglou" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that Kehayoglou is woven from recycled yarn and hand tufted. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the pronoun "she" and the noun phrase "Argentine textile artist Alexandra Kehayoglou" after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that Kehayoglou is woven from recycled yarn and hand tufted. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun "Alexandra Kehayoglou" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that Kehayoglou is woven from recycled yarn and hand tufted.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9c2d0969

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 9c2d0969

In 1959, marine biologist Dr. Albert Jones founded the Underwater Adventure Seekers, a scuba diving _____ that is the oldest club for Black divers in the United States and that has helped thousands of diving enthusiasts become certified in the field.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. club
- B. club,
- C. club—
- D. club, and

ID: 9c2d0969 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “That is...field” is an essential supplement, so we should not use punctuation to separate it from “scuba diving club.” .

Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “That is...field” is an essential supplement, so we should not use a comma (or any kind of punctuation) to separate it from “scuba diving club.” . Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “That is...field” is an essential supplement, so we should not use a dash (or any kind of punctuation) to separate it from “scuba diving club.” . Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence. It makes “that is...United States” into an awkward independent clause, but it also makes “that has...field” into its own awkward independent clause without the correct punctuation separating it.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8d83b986

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 8d83b986

In a 2016 study, Eastern Washington University psychologist Amani El-Alayli found that, among the study participants who experienced frisson (a physiological response akin to goosebumps or getting the chills) while listening to music, there was one personality trait that they scored particularly _____ openness to experience.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. high. On
- B. high on;
- C. high on
- D. high on:

ID: 8d83b986 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between the main clause ("there...on") and the supplementary phrase ("openness to experience") and to introduce the information that identifies which personality trait participants scored especially high on.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "on" and separates a necessary preposition from the clause beginning with "there." Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can't be used in this way to join the main clause ("there...on") and the supplementary phrase ("openness to experience"). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, whereas a colon is conventionally used to introduce an element that explains or amplifies the information in the preceding clause, making the colon the better choice in this context. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause ("there...on") and the supplementary phrase ("openness to experience").

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 20da2770

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 20da2770

That Chaucer’s *Canterbury Tales* inspired imitators is evident from the existence of three near-contemporary “continuations” of the collection: *The Siege of Thebes*, which purports to be a new tale told during the pilgrims’ _____ *The Tale of Beryn*, which depicts the pilgrims as tourists; and *The Ploughman’s Tale*, which features a minor character from the original work.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. return.
- B. return
- C. return;
- D. return,

ID: 20da2770 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of elements in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after “return” is conventionally used to separate the first item (“*The Siege of Thebes*...return”) and the second item (“*The Tale of Beryn*...tourists”) in the series of tales. Moreover, the semicolon after “return” matches the semicolon used later to separate the second item and the third item (“and *The Ploughman’s Tale*...work”) in the series.

Choice A is incorrect because placing a period after “return” results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “*The Tale of Beryn*.” Choice B is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the first item and the second item in the complex series. Choice D is incorrect because a comma after “return” doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second and third items in the series.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c70e2541

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: c70e2541

Julia Alvarez’s 1994 novel *In the Time of the Butterflies*, a fictionalized account of the lives of the Mirabal _____ can serve as a starting point for those wanting to explore how the rule of dictator Rafael Trujillo has been represented in Dominican American literature.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. sisters, and
- B. sisters and
- C. sisters,
- D. sisters

ID: c70e2541 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The comma after "sisters" pairs with the comma after "*Butterflies*" to separate the supplementary element "a fictionalized account of the lives of the Mirabal sisters" from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to describe the novel *In the Time of the Butterflies*, and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because a comma and conjunction can’t be used in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 621c4ffd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 621c4ffd

For thousands of years, humans have used domesticated goats (*Capra hircus*) to clear land of unwanted vegetation. When it comes to their diets, goats are notoriously _____ they will devour all kinds of shrubs and weeds, leaving virtually no part of any plant unconsumed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. indiscriminate and
- B. indiscriminate,
- C. indiscriminate
- D. indiscriminate:

ID: 621c4ffd Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between two main clauses. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between one main clause ("goats are notoriously indiscriminate") and another main clause ("they will devour all kinds of shrubs and weeds") and to introduce the following explanation of goats' nondiscriminatory behavior when it comes to what they eat.

Choice A is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it's conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Furthermore, the conjunction "and" fails to indicate that what follows is an explanation of goats' nondiscriminatory behavior when it comes to their diets. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses ("goats...indiscriminate" and "they...weeds"). Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("goats...indiscriminate" and "they...weeds") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c89d5dae

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: c89d5dae

In her 1983 book *The Managed Heart: Commercialization of Human Feeling*, sociologist Arlie Russell Hochschild first explored at length her conception of a “sociology of emotions”—the idea that the various cultural and ideological frameworks a person has internalized (class, gender, political affiliation, etc.) _____ each emotional reaction that person has within a situation.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. underlies
- B. is underlying
- C. underlie
- D. has been underlying

ID: c89d5dae Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "underlie" agrees in number with the plural subject "frameworks."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "underlies" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "frameworks." Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb "is underlying" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "frameworks." Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "has been underlying" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "frameworks."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9cb54dc2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 9cb54dc2

In Marisol’s 1968 sculpture *Mi Mama y Yo*, gone are the types of pop culture references that made the Parisian-born Venezuelan American artist a star at the height of the pop art movement. In _____ place is a far more personal subject: a sculptural depiction of the artist as a young girl with her mother.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. its
- B. they’re
- C. their
- D. it’s

ID: 9cb54dc2 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive determiners. The plural possessive determiner "their" agrees in number with the plural noun "types" and thus indicates that the more personal subject matter of Marisol’s 1968 sculpture takes the place of those types of pop culture references that made Marisol a star.

Choice A is incorrect because the singular possessive determiner "its" doesn’t agree in number with the plural noun "types." Choice B is incorrect because "they’re" is the contraction for "they are," not a possessive determiner. Choice D is incorrect because "it’s" is the contraction for "it is" or "it has," not a possessive determiner.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c9b82a58

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: c9b82a58

In 1986, conceptual artist Sophie Calle asked twenty-three people, all of whom had been born without sight, to describe “their image of beauty” in rich detail. Calle paired excerpts of these conversations with photographs—both of interviewees and the items they _____ to powerful effect in her exhibition *The Blind*.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. described, from hair to grass to sculptures
- B. described, from hair to grass to sculptures—
- C. described—from hair to grass to sculptures,
- D. described: from hair to grass to sculptures

ID: c9b82a58 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of supplementary elements within a sentence. The comma after "described" separates the first supplementary element ("both of interviewees and the items they described") from the second supplementary element ("from hair to grass to sculptures"). Furthermore, the dash after "sculptures" pairs with the dash after "photographs" to separate these two supplementary elements from the rest of the sentence. The pair of dashes, which operate at a higher organizing level than the comma, indicates that the elements between the dashes function together—in this case, the second supplement ("from...sculptures") describes the range of items mentioned in the first supplement—and could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to appropriately punctuate the supplementary elements in the sentence. A dash is needed after "sculptures" to separate the supplementary elements ("both...sculptures") from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to appropriately punctuate the supplementary elements in the sentence. The two supplementary elements "both...described" and "from...sculptures" function together to describe the photographs, and placing a dash between them would make this relationship less clear, suggesting that the supplement "both...described" is a standalone element that could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence, which isn't the case. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to appropriately punctuate the supplementary elements in the sentence. A colon isn't conventionally used in this way to separate a supplementary element ("from hair to grass to sculptures") from the noun phrase it is modifying ("items they described"). Additionally, a dash is needed after "sculptures" to separate the supplementary elements ("both...sculptures") from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d794697e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: d794697e

Researchers studying the “terra-cotta army,” the thousands of life-size statues of warriors found interred near the tomb of Emperor Qin Shi Huang of China, were shocked to realize that the shape of each statue’s ears, like the shape of each person’s ears, _____ unique.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. are
- B. is
- C. were
- D. have been

ID: d794697e Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "is" agrees in number with the singular subject "the shape."

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "are" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "the shape." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "were" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "the shape." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "have been" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "the shape."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 003e9ef2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 003e9ef2

In paleontology, the term “Elvis taxon” gets applied to a newly identified living species that was once presumed to be extinct. Like an Elvis impersonator who might bear a striking resemblance to the late musical icon Elvis Presley himself, an Elvis taxon is not the real thing, _____ is a misidentified look-alike.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. however but it
- B. however it
- C. however, it
- D. however. It

ID: 003e9ef2 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The clause “Like an Elvis impersonator...real thing” and the clause “it is...look-alike” are both independent clauses, so making them into two separate sentences is grammatically correct.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence error. The clause “Like an Elvis impersonator...real thing” and the clause “it is...look-alike” are both independent clauses, so they need to be separated with at least a comma + a coordinating conjunction. This choice provides the coordinating conjunction “but,” but it’s missing a comma. Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence error. The clause “Like an Elvis impersonator...real thing” and the clause “it is...look-alike” are both independent clauses, so they need to be separated with a semicolon, a colon, a dash, a period, or a comma + a coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence error. The clause “Like an Elvis impersonator...real thing” and the clause “it is...look-alike” are both independent clauses, so they need to be separated with at least a comma + a coordinating conjunction. This choice provides a comma, but it’s missing a coordinating conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c6d46f02

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: c6d46f02

Official measurements of the Mississippi River’s length vary: according to the US Geological Survey, the river is 2,300 miles long, whereas the Environmental Protection Agency records its length as 2,320 miles. This disparity can be explained in part by the fact that rivers such as the Mississippi expand and contract as _____ sediment.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. they accumulate
- B. one accumulates
- C. it accumulates
- D. we accumulate

ID: c6d46f02 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The plural pronoun “they” agrees in number with the plural antecedent “rivers” and clearly expresses the general statement that rivers expand and contract as they accumulate sediment. Secondly, the plural verb “accumulate” agrees in number with the plural pronoun and its plural antecedent.

Choice B is incorrect because the singular pronoun “one” doesn’t agree in number with the plural antecedent “rivers.” Choice C is incorrect because the singular pronoun “it” doesn’t agree in number with the plural antecedent “rivers.” Choice D is incorrect because the use of the personal pronoun “we” is illogical in this context; it suggests that a group of people (including the speaker) accumulate sediment, which doesn’t make sense.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 84bf96ab

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 84bf96ab

Humans were long thought to have begun occupying the Peruvian settlement of Machu Picchu between 1440 and 1450 CE. However, a team led by anthropologist Dr. Richard Burger used accelerator mass spectrometry to uncover evidence that it was occupied ____ 1420 CE, according to Burger, humans were likely inhabiting the area.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. earlier. In
- B. earlier, in
- C. earlier, which in
- D. earlier in

ID: 84bf96ab Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“However...earlier”) and another (“In...area”). The supplementary phrase “in 1420 CE” modifies “humans,” the subject of the third sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Moreover, the subordinating conjunction “which” creates a confusing and illogical sentence that suggests that the supplementary phrase beginning with “in” modifies the previous information (“However...earlier”) rather than the information that follows. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences (“However...earlier” and “in...area”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fa5970ee

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: fa5970ee

Stomata, tiny pore structures in a leaf that absorb gases needed for plant growth, open when guard cells surrounding each pore swell with water. In a pivotal 2007 article, plant cell _____ showed that lipid molecules called phosphatidylinositol phosphates are responsible for signaling guard cells to open stomata.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. biologist, Yuree Lee
- B. biologist Yuree Lee,
- C. biologist Yuree Lee
- D. biologist, Yuree Lee,

ID: fa5970ee Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed to offset the proper noun "Yuree Lee" from the title "plant cell biologist" that describes Lee.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed around the proper noun "Yuree Lee." Setting the phrase off with punctuation suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn't the case.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a6e45850

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: a6e45850

For the past 20 million years, Earth’s magnetic poles in the far north and far south have remained roughly where they are today. This has not always been the _____ throughout geologic history, Earth’s magnetic poles have swapped places several times through a process called polar wandering.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. case, though
- B. case, though,
- C. case; though,
- D. case, though;

ID: a6e45850 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. Placing the semicolon after the supplementary adverb “though” correctly indicates that the contrast in the text is between the information in the first sentence (that Earth’s magnetic poles have remained fixed for the past 20 million years) and the initial clause of the second sentence (“This has not always been the case”), rather than between the two clauses of the second sentence.

Choice A is incorrect. Using the adverb “though” as the head of a subordinate clause illogically indicates that the information in the previous main clause (“This...case”) is contrary to the information in the subordinate clause. Instead, the information in the second clause (that Earth’s magnetic poles have swapped places several times) elaborates on the statement made in the previous clause (that Earth’s magnetic poles are not as fixed as they may seem). Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Commas can’t be used in this way to punctuate a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect. Using a semicolon after “case” places the adverb “though” inside the second main clause (“throughout...wandering”), illogically indicating that the information in the previous main clause is contrary to the information in the second one. Instead, the information in the second main clause (that Earth’s magnetic poles have swapped places several times) elaborates on the statement made in the previous clause (that Earth’s magnetic poles are not as fixed as they may seem).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 62a6afbb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 62a6afbb

When a given industry—water and electricity are two well-known examples—carries high infrastructural start-up costs and other barriers that discourage competition, _____ of just one or two suppliers per municipality. Such industries are known as natural monopolies.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. these often consist
- B. they often consist
- C. it often consists
- D. this often consists

ID: 62a6afbb Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun "it" agrees in number with the singular antecedent "industry" and clearly indicates that the industry consists of just one or two suppliers per municipality.

Choice A is incorrect. The plural pronoun "these" neither agrees in number with the singular antecedent "industry" nor clearly indicates that the industry—not another plural noun in the sentence, such as "start-up costs" or "barriers"—consists of just one or two suppliers per municipality. Choice B is incorrect because the plural pronoun "they" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "industry." Choice D is incorrect because the singular pronoun "this" is ambiguous in this context; the resulting sentence leaves unclear what consists of just one or two suppliers per municipality.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 64bc7de5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 64bc7de5

Within Earth’s biomes, there are four main types of desert: arid, semiarid, coastal, and cold. The roughly _____ is classified as an arid desert.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. 200,000 km² Puntland Desert,
- B. 200,000 km², Puntland Desert
- C. 200,000 km² Puntland Desert
- D. 200,000 km², Puntland Desert,

ID: 64bc7de5 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between a modifier and a noun and also between a subject and a verb. No punctuation is needed when, as in this case, a modifying phrase (“roughly 200,000 km²”) precedes the noun phrase it modifies (“Puntland Desert”) to form the subject of the sentence. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the subject (“The roughly...Desert”) and the main verb (“is classified”).

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the main verb. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the modifier and the noun phrase. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the modifier and the noun phrase, nor is it needed between the subject and the main verb.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3d798aa0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 3d798aa0

Dong Lai and Diego J. Muñoz’s work on circumbinary disk accretion—a process in which, due to gravity, material from an orbiting disk spirals inward and accumulates onto two stars or black holes—relies heavily on simulations. Lai and Muñoz recognize the need for direct _____ recommending evolving binary star systems as a promising avenue for future study.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. observation; however,
- B. observation, however,
- C. observation. However,
- D. observation, however;

ID: 3d798aa0 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after “observation” pairs with the comma after “however” to separate the supplementary adverb “however” from the rest of the sentence, which consists of a main clause (“Lai...observation”) followed by a participial phrase (“recommending...study”).

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“Lai...observation”) and the participial phrase (“recommending...study”) that follows the supplementary adverb “however.” A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, and “recommending...study” isn’t a main clause. Choice C is incorrect because placing a period after “observation” results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “however.” Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“Lai...however”) and the participial phrase (“recommending...study”) that follows. A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, and “recommending...study” isn’t a main clause.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 224d81b6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 224d81b6

A model created by biologist Luis Valente predicts that the rate of speciation—the rate at which new species form—on an isolated island located approximately 5,000 kilometers from the nearest mainland _____ triple the rate of speciation on an island only 500 kilometers from the mainland.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. being
- B. to be
- C. to have been
- D. will be

ID: 224d81b6 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is finite and nonfinite verb forms within a sentence. Relative clauses, such as the one beginning with “that,” require a finite verb, a verb that can function as the main verb of a clause. This choice correctly supplies the clause with the finite future tense verb “will be.”

Choice A is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “being” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb. Choice B is incorrect because the nonfinite to-infinitive “to be” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because the nonfinite to-infinitive “to have been” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7c08c775

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 7c08c775

With a blend of traditional design elements, such as arched Gothic ceilings, and modern ones, such as floor-to-ceiling _____ design splits the difference between old and new, a mixture that is increasingly seen in home interiors in the US.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. windows; transitional
- B. windows—transitional
- C. windows. Transitional
- D. windows, transitional

ID: 7c08c775 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the introductory subordinate clause ("With...windows") and the main clause ("transitional design splits the difference between old and new").

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can't be used in this way to separate the subordinate clause ("With...windows") from the main clause ("transitional...new"). Choice B is incorrect because a dash can't be used in this way to separate the subordinate clause ("With...windows") from the main clause ("transitional...new"). Choice C is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "with."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d12c451c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: d12c451c

The African Games Co-production Market, one of over 180 annual international conferences supporting video game development, _____ the growth of the African gaming industry by helping start-up studios in Africa find partners.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. promote
- B. are promoting
- C. promotes
- D. have promoted

ID: d12c451c Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The subject of the sentence is “The African Games Co-production Market.” That’s one market, so it’s a singular noun, which means it needs a singular verb. “Promotes” is the only singular verb among the choices.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a subject-verb agreement error. The subject “The African Games Co-production Market” is singular, but the verb “promote” is plural. Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a subject-verb agreement error. The subject “The African Games Co-production Market” is singular, but the verb “are promoting” is plural. Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a subject-verb agreement error. The subject “The African Games Co-production Market” is singular, but the verb “have promoted” is plural.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d7ed7ab1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: d7ed7ab1

The musical scores of Japanese composer Hiroyuki Sawano are famous for their mysterious titles. Laden with emojis and seemingly meaningless words, and driven largely by Sawano’s “personal feeling and mood,” _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. the listener can approach each piece free from expectations because of the titles.
- B. the titles allow the listener to approach each piece free from expectations.
- C. each piece can be approached by the listener free from expectations because of the titles.
- D. the listener’s approach to each piece because of the titles can be free from expectations.

ID: d7ed7ab1 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “the titles” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrases “laden with emojis and seemingly meaningless words, and driven largely by Sawano’s ‘personal feeling and mood.’” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the titles—and not another noun in the sentence—are being described as laden with emojis and driven by Sawano’s personal feeling.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of “the listener” immediately after the modifying phrases illogically suggests that the listener, rather than the titles, is laden with emojis and driven by Sawano’s personal feeling. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of “each piece” (i.e., musical score) immediately after the modifying phrases illogically suggests that the pieces, rather than the titles of the pieces, are laden with emojis and driven by Sawano’s personal feeling. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of “the listener’s approach” immediately after the modifying phrases illogically suggests that the listener’s approach, rather than the titles, is laden with emojis and driven by Sawano’s personal feeling.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e046c7fc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: e046c7fc

The city of Amsterdam partnered with consultants to develop Public Eye—an ethical AI-powered crowd-monitoring _____ video streamed from cameras in heavily touristed areas, the AI algorithm determines crowd sizes without, in the interest of protecting individuals’ privacy, retaining the footage.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. system—analyzing
- B. system, analyzing
- C. system. Analyzing
- D. system analyzing

ID: e046c7fc Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("The city...system") and another ("Analyzing...footage"). The participial phrase beginning with "analyzing" modifies the subject of the second sentence, "the AI algorithm."

Choice A is incorrect. Placing a dash before "analyzing" creates a confusing and ambiguous modifying element ("analyzing...areas") and a comma splice between "areas" and "the AI algorithm." (A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.) Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("The city... system" and "analyzing...footage") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 60f8b1ee

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 60f8b1ee

Luci Tapahonso is the inaugural poet laureate of the Navajo Nation. Her book *Sáanii Dahataal/The Women Are Singing*—a combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and _____ serves as a testament to her versatility as a writer.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. prose;
- B. prose
- C. prose,
- D. prose—

ID: 60f8b1ee Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match.

Choice A is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match. Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. “A combination of fiction and memoir, poetry and prose” is a nonessential supplement, so it needs to be set off from the rest of the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a dash at the beginning of the supplement, so we need to add a dash at the end of the supplement to match.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f783abc0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: f783abc0

How do scientists determine what foods were eaten by extinct hominins such as Neanderthals? In the past, researchers were limited to studying the marks found on the fossilized teeth of skeletons, but in 2017 a team led by Laura Weyrich of the Australian Centre for Ancient DNA tried something _____ the DNA found in Neanderthals’ fossilized dental plaque.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. new: sequencing
- B. new; sequencing
- C. new, sequencing:
- D. new. Sequencing

ID: f783abc0 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. “A team...tried something new” is an independent clause leading to an explanation of what the new thing was. A colon can only be used at the end of an independent clause, and typically introduces further explanation that expands upon the first clause, which makes a colon the perfect choice here.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. “Sequencing...dental plaque” can’t stand on its own as a sentence, and so it can’t be linked to the independent clause “a team...tried something new” with a semicolon. Only two independent clauses can be connected in this way. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. If “sequencing” is included in the first clause, it can no longer stand on its own as a complete idea. Since a colon can only come at the end of an independent clause, using one in this way creates an error. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a sentence fragment. “Sequencing... dental plaque” can’t stand on its own as a sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6c740a1d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 6c740a1d

In discussing Mary Shelley’s 1818 epistolary novel *Frankenstein*, literary theorist Gayatri Spivak directs the reader’s attention to the character of Margaret Saville. As Spivak points out, Saville is not the protagonist of Shelley’s _____ as the recipient of the letters that frame the book’s narrative, she’s the “occasion” of it.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. novel
- B. novel,
- C. novel; rather,
- D. novel, rather,

ID: 6c740a1d Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a semicolon to join a main clause (“Saville...novel”) and a second main clause (“she’s...it”) preceded by supplementary elements (“rather...narrative”).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, the comma after “novel” can’t be used in this way to join the two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0d4eda00

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 0d4eda00

The pedagogy of the Suzuki method is rooted in several central _____ by Japanese violinist Shinichi Suzuki, who sought to parallel the linguistic learning environment, the method emphasizes playing instruments from a very young age and teaches students as young as three to play simple classical pieces such as “March in G.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. tenets. Developed
- B. tenets developed
- C. tenets that, developed
- D. tenets, developed

ID: 0d4eda00 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. This choice correctly uses a period to mark the boundary between one sentence ("The pedagogy...tenets") and another ("Developed...‘March in G’"). The participial phrase "developed by Japanese violinist Shinichi Suzuki" modifies the subject of the next sentence, "the method."

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("The pedagogy...tenets" and "Developed...‘March in G’") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it creates a confusing and illogical sentence structure. The relative pronoun "that" followed by a comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3ac1b7e6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 3ac1b7e6

Several advantages—the ability to react strongly with chip components, to avoid interference from other waves, and to be confined within tiny circuits—_____ acoustic waves as a promising alternative to electrical waves for transmitting data on computer chips; as a result, researchers are invested in developing more acoustic wave-based chips.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. have positioned
- B. positioning
- C. by positioning
- D. having positioned

ID: 3ac1b7e6 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite (tensed) verb to perform the action of the subject. In this case, the subject is "several advantages," and the present perfect tense verb "have positioned" supplies the finite verb to indicate what has made acoustic waves a promising alternative to electrical waves.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "positioning" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The prepositional phrase "by positioning" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "having positioned" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e055c0c8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: e055c0c8

Professional American football player Fred Cox invented one of the world’s most popular toys. In the 1970s, he came up with the idea for the Nerf football, which _____ of the harder and heavier regulation football.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. were a smaller, foam version
- B. are smaller, foam versions
- C. were smaller, foam versions
- D. is a smaller, foam version

ID: e055c0c8 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement and agreement between nouns. The singular verb “is” and the singular noun “version” both agree in number with the relative pronoun “which.” In this context, “which” functions as a singular subject because it refers to the singular noun “the Nerf football.”

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb “were” doesn’t agree in number with the singular noun phrase “the Nerf football” that it’s modifying. Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “are” and the plural noun “versions” don’t agree in number with the singular noun phrase “the Nerf football” that they’re modifying. Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “were” and the plural noun “versions” don’t agree in number with the singular noun phrase “the Nerf football” that they’re modifying.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0ef22e69

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 0ef22e69

The Austronesian language family includes Tagalog, Malagasy, and some 1,200 other languages throughout the Pacific, making it one of the largest language families in the world and of keen interest to _____ of the University of Toronto.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. linguist, Diane Massam,
- B. linguist, Diane Massam
- C. linguist Diane Massam
- D. linguist: Diane Massam

ID: 0ef22e69 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed to set off the proper noun "Diane Massam" from the title that describes Massam, "linguist." Because "Diane Massam" is essential information identifying the "linguist," no punctuation is necessary.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed before or after the proper noun "Diane Massam." Setting the linguist's name off with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn't the case. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d5ba1e15

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: d5ba1e15

For her film *I Am Somebody* (1970), a documentary about a successful months-long strike held by Black female hospital workers in Charleston, South Carolina, director Madeline Anderson chose a narrator who had participated in the _____ by allowing the narrative to be shaped by one of their own, amplified the agency and power the workers possessed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. protest. A decision that
- B. protest; a decision that,
- C. protest, a decision that,
- D. protest a decision that,

ID: d5ba1e15 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma after “protest” to mark the boundary between the main clause (“For...protest”) and the supplementary appositive (“a decision...possessed”) that provides additional information about Anderson’s choice of narrator. Furthermore, the comma after “that” pairs with the comma after “own” to separate the supplementary adverbial phrase “by allowing...own” from the rest of the appositive. This adverbial phrase functions to explain how Anderson’s choice of a narrator amplified the agency and power the hospital workers possessed, and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “a decision.” Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“For...protest”) and the supplementary appositive (“a decision...possessed”). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, and “a decision...possessed” isn’t a main clause. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause (“For...protest”) and the supplementary appositive (“a decision...possessed”) with appropriate punctuation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 200d993b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 200d993b

Recent analysis of 32532 Thereus—an outer solar system object orbiting the Sun between Jupiter and Saturn—has determined its color to be gray, suggesting an icy composition. Such interpretations are ultimately _____ the object’s gray coloration may be an incidental effect of radiation, solar wind, or collisions with other objects rather than evidence of its physical makeup.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. speculative, though
- B. speculative, though;
- C. speculative; though
- D. speculative, though,

ID: 200d993b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation in a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb "though" from the preceding main clause ("Such interpretations are ultimately speculative") and uses a semicolon to join the next main clause ("the object’s...makeup") to the rest of the sentence. Further, placing the semicolon after "though" indicates that the information in the preceding main clause (interpretations of an outer solar system object’s composition based on its color are ultimately speculative) is a qualification of the information in the previous sentence (the composition of an outer solar system object is suggested by its color).

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the two main clauses with appropriate punctuation. Choice C is incorrect because placing the semicolon after "speculative" illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause ("the object’s...makeup") is a qualification of the information in the previous clause ("Such...speculative"). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Commas can’t be used in this way to punctuate a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4cac5e01

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 4cac5e01

Interest in mechanotransduction, the mechanism by which cells sense and convert mechanical stimuli into biochemical signals, is expanding because of innovative work by biomedical scientists—many of whom, like neuroscience and biophysics expert Elba Serrano, _____ this mechanism to better understand how the body’s neurological and biomechanical systems interact.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. is studying
- B. has studied
- C. study
- D. studies

ID: 4cac5e01 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The plural verb "study" agrees in number with the plural subject "many."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "is studying" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "many." Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb "has studied" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "many." Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "studies" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "many."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 408bc30e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 408bc30e

Forming extensive networks via mycorrhizal association—that is, a symbiotic relationship between plants and fungi—_____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. it is the entanglement of pine trees’ roots and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*’s fungal hyphae that makes nutrient transport possible.
- B. the transport of nutrients is possible through the entanglement of pine trees’ roots and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*’s fungal hyphae.
- C. nutrients can be transported through the entanglement of pine trees’ roots and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*’s fungal hyphae.
- D. pine trees and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake* can transport nutrients through their entangled tree roots and fungal hyphae.

ID: 408bc30e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "pine trees and the fungus *Tricholoma matsutake*" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "forming...association." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the pine trees and fungus—and not another noun in the sentence—are forming the networks.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the it-cleft "it is" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically and confusingly suggests that "it" is forming extensive networks. Furthermore, it’s not conventional to follow a long introductory modifying element with an it-cleft construction because it results in an unnecessarily wordy and confusing sentence, such as this. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "the transport of nutrients" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the transport of nutrients is forming extensive networks. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "nutrients" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that nutrients are forming extensive networks.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID db445fdc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: db445fdc

In 1937, Chinese American screen actor Anna May Wong, who had portrayed numerous villains and secondary characters but never a heroine, finally got a starring role in Paramount Pictures’ *Daughter of Shanghai*, a film that _____ “expanded the range of possibilities for Asian images on screen.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. critic, Stina Chyn, claims
- B. critic, Stina Chyn, claims,
- C. critic Stina Chyn claims
- D. critic Stina Chyn, claims,

ID: db445fdc Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The conventions being tested are punctuation use between titles and proper nouns and between verbs and integrated quotations. No punctuation is needed to set off the proper noun “Stina Chyn” from the title that describes Chyn, “critic.” Because “Stina Chyn” is essential information identifying the “critic,” no punctuation is necessary. Further, no punctuation is needed between the verb “claims” and the following quotation because the quotation is integrated into the structure of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed before or after the proper noun “Stina Chyn.” Setting the critic’s name off with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed before or after the proper noun “Stina Chyn.” Setting the critic’s name off with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between “claims” and the integrated quotation. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the verb “claims” and its subject, “critic Stina Chyn.” Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the verb “claims” and the integrated quotation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bd351ca4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: bd351ca4

Based on genetic evidence, archaeologists have generally agreed that reindeer domestication began in the eleventh century CE. However, since uncovering fragments of a 2,000-year-old reindeer training harness in northern Siberia, _____ may have begun much earlier.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. researcher Robert Losey has argued that domestication
- B. researcher Robert Losey’s argument is that domestication
- C. domestication, researcher Robert Losey has argued,
- D. the argument researcher Robert Losey has made is that domestication

ID: bd351ca4 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “researcher Robert Losey” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “since...Siberia.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that researcher Robert Losey—and not another noun in the sentence—is who uncovered fragments of a 2,000-year-old reindeer training harness in northern Siberia.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “researcher Robert Losey’s argument” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “argument” is what uncovered fragments of a 2,000-year-old reindeer training harness in northern Siberia. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun “domestication” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that “domestication” is what uncovered fragments of a 2,000-year-old reindeer training harness in northern Siberia. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the argument” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “argument” is what uncovered fragments of a 2,000-year-old reindeer training harness in northern Siberia.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f748a869

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: f748a869

In 1977, legendary Puerto Rican performer Rita Moreno won an Emmy Award, making her one of the rare talents to earn the highest honors in television, music, film, and stage entertainment—the Emmy, Grammy, Oscar, and Tony ____ the achievement is known as “winning the EGOT.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. awards, respectively;
- B. awards; respectively
- C. awards, respectively—
- D. awards, respectively,

ID: f748a869 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb “respectively” from the rest of the supplementary element introduced by the dash after “entertainment” (“the Emmy...awards”), and it uses a semicolon to join the first main clause (“In...respectively”) and the second main clause (“the achievement...EGOT”).

Choice B is incorrect because placing the semicolon after “awards” illogically separates the supplementary adverb “respectively” from the supplementary element it belongs to (“the Emmy...awards”) and attaches it to the following main clause (“the achievement...EGOT”), resulting in a confusing and ungrammatical sentence. Choice C is incorrect. The dash after “respectively” pairs with the dash after “entertainment” to close the supplementary element (“the Emmy...respectively”), so it can’t also serve to mark the boundary between the two main clauses (“In...respectively” and “the achievement...EGOT”). The result fails to mark that boundary with appropriate punctuation. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, the comma after “respectively” can’t be used in this way to join the first main clause (“In...respectively”) and the second main clause (“the achievement...EGOT”).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c4ba4894

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: c4ba4894

Seneca sculptor Marie Watt’s blanket art comes in a range of shapes and sizes. In 2004, Watt sewed strips of blankets together to craft a 10-by-13-inch _____ in 2014, she arranged folded blankets into two large stacks and then cast them in bronze, creating two curving 18-foot-tall blue-bronze pillars.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. sampler later,
- B. sampler;
- C. sampler,
- D. sampler, later,

ID: c4ba4894 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause (“In 2004...sampler”) and the second main clause (“in 2014...pillars”).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. The word “later” is an adverb and cannot be used to join two main clauses unless it is preceded by a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. The word “later” is an adverb and cannot be used to join two main clauses unless it is preceded by a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1a132d72

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 1a132d72

Bengali author Toru Dutt’s *A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields* (1876), a volume of English translations of French poems, _____ scholars’ understanding of the transnational and multilingual contexts in which Dutt lived and worked.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. has enhanced
- B. are enhancing
- C. have enhanced
- D. enhance

ID: 1a132d72 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb “has enhanced” agrees in number with the singular subject “*A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields*,” which is the title of a book of poems.

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “are enhancing” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “*A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields*.” Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “have enhanced” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “*A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields*.” Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb “enhance” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “*A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields*.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 86dbec3a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 86dbec3a

The relationship between genomes and epigenomes reveals how cells with identical DNA develop different _____ whereas the genome in each cell contains a complete DNA sequence, the epigenome consists of chemical compounds that determine which traits in the sequence will be expressed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. functions
- B. functions,
- C. functions and,
- D. functions:

ID: 86dbec3a Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of a colon within a sentence. In this choice, the colon correctly introduces the following explanation of the different functions of genomes and epigenomes.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("The relationship...functions" and "whereas...expressed") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses ("The relationship...functions" and "whereas...expressed"). Choice C is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Furthermore, "and" fails to indicate that what follows is an explanation of how cells with identical DNA develop different functions.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 47ac9b25

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 47ac9b25

Helical _____ widely understood to confer stability and efficiency in the locomotion of a variety of microscopic organisms—including bacteria, eukaryotic algae, and ciliates—bestows similar advantages, albeit via different propulsive modes, to larger oceanic macroplanktons, such as salps.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. swimming, is
- B. swimming is
- C. swimming has been
- D. swimming,

ID: 47ac9b25 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after “swimming” pairs with the dash after “ciliates” to offset the supplementary element (“widely...ciliates”) that interrupts the main clause of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect. Adding the verb “is” here creates an ungrammatical sentence structure with two main verbs (“is” and “bestows”) without appropriate punctuation and/or conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to offset the supplementary element with appropriate punctuation. Furthermore, adding the verb “is” here creates an ungrammatical sentence that has two finite verbs (“is” and “bestows”) without appropriate punctuation and/or conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to offset the supplementary element with appropriate punctuation. Furthermore, adding the verb “has been” here creates an ungrammatical sentence that has two finite verbs (“has been” and “bestows”) without appropriate punctuation and/or conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 20f98424

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 20f98424

Philosopher Peter Kivy was a leading figure in musical _____ evidenced by his belief that instead of evoking particular emotions, such as sadness or joy, compositions elicit a listener’s emotional response to the structure and artistry of the music itself, Kivy’s approach to the study of music was decidedly formalist.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. aesthetics as
- B. aesthetics and as
- C. aesthetics, as
- D. aesthetics. As

ID: 20f98424 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("Philosopher...aesthetics") and another ("As...formalist"). The long adverbial element "as evidenced...itself" modifies the content in the following clause to support the claim that Kivy’s approach was formalist.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("Philosopher...aesthetics" and "As...formalist") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can’t be used in this way to join sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 816aca32

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 816aca32

Instead of sleeping on soft pillows, ancient Egyptians slept on hard, elevated headrests, their design _____ airflow, protection from insects, and hairstyle maintenance over comfort.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. had prioritized
- B. was prioritizing
- C. prioritized
- D. prioritizing

ID: 816aca32 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle “prioritizing” is correctly used to form a supplementary element that modifies “their design,” describing what the headrests’ design prioritized.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. The finite past perfect verb “had prioritized” creates a second main clause in the sentence, and the comma after “headrests” can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. The finite past progressive verb “was prioritizing” creates a second main clause in the sentence, and the comma after “headrests” can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. The finite past tense verb “prioritized” creates a second main clause in the sentence, and the comma after “headrests” can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9a0acca7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 9a0acca7

When they were first discovered in Australia in 1798, duck-billed, beaver-tailed platypuses so defied categorization that one scientist assigned them the name *Ornithorhynchus paradoxus*: “paradoxical bird-snout.” The animal, which lays eggs but also nurses _____ young with milk, has since been classified as belonging to the monotremes group.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. they’re
- B. their
- C. its
- D. it’s

ID: 9a0acca7 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The singular possessive pronoun "its" agrees with the singular antecedent "the animal" and indicates that the "young" belong to it.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a pronoun-antecedent agreement error. "They’re" is a contraction of "they are," a plural pronoun and verb, but the antecedent "the animal" is singular. Also, we don’t need the extra verb "are" — we already have a main verb in this clause, so adding "are" would be confusing and ungrammatical. Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a pronoun-antecedent agreement error. "Their" is a plural pronoun, but the subject of the sentence is "the animal," a singular noun. Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a confusing and ungrammatical sentence. "It’s" is a contraction for "it is." We already have the verb "nurses" in this clause, so we shouldn’t add the verb "is."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID aba8fefc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: aba8fefc

Walt Whitman's *Leaves of Grass* first appeared in 1855 as a slim collection of twelve poems, but Whitman would revise and expand it substantially over the next four decades. These extensive _____ the addition of hundreds of new poems, the removal of some existing ones, and the insertion of prefatory material, reflected the poet’s evolving literary perspective and experience of the US Civil War.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. changes, including
- B. changes would include
- C. changes included
- D. changes, include

ID: aba8fefc Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle "including" is correctly used to form a supplementary element that interrupts the main clause "These extensive changes...reflected the poet’s evolving literary perspective and experience of the US Civil War." This supplementary element, offset by commas after "changes" and "material," provides examples of the changes Whitman made to *Leaves of Grass*.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite modal verb "would include" can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element within the main clause. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite past tense verb "included" can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element within the main clause. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present tense verb "include" can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element within the main clause.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5f57cc24

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 5f57cc24

The violins handmade in the seventeenth century by Italian craftsman Antonio Stradivari have been celebrated as some of the finest in the world. In close collaboration with musicians, Stradivari introduced changes to the shape of a traditional violin, flattening some of the instrument’s curves and making _____ lighter overall.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. those
- B. one
- C. them
- D. it

ID: 5f57cc24 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun–antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun “it” agrees in number with the singular antecedent “violin” and thus indicates that the traditional violin (and not its curves) was made lighter.

Choice A is incorrect because the plural pronoun “those” doesn’t agree in number with the singular antecedent “violin.” Choice B is incorrect because the singular pronoun “one” is ambiguous in this context; the resulting sentence leaves unclear what Stradivari made lighter. Choice C is incorrect because the plural pronoun “them” doesn’t agree in number with the singular antecedent “violin.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 28e2ac70

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 28e2ac70

Paintings by the renowned twentieth-century US _____ were featured in *Artist to Artist*, an exhibition at the Smithsonian Art Museum that paired the works of artists whose career trajectories intersected in meaningful ways.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. artists: Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock,
- B. artists Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock
- C. artists Thomas Hart Benton, and Jackson Pollock,
- D. artists, Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock

ID: 28e2ac70 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation around noun phrases. No punctuation is needed because the coordinated noun phrase "Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock" is a restrictive appositive, meaning that it provides essential identifying information about the noun phrase before it, "the renowned twentieth-century US artists."

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase "the renowned twentieth-century US artists" and the restrictive appositive "Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock." Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the sentence's subject ("paintings by the renowned twentieth-century US artists Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock") and the main verb ("were featured"). Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinated elements "Thomas Hart Benton" and "Jackson Pollock." Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the sentence's subject ("paintings by the renowned twentieth-century US artists Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock") and the main verb ("were featured"). Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase "the renowned twentieth-century US artists" and the restrictive appositive "Thomas Hart Benton and Jackson Pollock."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fac40584

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: fac40584

A study published by Rice University geoscientist Ming Tang in 2019 offers a new explanation for the origin of Earth’s _____ structures called arcs, towering ridges that form when a dense oceanic plate subducts under a less dense continental plate, melts in the mantle below, and then rises and bursts through the continental crust above.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. continents geological
- B. continents: geological
- C. continents; geological
- D. continents. Geological

ID: fac40584 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between the main clause (“A study...continents”) and the supplementary phrase (“geological...above”) and to introduce the following explanation of the origin of Earth’s continents.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause (“A study...continents”) and the supplementary phrase (“geological...above”) with appropriate punctuation. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“A study...continents”) and the supplementary phrase (“geological...above”). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, whereas a colon is conventionally used to introduce an element that explains or amplifies the information in the preceding clause, making it the better choice in this context. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “geological.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7526d556

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 7526d556

In the list “Adorable Things” from Sei Shōnagon’s *Pillow Book*, the author delights in baby sparrows, a face drawn on a melon, and a young courtier in ceremonial garb. So shrewd an observer is Shōnagon, a lady-in-waiting to Empress Teishi, that her book’s musings on tenth-century Japanese courtly life _____ readers a thousand years later.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. fascinate
- B. has fascinated
- C. fascinates
- D. is fascinating

ID: 7526d556 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "fascinate" agrees in number with the plural subject "musings."

Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb "has fascinated" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "musings." Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "fascinates" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "musings." Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "is fascinating" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "musings."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 441029e6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 441029e6

A group of ecologists led by Axel Mithöfer at the Max Planck Institute for Chemical Ecology in Germany examined the defensive responses of two varieties of the sweet potato _____ TN57, which is known for its insect resistance, and TN66, which is much more susceptible to pests.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. plant.
- B. plant;
- C. plant
- D. plant:

ID: 441029e6 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between the main clause (“A group...plant”) and the supplementary element (“TN57...pests”) and to introduce the following elaboration on the specific varieties of sweet potato plants that were examined.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “TN57.” Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“A group...plant”) and the supplementary element (“TN57...pests”). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, whereas a colon is conventionally used to introduce an element that explains or amplifies the information in the preceding clause. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause (“A group...plant”) and the supplementary element (“TN57...pests”) with appropriate punctuation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0b04806c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 0b04806c

During the American Civil War, Thomas Morris Chester braved the front lines as a war correspondent for the *Philadelphia Press*. Amplifying the voices and experiences of Black soldiers _____ of particular importance to Chester, who later became an activist and lawyer during the postwar Reconstruction period.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. were
- B. have been
- C. are
- D. was

ID: 0b04806c Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "was" agrees in number with the singular subject "amplifying." Gerunds such as "amplifying" are always singular.

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "were" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "amplifying." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have been" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "amplifying." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "are" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "amplifying."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6ab2cf5d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 6ab2cf5d

In biology, many initially disordered systems will naturally move toward greater order according to the principle of self-organization, a conceptual framework for pattern _____ biologists believe can be used to explain a range of organic phenomena, from population dynamics to the sociality of bees and ants.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. formation, that some
- B. formation. Some
- C. formation that some
- D. formation; some

ID: 6ab2cf5d Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use and punctuation of an integrated relative clause. In this choice, the relative pronoun “that” is used to create an integrated relative clause that modifies the preceding noun phrase “a conceptual framework for pattern formation.” No punctuation is necessary between the noun phrase and the relative clause because the relative clause is supplying essential information about the framework.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase (“a conceptual...formation”) and the integrated relative clause beginning with “that.” Choice B is incorrect because it results in a confusing and ungrammatical sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. A semicolon is used to join two main clauses or items in a complex series, and what follows “formation” is neither of these.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f740bc16

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: f740bc16

On April 5, 1977, Kitty Cone and 150 other disability rights activists entered a San Francisco federal building. After pleading for years—to no effect—for the passage of key antidiscrimination legislation, _____ until their demands were addressed. Finally, on April 28, the legislation was signed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. pressure on lawmakers increased when the activists staged a sit-in protest
- B. a sit-in protest staged by the activists increased pressure on lawmakers
- C. lawmakers came under increased pressure when the activists staged a sit-in protest
- D. the activists increased pressure on lawmakers by staging a sit-in protest

ID: f740bc16 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “the activists” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “after...legislation.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the activists—and not another noun in the sentence—were pleading for the passage of antidiscrimination legislation.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “pressure on lawmakers” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “pressure” was pleading for the passage of antidiscrimination legislation. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “a sit-in protest” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “protest” was pleading for the passage of antidiscrimination legislation. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “lawmakers” immediately after the modifying phrase suggests that “lawmakers” were pleading for the passage of antidiscrimination legislation. While it’s possible for lawmakers to plead for the passage of legislation, the context strongly suggests that it’s the activists who pleaded for years for the passage of antidiscrimination legislation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8f3cd34b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 8f3cd34b

On July 23, 1854, a clipper ship called the *Flying Cloud* entered San Francisco ____ left New York Harbor under the guidance of Captain Josiah Perkins Creesy and his wife, navigator Eleanor Creesy, a mere 89 days and 8 hours earlier, the celebrated ship set a record that would stand for 135 years.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Bay and having
- B. Bay. Having
- C. Bay, having
- D. Bay having

ID: 8f3cd34b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period after “Bay” is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“On...Bay”) and another sentence that begins with a supplementary phrase (“Having...years”). Here, the supplementary phrase beginning with “having” modifies the subject of the second sentence, “the celebrated ship.”

Choice A is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences (“On...Bay” and “having...years”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7b6aa781

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 7b6aa781

In modern plays, actors typically won't acknowledge the _____ do so breaks the fourth wall, a metaphorical barrier between actors and audiences that allows viewers to suspend the knowledge that they're watching a staged performance.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. audience. As to
- B. audience to
- C. audience. To
- D. audience, to

ID: 7b6aa781 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("In modern...audience") and another ("To do...performance").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "as." Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("In modern...audience" and "To do...performance") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ebae4298

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: ebae4298

Along with carbon dioxide concentration and temperature, light intensity affects the chemical reaction rate of _____ as light intensity increases, so does the rate at which the reactants (water and carbon dioxide) are converted into their products (glucose and oxygen).

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. photosynthesis and
- B. photosynthesis,
- C. photosynthesis:
- D. photosynthesis

ID: ebae4298 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation in a sentence. In this choice, a colon is correctly used to mark the boundary between one main clause ("Along with...photosynthesis") and another main clause ("as light...oxygen") and to introduce the following explanation of how light intensity affects photosynthesis.

Choice A is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it's conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction ("and"). Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a coordinating conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses ("Along with...photosynthesis" and "as light...oxygen"). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("Along with...photosynthesis" and "as light...oxygen") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 77c8d3b5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 77c8d3b5

Roughly 300 nights a year, when the cold air descending from the Andes Mountains meets the warm air rising from Venezuela’s coastal Lake Maracaibo, the result is a spectacular lightning storm, its strikes so bright, so localized, and so _____ that it has become known as “Maracaibo’s Lighthouse.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. dependable:
- B. dependable;
- C. dependable
- D. dependable,

ID: 77c8d3b5 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of an integrated relative clause. No punctuation is needed before the relative clause beginning with "that" because the content of the relative clause ("that...Lighthouse") is integral to the meaning of the coordinated adjectival phrase ("so bright, so localized, and so dependable") that it modifies.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinated adjectival phrase ("so bright...dependable") and the integrated relative clause that modifies it. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinated adjectival phrase ("so bright...dependable") and the integrated relative clause that modifies it. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinated adjectival phrase ("so bright...dependable") and the integrated relative clause that modifies it.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 05b6463e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 05b6463e

During a 2022 expedition led by research zoologist Andrea Quattrini, scientists discovered a new species of black coral off the coast of Puerto Rico. Like other black corals, the newly discovered species, which they named *Aphanipathes puertoricensis*, has coiled branching structures that _____ it survive in the deep sea.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. has helped
- B. helps
- C. helping
- D. help

ID: 05b6463e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The plural verb “help” provides the relative clause beginning with “that” with a finite verb and agrees in number with the plural subject “coiled branching structures.”

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb “has helped” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “coiled branching structures.” Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb “helps” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “coiled branching structures.” Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “helping” doesn’t supply a finite verb to the relative clause beginning with “that.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a8290552

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: a8290552

In a recent analysis of lyrical trends in 350,000 songs, researchers cite increases in certain measures, such as the ratio of choruses to verses, as evidence music lyrics are becoming more repetitive. For instance, from 1970 to 2020, _____ chorus-to-verse ratios trended similarly, with each genre’s data indicating that relative to the number of unique verses, the number of repeated choruses in songs increased.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. rocks and raps
- B. rock’s and rap’s
- C. rocks and rap’s
- D. rock and rap’s

ID: a8290552 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive nouns. The singular possessive nouns "rock’s" and "rap’s" correctly indicate that the chorus-to-verse ratios belong to the genres of rock and rap.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive nouns "rock’s" and "rap’s," not the plural nouns "rocks" and "raps." Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "rock’s," not the plural noun "rocks." Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "rock’s," not the singular noun "rock." This choice incorrectly suggests that there was a single chorus-to-verse ratio for rock and rap together, whereas the ratio was calculated for each genre individually.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4a0d784a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 4a0d784a

Recordings of electrical activity in the brain, _____ increased activity in brain areas associated with suppressing motor functions.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. electrograms show that while responding to hypothetical match scenarios, the most highly skilled soccer players have
- B. the most highly skilled soccer players responding to hypothetical match scenarios have electrograms that show
- C. responses to hypothetical match scenarios show that the most highly skilled soccer players have electrograms with
- D. hypothetical match scenario responses show that the most highly skilled soccer players captured in electrograms have

ID: 4a0d784a Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun “electrograms” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “recordings of electrical activity in the brain.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that electrograms—and not other nouns or noun phrases in the sentence—are recordings of electrical activity in the brain.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the most highly skilled soccer players” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the players are recordings of electrical activity in the brain. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “responses to hypothetical match scenarios” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that these responses are recordings of electrical activity in the brain. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “hypothetical match scenario responses” immediately after the opening phrase illogically suggests that these responses are recordings of electrical activity in the brain.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3cc45d15

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 3cc45d15

Featuring works by the photographers Lola Álvarez Bravo and Else “Yva” Neuländer-Simon, the 2021 exhibition *The New Woman Behind the Camera* set out to provide a wide-ranging overview of photography by women in the 1920s through the _____ given the collection’s breadth of more than 120 photos, its efforts were largely successful.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. 1950s, and
- B. 1950s and
- C. 1950s
- D. 1950s,

ID: 3cc45d15 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction "and" to join the first main clause ("Featuring...1950s") and the second main clause ("given...successful").

Choice B is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 51989cbd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 51989cbd

Wanting to celebrate the 100th anniversary of the Alaska Purchase, _____ up with a motto that best captured the state’s unique character. The commission selected “North to the Future,” submitted by Juneau journalist Richard Peter, as its winning entry.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. a contest sponsored by the Alaska Centennial Commission would award \$300 to an individual who came
- B. an award of \$300 would go to an individual in a contest sponsored by the Alaska Centennial Commission for coming
- C. \$300 would be awarded to an individual by the Alaska Centennial Commission in a contest for coming
- D. the Alaska Centennial Commission sponsored a contest that would award \$300 to an individual who came

ID: 51989cbd Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "the Alaska Centennial Commission" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "wanting... Purchase." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the Alaska Centennial Commission—and not another noun in the sentence—wanted to celebrate the 100th anniversary of the Alaska Purchase.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "a contest" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the contest wanted to celebrate the 100th anniversary of the Alaska Purchase. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "an award of \$300" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the award of \$300 wanted to celebrate the 100th anniversary of the Alaska Purchase. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "\$300" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the \$300 wanted to celebrate the 100th anniversary of the Alaska Purchase.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ac74cb93

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: ac74cb93

Water in the North Atlantic Ocean is pushed eastward by powerful winds, but the rotation of Earth and interference from nearby landmasses together cause _____ to swirl into a massive, churning whirlpool—also called the North Atlantic Gyre—that spins clockwise.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. these
- B. those
- C. them
- D. it

ID: ac74cb93 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun "it" agrees in number with the singular antecedent "water" and clearly indicates that the water swirls into a whirlpool.

Choice A is incorrect. The plural pronoun "these" neither agrees in number with the singular antecedent "water" nor clearly indicates that the water—not another plural noun in the sentence, such as "landmasses" or "winds"—swirls into a whirlpool. Choice B is incorrect. The plural pronoun "those" neither agrees in number with the singular antecedent "water" nor clearly indicates that the water—not another plural noun in the sentence, such as "landmasses" or "winds"—swirls into a whirlpool. Choice C is incorrect. The plural pronoun "them" neither agrees in number with the singular antecedent "water" nor clearly indicates that the water—not another plural noun in the sentence, such as "landmasses" or "winds"—swirls into a whirlpool.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e1c72c3d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: e1c72c3d

Nuhād al-Ḥaddād, known as Fairuz, was one of the most beloved Lebanese singers of the twentieth century. Her broad singing repertoire—which included traditional forms, such as the Arabic *qasida* and *maqam*, alongside modern pop and jazz styles—lent Fairuz a timeless, cross-generational appeal, _____ her the moniker “the soul of Lebanon.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. earned
- B. had earned
- C. earning
- D. earn

ID: e1c72c3d Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The word "earning" is being used to introduce an additional modifying phrase, which describes how Fairuz’s repertoire lent her cross-generational appeal. When a verb ends in -ing and doesn’t have a helper verb like "is" before it, it can be used to modify a noun or verb. This is appropriate here.

Choice A is incorrect. The underlined verb is being used to introduce additional descriptive information, which is set off from the rest of the sentence by a comma. Because there is no subject here, a finite form of the verb (like "earned") creates an error. We need another form of the verb that doesn’t require a subject and can introduce descriptive information. Choice B is incorrect. The underlined verb is being used to introduce additional descriptive information, which is set off from the rest of the sentence by a comma. Because there is no subject here, a finite form of the verb (like "had earned") creates an error. We need another form of the verb that doesn’t require a subject and can introduce descriptive information. Choice D is incorrect. The underlined verb is being used to introduce additional descriptive information, which is set off from the rest of the sentence by a comma. Because there is no subject here, a finite form of the verb (like "earn") creates an error. We need another form of the verb that doesn’t require a subject and can introduce descriptive information.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 295b3027

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 295b3027

With the development of new technologies that use natural resources more efficiently, the overall consumption of those resources might be expected to decrease. Economists have observed that improvements in efficiency often correlate negatively with resource ____ efficiency gains, lowering the cost of use, may increase demand to the extent that resource consumption ultimately rises.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. conservation, though,
- B. conservation; though
- C. conservation, though;
- D. conservation, though

ID: 295b3027 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb "though" from the preceding main clause ("Economists...conservation") and uses a semicolon to join the next main clause ("efficiency gains...rises") to the rest of the sentence. Further, placing the semicolon after "though" indicates that the information in the preceding main clause ("improvements in efficiency often correlate negatively with resource conservation") is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (resource consumption would be expected to decrease with the development of new, more efficient technologies).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Commas can't be used in this way to punctuate a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the two main clauses ("Economists...though" and "efficiency gains....rises") with appropriate punctuation. Moreover, placing the semicolon after "conservation" illogically indicates that the information in the next clause (gains in efficiency may lead to an increase in resource consumption) is contrary to the information in the previous clause ("improvements in efficiency often correlate negatively with resource conservation"). Choice D is incorrect because placing a comma after "conservation" illogically indicates that the information in the next clause (gains in efficiency may lead to an increase in resource consumption) is contrary to the information in the previous clause ("improvements in efficiency often correlate negatively with resource conservation").

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5d4c1450

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 5d4c1450

In a US national election, one might expect major-party campaigns to focus on the most populous states. However, if polls and past voting data suggest that the outcome in a given state is a foregone conclusion, a campaign will not invest its resources there. Ultimately, a state’s voting record and polling data, not its population size, _____ its importance to campaigns.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. determines
- B. determining
- C. has determined
- D. determine

ID: 5d4c1450 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms in a sentence. The plural verb “determine” supplies the main clause with a finite main verb and agrees in number with the plural subject “a state’s voting record and polling data.”

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb “determines” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “a state’s voting record and polling data.” Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “determining” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite plural verb. Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb “has determined” doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject “a state’s voting record and polling data.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID be20e3ba

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: be20e3ba

African American Percy Julian was a scientist and entrepreneur whose work helped people around the world to see. Named in 1999 as one of the greatest achievements by a US chemist in the past hundred years, _____ led to the first mass-produced treatment for glaucoma.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Julian synthesized the alkaloid physostigmine in 1935; it
- B. in 1935 Julian synthesized the alkaloid physostigmine, which
- C. Julian’s 1935 synthesis of the alkaloid physostigmine
- D. the alkaloid physostigmine was synthesized by Julian in 1935 and

ID: be20e3ba Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “Julian’s 1935 synthesis” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “named...years.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that Julian’s 1935 synthesis of the alkaloid physostigmine—and not another noun in the sentence—was named in 1999 as one of the greatest achievements by a US chemist in the past hundred years.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun “Julian” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that Julian himself was named as one of the greatest achievements by a US chemist in the past hundred years. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the prepositional phrase “in 1935” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically and confusingly suggests that “in 1935” was named as one of the greatest achievements by a US chemist in the past hundred years. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the alkaloid physostigmine” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically and confusingly suggests that the alkaloid physostigmine itself (not the synthesis of it) was named as one of the greatest achievements by a US chemist in the past hundred years.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 73694f97

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 73694f97

Joshua Hinson, director of the language revitalization program of the Chickasaw Nation in Oklahoma, helped produce the world’s first Indigenous-language instructional app, Chickasaw _____ Chickasaw TV, in 2010; and a Rosetta Stone language course in Chickasaw, in 2015.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Basic; in 2009, an online television network;
- B. Basic; in 2009, an online television network,
- C. Basic, in 2009; an online television network,
- D. Basic, in 2009, an online television network,

ID: 73694f97 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after “2009” is conventionally used to separate the first item (“the world’s...2009”) and the second item (“an online...2010”) in the series of things that Hinson helped create. Further, the comma after “Basic” correctly pairs with the comma after “app,” and the comma after “network” correctly pairs with the comma after “TV” to set off the supplemental elements (“Chickasaw Basic” and “Chickasaw TV”) that provide the names of the app and the TV network, respectively. Altogether, the punctuation in this choice results in a sentence that clearly indicates that Hinson helped make a language app in 2009, an online TV network in 2010, and a language course in 2015.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to punctuate the complex series in a way that makes clear that Hinson helped make a language app in 2009, an online TV network in 2010, and a language course in 2015. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to punctuate the complex series in a way that makes clear that Hinson helped make a language app in 2009, an online TV network in 2010, and a language course in 2015. Choice D is incorrect because the comma after “2009” doesn’t match the semicolon used to separate the second and third items in the complex series.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2a41f78a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 2a41f78a

Alberto Gabriele, author of *Reading Popular Culture in Victorian Print*, tracks the transnational dissemination of works by author Mary Elizabeth Braddon via the magazine _____ from 1866 to 1899 and distributed throughout the Australian cities of Melbourne, Adelaide, and Hobart; the continental European cities of Brussels, Paris, and Turin; and cities in Turkey, India, and Jamaica, this magazine helped make Braddon’s serialized novels globally available.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. *Belgravia*; published
- B. *Belgravia*. Published
- C. *Belgravia* published
- D. *Belgravia*, published

ID: 2a41f78a Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between the first sentence (“Alberto...*Belgravia*”) and the second (“Published...available”). The participial phrase beginning with “published” contains a complex series punctuated with commas and semicolons (“the Australian cities of Melbourne, Adelaide, and Hobart; the continental European cities of Brussels, Paris, and Turin; and cities in Turkey, India, and Jamaica”), and this participial phrase modifies the subject of the second sentence, “this magazine.”

Choice A is incorrect. Using a semicolon to join two main clauses in this way in combination with the semicolons that separate the items in the complex series would result in an ambiguous and confusing sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. With no punctuation after “*Belgravia*,” the participial phrase “published...Jamaica” reads as an integrated modifier within the noun phrase “the magazine *Belgravia*,” and the first main clause (“Alberto...Jamaica”) is then joined to a second main clause (“this...available”) using only a comma. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 12ff7648

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 12ff7648

Po’Pay was a Tewa leader from Ohkay Owingeh, a pueblo located about twenty-five miles north of present-day Santa Fe, New Mexico. He was instrumental in organizing the Pueblo Revolt of _____ as a result of his leadership, the Spanish colonizers were expelled from the region for a time.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. 1680
- B. 1680 and
- C. 1680,
- D. 1680, and

ID: 12ff7648 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction “and” to join the first main clause (“He...1680”) and the second main clause (“as...time”).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c92f9518

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: c92f9518

In his *Naturalis historia*, Pliny the Elder praised Hipparchus’s star catalog, a second-century BCE list of roughly 850 different stars’ celestial positions. For centuries, scholars dreamed about locating a copy of this legendary lost _____ fantasy (partially) became reality in 2022, when researchers uncovered traces of the star catalog on a palimpsest, a reused parchment.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. work, that
- B. work that
- C. work. That
- D. work and that

ID: c92f9518 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("For...work") and another ("That...parchment").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("For...work" and "that...parchment") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can’t be used in this way to join sentences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dd53de12

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: dd53de12

The forty-seven geothermal springs of Arkansas’ Hot Springs National Park are sourced via a process known as natural groundwater recharge, in which rainwater percolates downward through the earth—in this case, the porous rocks of the hills around Hot _____ collect in a subterranean basin.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Springs to
- B. Springs: to
- C. Springs—to
- D. Springs, to

ID: dd53de12 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The dash after “Springs” pairs with the dash after “earth” to separate the supplementary element “in this case, the porous rocks of the hills around Hot Springs” from the rest of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because a colon can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 31cca369

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 31cca369

The 1977 play *And the Soul Shall Dance* depicts two Japanese American farming families in Depression-era Southern California. Critics have noted the way pioneering _____ compares the experiences of *issei* (Japanese nationals who emigrated to America) and *nisei* (their American-born children).

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. playwright, Wakako Yamauchi,
- B. playwright, Wakako Yamauchi
- C. playwright Wakako Yamauchi,
- D. playwright Wakako Yamauchi

ID: 31cca369 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed to set off the proper noun "Wakako Yamauchi" from the title that describes Yamauchi, "pioneering playwright." Because "Wakako Yamauchi" is essential information identifying the "pioneering playwright," no punctuation is necessary.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed before or after the proper noun "Wakako Yamauchi." Setting the playwright's name off with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn't the case. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the title "pioneering playwright" and the proper noun "Wakako Yamauchi." Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the proper noun "Wakako Yamauchi" and the verb "compares."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e099834c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: e099834c

Known as Earth’s “living skin,” biocrusts are thin layers of soil held together by surface-dwelling microorganisms such as fungi, lichens, and cyanobacteria. Fortifying soil in arid ecosystems against erosion, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. a recent study’s estimate is that these crusts reduce global dust emissions by 60 percent each year.
- B. an estimated 60 percent reduction in global dust emissions each year is due to these crusts, according to a recent study.
- C. these crusts reduce global dust emissions by an estimated 60 percent each year, according to a recent study.
- D. a recent study has estimated that these crusts reduce global dust emissions by 60 percent each year.

ID: e099834c Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The subject of the modifier "fortifying soil in arid ecosystems against erosion" is "biocrusts." Subject-modifier placement requires a modifier and its subject to be next to each other, so "biocrusts" or some variant meaning "biocrusts" (in this case, "these crusts") must begin the missing clause.

Choice A is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The subject of the modifier "fortifying soil in arid ecosystems against erosion" is "biocrusts," not "a recent study’s estimate." Choice B is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The subject of the modifier "fortifying soil in arid ecosystems against erosion" is "biocrusts," not "an estimated 60 percent reduction." Choice D is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The subject of the modifier "fortifying soil in arid ecosystems against erosion" is "biocrusts," not "a recent study."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cef3e13b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: cef3e13b

Supported by biochemical analyses of over 2,000 skeletons from the Middle Ages, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. vegetables and grains were, a 2022 study found, the primary components of early medieval rulers’ diets.
- B. early medieval rulers’ diets were found, in a 2022 study, to have primarily consisted of vegetables and grains.
- C. the primary components of early medieval rulers’ diets were vegetables and grains, according to a 2022 study.
- D. findings from a 2022 study suggested that vegetables and grains were the primary components of early medieval rulers’ diets.

ID: cef3e13b Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "findings from a 2022 study" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "supported...Ages." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the findings—and not another noun in the sentence—are supported by the biochemical analyses.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "vegetables and grains" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that vegetables and grains are supported by biochemical analyses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "early medieval rulers’ diets" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the rulers’ diets are supported by biochemical analyses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "the primary components" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the primary components are supported by biochemical analyses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID af32f69e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: af32f69e

Most of the ice found on Earth is ice Ih, distinguished by a crystalline structure in which molecules form a hexagonal pattern. Amorphous ice, on the other hand, constitutes most of the ice in the ultrafrigid environment of outer space. Defined by a disorganized molecular structure, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. ice Ih contains crystals, whereas amorphous ice, which lacks the thermal energy to form them, does not.
- B. amorphous ice lacks the thermal energy to form the crystals found in ice Ih.
- C. the lack of thermal energy in amorphous ice explains its inability to form the crystals found in ice Ih.
- D. ice Ih differs from amorphous ice in that it possesses the thermal energy to form crystals.

ID: af32f69e Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “amorphous ice” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “defined...structure.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that amorphous ice—and not another noun in the sentence—is being described as having a disorganized molecular structure.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun “ice Ih” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that ice Ih has a disorganized molecular structure, whereas ice Ih is previously described as having molecules that form a hexagonal pattern. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the lack of thermal energy” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the lack of thermal energy has a disorganized molecular structure. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of “ice Ih” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that ice Ih has a disorganized molecular structure, whereas ice Ih is previously described as having molecules that form a hexagonal pattern.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 76407481

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 76407481

The poem *Beowulf* begins with the word “hwæt,” which is an Old English _____ as “hark!” or “listen!” in some versions, the word was playfully rendered as “bro!” by Maria Dahvana Headley in her 2020 translation of the poem.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. exclamation, translated
- B. exclamation and translated
- C. exclamation translated
- D. exclamation. Translated

ID: 76407481 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("The poem...exclamation") and another sentence that begins with a supplementary element ("Translated...poem"). The supplementary element "translated as 'hark!' or 'listen!' in some versions" modifies the subject of the second sentence, "the word" (referring to hwæt).

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice after "exclamation." A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice B is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice after "versions." A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0ed8e5e6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 0ed8e5e6

In assessing the films of Japanese director Akira Kurosawa, _____ have missed his equally deep engagement with Japanese artistic traditions such as Noh theater.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. many critics have focused on Kurosawa’s use of Western literary sources but
- B. Kurosawa’s use of Western literary sources has been the focus of many critics, who
- C. there are many critics who have focused on Kurosawa’s use of Western literary sources, but they
- D. the focus of many critics has been on Kurosawa’s use of Western literary sources; they

ID: 0ed8e5e6 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “many critics” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “in assessing...Kurosawa.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that it is the critics—and not another noun in the sentence—who assess Kurosawa’s films.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “Kurosawa’s...sources” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that his use of Western literary sources is what assesses Kurosawa’s films. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the function word “there” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that “there” is what assesses Kurosawa’s films. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the focus...critics” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the critics’ focus is what assesses Kurosawa’s films.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID f452aa39

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: f452aa39

Despite being cheap, versatile, and easy to produce, _____ they are made from nonrenewable petroleum, and most do not biodegrade in landfills.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. there are two problems associated with commercial plastics:
- B. two problems are associated with commercial plastics:
- C. commercial plastics’ two associated problems are that
- D. commercial plastics have two associated problems:

ID: f452aa39 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice ensures that the modifying phrase “despite being cheap, versatile, and easy to produce” appears immediately before the noun it modifies, “commercial plastics,” clearly establishing that the commercial plastics—and not another noun in the sentence—are being described as cheap, versatile, and easy to produce.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the function word “there” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically and confusingly suggests that “there” is cheap, versatile, and easy to produce. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun “two problems” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “problems” are cheap, versatile, and easy to produce. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “commercial plastics’ two associated problems” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “problems” are cheap, versatile, and easy to produce.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 539274e1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 539274e1

When a given term—“self-fulfilling prophecies” and “role models” are two well-known examples—is generally accepted and frequently used, _____ susceptible to obliteration by incorporation (OBI). In cases of OBI, widely used terms are rarely, if at all, attributed to the individuals who coined them.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. they often become
- B. these often become
- C. this often becomes
- D. it often becomes

ID: 539274e1 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun “it” agrees in number with the singular antecedent “a given term” and clearly indicates that the term becomes susceptible to obliteration by incorporation.

Choice A is incorrect because the plural pronoun “they” neither agrees in number with the singular antecedent “a given term” nor clearly indicates that the given term—not another plural noun in the sentence, such as “examples”—becomes susceptible to obliteration by incorporation. Choice B is incorrect because the plural pronoun “these” neither agrees in number with the singular antecedent “a given term” nor clearly indicates that the given term—not another plural noun in the sentence, such as “examples”—becomes susceptible to obliteration by incorporation. Choice C is incorrect because the singular pronoun “this” is ambiguous in this context, leaving unclear what exactly becomes susceptible to obliteration by incorporation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 496152ac

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 496152ac

In many of her landscape paintings from the 1970s and 1980s, Lebanese American artist Etel Adnan worked to capture the essence of California’s fog-shrouded Mount Tamalpais region through abstraction, using splotches of color to represent the area’s features. Interestingly, the triangle representing the mountain itself _____ among the few defined figures in her paintings.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. are
- B. have been
- C. were
- D. is

ID: 496152ac Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject–verb agreement. The singular verb “is” agrees in number with the singular subject “the triangle.”

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb “are” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the triangle.” Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “have been” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the triangle.” Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “were” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the triangle.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 025e138d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 025e138d

Jetties—long, narrow structures that extend from a landmass into the water—are often constructed to protect coastlines from erosion. Jetties can sometimes have the opposite _____ obstructing the natural flow of sand along the shore can lead to increased erosion in some areas.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. effect, though;
- B. effect, though
- C. effect; though
- D. effect, though,

ID: 025e138d Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb "though" from the preceding main clause ("Jetties can sometimes have the opposite effect") and uses a semicolon to join the next main clause ("obstructing...areas") to the rest of the sentence. Further, placing the semicolon after "though" logically indicates that the information earlier in this sentence (that jetties can sometimes cause erosion) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (that jetties are often constructed for the purpose of protecting coastlines from erosion).

Choice B is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the two main clauses with appropriate punctuation. With "though...areas" functioning as a subordinate clause following the comma, this choice illogically indicates that the following information (that obstructing the natural flow of sand along the shore can sometimes lead to erosion) is contrary to the information earlier in the sentence (that jetties can sometimes cause erosion). Instead, the information following "though" supports the previous claim about the erosive effects of jetties. Choice C is incorrect because it's not conventional to use a semicolon in this way to separate a main clause from a dependent clause. Further, it illogically indicates that the following information (that obstructing the natural flow of sand along the shore can sometimes lead to erosion) is contrary to the information earlier in the sentence (that jetties can sometimes cause erosion). Instead, the information following "though" supports the previous claim about the erosive effects of jetties. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Commas can't be used in this way to set off a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1b2276bd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 1b2276bd

In premodern Europe, one could sail from the east coast of England to the Netherlands or France faster than one could travel by land to England’s capital, London. In that era, historian Michael Pye argues in his 2015 book *The Edge of the World: A Cultural History of the North Sea and the Transformation of Europe*, the North Sea did more to link the various peoples, cultures, and economies on _____ shores than to divide them.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. its
- B. it’s
- C. they’re
- D. their

ID: 1b2276bd Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive determiners. The singular possessive determiner “its” agrees in number with the singular noun “the North Sea” and thus indicates that the shores are those of the North Sea.

Choice B is incorrect because “it’s” is the contraction for “it is” or “it has,” not a possessive determiner. Choice C is incorrect because “they’re” is the contraction for “they are,” not a possessive determiner. Choice D is incorrect because the plural possessive determiner “their” doesn’t agree in number with the singular noun “the North Sea.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fbfd1f7b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: fbfd1f7b

The Arctic-Alpine Botanic Garden in Norway and the Jardim Botânico of Rio de Janeiro in Brazil are two of many botanical gardens around the world dedicated to growing diverse plant _____ fostering scientific research; and educating the public about plant conservation.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. species, both native and nonnative,
- B. species, both native and nonnative;
- C. species; both native and nonnative,
- D. species both native and nonnative,

ID: fbfd1f7b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a complex series (a series including internal punctuation). The semicolon after “nonnative” is correctly used to separate the first item (“growing diverse plant species, both native and nonnative”) and the second item (“fostering scientific research”) in the series of things that botanical gardens are dedicated to. Further, the comma after “species” is correctly used to separate the noun phrase “diverse plant species” and the supplementary phrase “both native and nonnative” that modifies it.

Choice A is incorrect because a comma (specifically, the comma after “nonnative”) can’t be used in this way to separate items in a complex series. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to separate the noun phrase “diverse plant species” and the supplementary phrase “both native and nonnative” that modifies it. Further, a comma can’t be used in this way to separate items in a complex series. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the noun phrase “diverse plant species” and the supplementary phrase “both native and nonnative” that modifies it. Further, a comma can’t be used in this way to separate items in a complex series.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 89ea1dd0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 89ea1dd0

On sunny days, dark rooftops absorb solar energy and convert it to unwanted heat, raising the surrounding air _____ a light-colored covering to an existing dark roof, either by attaching prefabricated reflective sheets or spraying on a paint-like coating, helps combat this effect.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. temperature; by adding
- B. temperature, adding
- C. temperature. Adding
- D. temperature by adding

ID: 89ea1dd0 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between the first sentence (“On...temperature”) and the second sentence (“Adding...effect”). The gerund phrase beginning with “adding” is the subject of the second sentence, and the verb phrase “helps combat this effect” describes what adding a light-colored covering can do.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the sentence “On...temperature” and the supplementary phrases that follow. Doing so leaves the verb phrase “helps combat” without a subject and thus results in a grammatically unconventional sentence. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a confusing and illogical sentence that suggests that adding a light-colored covering to an existing dark roof raises the temperature of the surrounding air. Furthermore, it creates ambiguity by leaving the verb phrase “helps combat” without a subject (so it isn’t clear what helps combat the effect).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 734d6377

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 734d6377

The radial velocity method, a means of indirect planetary discovery, has detected previously unknown exoplanets at vast distances from _____ the gas giant 55 Cancri d; at 60 light-years away, the Neptune-like planet Pi Mensae d; and, as of 2023, over 1,000 other exoplanets that are too far away and dim to be observed directly.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Earth at 41 light-years away:
- B. Earth: at 41 light-years away,
- C. Earth, at 41 light-years away,
- D. Earth at 41 light-years away,

ID: 734d6377 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. In this choice, a colon is correctly used after the main clause (“The radial...Earth”) to introduce the complex series that follows. Furthermore, the comma after “away” is conventionally used to separate the supplementary phrase “at 41 light-years away” from the noun phrase it describes (“the gas giant 55 Cancri d”), the first item in the series.

Choice A is incorrect because placing a colon after “away” illogically separates the supplementary phrase “at 41 light-years away” from the noun phrase it describes (“the gas giant 55 Cancri d”) and attaches it to the main clause (“The radial...away”), resulting in a confusing and illogical sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a comma cannot be used in this way to mark the boundary between a main clause (“The radial...Earth”) and a complex series. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause (“The radial...Earth”) and the complex series that follows with appropriate punctuation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 74b203cd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 74b203cd

That the expansionist appetites of colonial European powers had their sights set on his country was evident to Siam’s King _____ deterring those ambitions through international diplomacy and domestic reform was perhaps his foremost achievement. Though his reign ended roughly twenty years before Siam became known by its modern name of Thailand, King Chulalongkorn is often credited with ushering the nation into modernity.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Chulalongkorn;
- B. Chulalongkorn that
- C. Chulalongkorn,
- D. Chulalongkorn

ID: 74b203cd Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause (“That...Chulalongkorn”) and the second main clause (“detering...achievement”).

Choice B is incorrect. Using the conjunction “that” to introduce “detering...achievement” as a subordinate element of the main clause (“That...Chulalongkorn”) results in a confusing and ungrammatical sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6bfc4b14

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 6bfc4b14

The Progressive Era in the United States witnessed the rise of numerous Black women’s clubs, local organizations that advocated for racial and gender equality. Among the clubs’ leaders _____ Josephine St. Pierre Ruffin, founder of the Women’s Era Club of Boston.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. was
- B. were
- C. are
- D. have been

ID: 6bfc4b14 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested here is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb “was” agrees in number with the singular subject “Josephine St. Pierre Ruffin.”

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “were” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “Josephine St. Pierre Ruffin.” Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “are” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “Josephine St. Pierre Ruffin.” Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb “have been” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “Josephine St. Pierre Ruffin.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cab09799

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: cab09799

After immigrating from Mexico and obtaining U.S. citizenship, Octaviano Ambrosio Larrazolo entered politics, earning a reputation for being a fervent defender of Hispanic civil rights. In 1919 Larrazolo was elected governor of _____. In 1928 he became the nation’s first Hispanic U.S. Senator.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. New Mexico and
- B. New Mexico,
- C. New Mexico, and
- D. New Mexico

ID: cab09799 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma and the coordinating conjunction "and" to join the first main clause ("In 1919 Larrazolo was elected governor of New Mexico") and the second main clause ("in 1928 he became the nation’s first Hispanic US Senator").

Choice A is incorrect because when coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 790a532c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 790a532c

Solarpunk is an art movement that imagines renewable energy–powered technology infused complementarily into nature. In Paolo Bacigalupi’s solarpunk short story “Efficiency,” an artificial intelligence that absorbs sustainable energies, redistributing them through intricate networks of weights and generators, _____ Chicago’s energy grid.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. have been powering
- B. power
- C. powers
- D. are powering

ID: 790a532c Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "powers" agrees in number with the singular subject "an artificial intelligence."

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "have been powering" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "an artificial intelligence." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "power" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "an artificial intelligence." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "are powering" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "an artificial intelligence."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4ab573cb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 4ab573cb

Rabinal Achí is a precolonial Maya dance drama performed annually in Rabinal, a town in the Guatemalan highlands. Based on events that occurred when Rabinal was a city-state ruled by a king, _____ had once been an ally of the king but was later captured while leading an invading force against him.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. *Rabinal Achí* tells the story of K'iche' Achí, a military leader who
- B. K'iche' Achí, the military leader in the story of *Rabinal Achí*,
- C. the military leader whose story is told in *Rabinal Achí*, K'iche' Achí,
- D. there was a military leader, K'iche' Achí, who in *Rabinal Achí*

ID: 4ab573cb Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma.

Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma. Choice D is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7d31be24

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 7d31be24

Using natural debris, such as dried _____ such as plastic bags; and more traditional art supplies, such as tree glue, Ghanaian artist Ed Franklin Gavua creates his striking Yiiiikakaii African masks, which he hopes can help viewers rethink how waste is used in their communities.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. leaves, man-made trash:
- B. leaves; man-made trash,
- C. leaves, man-made trash,
- D. leaves; man-made trash;

ID: 7d31be24 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of elements in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after "leaves" is conventionally used to separate the first item ("natural debris, such as dried leaves") and the second item ("man-made trash, such as plastic bags") in the series of materials used by Gavua. Further, the comma after "trash" correctly separates the noun phrase "man-made trash" from the supplementary phrase ("such as plastic bags") that describes it.

Choice A is incorrect because a comma after "leaves" doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second and third items in the series ("man-made...bags" and "and...glue"). Additionally, it’s not conventional to use a colon in this way to separate a supplementary phrase ("such as plastic bags") from the noun phrase it modifies ("man-made trash"). Choice C is incorrect because a comma after "leaves" doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second and third items in the series ("man-made...bags" and "and...glue"). Choice D is incorrect because it’s not conventional to use a semicolon in this way to separate a supplementary phrase ("such as plastic bags") from the noun phrase it modifies ("man-made trash").

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 85656109

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 85656109

In 2016, engineer Vanessa Galvez oversaw the installation of 164 bioswales, vegetated channels designed to absorb and divert stormwater, along the streets of Queens, New York. By reducing the runoff flowing into city sewers, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. the mitigation of both street flooding and the resulting pollution of nearby waterways has been achieved by bioswales.
- B. the bioswales have mitigated both street flooding and the resulting pollution of nearby waterways.
- C. the bioswales’ mitigation of both street flooding and the resulting pollution of nearby waterways has been achieved.
- D. both street flooding and the resulting pollution of nearby waterways have been mitigated by bioswales.

ID: 85656109 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “the bioswales” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “By reducing...sewers.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the bioswales—and not another noun in the sentence—are reducing runoff flowing into city sewers.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the mitigation...waterways” immediately after the modifying phrase results in unclear modification. The resulting sentence makes it hard to determine what is responsible for “reducing the runoff”: the bioswales or some other noun in the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the bioswales’ mitigation...waterways” immediately after the modifying phrase results in unclear modification. The resulting sentence makes it hard to determine what is responsible for “reducing the runoff”: the bioswales or some other noun in the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “street flooding and the resulting pollution” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “flooding and pollution” are reducing runoff flowing into city sewers.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 059184e6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 059184e6

A species of *Byropsis* algae produces toxins to avoid being eaten by predators. However, in some cases, the toxins the organism uses to protect itself from predation actually _____ its attractiveness to predators. The Hawaiian sea slug, for example, not only tolerates *Byropsis* toxins but actually uses them for protection in the same way the algae does.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. is increasing
- B. increase
- C. increases
- D. has increased

ID: 059184e6 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "increase" agrees in number with the plural subject "toxins."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "is increasing" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "toxins." Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "increases" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "toxins." Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "has increased" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "toxins."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2f8baddd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 2f8baddd

Scala is referred to as a compiled programming language because it typically incorporates a compiler—a tool that translates lines of code into executable commands. Compiling isn’t exclusive to certain programming _____ any language can incorporate this tool.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. languages. However,
- B. languages; however,
- C. languages, however,
- D. languages, however;

ID: 2f8baddd Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb “however” from the preceding main clause (“Compiling...languages”) and uses a semicolon to join the next main clause (“any...tool”) to the rest of the sentence. Further, placing the semicolon after “however” indicates that the information in the preceding main clause (“compiling isn’t exclusive to certain programming languages”) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (Scala’s status as a compiled programming language might suggest that compiling is unique to certain languages).

Choice A is incorrect because placing a period after “languages” and starting a new sentence with “however” illogically indicates that the information in the next sentence (any language can incorporate a compiler) is contrary to the information in the previous sentence (“compiling isn’t exclusive to certain programming languages”). Instead, the information following “however” supports the previous claim. Choice B is incorrect because placing the semicolon after “languages” illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause (any language can incorporate a compiler) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (“compiling isn’t exclusive to certain programming languages”). Instead, the information following “however” supports the previous claim. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Commas can’t be used in this way to punctuate a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ceb5e824

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: ceb5e824

From afar, African American fiber artist Bisa Butler’s portraits look like paintings, their depictions of human faces, bodies, and clothing so intricate that it seems only a fine brush could have rendered them. When viewed up close, however, the portraits reveal themselves to be _____ stitching barely visible among the thousands of pieces of printed, microcut fabric.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. quilts, and the
- B. quilts, the
- C. quilts; the
- D. quilts. The

ID: ceb5e824 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause (“the portraits...quilts”) and the supplementary noun phrase (“the stitching...fabric”) that provides a further description of how the portraits can be identified as quilts.

Choice A is incorrect. A comma and the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join a main clause and a supplementary noun phrase. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join a main clause and a supplementary noun phrase. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “the stitching.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 45adafe0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 45adafe0

Nigerian author Buchi Emecheta’s celebrated literary oeuvre includes *The Joys of Motherhood*, a novel about the changing roles of women in 1950s _____ a television play about the private struggles of a newlywed couple in Nigeria; and *Head Above Water*, her autobiography.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Lagos, *A Kind of Marriage*,
- B. Lagos; *A Kind of Marriage*,
- C. Lagos, *A Kind of Marriage*:
- D. Lagos; *A Kind of Marriage*

ID: 45adafe0 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of items in a complex series (a series including internal punctuation). In this choice, the semicolon after “Lagos” is conventionally used to separate the first item (“*The Joys... Lagos*”) and the second item (“*A Kind...Nigeria*”) in the series. Further, the comma after “*Marriage*” correctly separates the title “*A Kind of Marriage*” from the supplementary phrase (“a television...Nigeria”) that describes it.

Choice A is incorrect because the comma after “Lagos” doesn’t match the semicolon used later in the series to separate the second item (“*A Kind...Nigeria*”) from the third item (“and...autobiography”). Choice C is incorrect because the comma after “Lagos” doesn’t match the semicolon used later in the series to separate the second item (“*A Kind...Nigeria*”) from the third item (“and...autobiography”). Additionally, a colon can’t be used in this way to separate the title “*A Kind of Marriage*” from the supplementary phrase (“a television...Nigeria”) that describes it. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the title “*A Kind of Marriage*” from the supplementary phrase (“a television...Nigeria”) that describes it.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 82a9b0f6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 82a9b0f6

Hegra is an archaeological site in present-day Saudi Arabia and was the second largest city of the Nabataean Kingdom (fourth century BCE to first century CE). Archaeologist Laila Nehmé recently traveled to Hegra to study its ancient _____ into the rocky outcrops of a vast desert, these burial chambers seem to blend seamlessly with nature.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. tombs. Built
- B. tombs, built
- C. tombs and built
- D. tombs built

ID: 82a9b0f6 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period after “tombs” is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“Archaeologist...tombs”) and another (“Built...nature”).

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice C is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join the two sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences (“Archaeologist...tombs” and “Built...nature”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cf29979b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: cf29979b

In 1453, English King Henry VI became unfit to rule after falling gravely ill. As a result, Parliament appointed Richard, Third Duke of York, who had a strong claim to the English throne, to rule as Lord Protector. Upon recovering two years later, _____ forcing an angered Richard from the royal court and precipitating a series of battles later known as the Wars of the Roses.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Henry resumed his reign,
- B. the reign of Henry resumed,
- C. Henry’s reign resumed,
- D. it was Henry who resumed his reign,

ID: cf29979b Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice ensures that the introductory phrase “upon recovering two years later” appears immediately before the noun it modifies (“Henry”), clearly establishing that Henry recovered two years later.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “the reign of Henry” immediately after the introductory phrase illogically suggests that the reign of Henry recovered two years later. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “Henry’s reign” immediately after the introductory phrase illogically suggests that Henry’s reign recovered two years later. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the function word “it” immediately after the introductory phrase illogically suggests that “it” recovered two years later.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID eec227cb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: eec227cb

In 1943, in the midst of World War II, mathematics professor Grace Hopper was recruited by the US military to help the war effort by solving complex equations. Hopper’s subsequent career would involve more than just _____ as a pioneering computer programmer, Hopper would help usher in the digital age.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. equations, though:
- B. equations, though,
- C. equations. Though,
- D. equations though

ID: eec227cb Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation to mark boundaries between supplements and clauses. The comma after “equations” is used to separate the independent clause (“Hopper’s...equation”) from the supplementary adverb phrase “though.” The colon after “though” is used to mark the boundary between the clause ending with “though” and the following clause (“as...age”). A colon used in this way introduces information that illustrates or explains information that has come before it. In this case, the colon after “though” introduces the following explanation of how Hopper’s subsequent career would involve more than just solving equations: she would become a pioneering computer programmer.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two independent clauses (“Hopper’s...though” and “as...age”) such as these. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an illogical sequence of sentences. Placing the period after “equations” and beginning the next sentence with “Though” illogically suggests that the following information (that Hopper would help usher in the digital age) is contrary to the information in the previous sentence (Hopper’s subsequent career would involve more than just solving equations). Instead, the information that follows supports the information from the previous sentence by explaining how her work and influence extended beyond solely solving equations. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two independent clauses (“Hopper’s...though” and “as...age”) are fused without punctuation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3a1de1f6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 3a1de1f6

While light is known as one of the fastest-moving substances, it slows down when passing through some types of matter. One such type of matter is a form of cooled, condensed gas called a Bose-Einstein condensate _____. Dutch physicist Lene Hau famously used a BEC to slow a beam of light to a complete halt.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. (BEC),
- B. (BEC) and
- C. (BEC);
- D. (BEC)

ID: 3a1de1f6 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a semicolon to join the first main clause ("One...(BEC)") and the second main clause ("Dutch...halt").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. Without a comma preceding it, a conjunction can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2eb802a6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 2eb802a6

The Herfindahl-Hirschman Index (HHI), a commonly used measure of competition between companies in a particular market, ranges from a score of zero to 10,000 points. Compared with that of a highly concentrated market—that is, a market controlled by very few companies—_____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. a market that is less concentrated will have a much lower HHI score.
- B. the HHI score of a less concentrated market will be much lower.
- C. when a market is less concentrated, its HHI score will be much lower.
- D. a less concentrated market will have an HHI score that is much lower.

ID: 2eb802a6 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "the HHI...market" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "compared...market." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the HHI score of a less concentrated market—and not another noun in the sentence—is being compared with the HHI score of a highly concentrated market.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "a market that is less concentrated" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that a market is being compared with an HHI score. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a confusing, illogical sentence. The placement of the modifier "when a market is less concentrated" after "a highly concentrated market" is contradictory. Furthermore, it's ambiguous what "its" is referring to in "its HHI score," resulting in an illogical comparison. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "a less concentrated market" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that a market is being compared with an HHI score.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 09151f47

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 09151f47

Sociologist Alton Okinaka sits on the review board tasked with adding new sites to the Hawai'i Register of Historic Places, which includes Pī'ilanihale Heiau and the Ōpaeka'a Road Bridge. Okinaka doesn't make such decisions _____ all historical designations must be approved by a group of nine other experts from the fields of architecture, archaeology, history, and Hawaiian culture.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. single-handedly, however;
- B. single-handedly; however,
- C. single-handedly, however,
- D. single-handedly however

ID: 09151f47 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb "however" from the preceding main clause ("Okinaka doesn't...single-handedly") and a semicolon to join the next main clause ("all...culture") to the rest of the sentence. Further, placing the semicolon after "however" correctly indicates that the information in the preceding main clause (Okinaka doesn't make such decisions single-handedly) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (Okinaka sits on the review board that adds new sites to the Hawaii Register of Historic Places).

Choice B is incorrect because placing the semicolon after "single-handedly" and the comma after "however" illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause (all historical designations must be approved by a group of experts) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (Okinaka doesn't make such decisions single-handedly). Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Commas can't be used in this way to punctuate a supplementary word or phrase between two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0eda705e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 0eda705e

The Mission 66 initiative, which was approved by Congress in 1956, represented a major investment in the infrastructure of overburdened national _____. It prioritized physical improvements to the parks’ roads, utilities, employee housing, and visitor facilities while also establishing educational programming for the public.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. parks and
- B. parks
- C. parks;
- D. parks,

ID: 0eda705e Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the coordination of main clauses within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon to correctly join the first main clause (“The Mission...parks”) and the second main clause that begins with “it.”

Choice A is incorrect. When coordinating two longer main clauses such as these, it’s conventional to use a comma before the coordinating conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a91326ea

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: a91326ea

While the ancient Celts—Iron Age peoples who inhabited parts of western and central Europe—weren’t a single unified group, their art often featured common elements. These included intricate patterns of interlocking spiral lines, which often held symbolic _____ of birds, horses, and other animals; and inlaid enamel accents.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. significance; depictions
- B. significance, depictions
- C. significance: depictions
- D. significance. Depictions

ID: a91326ea Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of elements in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after “significance” is conventionally used to separate the first item (“intricate...significance”) and the second item (“depictions...animals”) in the series of common elements found in Celtic art. Moreover, the semicolon after “significance” matches the semicolon used later to separate the second item (“depictions...animals”) and the third item (“and...accents”) in the series.

Choice B is incorrect because a comma after “significance” doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second and third items in the series (“depictions...animals” and “and...accents”). Choice C is incorrect because a colon can’t be used in this way to separate items in a complex series. Choice D is incorrect because placing a period after “significance” results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “depictions.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 13cea4cd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 13cea4cd

As jazz singer Sarah Vaughan honed her vocal abilities—acquiring a sophisticated timbre and precise control over pitch, dynamics, and _____ she earned comparisons to opera icon Leontyne Price, one of her personal heroes. The comparisons highlight how Vaughan, a jazz star, had transcended genre boundaries with her singing prowess.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. vibrato:
- B. vibrato,
- C. vibrato—
- D. vibrato

ID: 13cea4cd Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The dash after “vibrato” pairs with the dash after “abilities” to separate the supplementary element (“acquiring...vibrato”) from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to describe the vocal abilities Vaughan developed, and the pair of dashes indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because a colon can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6261d8d0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 6261d8d0

The Limón technique, developed by Mexican-born dancer and choreographer Jose Limón, is known for its emphasis on breath control and its interplay of weight and _____ dancers may explore, for example, the moment of mid-air suspension at the top of a jump.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. weightlessness
- B. weightlessness which
- C. weightlessness,
- D. weightlessness;

ID: 6261d8d0 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause ("The Limón...weightlessness") and the second main clause ("dancers...jump").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect. The relative pronoun "which" can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c81e6c4f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: c81e6c4f

Researchers studying magnetosensation have determined why some soil-dwelling roundworms in the Southern Hemisphere move in the opposite direction of Earth’s magnetic field when searching for _____ in the Northern Hemisphere, the magnetic field points down, into the ground, but in the Southern Hemisphere, it points up, toward the surface and away from worms’ food sources.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. food:
- B. food,
- C. food while
- D. food

ID: c81e6c4f Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is colon use within a sentence. A colon used in this way introduces information that illustrates or explains information that has come before it. In this case, the colon introduces the following explanation of why some roundworms in the Southern Hemisphere move in the opposite direction of Earth’s magnetic field.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two long independent clauses (“Researchers...food” and “in...sources”) such as these. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two clauses (“Researchers...food” and “in...sources”) are fused without punctuation. Furthermore, the conjunction “while” fails to indicate that what follows is an explanation of why some roundworms in the Southern Hemisphere move in the opposite direction of Earth’s magnetic field. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two clauses (“Researchers...food” and “in...sources”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dc1f1373

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: dc1f1373

Classical composer Florence Price’s 1927 move to Chicago marked a turning point in her career. It was there that Price premiered her First Symphony—a piece that was praised for blending traditional Romantic motifs with aspects of Black folk music—and _____ supportive relationships with other Black artists.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. developing
- B. developed
- C. to develop
- D. having developed

ID: dc1f1373 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The missing verb is part of the same clause as the verb "premiered," and "Price" is the subject of both. So we need the past-tense form "developed" in order to match "premiered."

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a verb form error. The missing verb is part of the same clause as the verb "premiered," and "Price" is the subject of both. So we need the past-tense form "developed" in order to match "premiered." Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a verb form error. The missing verb is part of the same clause as the verb "premiered," and "Price" is the subject of both. So we need the past-tense form "developed" in order to match "premiered." Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a verb form error. The missing verb is part of the same clause as the verb "premiered," and "Price" is the subject of both. So we need the past-tense form "developed" in order to match "premiered."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cc51e799

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: cc51e799

If an animal can recognize itself in a reflective surface (“the mirror test”), it is considered to have self-awareness. In a recent study, scientists _____ for evidence of self-awareness in snakes, species that rely primarily on olfactory rather than visual processing, adapted the test to foreground smell, modifying the scent trails of North American eastern garter snakes and African ball pythons.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. searched
- B. searching
- C. were searching
- D. have searched

ID: cc51e799 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle “searching” is correctly used to form a supplementary element that modifies the subject “scientists,” indicating that the scientists who adapted the test were looking for evidence of self-awareness in snakes.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite past tense verb “searched” can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element that indicates what evidence the scientists who adapted the test were looking for. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite past progressive verb “were searching” can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element that indicates what evidence the scientists who adapted the test were looking for. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present perfect verb “have searched” can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element that indicates what evidence the scientists who adapted the test were looking for.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4f73eb97

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 4f73eb97

Far from being modern inventions, _____ more than 5,000 years ago.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Sumerians in ancient Mesopotamia used drinking straws
- B. drinking straws were used by Sumerians in ancient Mesopotamia
- C. the use of drinking straws by Sumerians in ancient Mesopotamia happened
- D. ancient Mesopotamia was home to Sumerians who used drinking straws

ID: 4f73eb97 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The modifier “far from being modern inventions” must be describing “drinking straws,” because those are the only possible inventions in this sentence.

Choice A is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The modifier “far from being modern inventions” can’t be describing “Sumerians,” because they are a group of people, not an invention. Choice C is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The modifier “far from being modern inventions” can’t be describing “the use of drinking straws,” because it is not “the use” of drinking straws that is an invention—it is the drinking straws themselves. Choice D is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The modifier “far from being modern inventions” can’t be describing “Ancient Mesopotamia,” because that is a place, not an invention.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b7b18879

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: b7b18879

A recent study tracked the number of bee species present in twenty-seven New York apple orchards over a ten-year period. _____ found that when wild growth near an orchard was cleared, the number of different bee species visiting the orchard decreased.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Entomologist Heather Grab:
- B. Entomologist, Heather Grab,
- C. Entomologist Heather Grab
- D. Entomologist Heather Grab,

ID: b7b18879 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a name and title and between a subject and a verb. No punctuation is needed between the proper noun “Heather Grab” and “entomologist,” the title that describes Grab. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the sentence’s subject (“Entomologist Heather Grab”) and the main verb (“found”) that indicates what Grab did.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Setting the entomologist’s name off with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6c51142e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 6c51142e

Compared to that of alumina glass, _____ silica glass atoms are so far apart that they are unable to re-form bonds after being separated.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. silica glass is at a significant disadvantage due to its more dispersed atomic arrangement:
- B. silica glass has a more dispersed atomic arrangement, resulting in a significant disadvantage:
- C. a significant disadvantage of silica glass is that its atomic arrangement is more dispersed:
- D. silica glass’s atomic arrangement is more dispersed, resulting in a significant disadvantage:

ID: 6c51142e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes “silica glass’s atomic arrangement” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “compared to that of alumina glass.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that silica glass’s atomic arrangement—and not another noun in the sentence—is being compared to the atomic arrangement (“that”) of alumina glass.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “silica glass” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that silica glass itself (rather than its atomic arrangement) is being compared to alumina glass’s atomic arrangement. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “silica glass” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that silica glass itself (rather than its atomic arrangement) is being compared to alumina glass’s atomic arrangement. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “a significant disadvantage” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that “a significant disadvantage” is being compared to alumina glass’s atomic arrangement.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 0276c8da

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 0276c8da

Butterfly is a 1988 painting by the Japanese artist Ay-O. Like many of Ay-O’s paintings, *Butterfly*, which portrays a swimmer performing the butterfly stroke, attempts to make use of the entire visual light _____ sporting rainbow-striped goggles, the rainbow-hued swimmer splashes through a wavy rainbow of water.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. spectrum
- B. spectrum:
- C. spectrum while
- D. spectrum, while

ID: 0276c8da Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of a colon within a sentence. In this choice, the colon correctly introduces the following description of how the painting makes use of the entire visual light spectrum by depicting a rainbow-hued swimmer.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The main clauses ("Like...spectrum" and "sporting...water") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The main clauses ("Like...spectrum" and "while...water") are fused without punctuation. Furthermore, the conjunction "while" fails to indicate that what follows is a description of how the painting makes use of the entire visual light spectrum. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a logically confusing sentence. The conjunction "while," which suggests that what follows is occurring at the same time as or despite what came before, fails to indicate that what follows is a description of how the painting makes use of the entire visual light spectrum.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID d6fe291c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: d6fe291c

On November 2, 1772, amid rising tensions with Great Britain, Boston colonists formed the Boston Committee of Correspondence. By 1774, what had started as a local means of mobilizing support for the Patriot cause had grown into something far more _____ network of such committees that, facilitating communication among the colonies, helped lay the groundwork for the Continental Congress.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. extensive: a
- B. extensive; a
- C. extensive, it was a
- D. extensive. A

ID: d6fe291c Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of a colon within a sentence. In this choice, the colon is correctly used to introduce the following explanation of what the Patriot cause had grown into by 1774.

Choice B is incorrect because a semicolon can't be used in this way to join the main clause ("what...extensive") and the supplementary element ("a network...Congress"). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, whereas a colon is conventionally used to introduce an element that explains or amplifies the information in the preceding clause, making the colon the better choice in this context. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. The addition of the pronoun and verb "it was" forms the start of a new main clause in the sentence, and a comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between two main clauses. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "a network."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7d90b83f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 7d90b83f

The 2022 Nobel Prize in Chemistry was awarded to three pioneers in the field of click chemistry: two-time Nobel laureate Barry Sharpless, who coined the term “click chemistry” in 1998; Carolyn Bertozzi, founder of the Bertozzi Group at _____ and Morten Meldal, a professor at the University of Copenhagen in Denmark.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Stanford
- B. Stanford,
- C. Stanford:
- D. Stanford;

ID: 7d90b83f Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. This choice correctly uses a semicolon to punctuate a complex list (which is made up of items that have commas in them).

Choice A is incorrect. This is a complex list, indicated by the semicolon between "1998" and "Carolyn Bertozzi." What comes after the blank is a separate list item, so punctuation is needed after "Stanford." Choice B is incorrect. This is a complex list, indicated by the semicolon between "1998" and "Carolyn Bertozzi." The items in this list have internal punctuation in the form of commas and must therefore be separated by semicolons to avoid confusion. Choice C is incorrect. This is a complex list, indicated by the semicolon between "1998" and "Carolyn Bertozzi." Colons aren't used to separate items in a list.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fef27017

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: fef27017

Between 322 and 184 BCE, the Maurya Empire established a complex economic system that, through trade and centralized _____ funded major infrastructure projects throughout the Indian subcontinent. This included the building of many roads, canals, and hospitals.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. taxation:
- B. taxation,
- C. taxation—
- D. taxation

ID: fef27017 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after "taxation" pairs with the comma after "that" to separate the supplementary element "through trade and centralized taxation" from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to identify the funding source of the Mauryan economy, and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because a colon can't be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a dash can't be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b728bbf6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: b728bbf6

The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) tracks comparative price list data for its thirty-eight member countries. For instance, in July 2021, a hypothetical basket of goods priced at 100 US dollars (USD) in the United States would have cost 62 USD and 110 USD in fellow OECD _____ and Luxembourg, respectively.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. nations, Chile
- B. nations; Chile
- C. nations: Chile
- D. nations Chile

ID: b728bbf6 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed to set off the coordinated noun phrase "Chile and Luxembourg" from the title that describes the two countries, "fellow OECD nations." Because the proper nouns "Chile and Luxembourg" are essential information identifying the "fellow OECD nations," no punctuation is necessary.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the country names ("Chile and Luxembourg") and the title ("fellow OECD nations") describing them. Further, setting the countries' names off with commas suggests that they could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn't the case. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the country names ("Chile and Luxembourg") and the title ("fellow OECD nations") describing them. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the country names ("Chile and Luxembourg") and the title ("fellow OECD nations") describing them. Placing a colon after "nations" would confusingly suggest that these were the costs of the basket of goods for "fellow OECD nations" in general, not for Chile and Luxembourg specifically.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9f980671

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 9f980671

Josephine Paddock and Florence Esté were among the 300 artists who exhibited at the 1913 Armory Show, a groundbreaking New York City art exhibition that introduced modernism to American audiences. Though shocking at the time, an abstract cubist painting exhibited by Marcel Duchamp—one of several works that received scorn from critics—_____ the Western art canon more than a century later.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. has entered
- B. have entered
- C. were entering
- D. enter

ID: 9f980671 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "has entered" agrees in number with the singular subject "an abstract cubist painting." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have entered" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "an abstract cubist painting." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "were entering" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "an abstract cubist painting." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "enter" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "an abstract cubist painting."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c4a6c3d6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: c4a6c3d6

In 2015, a team led by materials scientists Anirudha Sumant and Diana Berman succeeded in reducing the coefficient of friction (COF) between two surfaces to the lowest possible level—superlubricity. A nearly frictionless (and, as its name suggests, extremely slippery) state, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. when their COF drops below 0.01, two surfaces reach superlubricity.
- B. two surfaces, when their COF drops below 0.01, reach superlubricity.
- C. reaching superlubricity occurs when two surfaces’ COF drops below 0.01.
- D. superlubricity is reached when two surfaces’ COF drops below 0.01.

ID: c4a6c3d6 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun “superlubricity” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “a nearly frictionless...state.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that superlubricity—and not another noun in the sentence—is being described as nearly frictionless and extremely slippery.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. Regardless of the introductory “when...” clause, the main subject “two surfaces” follows the modifying phrase (“A nearly frictionless...state”), illogically suggesting that the surfaces are the nearly frictionless, extremely slippery state. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “two surfaces” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the surfaces are a nearly frictionless and extremely slippery state. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the gerund phrase “reaching superlubricity” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the act of reaching superlubricity is the nearly frictionless, extremely slippery state.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a3c9df26

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: a3c9df26

Over twenty years ago, in a landmark experiment in the psychology of choice, professor Sheena lyengar set up a jam-tasting booth at a grocery store. The number of jams available for tasting _____ some shoppers had twenty-four different options, others only six. Interestingly, the shoppers with fewer jams to choose from purchased more jam.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. varied:
- B. varied,
- C. varied, while
- D. varied while

ID: a3c9df26 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of a colon within a sentence. In this choice, the colon is used in a conventional way to introduce the following description of how the number of jams available varied.

Choice B is incorrect because it creates a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses ("the number...varied" and "some...six"). Choice C is incorrect because it results in an illogical and confusing sentence. Using the conjunction "while" to join the main clause ("the number...varied") with the following clause's description of the number of jams available suggests that the variation in the number of jams is in contrast to some shoppers having twenty-four options. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an illogical and confusing sentence. Using "while" in this way suggests that the number of jams available varied during the time in which some shoppers had twenty-four options and others had six. The sentence makes clear, however, that what follows "varied" is a description of the variation, not a separate, simultaneous occurrence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 96d1c257

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 96d1c257

Detroit natives Timothy Paule and Nicole Lindsey have combined their two passions, Detroit and beekeeping, to improve the health of their city’s flowers and other vegetation. In 2017, the couple converted a vacant lot in the city into an _____ in the years that followed they acquired nine additional lots and established more than 35 hives.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. apiary,
- B. apiary, and
- C. apiary and
- D. apiary

ID: 96d1c257 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Both clauses in this sentence could stand alone as complete sentences, which means they are both independent clauses. This choice uses a comma plus a coordinating conjunction to link them together, which is one of the correct ways to link two independent clauses.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence error. Both clauses in this sentence could stand alone as complete sentences, which means they are both independent clauses. A comma by itself is not enough punctuation to link two independent clauses. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence error. Both clauses in this sentence could stand alone as complete sentences, which means they are both independent clauses. Independent clauses can only be linked in a few ways, including with a comma plus a coordinating conjunction. This choice uses the coordinating conjunction “and,” but it is missing the comma beforehand. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence error. Both clauses in this sentence could stand alone as complete sentences, which means they are both independent clauses. Independent clauses need to have certain kinds of punctuation marks between them. This choice doesn’t use any punctuation between the two clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3f5c3225

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 3f5c3225

Increasing the heat on an uncovered boiling pot of water does not increase the temperature of the water. What increases is the rate at which the water turns to ____ a pressure cooker pot, though, an airtight seal traps the vapor in the pot, creating pressure that allows the temperature of the water to increase past its boiling point.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. vapor. With
- B. vapor with
- C. vapor, with
- D. vapor and with

ID: 3f5c3225 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("What...vapor") and another ("With...point").

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("What...vapor" and "with...point") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join sentences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID dc10f1f8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: dc10f1f8

Sociologist Todd Gitlin co-opted the term “recombinant,” normally used in reference to genetic engineering, to describe serialized television shows of the 1980s. Gitlin’s use of the term referenced TV studios’ practice of repackaging successful narrative formulas as new _____ even shows that varied only slightly from other shows still attracted sizeable audiences.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. content, in that era
- B. content; in that era,
- C. content in that era,
- D. content, in that era,

ID: dc10f1f8 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause ("Gitlin’s...content") and the second main clause beginning with a supplementary phrase ("in...audiences"). Further, placing a comma after "era" separates the supplementary phrase "in that era" from the rest of the main clause that follows ("even...audiences").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses. Further, this choice fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase "in that era" and the rest of the main clause that follows ("even...audiences"). Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("Gitlin’s...content" and "in...audiences") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can’t be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9eb27189

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 9eb27189

Entomologists Yash Sondhi and Samuel Fabian have tried to explain why moths fly erratically around light sources at night. Knowing that flying insects keep their backs pointed toward sunlight during the day, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. the researchers theorize that moths, mistaking nighttime lights for the Sun, continually try to reorient their bodies while flying near such lights.
- B. the researchers’ theory is that moths mistake nighttime lights for the Sun, continually trying to reorient their bodies while flying near such lights.
- C. moths mistake nighttime lights for the Sun and continually try to reorient their bodies while flying near such lights, the researchers theorize.
- D. moths continually try to reorient their bodies while flying near nighttime lights, the researchers theorize, mistaking such lights for the Sun.

ID: 9eb27189 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "the researchers" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "knowing...day." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the researchers—and not another noun in the sentence—know that flying insects keep their backs pointed toward sunlight during the day.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "the researchers’ theory" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the researchers’ theory knows that flying insects keep their backs pointed toward sunlight during the day. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun "moths" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that moths know that flying insects keep their backs pointed toward sunlight during the day. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun "moths" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that moths know that flying insects keep their backs pointed toward sunlight during the day.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID df52033a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: df52033a

In 2018, a team of researchers led by Dr. Caitlin Whalen compiled every available measurement of ocean mixing rates from the past two decades. With this novel data set, the team was able to determine how current-driven mixing varies across _____ and what impact it has on the distribution of heat and nutrients in the ocean.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. regions,
- B. regions:
- C. regions;
- D. regions

ID: df52033a Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between coordinates in a sentence. The two elements "how...regions" and "what...ocean" work together as coordinates to complete the description of what the team was able to determine. Because there are only two coordinates in this case (as opposed to a series of three or more), no punctuation is needed between them.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinates "how...regions" and "what...ocean." Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinates "how...regions" and "what...ocean." Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the coordinates "how...regions" and "what...ocean."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fe0593f0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: fe0593f0

Recent pollen analyses of the Aran Islands have led some researchers to propose that the now treeless islands were once wooded. This hypothesis _____ that certain trees, such as *P. sylvestris*, survived without interruption or human intervention throughout the Holocene cannot stand, researchers Michael O’Connell and Karen Molloy counter, unless other explanations can first be ruled out.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. suggesting
- B. suggested
- C. suggests
- D. has suggested

ID: fe0593f0 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle "suggesting" is correctly used to form a restrictive participial phrase ("suggesting...Holocene") within the main clause ("This hypothesis...cannot stand..."). This participial phrase functions as part of the sentence’s subject ("This...Holocene"), providing essential identifying information about what the hypothesis states—namely, that certain trees survived without interruption or human intervention throughout the Holocene.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb "suggested" can’t be used in this way within the subject of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb "suggests" can’t be used in this way within the subject of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite verb "has suggested" can’t be used in this way within the subject of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e44327fb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: e44327fb

Key-value pairs are an important aspect of JavaScript Object Notation (JSON), an electronic file format for storing and transmitting data. Keys function as labels, while values contain the actual information. In a JSON file storing data about fire belly _____ instance, you could encounter a key such as “species” with the associated value of “*Cynops orientalis*.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. newts. For
- B. newts, for
- C. newts: for
- D. newts; for

ID: e44327fb Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after “newts” pairs with the comma after “instance” to separate the supplementary element “for instance” from the rest of the sentence. The supplementary element appears between the prepositional phrase (“In...newts”) and the main clause of the sentence (“you... *orientalis*”) and signals that the sentence is presenting an example of how keys and values function in JSON files.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a sentence fragment (“In a JSON file storing data about fire belly newts”). Choice C is incorrect because a colon can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element “for instance” from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element “for instance” from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID e2f27ae9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: e2f27ae9

The Balkan nation of Bosnia and Herzegovina does not have one president but _____ as members of the office of the presidency, one representing the nation’s Bosniaks, one its Serbs, and one its Croats, these elected officials take turns serving as the office’s chairperson.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. three, known
- B. three. Known
- C. three who are known
- D. three, who are known

ID: e2f27ae9 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“The Balkan...three”) and another (“Known...chairperson”). While the supplementary element (“known...Croats”) could logically be attached to either the first main clause (“The Balkan...three”) or the second main clause (“these elected...chairperson”), end-of-sentence punctuation is needed to indicate to which sentence the supplementary element belongs.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. In this choice, the first sentence, consisting of a main clause (“The Balkan...three”) and supplementary element (“known...Croats”), is incorrectly joined with a second main clause (“these elected...chairperson”) using a comma. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. In this choice, the first sentence, consisting of a main clause (“The Balkan...three”) and a relative clause (“who are...Croats”), is incorrectly joined with a second main clause (“these elected...chairperson”) using a comma. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two sentences. Additionally, this choice omits the comma needed after “three” to mark the beginning of the supplementary relative clause (“who are known...Croats”). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. In this choice, the first sentence, consisting of a main clause (“The Balkan...three”) and a supplementary relative clause (“who are...Croats”), is incorrectly joined with a second main clause (“these elected...chairperson”) using a comma. A comma can’t be used in this way to join two sentences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 85b53b74

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 85b53b74

Arms outstretched, right wrist over left with both hands dangling, South Korean musician Psy galloped from one foot to the other in the iconic dance of his 2012 international hit song “Gangnam Style.” Later, a statue depicting Psy’s arm-positioning during the dance was erected in the place that inspired the song’s _____ Gangnam District in Seoul, South Korea.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. name;
- B. name.
- C. name
- D. name—

ID: 85b53b74 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a dash after the main clause (“Later...name”) to introduce the supplementary element (“Gangnam...Korea”) that identifies the place that inspired the song’s name.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“Later...name”) and the supplementary element (“Gangnam...Korea”). A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “Gangnam.” Choice C is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause and the supplementary element with appropriate punctuation.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a9475e56

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: a9475e56

In the canon of North African literature, Moroccan author Driss Chraïbi’s 1954 novel *The Simple Past* (*Le Passé simple*) looms large. A coming-of-age story, a social meditation, and a sober gaze into the dark maw of French colonialism, _____ interrogates systemic power with memorable intensity.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Morocco gained its independence two years before the publication of Chraïbi’s debut novel, which
- B. Chraïbi’s debut novel, published two years before Morocco gained its independence,
- C. Chraïbi wrote a debut novel that, published two years before Morocco gained its independence,
- D. published two years before Morocco gained its independence, Chraïbi wrote a debut novel that

ID: a9475e56 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Subject-modifier placement requires a modifier and its subject to be next to each other. The subject of the modifier "a coming-of-age story...colonialism" is Chraïbi’s novel *The Simple Past*, so the subject "Chraïbi’s debut novel" fits perfectly after this introductory modifying phrase.

Choice A is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The introductory modifier "a coming-of-age story...colonialism" is describing Chraïbi’s novel, not Morocco. However, this choice places Morocco directly next to that modifier. Choice C is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The introductory modifier "a coming-of-age story...colonialism" all describes Chraïbi’s novel, not Chraïbi himself. However, this choice places Chraïbi directly next to that modifier. Choice D is incorrect. Modifiers and their subjects must go next to each other. The modifier "a coming-of-age story..." is describing Chraïbi’s novel, so that needs to be the subject immediately after the modifier. This choice adds another modifier that describes Chraïbi’s novel, but then puts "Chraïbi" himself—not the novel—right after that modifier, which doesn’t make sense. Chraïbi wasn’t "published two years before" Moroccan independence; his novel *The Simple Past* was.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 3190eed2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 3190eed2

Chondrites are stony meteorites that are undifferentiated—that is, their contents have not melted and separated into distinct layers. They are hardly _____ many chondrites experience aqueous alteration as a result of exposure to fluids, as well as fracturing, veining, and localized melting due to collisions with other objects.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. pristine, though
- B. pristine, though;
- C. pristine; though
- D. pristine, though,

ID: 3190eed2 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb "though" from the preceding main clause ("They are hardly pristine") and uses a semicolon to join the two main clauses ("They...though" and "many...objects"). Further, placing the semicolon after "though" indicates that the information in the preceding main clause (chondrites are far from pristine) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (chondrites have been generally unaltered by their environment).

Choice A is incorrect because placing the comma after "pristine" and using "though" as a subordinating conjunction illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause (many chondrites have experienced damage) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (chondrites are far from pristine). Choice C is incorrect because placing the semicolon after "pristine" illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause (many chondrites have experienced damage) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (chondrites are far from pristine). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, the comma after "though" can't be used in this way to join two main clauses.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 95001433

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 95001433

On March 23, 2021, a gust of wind wreaked havoc on global trade. *Ever Given*, an international shipping container vessel, became lodged in Egypt’s Suez Canal, a major shipping route between Europe and Asia. The vessel took six days to _____ it’s as heavy as two thousand blue whales when fully loaded.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. dislodge in part due to its sheer size,
- B. dislodge, in part due to its sheer size:
- C. dislodge, in part due to its sheer size,
- D. dislodge, in part, due to its sheer size

ID: 95001433 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between main clauses and a supplementary element. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause ("The vessel took six days to dislodge") and the supplementary element ("in part due to its sheer size") that provides additional information on why the vessel was difficult to dislodge. Additionally, this choice correctly uses a colon to introduce another main clause that describes the vessel’s size ("it’s as heavy as two thousand blue whales when fully loaded").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between two main clauses ("The vessel...size" and "it’s...loaded"). Additionally, it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause ("The vessel took six days to dislodge") and the supplementary element ("in part due to its sheer size"). Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between two main clauses ("The vessel...size" and "it’s...loaded"). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses ("The vessel...size" and "it’s...loaded") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c4388f3c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: c4388f3c

Latin America is known to have dozens, if not hundreds, of popular dance forms. Only five of these dances are included in international ballroom dance _____ rumba, samba, cha-cha-cha, paso doble, and jive—the last of which is grouped with the other Latin dances despite not having Latin roots.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. competitions, however:
- B. competitions, however,
- C. competitions, however;
- D. competitions; however,

ID: c4388f3c Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of supplementary elements within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb "however" from the preceding main clause ("only...competitions"), and it uses a colon to introduce the list of dances that follows ("rumba...jive"). Further, placing the colon after "however" rather than before indicates that the information in the preceding main clause (only...competitions) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (Latin America has many more dance forms).

Choice B is incorrect. The comma after "however" can't be used in this way to introduce a series ("rumba...jive"). Choice C is incorrect because it isn't conventional to use a semicolon in this way to introduce a series of items, such as the list of dances. Choice D is incorrect because placing the semicolon after "competitions" illogically indicates that the following list of five Latin American dances ("rumba...jive") is contrary to the information in the previous clause (only five Latin American dances are included in international ballroom dance competitions).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b73b70d4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: b73b70d4

In 2008, two years after the death of science fiction writer Octavia Butler, the Huntington Library in _____ received a collection of more than 8,000 items, including Butler’s private notes, research materials, manuscripts, photos, and drawings. Today, the Octavia E. Butler Collection is one of the most researched archives at the library.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. California,
- B. California:
- C. California—
- D. California

ID: b73b70d4 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. No punctuation should separate the subject of the sentence (“the Huntington Library in California”) from its verb (“received”).

Choice A is incorrect. No punctuation should separate the subject of the sentence (“the Huntington Library in California”) from its verb (“received”). Choice B is incorrect. No punctuation should separate the subject of the sentence (“the Huntington Library in California”) from its verb (“received”). Choice C is incorrect. No punctuation should separate the subject of the sentence (“the Huntington Library in California”) from its verb (“received”).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 518e8c44

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 518e8c44

The haiku-like poems of Tomas Tranströmer, which present nature- and dream-influenced images in crisp, spare language, have earned the Swedish poet praise from leading contemporary _____ them Nigerian American essayist and novelist Teju Cole, who has written that Tranströmer’s works “contain a luminous simplicity.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. writers. Among
- B. writers among
- C. writers; among
- D. writers, among

ID: 518e8c44 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and a supplementary phrase. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause (“The haiku-like...writers”) and the supplementary phrase (“among...Cole”) that specifies a contemporary writer who has praised Tomas Tranströmer’s haiku-like poems.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “among.” Choice B is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the main clause and the supplementary phrase with appropriate punctuation. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the main clause (“The haiku-like...writers”) and the supplementary phrase (“among...Cole”).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID b0ea7a05

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: b0ea7a05

Unique among animal species, humans use our vocal apparatuses primarily for two separate communicative purposes: to talk and to sing. The question of what cross-cultural traits distinguish these distinct modes, and secondarily what pressures led humans to develop them in the first place, _____ neuropsychologist Daniela Sammler’s 2024 study “Signatures of Speech and Song: ‘Universal’ Links despite Cultural Diversity.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. animates
- B. have animated
- C. animate
- D. animating

ID: b0ea7a05 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "animates" agrees in number with the singular subject "question."

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have animated" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "question." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "animate" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "question." Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "animating" doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID cb20115e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: cb20115e

In crafting her fantasy fiction, Nigerian-born British author Helen Oyeyemi has drawn inspiration from the classic nineteenth-century fairy tales of the Brothers Grimm. Her 2014 novel *Boy, Snow, Bird*, for instance, is a complex retelling of the story of Snow White, while her 2019 novel _____ offers a delicious twist on the classic tale of Hansel and Gretel.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. *Gingerbread*—
- B. *Gingerbread*,
- C. *Gingerbread*
- D. *Gingerbread*:

ID: cb20115e Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a subject and a verb. When, as in this case, a subject (“her 2019 novel *Gingerbread*”) is immediately followed by a verb (“offers”), no punctuation is needed.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the subject and the verb.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 63589ebe

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 63589ebe

In February 1919, following the end of the First World War, women from ten countries around the world convened the Inter-Allied Women’s Conference in Paris. The conference’s goals were _____ ensure women’s participation in the proceedings of the Paris Peace Conference, to secure the right of women to serve in the League of Nations, and to advocate for human rights.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. threefold: to
- B. threefold. To
- C. threefold to
- D. threefold; to

ID: 63589ebe Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. In this choice, the colon correctly introduces the series of goals held by the 1919 Inter-Allied Women’s Conference.

Choice B is incorrect because placing a period after "threefold" results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "To." Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The main clause ("The conference’s goals were threefold") and the series supplement ("to...rights") are fused without punctuation. Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to introduce a series. A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses, whereas a colon is conventionally used to introduce a series, making the colon the better choice in this context.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 48ff0d18

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 48ff0d18

Researcher Lin Zhi developed a process for increasing the tensile strength—measured in gigapascals, or GPa—of silkworm ____ dissolving and reweaving the silk in a solution of iron metal ions, zinc, and sugar, Zhi increased the amount of force required to stretch it from approximately 0.5 GPa to 2 GPa.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. silk, by
- B. silk by
- C. silk and by
- D. silk. By

ID: 48ff0d18 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The independent clauses "researcher Lin Zhi...silk" and "by dissolving...2 GPa" can be grammatically separated by a period. They can stand alone as sentences, and this is the only choice that lets them do that.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a comma splice. "Researcher Lin Zhi...silk" and "by dissolving... 2 GPa" are both independent clauses. They need to either be separated with punctuation like a period or a semicolon, or they need to be connected by a comma and a coordinating conjunction like "and." A comma alone isn't enough. Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a run-on sentence. "Researcher Lin Zhi...silk" and "by dissolving...2 GPa" are both independent clauses. They need to either be separated with punctuation like a period or a semicolon, or they need to be connected by a comma and a coordinating conjunction like "and." Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a run-on sentence. "Researcher Lin Zhi...silk" and "by dissolving...2 GPa" are both independent clauses. The coordinating conjunction "and" isn't enough to link them by itself. We need a comma, too.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 36aa1f73

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 36aa1f73

Working from an earlier discovery of Charpentier’s, chemists Emmanuelle Charpentier and Jennifer Doudna—winners of the 2020 Nobel Prize in Chemistry—re-created and then reprogrammed the so-called “genetic scissors” of a species of DNA-cleaving bacteria _____ a tool that is revolutionizing the field of gene technology.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. to forge
- B. forging
- C. forged
- D. and forging

ID: 36aa1f73 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of finite and nonfinite verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive “to forge” is correctly used to form a nonfinite (infinitive) clause that explains why the chemists re-created and reprogrammed the DNA-cleaving bacteria.

Choice B is incorrect. Without a comma separating the main clause (“chemists...bacteria”) from the participle “forging,” this choice illogically suggests that the bacteria are forging a tool, which doesn’t make sense. Choice C is incorrect. Without a coordinating conjunction such as “and” placed before it, the finite past tense verb “forged” can’t be used in this way to describe the chemists’ actions. Choice D is incorrect. If read as a finite verb, the present progressive verb “forging” isn’t consistent with the past tense verbs used in this sentence to describe the actions of the chemists. If read as a nonfinite verb, the participle “forging” can’t be used in this way because there is no following main clause for it to modify.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 1652da19

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 1652da19

Eli Eisenberg, a genetics expert at Tel Aviv University in Israel, recently discovered that _____ have a special genetic ability called RNA editing that confers evolutionary advantages.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. cephalopods, ocean dwellers that include the squid, the octopus, and the cuttlefish
- B. cephalopods—ocean dwellers—that include the squid, the octopus, and the cuttlefish,
- C. cephalopods, ocean dwellers that include: the squid, the octopus, and the cuttlefish,
- D. cephalopods—ocean dwellers that include the squid, the octopus, and the cuttlefish—

ID: 1652da19 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. In this choice, the dash after "cephalopods" pairs with the dash after "cuttlefish" to clearly separate the supplementary element "ocean dwellers that include the squid, the octopus, and the cuttlefish" from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element functions to explain what cephalopods are, and the pair of dashes indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element that explains what cephalopods are from the rest of the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element that explains what cephalopods are from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element that explains what cephalopods are from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4f8b7c3b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 4f8b7c3b

Established in 1936 by African American novelist Richard Wright, _____ it would become a vital part of the creative movement known as the Chicago Black Renaissance.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. the South Side Writers Group provided a valuable forum for Chicago writers to share ideas;
- B. Chicago writers in the South Side Writers Group had a valuable forum for sharing ideas;
- C. writers shared ideas at a valuable forum known as the South Side Writers Group in Chicago;
- D. Chicago was where the South Side Writers Group provided a valuable forum for writers to share ideas;

ID: 4f8b7c3b Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “the South Side Writers Group” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “established in 1936 by African American novelist Richard Wright.” In doing so, this choice clearly indicates that the South Side Writers Group—and not another noun in the sentence—was established in 1936 by Richard Wright.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “Chicago writers” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the Chicago writers were established in 1936 by Richard Wright. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “writers” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the writers were established in 1936 by Richard Wright. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “Chicago” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that Chicago was established in 1936 by Richard Wright.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID c2a7673e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: c2a7673e

The field of geological oceanography owes much to American _____ Marie Tharp, a pioneering oceanographic cartographer whose detailed topographical maps of the ocean floor and its multiple rift valleys helped garner acceptance for the theories of plate tectonics and continental drift.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. geologist,
- B. geologist
- C. geologist;
- D. geologist:

ID: c2a7673e Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. “Marie tharp” is essential information that completes the first clause — the first clause doesn’t function without it. So we don’t want to separate it with punctuation.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “The field of geological oceanography owes much to American geologist” is unclear: which geologist are we talking about? We need the “Marie Tharp” for clarity, which means it’s essential information and should not be separated by a comma. Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “The field of geological oceanography owes much to American geologist” is unclear: which geologist are we talking about? We need the “Marie Tharp” for clarity, which means it’s essential information and should not be separated by a semicolon. Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. “The field of geological oceanography owes much to American geologist” is unclear: which geologist are we talking about? We need the “Marie Tharp” for clarity, which means it’s essential information and should not be separated by a colon.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a67eb904

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: a67eb904

Wanda Diaz-Merced is an astrophysicist who lost her sight when she was young. Diaz-Merced’s condition inspired her to develop software that can translate scientific data into sound. Sound-based tools _____ scientists to detect subtle patterns in data. Such patterns may not be evident in traditional graphs.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. has enabled
- B. enable
- C. is enabling
- D. enables

ID: a67eb904 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "enable" agrees in number with the plural subject "sound-based tools."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "has enabled" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "sound-based tools."
Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "is enabling" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "sound-based tools."
Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "enables" doesn’t agree in number with the plural subject "sound-based tools."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID bbe72aa6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: bbe72aa6

Oglala Lakota poet Layli Long Soldier’s star quilt poems offer an unusually open-ended reading experience. With _____ eight panels of text stitched together in the shape of a traditional eight-pointed Lakota star quilt, the poems present viewers with a seemingly infinite number of ways to read them.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. their
- B. it’s
- C. they’re
- D. its

ID: bbe72aa6 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive determiners. The plural possessive determiner "their" agrees in number with the plural noun "the poems," thus indicating that the poems had eight panels of text stitched together in the shape of a traditional eight-pointed Lakota star quilt.

Choice B is incorrect because "it’s" is the contraction for "it is" or "it has," not a possessive determiner. Choice C is incorrect because "they’re" is the contraction for "they are," not a possessive determiner. Choice D is incorrect because the singular possessive determiner "its" doesn’t agree in number with the plural noun "the poems."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 4e39e9e1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 4e39e9e1

Gathering accurate data on water flow in the United States is challenging because of the country’s millions of miles of _____ the volume and speed of water at any given location can vary drastically over time.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. waterways and the fact that,
- B. waterways, and the fact that,
- C. waterways, and, the fact that
- D. waterways and the fact that

ID: 4e39e9e1 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation within two coordinated noun phrases. When, as in this case, a noun phrase (“the country’s millions of miles of waterways”) is coordinated with another noun phrase (“the fact”) followed by an integrated relative clause (“that the volume...time”), no punctuation is needed.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 13809bdb

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 13809bdb

The term “retroflex” derives from Latin and means “bent back,” an apt descriptor for the branch of consonants—retroflex consonants—pronounced with the tongue curling up and back in the mouth. In many languages, including English, these consonants are _____ in some dialects of Mandarin, however, four such consonants (“ch,” “sh,” “zh,” and “r”) are relatively common.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. rare and
- B. rare,
- C. rare
- D. rare;

ID: 13809bdb Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice uses a semicolon in a conventional way to join the first main clause ("In many...rare") and the second main clause ("in some...common") in this sentence.

Choice A is incorrect. Joining the first main clause ("In many...rare") and the second main clause ("in some...common") with the conjunction "and" conflicts with the use of "however" later in the sentence, resulting in a confusing and illogical sentence. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Without a conjunction following it, a comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two main clauses are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ca9db724

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: ca9db724

English poet and Shakespeare contemporary John Donne’s _____ much admired during his lifetime (1572–1631) and in the decades that followed, had, at the time of their enthusiastic rediscovery by the early twentieth-century modernists, been essentially gathering dust for the intervening 250 years.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. works were
- B. works, were
- C. works,
- D. works had been

ID: ca9db724 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation and verb forms within a sentence. This choice leaves the verb "admired" in its nonfinite past participle form to function within a supplementary element ("much...followed"). Offset by commas after "works" and "followed," this supplementary element interrupts the main clause ("English poet and Shakespeare contemporary John Donne’s works...had...been essentially gathering dust...") with additional information about the works’ reception during Donne’s lifetime.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to offset the supplementary element ("much...followed") with appropriate punctuation, and using the finite verb "were much admired" results in an ungrammatical sentence. Choice B is incorrect because using the finite verb "were much admired" results in an ungrammatical sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it fails to offset the supplementary element ("much...followed") with appropriate punctuation, and using the finite verb "had been much admired" results in an ungrammatical sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 67d9e4a1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 67d9e4a1

Beatrix Potter is perhaps best known for writing and illustrating children’s books such as *The Tale of Peter Rabbit* (1902), but she also dedicated herself to mycology, the study of _____ more than 350 paintings of the fungal species she observed in nature and submitting her research on spore germination to the Linnean Society of London.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. fungi; producing
- B. fungi. Producing
- C. fungi producing
- D. fungi, producing

ID: 67d9e4a1 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between two supplementary phrases following the coordinate clause (“but she...mycology”). This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the supplementary noun phrase (“the study of fungi”) that defines the term “mycology” and the supplementary participial phrase (“producing...London”) that provides additional information about the extent to which Potter dedicated herself to mycology.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join two supplementary phrases following a coordinate clause. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “producing.” Choice C is incorrect. The lack of punctuation results in a sentence that illogically suggests that the study of fungi is producing more than 350 paintings.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ab334e14

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: ab334e14

Recently unearthed Neronian tools in France dating to 54,000 years ago and attributed to *Homo sapiens* may provide evidence that interactions between Neanderthals and modern humans occurred 10,000 years earlier than was previously _____ finding that, if true, would overturn current theories about *H. sapiens* migration during the Upper Paleolithic.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. supposed; a
- B. supposed. A
- C. supposed a
- D. supposed, a

ID: ab334e14 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause ("Recently...supposed") and the supplementary element ("a finding...Paleolithic") that provides additional information about the implications of the Neronian tool discovery.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can't be used in this way to join the main clause ("Recently...supposed") and the supplementary element ("a finding...Paleolithic"). Choice B is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "a finding." Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The main clause ("Recently...supposed") and the supplementary element ("a finding...Paleolithic") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6b07b1f2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 6b07b1f2

During the decades-long movement to codify the rights of Latinos in the US, certain events were pivotal: the founding of social justice group the League of United Latin American Citizens in _____ *Katzenbach v. Morgan* court decision in 1966, which affirmed the rights of Latino voters, is another such event.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. 1929. For one, the
- B. 1929, for one, the
- C. 1929 for one, the
- D. 1929, for one. The

ID: 6b07b1f2 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The conventions being tested are punctuation use between sentences and the punctuation of a supplementary element. This choice correctly uses a period to mark the boundary between one sentence ("During...one") and another ("The *Katzenbach*...event") and uses a comma to separate the supplementary phrase "for one" from the preceding main clause. Further, placing the period after "for one" correctly indicates that the information in the preceding main clause ("the founding...1929") is the first example provided of a pivotal event in the Latino rights movement.

Choice A is incorrect because placing the period after "1929" illogically indicates that the information in the next main clause (describing the *Katzenbach v. Morgan* court decision) is the first example provided of a pivotal event in the Latino rights movement; rather, it's a second example. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses. Moreover, it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element "for one" from the preceding main clause.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID baab8c05

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: baab8c05

A conceptual artist and designer embraced by both the art world and the fashion _____ Mary Ping was chosen to curate the exhibition *Front Row: Chinese American Designers* for the Museum of Chinese in America.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. world
- B. world:
- C. world;
- D. world,

ID: baab8c05 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a supplementary phrase and a main clause. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist...world”), which describes Mary Ping, and the main clause (“Mary...America”).

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary between the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist...world”) and the main clause (“Mary...America”) with appropriate punctuation. Choice B is incorrect because a colon can’t be used in this way to join the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist...world”) and the main clause (“Mary...America”). In this context, the colon incorrectly suggests that the information in the supplementary phrase is an explanation or amplification of the information in the main clause (Mary Ping being chosen to curate the exhibition), which isn’t the case. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to join the supplementary phrase (“A conceptual artist...world”) and the main clause (“Mary...America”). Semicolons are conventionally used to separate two main clauses or to separate items in a complex series.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8daeb4f3

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 8daeb4f3

In addition to advocating for South America’s independence in two political treatises, the *Cartagena Manifesto* and the *Letter from Jamaica*, Simón Bolívar personally led armies against the Spanish, liberating three South American territories—New Granada (present-day Colombia and Panama), Venezuela, and Quito (present-day _____ from colonial rule.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Ecuador,)
- B. Ecuador)
- C. Ecuador),
- D. Ecuador)—

ID: 8daeb4f3 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary element within a sentence. The dash after “Ecuador” and the closing parenthesis pairs with the dash after “territories” to separate the supplementary element (“New...Ecuador”) from the rest of the sentence. The supplementary element specifies the three South American territories that Simón Bolívar liberated, and the pair of dashes indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Furthermore, punctuation isn’t needed between “Ecuador” and the closing parenthesis. Choice B is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 526444f5

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 526444f5

The Tantaquidgeon Museum in Uncasville, Connecticut, was founded in 1931 with the goal of showcasing the culture and history of the Mohegan _____. Today, nearly a century later, it is the oldest Native-owned and -operated museum in the country.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Tribe, and
- B. Tribe
- C. Tribe and
- D. Tribe,

ID: 526444f5 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. This choice uses a comma and a coordinating conjunction (“and”) to join two independent clauses (“The Tantaquidgeon...Tribe” and “Today...country”).

Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error known as a run-on sentence. The clauses before and after “Tribe” are both independent, so they need to be separated with some sort of punctuation. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error known as a run-on sentence. The clauses before and after “and” are both independent, so they can’t be linked with just a conjunction. A comma would also be required. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a grammar error called a comma splice. The clauses before and after “Tribe” are both independent, so they can’t be linked with just a comma. A coordinating conjunction like “and” or “but” would also be required.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 9fbd369d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 9fbd369d

As the fourteenth US librarian of Congress, Carla Hayden has many responsibilities. These include overseeing the Library of Congress’s collections, which boast more than 162 million _____ the US Copyright Office, which registers copyright claims and advises Congress on copyright law; and appointing the US poet laureate.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. items managing
- B. items, managing
- C. items; managing
- D. items. Managing

ID: 9fbd369d Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of elements in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after "items" is conventionally used to separate the first item ("overseeing...items") and the second item ("managing...law") in a list of Hayden’s responsibilities.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the first item and the second item in the complex series. Choice B is incorrect because a comma after "items" doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second and third items in the series ("managing...law" and "and appointing the US poet laureate"). Choice D is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "Managing."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2b9244cd

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 2b9244cd

In 2021, Mexican biologist Martha Lydia Macías-Rubalcava led a review of the scientific literature related to endophytic fungi (i.e., fungi that live inside a host _____ researching 120 endophytic fungi–produced compounds, she found that their phytotoxicity can make them viable alternatives to chemical herbicides for controlling weeds.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. plant). By
- B. plant), by
- C. plant) and by
- D. plant) by

ID: 2b9244cd Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("In...plant") and another ("By...weeds"). The prepositional phrase beginning with "by" modifies the subject of the next sentence, "she," which refers to Macías-Rubalcava.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two sentences. Choice C is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join two sentences. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The two sentences are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 501005cc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 501005cc

As a behavioral economist, Katy Milkman of the University of Pennsylvania recognizes that people sometimes make irrational economic decisions. Milkman’s research can thus address anomalies that neoclassical economic _____ assume that people are consistently rational decision-makers—cannot explain.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. models—which
- B. models, which
- C. models which
- D. models which—

ID: 501005cc Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The dashes after "models" and "decision-makers" correctly separate the supplementary element "which assume that people are consistently rational decision-makers" from the rest of the sentence. This punctuation indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because a comma can’t be paired with a dash in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it interrupts the sentence at an illogical and grammatically incoherent point. The dash should be placed before "which," not after it, to mark the beginning of the supplementary element.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8745319e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 8745319e

In knot theory (the mathematical study of curved, closed loops), knots are characterized by their crossing numbers—that is, the number of times the knotted thread crosses over itself. The trefoil knot and the figure-eight knot, each with a crossing number below five, _____ among the simplest possible knots with the fewest number of crossings.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. was
- B. are
- C. has been
- D. is

ID: 8745319e Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "are" agrees in number with the plural compound subject "the trefoil knot and the figure-eight knot." The two types of knots joined by "and" function as a plural subject and thus require a plural verb.

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "was" doesn't agree in number with the plural compound subject "the trefoil knot and the figure-eight knot." Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "has been" doesn't agree in number with the plural compound subject "the trefoil knot and the figure-eight knot." Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "is" doesn't agree in number with the plural compound subject "the trefoil knot and the figure-eight knot."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a02683d7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: a02683d7

In his 2011 book, historian Sebouh David Aslanian quantifies the reading patterns of early modern Armenian merchants from New Julfa. Aslanian’s macroanalysis _____ nearly 1,000 book titles published between 1512 and 1800 shows not only the steady popularity of religious texts but also a broadening interest in secular books, especially those on history and geography.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. examined
- B. examines
- C. had examined
- D. examining

ID: a02683d7 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The sentence’s subject is “Aslanian’s macroanalysis,” and its finite main verb is “shows.” This choice correctly uses the nonfinite present participle “examining” to form an integrated participial phrase (“examining...1800”) that describes the macroanalysis, indicating what it examined.

Choice A is incorrect because using the finite verb “examined” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “shows,” so “examined” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions. Choice B is incorrect because using the finite verb “examines” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “shows,” so “examines” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions. Choice C is incorrect because using the finite verb “had examined” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “shows,” so “had examined” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 714d435b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 714d435b

In 1966, Emmett Ashford became the first African American to umpire a Major League Baseball game. His energetic gestures announcing when a player had struck out and his habit of barreling after a hit ball to see if it would land out of _____ transform the traditionally solemn umpire role into a dynamic one.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. bounds helped
- B. bounds, helping
- C. bounds that helped
- D. bounds to help

ID: 714d435b Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is finite verb use in a main clause. A main clause requires a finite verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, Ashford’s “gestures” and “habit”), and this choice supplies the finite past tense verb “helped” to indicate what Ashford’s gestures and habit helped accomplish.

Choice B is incorrect because the non-finite participle “helping” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because the relative clause “that helped” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because the non-finite to-infinitive “to help” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8c020851

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 8c020851

At the Chicxulub asteroid impact crater in Mexico, the presence of many fossilized microbacteria, which seem to have thrived there despite the extreme heat that persisted after the Chicxulub impact, _____ claims that bacteria are among the planet’s most resilient organisms.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. have reinforced
- B. reinforces
- C. are reinforcing
- D. reinforce

ID: 8c020851 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb “reinforces” agrees in number with the singular subject “the presence.”

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb “have reinforced” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the presence.”
Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “are reinforcing” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the presence.”
Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb “reinforce” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the presence.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 5811ab2f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 5811ab2f

In the 1950s, novel audio technologies allowed the addition of another instrument to jazz and swing _____ relatively quiet instrument, its full range of sound was finally audible alongside the blaring brass instruments of the time, allowing flautists like Bennie Maupin and Bobbi Humphrey to perform with other jazz greats.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. music, the flute, a
- B. music. The flute, a
- C. music; the flute, a
- D. music: the flute. A

ID: 5811ab2f Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within and between sentences. In this choice, the colon correctly introduces the name of the instrument (the flute) that novel audio technologies allowed to be added to jazz and swing. In addition, the period is used to correctly mark the boundary between one sentence ("In...flute") and another ("A relatively...greats").

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to join two main clauses ("In...quiet instrument" and "its...greats"). Choice B is incorrect. In standard English, it's unconventional to form a sentence in this way with two uncoordinated subjects ("the flute" and "its full range of sound"), and the lack of a clear main subject results in an awkwardly constructed and confusing sentence. Choice C is incorrect. In standard English, it's unconventional to form an independent clause in this way with two uncoordinated subjects ("the flute" and "its full range of sound"), and the lack of a clear main subject results in an awkwardly constructed and confusing clause.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 102372cc

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 102372cc

The ghazal, a poetic form originating in seventh-century Arabic poetry, has an intricate structure. The twentieth-century Kashmiri American poet Agha Shahid Ali explains that each one of a ghazal’s couplets, while adhering to the patterns of rhyme (*qafia*) and refrain (*radif*) established in the poem’s opening lines (*matla*), _____ thematically and logically autonomous, resulting in a poem with “a stringently formal disunity.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. is
- B. were
- C. have been
- D. are

ID: 102372cc Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The singular verb "is" agrees in number with the singular subject "each one of a ghazal’s couplets." While the prepositional phrase "of a ghazal’s couplets" within the subject contains a plural noun, the head of the subject ("each one") is singular, indicating that each individual couplet (not the couplets as a group) is "thematically and logically autonomous," or self-standing.

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "were" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "each one of a ghazal’s couplets." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "have been" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "each one of a ghazal’s couplets." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "are" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "each one of a ghazal’s couplets."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 8d9a6515

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 8d9a6515

Bonnie Buratti of NASA’s Jet Propulsion Laboratory _____ data about Saturn’s rings collected by the *Cassini* spacecraft when she made an interesting discovery: the tiny moons embedded between and within Saturn’s rings are shaped by the buildup of ring material on the moons’ surfaces.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. studies
- B. has been studying
- C. will study
- D. was studying

ID: 8d9a6515 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense in a sentence. In this choice, the past progressive tense verb “was studying” is consistent with the other past tense verbs (e.g., “made” and “collected”) used to describe Buratti’s discovery. Further, the past progressive tense correctly indicates that an ongoing action in the past was occurring (she was studying) at the same time that another event occurred in the past (she made an interesting discovery).

Choice A is incorrect because the present tense verb “studies” isn’t consistent with the past tense verbs used to describe Buratti’s discovery. Choice B is incorrect because the present perfect progressive tense verb “has been studying” isn’t consistent with the past tense verbs used to describe Buratti’s discovery. Choice C is incorrect because the future tense verb “will study” isn’t consistent with the past tense verbs used to describe Buratti’s discovery.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 11713313

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 11713313

In the 1970s, Janaki Ammal, a prominent botanist, emerged as a powerful voice in India’s environmental conservation movement. Her exhaustive chromosomal survey of plants in Silent Valley, a pristine tropical forest in Kerala, India, that is home to nearly 1,000 species of native flora (many of which are endangered), _____ instrumental in the government’s decision to preserve the forest.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. are
- B. were
- C. have been
- D. was

ID: 11713313 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The subject "survey" is singular, and so is the verb "was."

Choice A is incorrect. The subject "survey" is singular, but the verb "are" is plural. Choice B is incorrect. The subject "survey" is singular, but the verb "were" is plural. Choice C is incorrect. The subject "survey" is singular, but the verb "have been" is plural.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 467ca468

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 467ca468

Fernando Palma Rodríguez creates robotic sculptures that combine mechanical elements with materials like feathers, soil, and seeds. The artist is from a rural farming community outside Mexico City, and he studied engineering in college. The natural and mechanical _____ highlight these two aspects of his background.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. materials that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art,
- B. materials that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art
- C. materials, that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art,
- D. materials, that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art

ID: 467ca468 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of an integrated relative clause within a sentence. No punctuation is needed between the noun phrase (“The natural and mechanical materials”) and the integrated relative clause (“that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art”). The integrated relative clause provides essential information about the materials, so no punctuation should separate it from the noun phrase it modifies. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the sentence’s subject (“The natural and mechanical materials that Palma Rodríguez uses in his art”) and its main verb (“highlight”).

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the sentence’s subject (“The natural...art”) and its main verb (“highlight”). Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase (“The natural...materials”) and the integrated relative clause (“that...art”) that modifies it. Additionally, no punctuation is needed between the sentence’s subject (“The natural...art”) and its main verb (“highlight”). Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the noun phrase (“The natural...materials”) and the integrated relative clause (“that...art”) that modifies it.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID ba7e2f7e

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: ba7e2f7e

Both Arteaga, in the state of Coahuila, and Lagos de Moreno, in the state of Jalisco, have been designated by Mexico as *pueblos mágicos* (magical villages) to celebrate these _____ natural beauty and unique cultural traditions.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. town
- B. town’s
- C. towns
- D. towns’

ID: ba7e2f7e Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive nouns. The plural possessive noun “towns’” correctly indicates that the natural beauty and unique cultural traditions belong to both Arteaga and Lagos de Moreno.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun “towns’,” not the singular noun “town.” Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun “towns’,” not the singular possessive noun “town’s.” Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the plural possessive noun “towns’,” not the plural noun “towns.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 10f7ac75

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 10f7ac75

Jamaican British artist Willard Wigan is known for his remarkable _____ so small that they are best viewed through a microscope, Wigan’s sculptures are made from tiny natural materials, such as spiderweb strands.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. microsculptures creations
- B. microsculptures, creations
- C. microsculptures. Creations
- D. microsculptures and creations

ID: 10f7ac75 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between sentences. In this choice, the period is used to correctly mark the boundary between one sentence ("Jamaican...microsculptures") and another ("Creations...strands"). The noun phrase beginning with "creations" modifies the subject of the next sentence, "Wigan’s sculptures."

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences ("Jamaican...microsculptures" and "Creations...strands") are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can’t be used in this way to join sentences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a3503fb9

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: a3503fb9

Mathematician Grigori Perelman, sometimes in conjunction with mathematicians Richard S. Hamilton and Shing-Tung Yau, _____ credited with proving the Poincaré conjecture. Having built on Hamilton’s previous work to solve the proof, Perelman has insisted that Hamilton receive credit. Yau later found and closed gaps in Perelman’s proof, persuading some mathematicians that he deserves credit as well.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. are
- B. have been
- C. are being
- D. is

ID: a3503fb9 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "is credited" agrees in number with the singular subject "mathematician Grigori Perelman."

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "are credited" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "mathematician Grigori Perelman." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have been credited" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "mathematician Grigori Perelman." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "are being credited" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "mathematician Grigori Perelman."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6c160d2d

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 6c160d2d

In 1955, Indian Bengali filmmaker Satyajit Ray released his first movie, *Pather* _____ quiet black-and-white drama about a family in rural India, Ray’s film was quite different from the loud, colorful action-romance movies that were popular at the time.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. *Panchali* a
- B. *Panchali*, which was a
- C. *Panchali*, a
- D. *Panchali*. A

ID: 6c160d2d Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence ("In...*Panchali*") and another ("A quiet...time"). The phrase beginning with "a quiet" modifies the subject of the next sentence, "Ray’s film."

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a10c4f7a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: a10c4f7a

American writer Edwidge Danticat, who emigrated from Haiti in 1981, has won acclaim for her powerful short stories, novels, and _____ her lyrical yet unflinching depictions of her native country’s turbulent history, writer Robert Antoni has compared Danticat to Nobel Prize–winning novelist Toni Morrison.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. essays, praising
- B. essays and praising
- C. essays praising
- D. essays. Praising

ID: a10c4f7a Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period after “essays” is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“American...essays”) and another (“praising...Morrison”). The participial phrase beginning with “Praising” modifies the subject of the second sentence, “writer Robert Antoni.”

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice B is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences (“American...essays” and “Praising...Morrison”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 978a7f27

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 978a7f27

Digital artist Jung (Lulu) Chen primarily uses a suite of software tools to create illustrations for children’s books. To manifest the warm and welcoming atmospheres that are a signature of her _____ she occasionally relies on more traditional art techniques, such as painting with watercolors.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. work, though,
- B. work, though
- C. work; though,
- D. work, though;

ID: 978a7f27 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. The comma after "work" pairs with the comma after "though" to separate the supplementary element "though" from the rest of the sentence. This supplementary element signals that what follows is an exception to Chen using software tools to create illustrations, and the pair of commas indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because the comma after "work" must be paired with a comma after "though" to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be paired with a comma in this way to separate the supplementary element from the rest of the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID a66d8f86

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: a66d8f86

Quantum particles of light—photons—provide an unhackable means of transmitting encryption keys over networks, as attempts to observe particles in quantum states will invariably alter the particles _____ dismantle any information they transmit.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. and in the process,
- B. and, in the process,
- C. and in the process—
- D. and, in the process

ID: a66d8f86 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. This choice uses paired punctuation in the form of two commas to set off the nonessential phrase "in the process."

Choice A is incorrect. The phrase "in the process" is a nonessential element and needs to be set off with paired punctuation. We need a comma after "and" to match the one after "process." Choice C is incorrect. The phrase "in the process" is a nonessential element and needs to be set off with paired punctuation, so we would need a dash after "and" to match the one following "process." Choice D is incorrect. The phrase "in the process" is a nonessential element and needs to be set off with paired punctuation. We would need a comma after "process" to match the one following "and."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6764eed8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 6764eed8

In the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, automobiles were commonly referred to as horseless carriages after the older technology they still resembled. Known as the Brass Era, this period in automotive design is remembered for its grandeur and artistry, its vehicles _____ by collectors for their ornate detailing and gleaming brass fittings.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. are highly prized
- B. had been highly prized
- C. highly prized
- D. were highly prized

ID: 6764eed8 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms in a sentence. The nonfinite past participle phrase "highly prized" is correctly used to form a supplementary element that modifies the main clause "this...artistry," describing memorable features of Brass Era automotive design.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Using the finite present tense verb phrase "are highly prized" creates a second main clause in the sentence, and two main clauses can't be joined in this way with only a comma after "artistry." Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Using the finite past perfect tense verb phrase "had been highly prized" creates a second main clause in the sentence, and two main clauses can't be joined in this way with only a comma after "artistry." Choice D is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. Using the finite past tense verb phrase "were highly prized" creates a second main clause in the sentence, and two main clauses can't be joined in this way with only a comma after "artistry."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 961a8575

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 961a8575

When external forces are applied to common glass made from silicates, energy builds up around minuscule defects in the material, resulting in fractures. Recently, engineer Erkka Frankberg of Tampere University in Finland used the chemical _____ to make a glassy solid that can withstand higher strain than silicate glass can before fracturing.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. compound, aluminum oxide
- B. compound aluminum oxide,
- C. compound, aluminum oxide,
- D. compound aluminum oxide

ID: 961a8575 Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation around noun phrases. No punctuation is needed because the noun phrase “aluminum oxide” is a restrictive appositive, meaning that it provides essential identifying information about the noun phrase before it, “the chemical compound,” and thus doesn’t require punctuation around it.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice C is incorrect because the noun phrase “aluminum oxide” is a restrictive appositive. Setting the phrase off with punctuation suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID fa32e106

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: fa32e106

For scientists to produce new iron nanoparticles of a specific size or strength, they must first be able to monitor reactions between oxygen and existing iron nanoparticles at a near-atomic level of detail. Fortunately, chemistry _____ and his colleagues at Temple University recently developed a new approach that does just that.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. professor Yugang Sun
- B. professor Yugang Sun,
- C. professor, Yugang Sun,
- D. professor, Yugang Sun

ID: fa32e106 Answer

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation between titles and proper nouns. No punctuation is needed between the proper noun “Yugang Sun” and the title that describes Sun, “chemistry professor.” Furthermore, no punctuation is needed after “Sun” because “chemistry professor Yugang Sun and his colleagues at Temple University” functions as the coordinated subject of the sentence, and together Sun and colleagues performed the action of developing a new approach to producing iron nanoparticles.

Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the proper noun “Yugang Sun” and the coordinated noun phrase “and his colleagues at Temple University.” Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed before or after the proper noun “Yugang Sun.” Setting off the professor’s name with commas suggests that it could be removed without affecting the coherence of the sentence, which isn’t the case. Choice D is incorrect because no punctuation is needed between the title “chemistry professor” and the proper noun “Yugang Sun.”

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 791ffa68

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 791ffa68

American abstract artist Richard _____ his installations to make passersby keenly aware of how one’s movements are affected by the physical features of one’s environment, assembles large-scale steel plates into sculptures that dominate the outdoor spaces they occupy.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. Serra is intending
- B. Serra, intends
- C. Serra, intending
- D. Serra intends

ID: 791ffa68 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. This choice pairs the comma after "Serra" with the comma after "environment" and uses the nonfinite present participle "intending" to correctly form a supplementary phrase describing the reaction Serra intends his sculptures to provoke. This supplementary phrase appears between the noun phrase that it modifies ("American abstract artist Richard Serra") and the finite present tense verb ("assembles"), which functions as the sentence’s main verb and describes what Serra does.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present continuous tense verb "is intending" can’t be used in this way in conjunction with the finite present tense verb "assembles," which already functions as the main verb in the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present tense verb "intends" can’t be used in this way to supplement the noun phrase "American abstract artist Richard Serra." Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present tense verb "intends" can’t be used in this way in conjunction with the finite present tense verb "assembles," which already functions as the main verb in the sentence.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 6ebe2f1c

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 6ebe2f1c

Legal scholars James Melton and Tom Ginsburg’s analysis of de jure judicial independence and its growth over decades _____ six constitutional features that enhance such independence, including judicial tenure and selection procedure. Albania’s constitution contains five of these features.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. are identifying
- B. identify
- C. have identified
- D. identifies

ID: 6ebe2f1c Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "identifies" agrees in number with the singular subject "analysis."

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "are identifying" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "analysis." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "identify" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "analysis." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "have identified" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "analysis."

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 918c076b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 918c076b

A subseasonal weather forecast attempts to predict weather conditions three to four weeks in ____ its predictions are therefore more short-term than those of the seasonal forecast, which attempts to predict the weather more than a month in advance.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. advance,
- B. advance
- C. advance;
- D. advance and

ID: 918c076b Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The clause “A subseasonal...advance” and the clause “its predictions...forecast” are both independent clauses, so using a semicolon to separate them is grammatically correct.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence error. The clause “A subseasonal...advance” and the clause “its predictions...forecast” are both independent clauses, so a comma is not enough to separate them. Choice B is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence error. The clause “A subseasonal...advance” and the clause “its predictions...forecast” are both independent clauses, so they need to be separated with specific punctuation (a period, a semi-colon, a colon, a dash, or a comma + a coordinating conjunction). Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a run-on sentence error. The clause “A subseasonal...advance” and the clause “its predictions...forecast” are both independent clauses, so the word “and” by itself is not enough to separate them. There would need to be a comma before “and” for this choice to work.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 50986e2b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 50986e2b

Since the nineteenth century, Egyptologists have commonly divided ancient Egyptian history into three primary ____ Old Kingdom (2700–2200 BCE), the Middle Kingdom (2050–1800 BCE), and the New Kingdom (1550–1100 BCE). Some historians, however, criticize the names of these periods for revealing more about the culture of the mainly European Egyptologists than that of ancient Egypt itself.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. periods. The
- B. periods: the
- C. periods; the
- D. periods, the

ID: 50986e2b Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between a main clause and an enumerated series. In this choice, a colon is correctly used after the main clause (“Since...periods”) to introduce the series identifying the three primary periods of ancient Egyptian history.

Choice A is incorrect because placing a period after “periods” results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with “the Old Kingdom.” Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can’t be used in this way to introduce a series. A semicolon is conventionally used to join two main clauses or to separate items in a complex series, neither of which is the case here. Choice D is incorrect because a comma is not conventionally used to mark the boundary between the main clause (“Since...periods”) and an enumerated series (“the Old Kingdom...(1550–1100 BCE)”) that contains internal commas. Using a comma in this way creates ambiguity about which commas separate elements in the series and which mark other boundaries in the sentence, making the colon the best choice.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 817a9286

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 817a9286

The first computerized spreadsheet, Dan Bricklin’s *VisiCalc*, improved financial recordkeeping not only by providing users with an easy means of adjusting data in spreadsheets but also by automatically updating all calculations that were dependent on these _____ to VisiCalc’s release, changing a paper spreadsheet often required redoing the entire sheet by hand, a process that could take days.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. adjustments prior
- B. adjustments, prior
- C. adjustments. Prior
- D. adjustments and prior

ID: 817a9286 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between the first sentence (“The...adjustments”) and the second sentence (“Prior...days”). Because the adverbial phrase beginning with “prior” indicates when changing a spreadsheet required redoing the sheet by hand, that phrase belongs with the second sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. Two sentences are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction “and” can’t be used in this way to join the sentences.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 7e30b2e0

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 7e30b2e0

To serve local families during the Great Depression, innovative New York City librarian Pura Belpré offered storytelling in both English and Spanish, an uncommon _____ celebrated *el Día de los Tres Reyes Magos*, an important community holiday; and put on puppet shows dramatizing Puerto Rican folktales.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. practice, at the time
- B. practice at the time;
- C. practice, at the time,
- D. practice at the time,

ID: 7e30b2e0 Answer

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of elements in a complex series. It’s conventional to use a semicolon to separate items in a complex series with internal punctuation, and in this choice, the semicolon after "time" is conventionally used to separate the first item ("offered...time") and the second ("celebrated...holiday") in the series of activities that librarian Pura Belpré offered. Moreover, the semicolon after "time" matches the semicolon used later to separate the second item ("celebrated...holiday") and the third ("and...folktales") in the series.

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to use appropriate punctuation to separate the first item and the second item in the complex series. Furthermore, a comma isn’t needed between the noun "practice" and the prepositional phrase "at the time" because the prepositional phrase is essential to the full meaning of the phrase "an uncommon practice at the time." Choice C is incorrect because a comma after "time" doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second ("celebrated...holiday") and third ("and...folktales") items in the series. Furthermore, a comma isn’t needed between the noun "practice" and the prepositional phrase "at the time" because the prepositional phrase is essential to the full meaning of the phrase "an uncommon practice at the time." Choice D is incorrect because a comma after "time" doesn’t match the semicolon used later to separate the second ("celebrated...holiday") and third ("and...folktales") items in the series.

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 31be2837

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	

ID: 31be2837

During the English neoclassical period (1660–1789), many writers imitated the epic poetry and satires of ancient Greece and Rome. They were not the first in England to adopt the literary modes of classical _____ some of the most prominent figures of the earlier Renaissance period were also influenced by ancient Greek and Roman literature.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. antiquity, however
- B. antiquity, however,
- C. antiquity, however;
- D. antiquity; however,

ID: 31be2837 Answer

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the punctuation of a supplementary phrase following a clause. This choice uses a comma to separate the supplementary adverb phrase "however" from the independent clause it modifies ("They...antiquity") and uses a semicolon to join the first independent clause ("They...antiquity") and the second independent clause ("some...literature"). Further, placing the semicolon after "however" indicates that the information in the clause that this is part of (that neoclassical writers were not the first to adopt classical literary modes) is contrary to what might be assumed from the information in the previous sentence (that the neoclassical writers were unique in imitating classical epic poetry and satires).

Choice A is incorrect because it fails to mark the boundary after "however" between the two independent clauses with appropriate punctuation. Choice B is incorrect because the comma after "however" can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between the two independent clauses. Choice D is incorrect because placing the semicolon after "antiquity" illogically indicates that the information in the clause that this is part of (that prominent Renaissance figures were also influenced by classical literature) is contrary to the information in the previous clause (that neoclassical writers were not the first to adopt classical literary modes).

Question Difficulty: Hard

Question ID 2c0904aa

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
PSAT/NMSQT & PSAT 10	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	

ID: 2c0904aa

Increased gender diversity is revitalizing the field of economics, according to Harvard’s Claudia Goldin. The trailblazing accomplishments of Goldin, winner of the 2023 Nobel Prize in Economics for her work on women in the labor force, _____ to the value of scholars of diverse backgrounds in spurring research into previously unexplored, but vitally important, topics.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. attests
- B. has attested
- C. is attesting
- D. attest

ID: 2c0904aa Answer

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "attest" agrees in number with the plural subject "trailblazing accomplishments."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "attests" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "trailblazing accomplishments." Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb "has attested" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "trailblazing accomplishments." Choice C is incorrect because the singular verb "is attesting" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "trailblazing accomplishments."

Question Difficulty: Hard